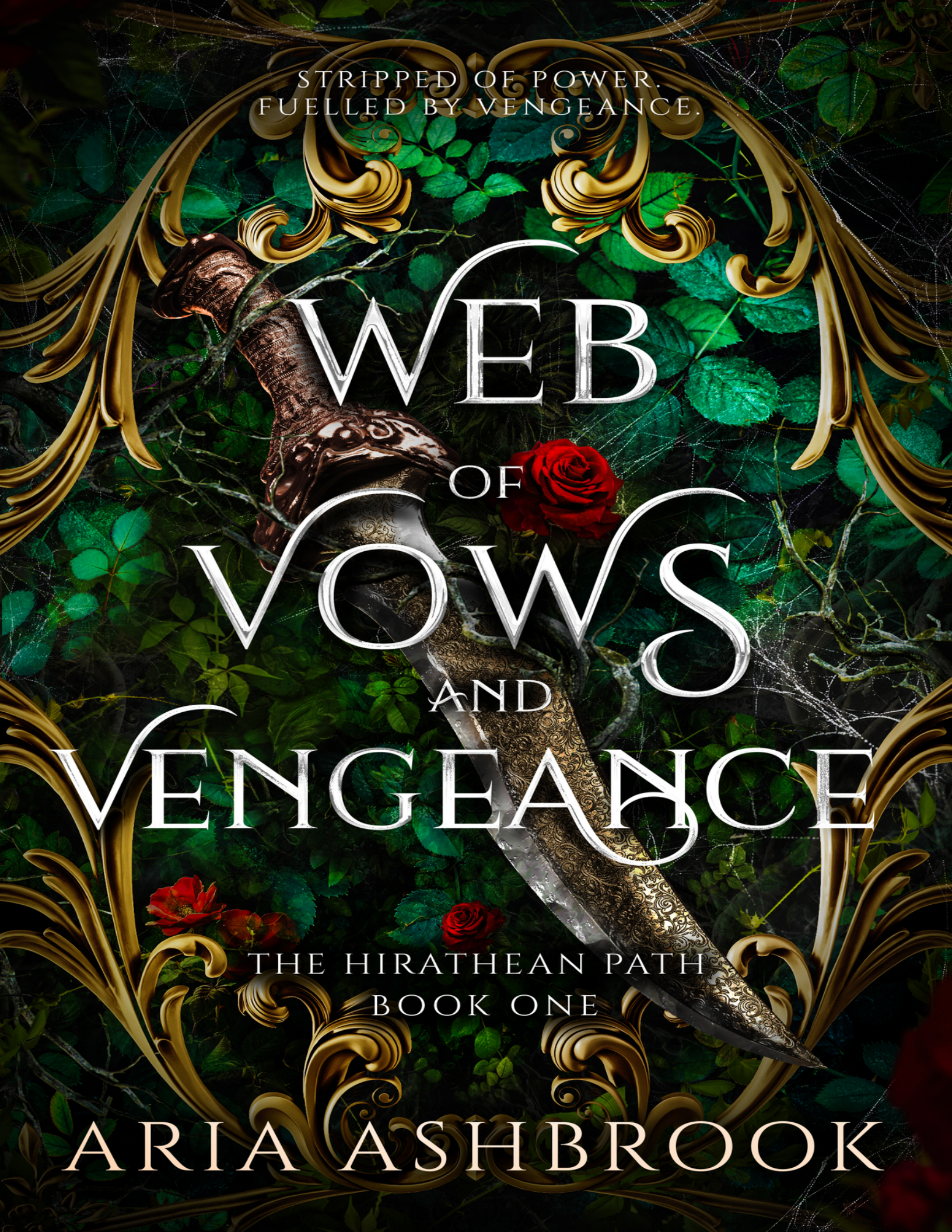

STRIPPED OF POWER.
FUELLED BY VENGEANCE.
WEB
OF
VOWS
AND
VENGEANCE
THE HIRATHEAN PATH
BOOK ONE
ARIA ASHBROOK



Web of Vows And Vengeance

By Aria Ashbrook

Published by Hellhound Press Limited



OceanofPDF.com

CONTENTS

Foreword
Map
Preface

Chapter 1
Chapter 2
Chapter 3
Chapter 4
Chapter 5
Chapter 6
Chapter 7
Chapter 8
Chapter 9
Chapter 10
Chapter 11
Chapter 12
Chapter 13
Chapter 14
Chapter 15
Chapter 16
Chapter 17
Chapter 18
Chapter 19
Chapter 20
Chapter 21
Chapter 22
Chapter 23
Chapter 24
Chapter 25
Chapter 26
Chapter 27
Chapter 28
Chapter 29
Chapter 30
Chapter 31
Chapter 32
Chapter 33
Chapter 34
Chapter 35
Chapter 36
Chapter 37

Chapter 38
Chapter 39
Chapter 40
Chapter 41
Chapter 42
Chapter 43
Chapter 44
Chapter 45
Chapter 46
Chapter 47
Chapter 48
Chapter 49
Chapter 50
Chapter 51
Chapter 52
Chapter 53
Chapter 54
Chapter 55
Chapter 56
Chapter 57
Chapter 58
Chapter 59
Chapter 60
Chapter 61
Chapter 62
Chapter 63
Chapter 64
Chapter 65
Chapter 66
Chapter 67
Chapter 68
Chapter 69
Chapter 70
Chapter 71
Chapter 72
Chapter 73
Chapter 74
Chapter 75

About the author

OceanofPDF.com

Copyright © 2026 by Aria Ashbrook.

All rights reserved.

No portion of this book may be reproduced in any form without written permission from the publisher or author, except as permitted by U.S. copyright law.

No generative AI used, ever.

Published by Hellhound Press Limited.

Cover design by Christian Bentulan.

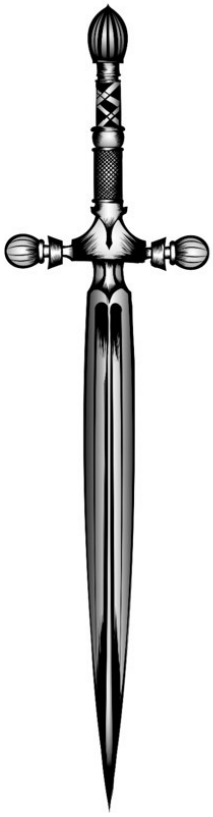
Developmental and line editing: Victoria O Editorial.

Copy editing: Laura McCallen.

Proofreading: Elizabeth at Arrowhead Editing.

OceanofPDF.com

CONTENT ADVISORY



This enthralling dark romantasy includes scenes of violence, death, grief, adult language (and actions), and the sort of emotionally poor decisions that only seem reasonable at the time.

Characters were harmed in the making of this story. Emotional support tissues are recommended.

If you're a spice lover, welcome. If you're a fade-to-black reader, consider this your warning that some scrolling may be required.

Please note that all of Aria's works are written in British English. Any unfamiliar spellings, phrases, or turns of speech are intentional rather than errors. Consider them part of the British charm.

If you're still game, then let's begin…

OceanofPDF.com

FOREWORD

If you're a person that needs to read in order, then you can grab the FREE prequel novella, ***Veil of Web and Ruin*** before you dive into ***Web of Vows and Vengeance*** by signing up for the free book on the website https://www.aria-ashbrook.com

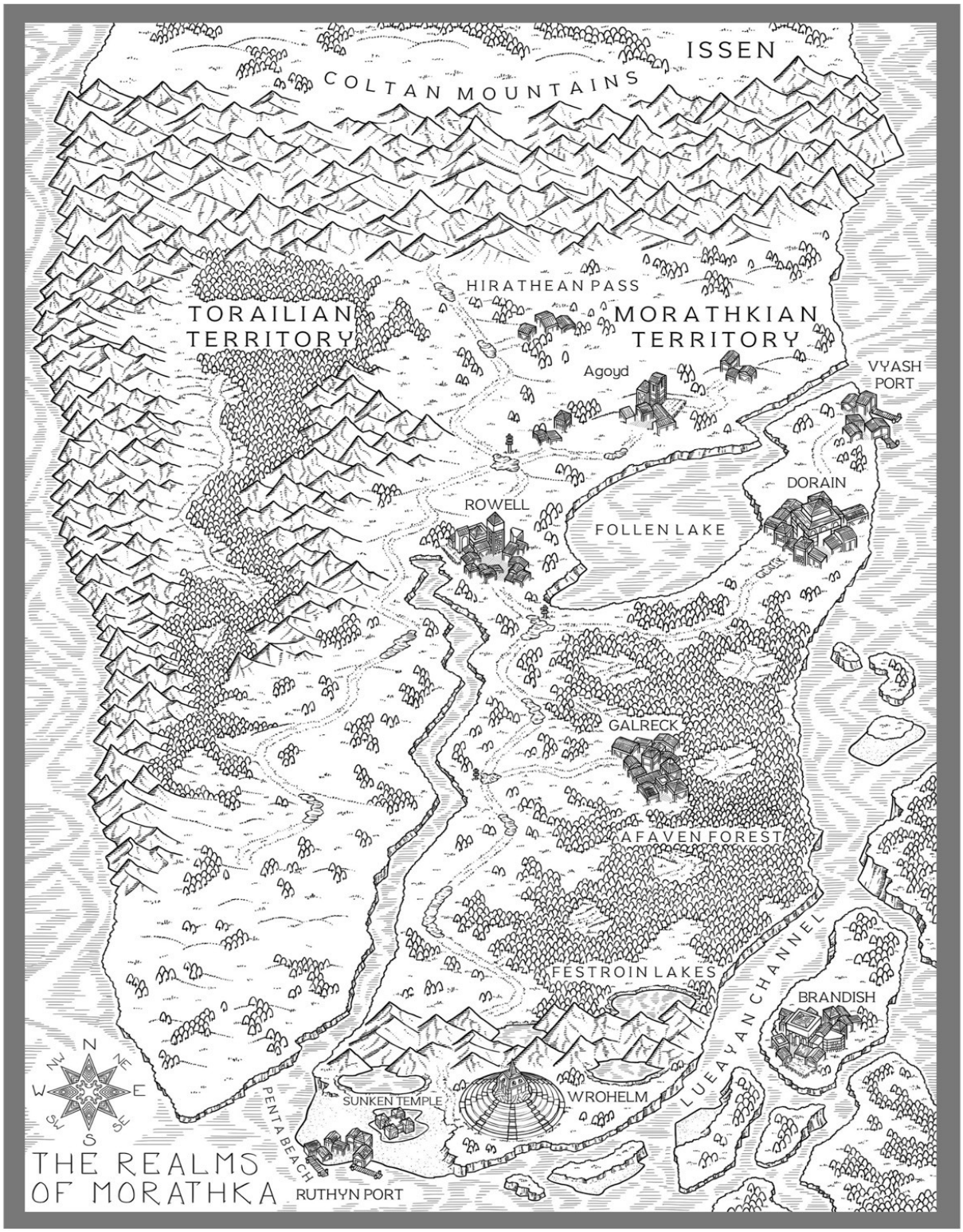
Otherwise, hoard it like a bookdragon for when you need a little something for the book hangover.

OceanofPDF.com

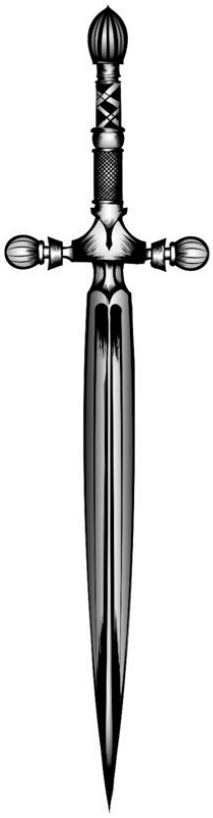
For those that dream of lightning.

OceanofPDF.com

Web of Vows and Vengeance



OceanofPDF.com



I should have known a man who kissed like a storm would only ever leave destruction in his wake.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 1

They say vengeance is a blade best kept sharp, and my dagger has been honed with every betrayal.

Shadows flicker in the torchlight as I count the silhouettes guarding the building where my hopes rest, my pulse skittering higher and higher.

There are no priestesses inside the temple tonight. No devotees of Etta giving the Great Goddess their libations and wealth as they breathe in the heavy incense and beg her forgiveness for all their sins. Instead, twenty-six knights and their twenty-six dire wolves prowl the silent ring of the citadel, waiting for the brave, the dumb, and the desperate – those foolish enough to risk life and limb for the chance to win the gifting.

This is the third night of my watch and the last chance I've got. I left it to the last moment to make my offering. The denizens from the other cities have already made theirs, and tomorrow they'll announce the few chosen by the Goddess. There won't be another Retterheld in my lifetime as there's never more than one in a century.

It's now or never.

I've spent the previous two evenings tracking their movements, their patterns. Watching, calculating, learning. The first night, I watched from the very edge of the wall, noting how long each loop of the temple took, where the knighted guards paused, and how often. And just as I expected, there is a rhythm and a pattern to it. Openings where, if I'm fast – which I am – I'll be able to get into the temple unseen.

Last night I crept closer, finding a small back window left ajar. That's going to be my way in. Sure, there's the slight issue in that the window is at

least twelve feet off the ground, but climbs like that don't bother me. When the only way you can get fresh eggs is by clambering up spruce trees and raiding siskin nests, you quickly become a skilled climber. Starvation encourages many nefarious skills. I regret none of my lessons though, only the circumstances that led me to them.

Over the past three nights I've seen five people successfully make it into the temple to give their offerings to Etta in the hope that she'll accept them into the Retterheld. Men and women who have succeeded in scaling the walls or crawling through the gutters, only to walk – or strut – out the main door soon after, their fingertips dyed black as a sign of their success. I've seen many more fail. Heard their screams, heard their rattling final breaths. They won't haunt me, not when I've already become inured to death; living in the slums is one long – or short – death sentence.

Not that every applicant to the Retterheld dies. The richest would have already passed on coins to guarantee that healers happen to be nearby. But even if you make it into the temple, the Goddess still has to *choose* you. To deem you worthy. Only then can you actually call yourself a Rettling. A name I will get or die trying.

Another howl, another scream. I wince in sympathy. Mother was one of those healers once, standing ready with spells and potions. There was a time when it felt like she could heal all but death itself, but when it came to it, even she couldn't defy Mortidem. And now, here I am, in rags and desperation, risking everything for my sister.

'You can't stay here all night, Rose,' I mutter to myself as I catch a shadow creeping along the outer wall of the third ring. If I've spotted the other supplicant, chances are good that one of the guards has seen them too. I wait for a cry to ring out, but there's none. I'm unsure whether I feel relieved or disappointed.

Six of the Morathkian Gods have temples within the third ring of Wrohelm, but none are as grand as Etta's. It's also usually the most frequented, but for the last week this section of the third ring has been under curfew, the streets emptied of everyone except the knights and their wolves. Cleared out entirely for this purpose – so that people can make their offerings and volunteer for the Retterheld. People like the man I've spotted in the shadows, dressed in furs and leather and crouching low, trying to stay hidden. I watch, breath held for him, as he glances back and forth, then bolts straight towards the temple.

Whoever he is, he’s fast. Maybe even fast enough. He’s moving at such a speed that it’s almost as if he’s forgotten about the icy moat surrounding the temple.

My chest clenches as I realise that’s exactly what he’s done. He’s running at a full sprint towards thin ice. He needs to stop, to pull up fast, or—

His hands flail, wild and desperate, and for a breath I’m certain he will crash into the icy depths of the moat … until a sudden flash of green light bursts from his frame, catching him, suspending him, and pulling him back to solid ground, instantly saving and dooming him.

‘Fuck!’ The sympathetic curse slips from my lips, and I wince at the sound of my own voice. The man used his magic to save himself, but in doing so he guaranteed his rejection by Etta. All applicants must come to her free of magic. It’s why being stripped of my magic is an advantage. There’s no risk of power slipping free when I have none.

I shrink back into the shadows, my heart knocking out my nerves against my ribs as I wonder if the inadvertent swear will fuck me as well. But there’s no outcry from a knight. No howls from the dire wolves. Tension eases from me. Despite myself, I feel bad for the man. Whatever desperate wish lured him towards the Retterheld now lies forever beyond his grasp.

The howls and growls burst through the silence as the wolves and their bonded knights rush to where the man stands. I brace myself for an attack, for the screams of pain as the wolves plunge their teeth into his thighs, only to watch on in disgust as coins clink as they pass hands. A bribe for a painless exit. I shouldn’t be surprised.

Sickness spreads through the slums like fire from our bastard king’s fingertips, and that kind of money, cast aside so casually, could save dozens of lives. Instead, lords and ladies hoard more coin than they could spend in ten lifetimes, and the poor of the citadel are left with nothing more than the thoughts and prayers of the priestesses.

Turns out thoughts and prayers do fuck all when what you actually need is food and medicine.

I won’t let my sister spend a lifetime struggling in the slums, just for illness to prematurely end her days. Not when she was meant for so much more. I’m doing this for Acacia – Kay.

I draw in a breath and return my attention to the task at hand. Dealing with the fur-covered man will keep the guards distracted for a moment or two longer. Not a single guard, nor their wolves, have even glanced in my direction since I arrived tonight. But why would they? Only a knighted guard or someone of noble birth can enter the Retterheld, and what kind of noble or knight would be coming from the direction of the slums?

One unfairly cast out. That's who. One ready to rectify that through any means necessary.

I could live out the rest of my life starving hungry, scraping a living from tonics brewed from the recipes in my mother's precious notebook, but I can't put Kay through it any longer. She doesn't deserve the miserable life the king and his pathetic narcissist of a son condemned us to. The gifting will change everything.

I will enter, and I will win. I have to.

My eyes track one guard and his wolf at the back of the temple. On the count of three, they are going to turn the corner and give me my best opening.

'This is it, Rose,' I murmur, dousing my body in a putrid liquid concoction of my mother's creation, designed to hide my human scent from the wolves. 'You can do this. You just need to fucking *move*.'

Three, two, one!

I climb down hastily, scraping my knuckles on the rough-hewn marble but barely noticing the sting as adrenaline roars in my ears. I daren't look over my shoulder. Instead, I keep moving until I'm a few feet away from the ground, then leap, landing gracelessly on all fours. I remain crouched for less than a heartbeat before I'm upright again and, with my heart hammering, racing in the direction of that high back window.

My lungs are close to bursting as I sprint towards the only hope I have left. I must get in. That's all there is to it. I'll work out how to survive the trials – without magic – once I'm chosen. Because I *will* be chosen.

Mindful of the other man's mistake, I slow my feet as they hit the thin, icy surface of the moat. Dangerously thin.

Fuck! This time I swallow the curse, biting my lip to keep any sound from slipping out. Panic thrums through me with every breath. Even my paltry weight will likely be too much for the ice, but I have no choice but to keep moving forward.

I'm halfway there. Halfway to safety. Halfway to death.

A loud crack sounds, followed by a quieter one, and then I'm plunged into freezing water up to my neck. Shock tears my breath from me – a blessing in disguise as my scream dies in my throat. If the Retterheld has swimming in it, I'm screwed. It's not that I can't swim; it's just that as soon as I know I'm out of my depth, a primal fear takes hold of my limbs and mind and leaves me flailing hopelessly. I steady my feet against the stony bottom of the moat, trying to calm my breathing ever so slightly.

The water is agonisingly cold, but while the jolt bites deep, it doesn't break me. I've no doubt the other nobles would be crippled by the shock. They may live in a cold climate, but they dress in thick furs and live in magically warmed rooms. They don't know what it's like to wake with your fingers and toes turning blue, ice crystals threading along your headboard, and the only drinkable water hidden beneath six inches of ice.

But I do.

So, ignoring the numbing cold that swirls around me, I wade through the still waters, clenching my jaw to stop the sound of my chattering teeth from escaping. *Gods, I am so close.*

Relief floods me when I reach the other side, though the feeling is short-lived. All that water soaking into my pitiful shoes has lessened their purchase. Considerably. Still, I have no choice. If I stay here, I'll die. It's that simple.

With my hands on the rough-hewn temple walls, I manoeuvre myself so that my foot is anchored and push myself upward. There's just about enough friction to get another precarious foothold, and then the next. My thighs burn as I force all my power through them, every muscle stretching as I reach for the thin metal frame of the open window above.

The pain that sears through my palm is enough to make me gasp, the sound echoing in the silence. The metal frame must have a jagged edge that has now sliced through several layers of skin, if not more.

That brew of mine might cover a lot of scents from the dire wolves, but I seriously doubt it's going to mask this much blood. I need to hurry.

I reach up again, and this time, I look up as well, placing my right hand carefully on the metal.

Haste makes waste, my mother's voice chides me from my memories.

A shout erupts. 'There! Over by the window!'

Fuck! There's a thunder of feet on the drawbridge and I know I'm down to my last seconds of opportunity.

Groaning aloud, I heave myself up on bloody fingers until my torso is level with the window, but it’s not enough. I need to be higher to avoid tumbling headfirst through the opening. There’s a ten-foot drop on the other side and I’m pretty sure arriving with a concussion will not impress the Goddess. I cannot screw this up now. Not when I’m so fucking close!

A metallic tang floods my tongue as I bite down on the inside of my cheek, but I pay neither the pain nor the taste any mind. Instead, I force myself to give one last push, heaving my body up that extra foot and opening the window fully.

With panting breaths, I block out the shouts of the guards below and draw my legs up beneath me to balance my feet on the sharp ledge. Then, without giving myself time to hesitate, I jump downwards.

My boots slam against the marble floor and I stagger, but pride and practice keep me on my feet. I’m quickly aware of the sensation of my limbs prickling with the heat of the temple.

I smile with satisfaction as a furious wolf howl cuts through the silence of the night, but my expression falters as I lift my head and take in the sight before me.

It feels like a punch to the heart.

It’s not the mesmerising crystal chandeliers, each holding a thousand flickering candles, that steal my breath. Nor the vaulted, painted ceilings. Nor even the white marble pillars that gleam like sun-bleached bone.

It’s my memories.

Memories of my family. Of our lost magic.

And it’s almost enough to undo me. To make me falter. To forget why I came.

Almost.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 2

The last time I was in this temple, I wasn't wearing torn rags and shoes with soles so thin a cross look could pierce them – I was dressed in silk. It was forest green, displaying the type of magic I once possessed, and paired with a rich stole of soft wolf fur.

It is the memories of the good old days that guided me here, that summoned my feet to Etta's temple, and now I must use them to make an offering. A gift to show her I'm worthy of the chance of a lifetime. That I have the reason, the desire, and the will to fight in the Retterheld until death or the end of the trials, whichever comes first.

Ironically, Etta asks for the one thing I've never lacked since that night fourteen years ago: tears.

So as I walk forward leaving sodden prints with every step, rather than trying to push down the memories that constantly seek to overwhelm me, I embrace them. Memories of my mother, before my brother Florian was taken and killed, back when her laughter came easily. When she offered her magic and knowledge freely to help and heal.

Not that she ever stopped trying to heal and help. Even when our magic was stripped and her own body turned against her, she harvested from the garden until her legs were too weak to stand. That was when I took over, following her instructions and adjusting my methods on her advice to ensure the brews were as potent as they could be. She taught me vigorously, knowing she wouldn't be there for much longer. Knowing I would be the one who had to keep the family alive.

As for my father … we lost him, in mind if not in body, the day they killed Florian. The death of his son broke him – as it did us all – but for him

the wound was too great to overcome.

A part of me still hates him for that. For making Kay and me feel like we weren't enough.

But for Etta, and the tears she demands, I embrace the bitter memories and the old grief.

In Father's last years, it was near impossible to reconcile the emaciated drunk with the strong, honourable man who had raised us to succeed. The man who would mark my face with the lines of my ancestors, arm me with bows and arrows, then blindfold me and take me out into the forest to prove myself. He would hide in the shadows, a silent sentinel who watched me as I figured out the way back to the High Hold, all the while believing myself utterly alone. The first time, I remember thinking I would never make it. That I would die there. But once I returned triumphant, the thought never so much as crossed my mind again.

The older I grew, the more fanciful my thoughts on such trips became. I imagined stumbling across one of the Torailian, the elusive warrior people who live in savagery to the west. Little naïve me thought I could defeat them – maybe even a dozen of them – although I continued to dread the idea of crossing the path of an Issen with their white garb, colourless eyes, and skin like fine lace. Not to mention the power to draw every ounce of life from the air around them. Feared by all Morathkians, the Issen were our nightmare come to life.

I've long since learned that the monsters are far closer to home, namely the lords and ladies of Morathka's court who turned their backs on us and cast us aside without hesitation or remorse. Still, no matter how deadly a monster is, you need only fear it when it draws close enough to bite.

Which is why I intend to show them all how well the past years have sharpened my teeth.

The spoiled gentry, with their warmed rooms and overflowing platters of food, haven't got a clue what real desire is. They don't know *need.* Which is why I know Etta will choose me.

As I turn the corner, the altar to the Goddess comes into view.

The great Etta. Goddess of Life. The one who gifted me powers and, with her blessing, the one who will return them to me.

'Great Goddess…' I kneel on the stone floor, surprised by my suddenly dry mouth.

I have rehearsed my prayer to the Goddess a thousand times, ever since the High Priestess announced two moons ago that there would be a Retterheld. Never had I dreamed that one would exist within my lifetime; if I had, I would have practised for it from the day my magic was ripped from me.

Closing my eyes, I force myself to take a long, steadying inhalation before continuing. ‘Great Goddess Etta, I am here to offer my soul and my life to you and to the Retterheld.’ I pause for a heartbeat. ‘You demand our tears in order to judge the truth in our words, but the tears I offer you are not mine alone. They are also my sister’s. My mother’s. My father’s. My brother’s…’ My voice breaks and tears burn my eyes as the words I’ve rehearsed flee me. The sheer injustice of it all cuts me anew, but I swallow hard and force myself to continue. If I can’t manage this, I have no place in the trials.

‘Let these tears be for all of those King Korvane has wrongly punished in his all-consuming rage. If you were there that night, Great Goddess, you saw the queen’s death, and you know the truth. You *know* my mother was not to blame. You know Prince Kyor lied.’

My hands shake and my lips twist in a snarl. My mother’s word should have been worth more than that of an eleven-year-old brat, prince though he is. I push on through my anger, the words no longer coming from a script, but from my broken soul.

‘No crime was committed and yet my sister has suffered *every* loss. Her home, her parents, her magic. Every day I see her brightness fading a little more, hopelessness creeping into her veins like a plague. She is a lady, in her bones and blood, and she deserves the safety and dignity offered by a life at court. A marriage. A family. A future.’ The last word comes out as a sob, and when I raise my hands to my cheeks, my fingers come away wet with salty tears. Before a single one can dry, I brush my tear-stained fingers across the stone of Etta’s altar.

My heart races even as it breaks. ‘Let me do this for you, my Goddess,’ I vow. ‘I will fight with everything I have for you and for my sister, and I will clear my mother’s name. All I ask is that you give me that chance. Please.’ Even though only a single tear is required, I move to collect more, but before I can shake them from my fingers, a loud shriek from outside the temple sends a shiver down the length of my spine. Someone else tried to enter and failed.

I, on the other hand, have said my piece to the Goddess. I am done here.

I let the last tears fall away, and then I dip my fingers into the bowl of black charcoal next to me, colouring my skin all the way to my knuckles. The knights and their wolves can't touch me now.

I turn to leave, only for a thud near the rafters to stop me in my tracks. Nerves prickle through me, though thankfully, it sounded too heavy to be a bird. The last thing I wish to see is a raven's black eyes watching me as I leave. My father always warned us to never turn our backs on a raven. That they will whisper your secrets to Mortidem if they think you're weak, so he knows the best way to trap you. The last thing I want is for the God of Death to think I've entered the Retterheld solely to make his acquaintance.

I twist my head upwards, my gaze sharp, jaw clenched, and ears listening keenly. Surely no one could have thought to enter through one of the clerestory windows? A skilled climber might have found it possible to reach the top, but it's a fifty-foot drop from there to the cold marble of the temple floor. Yet the creak of metal echoes around me. Someone *is* opening the window.

I'm simultaneously impressed and racked with nerves. If this is the strength the other Rettlings are showing without using magic, then winning this gifting won't be easy. Not that I ever thought it would be. Still, there's no guarantee that their presence here will grant them a place in the tournament. Regardless of how impressive their entry is, their tears may yet be insufficient for Etta.

A shadow moves at the window's edge. Even from a distance, I can see it's a man from the broadness of his back and the strength of his limbs. As I watch him, he turns his body so that he faces the wall, all while balancing on the thin window ledge. Then … nothing. He stays there, fixed in the same position.

He's realising he made a mistake, I think as I watch. That's why he's hesitating; he knows there is no safe way down. He is going to fall and meet Mortidem. Either that or stay there until morning when the priestesses arrive and rescue him. As I stand there, contemplating whether I should tell someone about his predicament, a dark shadow plummets to the floor. I cover my mouth, stifling a gasp as it smacks against the marble with an audible thud.

He's dead. He has to be. No one could survive that fall. My chest tightens as I stand there, unable to move. This is a temple to the Goddess of

Life. To have a dead body here, even one who was willing to offer his soul to her, desecrates her space. The life Etta granted my parents and my brother may have been riddled with pain and betrayal, and cut short by bitter anger, but she still gave them life. Just as she gave Kay and me life. I will not leave a body here, violating her most sacred temple in Morathka. I have to move it.

My breath skitters as I step towards the crumpled pile that was a living, breathing person only a heartbeat ago. Whoever he was, likely some lord or duke, I doubt he'd want to be buried out in the slums, so I'll give his body to the knights so they can return him to his loved ones.

The shadows shift above me as I take another step towards the corpse, and my eyes snap up, confusion grabbing hold.

The man is still there – still alive – and now he's moving, lowering himself down the slick rock face, one step at a time.

What. The. Fuck.

His muscles glisten with sweat, which must weaken his grip, yet his hands and feet find impossible holds that are invisible to me from this distance. I'm an excellent climber, but the way he moves bowls me over.

I momentarily tear my gaze away from him and take another step towards the mound on the floor. It's revealed to be nothing more than a rich fur coat.

Embarrassment courses through me at the thought that I was preparing to aid a mound of cloth. Clearly this man has no need of my help, and with my offering to Etta given, I have no reason to remain in the temple. Yet I stand rooted to the ground, watching his descent. The olive skin of his back is rippled with muscles and ghosted by scars. Every single fibre is taut as he stretches and bends, reaching out with nimble fingers. Where has he come from? All men in Morathka can fight, but to climb like this? He must surely be a knighted guard or a noble from one of the other cities. Most of the others who have come from afar have already made their submissions, but like me, he is cutting it fine.

I don't know what the Eastern Isles are like, but maybe the cliff faces there are even more jagged than those beyond our walls. Or perhaps he comes from Dorain or Rowell? I've heard the further north you get, the rockier and harsher the terrain is. Coming from one of those places could surely explain such skill.

More than once, his footing slips slightly, causing my breath to stutter, but every time he manages to find his place again, and from what I can hear, not so much as a gasp leaves his lips. When he's about six feet from the ground, he looks down, twists his body, and jumps. He lands silently, knees bent, and I watch as his shoulders drop in relief. So he *was* tense. That's something, at least.

As I stand there, the fur still by my feet, I consider whether I should make him aware of my presence. Unless he saw me when he first entered through the clerestory window, he'll have no idea I have been here all this while. Watching him.

I said my prayer aloud to the Goddess and would loathe for someone to have heard my private words. I owe him the same privacy. I prepare to clear my throat, but he turns just then, and his eyes snap to mine.

The colour alone is enough to steal my breath. Every shade of crystal blue shines within his gaze.

My pulse skips and my throat tightens as he brushes his thumb against his bottom lip, but beyond that subtle motion, neither of us moves. He is about my age – twenty-three, perhaps a couple of years older – but I was wrong in thinking he came from outside Wrohelm. Black ink marks his skin in six perfectly concentric circles that cross from his shoulder onto his chest. The six circles of our city. He is Wrohelm-born, meaning that perhaps I knew him growing up. He would not have looked like this all those years ago, of course, but I'd have remembered him.

Silence swells between us as his gaze shifts down, first to my charcoal-coated fingers, then to my body. He goes slowly, as if taking in every part of it. Of course he is. I'm wearing rags, whereas I suspect every other woman who's made it this far has been in full fighting leathers. Or at least had shoes without holes. Then again, it's not like he's fully dressed either. If he were, my eyes wouldn't keep absentmindedly drifting to that place where a thin line of hair disappears into his waistband.

His lips tip up into a smirk, and when he speaks, it's with a velvety baritone that makes my knees weak. 'That's not the kind of wet I normally like my women to be, but I guess it's a starting place.'

My gaze pings up to meet his, indignation flooding me, and it takes a split second for me to realise he's referring to my clothes.

'Wading through icy water was undoubtedly more enjoyable than any weak attempt at foreplay you could possibly offer,' I shoot back.

‘If icy water is the best you’ve had, sweetheart, then you’ve been tragically undereducated. I could always help rectify that.’

A ripple of static spreads across my skin, tingling in the most inappropriate places considering I’m standing in a holy temple. Fuck.

I scramble for a retort, anything to cut him down, but those piercing eyes pin me in place. My gaze slips instead to the puddle of heavy fur still lying at my feet.

His eyes must have followed mine, because contemptuous amusement is lighting their azure depths when I look back to him. ‘You believed that to be a body,’ he says. ‘Oh, sweetheart. I don’t fall. I can stay up all night if you need me to.’

I ignore his asinine comment in favour of studying him further. There’s something achingly familiar about him. The shape of his jawline, that slight frown line crinkling the skin between his brows, and that blue shade of his eyes … it stirs something in my memory. I’ve seen that shade of blue before, but in the eyes of a woman instead. I cannot remember exactly where or when, and he speaks again before I can chase the memory further, sending my thoughts skittering away.

‘Were you going to move it?’ he questions, a curl of disdain raising his upper lip. Once again, I stay silent, causing his sneer to lift even higher. ‘Compassion is suicide in the Retterheld. You should pray to Etta that she doesn’t choose you. You won’t survive the first trial.’

And just like that, I can speak again. ‘Worry about your own prayers,’ I snap with a nod towards the altar. ‘She’s already heard mine.’

‘Was it to die in a trial you have no hope of winning?’ He frowns, looking at my hand. Abruptly, he reaches out and grabs me by the wrist. He twists my hand over to display my palm and the angry red wound still oozing blood. I didn’t realise quite how deep the cut was. Wordlessly, he takes his finger and traces the skin just beside the wound. Static radiates from his touch. Stifling a gasp, I snatch my hand back and press my palm against my side.

Blue Eyes shakes his head at me. ‘You get wounded in the Retterheld, you die.’

Prick.

‘You should watch how you speak to others,’ I snarl as the attraction I felt moments ago leaves, and anger rolls in.

Fucking lords. I was too young when I lived at the High Hold to realise just what arseholes they are. But I know now. ‘Making enemies before the trial has started doesn’t seem like the wisest thing to do. Unless…’ I quirk my eyebrow. ‘Unless you’re relying on me beating you to a pulp to provide the tears needed for your offering?’

His sneer shifts to an amused smirk, revealing a hint of dimples in those chiselled cheeks. Good Gods. Jerk or not, he is a beautiful specimen of a man. If he does get into the Retterheld, I’ll need to pray to Etta that he’s eliminated as quickly as possible. There’s no way I need a distraction like him.

Though since he’s such an asshole, I probably won’t feel too guilty about his death. He’s willingly signing up for all of this. And Etta knows the world could do with fewer men with egos like his.

‘I’ll leave you to your prayers,’ I say before nodding to the fur on the floor. ‘And pick up your coat. It’s bad manners to litter.’

With that, I turn on my heel and stride out, ready for the long walk back to the slums. Every step out of the temple is a strut, and I – almost – convince myself that not a single one is for his benefit.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 3

‘Rose! Where were you? I was worried.’

So much for hoping Kay would sleep through my third and final night outing. I open my mouth, a lie already forming on my tongue.

‘I take it you also heard the screaming?’ she says. ‘It was Evelina, next door, wasn’t it? I saw the cloaks going in there this morning. I fear the worst.’

It’s the middle of the night, and she likely barely slept, yet my sister is still the most exquisitely beautiful young woman I’ve ever seen. Even with starvation hollowing her cheeks and the same white-blonde hair that we share, she’s radiant. But her beauty is more than skin deep. With all that we’ve lost and the hateful lies spewed about our family, you’d expect her to be bitter. But she’s still so innocent. So hopeful. It’s why I give over half the brews I make to Rula and her protection racket – to make sure Kay stays like that.

‘I’ll take a tonic round to Evelina,’ I reply, relieved to have dodged an interrogation. I walk over to the small stove to retrieve a pan of the pain-relieving brew I left simmering before I left and decant it into five meagre vials. I suppress a sigh. If I give one vial of the elixir to Evelina and two to Rula, that only leaves two for sale on the black market. The good news is that prices are high at the moment; the bad news is that it’s because people are dying. And given that the people who are forced to pay the high prices have as little as we do, I can’t – won’t – ask them to pay any more than usual. So two vials aren’t going to garner anywhere near enough to buy the type of weapon I’ll need to survive the Retterheld if Etta accepts me.

‘By the Mother!’ Kay gasps as her gaze suddenly narrows on me. ‘What’s happened to your hand?’

My pulse soars. Did I not do a good enough job of cleaning my fingers? Has she spied a speck of black ash on my skin? But then she grabs me by the wrist and twists so that my palm is facing up, revealing the deep cut.

‘It’s nothing,’ I lie. ‘I was just careless.’ I hurriedly take my hand back, just in case she notes the remnants of ash beneath my nails. ‘The edge of the pan was sharper than I thought.’

Her frown remains in place a moment longer.

‘It’s not nothing,’ she says finally. ‘It needs stitches.’

‘Later. I need to get this tonic to Evelina, and you need to get some sleep. You’re working tomorrow, right?’

It’s difficult for anyone to get work in the slums, but Kay’s job is part of the agreement I have with Rula. I keep giving Rula tonics for free, and Kay spends her days looking after children in the fifth ring, thinking that scoring her job was a stroke of luck, allowing us to land on our feet.

Landing on our feet. It’s enough to make me cry. Were we still living in the High Hold, she would be fighting off proposals from dukes, lords, and maybe even a prince. Instead, we live in utter squalor.

The gifting is the only chance I have to return her to the life she truly deserves.

‘I think there will be six children tomorrow,’ Kay replies. ‘And Losarah said she will pay me with flour from the mill. We usually get far more that way than when she pays me in loaves, so we’ll eat well tomorrow.’

My stomach growls. Eating well isn’t something I can recall doing since my father died, but for once we might not have to go to bed to the sound of our hollow stomachs crying out.

Kay sets a hand on her hip. ‘Stop trying to distract me,’ she scolds. ‘You’re not going anywhere until that wound is stitched up. And if you don’t do it, I will.’

This time I take her threat seriously. Though she’s talented at many things, her sewing’s even worse than her brewing. If I let her do it, I won’t be able to use that hand for days, if not weeks, and from the satisfied smile tugging at her lips, she knows I know it. Luckily, the cut is on my non-dominant hand.

Ten teeth-gritting minutes later, the wound is stitched and covered in a salve of my own creation. I show her my neat repair work and she nods,

finally happy to let me go.

‘Make sure you block the door properly when I’m gone,’ I say over my shoulder.

She rolls her eyes. ‘I will, Rose. Give Evelina my love, won’t you? And ask if there’s anything else we can do for them.’

‘Of course.’ Though, truthfully, we could offer little more than what they already had. At least there’s equality in the slums, where we’re all equally fucked.



THE NIGHT AIR somehow feels even colder now than it did when I arrived home. Frost creaks underneath my feet while clouds of smoke rise from those houses lucky enough to have fires burning inside.

I head out down the narrow pathway, and when I reach Evelina’s, I knock once, only to find the action is enough to push the door open. My chest tightens. That’s not a good omen. Leaving your door open in the slums is a sign that you have nothing left for people to take.

The room is larger than ours, although space comes at the cost of warmth. My breath swells into soft plumes even after I’ve stepped inside. The bed is in the corner, next to the tiny fire, and thick layers of fur and wool rise and fall softly. Corem is sitting with his body bent over his wife, so hunched that all I can see is a small slice of his back. The sound of muffled sobbing reaches my ears and my stomach twists.

‘Corem?’ My voice is soft, barely a whisper. ‘I brought a tonic for Evelina. Kay told me the priestesses were here today. I trust they eased her suffering?’

Corem’s back straightens and his hands move to his cheeks, wiping away tears.

‘Rose?’ He faces me, forcing a smile that only succeeds in highlighting the weariness and despair in his eyes. ‘Thank you. Yes, the cloaks came. Three of the sisters.’

Three being one of the holy numbers, the cloaks always came in threes if they could.

‘And?’ I don’t know why I say the word expectantly. Like I’m hoping he will tell me Evelina’s fever will pass, that the priestesses wove their

tendrils of magic around her body and lifted the sickness straight from her soul. Because I already know that isn't what he will say. Our wretched souls don't get the same treatment as those at the High Hold.

'Tomorrow, they will take her.' His voice breaks. 'Cleanse her body for the burning.'

'There is nothing more that can be done?' I try to hide the shock that shoots through me. 'You do not wish to wait longer? Wait until…?' *Until she dies.* The words don't leave my lips because they don't have to. We both know death is all that's left for Evelina.

Corem shakes his head. 'They said it is best for her to be in the temple when she passes. Her soul will be in less pain that way.' His bottom lip trembles. 'I don't want her to be in pain anymore.'

He's not the first person I've heard say such a thing, and yet, for my mother's sake, I pray it isn't true. She died in the home that we shared in the fifth ring after our fall from grace, our hands clasping hers as she drew her last breath. We even burned her together. Dinah was the only priestess with us. The only adult who stayed. My father had already left, choosing drink over duty before the pyre was even lit.

With effort, I quash my rising vitriol towards the man I once held in such high esteem.

'Here.' I stretch out my hand to offer him the vial of tonic, trying to shake away the weight of the past. 'It will bring her some peace as she sleeps.'

Corem hesitates. 'I cannot pay you what it is worth.'

'I do not ask for payment,' I say softly.

He falters a moment longer, then takes it. 'Thank you.' He pockets the vial before he stands and walks across the room to retrieve a bowl. 'Here. The cloaks brought these. Take a couple. For you and Acacia. It's all I can offer.'

Bread rolls. My stomach growls even more loudly than it did when Kay mentioned food earlier. Every part of my body wants me to reach out and grab them, but I pause, staring at the basket. If I take two, there'll be just one left, meaning he and Evelina will have to share. I'm not even sure she can eat, but if she can, I will not rob her of her last meal.

'Thank you, but I will just take one for Acacia. I've eaten already,' I lie.

Relief flashes across his face.

I want to offer to stay with him until morning, until the priestesses come, or offer to return when they take the body. But I already know he'll refuse.

Instead, I cross to Evelina, brushing her dark, sweat-soaked hair back from her forehead. 'Acacia sends her love,' I murmur, but she does not stir. 'As do I. Rest easy, Evelina.'

Her chest rattles as she breathes.

No, she does not have long now.

I silently nod to Corem as I leave. I already know there are no true words of comfort to offer the grieving.

I open the door and disappear into the frigid night, trying to fight the sting of tears behind my eyes. But it is a losing battle.

Because if there is one thing this life has taught me, it is that there is always time for more tears.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 4

‘You’re very quiet,’ Kay says as we elbow our way through the market the following morning. The smell of smoke and roasted nuts is thick in the air as we weave our way through the hordes of people.

‘*Death to Korvane!’* someone screams, and a jostle from the side makes me lose sight of Kay. My heart lurches, and the moment I spot her again, I grab her hand. Despite the shoving and sharp elbows – not to mention the angry tirades against our bastard of a king – the market’s usually a safe place to be. Usually. But there are always exceptions, and experience has taught me to remain vigilant.

‘You should be excited,’ Kay continues. ‘They’re announcing the Rettlings today.’

‘They are?’ I feign surprise even though my heart has been thundering since the moment I woke. Several times it crossed my mind to tell her what I’ve done, but with the possibility that my name won’t be called, there is no need for Kay to ever know I attempted to enter.

‘There are likely to be some names we recognise, don’t you think? People from the court?’ Excitement rises in her voice. ‘Perhaps some of our parents’ friends. Your friends, even.’

‘Acquaintances, Kay,’ I correct her. ‘Friends stand by you.’

Kay tuts as if my statement is unreasonable. The fact that she remembers less about our time in the High Hold means she doesn’t understand just how deep the betrayal was. We were an integral part of the court. We should have been above reproach.

‘Well, talking of acquaintances, look who’s walking this way.’ Kay gestures ahead. A group of people are bartering with raised voices for a jar

of something or other, but my eyes are immediately drawn behind them to a broad figure wearing a knitted beanie hat and an ever-present grin. Warmth spreads through me at the sight of him, a subconscious echo of the magic he wields.

Next to him is his friend, Peter, who scowls at me. I ignore him with practised ease. He may be Ruben's friend, but he's never been mine. It's difficult to place a finger on exactly what it is that I don't like about Peter. Perhaps it's the way he walks around with his sleeves rolled up, his swirling tattoo of a coil of smoke on display, as if he needs to prove his manhood by unnecessarily exposing himself to the cold. The last thing we need is more people dying of hyperthermia.

'Hey Ruben.' Kay beams when he finally squeezes his way across to us.

'Kay!' He opens his arms wide, offering a quite literally warming hug.

Rather than respond to him, Kay glances at me, as if she's asking permission. It's one hundred percent not necessary, but I nod anyway. A moment later, his arms are wrapped tightly around her, and I watch Kay's body relax as his warmth seeps into her. The gentleness of Ruben's ability to crank up his body temperature would have been laughed at in the High Hold. Sure, it would be impressive if he could convert that heat into fireballs that he could throw at the Issen and Torailian when they attack our borders, but down in the slums, his gentle warmth keeps people alive.

Korvane and his generals don't seem to understand that battles aren't the only thing that kills people at war. Cold does too.

As Kay steps back from Ruben's embrace, her face flushed with heat, he looks at me, an eyebrow quirked in question. I go in next. The warmth rushes to my extremities, and the relief from the cold is welcome. I didn't realise how freezing I was.

Unsurprisingly, Ruben pulls me in far closer than he did with Kay, then lowers his head so it's next to the shell of my ear, his breath teasing my skin in the way he knows I like. 'I haven't seen you for a couple of nights,' he whispers.

'I've been busy,' I mutter evasively. The last thing I need is for Kay to overhear our conversation, given that I told her I was spending time with Ruben when I was actually monitoring the guards at the temple.

'Well, my bed's been cold.' His brown eyes look down at me as he speaks. Soft, warm brown eyes. Friendly. Straightforward. Nothing like the icy-blue gaze that held mine last night.

Not that I was thinking about that asshole again.

I laugh in response. ‘Your bed’s never cold,’ I say, trying to sound casual as I inwardly curse myself for thinking about another man’s eyes when a perfectly good pair is staring right into mine.

‘Okay, you’re right,’ he concedes with a smirk. ‘But it would still be more comfortable with you in it.’

‘Also untrue. Your bed is always tiny and rock hard, regardless of the company.’

His answering laugh is deep and throaty. It’s incredibly tempting to press myself into his heat again and take his offer of spending more nights with him. It’s not as if I don’t like him. He’s a good guy, the kind who puts others first – the way people with nothing always seem to. And I know he likes me – even with my lack of magic – but would I weep for weeks if he suddenly told me he’d found someone else to spend his evenings with? I don’t think so. For all his easy smiles, he has a detachedness to him. Like he’s not ready to let himself really *be* in front of me. Like he needs to keep part of himself hidden.

Not that I’m one to talk. For the first six months of us sleeping together, he didn’t even know my surname, and when he finally heard the Kultavaris name – the Queenkiller’s name – I expected it to provoke some sort of reaction. But no, just a slight shrug. Sometimes I think that’s the reason he likes to spend time with me. The lack of commitment. The screw you to the court. And the screw itself.

‘Maybe later in the week,’ I suggest loosely.

‘It would have to be the very end. I’m busy the next couple of nights.’

I raise an eyebrow. ‘Busy?’

‘Jealous?’ He smirks.

‘No, just intrigued.’ The comment is genuine. Ruben and my get-togethers are normally so late at night that they verge on early morning, and generally speaking, no good deeds are happening at that hour. Not out in the slums, that’s for sure. So yes, I’m definitely intrigued as to what he’s doing.

‘If you two can stop sucking face for one second, I think something’s happening,’ Peter interrupts. He has the manners of a wounded dire wolf.

With my jaw clenched, I draw myself away from Ruben and offer a scowl to the man with the shock of red hair who’s currently smirking at me.

‘We were not sucking face. We were hugging. For warmth,’ I tell him. ‘And who even says “sucking face”?’

‘Oh, I’ve definitely seen you two suck faces before.’

When he grins, it takes more than a fraction of my willpower not to hit him.

The short, stocky illusionist, whose face is painted with a seemingly endless array of freckles, has more powers than anyone else I know in the slums. With magic like his, I’m sure he could have found himself a place inside one of the higher rings. But his powers aren’t the problem. His mouth is. He’s pissed off pretty much everyone at some time or another, except perhaps Ruben. But then again, maybe Ruben’s too laid back to ever get really annoyed. With his attitude, he could be from Dorain.

‘Rose!’ Kay exclaims excitedly as she taps me on the arm and points across the square. ‘I think they’re announcing the Rettlings!’

The noise cranks up around us as stalls are shifted and bartering is cut short. Six guards are approaching the market square, all of them dressed in the deep maroon that signifies King Korvane’s personal soldiers and security. He likes to brag that the enemy starts running the moment they see the colour against the ice, but we all know the truth: it’s so the blood is less visible when the bodies are returned.

‘Why’s the announcement so soon?’ I ask, trying to hide my panic. On the very slim chance that I actually get chosen, I wanted Kay nowhere near me when the announcement happened. ‘I thought they didn’t read out the list of Rettlings until noon?’

In the slums, time is told by stone. The great column of the High Hold towers at the rings’ centre, its shadow marking the hours as it crawls across the dirt. The market lies untouched by it still, which means the day is young – likely not yet even ten.

‘My grandfather said they announced the last one at dawn to give everyone more time to lay bets,’ Ruben says, oblivious to the way my hands are now trembling. He shrugs. ‘But then, *his* grandfather said they announced the previous one at sunset.’

‘So basically they do it whenever the hell they like,’ I hiss through gritted teeth. My heart is hammering beneath my sternum with such force I’m surprised it hasn’t broken free. I turn and look at Kay and try to steady my voice as much as possible. ‘Don’t you have to go?’ I say to her. ‘You don’t want to be late.’

She looks at me like I’ve grown two heads. ‘They are announcing Etta’s choice for Rettlings, for what is likely to be the only Retterheld I will ever

see in my lifetime. I'm not going anywhere! Besides, like I said, I want to see if we recognise any names.'

The lump in my throat is cutting off the air to my lungs, and I'm certain I'm going to faint.

The slum residents scatter to the sides of the square, making room for the imposing guards, and I'm surprised by the tension that ripples through my body at the sight of them. I've seen guards plenty of times since we were thrown out of the High Hold – I was dodging them for the last three nights, for crying out loud – but something about the way they're standing reminds me of the moment they dragged my mother away that night, the prince's cold eyes fixed on us.

'The Great Goddess Etta has made her choice for the nineteenth Retterheld.' The lead guard's voice pulls me out of the memory and sends the rest of the slum into heart-racing silence. 'The following nobles and knights have been selected to fight for the gifting—'

As the silence holds fast, I know most of the people around me are thinking the same thing: why the hell would a noble need a gifting? What does one who has it all need *more* for?

I'm fighting the urge not to reach out and take Ruben's arm for support, but I don't want to give him the wrong impression. Besides, if I can't stand on my own two feet now, I'm going to be screwed if I do actually get into the trials. The churning in my stomach is so strong that I swear I'm about to start seeing stars when the first name pulls me back into the moment.

'Sir Jonas Lorathin.'

Kay swivels to look at me. 'Jonas. Isn't that—'

'Artur's son,' I reply. That's all she will know of Jonas. His father found us the house in the fifth ring when we were cast out of the High Hold. He also used to visit occasionally, all the way until my mother's death. He was the only one.

Unlike Kay, I remember Jonas himself. I remember the days before we were cast out, when we sparred with one another, sword against sword, hand against hand. I recall his sandy hair – golden and warm, unlike my stripped white-blonde – and his amber eyes, and the way he would throw his head back when he laughed. Not to mention the awe he displayed whenever I showed him the first inkling of my magic, his own having not yet manifested.

I can’t deny that I’m more than a little intrigued to learn about the man he has grown into. Yet before I have time to fix my thoughts of him, the next name is called.

‘Rose Kultavaris.’

The air is stolen from my lungs and all the strength washes from my knees.

Me.

Etta chose *me*.

A gasp rattles around the market as every pair of eyes turns to look at me.

‘I’m in.’ The words come out as barely a whisper, and I find my lips still moving. ‘I’m in.’

I did it. I’m in the Retterheld.

The overwhelm that rushes through me is enough to have me reaching out a hand to balance myself, and it’s only when my fingers touch the rough edge of hewn fabric that I realise I did not find Ruben as I intended. Instead, I turn to find myself looking at a pair of eyes the exact same shade of green as my own. And right now, they harbour a hardness I didn’t know they could possess.

Kay’s jaw is tight. ‘What the fuck have you done, Rose?’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 5

I can count the number of times my sister has sworn on two hands, and even then, I can't remember any time she's used that particular expletive, but I sense there's a lot more vitriol coming my way. Her eyes are dark as she glowers at me, and a guilt-inducing sheen of tears appears.

'I don't understand. Why, Rose? Why would you do this?'

'We're not doing this here, Kay,' I say, missing the next name announced as we hiss at each other.

'You should have said something to me!'

As I take a step closer to Kay to tell her that we'll talk more when we're alone, in private, the silence of the market is suddenly replaced by rushed, bubbling whispers.

'Whose name did they just say?' I ask.

Jaw tight, Ruben replies, 'Kyor Knavin.'

My stomach drops.

Prince Kyor. The king's only son. The heir to the throne. The prince who lied and condemned my sister and me to this cursed life.

A loud question cuts across the mutters.

'The king let him enter?'

'It must be rigged. The king will not let him die.'

'Surely he's the strongest fighter? He's the high commander of the army.'

Kay's eyes bore into me. I can literally feel the fear radiating from her and I get it. If the Retterheld wasn't dangerous before, it sure as hell is now.

'He will kill you, Rose.' Her voice trembles as she spins our mother's ring on her finger. 'He would rather murder every person in the kingdom

than let you be gifted by Etta. Not after Mother—'

'Don't!' I snap as I turn to face her. 'He doesn't get a say in my fate. Not anymore.'

Winning the Retterheld was previously my only aim, but now I've added another goal to my list: kill Prince Kyor.

Half a dozen names I don't recognise are called before the guards leave with an announcement that all fifty who have been chosen will meet at the High Hold the following night for their presentation to the king.

Heat burns through me. Tomorrow, I will face *them*. Face the people who cast us out, who caused my parents to suffer undeservedly in every moment until their deaths. And in turn, they will finally face what they have done.



I'VE NOT GOT enough money to go to the third ring and buy a weapon, which means I need help, and there's only one person I can go to for it.

Unlike the previous nights, when I walked through the outer rings to reach the temple, time is an issue today. As such, I stow away on the back of a carriage. From the fabric that's stacked inside, I suspect it's heading to the second ring, though I can't know for sure as I silently drop down from the back before we reach the third. Then, trying to pretend I don't look completely out of place in torn clothes and with scraped elbows, I keep my head high as I approach the gate where three knights stand with their bonded dire wolves, one of which is currently sniffing the carriage I hitched a ride on.

I've heard from some people that you should acknowledge the wolves first, rather than the men-at-arms, as the wolves are the ones that hold the greater power. So, though the thought of facing an enormous pair of jaws is more than a little terrifying, I manage a split second of eye contact with the smallest of the beasts. It's long enough to see the white ring gleaming between the animal's pupils and irises – the sign that it is bonded. As my ribs squeeze my breath, I hurriedly offer a dip of my chin before looking away. Hopefully that's enough deference.

'You! What business do you have here?' The pompousness of the guard's tone immediately causes a twist of irritation to rise within me. I

know for a fact that my parents never spoke to anyone like that. Even when my father was so drunk he could barely remember our names, he remembered his manners. Though such a nature likely arose for the same reason that several members of the court refused to accept him as their equal. Given that his mother had worked the taverns of the fifth ring and his lordly father already had a *legitimate* heir by his wife, my father would never have set foot in the High Hold were it not for a twist of fate.

'My name is Rose Kultavaris.'

The guard's jaw drops slightly as his eyes flicker to my white-blonde hair.

'I've been selected for the Retterheld, and I wish to visit the temple of Etta.'

'You're filthy,' the second one interjects.

'And?'

'And the Retterheld is for the nobles and knights of Morathka, and you ain't either of them anymore.'

I tip my head to the side and stifle a sigh, wishing I had scaled the wall instead. 'I have been selected for the Retterheld,' I repeat, 'and considering my attire was good enough for Etta, it should be good enough for you.'

They exchange uneasy glances, but step aside.

'Thank you,' I say politely. As I start to move past them, one of the dire wolves takes a step towards me.

The great beast is covered in rust-red fur that's greyed around the muzzle, while one of its eyes has a milky whiteness to it, as if it's losing its sight.

'I am who I say I am,' I murmur to the wolf, trying to steady the drumming in my chest. 'You can let me pass.'

His black nose twitches as he sniffs, and then he nonchalantly turns around and lets me through. My legs tremble as I continue forward. Dire wolves are scary as fuck.

Although the temple is straight in front of me, I don't go towards it. Instead, I veer to the left, staying wide of the frozen moat as I pass the great marble building and head along a strip of frosted grass that crunches beneath my feet. My pace slows as I glance upwards to the small clerestories that sit fifty feet off the ground. From what I can tell, there are no better footholds on the outside of the building than there were on the

inside, and once again, my mind flits to those icy-blue eyes and the delicious body that possesses them. Shame about the soul.

Would Etta choose someone like him for the Retterheld? It's difficult to tell. He certainly has the strength to succeed in the more physical trials. But that arrogance? Would she really want to gift someone like *that* his heart's desire? Surely he wants for nothing.

Maybe Etta simply chooses some people as sacrifices – although if that is true, I pray that's not the reason she chose me.

Behind the temple is a long wall that bisects almost the entire third ring. Beyond are the living quarters of the handful of Etta's priestesses who reside within Wrohelm. A frisson of nerves ripples through me as I make my way over to the ivy-covered wall. It's been a long time since I've been to the priestesses' quarters, and I worry that she won't see me.

Unlike the grass, there is not a hint of frost on the deep green ivy leaves, and the moment my fingers brush against them, it is clear why. Magic fizzes through my palm, biting not only my skin but also the tears behind my eyes. There is something about this magic that calls to the surface the pain of everything that was taken from me, but without any magic of my own to rise to the harsh summoning, all I feel is hollow. That's what hurts the most about being stripped: knowing you will never be complete. Knowing however much you try, however good you are, there will always be holes within you. Kay and I deserve better.

'Priestess Dinah Poltick,' I murmur to the ivy, and my stomach clenches as I pray she will answer my request.

The heat on my palm remains for a moment longer before it disappears into nothing.

All I can do now is wait and hope that Dinah is even present in the temple. If she's not, then I'm going to have to come up with another plan, and quickly. But rather than focusing on what my next actions should be, I can't help but think of the Retterheld.

Like the people in the slums, I assumed the king would have forbidden his only heir to enter, but I find I am absurdly glad that he didn't. The Retterheld has already given me one gift: the chance at revenge. And maybe the fact that the Goddess deems me worthy is a sign that the royals should too.

Of course, I'm not oblivious to the whispers that flitted around the market when his name was called. About his skills as a fighter. About the

fact that people think he will win. But Etta knows the truth of what happened between us. She knows what he did to us. If the Goddess accepts anyone into the tournament purely as a sacrifice, it should be him.

‘Rose.’ Just the sound of my name spoken in Dinah’s soft tone is enough to stir memories.

I turn to find her framed by ivy, and her smile holds me immobile for a breath. It is so joyous, so full of love, that some cold part of me thaws just a little. Her eyes, though, have shadows of hurt and regret.

It pains her to see me. I knew it would. But I had no other choice.

Dinah steps forward wordlessly, cups my cheek, and then whispers in my ear, ‘My darling Rose. You’re the very image of your mother.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 6

Dinah looks as unchanged as ever. The pearlescent hooded blue cape she wears is the same shimmering shade as the opalescent stone embedded in her forehead, just above her brow line. The stonebinding is the last stage of becoming a priestess, and the power that resonates through the gem comes from their chosen God, giving them magic that is said to be far greater than anything the rest of us possess.

'Rose, my dear child,' Dinah murmurs. Tears fill her eyes as she runs her hand over my white-blonde hair then grasps me by the shoulders as if she's trying to assess how much weight I've lost since I last saw her. That's the main reason I've kept my distance. It's hard to pretend you're doing okay when every time you meet it looks like more muscle has melted from your frame.

'Tell me it's a mistake,' she says when she finally lets me go. 'Please, Rose. Tell me you didn't enter.'

'I did, and the Goddess accepted me.' I smile a little in pride, but Dinah closes her eyes and mutters to herself.

'She did,' she says eventually, opening her eyes and looking at me, her mouth tight. 'And the Goddess always has her reasons.'

I force my smile to remain in place. I hate that line. Really fucking hate it.

The Goddess had her reasons. That was what Dinah said after my family's magic was stripped. She said the words with conviction, but as my mother struggled and grew sicker, and my father began to drink himself towards a premature reunion with my brother, that conviction was tested. Every visit, the darkness in her eyes and the worry that clouded her became

more acute. She loved our mother and had raised her in the temple as a daughter. And so I witnessed the way it became harder and harder for her to say to us that *the Goddess had her reasons*. Dinah gave her life to the service of Etta, and it was as though our diminishment was making her doubt that choice.

'I'll be fine, Dinah.' My eyes are unblinking as I speak so that she can see how firmly I believe the words I'm saying. 'I promise. I may not have magic, but I have skills.'

And it's true. I'm not completely helpless. There may not be much room for axe swinging and practising with full-length swords in the slums, but daggers are a different matter. I started training with knives as a way to vent my frustration over my mother's death as much as anything else. I took the thin blades we used to skin rabbits – back when we could still afford to buy meat – and began hurling them at targets. Short distances at first, just across the room into the wooden beams that held up our roof, then stretching the length between me and my target further and further.

'Dinah, it's not me I'm worried about,' I say, steering the conversation towards the first of the two reasons I've come. 'It's Acacia.'

Dinah's expression remains pinched with concern, but she doesn't speak.

'I need her out of the slums,' I say. 'At least while I'm in the tournament. I need to know she is safe, or I won't be able to focus. Besides, you know they only get the information second-hand out there. She'll be a wreck if she doesn't even know if I'm alive.' Assuming I am still alive. 'I need you to reach out to Lord Artur Lorathin.'

'Artur?' Her expression tightens further. 'His son's also been chosen, has he not?'

'He has. Meaning he will understand the fear that Kay faces. He's a good man. I'm sure he will see to it that she's taken into one of the inner rings where she can watch my progress more closely. Will you do that for me?'

Dinah does not immediately reply and I can almost hear her mind whirring.

'I will speak to him,' she says shortly, eyes still dark with worry. 'Rose, the others… they will have powers, all of them. And they know how to fight. Every day they train to kill.'

I stifle a snort. ‘No one fights harder than someone who lives in the slums and knows what life is like outside of it,’ I tell her. ‘Believe me. And one day I will have powers too. Once I win and have what was taken from us returned.’ I let out a reluctant sigh as her eyes pinch in familiar pity. ‘I’m not being naïve, Dinah. I know what I’m going up against. I know how hard they fight, and I know this will be ugly, but I also know that none of them need to win the gifting the way I do. Besides, powers are not allowed in all the trials.’

‘One,’ she bites back. ‘They’re not allowed to use their powers in *one* of the trials. They can be freely used in the other four.’

‘I know the odds are stacked against me, but Etta chose me. She chose *me*, Dinah. Weak, stripped, powerless me.’ My gaze locks on hers. ‘As you are so fond of saying, the Goddess has her reasons.’

Dinah’s the only priestess I would ever dare speak to in such a manner, but she has always been more of a grandmother figure to me. A very slow-ageing grandmother.

‘Kay is not the only reason I’ve come,’ I say, keen to get to the other favour I seek before she has to leave. ‘I need a weapon. I don’t know what they will have there or if we will be able to take one from King Korvane’s armoury. Is there any chance you have something I may use?’

Her lips press tightly together. ‘I am sure I will be able to find something,’ she replies, then continues without pausing for breath, ‘I am going away tomorrow. Heading to the North. I will ensure Artur gets your message before I leave.’

‘The North?’ I question. That seems like a very vague description. If she were heading to one of the Northern Morathkian cities – Rowell or Dorain – she would have named it.

My nerves twist. Unless… she’s heading up the Hirathean Pass, towards Agoyd? I would rather she travel anywhere else than there. No ground in the kingdom has drunk more blood than the land south of the Coltan Mountains.

‘It should only be for a few days,’ she says, ignoring my question, though her response eases my fears slightly. It takes at least three days to reach Galreck, and that is only part of the way to Agoyd.

She continues, looking heartsore, ‘I will be gone for your vows, and it’s likely I’ll still be absent for the first trial, but I should have returned by the second. Please, Rose, stay alive until then.’

A smile curls my lips. ‘I’m definitely going to try.’

She reciprocates with a smile so fleeting I almost miss it.

‘Wait here,’ she says. ‘I will be one moment.’

Without waiting for me to reply, she turns her back and strides through the solid stone wall as though it offers no more resistance than mist. This was her gift before she took her vows to the Goddess, but I’ve always struggled to work out which God or Goddess granted it.

A warmth spreads through me as I recall Dinah telling me how, as soon as my mother learned to walk, she tried to mimic everything the priestess did. Which meant that when Dinah passed through walls, my mother attempted the same. Unsurprisingly, the bruises piled up quickly.

Dinah takes longer to return than I expected, and I wait nervously. When she steps back through the stone, her arms are laden with a large packet wrapped in hessian. The bundle is so high that her head is barely visible above it. There’s no chance that’s all weapons.

‘Clothes,’ she says, answering my unasked question. ‘I suspect they are years out of fashion, but if tradition stands, then the palace will host balls to mark the stages of the trials, and you will be expected to attend. Of course, if you have more fitting clothes, then please give these away.’

‘I don’t,’ I say quickly, taking them gratefully. However dated these clothes may be, they will be far more suitable for a ball than anything I currently own. We took nothing with us that wasn’t useful, because though gossamer gowns may look pretty, they do a piss-poor job of keeping you warm.

It’s only as I take the pile of clothes from Dinah that I spot the satchel slung across the priestess’s body.

‘It is a strange wonder, the odd items that people leave in the name of Etta.’ Dinah slips the bag off her shoulder. ‘Or maybe they just leave them here because they can no longer hold the burden of what they contain. Either way’—she loops the bag’s strap over me—’I believe you will find far more use for these items than the temple would have.’

The satchel is weighted and bulging. Even if it’s filled with bread alone, it’ll be a gift I deeply appreciate, though judging by her cryptic comments, I doubt it’s anything so prosaic. Relief surges. Perhaps she did find me a weapon then.

I reach for the flap, eager to see what’s inside, but before I can, Dinah places her hand on top of mine.

‘When you are at home,’ she says, ‘and cannot be overlooked,’ she adds pointedly.

I glance around us. There’s no one in our immediate vicinity, but I nod in understanding.

‘Thank you, Dinah. For everything.’

‘You are very welcome, child.’

She smiles and draws me into her arms. The embrace is clumsy with the cumbersome items between us, but no less welcome.

‘Stay alive,’ she instructs me fiercely as we break apart.

I smile, but I don’t make any promises. I don’t want to break my word, even in death.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 7

When I return home, Kay has gone from mad to livid.

'Of all the pig-headed things to do! And you just expect me to accept your idiocy? Well, I won't do that. I am furious with you, Rose. Furious!' She is beginning to repeat herself after fifteen minutes of ranting but has yet to begin losing steam. She continues sharply, 'No, furious is not enough. I don't have words for how angry I am with you right now. I'm … I'm … argh!!!' While her articulation is unusually sloppy, the manner in which she stamps her foot and glowers at me does a perfectly good job of expressing her feelings.

Her hands clench into fists and she brings them down on the wooden countertop of our table for the second time. Like everything in the slums, it's made of laughably weak wood, and if she's not careful, she'll break it in two. I don't point this out though, as I know I need to pick my battles wisely … which is why, of course, I signed up for the deadliest competition of my lifetime.

She rubs her hand and glares at me accusingly. 'At least if you'd spoken to me about it first, that would have been *something*.'

'If I'd spoken to you about it, you would have refused to let me enter,' I say mildly. 'Or done something even more stupid, like try to enter yourself just to make a point.'

Her glare is withering. 'So, *me* entering would be stupid, but for you it's a brilliant idea? Talk about hypocritical!'

'It's not hypocritical,' I lie, fully aware that it absolutely is. 'You are just eighteen, meaning you'd be the youngest there. You were barely in your

fighting furs when we were kicked out of the High Hold, so you have no idea what these people are like. I do.'

She scoffs. 'You're telling me that six years make such a difference, when the king's knights can enter? People who have trained in war and fighting for their entire lives? Prince Kyor is in it, for crying out loud! No, you didn't tell me what you were doing because you knew it was a terrible idea.'

'It isn't a terrible idea!' I spit back, my own temper finally fraying. I take a calming breath and reach for her hands, looking her in the eye. 'I'm not lying, Kay. I can win this. I can feel it in my bones. The Goddess heard my offering. She understood it and she chose me because of it. She will be on my side. She will guide me, keep me safe.'

'Do you not realise that every person who's been accepted also believes they are worthy of winning because the Goddess chose them? Surely you can see that?'

Fuck, when it's worded like that, it's hard to disagree. But whatever was in their tears of offering, whatever their pleas, I doubt they felt them as fervently as I did, nor are they as motivated. None of those spoiled, rich nobles know desperation like I do. I'm certain of it.

'What about Kyor?' Kay says wearily. 'Have you thought about what he will do to you?'

I try to shrug nonchalantly, as if his name hasn't even crossed my mind since it was called. 'I doubt he will even recognise me,' I remark. 'It's been fourteen years.'

She scoffs. 'Are you telling me you don't remember his face?'

'I recall his brown eyes, but apart from that … I honestly doubt I'd recognise him now.' I am lying. Of course I am.

I will never forget his youthful face as he begged my mother to save his mother. I will never forget the pain in his deep brown eyes when the queen chose her unborn child's life over her own, a child who never even saw his first breath. Most of all, I remember the venom in those eyes as he told his father that it was my mother's fault the queen was dead. That the queen had begged for her life, but my mother had chosen instead to deliver the frail babe, born with a cord around his neck and twisted limbs, rather than save the woman the king had grown to love.

I remember how the prince looked at me, unblinking, as he spewed his lies, condemning us all.

But would I recognise the man he has become? Maybe not.

I push the memories away and face my sister. ‘Kay, please.’ I lower my voice as I place my hands on her shoulders. ‘Let’s not do this. I’m going to the palace tomorrow and we have no idea how many moons these trials will last. I don’t want to spend our last hours arguing. It is done, and it cannot be undone. Please, sit with me. We can see what Dinah has given me.’

‘You went to see Dinah?’ she asks in surprise. The pair have always been close, and no doubt my solo visit is another black mark against me.

‘I did. And she gave me some things. Mostly clothes, but also this.’ I lift the satchel from where I placed it by the door, even more aware of its weight than I was when Dinah placed it on my shoulders.

Despite the angry facade she wants to keep in place, I can see Kay’s interest is piqued. It’s been a long time since we’ve had parcels or gifts… unless you include the rats that the stray cats sometimes leave outside.

‘What’s in there?’ she asks.

‘I don’t know. Shall we look?’

I’m desperately eager to gain back some favour with my little sister, and so I hand her the satchel and give her the chance to indulge her curiosity before I do.

She opens up the bag, slips a hand inside, and pulls out a small paper packet tied with twine.

‘It looks like seeds,’ she says, a frown marring her smooth skin.

My heart skips. ‘Seeds?’

She hands it to me, and the skip in my heart turns into a full-on lurch as I recognise the contents: rare and costly paparvy seeds, prized for their pain-relieving properties. I wince inwardly. Dinah clearly expects me to be in considerable pain over the coming weeks. Hardly encouraging. Still, it makes me wonder what other treasures the satchel holds. She was obviously lying when she claimed it contained only odd things left behind at the temple.

By the time I fold the top of the packet carefully, not wishing to lose a single seed, Kay has already got the next item out for me.

‘More seeds.’ She shrugs. ‘I don’t recognise these either.’

As she hands them to me, I feel a pang of big-sisterly love mixed with relief that she doesn’t recognise dealun seeds, which means she isn’t using them yet. I, on the other hand, rely on them – my hookups with Ruben are only possible because the weeds the seeds come from grow in abundance in

the slums. The last thing I need is a baby when I can barely feed Kay and myself. Still, the Retterheld is going to last several moons, and it's possible I'll meet someone who could serve as a welcome distraction from trials and training, so the seeds might as well come with me.

'Gloves.' Kay breaks my thoughts as she shoves a pair of brown leather fighting gloves at me. They're good quality, fingerless with straps that go down past the wrist, offering extra support. 'This one is heavy,' Kay says, pulling out a rectangular metal box and handing it to me.

'Are you not going to open it first?' I ask.

'You can do this one.'

'How generous,' I say, but we exchange a smile, our first since my return home, and I'm grateful for it.

I lift the lid and gasp at the sight in front of me.

It is a dagger unlike any I've ever seen before.

The hilt is made of copper, an unusually soft metal for such a role, and when I grasp it, it is a perfect fit for my grip. As I pull the weapon from its sheath, a bolt of energy shoots into my palm and up through my wrist. A gasp flies from my lungs.

'Rose?' Kay looks up at me. 'Is everything all right?'

My eyes return to the blade as a faint tingling continues to linger in my hand.

'Yes.' I meet her gaze with a forced smile. 'Yes, it's fine.'

With my attention back on the blade, I twist my wrist, turning it in circles as if toying with an invisible opponent. Light reflects from the surface, dispersing into shades of the kind of brightest blue usually found in the centre of the hottest flame. While the dagger's blade is smooth and silver, the sheath is a multitude of metals, one of which I'm certain is gold, embedded in the most delicate of patterns. Infinitesimally thin lines branch out from thicker central ones – almost like leaves, I think, only to correct myself. No, like feathers.

'Wow, that is beautiful.' Kay's voice croaks as she reaches out for it. Her fingers brush the metal, only for her to recoil. 'Ouch! That's hot! How in the Gods' names are you holding it?'

'Is it?' I question, turning it over again in my hand. It's not cold, but I'd hardly say it was hot. Warm, maybe. Body temperature. The fact that my sister would classify something like this as hot is just another sign that I need to get her out of these freezing conditions sooner rather than later.

Kay watches on as I continue to move the dagger through the air.

‘A blade like that must be worth a fortune,’ she marvels. Her words cause a lump to thicken in my throat and I place the weapon down. She’s right. The sensible thing to do would be to sell it and buy some cheaper blades before I leave, but as I turn it over, that thought fades.

Something tells me I was not meant to sell this weapon. I was meant to wield it.

Even now, I can see the way it would spin in the air. Perfectly weighted, there’s not a hair’s difference between the weight of the point to cross guard, and cross guard to pommel. A tingle, almost akin to the rush of magic, ripples through me as I imagine sending it hurtling through the air. Ideally into a royal chest.

‘You might have to kill with that blade,’ Kay says quietly.

‘Possibly,’ I reply. *Probably*, I amend internally, not taking my eyes off the weapon.

A silence forms between us, and I know she’s thinking the same as I am. Can I really do it? Do I really have it in me to kill another human? If it were only my own survival at stake, then perhaps not, but it isn’t. It’s for Kay’s survival as well, and that changes everything. For her, I will do whatever it takes.

‘There’s more in here,’ she says, prodding the box. ‘Do you want to look first?’

I do, but a heavy weight has been placed on my chest, and my gaze is still fixed on the weapon. Perhaps this is why Dinah gave me such an item. Something so stunning it could have been crafted by the Gods’ own hands to ensure I would never forget the value of each life I might take.

‘We’ll see the rest later,’ I reply, forcing a smile as I sheath the blade. ‘I’m hungry.’

Kay’s lips purse so tightly that they all but disappear and I know she’s not done arguing yet. But thankfully, she releases the expression with a sigh. ‘Fine. We’ll eat. But we’re not done talking about this.’

‘No,’ I say, unable to stop myself from rolling my eyes. ‘Somehow, I didn’t think we were.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 8

I give up trying to sleep as dawn's weak light trickles in through the gaps in our makeshift walls. My chest is tight. Today I leave Kay and present myself to the High Hold.

I can't bear to imagine what it will be like without her. Family and friends can't see the Rettlings unless they're invited to attend the balls held in Korvane's court, meaning it could be months until I see my sister again, and fear gnaws at me that she won't be safe without me. As yet, there's been no word from Dinah or Lord Artur Lorathin.

A gentle trill sounds from outside and a smile pulls at my lips. No bird makes that sound, but a whistling Ruben does. Careful not to wake Kay, I slip out the door and into the street. The sky is grey, the sun having not yet broken the horizon, and Ruben's smile provides a welcome warmth.

'Hey Rosey.' Ruben's soft eyes look at me as he scratches at his stubble. 'You got a minute?'

I smile. 'Sure. I didn't know if I'd get a chance to see you before I left …'

'Bet you thought you'd sneak off to claim great victory and power without even saying goodbye, right?' He shakes his head as if he's annoyed, but it doesn't dim the smile on his lips. 'I knew you were only ever using me for my warmth.'

I laugh and raise an eyebrow. 'And do we want to talk about what you were using me for?'

He smirks and lowers his voice. 'A gentleman never tells.' The smile fades then, and his expression grows uncharacteristically serious. 'I've got a gift for you.'

‘For me?’ I ask dumbly.

‘For one of our own,’ he says solemnly, repeating the words that were sprayed across the walls of the slum buildings almost immediately after the guards’ announcement yesterday morning, next to my initials.

The best graffiti I’ve seen was a thorny rose wrapped around the High Hold in triumph.

When I feel uncertain, I’ll picture that image in my mind.

Last night food was placed by our door. More food than I could ever eat, gifted for me to gain my strength before I enter the Retterheld. Just thinking of their kindness makes me want to weep.

Ruben reaches for his wrist and unfastens a thin bracelet with a single bead the size of a thumbnail. At first glance, it appears to be made of ordinary glass, but I quickly realise it’s far more than that. Magic has been physically channelled into the item, the swirling iridescent reds and yellows writhing with trapped power.

‘What is it?’ I ask as he holds it out to me.

‘A fire bead. It’s a one-shot thing though, I’m afraid. You throw it at the ground, and whatever is there will catch light.’

I gape, my jaw dropping in pure disbelief. Ruben’s giving me *magic?*

He winks. ‘Make sure you don’t light it on a patch of ice, all right? Make it count.’

I take the bracelet in my hand and find myself at a loss for words, too mesmerised by the slight hum that fizzes through my skin where it touches the bead.

‘This isn’t just from me,’ Ruben rushes to add. ‘It’s from the slums. From all of us.’

‘The slums,’ I say, finally drawing my eyes away to look at him. ‘They’ve already given me so much. Too much.’

He nods. ‘People want to help give you a chance. Let’s be honest. We all know this kingdom would be a whole lot better if it were someone like you, and not Korvane’s narcissistic offspring, who wins.’

A coil of nerves twists in my stomach. Never, in all our nights together, has Ruben ever mentioned any disdain for the kingdom, and certainly not the king and his son. It would be treasonous. The fact that he’s risking this with me now, it’s … it’s terrifying, yet it also causes a rush of relief to roll through me. I might be on my own in there, but I’ll have people rooting for me on the outside, and that matters. *One of us.* One of the outcasts, the

downtrodden. Yes, I'm one of them all right. They taught me what it takes to survive, and I'm not going to forget that now.

I clip the bracelet around my wrist, then wrap my arms around Ruben's torso. I'm not hugging him for his warmth now, nor to hide my loneliness the way I usually do. I hold him simply because I want to hold him as tightly as possible. It feels like my heart might burst with gratitude. I will do my damnedest to be worthy of his gift.

'I have been very lucky to have a friend like you, Ruben,' I choke out when we break apart.

He mock-winces. 'Ouch. Friend-zoned just like that.'

I punch him lightly. 'Maybe, but you're a damned good friend to have.'

He rubs his shoulder as if I hadn't pulled my punch. 'Be gentle with me, Kultavaris. I'm not as deadly as you.'

I snort at his antics, then sober. 'I really am so grateful. This … it could save my life.'

'I hope it does.' He pauses awkwardly. 'Well, I should go. Leave you to it.'

He turns to leave but I grab him by the shoulder.

'Wait. I need to ask something of you. Something more,' I add, glancing down at the bead around my wrist. 'When I'm gone—'

'You want me to keep an eye on Kay?' he finishes before I can. 'You don't even need to ask.'

Heat pricks behind my eyes as I look back up at him. 'I don't deserve you.'

'Sure you do, Rosey.' He slips his hand around my neck and plants a gentle kiss on my lips before breaking away. 'You deserve the entire fucking kingdom.' A tear slips down my cheek as he steps away. 'Don't worry. I'll make sure nothing happens to Acacia.'

I nod, hating the lump that has reformed in my throat. 'I have some friends … friends in the High Hold. They should be coming to get her, to take care of her, but if they don't … if she's alone…' I can't even finish that sentence, let alone finish that thought.

'She will never be alone, Rose. I promise you that. If they don't come, she'll move in with us. She'll have to sleep next to my ma with her snoring, but she'll be fine. Don't worry. We'll sort it.' As his eyes catch mine, a glint flickers within them. 'Oh, and don't worry. I won't tell her what happened in the tannery.' He winks.

A laugh chokes from my throat as I reach out and thump him on the arm again.

‘You better not!’ I grin at him, though instead of his smile widening at the memory, the way mine did, his face falls. For the first time I can ever remember, Ruben looks at me with an expression of pure seriousness.

‘Give them hell, Rose,’ he says. ‘You deserve that gifting. Go get it.’

‘I plan on it.’

He hesitates. ‘The flame bead. Give it a little squeeze before you throw it. Just to make sure it works properly.’

‘Thanks,’ I tell him again, wondering how the hell he got his hands on it in the first place. But I don’t ask him. Instead, I simply watch him walk away.

Kay is awake when I return inside, her cheeks once again glistening with tears.

‘Please, Kay.’ I kneel down beside her. ‘No more tears. Not now. Let’s not spend our last hours together like this.’

She sniffs. It’s such a simple action, yet it somehow transforms her from a beautiful young woman into my fragile little sister, someone I would give my life to protect. Which, I guess, is exactly what I’m about to do.

‘We have some time, right? Can you tell me some stories? Stories of before?’ Her voice cracks as she whispers to me. ‘Tell me about when we all had magic?’

‘We have time,’ I reply softly. Precious little, but time enough for her. Always for her. I sit next to her, put an arm around her shoulders, and start to talk of better times.



THIS IS WHAT I WANTED, right? A flicker of doubt fills me as I walk towards the sixth ring, and a desperate urge to turn around and run back to Kay nearly overtakes me. She offered me Mother’s ring to bring with me as a memento, but I don’t need tokens. I carry everything inside me already. Still, I barely made it two steps from the front door before my own tears fell.

I keep moving forward. I have no choice now.

‘One of us!’ a voice calls out. I turn to the side to see a man in ragged clothes, his hand raised in salute. I wave my hand briefly in response, only for the same thing to happen a few steps later.

‘One of us!’

‘Go give ’em hell!’

‘You’ve got this!’

Their words bolster me. I *am* one of them. And when I win this, I will give back to them in the way they deserve.

I’m still in the outer ring when a carriage draws up behind me.

‘You the Rettling from the slums?’ the driver asks, his eyes fixed on the large bags slung over my shoulders. ‘The flower?’

‘Yes. Rose, Rose Kultavaris,’ I tell him.

His lips part to reveal a near-toothless smile. ‘Hop on. Only going as far as fourth, but we can pick you up another ride there.’

He reaches down and offers me a hand, exposing a tattoo on his wrist. A tendril of smoke, almost identical to Peter’s. It’s not a particularly bad design, but I’m surprised to see it replicated so closely. One of the tattoo artist’s favourite designs, perhaps?

The chants of ‘one of us’ follow me all the way into the fifth ring, and I am both bemused and heartened by all the support.

Just as he promised, when the driver reaches the fourth ring, he secures me a lift through the next few gates, though I’m back in the back this time, bouncing on the hard wooden bed alongside crates of pears. It’s tempting to take one or more and slip them into my pocket – after all, these are headed to the High Hold, to people who have likely never felt a rumbling stomach, let alone pure starvation – but I’ve got this far in life without stealing food and I’m not going to start now.

The walls of the High Hold tower above the lower city rings, masking all inside it besides the tips of the highest turrets of the palace. Foreboding. That’s one word that springs to mind. Corrupt, malignant, and dangerous are others.

Thousands of people live within those walls, hidden from view. They’re the king’s court. Dozens of noble families with their own houses – mansions, really – each filled with their own servants.

Then there’s the barracks, which are occupied by those who train to be guards, bound to fight and die for the king. As well as the soldiers, the walls are bursting with priestesses, wardens, and emissaries. Sellers, scholars,

physicians, and healers. There are stables crowded with horses, as well as all the stablehands needed to tend to and groom the animals. Scribes and chefs. Craftsmen and acolytes. The High Hold is filled with the most powerful, respected, and richest of all in Morathka, and now I'm to join them yet again.

I don't want to feel nervous. I want to feel as confident as I did when I scaled the third wall and monitored the guards at the temple. As confident as I pretended to be when I told Kay everything would be fine. But it's hard.

As I step out of the carriage, I clutch the satchel Dinah gave me, wishing I'd taken the dagger and slipped it in the back of my trousers already. Instead, a steeling breath is all I have to quench my nerves as I make my way up the steps to where over a dozen knights stand with their bonded dire wolves.

'Rose Kultavaris,' I tell them.

Immediately, they step aside. There's no questioning me today. It should be a relief, but it doesn't stop the skitter of nerves at the way the wolves' eyes follow me as I walk through the entrance towards the narrow passageway beyond. Unlike the rest of the Wrohelm walls, which are only ten or so feet wide, the inner ring wall protecting the High Hold is almost double that. And traversing the narrow passageway through it, lit only by pale yellow lamps, feels like walking into a whole new world. I suppose it is.

I hate the gasp that leaves my lips as I enter the High Hold. There is no darkness anymore. The wall's stones, which were onyx black on the outside, are marble white here, reflecting the weak light that falls on them and turning it into something truly spectacular. It is the sheer amount of open space that stuns me the most. The room between the buildings, the height of which dwarfs even the largest structures in the outer rings.

Several passersby offer me a glance, only to wrinkle their noses and scurry away as if poverty were contagious, yet I pay them no mind. The High Hold. This is where Kay belongs. And I will get her here, even if it's the last thing I do.

Though first I have to figure out where I'm supposed to be going.

While the rest of Wrohelm is divided into rings, the circle of the High Hold is divided into arcs fanning out from the palace at the centre. While I'm pretty sure the Rettlings aren't going to be in the temple arc or the courtier arc, I don't know for certain, and annoyingly, there's no big sign

with ‘Retterheld’ written on it, directing me. Which means I’m going to have to ask someone.

As I search out a friendly face among the scores of people milling about in their finest furs, I spot a priestess of Yordenrin – Goddess of Chaos – dressed in a purple cloak. Priestesses feel like a safe bet to ask for help. With a slight grunt, I hoist my bags firmly back onto my shoulder and hurry over to her.

‘Excuse me.’ I wait until she’s looking at me before I continue. ‘Do you know where the Rettlings are supposed to go?’

The elderly woman tilts her head to the side, and the purple stone within her forehead gleams like fire in amethyst. Rather than speaking, she merely points towards the palace.

It’s not the most helpful direction I’ve ever been given, but I do as she directed, walking between two large buildings with great colonnades while trying to keep my mind on the task at hand, rather than getting distracted by all the wondrous sights around me.

I know it’s been fourteen years since I was here, but my memory has grossly failed me. Either that or it deliberately tried to forget how truly magnificent it was so as not to make me ache for it more. Everything feels like I am seeing it for the first time.

To my right, a large pond is set in front of a red brick building, and waterlilies grow above broad-plated leaves. To my left, a group of red cloaks – priestesses of Niairah, Goddess of Air and Fire – stand in silence around a vortex of swirling flames. I assume the building behind them is a temple to the Goddess. Just as I’m starting to think I never spent any time in this part of the ring, I spot a large wall behind the temple and a spark of recognition alights within me.

Is it the barracks beyond there or the courts? No, the courthouses were in the eastern arc, I’m sure of that. So that would be the barracks, wouldn’t it? And for some reason, I suspect that’s where I’m meant to go. I turn, hoping to find another guard or priestess I can ask, when I hear my name called.

‘Rose? Rose Kultavaris?’

The man calling me is dressed in a tight white top and a pair of equally snug dark black trousers that sure as hell leave nothing to the imagination, though from what I can see, that’s the point. Not wanting to be caught staring, I draw my eyes up his torso. Shadows curve around his abs and his

shoulders have to be equally broad as Ruben's, only far more filled out. But it's his face that holds my attention. His warm sandy hair, his amber eyes that hold a hint of familiarity, and his soft smile. A corkscrewing that has nothing to do with nerves ripples through my stomach as he strides towards me.

'Rose Kultavaris,' he says, embracing me – or rather, engulfing me with his arms. When we break away, his grin is replaced by a frown. 'I can't believe it,' he says. 'You, a Rettling? Honestly, when I saw your name …' He lowers his voice slightly, eyes lingering on my hair. 'You're still stripped, right?'

'Jonas?' I feel my lips break into a grin as I finally place him. 'Jonas Lorathin?'

The last time I saw Jonas, he was a scrawny boy, desperate to prove himself. To grow some muscles and fight with the men. Well, it sure as hell looks like he succeeded in that.

His face is partially hidden by a full, neatly kept beard, and the top half of his thick blond hair is tied in a knot, while the remainder is in a thick braid that passes his shoulders. The type of braids I could imagine getting a good hold of as I pull him—

'You're staring,' he says, a slight quirk on his lips. 'Is that a good thing?'

His voice cuts into my inappropriate thoughts before they can fully form, and I clear my throat to buy myself a moment.

'It's an … odd thing.' I say truthfully. 'It's weird, you know? In my head, you're still a little kid.'

'Yeah, same.' A smile flickers into a smirk, and good Gods, it's cute on him. Reassuring, comforting … flirtatious. I must remember to thank Dinah for putting those extra dealun seeds in my bag.

'Most of the other Rettlings are sparring in the battle yard.' Jonas's voice once again stops my daydreams in their tracks. 'Everyone's keen to get acquainted with their opponents and explore the king's weaponry store, which he's opened for our use. You know, work out the best ways and tools to beat them.'

Fuck. I was so focused on getting as much time with Kay as possible that I didn't even think about the advantages that would have come with arriving early. Well, there's no point wasting time now.

‘The aim of the Retterheld is to win the challenges, not kill the other competitors.’ I’m not sure why it seems so important to say this. I’m not normally naïve, but a part of me had just *hoped*.

His smile widens. ‘I like your optimism.’

But it’s foolish. The words go unsaid but hang in the air regardless.

‘Do you know whether your father has my sister?’

He blinks. ‘Should he?’

Panic grips me. ‘I … I asked if he would keep her nearby.’

He shrugs. ‘Then he probably did so. I haven’t been able to see him since I arrived last night.’ His tone is vaguely apologetic.

I force a smile. ‘No problem. Can you take me somewhere to dump this stuff, then to the battle yard?’ I ask. ‘I guess it’s time I got practising.’

‘Sure thing.’ He lets out a slight chuckle as he tosses me another glance. ‘Rose Kultavaris,’ he mutters again. ‘In the Retterheld.’ He shakes his head in utter disbelief.

I tighten my grip on my bags. I’m going to prove him wrong. Prove all of them wrong. I deserve to be here, and I *can* win.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 9

As we walk through a series of archways and corridors, Jonas tells me about people he thinks I should remember. People who are in the Retterheld. Those who tried but didn't make it as far as the offering. Those who made the offering but didn't get selected.

'You remember Lora, right? You two used to be friends. She tried to enter but got bitten by a dire wolf outside the temple. Luckily, she had a team of healers on standby, so she's fine.'

I'm glad that Jonas is happily talking away to himself. It means he isn't looking at me. Lora. That's a name I've tried to push from my mind in the last decade and a half. He was right. We were friends. But that was before.

'Florian was a baby,' she said when she saw me after the queen's death. 'You should be grateful it wasn't you or Acacia the king decided to kill instead.'

Gratitude for the murder of my brother. That's what my best friend thought I should feel.

That was the last time I spoke to Lora, and I'm more than a little delighted that she wasn't able to get into the Retterheld.

'We're all in the eastern arc,' Jonas says, walking through a large gate set into yet another wall and leading us across an open courtyard. 'The king's guards had to give over one of their barracks and training grounds for the Rettlings. It's basic, but comfy enough.'

The eastern arc is a part of the High Hold I've never been in, though I used to dream about it often enough. I dreamed about being selected to become a guard. About training for four long years before being sent to the

Afaven Forest to bond with a dire wolf. Now though, I can't help but wonder how many knights there are going to be in the competition.

The more we walk, the less concerned I feel about remembering so little about my life here. High Hold is bigger than I ever realised – and coming from someone who's lived in the shadow of it for years, that's saying something.

'After tonight's announcement, this'll be home,' Jonas tells me as he offers a nod of thanks to a guard who steps aside so we can move through another gate. 'No going out unless it's for a trial – or a ball, obviously,' he amends.

As I step into the sand-covered courtyard, I take a moment to breathe it in. The slums are so crowded that the marketplace is the only space large enough for a gathering, but even then it's still claustrophobic. Here, there's space. Space to run. To feel. To breathe.

'You coming?' Jonas calls from ahead.

I pick up my pace and hurry to join him. A minute later, we're walking into a grey stone building several times the size of Etta's temple.

'This is us.' He grins. Seeing this small fraction of the training barracks reminds me of the size of the army needed to defend against the Torailian and Issen. I might despise King Korvane to my very core, but at least he's keeping his people safe, which I guess is something.

'You okay?' Jonas brushes his hand against my arm, causing me to jerk at the unexpected shudder that rolls through me. When our eyes meet, a single frown line is etched between his brows.

'Yes, sorry, you were saying?'

His gaze lingers on me for a moment longer before he continues. 'The main training ground we get to use is around the back. Out through the dining hall, which is here.'

I step past him into a massive room filled with rows and rows of wooden tables, all currently empty. It must seat at least four hundred people, and my eyes are drawn to the end where a large fireplace roars with gold and ruby flames. Outside may have been warm, but inside it's toasty.

'I can't get over how warm it is.' I say the words more to myself than to Jonas.

He looks at me quizzically before shrugging his shoulders. 'It's just the residual magic, right? Same as everywhere.'

His naïveté is cute. ‘Right,’ I say, suppressing a snort. Residual magic. Those currents of power that drift from the Gods and run down through the citadels. By the time they reach the slums, virtually every drop of power has been leached away, leaving no warmth. With Korvane keeping his massive dining halls fully heated even when no one is in them, that’s hardly a surprise. Selfish bastard.

‘What’s downstairs?’ I ask as we walk past a narrow stone staircase that weaves its way to the floors below.

Jonas offers a shrug. ‘Kitchen, I guess. Dorms are upstairs. That’s where I was going to take you next.’

The word kitchen causes a growl to rattle from my stomach. Even with all of the food gifted to me, I’m still hungry. My stomach wasn’t able to manage much after going so long without. Hopefully, once I’ve dumped my things, I can grab some bread or something before the Cotillion ball that will kick off the Retterheld this evening. But I can’t think about the first ball right now, not when I’m busy trying to keep pace with Jonas. That man has one hell of a stride on him.

‘Here.’ He stretches out his hand as we reach the bottom of another staircase. ‘Let me take one of your bags for you.’

‘I don’t need you to do that. I can manage.’

‘I know you don’t need me to, but I’m offering. There’s this thing called chivalry? It’s still alive … at least with me, anyway.’

He flashes a smile that causes more fluttering in my stomach and a spike in my pulse.

Realising that I’ve been staring a fraction too long, colour rushes to my cheeks and I hand Jonas one of my bags in an attempt to distract him from my rising blush. Some of the ballgowns inside weigh a tonne, yet he slings the bag over his shoulder like it’s weightless before continuing on.

The staircase is wide enough for four people to happily walk side by side, though Jonas stays close to me the whole time. Close enough that it almost feels like my hand should be in his. Halfway up, I pause at a large window offering a view out over the training grounds. At least twenty people are out there, most of them currently fighting, and their movements are mesmerising. The kicks, the blocks, the flashes of swords and daggers. I’m too far away to hear their shouts and grunts, but I can sense them in my bones, and for the first time since my name was called, I feel a surge of genuine fear. The way they move is so fluid, so flawless, that it’s as if they

are one with their weapons. Something tells me they haven't been scraping by on whatever scraps of food they could come by these last few years. They've been training. Training for war. Training for this. And Etta found them worthy, too.

It's far from a comforting thought.

'How many people have been accepted?' I ask when I look up and find Jonas several feet ahead. For the second time, I quicken my pace to catch up, and he graciously waits until I am beside him before he answers.

'Around fifty this year. Rooms will be fairly tight until the first trial, and you'll want to pick where you bunk carefully. People have already formed alliances.'

Alliances. Just the thought of it makes me uneasy. And that unease only increases when Jonas suddenly stops and turns to face me. Good Gods, his eyes are amber. And the way they're looking at me is intense.

'I wasn't sure if I should tell you this, Rose,' he says, his timbre serious, bordering on forlorn, 'but there have already been two deaths.'

'Deaths?' That pulls me out of his gaze fast. 'How? The Retterheld hasn't even begun! Surely Etta won't approve of deaths outside the trial?'

He presses his lips tightly together. 'Some people don't agree with your thinking.'

'They were killed by other Rettlings?' I ask, feeling faintly sick. 'Why?'

'I don't know the ins and outs,' he says, but he's turned away from me, as if he doesn't want to look me in the eye. 'Come on, let's find you a place to sleep.'

I want to know exactly what happened and why two Rettlings have already been killed – and by whom – but he obviously doesn't want to talk about it, and the last thing I need is to alienate the only person who might actually help me in this thing. If nothing else, I'm going to need a sparring partner on training days, and I can definitely think of worse people to work up a sweat with than Jonas.

'Where's your dorm?' I change the subject as naturally as I can. 'And have you already made your alliances?'

'There are people I know,' he says vaguely.

Gods, I've forgotten how the nobles talk in riddles and circles. Information is power, so everyone scrambles to grab it, then hoards it like a squirrel with nuts.

I press on. 'You know them from the High Hold, you mean?'

He nods. ‘Not sure whether I’d call them allies, though. We’ve not really solidified anything.’

He’s turned off the stairs now and is walking down a corridor.

‘So are you sharing a dorm with any of these “not-quite-allies” of yours?’

‘No.’ This time he turns to face me. ‘And I’m not in a dorm. I managed to snag myself a space on my own,’ he says. ‘It’s a box room, but it’s quiet, and it’s away from most of the others. An advantage of being in the court is that I was able to get over here and claim my spot the moment the announcement was made. I think all ten of us from Wrohelm did.’

‘A room to yourself,’ I say, trying to stop a grin from twisting my lips. ‘And away from the other Rettlings. It’s almost like you don’t want people to hear what you plan on doing in there.’

‘I haven’t made any plans yet,’ he replies, a smirk twisting his lips.

‘No? Want to see if we can think up any together?’

The flirtatious words slip out before I can stop them, nerves making me far bolder than I usually would be. Still, I don’t regret it; he’s attractive and friendly, and I need someone in my corner. Hearing about the deaths, and seeing the others sparring, has reminded me that I can’t take on all the other Rettlings alone. I need allies, and I could do far worse than Lord Lorathin’s son.

To my surprise, a pink tinge rises on his cheeks as the tension between us stretches so taut I’m pretty sure it could snap a rope. His eyes drift down to my lips, and heat stirs in my gut. I consider taking a step towards him, but I don’t. I might flirt, but I don’t chase. And although we were childhood friends, I don’t know the man he’s become. Not yet.

His pupils are blown wide, and his tongue darts out to wet his lips as I wait for him to respond. Finally, with a light chuckle, he releases the tension growing between us.

‘Let’s get you a place to put your belongings,’ he says.

He takes a few steps down the corridor and stops in front of a door.

‘Let’s try this one,’ he says, placing his hand on a metal doorknob and twisting it open.

Just then, a voice yells from down the corridor, ‘You found her then? The slum rat?’

I turn away from Jonas to find a young woman about my age standing with her arms folded across her chest. She’s dressed in the blood-red

colours of Rowell, and while the sides of her head are shaved, the rest of her auburn hair is worn in three braids, the thickest of which runs down the centre of her scalp and is phenomenally intricate. I always thought I was adequate at braiding, but I've never managed anything as elaborate as that. Though given the way she's practically snarling at me, I don't think she's going to give me lessons on how to do it. She's flanked by a few other Rettlings, and they don't look any more welcoming.

'Zara, you need to back away.' Jonas steps in front of me as he speaks. His voice is measured, but I can hear the firm menace beneath the tone. 'Go back to your room.'

'Oh, I will,' she assures him with a sneer. 'Just as soon as I've culled the final runt.'

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 10

Well, I guess I now know what happened to the other Rettlings. Or runts, as she so kindly put it. And if I had any doubts about how this Retterheld would go, I don't anymore.

Unlike Jonas and me, Zara and her cronies have opted to wear their battle sigils to greet the other Rettlings: three symbols painted in blue on the left side of their faces, marking their hometown and their two fealty Gods. The blue chevron below her eye tells me she's from Rowell, but it's the other two marks that my gaze lingers on: the starburst above her brow line that marks her fealty to Yordenrin, the Goddess of Chaos, and the downwards arrow beneath the chevron denotes her second favoured God. But who the hell shows fealty to Mortidem, the God of Death? Especially in a tournament in honour of Etta, the Goddess of *Life*.

I guess the answer to that is someone who thinks killing off people before the trials have even started is a good idea.

Still, however much of a bitch this Zara is, I don't want the confrontation ending in bloodshed unless it has to, and if it does, then it sure as hell won't be mine.

'Rose, you need to get back,' Jonas instructs me curtly as I move to stand next to him. The corridor is fairly cluttered with what I assume are items left by the guards forced to vacate this place for the Rettlings, but at its widest, it could fit about four people abreast. Zara is flanked by two Rowell women, both dressed in blood-red and looking as angry as their attire. Both wearing braids equally as amazing as their clear leader.

Damn it. This is not the time for hair envy.

‘Rose, did you hear me?’ Jonas hisses.

‘I heard,’ I reply, though I don’t move back. Not even a sliver of me is tempted to do as he says. This woman isn’t messing around, and the last thing I can afford is for this bitch, or anyone else, to think I have to cower behind someone to survive. That’s a sure way to commend me to Mortidem.

‘Do you really think Etta is going to let you win this if you’re taking out others before it’s even begun?’ I scan my opponent casually, surreptitiously looking for weapons. There’s nothing that I can see, but that’s not necessarily a comfort. Magic is the biggest weapon here, and the best hunters don’t need a full quiver when they go into the forest. Only those who fear missing a shot do. ‘I’ll be honest,’ I continue, tone solicitous, like I give a fuck about her soul. ‘I don’t think it’ll garner you any favours.’

‘I disagree,’ Zara replies flatly, without a hint of self-doubt. ‘If the Goddess disapproved of my methods, she would have come to the aid of the other runts. But what do you know …’ She smirks unpleasantly. ‘She didn’t.’

Zara has confidence and arrogance oozing from her pores and no matter how this ends between us, I’m pretty sure she’s not going to ask me to bunk down as her roommate after it.

‘You can’t honestly believe the Goddess of Life would choose someone who kills indiscriminately for a gifting?’ I press on, though I already know from the set of her mouth that I’m not going to persuade her otherwise. Violence is coming for me, and I have no weapons. Well, not *no* weapons. I finger the bracelet on my wrist. I’m torn because I don’t want to use the magic lightly, and yet I’m sure that if this confrontation continues, Zara and her buddies will try to kill me. Why the fuck didn’t I just wear the damned blade?

‘I think the Goddess will gift the person who wins the Retterheld regardless of what they do to achieve victory,’ Zara snarls at me. ‘And if I wasn’t worthy, I wouldn’t be here. She heard my pleas. She chose *me*.’

Yup, Kay was right. Every Rettling believes in their absolute right to be here.

‘You’re the one who’s stripped, right?’ she goads. ‘Mummy was the Queenkiller, and daddy drank himself to death? And there was a baby, too, right? Did he even get his first steps before the king put him down?’

Rage roars in my veins, and I pull the bead from my bracelet. Only the fact that I don’t want to waste it tempers my fury. ‘I’ll give you one last

chance to walk away. We'll settle this in the tournament. The way we're supposed to.'

She laughs. 'Slum rat, you're not going to make it to the trials. You're not even going to make it to the ball tonight.' She lifts a hand and a dull throb spreads across my knees and the top of my feet before a searing pain shoots across my palm. I glance down to see that the stitches from the night before have been ripped open. She's a deleterious; she can reverse the healing my body has already done, causing old wounds to spring open.

I can cope with the cut on my palm, but it depends on how strong her powers are and how far back into my past she can go to make old wounds new. Days, weeks, months? Earlier this year, a potion I was making boiled over and scalded my thigh. Badly. I'd run out of salve at the time, and the blisters were so raw and angry I could barely cope with the touch of fabric against the skin for weeks. As if summoned by my thoughts, a searing pain flares at the top of my left leg. A gasp threatens to leave my lungs, but I lock my jaw against it. If that's as far back as she can go, it means she's not going to be able to get much more out of me. And while the burn and cut may hurt like a bitch, she's going to have to do some actual damage herself if she wants to seriously hurt me.

'Let me get this right.' I steady my voice with a confidence I sure as hell don't feel. 'You can't actually cause any injuries of your own, can you? You just work on the hope that other people have already done the job for you. Some predator you are,' I sneer.

Her eyes flash. 'I'm going to eat you alive, runt!'

'Cannibalism, too?' I sound amused, relaxed. I'm not quite sure how I'm pulling it off or why the fuck I'm goading her. If she has a dagger sheathed behind her, I'll be in seriously dangerous territory.

There's a growing crowd of people gathered behind her now – a captivated audience – so it's now or never.

I don't give myself any time to second-guess my decision. While holding Zara's gaze so she can't see what I'm about to do, I squeeze the bead to activate it.

'You really think you know everything about me and my family?' I say, allowing a smirk to rise on my lips. 'You know *nothing* about me. Nothing about life in the slums. Nothing about the powers I've learned living there.'

'Powers in the slums?' she scoffs. 'Bullshit.'

'Rose, what are you doing?' Jonas mutters, still at my side.

‘Proving that I’m not a runt.’

Zara takes another step closer to me, and her goons move to follow. Can the flame bead take out that many people? I don’t know. I don’t have a clue what it’s capable of, but I know I need to make sure it strikes something that can catch light. Right now, Zara’s standing next to a stack of books. They’re leather-bound with gilded paper, and the top one has fallen open, meaning it’s the perfect kindling. The only problem is… they’re books. After years of missing my library and wishing I had enough money to be able to trade tonics for books instead of food, I hesitate to burn something so precious. But if she just steps a little further forward, she’ll be in line with a wicker basket filled with kindling to start the fires in the rooms. It doesn’t get better than that. I just need to provoke her into moving.

‘Three against one,’ I say, raising an eyebrow. ‘You too afraid to take me on your own?’

‘Says the woman with the seven-foot-tall bodyguard,’ she snorts.

I crinkle my nose as I cast a glance back at Jonas. ‘I’d guess about six-three. It’s okay,’ I taunt, ‘not everyone can count. So, come on, are you actually going to do anything?’ I mock. ‘Or was I right in the first place? You can’t actually do any damage yourself?’

‘I’ll show you just how much damage I can cause,’ she snarls and steps forward. Bingo.

I act immediately and throw the activated bead into the basket. The flames are instant and mammoth, the fire blue and with a heat so fierce that the flames don’t just catch, they consume.

‘Argh!’

Zara screams and the acrid smell of burning is thick in the air. It’s not just her tunic that has caught. It’s her skin and that perfect, long, auburn braid of hers.

‘Help! Water! Where the hell is water?’ one of her companions shouts. Whatever powers her goons have, they don’t seem to be able to help.

I doubt there are any water wielders here. That magic is as rare as they come. There certainly won’t be anyone able to douse it with ice. I don’t need to have seen the marks on the others’ faces to know that none of them will have that gift, not when control of that magic is bound so tightly to the Issen that Korvane’s ancestors executed anyone who dared to show an affinity with ice.

I don’t want to look at Zara, to see the pain I’m causing. Despite the fact that I had no alternative, I feel faintly sick.

‘Duck!’ a woman’s voice orders as the smell of charred hair fills my nostrils. An instant later, an icy gust of air blows through the hallway, so cold and harsh it extinguishes the flames completely.

The floorboards are scorched, the ceiling is black with smoke stains, and the heat has even stripped the paint from the walls. Yet despite all the destruction around me, it’s Zara that my gaze fixes on.

Blisters bulge from her skin all the way from the top of her crown to her waist. How the hell she’s still standing, I don’t know. Then again, I’m not sure how I’m still on my feet either. The realisation of what I’ve done weakens my knees. As if he knows, Jonas steps beside me and holds my elbow. I can’t show weakness. Not now. Or it’s all for naught. I lock my knees and stand a little straighter.

‘You should have let her burn,’ someone mutters.

I’m sure that’s what other people are thinking too, but looking at her in this state, I’m glad someone blew the flames out. If the trials involve killing, then I’ll do what I have to to survive, but I don’t want to take a life like this – trying to prove I’m tough enough.

‘We need to get you to the healers,’ one of Zara’s goons entreats as they try to take her arm, but she shrugs them away.

‘I can walk,’ she hisses, stifling a gasp as she shuffles forward.

Well, any hope I had of a collaborative tournament is well and truly dead. I don’t think Prince Kyor is going to be the only one gunning for me now.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 11

‘If any of you let her bunk with you, I will kill you too.’ They’re the last words I hear Zara speak as she limps away. The fact that she’s not passed out from the pain has to say something about her. And clearly, I’m not the only one who thinks that, because I’m met with the same response in every room I try: no. The first one says there’re no beds for me and practically pushes me out the door so I can’t see all the empty bunks I already clocked behind them – but the second tells it like it is.

‘The Duartes are practically royalty in Rowell. We can’t risk making an enemy like that.’

‘Come on,’ Jonas says before I try the next one.

‘Where are we going?’

‘I guess I’m going to have to give up my solitude after all,’ he replies, leading me to the very end of the corridor where a thin spiral staircase sits. With rusted metal and screws that jut out from dubious angles, I can barely believe it hasn’t collapsed already.

Jonas leads us up the rickety staircase, and though the metal creaks under my feet, it holds, and that’s all that matters.

The burn on my leg stings like a bitch and every step is agony. That is one nasty talent Zara Duarte has, and considering she’s going to be up against people who have been fighting battles for years, it’s also a bloody good one to have.

Trying not to show any pain, I follow Jonas onto a small stone landing with a single door. He nudges it open, and once he’s inside the room, he picks a bag up off the narrow wooden bed and drops mine down instead.

‘What about you?’ I ask wearily. ‘Do you have somewhere else to go?’

‘I’ll be fine. Plenty of rooms I can bunk in. More importantly, what in the Mother’s name was that?’ His eyes are wide as he stares at me. ‘You never had fire magic. And what magic you had was stripped. I was there. I saw.’

The last part of his comment takes me by surprise. Of course, I knew there was an audience to our punishment, but I never realised Jonas was part of it.

‘I have skills, not magic,’ I respond, being deliberately elusive. I don’t need anyone, including Jonas, knowing that my one and only ‘skill,’ as I chose to call it, has now been used up. ‘All that matters is that they got me out of a tricky predicament.’

‘Well, now everyone knows what skills you’ve got, and that little stunt has likely put you in an even worse position.’

His patronising assessment puts my back up. ‘Worse than letting her kill me?’ I ask pointedly.

‘No, that’s not what I meant.’ He lets out a low sigh. I might not know Jonas well anymore, but I can read the worry in his eyes. ‘She won’t forget that. I wish you’d let me handle it instead.’

‘And confirm to her and everyone else that I really am a runt? No, not a chance.’

‘You know, I forgot how stubborn you can be.’ His eyes drift to my hand and he steps forward. ‘Shit. Is that all right?’

‘Stings a bit,’ I concede drily.

He takes my hand gently in his, and a tingle spreads down the back of my knuckles where he touches me. From the way he draws lazy circles on my skin, I’m wondering if he’s reconsidering looking for another room.

‘Is that how she killed the others?’ I ask, feeling a sudden need to fill the silence. ‘By opening their old wounds?’

‘Not sure. She didn’t act alone.’

‘The others from Rowell?’ I ask, resigned.

‘Yeah. And not just the ones who were with her just now. There are a few more of them, including her twin brother, Shim.’

‘There are two of them?’ My eyebrows rise. Fantastic. No doubt Zara’s sibling is going to *love* me.

‘Yep. And they’re both as nasty as one another.’

I let out a low sigh and try to swallow the lump in my throat. Kyor, Zara, Shim and the rest of the Rowell Rettlings. The list of people who

won’t want me to survive this thing, let alone win it, is growing. ‘Fuck. What does his magic do?’

‘Not sure. Wasn’t entirely sure what her power was until she did that to you.’ He shakes his head. ‘I should have stepped in. What other injuries did she bring back? You were limping.’

I’m tempted to lie, but as I start to shake my head, I change my mind. ‘The top of my leg … I burned it a few months back.’

His eyes wander down to my thigh. ‘Do you want me to have a look at it?’

‘Are you a healer?’ I question. Jonas is a year younger than me, but his powers hadn’t yet settled when I left. Meaning I’ve got no idea what he’s capable of.

‘No,’ he admits. ‘Not a healer.’

‘Then what exactly would you be looking for?’ I ask archly.

He swallows hard and that same pink colouring as before dusts his cheeks. I like it. It’s a nice contrast to that burly, broad side of him.

Rather than flirt with him and tease him further, I laugh at him, letting him off the hook. ‘It’s fine,’ I say, shifting out of his grip. ‘I think I have some salve in my bag. I can sort it.’

‘There are healers on hand for things like that.’

‘I can sort it,’ I repeat, more comfortable with doing what I can myself.

I reach into my bag and pull out a series of vials. Some are from Rula’s other suppliers, but most of them are my own concoctions. When I wasn’t trying to stop Kay from crying last night and this morning, I was packing up as much as I could. Anything I couldn’t make, I traded for. It’s officially the most well-stocked my stores have been since I moved into the slums. I’ve even got a small gas stove, a copper pan, and a pestle and mortar in my bag, just in case I need to whip up more of something.

‘Bathroom through here?’ I nod towards a door.

‘Yeah,’ he says.

‘Great. I’ll just be a minute.’

I wonder if perhaps he’ll leave while I’m in the bathroom, but there are no footsteps on the creaking stairs as I pull down my trousers and look at the wound, only to wince. It’s red and angry, but not half as bad as it was the first time, which is interesting. Did her powers get weaker because it wasn’t the first of my injuries she reopened, or because it was the furthest

back? It’s a question I stow away for later as I slather the salve over my pained skin.

I apply it liberally, hoping I’ll be able to find more ingredients in the palace if I need them. Then I pull my trousers back on, already benefitting from the cooling effect.

Back in the bedroom, Jonas is pulling items out of the wardrobe and shoving them into his bag.

‘What’s your power?’ I ask, the question leaving my mouth before I can stop it. It’s rude to ask so plainly, but instead of apologising for it, I double down, unable to drop it now that I’ve raised it a second time. ‘You didn’t have it when I … when we left. I know you’re not a healer, so what is it? Can you show me?’

He twists around to look at me, still stuffing the bag. His brow crinkles. ‘It’s not something you want to see.’

‘How about I be the judge of that?’ I ask archly.

Rather than respond, he bites down on his bottom lip and I’m struck by an urge to move closer, maybe move my fingers in lazy circles across his skin, the way he did with me only a moment ago. It’s the longest silence we’ve shared, and I’m discovering I’m not great at silences. Not around Jonas, anyway.

‘It’s not very pleasant,’ he says finally.

‘For you?’

‘For the person I do it to.’

‘So it’s an offensive power? A fire wielder? No, you’d be able to show me that without having to do anything to me. So is it something like Zara’s power?’

He releases a single, chesty laugh. ‘No. It’s not a power you’re going to guess. And it’s not painful, more … disorienting.’

I take a step past him and take a seat on the bed. ‘Why don’t you stop talking in riddles and just show me?’

He presses his lips tightly together. I can see he’s not keen on the idea, but it’s not as though I’m going to use it against him. The truth is, the only person I’d even consider making an alliance with is him, and so it would really help me to know what I’ll be working with.

‘Please,’ I say softly.

When he lets out a low sigh, I know I’ve persuaded him. He drops onto the bed next to me before he speaks. ‘I need you to take my hand.’

I try to keep the surprise off my face. ‘You have to be touching the person for it to work?’ In terms of powers, requiring touch is generally not a good sign. I wonder if it’s some kind of mind-reading? If that’s the case, I want to back out now. Either that or I quickly need to erase the dirty thoughts I’ve already had about him before he can see them.

Mind-reading or not, I can’t imagine a power that needs touch will be much use in a tournament when the other participants want you unconscious or dead. Being close enough to hold them means you’re definitely close enough for them to stick a sword through you.

‘No, it doesn’t need touch to work. You’re not taking my hand for me.’ His voice is soft. ‘It’s for you. Like I said, it can be disorienting.’

Not entirely sure I’m making the smartest decision, I take his hand.

‘Wh—?’ Before I can finish the word, I know exactly why I needed to hold him.

I sit up sharply, trying to steady my heartbeat.

‘Jonas?’ My voice catches as my pulse soars. I don’t want to sound terrified, but I really am. I can’t see. There’s nothing. Just pure, bright-white emptiness. I thought darkness was disorienting. But this…? Without my sight for reference, it’s like I can’t balance. My head is spinning and panic tears through me.

‘It’s okay, Rose. I’m still here.’ He squeezes my hand tightly and the touch anchors me, steadies me. A second later, my vision returns, but the feeling of disorientation remains. I blink a few times, trying to make sure I can fully see.

‘I’m sorry. I shouldn’t have shown you.’ Jonas’s face is pinched with guilt.

‘No … I … I asked. Thank you. That’s just … wow.’ I shake my head, checking my balance is intact. ‘How many people can you do that to at once?’ If he can target a few people at the same time … I can see why he didn’t bother cementing any alliances.

‘Just one target,’ he tells me. ‘One person at a time. But as long as I have a direct line of sight on them, it doesn’t matter how far away I am. It’s a fairly powerful tool.’ He slides me a nervous look. ‘It will likely work best if I pair up with someone. I disorient the mark while the other person lands the blow.’

‘Makes sense,’ I say, wondering if he’s thinking what I hope he is.

It’s only as I go to speak again that I realise he hasn’t let go of my hand. Not only that, but our fingers are intertwined. It’s reassuringly warm and almost enough to distract me from the pain in my left hand. Almost. As his eyes meet mine, his fingers graze my jaw. A swarm of butterflies takes flight in my stomach.

‘I thought about you.’ His voice is close to a whisper. ‘I thought about you almost every day since you left. Like somehow I knew I’d get to see you again.’

‘I thought about you, too,’ I respond, inching closer to him. ‘Your father was one of the only people who was kind to us after everything that happened.’

Rather than continuing to lean closer, the way I expected him to, Jonas stiffens slightly, then drops his hand from my face and stands.

‘I should go,’ he says abruptly. ‘Find another place to sleep. But I’ll see you at the ball.’

‘Right, yes.’ The sudden change in atmosphere feels more tense than just an average brush-off, but what the hell could have caused it, I have no idea. Then again, perhaps it’s for the best. I’m here for a reason, and it’s time I focus on that. That means no distractions. Not yet.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 12

The room is unnervingly still once Jonas is gone, and I rest for a moment on the too-soft bed. I'm so used to the constant noises of the slums: the hustle and bustle, the cries of children continuing well into the night, the drunken bellows of those lucky enough to afford drink to lose themselves in, and the quiet murmurs of prayers from those who are desperate to believe that this will not be their fate.

Here, there's nothing, and I miss the reassurance of Kay's steady presence beside me, even if she does snore. I can hear muted footsteps below me, Rettlings talking softly and moving around. But there are no screams or cries. With nothing to break the quiet, it reminds me of a mausoleum. The thought isn't a reassuring one.

I heave myself off the bed and turn to my bags. With Jonas having emptied the wardrobe, there's more than enough room for me to place my own belongings inside, and given the quality of the robes Dinah gifted me, it only seems right to hang them up. As my fingers run over the silks and furs, I think again of Kay. Has Artur fetched her yet?

If not Artur, then Ruben will surely have her, I reassure myself, trying to push the anxiety down.

Once the clothes are hanging, I need to work out what to do with the satchel and the rest of the items. There's a drawer at the bottom of the wardrobe, but there's no key for the lock. What I need is somewhere secure. Somewhere hidden.

I turn on the spot, taking in the brick walls and wooden floorboards. Everyone has things they want to hide, and I suspect the guard who usually bunks here isn't any different. I start to tap my foot along the floor, hoping

to hear the hollow sound of a hidden compartment, even moving the bed to check beneath it. When I've no luck with the floor, I move on to the wall, tapping the bricks and dragging the only chair around with me so I can try the highest corners. I feel myself growing more and more despondent with each fruitless knock, and I'm just about to give up when I remember the bathroom.

As though led by a guiding hand, I move straight to the sink and tap the tiles below it. My ears are met with a crisp echo, and a minute later I've prized off the white tile and found a decently sized gap behind it. It's not quite big enough for the entire satchel, but it's large enough to slide in several bags of the rarer seeds Dinah gave me, not to mention the two smaller daggers I found while going through the rest of the bag. For the copper-hilted one, I take one of the straps from the bag, wrap it around my thigh, and sheath the dagger into place. I'm sure the other Rettlings will have properly crafted holsters for their weapons, but this works perfectly well, and the incident with Zara has taught me not to go anywhere unprotected.

With my limited belongings away and secure, I drop onto the bed, only for my stomach to growl. Loudly. Korvane's balls never used to begin until the sun had set, and I don't expect this one will be any different, which means it will likely be hours and hours until I get to eat unless I go find something for myself. Though before I leave, there's one other thing I want to do …

I head into the bathroom, strip off, and start the shower. The steam billows off the water and I step beneath the spray with a happy sigh, which quickly dissipates as the hot water hits the burned skin on my thigh. I wince but persevere.

After, as I dress in a pair of clean trousers and a plain brown top – standard colour choices for the slums as they hide the dirt – I note just how gaunt my face is and how pale my complexion. The sooner I put some more weight on, the better. And hopefully, that's going to start now.

Grateful that I don't have to go back past all the other doors, I take my rickety metal staircase down to where it meets the sturdier stone steps beneath it and continue descending.

The staircase opens at the far end of the hall I saw earlier, which is still empty of both staff and Rettlings. I assume the kitchen workers have been summoned to the king's quarters to prepare for tonight's feast and that I'll

be able to sneak in and grab something to eat without being seen, but as I take the first steps towards the kitchen, a sound stops me.

There are people talking. Or, more specifically, laughing.

My heart drums a fraction faster as I listen in, trying to recognise the voices – not that it's likely I will, unless it's Jonas's, of course – but I quickly realise that isn't the case.

My stomach growls again, and I reach down and feel the dagger on my thigh. I was a damn good fighter fourteen years ago – for a nine-year-old – but one blade and rusty skills aren't going to cut it against the full magic and strength of several well-trained Rettlings. Deciding it's probably best to avoid any kind of confrontation for now, I turn on my heel. After all, it'll hardly be the first time I've gone hungry.

A rich male voice rises from behind me, stopping me again. From his accent, I'm fairly sure he hails from the Eastern Isles. 'You don't need to go. We're not a threat. I promise.'

'And there are pastries,' a woman adds, her accent also from the Eastern Isles. 'Good pastries.'

I remain where I am, still undecided about what I'm going to do. Zara made it very clear that I shouldn't go into this thinking I can trust people, but Jonas's comment about alliances is still fixed in my mind. He implied he was willing to work with me, but implied doesn't mean agreed. And even if we do work together, it's still just the two of us. As impressive as his power is, it's not going to inflict damage the way a flame-wielder could.

Which is why, despite the hammering in my chest, I turn back and take the last few steps towards the kitchen, where a group of five – four men and one woman – are sitting around a table. Just like they said, there is a platter of pastries between them, and my eyes feel as though they're bugging from my head at the sight of the glazed delicacies. The sugar is so thick it's practically sparkling, and I'm not even sure what all the fruits on top are. They don't make things like this in the slums.

'Come and join us,' the woman says as she pushes the platter towards me. 'Don't worry. You won't find any fans of Zara and the Rowell crew in here.'

'She killed one of us yesterday.' The one who speaks looks like the youngest. I know he has to be at least eighteen to even be here, but he looks younger than Kay. His sandy-blond hair is tousled, his olive cheeks pale,

and his eyes torn with grief. ‘Suan. Zara decided she was another *runt*.’ His voice is bitter, and I don’t blame him.

An enemy of my enemy though … I approach the group with a little less trepidation. ‘I’m so sorry.’ I take a seat at the end of the bench, a short way away from the only female of the group. ‘May Mortidem hold her gifts with grace.’

‘Thank you. We appreciate that.’ The one who speaks this time isn’t the biggest; that position is held by the boulder of a man at the end of the table who hasn’t so much as glanced at me as he’s too busy shovelling food into his mouth, but he has an air of distinction about him. His skin is dark, his curly black hair cropped close to his head, and he sits with an impressively straight posture as he stretches out a hand to me. ‘Benny.’

‘Rose,’ I respond, taking his hand briefly.

‘Llinos.’ The brunette woman introduces herself next, pronouncing the first sound of her name with a liquid noise somewhere between a ‘c’ and an ‘l.’

‘Sorry, did you say Clinos?’ Better to ask now than still be pronouncing it wrong in a week’s time.

‘Llinos,’ she repeats with that same c-l combination. ‘Don’t worry. You’ll get the hang of it.’ She winks at me, freckles scattering across olive skin as her hazel eyes gleam with mischief.

‘Coulter,’ the youngest one names himself.

The fourth man at the table is much older than the others, with grey hair and skin a remarkably similar colour, but as he merely nods at me and mumbles inaudibly, I’m none the wiser as to his name. As for the boulder man, who looks a good decade older than the rest of them, he doesn’t even bother acknowledging me. A friendly sort, then.

‘It was definitely an unwelcome start to this thing,’ Llinos says, presumably talking about what happened with Suan. ‘I was hoping I could get through this entire Retterheld without having to kill anybody. But I guess that was wishful thinking.’

‘There was one Retterheld five hundred years ago, where everyone made it through to the start of the Ofur – the final challenge. They all just worked together.’

‘I heard about that one too,’ I add. ‘I was kind of hoping it would be like that this time, but that was wishful thinking. If I didn’t have a target on my back before, I definitely have one now.’

‘It’s safe to say you made quite an impression.’ Benny’s response isn’t exactly comforting, though his smile is soft and genuine. ‘Nice trick, by the way. What was that you threw to start the fire? Looked like some kind of glass orb. Magic-infused, I take it?’ His question is casual, but a ripple of fear fills me. I was hoping to fool the others into thinking I had at least *some* magic for at least the first trial.

‘Who said I threw anything?’ I try to appear relaxed despite the prickling down the back of my neck.

‘Benny’s gift is sight-related,’ Llinos explains. ‘He can slow down what he sees and take in all the details. You won’t get anything past him. Super annoying when we played hide-and-seek as kids.’

‘Wow, I’ve never heard of anything like that before.’

‘It’s not exactly common.’ Benny shrugs. ‘Has more advantages than you’d imagine. Though it’s not as visually impressive as some. Right, Jai?’

Jai, I discover, is the name of the mountain of a man at the end of the table.

‘Go on, show her,’ Benny cajoles. ‘Just keep it under control. Maybe use the hearth.’

Jai’s face is twisted in a scowl, and he looks like he wants to throw Benny across the kitchen rather than do what he says, but a moment later, he lets out a slight grunt and the bricks around the fireplace begin to glow – softly at first, and then brighter and brighter until I can feel the heat radiating from them. In moments, the heat is almost as strong as that from the fire bead.

‘Isn’t he amazing?’ Coulter says in wonder.

‘Okay, buddy, that’ll do.’ Benny taps Jai on the arm, and with another grunt, the man stops, and the bricks cease to glow, though the ripples of heat remain.

‘Loch, here, is our bat ears,’ Benny continues with a nod to the man whose name I missed earlier. ‘Which is how we knew you were out there on the stairs. And Coulter can do pretty much the same as Jai, but he heats liquids, not solids.’

As I try to memorise the powers and names and link them to the faces, one overwhelming thought takes hold. ‘You’re not nervous telling me your powers?’

Benny shakes his head. ‘We’re chill. And I saw how you were with Zara. You didn’t want to fight her; you wanted her to back the fuck off. I

respect that. Besides, you already saw what Llin can do.'

I'm utterly confused. 'I did?'

'The wind,' Llinos explains. 'The one that blew the fire out. That was me. Sorry,' she adds apologetically.

'I would've let the bitch burn.' They're the first words Jai's grunted since I got there, and I'm one hundred percent sure he meant them. Despite the positive vibes I've got from Benny, Coulter, and Llinos, I can't say the same about Jai.

'We know you would have,' Benny says flatly, 'but we didn't want the fire to spread. As much as we all want Zara dead for what she did to Suan, there were a lot of people in that corridor who didn't deserve to be flame-grilled. Our plan was never to kill people. Our plan is to work together, get as many of us to the Ofur as possible, and hope that Etta deems one of us worthy to give us the gift. Remember?'

With his easy tone and smile, Benny exudes quiet confidence and charisma.

'You're all from the same city?' I ask, partly to turn the conversation away from Zara, and partly because I may as well use the opportunity to learn as much about them as I can, particularly while Benny's in such a sharing mood.

'Sort of. Llin and I are both from Brandish. The others are from different islands. Different cities.'

Different cities? I assumed there was only one city in the Eastern Isles because people only ever spoke of Brandish.

'So what's your power?' Coulter asks me bluntly. 'Because, you know … throwing things won't get you far.'

'My power?' I repeat dumbly, fingering my hair, heat rising to my cheeks as embarrassment claws at me. Gods, they invited me to sit with them, but they don't know I'm the stripped slum rat. Maybe they assumed I had Issen blood. Either way, there goes my chances at allying myself with them.

'Yeah. I mean, I thought that was what we were doing, right?' Coulter says pointedly. 'Sharing things.'

'Yes,' I agree, swallowing hard. I lean forward and pick up a pastry. I may as well get that before they chuck me out. With a firm grip on the sticky treat, I admit, 'But I don't have anything to share.'

Confusion clouds all their faces.

‘What do you mean?’ It’s the first thing Loch has said, and his voice is unfeasibly quiet. Then again, I guess if you can hear footsteps from however far away, you’re not a great fan of shouting.

I’m not sure how I should respond. Telling them I’m completely powerless seems foolish, but given Zara didn’t hold back from calling me stripped before I set her alight, I’m not going to be able to keep the truth hidden for long.

‘I’m Rose Kultavaris,’ I say after a pause.

I figured that would be all I needed to say. That they would gasp and exchange pointed looks before hastily retreating from my presence. But though Benny and Llinos exchange a quick glance, the others look at me with complete confusion.

‘You’re gonna have to give us more than that,’ Coulter says.

Huh. ‘You honestly don’t know?’

‘Yeah, we’re just really good at playing thick,’ Jai replies sarcastically. ‘No, Rose Kultavaris, we have no idea who you are. That name should mean something to us, I gather?’

I take a deep breath. ‘My mother was Reeva Kultavaris. She was the one who helped birth the queen’s second child.’

And just like that, I see realisation colour the rest of their faces. Tension wraps itself around me as my throat tightens. I try but fail to swallow the sensation down. Now that they know who I am, they’re probably pissed Zara didn’t get rid of me when she had the chance.

Llinos’s eyes lock on mine, and my fingers twitch for the dagger at my side, but they’re full of the sticky treat instead. Way to go, Rose. You’re going to die because you had a pastry in your hands instead of a weapon.

‘I am so sorry,’ she murmurs. ‘I was twelve when it happened. I remember the upset through the islands. The grief. It was…’

She doesn’t finish her sentence. She doesn’t need to.

‘The queen was an incredible person,’ I say stiffly.

‘Yes. But that isn’t the only reason we grieved. People die every day in childbirth. Sometimes healers just can’t get there in time. And sometimes the healers aren’t enough. It’s a cruel reality and I don’t know anybody who hasn’t been touched by it at some point. But to punish the person who was there to help … that should never have happened. I’m sorry for your mother. And your baby brother … I can’t imagine how horrific that must have been.’

I sit dumbfounded and breathless.

People I considered my friends, and people my parents considered their friends, left us the moment the king made his ruling. Yet here are strangers who don't blame my mother. Who don't agree with Korvane's ruling and are bold enough to say so.

While I'm still gaping, Benny speaks up. 'Is it true that the prince was the one who said your mother was responsible?'

My jaw clenches and my nostrils flare in anger. The words, when they come, are said through gritted teeth. 'He lied. The queen told my mother to save the baby at all costs. And she tried, but …'

'You don't need to talk about it.' Llinos's hand reaches across the table.

Benny lets out a low whistle. 'With the prince in the trials, this is going to be one hell of an awkward reunion. Maybe you should've let Zara get to you after all.'

His lips quirk upwards as his eyes glint with mischief, telling me he's only joking. I'm grateful for his attempt to lighten the mood and for Llinos's understanding. It was exactly what I needed.

I never realised quite how much.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 13

I spend close to an hour down in the kitchen getting to know the group. I learned long ago that there aren't friendships in Morathka's court, but there are alliances born from a need to gain power or in a desperate bid to hold on to it. Right now, I'm in the former camp. If Jonas and I team up with the Eastern Isles group, we could be a damn strong team, although I'm uncomfortably aware that I'd be the weak link within it.

'Got your dress ready for the ball?' Benny asks his friend, shooting Llinos a smirk. 'I heard your Carys packed some stunners.'

Llinos scowls back. 'I don't mind how they look,' she says in an aside to me. 'I just hate how I can't move properly in them. Honestly, I'm tempted to take a pair of scissors and cut some damn slits up the side.'

'Then why don't you?' I shrug.

She purses her lips, as though the thought hadn't even crossed her mind. 'I guess I could,' she says slowly, tapping her lip. 'It's not like my family is going to see me. Maybe I will.' She brightens. 'What about you? Have you got anyone to fix your hair, or do you need help?'

I frown. My hair is not something that is easily 'fixed.' My white strands are currently loosely plaited and fall down in front of my shoulder, and there's not much else that can be done beyond that. The strands are that irritating type of waviness that frizzes at the first sign of dampness in the air and mats the minute you rest your head against a pillow.

'Oh, I was just going to do it,' I reply. But even before I've finished speaking, an expression of excitement twists Llinos's lips. 'Or you could help me?' I offer, extending a hair-related olive branch. When she flashes a smile, I know I've said the right thing.

‘I’d love to!’ She beams. ‘We should get going now though.’

En route to my room, we stop at Llinos’s dorm, which she’s sharing with the other members of the Eastern Isles group. There are six single beds, but there are now only five people in the room following Suan’s death. For a second, I consider asking if I can take the spare one – after all, if Llinos is offering to do my hair, she’s probably hoping a friendship’s going to form here – but I keep quiet. The last thing I want is for them to think that I’m trying to replace her when her body’s barely cold.

‘I’ll just be one second,’ Llinos says, grabbing a bag and slinging it over her shoulder. ‘Okay, so where are you bunked down?’

It’s easy to remember the way to the cast-iron spiral staircase, though halfway up it starts swaying in a way that’s more than a little disconcerting. When I glance back, I find Llinos holding the banister and rocking it back and forth.

‘Just trying to feel how sturdy it is!’ She grins.

‘Any chance you can do that while I’m not three-quarters of the way up?’

‘You’re no fun,’ she teases, but she stops rocking the frame.

Once at the top of the stairs, I move to open the door, only to notice something that wasn’t there before: a large bucket filled with sand. Two letters are marked at the top. The letter J, followed by an x for a kiss beneath it.

My heart does a little skip as a smile forms on my lips unbidden.

‘Everything okay?’ Llinos asks, having also reached the top of the staircase.

‘Oh, yes.’ I pick up the bucket and take it into the room with me. ‘Everything’s just fine.’ I don’t explain Jonas’s tongue-in-cheek gift – *as if* I have the power to burn this whole place down – but I chuckle to myself.

She lets out a low whistle as she sees my space. ‘You lucked out here – if you exclude the death trap of a staircase.’

‘No, Jonas lucked out,’ I tell her. ‘He’s from Wrohelm so got it before most people arrived. He said I could take it after the incident with Zara.’

‘How very gentlemanly.’ Her lips twitch, though I choose to ignore her teasing expression. ‘Come on, sit down,’ she says a moment later. ‘Time to get started.’

It takes Llinos less than three minutes to realise that making my hair *ball-worthy* is not quite going to be the straightforward task she obviously

hoped it would be.

‘Sorry,’ I say after a moment. ‘My little sister, Acacia, she got all the good hair. Plus the good looks and just general goodness in the family, really.’

‘Are you kidding me? You’re freaking stunning. You just look … um … weary …’

Weary. That’s one way of putting it. And it’s not as though I’m going to get a rest now that I’m here.

‘What about you?’ I ask as she continues to battle with my split ends. ‘Do you have siblings?’

‘I do.’ Even though she’s standing behind me, I can sense the smile forming on Llinos’s lips. ‘A little sister called Carys. She’s only nine but already runs rings around my parents. Gods, I love her to bits. I hate the fact that I’m not gonna be able to see her while I’m here. I can’t bear the thought that, well, you know …’

‘I know,’ I reply. We fall into silence, and I know we’re both thinking about how so many people here won’t get to say goodbye to the ones they love.

I hope to hell we’re not in that group. A lump that I’ve been trying to suppress in my chest all day threatens to reform, when suddenly Llinos jumps up.

‘Hold on. I’ve got another idea.’

Without waiting for me to respond, she bounds out of the door, her footsteps rattling on the stairs. Thoughts of Kay are still burning behind my eyes, and if I don’t do something soon, I’m going to chicken out, say ‘to hell with whatever fate Etta inflicts on me for desertion,’ and race back to the slums to find my sister. But that won’t help anyone in the long run. So instead, I stand and move over to the wardrobe. I’m going to have to choose my outfit eventually, although I’m secretly hoping Llinos will make the decision for me.

In far less time than I expected, I hear the rattle of the stairs again, and Llinos is back. In her hand is the smallest dagger I’ve ever seen.

‘What exactly are you planning on doing with that?’ I ask curiously. It surprises me that I don’t feel at all nervous to have her near me with that dagger.

‘Just wait. It’s gonna work, I’m sure of it. Now sit down.’

I do as instructed and let her work her way through my knots.

‘Okay, here’s my thinking. I’ll make a bunch of small braids down each side, leave half of them hanging, and pull the rest back. Then I’ll pin them and the rest of your hair up with the dagger. It’ll give a ready-to-fight, don’t-fuck-with-me look.’

‘Sounds good to me,’ I reply, only half able to visualise what she said but more than happy to have another weapon at hand, even if it is the tiniest one I’ve ever seen. ‘Does that actually have a purpose? Or is it just decorative?’

She shrugs. ‘You’d have to ask Benny. It’s one of the many things his family gave him to bring. Good luck tokens, I think. It’s meant to help motivate him, you know? A reminder of why we all need this gifting.’

‘What are *you* here for?’ I ask. ‘You said you were going to work together, right? Does that mean you all want the same gifting?’ Only when an extended pause follows my answer do I realise that the question is rudely personal. ‘Sorry, that’s none of my business,’ I say hastily.

‘I’m sure lots of us want the same things in some sense,’ she replies, sweeping past my question. ‘Now, let’s just see if I can successfully pin this up first.’ She moves to sweep up a handful of my hair when I hear her gasp. ‘Look,’ she whispers, her voice hitched with excitement. ‘A raven.’

As she drops my hair entirely, I twist around and watch as she takes a step towards the window. Sure enough, on the sill is a great black bird with beady, glass-like eyes. I expect the bird to fly off as she nears it, but it doesn’t.

‘We don’t get them in the Eastern Isles.’ Her voice is still whispered awe. ‘This is the first time I’ve ever seen one. Caz would be so excited. She loves birds.’

‘They’re meant to be bad omens,’ I tell her, certain she wouldn’t be staring at it with quite such reverence if she knew how they were viewed here. ‘Very bad omens.’

She turns around. ‘Why?’

‘My father said they whisper your secrets to Mortidem so he knows the best way to take you,’ I admit. To ease the heaviness of the moment, I ask, ‘Who’s Caz? Is that your sister?’

‘My sister? No. No!’ She lets out a laugh as if I’ve said the most preposterous thing in the world. ‘Carys is my sister. Caz is my … was my … Caz was my every*thing*, I guess. She knows all about birds.’

‘She’s still on the Eastern Isles?’ I ask. ‘Did she also try to enter the Retterheld?’

‘No. No, I haven’t seen her for four years now.’

There is something about the way Llinos speaks that implies Caz hasn’t passed away and been given to Mortidem to distribute her powers anew. Which is why I ask gently, ‘Where is she? What happened?’

With one last glance at the raven, Llinos moves back to the bed and drops down next to me with a huff.

‘I don’t know,’ she says. ‘That’s the truth. I don’t know.’ The silence between us lingers, but eventually, she finds her voice. ‘We grew up together,’ she starts. ‘Best friends until we realised we were a lot more than that. I was twenty-one when she gave me this.’ She lifts her hand and shows me the ring on her middle finger. It’s a recognised sign of intention and is traditionally joined by two more rings on the adjacent fingers at marriage. ‘Four years. There was never a moment in my life that I could’ve envisioned her not being in it. I thought we’d do everything. Start a family. Grow old. Even have our pyres lit together. That’s how much I couldn’t imagine a life without her.’

‘So what happened?’

The saddest of smiles graces Llinos’s lips, though it does nothing to erase the pain in her eyes.

‘One day, she was gone.’

‘Gone where?’

‘I don’t know. Just gone,’ she repeats, shaking her head.

I frown. ‘Do you mean she was taken?’

‘No. More … I think she was sent.’ She shakes her head again, this time with more ferocity. ‘Sorry. I shouldn’t have—’

‘No, it’s fine. I don’t mind.’

‘No, I shouldn’t talk about it. I shouldn’t. Her power … it was … useful …’ She sighs. ‘The fact is, I don’t know where she is, and I’ll probably never see her again. And that’s just something I have to live with.’ She pauses and twists back to the window, but when I follow her line of sight, I see the raven has gone.

‘I know what I need my gifting to be,’ she says quietly, ‘but sometimes I can’t help but wonder if maybe, if I win, the Goddess will bring her back to me. As a gift of my own, you know?’

Silence descends, and I’m faced with a reality I don’t want to think about. Only one of us can win the gifting, so do I really want to get close to these people when me getting my dream means them missing out on theirs?

It’s a question I don’t have an answer for.

‘Come on.’ Llinos breaks the silence as she grabs a handful of my hair and begins to separate it into strands. ‘The sooner we can get your hair done, the sooner we can decide what dress you’re going to wear.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 14

‘You know what you said about putting a slit in *my* dress? How would you feel about doing it to yours? I think it would be the perfect final touch.’

I haven’t yet been allowed to see my reflection, though I know the dress Llinos finally decided on is black at the bottom and red on top.

‘These dresses are incredible,’ she said as she rummaged through the wardrobe. ‘They need a bit of updating, but still, the fabrics are so on point.’

‘Feel free to borrow them,’ I replied, assuming ‘a bit of updating’ was a major understatement and Llinos was just being kind.

‘Really?’ Her eyes bugged with delight before her face fell. ‘My little sister Carys chose my first couple of ball dresses, so I feel like I have to wear them first, you know? But maybe I could wear one to one of the later balls?’

‘Absolutely.’

While I put on the dress she’s picked out, she heads back downstairs to her room to get yet another item: an actual garter sheath. She returns with the leather in her hands.

‘There’s no way I’ll cope, knowing there’s a grubby old belt strapped around your thigh,’ she says, handing it to me before twisting me around to take hold of the corset ribbons on my dress. Only when she’s yanked so hard it feels like she’s cracked a couple of ribs does she spin me back around to face her. ‘Now, what do you say about that slit?’

I can’t imagine anyone choosing the Cotillion ball as an opportunity to attack each other, but who knows? And there’s not much point to having my

dagger sheathed on my thigh if I've got to hoist up my entire dress to reach it.

'Go for it,' I say and watch the grin spread across Llinos's face. It's worth desecrating the dress for that alone.

Without waiting for me to change my mind, she grabs her own dagger and slices the fabric of the dress all the way to the top of my thigh. Standing, she looks me up and down. 'Do you have any fighting shorts?' she asks.

'Fighting shorts?'

'Just plain black leather. I've got an idea.'

'Okay …'

'Do you need me to get you a pair?'

'No, I've got some.'

Leather shorts are one of the few items of clothing I have left from my mother, and they were among the first things I packed to come here. I slip some on under my dress, then turn back to Llinos, who has her dagger waiting. She slides it up the other side of the skirt, then along the stitches of my waistband. A large swath of the dress's skirt comes away in her hand.

'I like it. Really like it.' She grins. 'Go. Have a look.'

With an unexpected flutter of nerves, I head into the bathroom, only to do a double take at my image.

There's still that element of weariness in my face that Llinos mentioned earlier, but the way she styled my hair does a good job of hiding it. My gaze quickly trails down the rest of my body. The top of the dress is a deep burgundy velvet corset that's been pulled so tight that, for the first time in my life, I've actually got curves. And while the leather skirt balloons out, the panel that's been taken from the centre reveals more than just a glimpse of my shorts and garter sheath. It is by far the most striking thing I've ever seen, let alone worn.

'You're not going to go unnoticed like that.' She smirks, and I can't help but agree. She was right about fixing the dagger in my hair. Combined with the leather of the shorts and the dagger on my thigh, I don't look like someone you'd want to fuck with. Though hopefully the incident with Zara has already confirmed that.

'Can I help you get ready?' I ask Llinos, aware of just how unconfident I sound. Neither my hair nor my clothing skills are half as good as hers, and I get the feeling she knows it.

‘Don’t worry,’ she says. ‘It won’t take me long, though I’ll probably need to hurry the guys. You know how they like to preen and pamper themselves. Well, Benny does, at least. See you in the dining room in twenty?’

‘Sounds good,’ I reply with a chuckle.

It’s only when she goes that I see the raven has returned and is tilting his head as he looks at me.

‘It’s a ball, okay?’ I snap, not sure if talking to a raven can cause even worse luck than one simply appearing in your presence. ‘This is what people wear to balls. I think.’ As I finish speaking, he flutters his wings before taking flight and leaving me alone. The twist of fear in my chest is accompanied by an undeniable surge of adrenaline.

As much as Llinos’s comment about not going unnoticed unnerved me at first, I think it might actually be useful. Because it means the king and the prince are likely to notice me among the crowd of competitors.

It’s time they realise exactly who Etta let into this tournament.



MANAGING THE RICKETY, impractical stairs in the skirt is even harder than scaling a damn wall, and my nerves definitely aren’t helping. Given that I now have a small cluster of people I feel relatively safe in front of, I should be feeling slightly less fearful, but instead, my throat is growing drier and drier with every breath, and by the time I reach the bottom of the staircase, I wish I’d had a drink of water. But there’s no way I’m going back up. My best bet, I decide as I continue down the narrow – but substantially less perilous – servants’ staircase, is to get myself a glass of water in the kitchen where I met Llin and the others earlier.

Jai is the only member of the group already in the dining hall, and after offering him a quick nod of acknowledgement, I head for the kitchen … only to find my route blocked.

For a split second, he doesn’t see me – he’s too focused on the bottle of drink that he swigs from like he’s suffering from an uncontrollable thirst – and I stand frozen, my stomach somersaulting at the sight of his familiar icy-blue eyes.

He’s not dressed for a ball – hell, he’s barely dressed at all – and I can’t help the way my eyes scan his upper body – the hard muscles that carve his flesh and the tattoos rippled over them. His skin is decorated with scars, but rather than mar him, they seem to highlight all his perfections. Never have I known my body to react so instinctively and viscerally to a man.

His eyes find mine and he drops the bottle from his lips. ‘Kultavaris?’ His voice is just as deep and gravelly as I remember, but the use of my name causes my heart to jolt.

‘You know who I am?’

‘Everyone knows who you are, daughter of the Queenkiller.’ He waits a beat, then slowly and deliberately drags his gaze down my body, lingering on my exposed legs. Heat flickers in his eyes, dark and hungry, and I feel the pull between us coil tighter, as if the air is contracting, eliminating the space between us. ‘That’s one hell of a dress. Not trying to fit in with the ladies of the court, are you?’

‘I’m not here to make friends.’

His expression tightens. ‘No, you’re here to die.’

‘I’m here to win,’ I snap back.

He laughs, the sound patronisingly amused. ‘You’re a lamb among wolves. I don’t know what the fuck Etta was thinking, letting you in. You’re doomed.’

‘You’re hardly the first person to tell me that today, yet Zara Duarte is the one holed up with the healers, and I’m standing here, enjoying this riveting conversation,’ I spit out, hating the condescending tone of his voice. Hating that *anyone* has written me off so easily.

His eyebrows rise. ‘Is she now?’ He looks at me, his gaze now appraising instead of hot. ‘Well, well. Perhaps the rose has some thorns after all.’ He takes another swig from the bottle and pushes off the wall he’s been leaning against before staggering deeper into the kitchen, no doubt hoping to find more drink. He’s drunk before the Retterheld has even begun, and yet he thinks *I’m* the one who’s going to die out there?

Frissons of something I don’t want to name continue to roll through me as I watch him go, unable to haul my eyes away from his back. Those perfect black circles etched in his skin. Only once I’m sure he’s gone do I make my way into the hall to join the others. My need for a drink is all but forgotten, a very different type of thirst having taken over.

~

‘WOW, ROSE.’ Coulter’s jaw hangs loose when he sees me walking over to join them. My interaction with the blue-eyed problem was evidently just long enough for them all to gather. ‘You look amazing.’

‘Thank you. As do you.’

He drops his gaze to the ground as the tops of his ears colour bashfully.

I’m not the only one who’s stepped their attire up a notch. Llinos is in a bright red dress that must have a train twice as long as mine, while the boys are wearing black shirts with sharp dinner jackets. They all look impressively smart, though there’s something about the cut and stitching of Benny’s – not to mention the deep purple hue and the gold accents – that makes it look a grade above the rest. The quiet confidence I sensed from him before has been kicked up another notch.

‘I guess we’re not the only group who thought to meet here first,’ Loch says. ‘Though I think a few groups have already moved on.’

He’s right. Four distinct clusters have formed around us, one with notably older participants than the others. It’s the biggest group, with around a dozen people. Knights. Each one of them is ripped, with taut muscles displayed even from the women’s backless ballgowns. Unlike the group I find myself attached to, these men are shirtless beneath their jackets, revealing the intricate designs of their chest tattoos: circles of Wrohelm, the chevrons of Rowell, and the three bands of Dorain, all intertwined with various symbols. Not just for their Gods, but for their families, too. Their personal desires. But all of them have one thing in common: the lined symbol of a wolf. They are all bonded, which means to be here, they must be separated from their dire wolves. I wonder if it hurts or if it’s like the separation I feel from Kay – a dull throbbing behind my ribs.

Thankfully, I don’t recognise any of the faces in the other groups, so either the Rowell Rettlings have already left or they’re not ready yet. Assuming Zara even makes it to the ball. I don’t know how long it would take healers to work on burns like that, but I can’t imagine it would be quick.

‘So shall we get going?’ Llinos loops her arm through mine. ‘First ball of the trials. Ready?’

The knot in my stomach says no, but it’s Jai who answers.

‘Let’s get the fucking parade started,’ he grunts.

As we start the march across the courtyard and towards the palace, the cold wind bites at my arms and I wish I’d brought some sort of shawl to cover them. I’ll remember for next time.

Assuming I make it to one of the other balls, that is.

‘You feeling okay?’ Llinos mutters to me. ‘You know he’s going to be there, right?’

My stomach squirms. I don’t need to ask who ‘he’ is. While I’m sure an exception will be made for Zara, I can’t imagine the king would be too happy if his only son missed the event. Which means that for the first time since he had us stripped, I’m going to be face-to-face with Prince Kyor. At least I have allies with me. That’s something, right?

‘Holy shit. They don’t do things like this on the islands,’ Coulter says as we step into the outer atrium of the place. ‘Korvane must be broke if he spends all his money on stuff like this.’

‘Not when it’s the other cities’ taxes he spends,’ Loch bites back.

Llinos shoots him a look. ‘As we have discussed numerous times, I can accept that one, or even most of us, might get killed in the trials,’ she says, ‘but I *will not* accept it if you get yourself killed because you piss off a member of the royal family. Or anyone in this court. Keep your tongue civil. Got it?’

A low rumble of noncommittal noises drifts from Loch and Coulter.

‘She asked if you got it,’ Benny repeats with a glare at the other men. This time, when they respond, they are louder in their agreement. ‘Good. Don’t forget our priorities here. We have a gifting to win,’ he says firmly.

When I walk to the hall, anger stirs, hot and heady. Korvane is such an utter prick. Lots of memories may have faded from my mind since leaving the High Hold, and though I attended only a few of the balls as a child, I’m certain I’ve never experienced anything like this.

The hall is decked out in dark wood, but it’s the ceiling that’s the most breathtaking feature. It’s as high as the temple’s, but here the light comes from massive chandeliers instead of windows. The design of each is deliberate, with six rings stretching outward, like the six rings of a Hold. It’s not exactly *subtle*, but it *is* beautiful. What makes me baulk, however, is the choice of candles he’s used to fill it. Smaller, dimmer ones to fill the outer loops, getting larger and brighter until they reach the point right in the centre – the High Hold. It is a brash and arrogant analogy.

Despite the sheer number of Korvane's people who live there, there are no lights for the slums.

One of us. Yes, I think I am. More than I realised. The depths of the slums have ingrained themselves into me in more ways than the dirt embedded into my skin.

Llinos beams at me. 'I think we're supposed to go this way.' With a slight tug on my arm, she directs us towards a large arched doorway. Though she's barely taken two steps in when our route is blocked.

My line of sight falls straight on a broad chest I immediately recognise, though it's not the one I've been thinking about almost constantly since the incident in the kitchen. The dark leather jacket he wears is unbuttoned, revealing a crisp cream shirt beneath it, fastened with garnet-coloured buttons, and for a second, all I can do is stare at the hints of tattoos and muscles visible beneath the fabric. A light tan weapons belt is slung around his waist, and the decorative, gem-covered hilt of a dagger pokes out of the top. It's not something you'd use in an actual fight. Appearance over substance. Like so much of Korvane's court. Though somehow it doesn't annoy me as much given the wearer.

'Jonas?' As I shift my gaze up to his face, I try to keep my voice sounding as neutral as possible, but it's hard. You'd have to be dead not to be attracted to him in this moment.

'Wow, Rose.' Jonas's voice is breathy as his eyes wander all the way down my body and back up again. 'Who knew you could scrub up so well?' A smile begins to form on his lips, only for his jaw to drop as his brain catches up with how offensive his words were. He flushes bright red. 'Oh Gods, I didn't mean, you know … because of the slums or anything. I just mean … I meant …'

'It's fine,' I say, placing my hand on his arm and liking how easily it fits there. 'I know what you meant. And you don't look so bad yourself.'

I have no intention of using Jonas as a guard in any of the trials, or when facing Rettlings like Zara, but having Jonas here, in a ballroom full of enemies … well, that's a comfort I'm willing to accept.

'Thank you for the gift. The sand bucket,' I clarify. 'Very amusing.'

'Oh, there was no joke involved.' His lips twist. 'I just didn't want you setting fire to the entire barracks before we've even got to the first trial.'

I let out a laugh at his warm teasing.

'So are you going to introduce us?' Llinos interrupts.

‘Sorry, yes.’ I step back so Jonas can see the rest of my group. ‘Jonas Lorathin of Wrohelm, this is Llinos … Llinos of the Eastern Isles.’ I make a mental note to learn the islanders’ surnames. ‘And this is Jai, Coulter, Loch, and Benny.’

As Benny steps forward to shake his hand, Jonas’s brow furrows.

‘Haven’t we met before?’

‘Probably, if you’ve been dragged along to these things for decades like I have,’ Benny replies with an easy laugh. ‘Now, let’s get in there. I need a drink.’

As Benny and the others head inside, Jonas places his hand on my waist, twisting me around to face him.

‘Rose, before you go in, there’s someone I need to warn you about.’

‘Your father?’ My heart skitters. ‘Is he here?’ I need to make sure he got my message about Kay. Hearing that she’s somewhere safe, where she can keep tabs on how I’m doing, would be the positive news I need to get through the rest of the night.

‘Not yet, no. But look, Rose, I’m not sure how to say this. You just need to know—’

‘Oh fuck,’ Llinos says, her voice loud enough to cut Jonas off. ‘I don’t know if I’m impressed or terrified.’

I follow her line of sight.

Turns out Zara isn’t holed up with the healers after all.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 15

I wish I couldn't see Zara, a furious scowl on her face and angry burns still marring her skin. The healers have done one hell of a job on the blisters and brought down the swelling, but the evidence of what I did is still clear. Her skin is puckered and pink, the hair on that side of her head gone entirely. Not just shaved but scorched away.

Beside Zara is a slender man with an almost identical face to her own. I assume it's her brother, Shim. When he sees me staring, he taps his sister on the shoulder. Slowly, she turns to face me. Her choice of outfit is fierce – a dress that's eighty percent chains and no more than six inches of fabric. It definitely gives the burns room to breathe.

Every muscle in my body clenches as I stand there, bolted to the ground, awaiting whatever pain's going to come. But there's nothing. Nothing but my own pulse hammering in my ears as her lips curve into a sneer. Whatever she's got planned for me now, I have a feeling it's going to be a hell of a lot worse than when she merely considered me a 'runt.'

'I need a drink,' Jai grunts, and for once I'm grateful for the curtness of his interjections.

'Yeah, me too,' I reply, trying to stem the trembling in my knees. I can feel their gazes trained on me – the courtiers, former so-called friends of my family – as my own eyes fall on a redheaded woman. A gasp escapes me. It's Lora's mother, and she hasn't aged a day. Only … my stomach sinks as I realise it's not her mother at all. It's Lora herself. I hastily look away.

As I continue to scan the scene, I wonder how many among the crowd have placed bets that I'll be dead by the end of the first trial and how many don't expect me to even get that far. Now, more than ever, I'm glad I went

down to the kitchens earlier, and not just because it meant I met Llinos and her gang; I'm not sure my stomach could handle anything right now.

Along the side of the main ballroom, there are a series of archways that lead into different corridors and, I assume, more rooms where the real action takes place. My father always said that balls are never about dancing or drinking. They're for clandestine meetings, mingling, information gathering, and forming alliances.

'Okay, Wrohelm,' Benny says to Jonas after Jai's grabbed a full tray of drinks from a waiter. 'Since you're hanging around with us, you can make yourself useful. Who's our biggest competitor?'

'Really?' Coulter looks up at Benny. 'We don't even get tonight off?'

'You can if you want,' Benny replies, 'but I intend to use my time wisely, as I'm sure all the people who want a chance of actually winning this thing will do.'

I shoot Coulter a sympathetic smile. Maybe it's because of his age, but I get the feeling this event, with the drinks and the glamour and the eight-piece musical ensemble, is a far bigger deal to him than the others. I can only imagine how giddy Kay would be if she were here.

'There'll be plenty more,' I remind him. 'One after each trial.'

'Yeah, as long as I live through them,' he grumbles.

'Oh, for Aitara's sake. Come on, let's go have a wander,' Loch huffs. 'They can fill us in later, right?'

As Loch glances at Benny, the two exchange a look, and I realise the older man's offer to take Coulter for a tour of the ballroom creates an opportunity to put that magical hearing of his to good use. Smart.

Llinos stays close to Benny's side, whereas Jai stands slightly apart from us and is already on his second drink. Apparently, grabbing intel on the other competitors isn't so important to him, but I guess when you're built like a small house and can turn the rocks beneath people's feet into molten lava, you don't worry about stuff quite so much. I, however, need the intel.

Rather than immediately jumping into his role as a Wrohelm guide, Jonas hesitates, his expression tightening.

'I didn't know if perhaps there were people Rose wanted to speak to,' he says, looking pointedly at me. 'You know, since you used to live here.'

'Trust me, there is no one from the past that I want to talk to,' I mutter. 'So, spill. Who's who?'

Jonas lets out a groan before taking a pull of his drink. ‘Okay, so it’s mostly knights and nobles we’re up against, and I don’t know much about the knights, other than what I’ve heard over in the barracks.’

‘Which is?’ Benny presses.

‘They’re tough as fuck.’

A slight sigh escapes Benny’s lips. I think it’s fair to say we could have worked that out on our own.

‘But the toughest,’ Jonas continues, ‘is Grenda.’ He gestures subtly with his head to the other side of the ballroom. ‘Grey hair, black dress. I heard she’s the second oldest in the Retterheld this year, but age has certainly not diminished her. She’s got two sons stationed on the Hirathean Path and has already told everyone that her gifting would be to get them home alive.’

My heart squeezes tightly. Risking death so your children can live. Hard to find fault with that.

‘Have her sons been given leave to come and watch her compete?’ Llinos asks.

Jonas shakes his head. ‘Who knows though? Maybe after the vowing they’ll be allowed to return.’

Fucking Korvane, making people risk death just to see their own children. Everyone knows that going to the border is basically a death sentence. Few come back from it, and if they do, they’re in no fit state to even talk about what they saw.

‘Who else?’ Benny presses. ‘What about the nobles? There’s the prince, of course.’

Jonas’s cheeks suck inwards. ‘Yeah, Kyor’s going to be one hell of a tough competitor. He was trained by Zelle, the youngest ever commander of the army, until Kyor stole that title from him. Apparently, his bond with his wolf is crazy strong and works over miles, and as for his magic …’ He lets out a low whistle.

‘What is it? What can he do?’ I ask.

Back before we were stripped, there were rumours of what the prince could do. Some said he would one day rival even my father as a storm summoner, but he was too young then for his powers to have settled, so it was mostly conjecture.

‘Oh, I’m sure you’ll see,’ Jonas says vaguely. ‘Don’t know where he is now or if he’ll even turn up before the inauguration. Rumour has it he rode his wolf straight back to the battlefield after his offering.’

‘What?’ Llinos’s face displays the same level of shock as I’m feeling. ‘He rides his dire wolf? Don’t people have their legs ripped off for even attempting that?’

‘Well, he’s said to ride her,’ Jonas replies with a shrug.

It sounds like a wild rumour to me. The type to make the prince sound like he’s greater than the rest of us and worthy of his position. I’m happy to call bullshit on that, but I don’t know if I’m pleased or not about the fact that he may not show up tonight. I have dreamed about seeing the prince countless times since we were cast out, rehearsed what I would say to him over and over again, but that doesn’t stop the twinge of fear sparking in my gut about the potential consequences of lambasting him publicly. For Kay, I’ll hold my tongue – for now.

‘So … the other nobles,’ Benny continues to push. ‘I heard there were ten of you?’

‘Right.’ Jonas slips back into his role of court informant, this time a little more enthusiastically. ‘The other guys are older. Nathan Taros is sixty-plus and a fire wielder. Was amazing but makes mistakes now. His daughter, Nessira, is probably the better fighter. She’s competing as well.’

‘Fire wielder?’ I question, as keen as Benny to learn all I can.

‘Not exactly. She’s a healer. A cauter.’

‘A cauter?’ Llinos questions.

‘She can cauterise wounds,’ Jonas explains. ‘Damn useful skill to have in battle. Stops soldiers bleeding out when they take an ice blade from the Issen.’

That does sound handy, but hardly competition-winning magic. Still, it’s better than my sweet fuck-all.

‘It’s the same skill as her aunt, Clade – Nathan’s sister – who’s also been accepted.’

‘Wow, talk about keeping it in the family,’ Benny murmurs. ‘I’m guessing the Taroses will work together, given that they’ve probably trained together their entire lives.’

‘It’s likely,’ Jonas agrees, ‘but they’ll probably need help from some of the others, given that Nathan’s the only one with offensive powers. Yeva Mancy is an obvious choice.’ He looks around for her, only to come up empty. ‘She’s an ash weaver. Really grey eyes so you’ll know her when you see her. The power sounds weak until you see what an ash storm can do. She’s not the strongest, but she’s tough. Pen Tharolin is the youngest of the

Wrohelm Rettlings. Her touch blisters, which is nasty if you're the recipient of it, but she's not much of a fighter. I expect most people will be able to stop her from ever getting that far.'

Jonas pauses for a breath, but it's clear he's now in the flow of things.

'Who's that?' I point to a woman standing near a fireplace, her body rigid as an older man and woman try to engage her in conversation. I don't know what it is, but there's something about her that makes me think she's a Rettling and not just a member of the court. She has a circular tattoo for Wrohelm on her upper arm, which I can't imagine anyone who wasn't from here would ever get, though she seems to be observing her surroundings intently. Not only that, but there's an anger radiating from her, a tightness to her frame, as though she's only here because she has to be. It feels remarkably familiar.

'You don't know Estel?' Jonas says. He shakes his head slightly, as though he's realised his mistake. 'Of course. You were already gone when her sister was stripped.'

'Her sister was stripped? What, why?'

My stomach does something between a drop and a somersault. Another noble stripped? But just the sister, not the whole family. Her 'crime' can't have been as severe as ours.

The three of us are staring at Jonas, waiting for his response, but it appears his reticence has returned. Regardless of his revelations over the last five minutes, he's clearly not a gossip. I find that I like that about him.

'What did the sister do?' Llinos repeats my question. 'Why was she stripped?'

Jonas's Adam's apple bobs slightly before he answers us. 'She got pregnant … without Etta's blessing.'

The shock is so acute that I feel almost winded by it.

'You have to be joking.' Benny's expression is as aghast as mine. 'You can't be serious? Stripped for accidentally getting knocked up?'

People aren't *meant* to get pregnant before they're married and blessed by one of Etta's priestesses – after all, she is the Goddess of Life – but I've known dozens of children born out of wedlock in the slums, and none of them have been stripped. Not that most of them have much magic to strip. More and more children in the slums are being born with barely any magic at all. I suspect that – as with most things – the noble children get the majority.

‘Was it just because she was a member of Korvane’s court when it happened?’ I ask in bemusement.

‘That’s the reason that was given,’ Jonas replies, yet I can hear the ‘but’ teetering at the end of his words.

‘But …’ I prod him.

Jonas looks around as if he’s afraid of being overheard. Fair. Assuming there’s someone else with Loch’s skill around, there’s a good chance of it. Jonas must reach the same conclusion as he presses his lips together and mutters, ‘Later.’

I’m desperate to know the details, not to mention where the sister is now, as there’s a chance that she and Kay could be of comfort to each other while Estel and I are facing the trials. I’m about to suggest we head to one of the antechambers around us so we can speak freely, when a young man walks towards us.

‘Brother!’ He embraces Jonas tightly before stepping back with a wide grin. ‘I worried I wouldn’t get to see you.’

‘Brother?’ Surprise hitches in my voice. The boy looks about fifteen, which means that he would have been born before I was stripped. Yet Jonas’s mother died several years before, and as far as I’m aware, Artur never remarried.

‘William.’ Jonas smiles at his sibling. ‘I’m surprised to see you. I didn’t think Father would allow you to come.’

‘Well, he’s not here.’ William winks. ‘Had to do something important, apparently. But there’s no chance I’m missing the inauguration.’

‘Your father remarried?’ I blurt. ‘You never said.’

Jonas combs his fingers through the length of his beard as his eyes skim over mine and across to the rest of the group. ‘William is my father’s ward.’

‘But I’ve been with him so long that we’re as good as kin,’ William quickly adds. ‘I know Jonas better than my own family in Rowell. In fact, I doubt I would even recognise them if one of my cousins from the city were here at this very ball.’

‘If they’re from Rowell, you’re probably better off not knowing them,’ Llinos mutters to me and we share a smile.

‘So how come you ended up here? With Jonas?’ Benny asks. ‘It’s a long way from Rowell.’

‘Indeed.’ William nods. ‘My mother sent me here after my father passed away, when I was about three or four. She knew Artur from their youth and

believed I would have a better education here than if I'd stayed up north.'

'And you've stayed here all this time?' I query. Even when my mother was so sick she could barely remember our names, she'd never have sent us away. But maybe that was because she'd already lost Florian. After his death, she clung to Kay and me harder than ever before.

'My mother died when I was nine,' William tells me. 'Killed in a battle with the Issen. I have an aunt in Rowell, but it was seen as best that I stayed here.' He shrugs, trying to portray a nonchalant air that I don't believe. 'It is my home now.'

'I'm sorry for your loss,' I say, meaning it. Kay was only twelve when our mother died, and it was two years later that we lost our father, too. At least she has memories of them, even if so many of them are tarnished by sickness. If William only has memories of his parents up to the age of four, I doubt there is much, if anything, he can genuinely recall.

Thoughts of Kay make my stomach churn with worry. It's not even been a full day apart and I feel half mad with the need to see her, to know she is well. We've never been apart for longer than a night, and it's clear this separation will be more torturous than I feared.

'Where is Father?' Jonas asks, echoing what I'd asked him upon my arrival. 'Why is he not here?'

William lifts a shoulder. 'Dunno. Said he hoped to be back for tonight, but I guess that's not the case. I don't think he's gone far though.'

I hope his task is to find a home for my sister, someone to take care of her in one of the inner rings, but I daren't voice the hope aloud, lest I curse it with my breath.

'Worked out who you've got to kill to win this thing?' William asks Jonas, that childish grin back on his face.

'Hopefully no one,' Jonas replies with a frown. 'That's not the purpose of the Retterheld.'

William rolls his eyes. 'No, but you know some people are going to want to kill you just because, right?'

'Sure sounds like you're from Rowell,' Benny mutters, and the rest of us can't help but chuckle, regardless of how macabre it may be. Before William can rebut, a hush drifts across the room, prickling my skin. The musicians stop playing, and a moment later, the entire hall is eerily silent.

The crowd parts at the far end of the room, and the figure they were all crowding around comes into view.

King Korvane.

My stomach clenches as the taste of bile stings the back of my throat. The monarch's hair is a little longer than the last time I saw him, but it's still just as dark, and even from this distance I can see his eyes share the same dark brown hue as his only son.

My pulse thuds, and for one blood-rushing second, I wonder if I should take my chance and plunge a knife through Korvane's black heart right now. This distance, no breeze, a clear view … I'd hit my target the first time. And the blade strapped to my thigh would do the job perfectly. Heat fills my lungs as my hands quiver. So much of me longs to do it. To kill him. The way he killed Florian. And it's not like that's the only life he took. In killing my brother, he also killed my parents. They just took longer to die.

I take a steady breath and cool, rational thought returns. I could kill Korvane, but then what? He's surrounded by knights, guards, and loyalists with magic I could only ever dream of. If I miraculously got my dagger unsheathed and in his chest before someone stopped me, I'd be dead before I could even scream out why he deserved to die. And they wouldn't just stop with me. They'd come for Kay, too.

And it's not like the king's death would change anything. Not when Kyor is just as vicious as his father.

Korvane's low drawl, silky and smooth like a snake, interrupts my thoughts. 'Lords, ladies, distinguished guests, and of course … Etta's blessed Rettlings. Welcome to my humble abode.'

A light laugh ripples through the ballroom like a wave. A lump swells in my throat, and for a moment, I struggle to breathe.

'Are you okay?' Llinos reaches out and squeezes my hand, steadying me.

'Not really,' I admit, gratefully clinging to her like an anchor. Regardless of what happens in the trials, I already know I'll be indebted to Llinos, if only for this moment and the steady hold I didn't realise I needed.

'The Retterheld is revered across all Morathka as the most formidable and honoured trial that our people can face,' Korvane continues, 'but the reward outstrips even the gold in our coffers. What could be more precious than a gift from the Goddess Etta herself? I'll tell you. The winner of the Retterheld will enjoy not just the gifting from Etta, but our favour as well.' He smiles as if the second gift is as worthy as the first.

My ears hum so loudly with the rush of adrenaline that I barely hear what he says next. Instead, my eyes are fixed on his crown – probably the most ostentatious piece of jewellery in existence. It's not the first time I've seen it. It was upon his head when he came to his wife's bedchamber and found her lifeless.

Though I know it's impossible, the smell of the queen's blood fills my nostrils, cloying and metallic. I can't cope, can't breathe. I need to get out of here. But there's no way I can bolt without drawing attention to myself. My heart is battering my ribs as I try to keep myself still, when from the other side of the room, a loud banging causes Korvane to fall silent.

A sudden murmur of voices swirls around me as the moment is broken, and the vice around my ribs falls away. Dropping Llinos's hand, I gasp in relief. I can still smell it, that acrid tang of blood, but I can breathe. And that's something.

When at last I drag in enough air, I realise the chatter has fallen to a hush, and every eye has swung from the king to the lone figure staggering across the ballroom. In one sweep, the swaying man grabs a glass of champagne, downs it in one, and returns it empty to the waiter's tray before grabbing another.

'Well, isn't this a fucking delight?' I can't yet see his face, but his voice is a deep drawl that's awfully familiar. 'Let's have a party while the great king's soldiers die. Or maybe that's *why* we're having a party? Is it?' As the second drink follows the first down his throat, he grabs yet another and turns in a slow curve towards the king, his arms stretched out wide. 'Have I missed the toast? Has our beloved king already said a word for the fallen?'

Eyes wide, I baulk. Whoever this is, he must have a death wish to speak to the king like that in front of this many people. I wait for the knights to snap into action, for the few dire wolves prowling the room to rip across the floor and savage him. But none of them move.

'Come on, who's drinking to our fallen?' His words slur and the champagne in his glass spills onto the floor as he gestures wildly.

King Korvane laughs loudly, but his eyes are hard and cold. His forced jovial tone falls flat when he says, 'Well, it appears that our alcohol might be a little too strong tonight. This is indeed a celebration and we need a toast. To Etta and our great Rettlings. Drink up, everyone.'

The room does as instructed, lifting their glasses and muttering their toasts in hushed and hurried whispers, yet my attention remains fixed on the

man who swans through the room as if he owns the place.

As he moves to set his empty glass back on a tray, he finally faces me, and the breath rushes from my lungs as his icy-blue eyes lock onto mine.

It's him.

A thousand shivers cascade down my spine as the heat and fury I felt at the sight of Korvane transform into something else entirely. Something that causes every sense in my body to heighten.

The white shirt that he's wearing is unbuttoned a third of the way down his chest, revealing a hint of the circular tattoos that mark him. But I remember them all. Just as I remember the sharp lines of the muscles beneath his olive skin and the way his lips curved into a smirk when he spoke to me. A warm and involuntary shudder overtakes me.

'Who is that?' I whisper to Jonas, but my voice barely makes a sound. I clear my throat and try again. 'Jonas, who is that? He's from Wrohelm, right?'

Jonas looks at me like I've lost my mind. 'You're joking, right? That's Prince Kyor.'

'No,' I murmur in confused denial, unable to draw my eyes away from the royal as he drinks directly from a champagne bottle, gulping down the expensive vintage as though it's water.

'No,' I say more forcefully. 'Kyor had *brown* eyes.'

'He *did*.' Jonas puts all the emphasis on the second word. 'But then he had them changed – after his mother died.'

'What?'

I search Jonas's face for any hint of humour, as if he might be pulling my leg. But there's nothing.

'It was a massive scandal,' Jonas continues. 'Korvane was furious. Every heir to the throne has had the same dark brown eyes for the last, well, Gods know how many generations. And then Kyor went and pulled that stunt. He had priests and priestesses from all seven Gods perform the charms, so it's irreversible. Kyor will be the first blue-eyed Morathkian king for centuries.'

I can but gape. Those icy-blue eyes – the ones that have haunted both my sleeping and waking dreams since I first saw them two nights ago – belong to fucking Prince Kyor? That touch that caused my skin to nearly melt belongs to the man I despise more than even the king himself?

The knots in my stomach twist so tight I can barely draw breath. I don't want to believe it. With my whole heart, I want Jonas to be lying, but I know he's not. I knew I recognised those eyes somehow, but I couldn't place them, convinced that the last time I saw eyes that shade, they belonged to a woman. And I was right. Kyor's eyes are the exact shade of the irises that looked up at my mother and told her to save the babe instead. The blue eyes that flashed when the queen sent me a fleeting smile as I stood at my mother's side, uncomfortably aware of the blood that was pooling on the ground by our feet.

'Are you all right?' Jonas brushes my arm. 'You look pale.'

Of course I look fucking pale, I want to snap at him. This is the man responsible for ruining my entire life, and I've been *lusting* after him. A mixture of fury and disgust rises within me, and not just because of our past.

This ball is in celebration of Etta's name, and he is a Rettling gifted with the honour of competing, when dozens – if not hundreds – of others were rejected. Yet he's here, drunk and talking of death. Whatever powers he may have been blessed with, even Zara has more right to win this thing than he does. What can *he* possibly need?

I lift my glass, desperate to ease the dryness in my throat. As the champagne bubbles touch my lips, those blue eyes lock on mine for a second time. My pulse soars and I will him to look away, but he doesn't. No, this time he holds my gaze completely. Adrenaline floods through me. No matter how much I want to tear my eyes away, I can't. My mind and my body are locked in conflict.

Finally, I let my lips shift into a snarl, letting him see all of my fucking hatred for him.

In answer, his own lips tip up in amusement. My hatred *amuses* him? My jaw clenches and I refuse to look away. Refuse to show him even an iota of deference.

But the prince, it seems, is not in the mood for a staring contest across a crowded room. Instead, he drops the champagne bottle to his side and starts walking.

Straight towards me.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 16

‘Uh, Rose?’ Llinos’s voice is a whisper, but it’s perfectly loud enough for me to hear the panic within it. I give her hand a squeeze and then release it. I want my hands free for what comes next, but I let one hover close to the dagger’s pommel.

Benny stiffens next to me, but it’s Jonas I’m most aware of. His fingers graze my hand as if he’s considering taking hold of it, only to pull away as Kyor approaches.

‘Kyor,’ Jonas says, his voice neutral. ‘I am glad you made it back for the Retterheld. People were starting to worry you wouldn’t return in time from the Northern territories.’

Kyor doesn’t so much as acknowledge Jonas’s presence. His attention is all on me, his icy-blue eyes staring me down, breaking contact only to scan my body in a tortuously slow sweep that lingers on my hips, my thighs and – it feels – every one of my curves.

‘Have you spoken to my father?’ he asks casually. ‘He’s no doubt dying to see you again, Kultavaris.’ The emphasis he puts on the word *dying* suggests that I’ll be the one seeing Mortidem sooner rather than later.

‘I haven’t yet had the pleasure,’ I fire back as flatly as I can manage.

‘No. From what I recall, pleasure is something you’re lacking in,’ he says, his eyes glinting.

I bite back the retort on my tongue. He might be untouchable here, surrounded by knights and lords – people I’m sure would happily give their lives for his – but I’m not. Besides, what I have to say to him doesn’t need an audience.

When he finally realises he’s not going to get a rise out of me, he looks around at Jonas and Benny. He nods his head at Jonas. ‘Sensible of you to pick this one to fuck first, given she’s not going to survive the first trial. The Retterheld has no place for flowers. Graveyards do though. Which is exactly where she belongs.’

His venom works to knock the breath from me, and though fury rises sharp and hot in my chest, not a single word makes it past my lips.

‘Okay, that’s enough.’ Benny places his hand on Kyor’s shoulder. ‘I know you’re a prince and everything, but your manners are shocking. And in case you haven’t realised, tonight is meant to be fun.’

Given how Benny had no intention of making the night anything more than business only minutes ago, I should find the comment amusing. But I don’t. I’ve only just made these friends, and now they’re being forced to make an enemy of one of the most powerful Rettlings. For me.

The air grows taut as Kyor’s eyes narrow on Benny. ‘I know you.’

‘Probably from one of these tedious things,’ Benny replies drily, the same way he had to Jonas earlier. ‘Now, did you want anything else, or are we done here?’

Kyor’s lips twist as his attention shifts back to me. ‘You are racking them up, aren’t you, Kultavaris? Can’t say I blame you. Might as well get as much fun in as you can before you meet Mortidem. Maybe I could join you one night, too? I guess it would have to be soon. You know, with the trials coming up. So … is it a together thing, or one at a time?’

A sound rumbles from Benny and his fingers flex as though it’s taking all his restraint not to hit the prince. And from the way the corner of Kyor’s mouth twitches, he sees it too. It’s all just a game to him.

But if he truly wanted me dead, he could have done it at the temple. So why didn’t he?

If I’d known who he was, I would certainly have been rooting for him to fall from that damned window. And though I wouldn’t have killed him in Etta’s temple, I would have been damn tempted to wait outside and throw a dagger through his chest the moment he left. So what stopped him?

Understanding hits me the moment the thought strikes. Unlike Zara, Kyor doesn’t believe Etta will gift him if he starts unnecessarily killing her chosen ones before the trials have even begun. Just like he did with the offering, he’s following the rules. After all, there isn’t a knight alive who would have allowed their wolves to attack the heir to the throne, meaning

he didn’t have to put his life at risk to enter the temple through the most dangerous route possible. But he did it anyway, taking the same risks as every other candidate to ensure he was equally worthy of Etta’s consideration.

Meaning that in this moment, in this place, I’m absolutely safe from him.

‘It’s fine,’ I say, placing my hand on Benny’s arm and moving past him and Jonas so there is nothing but a whisper of air between the prince and me. With my pulse pounding, I lean in.

‘You lied, Kyor,’ I whisper, close enough for him to feel my breath on his skin. ‘You might have convinced your father, but we both know the truth, don’t we? Just like Etta does. Like all the Gods do. One way or another, your pathetic soul is doomed.’

With that, I turn around and look at my friends. ‘Who wants to dance?’ I ask airily. Without even bothering to answer me, Benny takes my arm and leads me to the floor. I don’t look at the prince again.

Benny twirls me around effortlessly and we fall into a natural rhythm. My head has forgotten the dance moves, but my feet have not, and we move smoothly around the other couples, as if we’ve partnered together for years.

Benny’s thoughts must have followed a similar line, for he murmurs to me, ‘I know we didn’t formally agree on an alliance, but considering the enemies I’ve now made, I do propose we work together in the trials.’

I tilt my head to the side and pretend to consider the suggestion. ‘Well … I do have quite a few options, you know …’ A grin breaks free on my lips. ‘Deal.’

He beams back. ‘Wonderful.’

As the music ends, Llinos hauls us off the dance floor. ‘We aren’t supposed to be making enemies,’ she hisses at Benny. ‘That’s your rule.’

He shrugs. ‘He’s an enemy I would have been perfectly fine with making anyway,’ Benny replies. ‘But happily, it was worth it. Rose has agreed to work with us.’

Llinos beams at me, relief flashing in her eyes. ‘That’s great news.’

‘I think so,’ I quip. ‘More so for me than you guys, but I’ll take it.’ I turn to Jonas. ‘You with us?’

While I’m now more than a little relieved to have a team beside me, Jonas looks nervous about the proposition.

He presses his lips tightly together. ‘It’s not quite so straightforward for me. I don’t want to make any enemies. Any more enemies,’ he corrects himself with a grimace.

‘Think it over. There’s no rush,’ Benny says. ‘But we’re a good team to have on your side.’

‘I believe it.’

All four of us have barely touched the wine, but we seem to be among the minority as inebriated guests swirl around us. When we’re joined by Loch and Coulter, it’s clear the younger of the pair has also been enjoying his fair share of beverages.

‘This place is amazing,’ Coulter gushes. ‘There are so many rooms: games rooms, drawing rooms, studies. And the wine? Gods, tell me you’ve tried the pink one? Pink wine. It’s my new favourite.’

His cheeks have a ruddiness to them, which is undoubtedly from the drink. As is the slight glaze to his eyes. His exuberance makes me smile. Was I ever so *young*?

‘Learn anything?’ Benny asks, looking directly at Loch while Coulter scans the room for another waiter. He clearly has his priorities.

‘Couple of things. Apparently two of the Rowells – Elenor and Oke – threatened the healers to make sure they fixed Zara up enough that she was ready for the ball. It’s left them all entirely drained, so let’s hope none of us get injured tonight.’

Llinos and I exchange a worried look. The only time I ever saw my mother drained was when she was trying to help the queen. Her body had paled, her skin turning translucent as she tried to call upon any last shreds of magic she could, her very life essence being stripped from her cells. Recovery from draining can take anything from hours to weeks, depending on how bad it is, so trying to stay injury-free for at least a few days sounds like a solid plan. Better still would be avoiding injury altogether, but that seems unlikely.

‘Oh.’ Loch’s voice yanks me back into the room. ‘And there’s another woman in the Retterheld whose sister got stripped and banished from the High Hold because she got pregnant by the prince.’

‘What?’ My jaw drops open as I spin around to face Jonas. My eyes are so wide I can feel them bulging. ‘That’s what you wouldn’t tell us?’

‘It’s all rumours.’ He shakes his head as he speaks. ‘Nothing concrete.’

‘When did this happen?’

‘Three or four years ago. I can’t remember exactly.’

‘You’re saying the prince has a child out there? A rightful successor to the throne?’ Benny interjects.

Rather than replying, Jonas bites down on his bottom lip and glances around. I’m honestly not sure why he’s that worried. Obviously other people are talking about it, or Loch wouldn’t have heard. Of course, with his power, who knows how far away the people were when they were having what they likely thought was a private conversation.

‘No.’ His timbre is grave. ‘Apparently the child didn’t make it.’

‘That poor woman.’ Llinos’s words echo my own thoughts. Stripped and banished, only to lose the reason for it. Just awful.

The trail of destruction the prince leaves behind him really does know no bounds. No, I’m not surprised that Kyor is the type of person who gets a kick out of destroying others.

‘Guys.’ Coulter’s trembling voice breaks the silence that has settled. ‘I think the king’s coming around, meeting the Rettlings.’

He gestures to the other side of the room where, sure enough, Korvane Knavin, backed by two knights and their dire wolves, is shaking hands with an elderly woman who has a large, curved tattoo on her back – the arch of the city of Dorain. From there, he moves on and shakes the hand of a young man.

King Korvane is exactly as I remembered, with narrow, deep-set eyes and a sharp, angular nose and chin. He’s not as broad as his son, and I doubt he was ever close to as good-looking, but his body exudes power. So much so, I swear I can almost see it rippling around him like an aura.

He moves swiftly, shaking the hands of the groups near him before turning his attention to other areas of the room. When his gaze falls on our little gathering, nausea sweeps through me.

‘Need my hand again?’ Llinos mutters. ‘Or would you rather my dagger?’

‘Both,’ I hiss back, while simultaneously forcing my cheeks upwards in a smile. I can fake deference. For now.

Korvane’s eyes skim past the rest of us and land on Benny. His lips purse slightly, but before he can speak, Benny offers him a courtly bow.

‘Benaris Birch, of the Eastern Isles. An honour to meet you, Your Majesty.’

‘Birch. That’s not a name I’m familiar with. Lesser noble, I assume?’

Prick, I think, as Llinos sucks in a breath next to me. But Benny seems utterly unperturbed by the comment. ‘Quite possibly,’ he replies with perfect politeness.

From there, Korvane moves his attention to Llinos and the others from the Isles, though where Jai has got to, I’m not sure. By the time Coulter has finished babbling to the monarch, my heart is lodged so far up my throat I can barely swallow. Every part of me is praying that Korvane will speak to Jonas next. That maybe the two of them will get so embroiled in conversation that I’ll be able to slip away unnoticed.

But the king looks at me instead. His stare is just as piercing as his son’s. My hand is perfectly steady, like it could still hold a dagger firmly enough to stab him, but I resist the urge to test it.

King Korvane looks at me, waiting for me to extend a hand for him to take, but I refuse to shake the hand of the man who murdered my brother.

Rather than speak, he rolls his gaze across my shoulders and chest, looking for a tattoo. For marks of the city I show fealty to. Some people in the slums wear the Wrohelm rings, but not me. I’d rather stick pins in my eyes than show fealty to anything this man and his family hold in esteem.

Knowledge sparks in his eyes, and I know he’s worked out who I am. ‘It would seem as though Etta is giving a chance to even the most unmeritorious in this Retterheld,’ he murmurs.

‘Are you questioning the Goddess’s wisdom, Your Majesty?’ I reply, my eyebrow arching. There’s no denying the sliver of satisfaction that comes with knowing my presence here riles even a tiny part of him.

I can only imagine what it’ll be like if – *when* – I win this thing. The thought makes me smile. He’s publicly said he will give the winner his favour, and it would delight me endlessly to see him forced to acknowledge me.

‘Not at all.’ His smile is thin, cutting, a threat rather than a kindness. ‘But Goddess though she may be, there is no denying that females are slaves to their emotions, especially in situations where only cold, hard logic should rule. It’s what makes them easy to manipulate.’

For a moment, my brain disconnects. Did he just insult the Goddess? I reply without hesitation, ‘Well, it is not for any of us mere mortals to judge her decisions. She chooses with a wisdom and insight that, unfortunately, even the highest of nobles are not blessed with.’

It’s a poorly veiled insult, but unlike Benny, the king doesn’t feign obliviousness to it. Instead, his cheeks suck inwards and his jaw tightens. When he speaks, his voice is like gravel. ‘I’ve heard there has already been one attempt on your life, Rettling Kultavaris,’ he says. ‘And before the inauguration, too. It can’t bode well for your chances.’

I smile back. ‘A failed attempt, which I believe bodes very well indeed.’

He inhales with a hiss and my eyes are drawn to his hand, where a skitter of flames begins to dance. He lets them grow on his palm until the heat reaches my skin and intensifies. My jaw locks as my skin throbs, but I refuse to step back from his less-than-subtle threat.

As suddenly as they come, the flames vanish. He smiles slowly now, his expression dark and sinister. ‘Well, let us hope that you continue to be as fortunate throughout.’ His smile widens. ‘Then again, the Gods’ favour only lasts for so long.’

Done with me, he turns to Jonas. ‘Rettling Lorathin, I will admit I find your choice of company this evening peculiar.’

‘Just trying to make all the visitors to our great city feel welcome,’ Jonas replies smoothly, though I hear the tentativeness in his tone.

‘Indeed. I’m sure there are others who would welcome your hospitality. Though perhaps they are not as pretty as the companion you’ve chosen.’

A thrum of annoyance roils within me. The fact that both Korvane and his son think the only reason Jonas is at my side is so he can screw me says far more about them than us, and it’s taking every bit of willpower I have to bite my tongue.

The king straightens as he draws in a breath, causing the obnoxious stones in his crown to glint. ‘I’ve not seen your father yet this evening,’ he continues to Jonas. ‘I assume he will be bringing his wards with him to watch you and your new friends’ progress in the trials. There’s one you’re particularly close to, isn’t there? I can’t recall his name?’

Jonas pales. ‘My father has several wards,’ he finally replies. He stands a full head taller than the monarch, but his shoulders have curled inwards, diminishing his height in a manner I could never have believed possible were I not witnessing it now. ‘I like to consider myself close to them all.’

‘How generous. I’m sure that is exactly what they need – a brother who loves them. I pray they all remain safe when you are in the trials. It would be terrible if anything happened to them.’ The threat is unsubtle, just like the man making it.

Heat surges through my body. If evilness has ever taken on a corporeal form, it is surely standing here, right in front of me. He killed a baby boy, and he's near enough threatening to do the same to Jonas's brother, just because Jonas is standing at my side. How the Gods can allow such a man to rule is beyond me. My teeth grind together but before I snap, the king dips his chin slightly, flashing his most demure of smiles, which fools precisely no one.

'I will let you enjoy the rest of your evening,' he says, with one final glance at me. 'It is time I attend to my more … esteemed guests.'

And with that final insult, he spins on his heel and leaves.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 17

I stay for another hour – long enough to see a stocky bald man with a wiry beard and a tattoo across his scalp guide a swaying Kyor out of the room after fruitlessly trying to make him eat something. More than once, the prince's gaze sweeps across the room and his eyes meet mine before I hastily look away, and each time there's a burning in my chest that's made of anger and hatred, but also something else.

Guilt.

Guilt at the way my eyes grazed across his bare chest before I knew it was the chest I wanted to plant a dagger into. At the way my pulse stuttered when he ran his finger across my palm, or how I let those icy eyes drift into my imagination in ways I would never dare share with anyone. And all that time, he knew who I was. He was toying with me like a cat plays with a mouse until it has broken every bone in its body. Well, he'll find this mouse has sharp teeth. I may be little, but I can still do some damage. Let him underestimate me, let them all underestimate me. Etta doesn't.

Kyor's departure should have given me a reason to relax, and perhaps even enjoy the ball a little – though possibly not as much as Coulter, who, with his new alcohol-infused confidence, took it upon himself to start requesting particular tunes from the musicians. I have no doubt that the sight of me, relaxed and merry, would be enough to make King Korvane's blood boil, and for that reason alone, it would be worth it, but no sooner has the prince left than I get bumped from behind.

'Queenkiller's bitch!' a woman's voice hisses.

As I regain my footing, I spin around, trying to see who spoke and where they went, but the crush of people has swallowed the woman up.

Besides, I'm not sure what I would have done anyway. I should have known that this was what balls would be like. Sometimes a big party really is just a trussed-up hellscape. Devils in stilettos. Still, it's not as though I came here to dance. I came here to win, and sometimes that's knowing when to leave.

'I'm done,' I announce, placing my glass on a nearby table. 'I'll see you all tomorrow.'

'Already?' Jonas's eyebrows rise. 'These things go on for hours.'

'I've already seen enough.'

I offer Benny and Llinos a quick hug, but when I turn to Jonas to do the same, he holds out his arm for me to take instead.

'I'll walk you back,' he offers.

'You don't need to do that.'

'I know, but I want to. Besides, it's a big place. You could easily get lost.'

It's a little patronising, but I don't bother arguing again. Instead, I take his arm, aware of the smirk and eyebrow-waggle Llinos shoots me as we walk away.

Jonas and I are silent as we head back towards the barracks, and though there's a definite tension between us, I can't quite tell if it's the good type or not. After all, the king did just threaten his family because of me. I wouldn't be the slightest bit surprised if this is the moment he tells me that any form of alliance or friendship is off the cards. I'm surprised by how sad this makes me. And not just because of how good he looks tonight.

Having Jonas by my side makes me feel like my mother hasn't been judged wrongly by the entirety of the High Hold. That there are still people on the inside who believe she was innocent. I'd hate to lose that feeling.

When we reach the dining room, I slip my arm out of his and prepare for him to give me his excuses. Not that he needs to. He can make alliances with whoever he likes.

'You should go back,' I tell him. 'I'm fine.'

'Actually, I was going to ward your door. I found a spell before the ball. Thought it might help you sleep a bit better if you knew people couldn't get into your room at night.'

'You can spell?' My gratitude for the sweet gesture is supplanted by complete surprise. When I lived in the High Hold, people always considered spelling to be a lower form of magic. Weaving the residual tendrils that drift through the air is – according to the haughty majority – far

less impressive than channelling magic yourself. It's a reason that my mother's magic was considered lower in some situations, even though it came from Etta herself. Sure, she could grow vines fast enough to strangle a man before he even had a chance to draw a dagger, but she very rarely – if ever – did. She preferred using her knowledge of plants and combining it with spell work.

'My powers took so long to settle that my father thought it was a good idea to learn,' Jonas explains. 'He thought I stopped when my magic came in, but honestly, I find it so useful. I'm surprised more people don't learn to do it. So will you accept my help?'

There's pride and there's stupidity, and while I may have a little of the former, I'm trying to keep the latter to zero.

'Yes, thank you,' I tell him gratefully.

The staircase creaks as we climb up to my room.

'Can I watch?' I ask him. You still have to have the essence of magic within you to weave, and the stronger it is, the better you are. My mother was great at it. It's what made her such a phenomenal healer. She taught me a few minor spells when I was young, but my magic wasn't attuned enough back then, so it's not something I'm going to be able to use. Not until I win the Retterheld and get my powers back, anyway.

Then I'm going to excel at every damn type of magic this world has to offer.

'Sure, though it's not very exciting.'

He pulls a slip of paper out of his pocket and places his hand on my door as he begins muttering hard consonant sounds that smack of tongue and teeth. When the slightest flicker of light flares across the wood, he removes his hand.

'All done,' he says, turning to me. 'Now you and I are the only people who can go in and out.'

I press my hand against the wood, indulging in the slight tickling of magic that crosses my palm.

'Sorry?' I tilt my head as I turn back to look at him. 'Did you just say you gave yourself permission to enter my bedroom? Whenever you want?'

Just as I'd hoped, that bashful hue colours Jonas's cheeks.

'It's because I'm the one who did the ward,' he tells me hastily. 'Obviously, I wasn't going to let myself in. Not unless you invited me in, that is.'

‘And why would I do that?’

It feels good to flirt unashamedly. Particularly after learning I’ve been daydreaming about bloody Kyor since I first saw him. And from the grin that spreads across Jonas’s face, he doesn’t mind either.

‘How’s your hand?’ he asks, taking my wrist and increasing the tension between us tenfold.

‘Sore,’ I admit.

He brushes his thumb just a little way from the cut. ‘And your leg?’

‘You going to stroke there too?’ I tease, still not sure which way I want his answer to go.

‘Not tonight,’ he says softly, leaning forward and kissing me lightly on the cheek. I’m surprised when I feel a definite pang of disappointment. Maybe I’m not ready to be alone with my thoughts just yet. ‘Tomorrow’s going to be a big day. You should get some sleep.’

‘I intend on it,’ I reply. I step into my room and close the door.

A sand bucket, a spelled ward, and angering the king by standing at my side. Jonas Lorathin has grown up well.



GIVEN everything that’s happened over the last twelve hours alone, I’m mentally and physically exhausted. And yet sleep refuses to come. Despite being in the softest bed I’ve lain on in a long time, my mind just can’t switch off, thinking about Kay, Jonas, Kyor, and Llinos and Benny. Not to mention the inauguration of our vows tomorrow. My mind is in a constant whirl.

Like the offering to be considered for the Retterheld, the inauguration requires a gift to the Goddess. Last time, it was tears and prayers. This time it’s blood. Thankfully, nothing more than a pinprick is required to bind your mortal body to the Goddess.

The trials begin once the blood sacrifices have been made, and there’s nothing to stop the first trial from starting the moment the inauguration is over. The thought’s enough to make me nauseous.

Night rolls on as I get lost considering all the fates that may await me, and voices start to drift up from the floors below. The Rettlings are letting their hair down tonight, and the dormitory beneath me is noisy. Some are

drunkenly singing, some are low-level bickering, and some are moaning, having already found themselves in bed with a companion. Whatever the noise, it's all complicit in keeping sleep at bay, which is why, when the moon is well into its westerly traverse, I give up the ghost and get out of bed.

Is it safe? No, but neither is going into the Retterheld unprepared.

Pulling my coat tight around me, I cross the courtyard and cut through the large wooden gates that lead to the battle yard. I've no idea if the armoury's weapons are locked up at night, but it doesn't matter. I only plan on using my own. At least until I push the gates open and step inside.

I stare in awe at the vast space, which is at least three ballrooms long. Only the small entry area under which I stand is under cover. Everything else is open to the elements, with a wall at least thirty feet high blocking the view of what goes on in here from the rest of the palace. Gods, I wouldn't want to be stuck alone in here with Zara, that's for sure. I wouldn't get out alive.

A sense of foreboding settles uncomfortably in my stomach, but I push it aside. She's the one who came off far worse in the scuffle, and if I wanted a sign that Etta's on my side, that should be it. Still, better to check my aim with this new dagger than leave it to chance.

As I'm looking for a suitable target, my eye falls on a weapons cabinet only a few feet away, and I decide a quick look won't hurt.

It's an impressive array of weapons, with swords, axes, spears – and daggers. Gods, the daggers. My heart flutters as I run my hand along the smooth edges of the blades.

Though some of the knives are more ornate than others, the craftsmanship of each one is exquisite, and though every single variation of length and thickness is on display, it's the few more unusual specimens that grab my attention. Several short push daggers with broad bone hilts and stubby blades. Devious tools, they could be easily hidden in waistbands to be drawn quickly for combat when space is limited. My mother did her best to patch up more than one wound from such a weapon when we were living in the fifth ring. Anyone who can wield a decent punch can do some serious damage with one of these. But given that I'm hoping to stay far away from any adversaries, punching won't be an option for me.

I move on to the next specimen – a masterpiece that's double-ended with a punch blade for extra, well, punch. I also wouldn't want to be on the

receiving end of one of these, but that doesn’t stop me from running my hand across the cool metal. That tickle of excitement grows stronger. Whether I plan on using it or not, I can’t resist seeing what it feels like to hold. Wrapping my fingers around the central hilt, I lift it.

‘Let me guess. You’re wondering which one of those is going to be the one that kills you,’ a male voice drawls.

Ice fills my veins.

Kyor is here, with an array of weapons at his fingertips.

And this time, there’s no fire bead to save me.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 18

How fucking stupid could I be? Why did I think that wandering around in the dead of night was a good idea?

Kyor is standing only a few feet away and still wearing his shirt from the ball, though now it's entirely undone, revealing even more of those circular tattoos. I seriously consider trying to stab him, and my hand squeezes the hilt as blood thrums behind my ears. One quick swing of my wrist and, if the Gods are on my side, he will finally get what he deserves. At the thought of the Gods, Oel's name rings through my mind. As the God of Order and Logic, he would likely tell me that, logically, me killing the prince like this would not be the best idea. Besides, like Kyor, I don't want to risk Etta's disfavour by starting something outside of the trials. If he dies in them … well, that's a death I'm not going to waste tears on. But stabbing him now while he's clearly drunk? No. No matter what he did, I won't stoop to his level.

'I'm surprised to see you up,' I scoff, trying to swallow my fear. 'I thought you'd been sent to bed for the evening? Told off for your inappropriate behaviour?'

He scoffs. 'If you think that's me being inappropriate, then you've got a lot to learn.' The way his lips quirk, it's clear he's toying with me.

He takes a half step towards me, letting his eyes trail down my body, only for them to stop at my thighs. A frown mars his forehead. 'That dagger.' He nods his head to it. 'Where is it from? That's not one of ours.' His tone is censorious, and I hear the undertone of '*where did you steal it from?*'

‘It’s mine,’ I bite back and purposely hold my tongue from explaining further. I don’t need to justify my belongings.

Rather than responding, he turns towards the weapons and runs his hand across the metal in a manner that’s remarkably similar to how I was caressing them only a few moments ago.

‘There should be another knife here.’ He strokes a gap. ‘A two-inch blade with a hammered metal hilt that has bone inlay. Great for holding between your knuckles. No one has permission to take these – not unless Zelle says so – but someone’s taken it. And another one there.’ He points lower in the cabinet, to where swords hang in a frame. It doesn’t look like there’s anything missing to me, but when he slides a panel across slightly, he reveals more than enough room for another weapon. ‘A seax. Twenty inches. Three hundred years old. Leather grip. It was replaced less than six months ago, and it was here yesterday.’

I have to say, I’m impressed. From the slight slur to his tone, it’s fair to assume he’s still drunk, and yet he can remember all that detail. Or maybe impressed isn’t the right word. Maybe angry is.

‘Funny …’ I tilt my head. ‘You can remember all that, and yet you immediately forgot your mother crying out and begging mine to save your younger brother and *not* her.’

His eyes jolt up from the swords, and the next thing I know, my back slams into the wall of the cabinet, his hand around my throat and the blade that was in my hand drops to the ground in the shock. The blunt edges of the weapons in the rack press into my spine as his eyes meet mine with so much fire it almost obscures their iciness.

‘Don’t.’ His hand remains on my throat with constant pressure. Enough to hold me in place but not choke me. In fact, there’s more than enough freedom for me to reach down and grab the dagger strapped to my thigh. I move slowly, not wanting to alert him. My fingers find the cool metal easily and it takes all my willpower not to simply whip it out. Given that he moved faster than I even thought possible when he pinned me here, I have to take my time and do this right. If I don’t, it might be the last thing I do.

Slowly, my fingers curl around the copper. Only when I’m sure my grip is completely secure do I unsheathe it. My eyes remain unblinking on Kyor’s as I slowly bend my elbow and twist my wrist, pointing the tip of the blade upwards. Do I want him dead? With every fibre in my body. But do I want to kill him like this? No. But only because I think that would limit

my chance of winning the gifting. And then there's the slight issue that I would've murdered the heir to the throne. But as maiming him would likely come with the same consequences, there seems little point in holding back.

When he speaks, his voice is brisk, calm, and instructional. 'If you're going for the heart, don't go for the centre. You'll hit the sternum and the bone's too thick there. Go to the left, between the ribs. That's the best shot.'

My breath stalls and my entire body braces. He knows. He knows I've got the dagger in my hand. I try to swallow, to think of something I can say or do. A way to distract him. A way to get out of this alive. But there's nothing. He's got dozens of weapons within his reach. Or maybe he'll choose to simply tighten his grip around my throat or use whatever magic he has to end me. Yet he merely continues to stand there. Waiting.

Is he trying to goad me so he can be justified in killing me?

'Aim to the left a little more,' he continues. 'That's the side of the heart that pumps all the blood to your body. I mean, sure, if you hit the right side, my lungs are going to fill with blood and it's going to be a less-than-pleasant ending, but you should always aim for the left.'

I don't respond.

'Rose doesn't feel like the right name for you. You're much too prickly to be a Rose. Too sharp. Thorn. Yes … Thorn fits you perfectly. Your parents should have named you Thorn.'

Blood rushes to my ears, and before I've even drawn breath, I've raised the dagger and pressed it against his chest. Just to the left of his sternum, where he instructed. I can even feel the dip between the ribs.

'You don't get to mention them,' I spit, the words sharp and fast. 'Your lie ruined us and killed them both.'

'Then take your vengeance,' he spits out. 'I'm not stopping you. Come on, Thorn. Do it. You want me dead, so fucking own it.'

I push the hilt in slightly, just enough to pierce the skin, but I don't go any further. He's right, I do want him dead. But I also don't want the consequences. I'd accept a public execution, but … Kay. I came here to better her life. There's no chance of that happening if I'm dead, slaughtered for killing the king's heir.

'Let go of me,' I hiss. 'Let go of me, and I won't kill you.'

This time, I see his smirk in full form. It's infuriatingly attractive given that he is pure evil. 'What makes you think I won't kill you instead?'

‘Etta,’ I say simply. ‘Either we both leave here tonight, or neither of us does.’

‘You sound pretty confident for someone with no magic.’

‘I am,’ I lie.

‘I’m looking forward to seeing how that confidence holds up with five chances to die, Thorn. One each moon cycle.’

A question I’ve already asked myself rears its head once more. What the hell does Kyor need the gifting for? He’s the prince and the entirety of Morathka will one day be his. Wrohelm, Rowell, Dorain, Galreck, the Eastern Isles – all of it. And it’s not as though he’ll suffer any consequences if he kills me. He could end this now and carry on his life without a second thought. And yet, his grip loosens. A moment later, he steps back from me and turns around.

‘If you know who stole the blades from here, tell them to put them back,’ he calls as he strides away without so much as a glance over his shoulder. Only when the gates to the battle yard swing shut do I drop to my knees and let out the deepest sigh of my life.

What the fuck just happened? I’m alive. That’s what happened. For the second time since I arrived here, I’m alive when I really don’t think I should be. I just hope this Gods-blessed luck lasts long enough to get me through the trials, too.



MY FACE ITCHES, unused to the ink now painted across my skin. Unlike the initial offering and the balls, Rettlings are expected to attend the inauguration in full fighting attire. That means furs, weapons, and, last but not least, our battle sigils. Just like all the other Morathkian Rettlings, mine consists of the symbols of my hometown and my fealty Gods, and while I might not have Wrohelm tattoos, it feels wrong not to place the blue concentric circles on my cheeks.

It’s been over a decade since I’ve attempted to draw my sigils, and my rings of Wrohelm are decidedly wonky.

‘Gods, I hope I’m getting this right,’ I mutter, taking the blue dye and marking my fealty Gods next. A spiral above my brow line for Etta – for all life is centred on her – and beneath the circles of Wrohelm, a single line and

inverted triangle made of six solid blue dots for Aitara, the Mother of Gods, in honour of my own.

As I try to steady my hand, memories of my parents arise. My mother always marked my skin, but my father did hers. Not because he was better at it, but as a gesture of partnership. A sign that he was as devoted to her Gods as he was to his own. I take the pain of that memory and let it burn through me, doing all I can to transform it into anger. I'm going to let this drive me, push me through the inauguration and whatever it involves. I *will* get through this.

My eyes sweep around me as I enter the battle yard. My fighting leathers are black to show my fealty to Wrohelm, the Dorainians are in navy blue, the Rowells in blood red, the Galreckians in emerald green, and the Eastern Islanders in royal purple.

Clusters have formed: knights in their maroon red in one group, and then five smaller splinter groups of nobles gathered in their city colours. Despite the seemingly city-based solidarity, I know I won't be welcomed in the Wrohelm cohort, so I make my way over to the groups of islanders. My hair already marks me as an outcast, so wearing black among a sea of purple is nothing to me.

'My little sister Carys told me all about the Sunken Temple before we came. She did a tonne of research,' Llinos is saying as I join the group, 'especially about the blood vow. One year, every Rettling had to fill an entire cup with their blood.'

'That can't be true,' Coulter replies before adding worriedly, 'Can it?'

'No,' Benny says firmly. 'Carys was just winding Llin up. Ninety percent of the time it's been a slice to the palm.'

I had plenty for breakfast, but I've also placed a couple of pastries in a cloth bag that's slung over my shoulder. I guess old habits die hard, although now I'm grateful I did. If they do take a cup's worth of blood, some sugar will speed up my recovery.

'And the other ten percent?' I ask, only for Benny to suffer from a sudden lapse of hearing.

'Nice blade,' he compliments Jai instead.

The boulder-esque man shrugs as he glances down at his belt, where several blades are sheathed. The one Benny is talking about has only the hilt visible: hammered metal with bone inlay. Something twists uncomfortably inside me, but then again, I'm sure it's just a common design.

‘Got it on the boat over,’ Jai grunts in response.

I don’t press him. I need allies, and I’m not losing them on the prince’s say-so. Kyor could be lying. After all, he might have spotted the blade on Jai’s hip and made the whole thing up. Yet there’s still a heavy stone in my gut.

‘Carriages are coming up from the sixth ring now,’ Loch tells us. ‘Lots of them. I suppose that’s how we’re getting to the Sunken Temple.’

The sixth ring? The fact that Loch can hear that is both impressive and terrifying. I wonder if he could hear it because he was specifically listening for it, or whether he can just hear that far away. If that’s the case, it must be torture at times.

I look over at the other clusters of Rettlings. Thankfully, the Rowell group is a fair distance away from us, and there’s no sign of Kyor yet – though I hate myself for looking – but there’s one person on her own who catches my eye.

‘Estel!’ I lift my hands as I call her name. When she’s looking in my direction, I wave her over before glancing at Benny.

‘You don’t mind, do you?’

‘More the merrier,’ he replies easily. ‘At this stage anyway.’

‘Hey,’ I say, stretching out my hand as she reaches us. ‘I’m Rose. Thought you might want to ride over with us.’

Her eyes narrow. ‘I don’t need your sympathy. I’m not like you. I have powers.’

The remark stings more than I expected. ‘You may have powers, but apparently you don’t have any manners,’ I respond sharply.

Her lips purse. ‘You’re right. I’m sorry. Long night bunking with a crazy woman from Dorain. Thank you for the offer.’

There’s no general chitchat or offer of polite conversation, and I’m just starting to regret my decision to invite Estel to join us, when Jonas approaches. While everyone else looks at least a bit haggard – either from too much drink, not enough sleep, or a combination of both – Jonas is sporting a perfectly fresh face. His mane of hair is tied back in a knot on the top of his head, while his eyes glimmer like he’s never been more well-rested.

‘It’s eight people to a carriage,’ he tells us. He notices Estel and offers her a nod. ‘You’re joining us?’ he questions her.

Benny doesn’t miss a beat before he replies, ‘Us? I assume that means you’re happy to work with us, Jonas?’

The two men observe each other for a beat longer than would be considered normal.

‘To start with,’ Jonas replies breezily.

‘Obviously,’ Benny drawls.

It’s a little while longer until the wide gates at the back of the yard open, and a stream of horse-drawn carriages files into the courtyard. All made of the same deep, stained wood, the carriages look incredibly claustrophobic, and I’m not even inside yet. It doesn’t bode well. Before I have time for panic to sink in, Llinos sidles up beside me.

‘So what happened with you two last night?’ she asks with a slight gesture to Jonas.

‘What? Oh nothing,’ I reply. ‘Well, he warded my room, but that’s it.’ It’s only then that I remember the way Jonas’s thumb brushed against the skin by my cut and how he kissed my cheek. It was as though the incident with Kyor this morning had pushed him entirely from my mind. Not that I plan on telling Llinos about that either.

‘He didn’t come back to the ball. Not while we were still there,’ Llinos presses as if she’s sure I’m lying.

‘Then he probably went to bed. On his own,’ I stress.

A moment later, a carriage draws up beside us. It’s the only carriage with jet-black horses, and for reasons I can’t explain, my eyes gravitate to the top of the wall beside me. The skin on the back of my neck prickles, and some part of me already knows what I’m going to see.

Sure enough, a single raven sits at eye height, its beady gaze narrowed directly on me. Maybe that’s just the way their eyes are, always looking like they’re staring at you. Like those portraits where the subject’s gaze follows you around the room. That’s all it is. That’s all it can be. Yet despite my valid reasoning, a hollowness forms in the pit of my stomach.

With a shake of my head, I move towards the carriage to climb in next to Coulter and Jai, who are already on board.

It’s not an omen. It’s just a bird. It doesn’t mean anything.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 19

The carriage door clicks closed, and a moment later, we jolt forward. There are no windows and no way to see out, save for a thin crack around the door that lets a sliver of light through and an open skylight. I fix my eyes on the sky above, watching it turn from blue to grey.

'Remember, it doesn't matter how much blood you give at the blood vow,' Jonas says as the horses' footsteps clatter on the paving stones. 'It's just to seal your participation in the trials.'

'Yeah, we were talking about it before you turned up,' Llinos tells him.

'Right, of course, but Rose,' he continues directly to me, 'if the cut is on your hand and you get to choose which hand to bleed, it's probably best if you use the one that's already injured rather than opening up a new wound.'

'Yeah, I figured,' I say.

I push the exasperation down. It's sweet that he's worried about me, but I'm not stupid.

'Also, several years ago, one of the trials took place in the Sunken Temple,' Jonas continues. 'So it's worthwhile researching the space while we're there for the vow.'

'Which, of course, you already have. I bet you've been there dozens of times,' Jai mutters.

'No one is allowed into the Sunken Temple,' Jonas snaps back. 'Only the priestesses. So no, I haven't.'

'I bet you've studied maps and shit.' Jai folds his arms.

'He's trying to be helpful,' Benny says sharply.

'Well, if he could do it without sounding quite so condescending—'

‘Guys,’ Llinos cuts in. ‘I get that the impending inauguration is making us all nervous, but this is *nothing*. It’s not even a trial. And there’s no way this is scarier than last night. I mean, at least we’re in comfy clothes, right?’

Her attempt at levity fails, and tension rolls through the carriage. And we’ve still got one heck of a journey ahead of us. I’ve heard that several of Etta’s priestesses have powers of portation and can move between locations in an instant, but you’d have to have an insane amount of strength to move all the Rettlings.

‘You show fealty to Etta, too,’ I say, noting the spiral marks on Llinos’s face, although the two lines – one wavy, one straight – above her brow mark her main God as Niairah, the Goddess of Air and Fire. Fitting, considering her gift as a wind-wielder. I wonder who Kyor’s Gods are, though I’d bet a pint of blood the Goddess Yordenrin is there. That man has chaos written all over him.

‘My aunt is a priestess of Etta’s,’ Llinos tells me. ‘So we’ve strong family ties to the Goddess.’

‘My mother was raised by a priestess when she was abandoned in the slums,’ I reply, surprisingly grateful we have yet more to bond over. It’s been a long time since I’ve found myself wanting to form friendships, and given that we’re in direct competition, forming one with Llinos probably isn’t the wisest thing to do, but I don’t think I could end our burgeoning friendship even if I should. I need it too much, and I think she does too.

‘Sorry, not to be rude, but if your mother was abandoned in the slums, how were you a noble?’ Benny joins in the conversation.

‘My father,’ I explain. ‘He was a noble.’

‘Barely.’

The word is muttered under her breath, but it’s loud enough to ensure all eyes fall on Estel. I’m really starting to regret my decision to invite her to join us. She clearly has a very large rod up her arse.

Everyone’s questioning gazes return to me, and I’m not sure why I’m hesitant to tell them my father’s story. After all, the fact that they stayed beside me after learning of my connection to the queen’s death tells me these are good people. Still, I suppose it has to come out at some point.

‘He was a bastard,’ I say, ‘born to a woman in the third ring. My grandfather’s actual wife couldn’t have any children, but when my father was nine years old, they could already see how much power he had, and so my grandparents took him in and raised him as their own. There are some in

the High Hold who held that against him …’ I shoot a glare at Estel, though she doesn’t look like she gives a shit.

‘And then he went and married for “love,” which was a surefire way of weakening family lines and screwing with centuries of alliances in the High Hold. Real romantic,’ she scoffs. ‘Not that I suspect a bastard had many allies.’

I grit my teeth and force myself not to reply.

An uncomfortable silence descends, and I catch Benny’s eye. He sends Estel a side-eye accompanied by a jerk of his head that tells me he’d be more than happy to push her out of the carriage if I wanted. With my lips pressed tightly together, I manage to suppress a chuckle, but my spirits lift. Estel may think less of me for my roots, but Benny doesn’t give a shit.

‘So,’ Llinos says, breaking the silence, ‘how about this weather we’re having?’

I’m beginning to really love these islanders.

The longer we’re moving, the more varied the sounds and smells that drift in from outside become, and eventually I recognise the familiar stench of the slum. I’m not the only one who smells it.

‘Gods, how can anyone live in this stench?’ Jonas says in revulsion, only to immediately realise his mistake. ‘Rose, I’m so … I didn’t think. I’m—’

‘It’s fine,’ I say, wishing he wasn’t sitting straight across from me so I could avoid looking at him. I shrug lightly. ‘You get used to it.’

With people now steering clear of the topic of families and previous living situations, conversation moves to the trials. We list all the ones we can remember, including the delightful time the Rettlings were forced to free themselves from underwater chambers before the air ran out, and another trial where they had to catch and hogtie an unbonded dire wolf. Apparently, a record number died that year. Through it all, my gaze constantly flickers upwards to the sky, almost as though I’m expecting another raven to appear. Thankfully, there’s no sign of any. That’s a good thing, right?

Thick clouds are all that’s visible through the skylight when suddenly we are plunged into utter darkness.

‘Well, we’re definitely underground,’ Benny says after the unrelenting darkness has continued for a few minutes.

We must be nearly there.

The Sunken Temple is a place whispered about with reverence, even in the slums. It's shaped like an inverted cone, going hundreds of feet underground, and was carved by the Gods or giants – or so the story goes. Down its sloping marble walls winds a procession of stone steps, descending into shadow, upon which spectators may sit to watch events in the arena. As a holy place, the Sunken Temple is rarely open to the public, but access is granted during the Retterheld. Being here is a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity, and I'd be lying if I said excitement wasn't fizzing in my veins.

From across the carriage, a hand reaches out in the dark and touches my knee.

'You okay?' Jonas's voice echoes.

'I'm good,' I murmur quietly.

'Is it me, or have we been going down for ages?' Coulter asks plaintively. 'Is this right?'

'Of course it's right,' Jai grunts back.

'Not long now,' Loch tells us. 'The front carriages have already stopped.'

Yup, there's no denying it; his power may not look as cool as wielding flames, but it's awesome.

When we finally come to a stop, the carriage doors spring open and a scattering of torchlight breaks the unrelenting darkness. We start to file out, but as I move to stand, Jonas reaches forward and places his hand on my arm.

'Can you give us a minute?' he asks, looking at Benny and Llin.

Benny doesn't reply until he looks at me and I give him a nod to say I'm fine, after which the others squeeze past, and I sit alone with Jonas.

'I'm sorry about what I said earlier. About the slums,' he clarifies.

'You don't have to apologise.'

'I do. It was a flippant remark, and I didn't think about its consequences. And for what it's worth, I'm also sorry about what Estel said. About your father.'

Again, I didn't need the clarification.

'I'm sure she's not the only one who's thought it,' I reply shortly.

'Then they're fools,' he says, laying both his hands on my knees as he looks directly into my eyes. 'Your father was phenomenally powerful. More

powerful than almost every other noble in the High Hold. If they did have a problem with him, it's because they were jealous. I mean that, truly.'

'Thank you. I appreciate that.' I take his hands and squeeze them as I lift them pointedly off my knees. 'Come on. We should get going. We've got places to be.'

I step out of the carriage into a long, narrow tunnel, with torchlights offering the only illumination. The sound of the Rettlings' footsteps bounces off the walls, making it sound as if there are hundreds of us rather than a mere fifty.

A short way ahead, Llinos is waiting for me. 'So did you two kiss and make up? There obviously wasn't time for any more.'

'Sorry to disappoint, but there was no kissing.'

'That *is* disappointing. Nothing like a bit of gossip to distract from a spot of impending doom.'

'You'll have to find another source, I'm afraid,' I say drily, smiling despite myself. The tunnel we're moving through continues to slope down, growing narrower and narrower, and soon it's barely wide enough for us to stand side by side, at which point it turns into a series of steps. Another precarious staircase, and this one in near darkness. Great.

Finally, the steps end at a massive underground cave. Almost three-quarters of the ground is covered by a lake of pale sapphire blue, so still it acts like a mirror, reflecting the stalactites that hang from what must be a hundred feet above. I'm gawping at the sight, I know I am, but I don't care. Korvane's ostentatious chandeliers have nothing on this raw, natural beauty.

'Rettlings, welcome to the Sunken Temple. Now, it is time for a few guidelines to make sure things run smoothly.'

The voice is filled with the tone of command, but annoyingly, I can't see the speaker because the Rettlings who got here first have crammed themselves so tightly around the person that there's barely any room to move. As I search out a better view, I notice an outcrop not too high up on the edge of the wall. The stone is rough, with deep divots that will be perfect for climbing.

'Where are you going?' Llinos whispers as I squeeze past her.

'To get a better view,' I say, pointing to the wall.

She turns back towards the speaker, who is now praising Etta and the other Gods. I'm only half listening, focused instead on choosing the quickest path to take up to the outcrop and ignoring the stinging in my left

hand as I hoist myself up. The instant I take a seat on the ledge, I know I've made a good decision. I've got a much better view up here, and not just of the speaker, but of the Rettlings, too. The knighted guards are still clustered together and easily identifiable by the manner in which they stand. Still, attentive, and confident, it shows their respect for the occasion. Respect not everyone else is displaying.

An older woman is running back and forth to the water's edge, while a younger one tries to stop her with constant hushing noises, which only serve to elicit more attention. As I watch, I recall what Estel said about the crazy woman from Dorain she was sharing a room with. I suspect I've figured out who she was talking about.

By the looks of things, there are several more Rettlings from Dorain with the two women, many rolling their eyes at the older woman's antics, though not as many as the group from Galreck, whose pale faces are all marked with the four vertical lines to represent their city's famous towers.

Zara is still with her goons, Oke and Elenor, and they're joined by Shim and a couple of others. As I take in the Rettlings, I realise I should be listening. Getting distracted during the trials could be deadly. I need to focus.

I look to the speaker and immediately recognise him as the man who tried to help Kyor sober up at the ball.

He looks around sixty, with a grey beard and bald head, yet his frame is still ripped with muscle, and he carries himself with the same sort of gravitas as the knights. I'd bet my supply of seeds from Dinah that he's got a dire wolf somewhere. I allow myself a quick scan to see if it's present, and I'm not sure if I'm relieved or disappointed when I don't spot it. I do spot someone else, though. Kyor.

He's leaning against one of the cavern's jagged walls, staring blankly at the speaker. Hungover, probably. He wears a fur stole across his shoulders and leather fighting trousers, and that's it. The man must not feel the cold. Either that, or his plan is to distract everyone with his physique, which I hate to admit is an annoyingly effective technique. As he stands there, I try to make out the marks of his fealty Gods. I'm sure it's Yordenrin's starburst below his Wrohelm insignia, but I can't decipher the one above his brow bone. What I do know is that the blue dye suits him. The colour glistens against his olive skin, while the crispness of the lines makes his cheekbones look even sharper.

The thought barely forms before he turns and catches my eye. I shift my gaze as fast as I can, but I know I wasn't quick enough. I die a little inside, knowing he saw me ogling him.

'The priestesses alone know what the trials will encompass,' the speaker is saying, 'so while Commander Holden and I will be responsible for your training, we do not know what dangers you will face.'

Holden. The name rings a bell, but I can't immediately place it.

'Thank you, Commander.' The man who must be Holden steps forward to stand beside the speaker. A short man, Holden looks to be of a similar age to what my parents would be if they were still alive. 'Over the course of the Retterheld, we will become better acquainted. Either Zelle or I will be in the yard from dusk till dawn each day, and I would recommend that any of you who want to succeed do the same. Although it must be said that training alone will not be enough to help you survive.'

So the first speaker was Commander Zelle. He's rumoured to be good friends with Prince Kyor, which immediately makes me distrust his judgement.

'After the vows, you will be transported back to the palace.' Zelle takes over again. 'And I would urge you to remember that while each of you here has been blessed by Etta, the Goddess can strip you of that blessing just as quickly as she gave it. So tread carefully.' The way he enunciates his words, like he's issuing a personal threat to us all, causes a chill to roll through the courtyard. 'You will be called one by one today to give your blood in the manner chosen by the priestesses. You do *not* speak. Not before, not during, not after. Not a single word.'

He pauses again, and tension swells through me. 'Does anybody know the punishment for speaking in the Sunken Temple?'

As the hair rises on the back of my neck, I don't doubt that every single person here knows *exactly* what he's talking about. The Sunken Temple is not just a temple of Etta. It is sacred to *all* the Gods, and only the priestesses may converse in this sacred space.

'We're not in the temple itself yet,' Zelle reassures when he realises volunteers aren't forthcoming. Even the young woman from Dorain has ceased hushing her older companion. 'You can bet my life I wouldn't be speaking if we were. Now, someone tell me, what's the punishment?'

Slowly, a shaking hand rises into the air. Coulter.

'You have your lips bound together?' His voice trembles.

‘Yes,’ Zelle replies. ‘For how long?’

‘One stitch and twelve moons of imprisonment for every word spoken.’ It’s a knight who answers this time, and I’m pretty sure it’s Grenda, the one Jonas told us was a serious contender.

‘Good.’ Zelle scans the crowd, nodding. ‘A stitch and a year for every word you speak. So keep your mouths shut in there. Or if you *must* say something, you’d better make it good, because those words may well be your last.’

I can feel the nerves ripple through the space. Coulter is physically trembling, and it’s not the kind of clenched-fist tremble you can keep to yourself. His knees are jerking up and down, and from where I’m perched, it looks like his skin has taken on a greenish hue. Llinos places her hand on his arm and whispers something comforting in his ear.

‘Any questions?’ Holden barks.

I assume the question is rhetorical, and yet one hand shoots into the air: Zara’s.

‘Why aren’t you two in the Retterheld?’ she says. ‘You’d be eligible. Did she turn down your offering?’

A collective gasp echoes at her gall, but while Holden’s face flashes with fury, Zelle offers a smile in response.

‘From my experience,’ he says, ‘one who cannot find happiness within the gifts they have already been given will struggle to be satisfied by more. Now, unless there’s a question that actually has a purpose, let’s get that blood drawn.’

A couple of hushed whispers pass between a few of the Rettlings as my mind ponders what Zelle said. By his reasoning, I’m the only one this gifting will truly benefit. Maybe I *should* trust his judgement after all.

As silence takes hold of the group, I twist around and carefully make my way back down the cave wall. When I reach the ground, I immediately look for the group from my carriage, wanting their moral support. Excluding Estel, that is.

After spotting Llinos in the crowd, I make a beeline for her, only to find my path blocked. Not by a Rettling, but by Commander Holden himself, the scowl still very much in place. Seeing him up close, I realise he’s not quite as short as I originally assumed; Zelle must just be exceptionally tall.

‘Of course, I should’ve known a Kultavaris wouldn’t be able to just stand and listen like everybody else.’

‘You knew my parents?’ I ask, surprised by my own forthrightness.

Holden scoffs and his features contort as though he’s swallowed something impossibly bitter. ‘To think, the Goddess chose the offspring of the bastard lord and his witch wife over, over …’

‘Over you?’ I suggest.

A snarl rattles from his lips. Animosity from the other Rettlings I expected, but from one of the people in charge of training us? That’s something I wasn’t prepared for. Jonas’s words about the only people having problems with my father being those who were jealous of his powers swim around my head. Well, I can’t say for certain, but I’m pretty sure this interaction is telling me that Holden was seriously jealous.

‘Holden.’ Zelle’s voice echoes in the cave. ‘Time to move.’

Holden bites down on his lip as he stares at me.

‘Plenty of Rettlings don’t make it out of the trials,’ he finally says, his voice almost a hiss. ‘I’ve even heard of one or two not making it through the vowing. I’ll be keeping my fingers crossed for you.’

What a delightful human, I think sarcastically as he turns on the ball of his foot and strides away.

‘What was that about?’ Jonas asks, appearing at my side.

‘Oh, nothing at all,’ I say, watching Holden march away. ‘Just another person who wants to see me dead, that’s all. Come on, we should go.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 20

As we enter the temple itself, an unexpected blast of light causes me to squint. When the shock and pain fade, my eyes open and gravitate upwards, to the tiers of white marble seating that stretch upwards to the pale blue sky. It's unlike any holy sanctum I've been in before. There are no altars. No candles set around the edges. Instead, sand covers the ground of the perfectly circular space where only a single raised platform sits in the middle, topped by a marble font glistening with water. A line of priestesses stands behind the dais, all in their ceremonial robes with blue stones embedded in their foreheads. My heart clenches. If only Dinah were among them.

We file in and stand around the dais, and once we're all in place, a priestess holds up a hand to signal the others. As one, the priestesses around the dais stamp their feet, and in the echoing boom, King Korvane and other courtiers appear in the lowermost marble seats.

Portation, I think as my mouth dries.

Another beat, another choral stamp, and another level of seats is filled.

The Rettlings watch agog as, stamp by stamp, the noble spectators are brought in, dressed in their finery. They, too, must have been warned about the need for silence, for despite the pageantry, no one dares to speak.

The tension grows heavy as the stands fill in eerie silence, and the weight of the assemblage's stares crushes us.

When the stands are finally full, a single priestess steps forward. My gaze swings to her, and my vision tunnels, my veins fill with ice, and my knees struggle to keep me upright.

With Dinah unable to attend, I did not expect to recognise any of the priestesses present today. And yet I do. Mila, the one who took our powers. The knowledge is enough to set my head swirling.

‘People of Morathka,’ she begins. Her voice is resonant, yet I can barely hear her over the blood that rushes behind my ears. Desperately trying to brush off the remembered agony of having my magic stripped by this very woman, all I can do is breathe and try to ground myself in the here and now.

Her forehead stone is different from those of the other priestesses – an amethyst purple rather than pale sapphire blue. So Mila is the High Priestess now. I wonder if she profited from our stripping, if our magic bought her that purple stone?

‘We have come today to take the blood offering of the Retterheld,’ she continues. ‘Before you stand our Rettlings, those the Great Goddess Etta has chosen to compete for the greatest reward of all: the gifting. Only one here will be granted this almighty blessing. By their presence, they were judged worthy. Whether they *remain* worthy, we shall now see.’

What? I turn to my side. Llinos’s wide eyes reflect my own thoughts exactly. What the hell?

A surge of fear sweeps through the Rettlings, but in our enforced silence, there is no opportunity to react. No one speaks, though several sniffs echo their way to my ears. Coulter. Coulter is crying. I catch his eye and reach out to give his hand a squeeze. I want to tell him it’ll be all right – mouth the words at least – but I can’t risk a sound escaping from my lips. Not here. And so all I can do is offer a smile.

He nods and tries to reciprocate but manages only a grimace. While his shaking continues, the High Priestess calls the first name. ‘Baylis Airlan,’ she says.

With his head held high, one of the knights walks forward.

‘Take your place.’ She points to the dais and he is followed up by two priestesses. ‘Baylis Airlan, kneel and pray as the Goddess demands.’

This is *not* what I expected. I thought it would be a hands-out, palm-cut scenario. And I’m sure that’s what the others thought as well.

The priestesses whisper something into Airlan’s ear and he leans forward, arms stretched out in front of him, palms down.

‘Baylis Airlan, you have offered your tears. Now you will offer your blood. May Etta accept it, or may the consequences be just.’

She raises a dagger and then plunges it straight through the back of his hand. His body tenses, and a collective gasp rattles the air around us. But while my chest lurches, it's not the pooling blood that has my attention. It's the dagger in the priestess's hands.

It reflects the light almost as if it is luminous, the hilt copper and the blade two-toned. It's exactly the same as the one Dinah gave me.

As I force myself to swallow the lump in my throat, I glance across the other Rettlings, only to see that one has his gaze fixed straight on me. Kyor. He saw it too. And now I'd bet my already vulnerable life that he's wondering, like me, what the fuck I'm doing with the dagger's twin in my possession?

As Baylis Airlan descends from the dais, my eyes stay focused on the knight's hand. I saw the blade disappear behind his knuckles, heard the crunch of the bone, and saw the blood dripping from the blade of the dagger as it was removed. A wound like that should require urgent attention, but the cut isn't even bleeding.

So is the knife imbued with magic? Magic that limits how much damage it can do? That certainly feels possible. But if that's the case, then Dinah's gift is close to useless. A knife that can't kill, that would only mildly aggravate a person, isn't exactly ideal.

When the next name is called, the Rettling is substantially more apprehensive, which is unsurprising given what we just saw. They flinch as the cleaned blade is impaled into the back of their hand, then gasp with relief as it's pulled out. No words, just sounds. With that, they're walking back to their place, and the next name is called.

I watch the Rettlings ascend the dais one by one, trying to ignore the pounding in my chest. It doesn't help that I constantly find my attention back on Kyor. From here, I can see the marks for his fealty Gods with perfect clarity. Yordenrin and Niairah. I was right about the chaos then, and Niairah is hardly a surprise, given he's probably a fire wielder like his father.

I don't know what's wrong with me. I don't feel the same need to look at Jonas or Benny, but then maybe that's because I don't fear what they might do to me.

I'm only able to forget about Kyor entirely when the first of our allies is called up. Loch.

His pace is quick, almost a near sprint over to the priestess. Unlike with Baylis, when the blade is removed, a fair amount of blood streams from his hand – enough to cause droplets to fall into the sand as he rushes back to his place – and then Jai is called next.

I can't help but notice the possibly stolen dagger still protruding from Jai's weapons belt, and I wonder if Kyor's seen it too. He would know for certain if it is indeed the missing one.

As Jai takes his place with arms extended, she recites the standard line. 'Jai Den, you have offered your tears. Now you will offer your blood. May Etta accept it or may the consequences be just.'

The knife plunges into the back of Jai's hand, but when it's removed and Jai stands, there is a slight wobble to his frame. It could just be due to his size, of course. He's a big man and was near enough lying on the ground, but as he takes his first step off the dais, I notice the cut on his hand. While the other Rettlings' wounds varied from a deep gash to a mere scratch, Jai's hand is streaming with a torrent of blood, colouring his fingers, his nails, and even his trousers. It pours like a river, staining the sand beneath his feet.

I thought the magic was supposed to *limit* the damage, yet blood is rushing from him so fast that his face is paling. With one hand covering my mouth, I reach out for Llinos with the other. But she's not looking at me. She's not even looking at Jai. Instead, her gaze is locked on Coulter, who is watching his idol with abject horror.

The young Rettling's eyes are red with tears, his whole body shaking as he bites down on his knuckles, low whimpers escaping from his mouth like a wounded animal.

Jai is still moving, staggering slowly towards us, towards Coulter. But every step he makes is a stumble, a sway that knocks him more and more off balance. He's still walking … until he's not. Sand billows up from the ground as he falls to his knees. His glassy eyes meet his protégé's for a heartbeat before he drops face-down to the ground.

'No!' Coulter screams. That single word is all it takes, and he knows it.

His hands fly up to his mouth as he shakes his head repeatedly. But it's too late. Two priestesses move in to grab him, eyes flashing with fury.

'Please, no …' he says, eyes wide with panic as they grab him by the wrists and drag him through the trail of blood left by his friend.

Three words. Three stitches. Three years.

Shut up, Coulter!

He'll still be young when he's free if he just stops now.

He doesn't stop. 'I didn't mean to disrespect them! I didn't! I didn't! Please believe me!'

Pain sears through my chest. How many words was that? My mind can't keep a tally. More than ten, surely. Fifteen? Twenty? I feel sick. Twenty years? That's more years than he's been alive.

He doesn't deserve this. I want to run to him and clasp my hand around his mouth. Or to scream out at him to shut the fuck up. But I can't. None of us can.

Not unless we want to share the same fate.

I press my lips together as a tear slides down my cheek. I hear a soft, pained sound next to me and I reach again. This time my hand finds Llinos's, though I don't look at her. I don't need to. I know she'll be crying too. Tears of impotence and fury. It's *wrong*.

I've seen plenty of dead bodies during my years in the slums – killed by sickness or starvation, or murdered for not paying what's owed to someone like Rula – but hollow eyes and lifeless lips never fail to evoke the same sense of sickness, especially when they belonged to someone you knew.

Guilt strikes, hot and thick, and I choke on it. What if the Goddess decided it was Jai's time to meet Mortidem because he stole the blade? Kyor told me to tell the thief to return it, but I didn't. If I had, if Jai had returned it, would he be standing beside me now? No, there had to be more to his death than simply theft, or else surely Zara would have been struck down too. She *killed* Rettlings, yet from what I could see, she had no issues when the blade impaled her hand.

I look again at the priestess's dagger. I now have no doubt that it holds magic.

My grip on Llinos remains unwavering, as does hers on me, the pair of us offering the only support we can.

To die like Jai just did, with no chance of even fighting back and surrounded by people watching on in stunned silence, doesn't feel right. None of this feels right.

In a daze, I watch Kyor take to the dais. The ritual is completed without issue and Kyor returns to his place, a thin trickle of blood weaving its way down his wrist. My gaze meets his for just a second before it's torn away by the calling of another name.

Mine.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 21

Jai's body is still on the ground, face down in the sand.

I would have rather died by Zara's hands than like that. *Please, Etta, don't let me die in this place.* I keep the words in my head, where only the Gods and I can hear.

The drumming in my chest and ears drowns out the sound of my footsteps as I take my place upon the dais.

Her eyes glitter with recognition, but the High Priestess's words are lost to me. I already know her instructions, so I kneel, arms outstretched, jaw clenched, breath held. An instant later, the tip of the dagger pierces the top of my hand – the uninjured one.

As the blade is plunged all the way through my flesh, I wait for the pain to hit, for the reality of the wound to sink in, but there's nothing.

Even as I feel the knife withdraw, it's little more than a sting.

The priestess dismisses me, and I stand, turning to walk back to my place. There's no light-headedness, certainly no gushing of blood, and my feet are as steady on the sand as they were when I walked up. Probably more so, given that my knees are no longer trembling.

I'm in.

Really in.

Etta has accepted me twice, and now there's nothing between me and the gifting – except the other Rettlings and the five trials, that is. A flurry of hope flitters through me, and for the first time, I lift my gaze to the spectators gathered within the Sunken Temple.

Tiers upon tiers of people stretch upwards, rising like a mountainside. There must be a thousand, if not more, and yet out of all the people there,

my eyes fall on one face.

She's seated in one of the lowest levels, close to the action, her hand covering her mouth. Her white-blonde hair is no longer dulled from the grime of the slums, but clean and blindingly bright.

Kay.

Any pain left in my body evaporates. I don't know how she's here. Or if she really is. Perhaps I'm hallucinating? Could this be a trick of the dagger? Or a blessing from Etta? Right now, I'll take either.

I smile at her, and she drops her hand from her mouth and beams back, her fingers toying with Mother's ring, spinning it on her finger in a sure sign of stress. It's loose, but she is somehow dressed in finery like any other courtier, and if she's here with Lord Lorathin – as I desperately hope – then she must be being fed well. Perhaps the ring won't spin so easily soon.

Kay is here, and I can hardly believe it. I struggle to focus on the rest of the vows, but I force myself to do so. At the very least, I can bear witness.

Two other Rettlings die the same way as Jai: the young woman from Wrohelm called Pen, whose touch blisters, and Orwen, a knight. It's hard to understand why the Goddess accepted the offering of their tears, only to now find them unworthy. Maybe it was just a numbers game. Who knows?

When the last Rettling is inaugurated, the priestesses stamp their feet in unison, and *all* of the spectators vanish as one. I can't even begin to imagine the kind of power it takes to undertake a portation on that level, but as a number of priestesses sway and drop where they stand, I know it took a lot.

I didn't even get a chance to speak to Kay or wave goodbye to her, but it doesn't matter. She is safe. That's all that matters.

I'm grateful when Estel chooses another carriage to ride back in, though it doesn't change the silence that consumes ours. When Benny finally breaks it, I wish he hadn't.

'I never expected to lose Jai first,' he says quietly.

'Death was expected. Coulter's fate was not,' Loch responds. 'Was it fifteen or seventeen? Did anyone count?'

'I'm not sure,' Jonas says. 'It depends if they count the contractions as one word or two.'

My eyes remain trained on my feet, and silence swells again. Death may have been an expected part of this process, but none of us imagined it would come so soon to someone like Jai.

Finally, Benny sighs. ‘He’s nineteen. He’ll see it through, and when he comes out of the Sunken Temple, we’ll be waiting for him. Waiting to give him the life he truly deserves. I promise you that.’

I don’t raise my head to see if anyone nods in agreement or even see if Benny really believes what he’s saying. There’s only one thing I’m sure of now: when Coulter finally gets out of there, he won’t be the same person we knew.

It’s only when the sunlight starts filtering through the skylight in the carriage that I notice Jonas’s hand is on my knee. I’ve no idea when he put it there, but I don’t bother moving it away, even as I lean my head against Llinos’s shoulders and shut my eyes. Sleep doesn’t come, but Kay’s image does, and that’s the best I can hope for.



‘WE SHOULD GO TO THE HEALERS,’ Jonas says hours later when we arrive back at the High Hold. ‘I heard Zelle and Holden telling people to head straight there to tend their wounds. How’s yours?’ he adds to me.

‘Fine,’ I reply truthfully. ‘It didn’t hurt. Not really.’

I glance down at the faint line on the back of my hand. Somehow, it’s healed more than the one Zara reopened on my palm.

‘What the hell?’ Jonas’s eyes widen as he twists around to the others. ‘What do yours look like?’

Benny and Llinos stretch out their hands, revealing ugly red marks. They might not be bleeding, but they certainly don’t look like mine.

‘It’s just luck,’ I say quietly. ‘Some people bled, some people didn’t.’

‘I’m not sure anything in this place is luck,’ Loch replies, staring at the carriage wall. No one speaks again until the horses draw to a stop.

As the others clamber out of the carriage and into the battle yard, all planning on heading to the healers as instructed, I brush my hand against Jonas’s arm.

‘I want to go to the library,’ I tell him, lowering my voice, keen not to be overheard. ‘Is there a way in through this arc?’ Back when I lived in the eastern arc, you could access the library through the basement, and I’m hoping it’s the same here.

‘The library?’ he questions.

‘I just want some books to read.’ I shrug. ‘It’s been a while.’

It’s only half a lie. I definitely plan on finding some reading material while I’m down there, but mainly, I want to see what I can find on my priestess-gifted dagger. Until I know how the blade works, I’m not sure I can risk using it. And as the only times the Rettlings are supposed to leave the barracks are for balls or trials, I need a direct route that will allow me to get to the library unseen.

‘The other arcs all have routes down from the lower floors,’ Jonas replies, chewing on his bottom lip as he contemplates my question. ‘So if there is, I assume it would be the same here?’

He doesn’t know any more than I do. I sigh internally. I’ll have to look for myself.

‘You want me to come with you?’ Jonas asks, but the question is half-hearted at best.

I shake my head. ‘No, it’s fine. You need to go to the healers. Besides, I could do with some space.’

‘I get it.’ From the way his eyes soften, he’s telling the truth. ‘See you later?’

‘Sure.’

He leans forward and kisses me lightly on the cheek. When he moves back, his eyes lock on mine. ‘I know this is going to be tough, Rose, and I still don’t understand what Etta was thinking, letting you into this, but I’m glad you’re here.’

It’s only as Jonas heads to the healers that his words sink in. He doesn’t understand what Etta was thinking – shorthand for: he thinks I’m going to get myself killed. It’s not exactly a vote of confidence. Still, I don’t have time to worry about that now. Instead, I turn on my heel and make my way down into the lower floors.

The kitchen is the only place I’ve been downstairs, so I figure that’s as good a place as any to start. Even if there isn’t access, hopefully the staff will be able to point me in the right direction.

As I take the stairs down from the dining hall, the clatter of pots and pans, and the scent of roasting meats, weave their way up to me, and I already know I’m going to find the place far more alive than the night before. I’ve just reached the bottom steps when a laugh catches me by surprise. It’s a young man’s laugh, low and resonant yet also warm and

frivolous. It feels so at odds with the day I've had, but so unbelievably needed. Like fresh air after all those years in the slums.

For a heartbeat I stand there, absorbing the sound, as if it could block out all the pain of the day, but when it stops, I blink myself back to reality and take another step forward into a cluster of women dressed in brown smocks, busy at work. The man, who I assume was the owner of the laugh, is sitting on a table with his back to me.

With a sudden sense of nervousness, I clear my throat, and several pairs of eyes turn to me. All questioning. Some fearful.

'Sorry.' I swallow the lump that has filled my throat. 'I wondered if you could help me?'

'Rettlings aren't supposed to be down here.' The woman who speaks is shorter than me, with honey-blonde hair and round eyes. 'Food's served in an hour. You'll have to wait until then, I'm afraid. We weren't expecting you back from the vows so early. We can only do so much.'

Her exasperated tone – and the comment itself – take me by surprise.

'Sorry, I … that isn't what I'm here for.' I stumble over my words. 'I wanted to know, to ask, if you know the way to the library?'

'The library?' She looks confused. 'Oh, well. Maybe …'

Rather than replying, she turns to the man on the table, who hasn't moved an inch. For the first time I look at him properly. He's dressed in a plain black shirt, through which I can see his back is rippled with muscles, and there's something familiar about the cut of his hair and the tension fixed across his shoulders.

I realise all too late who it is. Kyor. The life ruiner. Short of turning around and running back up the stairs to my warded room, there's nothing I can do. And even then, I don't think I'd be fast enough. Still, he won't kill me here, not in front of the cooks – I'm at least certain of that – so I stomp hard on any fear that wants to rise.

In one smooth, swift motion, Kyor jumps down off the table and turns around. Rather than look at me, he faces the cook, flashing her the type of smile I didn't think he was capable of.

'It's okay, Leilah,' he says with an unexpectedly roguish wink. 'I'll take care of this.'

He found the time to remove his furs and put on a shirt, but he's only managed to half-clean his face; blue smudges remain on his eyebrow, and there's a shadow of stubble around his lips.

He moves closer to me, his voice low. ‘Think books are going to help you survive this thing, Thorn?’ he scoffs.

‘Maybe I need the library to find a way to spell you into admitting what you did all those years ago.’

The slightest hint of a smile flickers on his lips. ‘You are so damned prickly. And you need magic to spell. Something I believe you’re lacking.’

His eyes lock on mine and it’s war again – a battle not to be the first one to look away.

‘Ky—Your majesty.’ It’s Leilah’s voice that causes us both to look away. ‘If you don’t mind …’

She gestures to the women around her, all looking extremely uncomfortable, not to mention unable to do their jobs. With a flush of embarrassment, I edge back.

‘I’m sorry,’ I say as I turn back to the staircase. ‘I didn’t mean to disturb you.’

I hurry past the women.

‘Hey, Thorn?’ Kyor calls out to me.

I stop, only to curse myself for responding to his stupid bloody nickname. I grit my teeth and start to move, but he speaks again. ‘You’ll find access to the library through the guards’ temple. Maybe there’ll be a book to help you save yourself. But I doubt it.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 22

Kyor is lying. He has to be. I can't think of a single reason in the world why he would actually help me. Send me into a forest full of hungry dire wolves? Absolutely. Throw me into the path of a speeding carriage? Again yes. But help me with anything? No.

And yet I head to the guards' temple all the same. Of course, there's a good chance the door was somewhere in that kitchen and Kyor was left chuckling to himself the moment he sent me on this wild goose chase, but if I can't find a way in through the temple, then I'll just go down to the kitchen later, once the cooks have left, and have a proper look around.

As I make my way across the battle yard towards the white stone building, the sound of his laugh echoes in my memory, stirring my hatred to a new level. What must it be like to laugh so freely? To know that whatever happens, life will always be one big party. He's never known hunger. Never known suffering. And it's not like there's any real chance of him dying in this thing. The king just wouldn't allow it. I'll admit that the fact he knew the cook's name caught me by surprise, but there's bound to be a reason for that. Something he gains from pretending to be friends with the staff. Better portion sizes, probably.

I do my best to quash all thoughts of the prince as I reach the temple and push the wooden doors open.

This is not a temple to Etta alone; it's a temple to all the Gods. It makes sense given that space in the High Hold arcs is limited. If they put in a temple for every God, there wouldn't be any training space left for the guards.

As I step inside and am hit by a blast of light from the stained-glass windows, I see a figure seated a few rows ahead. I don't want to disturb someone's prayer by wandering around searching for doors, so I hover, unsure if I should stay. But just as I go to leave, the praying man stands and turns to exit himself.

'Commander Zelle, I'm sorry. I didn't mean to disturb you,' I murmur, voice low in deference to our location.

'You're not. I was just leaving,' he says gruffly as he walks towards me.

My body tenses, recalling the thinly veiled threats from Holden in the cave. Does Zelle also want me dead? If he does, then now, alone in a temple with no witnesses, would be a perfect time. I shift back, offering him a clear route through to the door, yet as he reaches me, he stops. My heart squeezes as he tilts his head to the side, studying me. I do my best to ignore the row of blades strapped to his belt, any of which could run me through within a heartbeat. 'You're Elyas and Reeva's daughter, aren't you?'

Hearing their first names spoken aloud causes a throbbing in my chest I couldn't have anticipated. He is the first one to call them by name, rather than a spat *Kultavaris*.

'You knew my parents?' I ask.

'I did. I'm sorry to hear they passed. And for what happened before.'

The throb transforms as my back molars grind together. Such a simple phrase for the utter destruction of my family.

I change the subject. 'I was told there was a route to the library through here. I was hoping I could visit.'

Zelle smiles, a small but knowing twist of his lips, as he dips his chin in a nod.

'Yes, beside the altar to Aitara. But I hope I will see you in the battle yard soon. Come early enough and we can have some training time alone,' he proposes casually.

It's an extraordinary offer, and I find myself gaping at him.

'Your parents were phenomenal fighters. And good people. I'm sure they taught you well.'

'When they were able to,' I respond truthfully.

Again, he offers another of those smiles, as if he understands everything I'm not saying. 'Well, I will leave you to your books. See you soon, Lady Kultavaris.'

He walks out, leaving me staring after him. I am no lady, not anymore, and he knows it. What does his use of my former title mean?

Is it possible that someone else in High Hold agrees that what happened to us was unjust? That I might have another ally or, at least, not another enemy? The thought is strangely comforting.

The moment he is out the door, I head to the altar of Aitara, marked with seven stars – one for her and six for her children. If I had the skill, I'd have drawn stars, rather than dots, on my face for her mark, as they do at weddings. For now, I offer her a brief prayer of thanks before continuing around the altar to where, just like Zelle said, there is a door. A smile forms on my lips.

With every step down, the aroma of leather and paper grows, as does my excitement. I know I've come here for a reason, but that doesn't mean I can't have a wander first. After all, something tells me Zara isn't a reader; I should be safe down here.

A gasp escapes me when I finally arrive on the library floor and am greeted by rows and rows of books on wooden shelves. Some are cloth-bound, others leather-bound, and a feeling of awe takes hold. With all the years away from them, I forgot how calming it was to be surrounded by books. At least I know where I can escape to now between the trials.

The issue I have is working out where the hell I'm going to get the answers I need. The area of the library under the court was always filled with staff – archivists, curators, scribes … people who could tell you where to find what you needed. But I've no idea how I'd even get to that side of the library, let alone how long it would take me. As I'm trying to work out what to do, an impatient male voice cuts through the quiet.

'Have you written that down? Did you hear what I said? He took the Sannings' magic. That's who they were. Sannings. The first men stripped.'

My attention is piqued. I'm not sure who these Sannings are, and I've never heard of people by that name being stripped of magic, but then, I never heard about Estel and her sister either. I follow the voices to a seated area, where a young woman is sitting at a desk with an elderly man. His eyes are opaque, a pearlescent pink-blue sheen covering his irises and pupils.

'Did you get all that down?' He's talking to a young woman with dark skin and warm blonde hair shaved close to her head. She's dressed in a green robe and is scribbling in a notepad with an inkwell next to it.

‘I did,’ she says softly.

‘If I find out you’ve missed anything from here, there’ll be consequences,’ the blind man snaps.

‘Would you like me to repeat what you just told me?’ she says. Her voice is soft and calm. It’s certainly not how I’d speak if someone were talking to me like that.

‘Fine. Yes.’

‘“In the days after the Great Goddess created the Earth—”’

‘The Great Goddess Aitara! Listen, Caroline! That should say the Great Goddess *Aitara*.’

‘I shall amend that now,’ Caroline replies, dutifully revising her notes before continuing. ‘“In the days after the Great Goddess Aitara created the world, she birthed her six children. But the world was too big and lonely for the six of them alone, and so they created man. The Gods decided that the humans would have a share of their powers and distributed them among them, gifted for one life only, to be returned to the Gods via Mortidem upon death, and bestowed upon another at birth. But only six of the seven Gods agreed to this. Sanrott, God of Land and Sea, was angered by his siblings’ and mother’s choice, and as the centuries passed and his bitterness grew, he began stealing the magic back. The Sannings were the most isolated and nomadic of the humans, marked as different with their pale skin, pale blond hair, and peridot eyes. Their lives were so hidden in the forests that even the Gods did not notice what Sanrott was doing until it was too late and he had stripped the Sannings of their powers entirely.”’

A cold shiver runs down my spine. It is a compelling story, and her delivery is captivating, but I don’t have time for fairy tales – particularly not ones that are borderline blasphemy. I’m looking for answers and, hopefully, someone to help me find them, so I move into the woman’s line of sight.

As Caroline notices me, a smile – one which looks remarkably like gratitude – rises to her face.

‘I’m sorry, Rohan,’ she says, closing the notepad. ‘We’ve got to finish for today. I’ve other people I need to go and scribe for now. But I can meet you tomorrow?’

A grumbling sound clears from the man’s throat. ‘Already? But I haven’t even got to how Aitara and the other Gods sealed Sanrott up!’

Caroline’s smile flickers. ‘I’m sure we’ll get to that soon.’

She offers me a glance, and I know exactly what she’s saying.

He’s crazy.

Everyone knows that making up falsehoods about the Gods is a surefire way of turning them against you, but then, as he looks close to eighty and they’ve already taken his sight, I guess he’s not that worried.

‘Can I help take you to the west arc?’ she asks as she stands and helps Rohan gather his things. For a moment, I’m shocked by just how tall she is. Taller than me by a head and a half at least. As I try to stop myself from staring, Rohan shrugs her off and grabs the stick by his side.

‘I was walking these halls when you came in off whatever ship you arrived on.’

I stiffen and watch as Caroline does the same, though when she looks back to me, she simply rolls her eyes. I need no further assurances to know that Rohan is an arsehole. A blasphemous arsehole. Although apparently an independent one. Despite his age and lack of sight, he takes his books and strides confidently away from us.

Only when I can no longer hear his footsteps down the hall do I speak.

‘Sorry, I didn’t mean to interrupt.’

‘Oh, you didn’t. Trust me, I was hoping for a reason to stop.’

There’s a calmness that radiates from Caroline that is so different from the Rettlings I’ve mixed with over the last twenty-four hours. Even the lovely ones. Probably because she’s not worrying if she’s going to survive. It’s refreshing to see.

‘Do you work here?’ I ask.

She shakes her head. ‘No. Normally I work in people’s homes when I’m scribing, and sometimes in the palace or court. Basically, wherever I’m required. It’s just with Rohan that I have to work down here. His family have had enough of hearing his stories, and unsurprisingly, people aren’t too keen to hear him in other parts of the library.’

‘He doesn’t actually believe what he’s saying, does he?’

‘Very much. It’s interesting what people believe, isn’t it?’

Her eyes drift away, and when they return to me, there’s a strange intensity in her gaze. Then it’s gone.

‘I’m not sure you’re going to find anybody who actually works here in this part of the library,’ she says. ‘But I can try to help. I’ve spent a scary amount of time down here over the last five years.’

‘Thank you. I’m Rose,’ I say, stretching out my hand. She looks a similar age to me. Perhaps older, around twenty-six. ‘And you’re Caroline?’

‘Yeah. Nice to meet you. I’m guessing since you came down from the barracks’ arc that you’re a Rettling?’

‘Yeah.’ The word leaves my lungs with a sigh. ‘I am.’

From the way she presses her lips together, I know she wants to ask questions about the Retterheld, but after this morning, I’m not entirely sure I can deal with them.

‘I know you’ve only been here for a couple of days, but have you had a chance to get to know many of the others?’ she asks softly, eyes apprehensive.

‘A few,’ I tell her. ‘Why? Do you know someone who was accepted?’

She lifts her thumb to her mouth and bites the nail. ‘I’m not sure. I have a couple of friends from home who I think may have gone in for the offering.’

‘Where are you from? I might recognise the names.’

‘The Eastern Isles?’ she says hopefully.

A hollowness consumes my stomach and heart, and all I can think about is Coulter’s face as the priestesses dragged him away past Jai’s lifeless body. Though I try to keep the horror off my face, from the way Caroline’s hand flies up to her mouth, I evidently didn’t do a great job.

‘Oh God. This is why I didn’t want to know,’ she says, covering her face as she shakes her head. ‘Forget I asked anything. Please.’

‘I’m sorry. I didn’t mean—’

‘It’s fine. It’s better if I don’t know. Honestly, it’s been a mission to avoid people talking about it these last few days. I don’t know why I even asked. And I doubt they’d have been stupid enough to enter.’ She winces. ‘I’m so sorry. I didn’t mean to imply … I wasn’t saying—’

‘It’s fine, trust me. I get it.’

An apology rises in her eyes and she smiles softly. ‘Look, I actually have two hours before I’m needed upstairs to listen to another old man drone on about all the crazy things he believes he saw in battle, so why don’t I help you look for the books you’re after?’

‘Really? That’d be amazing,’ I reply, grateful for the change of subject, though Jai and Coulter’s faces remain at the back of my mind. ‘I wonder if there are any books on ceremonial daggers? Specifically the one that the priestess used today for the vow. It obviously had some magic imbued in it and I was just wondering if I could find out about it.’

‘Well, I’m no expert on daggers,’ she says, ‘or priestesses either, but I’m sure we can find something. Let’s have a look.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 23

An hour later and I'm leaving the library with four great tomes. Two are on weapons in general, one is on ceremonial weapons in particular, and the last is on the Retterheld itself. The more I know about the different trials, the more I'll be able to prepare. I hope. Surprised by their weight and disgruntled at my lack of strength, I carry the books up to my room. Once there, I change and head down to the battle yard.

Even though I took a fair while at the library, there are still very few people practising. The knighted guards, including Grenda, are all in a conversation with Zelle on the far side of the space.

Estel is practising ducking and jabbing with a large, enchanted bag that swings back and forth, constantly changing angle and height.

For a minute, all I can do is watch her. She's fast but inaccurate with her shots, and if she's got magic to help her, she's not using it. Her only method is avoidance. It would be lovely if that could get us through, but I doubt it will. We're going to need to fight, maybe even kill. I've never done that before, but I need to steel myself to the possibility. For Kay, there's nothing I won't do.

Over in the corner, Benny is sparring with Loch. It's not a gentle practice. They're really fighting. They're angry, and I don't blame them.

A surge of sadness rolls through me, and for a second, I consider going over and offering them my condolences, but words won't help them. Even the gifting can't bring their friend back. The dead always remain so.

'They need to work this out in their own way,' a voice says behind me, causing me to start. I turn and find myself facing Zelle for the second time today. 'Did you find what you wanted in the library?'

‘I’m not sure,’ I reply truthfully. ‘Can I ask something?’

‘Aye. Doesn’t mean I’ll answer though.’ He winks, and I soften a little more to the old man. I’m sure he’s a cold, hard killer when he needs to be, but he’s been nothing but kind to me, and I’m grateful for it.

‘Did you know the knife would do that?’ I ask him. ‘Did you know it would make some people bleed more than others?’

‘No,’ he replies. ‘But I wouldn’t have told you if I had as it wouldn’t have changed things. All it would have done is increase the fear, and fear has no place in the Retterheld.’

I raise an eyebrow.

‘Surely fear is inevitable in the trials and has its place,’ I say. ‘Adrenaline, for example. It helps you focus.’

‘Nerves or apprehension can help hone focus, yes. But true fear freezes you, distracts you,’ he explains. ‘The best thing you can do is know yourself. Know your weaknesses. Know your fears. Know your strengths. Know when you can push yourself, and when you need to slow down. Knowing yourself inside and out, that’s the best preparation you can get.’

‘Is that what you did when you went into battle?’ I ask, expecting him to reply with an equally loquacious answer. Instead, he arches an eyebrow.

‘Who said anything about a battle?’ He smiles. ‘That’s just how I get through the day.’

A startled laugh bursts out of me, and it shocks me. When was the last time I laughed?

The commander looks pleased with himself as he claps me on the shoulder and then walks away.

I think I like Zelle.

‘Rose! Great, you’re here.’ Jonas stands behind me, holding a note in his hand. ‘My father just sent me this. It’s about Kay.’

‘What does it say?’ The adrenaline that Zelle told me to get hold of surges through me.

‘He’s brought her to court. She’ll stay with him in our quarters until the Retterheld is over.’

Relief floods through me. I *knew* I wasn’t hallucinating. She was there in the Sunken Temple. She saw me take my vows.

‘She’s definitely okay?’ I ask again.

‘It doesn’t say much, just that she’s here. But I guess yeah, she’s all right.’

‘Here, in the High Hold …’ My heart skips. I’ve only been away from her for a day and a half, but it’s the longest we’ve ever been separated and the absence hurts like hell. There are things I should have said to her. Like not to forget the health tonic mother always made us take.

‘She’ll be at the ball, I expect,’ Jonas says. ‘After the first trial. You can see her then. Provided you stay alive, that is.’

There’s something about his tone that makes me feel like he’s not sure that’s going to happen, and he’s probably right. If I don’t start training, I’m going to be screwed. Well, Zelle’s offered private training sessions, and I’d be a fool not to take him up on it, and I’m no fool. Looks like tomorrow, I’m getting up early. But for now, I have Jonas to train with.

‘Well, rather than talking, you could always help me fight?’ Grinning with the knowledge that Kay is safe for now, I stride over to the rack of weapons and grab a sword. But as I move to lift it out of its hold, it stays exactly where it is. Even when I alter my grip and try again, the damn thing refuses to budge.

‘Are these things spelled in place?’ I ask. I’m looking at Jonas when I speak, but it’s a voice behind me that replies.

‘No, they’re not.’ Still dressed in the plain black shirt he was wearing in the kitchen, Kyor pushes past me and picks the sword up like it weighs nothing more than a feather.

I don’t know how long he’s been there, but I refuse to let him sully my good mood, especially when I know he won’t kill me here. I offer him the sweetest smile I can muster.

‘I prefer daggers anyway,’ I say, locking eyes with him as I speak. ‘You know, so I’m up close when I plunge it into you … I mean, whoever it is I’m fighting.’ I offer him the hint of a smirk as I pick up one of the light push daggers he pointed out in the early hours of this morning.

His ever-present look of superiority is so damned infuriating. ‘Ready when you are, Thorn.’

I ignore his response and stride past him with my shoulders back.

‘You know, sometimes I think you have a death wish,’ Jonas says as he trails after me.

‘I don’t,’ I assure him. ‘I just don’t make friends with arseholes.’

‘I guess I’ll take that as a compliment.’ He grins. ‘Now, let’s see what you remember.’

~

IT TURNS OUT, I remember precious little. After three days of getting up in the dark to train with Zelle before the other Rettlings awake, and then training with Jonas and the Eastern Islanders all day, my muscles are so sore that I can't remember what it's like not to ache with every breath I take.

Breakfast in the dining hall is always a noisy affair because waking up and knowing we're actually going to see another morning feels like enough of a reason to celebrate. Which, in the Retterheld, I guess it is.

'How are you still able to walk?' I huff to Llinos as I follow her to our table. 'Do your muscles not feel like lead?'

'They're definitely tight,' she admits, 'but we've trained a lot. You know, since birth.'

So had I. Even when we were first stripped and moved to the fifth, we trained daily. It's just these last few years in the slums that saw it slip. Badly. It's hard to practise running laps anywhere when you're so hungry you get light-headed just walking to the market.

Unspoken rules have formed among the groups. The knights sit nearest the food tables. I'm pretty sure a couple of them know the cooks, or at least, they're definitely favoured by them, as the piles of pastries on their plates are substantially larger than on anyone else's. Zara, Shim, and the other Rettlings from Rowell take the table by the main staircase. I'm pretty sure it's so they can glare at everyone coming in and out, which is what they do best. Thankfully, I use the thinner staircase at the other end of the hall, meaning I get to avoid some of their glowers, though they normally switch their attention to me when they see I've arrived, and in truth, I can't blame them. Zara's burns have mostly healed – rumour has it she goes to see the healers for hours every night – but there's still scarring. I suspect there always will be.

The only Rowell Rettling I've ever heard speak beside Zara is Oke, who is equally vicious. So much so that she sent one of her group, Mattieu, to the healers on the first day of training with a knife throw to the arm. He was back sitting with her the next day, suggesting they're a close-knit group, but I've never seen any of them laugh or even crack a smile. I'm not actually sure they're capable of it.

So far, there have been no more threats on my life, but I don't doubt Zara's biding her time. I can't blame her. If there's one person I wouldn't mind sending to Mortidem's eternal darkness to have her powers redistributed, it's definitely Zara.

I also wouldn't mind sending Kyor. Or Holden. The list is ever-growing.

I've learned the crazy old lady from Dorain is called Seiren, and the younger, exceptionally tall woman who looks after her is Kestria and that every Rettling from Galreck is male. Rumour has it that the duke there forbade women from making offerings, but I struggle to believe that's true. The dukes answer to the king and I can't imagine any would be foolish enough to make their own rulings against his.

My group sits at the end near the fireplace – a choice of table for which I'm pretty sure I'm responsible, as my time shivering in the slums makes me naturally seek out heat. I'm still in awe of the size of the fires here. The four of us – the three who remain from the Eastern Isles and me – are a constant, but Jonas tends to spend just a short while with us before flitting around all of the other tables, excluding Zara's. Estel joined us the first morning, though I haven't seen her since. And as for Kyor … I've been blessed not to see him in the dining hall at all.

Unlike Zara and Shim's group, it's clear that Benny and Llinos have adopted humour as a way to cope with their loss, and the laughter is fairly constant. Normally, they are ribbing one another for mistakes they made in training or recalling some in-joke from years back, but for once, I'm not listening to the goading.

'What's that you're reading?' Llinos asks, leaning over my shoulder.

'It's a book on weapons.'

'Ah yes, *reading* about fighting,' Benny says, amused. 'The best way to ensure you don't actually win a fight. But hey, at least you'll be able to evaluate what you did wrong when you're stabbed.'

I shoot him a glare as Llin thumps him on the shoulder.

'Thank you,' I say with a smirk.

'Any time.'

'And I'm not reading about fighting,' I inform him. 'I know how to fight. I'm looking for something in particular.'

'Want to tell us? Maybe I know what it is,' Llin suggests. 'I was a bit of a weapons geek when I was younger. And my party trick was telling you the exact length of any blade just by feeling its weight.'

‘Which is why the guys are grateful she chose women as her preference in bed.’ Benny snickers.

Llinos’s glower narrows. ‘One, not a choice. Two, a true blade master knows it’s not the length of the blade, but what you do with it. Too bad I heard you’re failing on both counts, Benny.’

‘If you ever want to find out …’

Llinos mock gags. ‘Please don’t. I’m eating.’

I shake my head.

‘It’s not just any weapon,’ I say, deciding to go with the truth. After all, Kyor has already seen it, and I don’t see any harm in telling the people I actually trust here. ‘It’s the knife the priestess used in the blood vow,’ I explain. Immediately, their faces pale and I realise what an idiot I am. Of all the things they didn’t need reminding of. ‘I’m so sorry. I shouldn’t have said anything.’

‘No, it’s fine,’ Llinos says, drawing in a long breath to steady herself. ‘We asked. So what is it you’re looking into? The properties?’

‘No. Well, yes. But no. I was given a knife by a friend when I got accepted here. I’d never seen anything like it before but … well, it’s the same as the one the High Priestess used.’

Both pairs of eyes widen. ‘Seriously?’

‘Yep. I was looking to see if I could find out anything else about it, but I’ve not had any luck. It doesn’t help that I’m struggling to read at night like I normally do, what with all the early morning training with Zelle. Still, I’ve at least scanned through all the books I got from the library, and I’ve not found anything yet.’

‘You got books from the library?’ Llin says, latching onto a different part of the conversation. ‘We can go to the library here? I thought we could only stay in this arc, unless it was for the balls or trials.’

‘Yeah,’ I say. ‘The library is down in the basement and there’s access from the guards’ temple. Zelle knew I was heading there and didn’t say anything, so I don’t think it’s a problem.’

‘Can you take me there after morning training?’ she asks, her eyes lighting up. ‘Or just tell me how to get there, and I’ll go without you.’

‘I’ll come with you,’ I offer. ‘Although I was planning to go this morning after breakfast. Caroline was going to look for something for me and said that was the best time to catch her.’

‘Caroline?’ Llinos’s smile drops as her posture stiffens. ‘What does she look like, this Caroline person?’

‘Umm … similar age to us. Maybe a bit older. Warm blonde hair. Dark skin. And she was tall.’

‘Blonde? And how tall? Like a little taller than you or actually tall?’

I feel the blood drain from my cheeks. I got so wrapped up in looking for books that I forgot about the questions Caroline had asked me before we started the search. About whether I knew any Rettlings from the Eastern Isles. Gut churning, I realise that they almost certainly know each other, though it’s a moment later when I realise quite how well they might.

Caroline.

Caz.

‘I think I should take you there. Now,’ I insist.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 24

‘How could you not have said you know a Caroline?’ Llin huffs, hot on my heels as I lead her and Benny through to the guards’ temple.

‘It wasn’t deliberate, I promise. I spoke to her just after the vows and everything was a mess. She only asked me once about the Isles, but then she said she didn’t want to know any more and I didn’t make the connection …’

‘Did you know? Did you know she was here?’ Llinos asks Benny.

‘No,’ he replies. When she responds with a withering glare, he stresses his answer with a little more force. ‘I promise, Llin, if I had known, I would’ve told you. Besides, we still don’t know if it *is* her.’

‘It’s her. I know it’s her. Honey-blonde hair with dark skin, that’s what you said, wasn’t it, Rose?’

I nod.

‘And her eyes. They’re brown-flecked with green, right? Like little green freckles.’

I didn’t think it was possible to look so closely at someone’s eyes as to see the colour of the freckles within them. But then I remember the way Kyor’s icy irises held me completely entranced in Etta’s temple the night of my offering.

‘I’m not sure,’ I admit.

As I reach the doorway past Aitara’s temple that leads down to the library, Llinos pushes straight past me.

‘Caz!’ she calls down, thundering so fast I’m surprised she doesn’t slip. ‘Caz, are you here? Are you fucking here?’

‘It’s a library,’ I hush from behind her as I try to keep up, but I know there’s little point.

‘Caz, are you here?’

‘Llin, you need to slow down,’ Benny repeats, but she doesn’t listen. She just keeps running and calling Caz’s name. I quicken my pace as much as I can, only to almost slam into her back when she suddenly stops.

It only takes me a heartbeat to see why.

There, standing in front of us, is Caroline. Honey-blonde hair, dark skin, and even though I can’t quite see them, I’d bet there are green freckles in her tear-filled eyes. Eyes that look solely at Llinos.

‘I don’t know if I wanna kiss you or kick your arse for being here,’ Caroline says quietly.

‘How about we start with the first one?’ Llinos replies, striding forward and taking hold of Caz.

‘I’m so sorry,’ I say to Benny. Tears prick my eyes. ‘I should have brought her days ago…’ As a Rettling, every single day counts, and I’ve cost my friend three precious days.

‘It’s fine, really,’ Benny says, touching my arm. ‘Besides, if Caz had wanted to know, she could’ve easily found out. I suspect she’s been deliberately avoiding it.’

‘Because she didn’t want to know that Llinos has put herself at risk?’

He doesn’t answer my question. He doesn’t need to. It’s been a long time since I’ve seen true love – absolute devotion no matter what trials the couple has faced, adoration even when exposed to each other’s worst version of themselves. I never understood how my mother stood by my father’s side for all those years, but the way Llin and Caz look at each other, as if staring at the full glory of a God made corporeal, helps it make a little more sense.

‘Come on,’ Benny says, gesturing to the stairs behind us. ‘I suspect Llin is going to miss training this morning.’



THE BATTLE YARD is the fullest I’ve seen it, which I take as a sign that everyone’s hand has finally healed completely from the blood ceremony. Everyone’s trying to get in as much practice as possible before the first trial.

Which could be announced at any time.

All we know is that it will happen before the next full moon. Or at least, we assume it will.

My eyes immediately seek out Zelle.

The commander is not just a skilled fighter; he's also a formidable teacher. The way he teaches, guides, and pushes me in every session with just the right amount of force and encouragement reminds me of my father. Or at least, the man my father was before my brother died. I watch him working with Zara and Oke, forcing them to fight with one hand behind their backs, as if they were injured. To make it 'fair,' he's fighting them the same way. Two against one, and yet he's still winning effortlessly.

Zara's teeth are bared, her eyes glowering as if she's desperate to rip open his old battle wounds and win with magic. But nobody can use their powers on Zelle. That's his power. He's a siphon; he blocks out other people's magic. And from what I can tell, he can do it from a fair distance. Sometimes, when they've been right on the edges of the yard, a few people have managed to use their skills, but if you're anywhere near Zelle's vicinity, it just doesn't happen.

It's a great skill for a teacher, allowing him to force people to work on their physical strength rather than relying on their magic. But against the Issen, where his presence alone is enough to neutralise their ice magic, it's enough to win battles. It's no wonder he's so renowned.

'So what kind of training do you want to do?' Benny asks. 'The type they're doing?' He nods to Zara and Oke, then Grenda and the other knights before looking back at me. 'Or our type of training?'

'Which one is more likely to keep me alive?'

A grin widens on his face. 'Our type of training it is.'



WE ARE THIRTY FEET UP, perched at the top of a sandstone wall, looking down at all the fights that are taking place below us. Benny refused to let Jonas join us because yesterday, when we were sparring, I thought it was going well, only to discover he was using his left hand and deliberately holding back. That was when Benny stepped in.

‘You’re not helping her.’ He scowled at Jonas. ‘If anything, you’re giving her a false sense of confidence.’

That was definitely something Benny couldn’t be accused of. He had me flat on my back in a matter of minutes, then called one of the guards to join us. He blindfolded her, then handed me an axe while leaving her with nothing more than a wooden shield so I could see just how inferior a fighter I was. When he called over Loch, I wanted to throw down my axe and cry.

‘Don’t get me wrong. It’s not that you’re bad,’ he says to me today as we survey the crowded battle yard. ‘It’s just that most people here are exceptional. Except perhaps Elenor, but she’s got Shim.’

Apparently, after I left the ball, everyone learned that Zara’s brother and Elenor are a couple and have been together for years. At this point, they’re a well-oiled machine, and with Mattieu the fire wielder in the Rowell group, they’re practically indestructible.

Our group has already lost two of its members, and as I’m a powerless dud, we are at a distinct disadvantage. But as passive as Benny’s powers to slow things down and examine the details appear to be, having time to observe your opponents is more useful than I thought.

‘Okay, tell me again, what’s Shim’s weakness?’ he asks.

‘He loses balance slightly after striking with his sword because he overthrusts,’ I confirm.

‘Right. Doesn’t matter how big it is. If you overthrust, you’re going to embarrass yourself. Or so I’ve heard.’

I roll my eyes before offering the answer to the question I know he’s going to pose next. ‘I’d counter by using his momentum against him. Sidestep to his left – his weaker side – pivot, then ideally strike him from behind so that he topples forward.’

As much as I want to believe that the trials, and not the other competitors, are the only risks to me, I know that’s not true, which is why Benny’s right. If I don’t know how to at least defend myself against them, the chance of me even getting to the Ofur, let alone winning, is close to zero.

‘Okay, what about Grenda?’ he asks next.

‘Grenda? You haven’t told me Grenda’s weaknesses.’

‘And that’s because she hasn’t got any. Not that I can spot. If Grenda’s after you … you run. And then you climb something. That’s the one advantage you’ve got on her. On most people.’

He’s not just flattering me. This is the second time we’ve scaled the wall to get to this viewpoint, and each time, I’ve been comfortably seated long before he’s reached his final handhold. Although he was right in saying it’s only an advantage over most people, not everyone. Not with the way Kyor scaled the temple. Instinctively, I search the crowded training grounds for the prince, only to find him missing. Obviously, he doesn’t think he needs to be here.

‘If it does turn into sparring,’ Benny carries on, still talking about Grenda, ‘try to get three on one at a minimum. That’s the only way any of us will stand a chance. That said, from what Loch’s heard, she’s pretty honourable. I can’t imagine you needing to watch out for any of the knights, to be honest, unless the whole trial is just to kill as many people as possible. In that case, you’re screwed, but so are most of us.’

At the mention of Loch’s name, I seek out the islander. Since the vow ceremony, he hasn’t said more than ten words around me. It’s good to know that he’s still talking to Benny.

Benny and I remain there for the next half hour before heading back down the wall. I take a different route down, choosing to go as much horizontally as vertically. The workout it gives my arms is just as good as swinging a sword.

I’m about ten feet from the bottom when I jump down, but as my feet hit the ground, I notice something. Markings on the wall. Knife marks. Hundreds of them scratched in a tally. They stretch several metres across, the older ones looking as though they’ve been there for years, if not decades. Though there are hundreds of new ones, too, where the chiselled rock is still sharp, the wind and rain not having yet had time to weather it down. I run my fingers over some of the smoother notches, my eyes drawn to certain ones. Ones where the marks are stained deep brown. There doesn’t seem to be any rhyme or reason to them, no pattern, so maybe it’s to do with the knife used to cut them into the stone.

I push the mystery of the marks aside and head back into the centre of the arena. Knowing why they’re there won’t help me stay alive.

Zelle is free and drinking from a water fountain. My plan is to ask him for a daylight session, but as I approach, a shadow sweeps past me, brushing against my arm.

‘Hey old man. Time to have a proper fight?’ The intonation of Kyor’s address makes it sound like a term of endearment.

‘I think Kultavaris was just coming to ask me the same,’ Zelle replies with a flash of a smile. He really is everything Kyor isn’t. Honourable. Polite. Not an arsehole.

At the sound of my name, Kyor twists around and looks at me as if he wasn’t aware he’d pushed straight past me. Yup. Arsehole. He sniffs once, then turns back to Zelle.

‘Well, how about I tire you out for a bit? Then there might be the slightest chance Thorn can last two minutes.’

Zelle looks at me. It’s clear he won’t accept without me agreeing, but the last thing I want is Kyor watching while I practise my footwork.

‘As you will, Your Royal Highness.’ I shrug as if I couldn’t care less.

I smile a little as he bristles at the remark, but a moment later, he’s walking out into the arena and stripping his top off.

‘It looks like I came at the right time,’ Llinos says, admiring the prince’s physique.

It’s the first time I’ve seen her since Benny and I left the library and I can’t help but rush to apologise. ‘Llin! I’m so sorry. I swear, it didn’t even cross my mind that Caroline—’

‘It’s fine.’ She squeezes my shoulder as she beams. ‘It’s fine. I know you didn’t know. And we’re together again now.’

‘I’m so happy for you.’ A surprising heat burns behind my eyes as I remember the way she spoke about Caz. *My everything*.

‘Me too.’ She grins. ‘By the Mother, I’m not letting her go again. Good Gods, have you seen the muscles on that man?’ Her eyes shift away from me, and I know exactly who she’s looking at.

‘I’m sorry, but weren’t you just saying how happy you are to be reunited with the love of your life?’

‘I’m just appreciating the human form,’ she replies.

‘Yeah, well, that particular human is an evil narcissist who ruins lives.’

‘Oh, I know. I just find it funny that you’re still looking given it’s your life he ruined.’

She’s not wrong. It’s hard not to look. Having stripped off his top, Kyor is now walking barefoot across the sand. Those circles of Wrohelm aren’t the only tattoos on his body. There’s also an orthogonal-shaped rune at the top of his forearm that I’ve never noticed before.

As he and Zelle begin moving, it’s absolutely impossible to drag my eyes away. The way he holds his sword is so light, so gentle, and yet as he

swings the blade in towards Zelle, the amount of power in the strike is phenomenal. The clatter of metal sounds out around us, drawing the attention of anyone in the arena who hasn't yet stopped to watch. Light reflects off Kyor's skin, highlighting each curve of his muscles. His pivots are perfect, and his body moves in a fluid arc as he leans away from Zelle's blade.

His eyes meet mine, and though it's only for a moment, a millisecond, I know exactly what he's saying. He's telling me that when I get to the arena, he's what I'll be up against. And I'm toast.

'Benny,' I say, whipping to my side. 'Tell me he's got a weakness?'

'He's too close to Zelle for me to tell,' he says. 'You want to climb the wall and check?'

Yes is the sensible answer. I should absolutely want to go and study the weapon that is Kyor Knavin if I'm going to have any chance of defending myself against him. But the words don't come out. Because going up high to watch will mean looking away, and I'm not sure I can.

My mind is a hundred percent full of Kyor. The focus in his eyes, the scars etched into his skin. The way his torso twists, and his bare feet pull across the sand as he swerves and ducks another strike from Zelle. He's not even attempting to bring the older man down. Zelle, on the other hand, is giving it his all. His knuckles are white and his teeth are gritted as he aims for every exposed part of the prince. But Kyor makes each block look effortless.

'Does anyone know what Kyor's power is?' I ask without looking.

'Shh, you're distracting from the moment.' I don't know who speaks, but they're probably right.

He swings his sword faster and faster. I didn't know it was possible to move that quickly. His body is a complete and utter masterpiece.

'He can't beat Zelle, can he?' Llinos whispers. 'I've seen the commander take on the knights three to one. There's no chance the prince is actually *that* good, is there?'

I don't reply. There's no need because we're all witnessing the answer.

Yes, Kyor is that good.

There's a reason he's not been in the battle yard on any of the other days. It's not just because he doesn't need it; it's also because he wanted this. He wanted the rest of the Rettlings to be blindsided by just how

fucking good he is. He wants us to see, and know, that the gifting is his to lose.

So much for it being nepotism that put him at the head of the army. If this is how he fights in battle, then he deserves everything that's been given to him.

For a split second, Zelle gets an edge back and my heart stutters, but then a smile flickers on Kyor's lips, and I realise it was all a ploy. He's going in for the final strike.

In a move that is as beautiful as it is deadly, Kyor lifts his leg and smashes it right into Zelle's chest. The instructor stumbles back, momentum taking him all the way to the ground. A second later, Kyor has his sword at Zelle's throat.

'Don't be mad, old man,' he says when he finally moves the blade out of the way, replacing it with his hand to help Zelle up. 'I had a pretty good teacher.'

'You know, if I were in my prime, I would have got you at the beginning when you were playing with that sword like a circus performer,' Zelle complains as he stands upright.

'So you say.' Kyor grins. 'But we both know I would've kicked your arse then, too.' The pair seem completely oblivious to us all watching on and would probably have stayed that way if Zara hadn't stepped forward, breaking the moment.

'Prince Kyor,' she says, bowing in a way that's so sycophantic it makes me nauseous. 'It would be the greatest honour of my life if you would train with me. Train me,' she clarifies.

Silence falls again as every pair of eyes shifts from Zelle and Kyor to Zara and the prince. My heart is beating so damn fast. It's probably just because they'd be a deadly combination together … with me at the top of their kill list. Yes, that's undoubtedly the reason I feel like I can't breathe. It's definitely not because Zara training with Kyor would mean her getting to see him sweaty and half-naked more often. No, I would have to be completely insane to be thinking something like that.

For a moment, his eyes narrowing on Zara, Kyor doesn't speak.

'You're the one who got rid of the … runts? You wanted to make sure only the best got through?'

'That's me.' She beams with pride.

I watch the twitch of his lips and somehow already know what he’s going to say.

‘I’d rather train Kultavaris than you,’ he says, nodding towards me before meeting my eyes with that icy gaze.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 25

The next morning, I arrive for my pre-dawn training session with Zelle, only to falter as I enter the battle yard. Kyor is there, leaning against the wall, without a scrap of fabric on his torso despite the cold.

'I'll come back later,' I say, turning to leave, but before I can move Zelle steps out of the shadows and shakes his head. 'He's here to help.'

Kyor snorts. 'I'm here to trounce you. It'll be fun.'

The commander levels a withering look at the prince, who offers a jerk of his shoulder in a half shrug. At least the smirk is now gone from his face.

'We still need to work on your stance,' Zelle says. 'Without weight on your side, if you don't position yourself correctly, you'll be too easy to topple.'

I press my lips tightly together. We've been working on this for the last few sessions, and I thought I was making good progress. Though if Zelle's brought Kyor in to humiliate me, he obviously doesn't think the same.

'Every step needs to become instinctual,' Zelle continues. 'We're aiming for muscle memory so that your body, not your mind, is what controls how you move.' He shifts into a low stance, knees bent, feet apart. His movements are precise and elegant, like a blade being drawn from its sheath.

'Focus on balance first,' he instructs. 'Without balance, you fall.'

Kyor grins like a wolf scenting prey. 'And falling means you die.'

I shoot him a glare, then mirror Zelle's stance. My thighs, already tired from the last few days, start to burn almost instantly, and my back foot wobbles. Kyor doesn't miss it. He steps in close, and I immediately prepare to back away, but he grasps my hip with one strong hand, the other reaching

down to nudge my ankle wider. I tense until I realise he's helping me get my stance right. What the fuck?

'Too narrow,' he says. His breath brushes my ear, his voice irritatingly smug. 'You'd topple like a drunk with one push.'

The comment hits close to home, bringing up memories of finding my father sprawled on the floor too many times to count. I shake them off and focus on the present.

Because out of the two of us, there's only one who arrived at the first ball barely able to stand and drinking from the bottle. 'You'd know,' I mutter.

'Your stubbornness is going to be the death of you.' He taps my shin with the flat of his boot. 'Weight forward.'

Zelle clears his throat, the sound sharp as a whipcrack. 'Less commentary, more correction.'

Kyor sighs but presses down lightly on my shoulder, forcing me lower. My legs tremble. 'Better. Now move. Right foot first. Small steps. Keep your stance. Don't cross your legs.'

I obey, shuffling forward. It feels clumsy and awkward, like learning to walk again. My arms flail, searching for balance, and Kyor chuckles drily.

'Graceful as a baby deer.'

'Shut up,' I snap, then instantly lose my balance, lurching sideways. His hand clamps around my elbow before I can hit the ground, and heat flares in my cheeks at the contact, even more so when his smirk returns.

'You're welcome.' He winks.

Zelle strides over, his expression flat as stone. He adjusts my foot himself, his grip firm but not rough, then gives Kyor a look that promises pain if he speaks again. It's a moment I'll cherish.

'Muscle memory takes repetition,' Zelle repeats. 'Again. Left foot. Back. Hold your weight evenly.'

I grit my teeth and try again. Step. Step. Balance. Burn. Every correction feels like humiliation, yet beneath it all something steadier is forming. The muscle memory is slowly returning after years with no proper training. My body still aches, but my stance doesn't falter as easily by the end of the session.

The whole time, Kyor circles me like a hawk, pointing out my mistakes with unbridled joy.

‘Why are you helping me?’ I mutter when Zelle is far enough away not to overhear.

‘You think I’d miss the opportunity to watch you humiliate yourself over and over?’ He grins. ‘Besides, I told Duarte I’d train you, and I’m a man of my word.’

‘You said you’d *rather* train me than her, not that you would.’

He shrugs. ‘Zelle also bet me that I couldn’t make a decent fighter out of you. I like a challenge, and I was bored.’

I want to be furious that Zelle bet against me, but I have to admire the cunning. The challenge appeals to Kyor’s gargantuan ego, and if he’s busy trying to prove himself as a teacher, then he might be less inclined to kill me.

For the first time since I saw the other Rettlings fight, I actually feel optimistic.



THE NEXT WEEK is a blur of sleep, fighting, reading until my eyes get too heavy to stay awake, then waking up and doing the same again. Zelle keeps Kyor in check, but I continue to struggle with the training sessions. Having the prince’s hands on me is distracting, but little by little, I’m improving.

Every part of my body aches. Muscles in places I didn’t even know I had muscles have been stretched and strained to their limits. Baths are no longer the luxury they were when I first arrived, but a necessity.

‘Holden was pretty harsh on you this afternoon.’ Benny speaks between mouthfuls at our table that evening. ‘What was his problem today?’

‘Oh, just the usual. Me.’

Since our first conversation in the cave, Holden has varied his interactions with me, from completely ignoring me to criticising and belittling me at every possible opportunity.

‘That’s a great example of how to get killed easily’ is one of his favourite lines, and it’s usually paired with a taunt about my father. *‘He had sloppy footwork for a noble, but then again, that should hardly be a surprise, considering he wasn’t actually a noble, was he?’*

Today’s dig was about my father again. *‘Fighting like that, you seem to think the Great Goddess will offer her gifting to just anyone. Then again, I*

guess you need her to.'

'He's all bark,' I add, aware that the others are still looking at me. 'Honestly, I can't imagine how he got a dire wolf to bond with him.'

'I guess some wolves just have really shitty taste,' Llinos replies.

As I laugh, my eye is drawn to the far end of the dining room, where Oke is glowering at me. It's not an unusual sight, and I actually wouldn't be surprised to discover they've written up a timetable, an actual rota, to ensure that, no matter when or where we are, one of the Rowell Rettlings is glaring at me.

'You know we have spare beds in our dorm,' Llinos says, staring pointedly at the Rowell group. 'You can move in if you like. Safety in numbers and all that.'

Safety from Zara is what I'm sure she means, yet there have been no threats on my life since that first day. I have a horrible feeling that Zara wants an audience when she finishes me off, which means a trial that they let spectators attend.

'Oh yeah,' Benny says, 'I'm sure Rose wants to give up her little corner of tranquillity to listen to you and Caz all night.'

Llinos's cheeks colour. 'Talking,' she clarifies. 'We talk. And it's not all night. She always makes sure she's back in the northern arc in the morning. The last thing we want is for someone to catch us and stop her coming.'

Benny's cheeks puff and his eyes squeeze shut as a strangled snort threatens to burst free.

'What are you doing?' Llinos asks as his body shudders.

A snicker escapes. 'You said you didn't want someone to stop her coming. It's just too easy.'

Llinos rolls her eyes before looking back at me.

'So … about the room?' she asks yet again.

I press my lips together as I prepare to give her the same reply I've given the last five times she's asked me. 'Is it okay if I think about it?'

'Is someone else having their own bedtime conversations?' Benny waggles his eyebrows suggestively. 'You and Jonas were having a good spar the other day. From where I was standing, things looked as though they were getting rather hot – if you get my drift.'

'Everyone gets your drift,' Llinos comments scathingly, 'because your innuendo has all the finesse of a horny bull on market day.'

I snort.

‘Wow. Cruel.’ Benny pouts.

‘But seriously.’ Llin turns to me. ‘Have you two finally bitten the bullet yet, or are you still pretending that you’re just “old friends”?’ She uses her fingers to emphasise the last two words. Not that I need the visual cue to get her meaning.

‘We *are* just old friends. I think,’ I reply, only to let out a sigh.

I’m still not sure what’s going on with Jonas and me, but it definitely hasn’t got to the stage of needing a room. We’ve mostly given up sparring together, mainly because he’s still going too easy on me – making me oddly grateful that I have Kyor making my morning training sessions such a misery – yet Jonas always appears at some point in the day, and each time, we end up talking. Sometimes for hours. Often the conversations centre around the trials, but not always. He’s told me about his father’s wards and how he’s sure Kay will be enjoying her time with them. He’s massaged my shoulders when they’ve been tight from training, and I’ve offered him salves to help with his scrapes. I’ve even fallen asleep on his shoulder at the dining table after a particularly brutal day.

And through it all, he’s never once mentioned any significant men or women in his life. But then, I’ve not brought it up either. Though if he is betrothed, or even seeing someone, I can’t imagine they’d appreciate the time he and I spend together. Or the static hum that buzzes in the air when his eyes have held mine for just a fraction too long.

I hate to be cynical, but I’ve come to two conclusions: one, that he doesn’t want to sleep with me and get too attached because he thinks I’m going to die; and two, that he doesn’t want to sleep with me because, like many of the other Rettlings, he’s repulsed by my lack of magic. But the more time we spend together, the less the second one feels true.

So early death it is. I just hope that whatever this is between us, it’ll be enough for him to feel a desire to look after Kay if anything happens to me.

‘They told me to warn you! They told me to make you see!’

My thoughts are severed by a commotion over on the other side of the dining hall. Seiren is wildly waving her hands around as she races between the tables, shouting at the top of her lungs, ‘Why won’t you see?’

‘Fuck, here it comes,’ Loch mutters.

‘Brace yourself.’ Benny grimaces.

‘Maybe Kestria will manage to stop her before she—’ I don’t get to the end of my sentence before the entire dining room is swallowed in darkness.

Seiren’s illusion magic is something else. The walls are instantly replaced with towering trees, the tiled floor now grassy undergrowth, complete with scuttling rodents. But it’s the shift in the air that’s most astonishing – the cold chill and crisp sweetness that can come only from the forest.

The first time it happened, it showed which of the Rettlings were able to keep their cool. I, like most of the others, went straight for a weapon. But there were several – including Elenor – who began shaking with fear.

Shrieks of ‘It’s the first trial. It’s the first trial!’ rang out.

‘It’s not the first trial!’ Kestria yelled in response, trying but failing to make herself heard above the chaos. ‘It is not the trial! It’s Seiren.’

Only when the old woman calmed down did the illusion finally drop and the dining hall return to its previous state, albeit with more than one upturned chair and several spilt jugs of water.

‘How long do you think this one’s going to last?’ Jonas asks as he sidles up beside me. A corkscrew twists my insides as I consider the conversation we were having just before Seiren’s latest episode.

‘Where did you come from?’ I ask.

‘I was just over there talking to a couple of knights. Apparently, they think the first trial will be within the next three days.’

‘I’m pretty sure someone said that three days ago,’ I remind him.

‘Maybe, but it pays to be alert.’

I can’t help but scoff a little. Alert has been my constant state of mind since I arrived here. So much so that I even considered taking some of the paparvy seeds from Dinah to relax. But that’s not a route I want to go down.

‘Probably best to get an early night then,’ I say, finding his gaze through the darkness and making my intention perfectly clear. Or at least I thought so.

‘That’s probably best,’ he replies without a hint of hesitation. ‘The better rested you are, the better you’ll be able to fight.’

I’m still not sure if it was a brush-off or complete obliviousness on his part as I climb the stairs to my room a short while later. He’s right about one thing though – I do need sleep. I pull off my boots, strip down to my underwear, and drop down onto the bed.



MY EYES JOLT open as I bolt upright.

‘What the hell?’

My body feels like I’m in the centre of a bell as a thunderous peal sounds, loud enough to shake the metal bed frame. I clamp my hands around my ears, unable to see the source.

Magic, I realise groggily. Magic is waking me up when it’s still pitch-black outside, and I know there’s only one reason that can be: the first trial. An uneasy sensation rolls through as knots clamp around my insides.

It’s started.

As lucidity takes hold, the sound softens but doesn’t stop.

I hastily pull on the clothes I dropped by the bed before I fell asleep, only to remember I need my furs for this. Not to mention my sigils.

The ruckus is muddying my thoughts and there’s no way I’ll do a good job of painting my sigils in here, so when my boots are on, I sheath my daggers, grab the tin of blue paint and a brush, and head downstairs. I swear the metal staircase creaks more every time I go up and down, and I can’t help but wonder if Zara’s loosened the screws so that I’ll tumble to my death.

I dismiss the thought quite quickly as that’s not her style. She’ll want to look into the whites of my eyes as she kills me.

I’ve just reached the bottom step when Jonas appears next to me. He’s got a bag with weapons on his back, and despite not being fully dressed, he has already painted his sigils.

How the hell have I not seen him topless before now? I try not to gawp, but it’s damn hard. Of course, I knew he was toned – I’ve seen his bare arms often enough – but his chest? His shoulder blades? His tattoos? Not just Wrohelm rings but the lines of Galreck, too – probably for his time spent training there when he was eighteen – and a sweeping letter U for Una, his mother, who passed away when he was only a toddler. A small line of hair runs from his belly button down, and it’s only when he clears his throat that I realise I was looking in entirely the wrong direction.

A rush of embarrassment floods me, and when I lift my eyes, the slightest hint of a grin flutters on his lips, though it almost immediately turns into a frown.

‘You were still upstairs,’ he says. ‘Why’ve you not moved in with Llinos? She asked you again yesterday, didn’t she?’

‘She did,’ I start, only to stop. ‘How do you know that?’

‘Because I asked her to. Just like I asked her after the vows.’

‘You did what?’

Each of those beds belonged to a person. A friend. A friend who was now gone. That’s why I haven’t accepted any of Llinos’s previous offers to take one, and that’s why I’m more than a little pissed that Jonas has done this.

‘If I want to move into her dorm, I’m perfectly capable of asking her myself,’ I snap. ‘And if you thought it was a good idea, why didn’t you say so?’

‘I don’t know,’ he admits. ‘I guess I didn’t want you to feel like I was coddling you.’

‘Like when we fight, you mean?’ I grit my teeth. ‘Jonas, Etta accepted me, and no one has tried to kill me for weeks. I’m fine, okay?’

Whether I will be after the first trial is another matter, though.

Thankfully, Llinos appears before Jonas can continue. Trailing behind her is a tired-looking Caroline. From the way both of them are rubbing their eyes, they didn’t get much sleep either.

Jonas’s eyes widen. ‘She’s not a Rettling. Why is she here?’

Caz’s lips purse slightly, but Llinos doesn’t miss a beat.

‘Library delivery service,’ she says. ‘Now, shall we get going? This damn ringing is driving me insane. And I don’t know about you, but I’ve got a trial to survive.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 26

Over half the Rettlings are already gathered in the dining hall, almost all of them bedraggled and, like me, still needing to draw on their sigils.

‘Do me a favour and try to stay alive, will you?’ Caroline whispers as she kisses Llinos at the door.

It’s not a small peck, either. Llinos’s hands reach around the back of Caroline’s neck as she pulls her in close. It’s the kind of kiss I might do in private if I were in the right mood, and a pang of jealousy streaks through me at the way they press their foreheads together when their lips part. Theirs is the type of love that doesn’t require words, and seeing them together makes it feel impossible that they’ve ever been apart.

‘She’s not actually from the library, is she?’ Jonas whispers in my ear.

‘Oh, she is,’ I tell him. ‘She definitely is.’

Five minutes later, sigils have been painted, the rest of the Rettlings have arrived, and Holden and Zelle appear at the front of the dining room. Speculation has run rife, not just about what the trials will be, but about how we will get to them. Many of the Rettlings are keen to experience portation, but much to their disappointment, we are merely led out into the battle yard, where the same series of carriages used previously awaits us.

‘So what do you think we’re going to face?’ I ask as I pile into a carriage. Estel goes with Kestria and Seiren this time, and without Jai and Coulter, the carriage feels close to empty.

‘It’s hard to guess what direction we’re heading in right now,’ Benny replies, glancing up at the skylight, ‘as we won’t know until we’re out of

the city and the sun's up, but my bet is the forest. Eight Retterhelds have had their first trials in the forest.'

I could cope with that, I think. Lots to climb in a forest.

'How many trials have taken place in the water?' I ask, trying to keep my face as passive as I can.

'In the water or on the water?' Jonas clarifies. 'Do you mean on boats or actually swimming?'

'Either,' I say, though really, it's the second possibility that terrifies me. As a child, I learned to swim in the Festroin lakes, a low mountain area about a four-hour carriage ride outside of Wrohelm, but that was a long time ago, and I worry I've forgotten.

Benny looks to Jonas as if he's expecting him to answer, but Jonas stays quiet, leaving Benny to explain.

'Normally one per Retterheld, though it's normally only one aspect of a trial. Like swimming down to an underground cave or rowing across to one of the Vypark islets and continuing from there.'

Swimming to an underground cave may feel like a 'small part' of a trial to Benny, but unless it's glassy water and the depth of the cave is no more than ten feet, I'm going to struggle. Hopefully, this year there'll be some type of rowing involved instead. Ideally, rowing across water so tranquil there's zero chance of me falling in.

'I notice you haven't asked us how many times the first trial has been the magicless one,' Jonas comments.

'But I get the feeling you're going to tell me, right?'

'Three. If the scribes are right.'

'Out of how many?'

'Eighteen documented.'

Is that good or bad for me? I've no idea. As I glance at Llinos, she shrugs.

'Whatever this is, we do it together,' she says, all strained confidence. 'We can all get to the Ofur. We can all complete and pass all the trials without anybody needing to die, right?'

'We work together,' Benny agrees. 'Until the last one. Then we go for it by ourselves.'

I clear my throat. 'If I ever become a burden—'

'You won't,' Llinos interrupts.

‘But if I do, tell me, okay? Tell me and I’ll go it alone. It’s what I planned on doing before I got here.’

‘That’s not going to happen. Not for the first four trials,’ Llinos assures me.

It’s impossible not to notice how quiet both Loch and Jonas have been, and now silence sweeps around the carriage, amplified by our shared tiredness from being woken so early.

‘Maybe we should sleep,’ Jonas suggests. ‘No idea how long it’s going to take us to get there.’

He pulls off his fur coat and folds it in half before laying it on his shoulder. He looks at me. ‘For a pillow, if you want?’

The way his eyes meet mine, I know what he’s actually offering: a truce. An apology for going behind my back to Llinos. When this trial is done – and assuming I survive it – this situation of ours needs clarifying. Not knowing what we are is taking up too much of my mental capacity, and right now I don’t have any of that to spare. For now, the thought of a comfy shoulder and sharing someone else’s body heat is too good to pass up.

‘Just don’t forget to wake me when the trial begins,’ I say before snuggling down and closing my eyes, my head resting against him.



‘WEST, I’m telling you, we’ve definitely gone further west.’

I’m not woken by our arrival at the trials, but by Jonas and Benny at loggerheads.

‘We’re going west *now*,’ Jonas says, ‘but I think we’ve gone north just as much. That would put us in Afaven Forest.’

‘We *went* north to start with,’ Benny replies. ‘But while you were snuggling up with Rose, I was awake, and that’s how I know we’ve been going west the entire time. I’m telling you, we’re at the coast.’

Benny looks to Loch. ‘What do you hear?’ he asks. ‘Forest or water?’

‘Right now, I just hear a lot of horses’ hooves and you two arguing,’ Loch replies sourly.

Llin and I suppress a smirk.

As I glance up, I can see the sun directly above us. I’m not exactly sure what time it was when we left, but I must’ve slept for at least six hours.

That’s more hours than I’ve slept in my room, and I should feel rested, only there’s a crick in my neck from sleeping against Jonas that reminds me of my bed in the slums.

I wonder what bed Kay is sleeping on. If she’s warm, well fed, happy. With effort, I push my worries down. I can’t afford to be distracted, not now.

It’s only when I go to rub my neck that I realise my fingers are entwined with Jonas’s. I’ve no idea when it happened, but given how much longer he’s been awake, he must have noticed. As subtly as I can, I try to draw my hand away, and as I move, my eyes fall on Llinos. This time I’m well aware that her smirk is directed at me, a smirk that evaporates when Loch suddenly stiffens.

‘Loch?’ she says. ‘What is it? What can you hear?’

The older islander flinches at her voice, blinking and shaking his head.

‘It doesn’t make sense,’ he mutters. ‘I don’t understand. It doesn’t make sense.’

Benny leans forward in his seat. ‘What, what doesn’t make sense? Loch, buddy, what can you hear?’

Rather than reply, Loch continues to shake his head. Jonas and I exchange a concerned look. Loch’s certainly the least sociable in the group, but he’s never been like this before. The only Rettling who can usually lay claim to this kind of incoherence is Seiren.

He rocks a little in the seat. ‘I don’t understand. I should be able to hear them. Why can’t I hear them? They must be lying.’

Benny looks confused. ‘You can’t hear? Is that what you’re saying? Have they blocked our magic?’

My ribs clench around my chest. Is it a good thing or not if the first trial is the one where magic’s banned? It would definitely even the playing field among the other Rettlings, but it won’t make me any stronger or more able to defeat whatever’s waiting for us.

‘My magic’s fine.’ Llinos lifts a hand and conjures a breeze that wafts through the carriage.

‘Mine too,’ Benny replies.

Jonas doesn’t bother commenting. I don’t know if the others even know what his magic is, but even if they do, now doesn’t feel like the right moment to test it.

‘They’ve done something to them,’ Loch continues his babbling. ‘They’ve done something.’

‘Them? Do you mean the other Rettlings?’ I ask, only for a noise from outside to steal our attention. The driver of the carriage is calling out, slowing the horses. As it draws to a stop, none of us move.

‘I don’t think I want to do this.’ Loch’s voice sounds more like a child’s than a middle-aged man’s. ‘I don’t think I can do this. I don’t think I can face them.’

Jonas reaches over and grabs his hand. ‘You heard what we said on the way over here, didn’t you? Whatever it is we’re about to face, we face it together.’

Warmth floods through me. Jonas may have made more than one comment that has irked me over the last couple of weeks, but then he goes and does something like this – finds exactly the right words to say – and my heart melts.

‘Come on, buddy. I’ve got you,’ Benny says. He opens the carriage door and steps out first, waiting for Loch to follow.

As Llinos stands to join them, Jonas grabs me by the wrist.

‘One minute,’ he says. ‘Just give me one minute.’

Given there’s a patch of wet on his fur that I’m fairly sure is my drool, I figure I can give him this. Even if I’m burning to know what’s out there.

‘Rose.’ Jonas’s voice is low, his eyes solely on mine, like we’re the only things that matter and not the trial waiting just outside that could very well kill us. ‘Whatever we face today, I need you to promise me you won’t take any risks. Promise me that.’

I laugh. It’s not deliberate, but it’s the most ridiculous thing he could possibly say.

‘Not take any risks? Jonas, we’re going into a *trial*. This is the Retterheld. It’s meant to be one giant risk. That’s why we deserve a gifting at the end of it. One of us, anyway.’

‘I know that. I do. But you have people here. Friends with powers. Friends who *can* risk their lives because they’re in a better position to fight than you. If it comes to that, let them take the fall. Keep yourself safe.’

I study him, wanting to make sure I’m understanding him correctly. But I am. I *know* I am.

‘Are you saying I should just let my friends die?’ I ask. ‘If that’s the best option for me?’

‘I’m one hundred percent saying that, yes.’ He nods. ‘Everybody signed up for this knowing they would face death.’

‘Everyone including me,’ I tell him.

‘Please. Please, for me.’

He lifts his hand and cups the side of my cheek, his thumb brushing gently across my jaw. There it is again, that fizzing, twisting in my stomach. It’s as potent and dizzying as the first time I saw him again in the High Hold.

‘For me, Rose,’ he entreats. ‘There’s so much I want to tell you. So much I need to tell you. You just have to survive this, okay? Promise me. No unnecessary risks.’

I open my mouth, still not sure how I’m going to reply, but I don’t get a chance. Before I realise what’s happening, his lips are on mine. Days of not knowing where exactly he and I stand, and finally I have my answer.

There is an urgency to the way he kisses me, like it might be the only time he gets to do it. But thinking like that won’t help either of us.

I press my hand to his chest, not sure if it’s to move him away or simply to feel him. And before I’ve made up my mind, there’s a hammering on the door. Leaning away from him, I push the door open.

‘Time to get out, guys.’ Llinos offers us only a fleeting glance before turning back to whatever is awaiting us. ‘You’re gonna want to see this.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 27

The good news is, there are no spectators at this particular trial. But that's where the good news ends.

Jonas's prediction was very wrong. Rather than the forest, we're at the beach, standing on the edge of a dune with sparse grasses growing in dense tufts over the undulating landscape. The waves crash against the shore in the distance, and further out, whitecaps rise ten feet into the air above the churning grey sea.

But it barely warrants a second glance because we're not swimming today. Or ever going in the water.

No, our trial has to do with what's standing on the stretch of sand in front of the shoreline.

'Are those…?' I trail off, gaping.

'Jötnar,' Benny answers, as he rubs at the back of his neck. 'Those are jötnar.'

Of course, I've heard of jötnar before. The thirty-foot-tall giants fill the storybooks my parents would read to me as a child. They're said to roam the frozen islands beyond the Torailian territory, eating everything in their path, from whole cattle and humans to boulders and icebergs. But I never believed they were *real.* And Goddess bless, some of them are definitely over thirty feet. My mind can hardly accept that they're real. Perhaps they're not. Maybe they're nothing more than an illusion, like the type Seiren creates … but something tells me that isn't the case.

'Did you know jötunns were real?' Llinos's words echo my own thoughts.

‘Jötnar,’ Jonas corrects. ‘Jötunn is only used for the singular. It’s like you’re asking, “Did you know mouses are real”, instead of “mice”.’

‘Honestly?’ My jaw drops slightly. ‘You think now is the best time for a grammar lesson?’

This time Jonas has the sense to stay quiet.

As we stand there in collective awe, several questions roll through my head. First, where did the priestesses get them and how did they wrangle them onto the mainland? And more importantly, how are we going to survive this?

It’s clear from the pained expressions, gritted jaws, and bulging eyes of the gargantuan jötnar that they are bound by some kind of magic. Held in place, I’m guessing, until the Rettlings have been told exactly what we need to do. Despite their visible pain, not a sound rolls from their drool-covered lips. Is that what Loch was talking about? Are the jötnar what he couldn’t hear?

I swallow the lump sticking in my throat and squeeze Jonas’s hand.

He squeezes back. ‘Remember what I said,’ he whispers.

People have already begun to cluster together with their allies, creating coloured pools of shell-shocked Rettlings. There’s something almost prophetic about the colours, the way the Wrohelm black mirrors the grey clouds above us, while the Galreckians in their emerald green remind me of the tufts of sea grass that break through the dunes. But it’s the red my eyes linger on the most. With both the knights and Rowell Rettlings in different shades of the colour red, I can’t help but wonder if it’s a sign that by the time this trial is over, the sand will be soaked in blood.

As my group stands wide-eyed with panic, it’s almost a relief to see that even the knights look shocked. No preferential treatment there, then. That’s something. I scrutinise the other contestants and don’t find a single face that looks anything but terrified.

Until I spot *him*.

I’m sure, being the prince and commander of the army, he could have his choice of allies, and yet the way he stands apart from the other Rettlings implies he’s decided against making any. Rather than fear, a crinkle of mild confusion is all that clouds Kyor’s expression as he stares at the creatures one by one. Then, without explanation, he shifts his attention up to the sky, kicks off his shoes, and digs his toes into the earth. It’s the oddest battle preparation I’ve seen.

‘Fingers crossed one of them’ll crush that lying, vindictive bastard.’ I turn to my side to see Estel standing there, her jaw locked. From the way her eyes are trained on the prince, there’s no doubt as to who she’s talking about. Clearly there’s something in the rumour I heard about Kyor and her sister.

‘It’s her,’ Llinos murmurs as she stiffens beside me, drawing my attention away from Estel.

The High Priestess Mila strides across the sand, her robe billowing in the salt-filled breeze as her amethyst stone reflects the midday sun. As she stops directly in front of three of the jötnar, I release Jonas’s hand and feel for the dagger at my side. I’m not sure what good a blade like this will do against a giant, but daggers are all I have.

‘Rettlings, welcome to your first trial.’

Mila’s voice booms around us and several of the jötnar snarl at the sound, their lips curling back from their sharp, pointed, yellow teeth.

Somewhere across the way, I hear a whimper from one of the other Rettlings, and I can’t say I blame them.

‘This trial will be timed.’ She waves her hand and a platform, complete with a priestess and a ten-foot hourglass sand timer, appears to the left of us. A simple cloaking spell, I assume, and though it looks good, I can’t help but wonder if Etta really asked for such dramatics at the first honouring of her name.

‘Your task is straightforward. Those of you who survive the next thirty minutes will live to see another day.’

Thirty minutes. One thousand and eight hundred seconds. That’s all I have to stay alive for. Easy.

‘The time will begin when each of you sets foot on the sand,’ she continues. ‘But there is another caveat. Any of you who bring down a jötunn permanently will immediately be removed from the trial and excused from the second trial as a reward.’

Gasps, mutters, and murmurs ripple around us.

‘Is that even something she can do?’ I whisper. ‘Can she excuse Rettlings from one of the trials?’

‘She’s the High Priestess of Etta.’ Jonas shrugs. ‘She’s the one who hears what the Goddess wants.’

‘Rettlings, take your places.’ The High Priestess lifts her hand to beckon us forward and then moves to the platform.

There are forty of us and nine jötnar. That means four-point-four people for each giant. Obviously not an even number, but with the variation in the sizes of people's allegiances, some of the bigger groups could split into two or more. But the announcement of the reward changes everything.

Surely everyone will want to bring down a jötunn alone? It's a mess. Suddenly, we're not just fighting the giants. We're fighting each other, too.

The line of Rettlings begins moving forward, heading onto the beach. Several people drag their heels – one or two out of fear, but others, like myself, are trying to work out which jötunn will be easiest to take down.

'Our alliance still holds,' Benny announces firmly as our group huddles together. 'It doesn't matter which one of us takes it down, right? If any of us get excused from the second trial, then that's a win.'

'Right,' I agree.

My heart is beating so fast that I'm having to remind myself to breathe as I move forward. As fear threatens to consume me, Zelle's words of advice echo in my mind. I know myself. I know that I was accepted into the Retterheld because I deserve to be here. Which means Etta believes I have the strength to survive this.

A spark of confidence flickers inside me, and I glance over my shoulder, counting the moments until the last person steps onto the sand. Then a snarl, raw and alien, shatters the air. The sound is deafening – a thousand times louder than the bell this morning – and accompanied by a rancid smell that burns the back of my throat.

Chaos breaks loose.

The jötnar are dressed in rough garb, and though they don't seem to have weapons, it's clear that they don't need them. They're waving their arms, growling, snarling, and simply bending down and scooping up sand and Rettlings alike. I watch in muted horror as one body is flung towards the sea, into the white-capped waves. I don't need to look to see if they stand again. There's no chance of surviving that.

Some of the Rettlings are running, running straight to the edge of the water, as if being there will save them. Instead, it just pins them in if a jötunn comes for them. Not the wisest move.

Then there's the magic.

This entire place is filled with it. Fire is hurled from every direction, but it doesn't seem to touch the giants, and blasts of wind that would have me flat on my back appear to do little more than irritate them. It's not that

they’re impervious to the Rettlings’ powers; they’re simply too big for the magic to affect them to a significant enough degree.

I glance at Zara and find her standing frozen, her face twisted in concentration. She’s trying to open up whatever wounds they have, and though it seems to be working – there are certainly a few bleeding gashes appearing on the jötunn she’s fixated on – it’s primarily just making him angrier.

It’s the people who are running around that seem to be getting the brunt of the force of our enemy, the giants swatting them like flies.

‘We have to bring them down,’ I say grimly. ‘There’s no way we’ll survive for thirty minutes just dodging them.’

‘Agreed,’ Llinos replies.

‘That one, the one with the jagged scar,’ Jonas yells. It’s hard to hear him over the roar of the giants, so he points again.

‘No!’ Benny shouts. ‘That one.’

He gestures towards a jötunn at the back of the group. Even the smallest of the monsters are at least thirty feet, but the one Benny picked must have another ten feet on that.

Ignoring Benny, Jonas tugs me towards the jötunn he picked, but the Eastern Islander shakes his head.

‘That one,’ Benny says again, more adamantly this time.

I pull my hand from Jonas’s grip. ‘He can see,’ I say, hoping Benny doesn’t mind me sharing what his power is. ‘He can *see*, Jonas. He knows which one to go for. Trust us, please.’

Jonas looks between us, pressing his lips together. ‘It’s enormous.’

‘Trust me,’ I plead.

A muscle twitches along his jaw. ‘Fine, but only if you remember what I said,’ he murmurs before sprinting across the sand towards Benny.

As I move to follow them, a figure appears at my side. Estel.

‘You want another pair of hands?’ she asks.

Since we’re facing giants, I give the only reply I can. ‘Absolutely. The more the merrier.’

Together, we race towards the others who are now less than twenty feet from the colossal creature Benny chose.

‘What are we doing?’ I yell above the roars.

‘His legs,’ Benny hollers back. ‘He’s struggling to hold weight on them. I’m guessing he took the biggest beating when the priestesses brought them

here. It hurts him to walk, meaning we don't have to worry about him kicking out or chasing us. We just have to worry about his fists.'

'That's not exactly a little worry!' Jonas shouts, jumping back as the jötunn bends down and swings at us. His clenched fist is easily the size of a carriage, and it hurtles through the air with such a force that even the wind it creates is enough to unbalance me.

As I watch, powerless, Llinos sends a blast of air at his chest. It doesn't stop him, but he slows by a fraction.

'He's in pain,' Estel reminds us. 'And that just made him angrier.'

She's an empath – another skill that's absolutely useless in this scenario. We've no fire wielders or anyone who can raise the temperature of the jötunn's blood until it boils. Just people who can look and hear and feel its emotion. Brilliant.

'Jonas.' I turn to the only one of us, besides Llin, whose magic physically does something. 'Can you use your powers on him? Maybe if he's disoriented, we can lead him into the sea.'

'I can try,' he says dubiously.

Jonas steps back and raises his hands. I see his muscles twitch and his jaw tighten. I can practically feel the power radiating from him.

'I think it's working,' I murmur.

The jötunn slows its movements, as if confused. That's good. I remember exactly how Jonas's powers affected me, and the blindness it brings means the giant won't notice us coming at it with our weapons. But as I move to make my first strike, the jötunn lets out a scream.

Guttural, animalistic, and putrid, it's strong enough to blow my hair back from my face.

'He's really mad now!' Estel shrieks.

Some powers are even less helpful than none at all, I can't help but think. Still, I use the moment to throw a dagger up towards his neck. The aim is spot on, but he moves his head at the last minute, and the blade bounces off his jaw.

'It's fine,' Jonas says. 'This will work. I'm disorienting it.'

'He doesn't need fucking disorienting,' Benny snaps back. 'He needs fucking putting down.'

Benny's right. In the confusion of the blindness, the giant is stumbling forward, the pain in his legs secondary to this new affliction.

As I hasten out of his path, I glance across the battlefield. Only one jötunn has been taken down so far. Unsurprisingly, it's the one the knights were fighting. But then something else catches my attention.

Kyor is battling a jötunn. Alone.

He has his jötunn trapped in his own micro-storm, and rain pelts down from green-tinged clouds hanging above his head. But it's the lightning that mesmerises me. Hundreds of forked streaks strike its shoulder as wind knocks it back and forth. Goosebumps that have nothing to do with the storm slide over my skin.

'Well, that makes my power look pretty shit.' Llinos is at my side, blasting another burst of air at our jötunn's fist as it swings above the sand.

'Your power is definitely not shit,' I say. 'Right now, it's what's keeping us alive.'

'True. But I'm not sure for how long.'

I struggle to tear my eyes away from the prince. With his powers as a storm-weaver, lightning, rain, and wind buffet his foe in an impressive display. He really is formidable … and a distraction I really don't need at the moment.

I refocus. Daggers aren't any good against the giant as the blades merely bounce off its thick, leathery skin. And though Benny and Loch are getting a few swipes in with their swords, they're barely slicing through the giant's top layer of skin.

'We have one very unhappy big fella here,' Benny yells. 'We need to switch this up. And whatever the hell you're doing, Jonas, for fuck's sake, stop it.'

'I'm helping!'

'You're not,' Estel snaps. 'Any minute now he's going to—'

The jötunn roars as it lashes out, its whole body sweeping in a wide circle that catches Jonas on the thigh before continuing on. Llinos is blasting everything she has at it, but it's not making the slightest bit of difference. When its fist swings out the next time, it collides with Estel. The crunch of her bones reverberates in my ears as her body is thrown up into the air.

She hits the sand with a lifeless thud.

Guilt swamps me, but I can't let it distract me. Not now. We are losing this. We are losing our lives. As I stand there, frozen by indecision, Benny and Loch continue attacking with their swords, but it's not going to be

enough. We're only getting weaker, and the giant's just getting more pissed off.

'Rose!' Jonas calls out to me. 'Do you remember what I said? What you need to do?' He nods across to the sand timer and I see the half hour is already more than halfway gone. He's telling me to save myself.

But Llinos is giving it everything she has. Benny, too.

Estel is a crumpled heap on the sand, and like fuck am I going to leave them to a fate like that.

I have to do something. Know yourself. That's what Zelle told me to do. Well, I do know myself. I know I can throw knives, and I know I can climb.

The thought has barely formed when it hits me. There's only one thing here that I can scale and doing it might actually help us.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 28

‘Keep him distracted!’ I yell at the others, not giving myself a moment to consider what I’m about to do. ‘Pain, blind him, I don’t care. Just keep him distracted!’

‘Rose, whatever you’re planning, don’t do it!’ Jonas shouts back, but I block him out as I run towards the jötunn and launch myself upwards. My hands claw at his calves and the thick, bristly hair that covers them. Gross, yes, but also incredibly helpful. I pull myself up on it, using all the friction I can get from his rough, pitted skin. It’s not easy – and a darn sight harder than climbing the wall with Benny – but it’s doable. I can do this. I have to do this.

The jötunn’s arms swipe haphazardly around, and I press myself flat against him as his gnarled fingers pass only inches from my side. Relief floods through me. He wasn’t aiming for me. If he had been, I’d be on the floor. I’m nothing to him. An irritation at most, and one that’s causing way less pain than the others.

I climb higher and faster than I expected. Before I’ve even had a chance to check how far I’ve come, I’m standing on his shorts-like attire. It’s the closest thing I’ve had to a ledge to stand on, and I intend to use it for a moment’s respite. But as I glance up, the coarse fabric of the garment slips beneath my feet, and the ball of my foot goes down with it.

‘Fuck!’ All I can feel is air beneath me as gravity takes over, my body twisting as I start plummeting. Somehow, I’m able to grab hold of the waistband with my fingertips, and the slightest quiver of relief trembles in my breath as I claw myself back up.

‘Of course, we had to pick the tallest fucking jötunn,’ I mutter, dragging my feet back onto the waistband. This time I make sure I’ve got more than one secure hold as I catch my breath and glance at the sand timer by the priestesses.

I’ve heard the expression ‘time flies when you’re having fun,’ but apparently, it also flies when you’re trying to stay alive. There can’t be more than ten minutes left. It should be comforting, except it would still only take the jötunn a matter of seconds to permanently end things for any of us.

All of the crew is bloodied now. Blood from a gash on Llinos’s forehead is streaming into her eyes, and I’d be amazed if she can even see. I need to do this. For them. For Kay. For me. I straighten, suck in a lungful of air, and prepare to go again.

I may have reached the halfway point, but the jötunn’s back reveals a new problem. Unlike his legs, there’s far less hair here and far less friction. There are a few patches of calloused skin that look hard and rough enough for me to use as handholds, but all of it is slick with sweat.

I pause, considering my options. Other than the blade from Dinah, which I’m not sure will even work, I’ve only got one dagger left. Theoretically, I could use it with the minimal natural handholds I can find and scale him that way, but it would mean stabbing a dagger into his back. Repeatedly. A dagger in the back of a creature this size might do next to no damage, but it would likely be enough to tip me from *irritant* to *threat.*

Still balanced on the fabric of his shorts, I search for my next handhold.

‘Oh Gods, that is truly disgusting.’ I gag at a wart-like mound that protrudes from his lower back, but I use it all the same.

I stretch my fingers wide, retching against the smell as I clasp the rough, cracked bulge. I’ve just pulled myself up and am using it as a foothold when it feels as if the entire earth shakes. It takes me only a moment to see what caused it.

Kyor has brought down his jötunn.

I don’t know how the other groups are doing, and I don’t care. I need to keep going and focus on the task at hand. With a loud grunt, I hoist myself up onto the next protruding mound, my stomach churning from a mixture of fear and the putrid smell, and barely wait for my feet to steady before searching out the next callus.

I find it in an old, puckered scar, just thick enough to get my fingers on. It's hardly secure, but it's the best I've got. My wrists burn from the weight of pulling myself up, and I push my shoes against his slick skin, hoping that will help me get the traction I need to reach my target: his shoulder. Once there, I'll have access to his neck. Then I can do some real damage.

With every bit of strength I have left, I grapple upwards and find the wide precipice of his shoulder blades, which will be perfect for hauling myself up.

'Rose!' I'm sure it's Jonas's voice I hear through the torrent of cries and swirling winds, but when I glance down, I can't even see him. Benny, on the other hand, is directly below me, grinning while simultaneously slicing at the giant's ankles, and I'm pretty sure he's grinning because of me. But I have no plans on smiling just yet.

The good news is that this is the most stable position I've been in for the entire climb. The bad news is that it's also the easiest position for the jötunn to swat me off. And I can't let that happen. Not until I've done what I need to do. I won't be able to saw at his neck, so the stab wound is limited to being a one-time deal, and to make it significant enough to take him down, I need to do something stupid.

With my left hand braced against the tendons of his neck, I reach for my blade and sink it right into his jugular. The skin here is thinner than I thought, immediately yielding under the pressure of the sharpened edge. As blood pools around my hand, I push it in as deep as I can, then swing around and clasp the hilt with both hands. Jumping, I put my whole weight on the hilt. With everything I've got behind it, the knife pulls down the length of his throat.

His roar sends pain shooting through my skull, leaving my entire head ringing as my vision blurs. Yet despite the blood pouring from his wound, he's still standing.

Right now, his hand is flailing, but if it moves towards his throat to clasp the wound and stop the blood flow, he'll knock me off or, worse still, crush me. I have no choice; I have to fall. Overriding every rational part of my brain, I pull my dagger out and let myself plummet.

A scream tears from my lungs as the air whistles past me and my body accelerates towards the ground, faster and faster.

I'm going to die. There's no way I can survive this.

‘I’ve got you!’ Llinos shouts, but it doesn’t feel like she does. I’m falling, and I’m going to hit the sand and break every fucking bone in my body. They’re going to crunch like Estel’s, and then Kay … what will happen to Kay? I’m tumbling helplessly through the air and I brace myself for impact, hoping that if death is going to take me, then it does so fast.

But instead, I feel it. The wind. The wind that comes not from the sea, but from the ground, and with just enough force to slow me. Just enough to help me land safely.

She has me. Llinos has got me.

My feet hit the sand with an almighty thud, sending me to my hands and knees as pain sears through every part of me.

‘We’ve got it!’ Benny crows in triumph.

The jötunn is clearly getting woozy, the blood loss weakening him, and Benny is already following my example and climbing the jötunn’s leg. He climbs as far as the stomach, where he plunges his sword into the giant’s flesh. Again and again and again he strikes, and blood flows forth like a giant, coppery river, washing the sands with the stench of it.

The jötunn hunches forward, clutching his abdomen, and for a split second, I think my friend is about to be crushed, yet Benny is entirely calm, not a hint of fear on his face, and he jumps sideways just in time. I should’ve known. With his sight, he was always going to be fine.

But have we done it? Blood is pouring from the jötunn. Surely there’s no way it can survive this. Any second now it’s going to be face down on the ground.

The thought hits me a moment too late.

‘Shit!’

The jötunn is indeed falling … straight towards me.

‘Rose!’ I’ve barely had time to register the sound of my name when Jonas slams into my side, propelling me forward and out of the path of the falling giant as it crashes down onto the sand, sending up a spray wide enough to blot out the sun and engulf us entirely.

‘Fucking hell, Rose!’ Jonas pants as his arms hold me tight. His voice is muffled against me. ‘What the fuck were you thinking? You could have died!’

‘I could have,’ I agree, panting, ‘but I didn’t.’

We lie there, a tangled mass of limbs, trying to catch our breath. Fear and anger, not to mention pain, burn visibly in Jonas’s gaze as he glares at

me. Fuck, his leg. I didn't even think about that. Running for me like that must have been agony with his injured thigh.

'Guys!' Llinos's voice cuts through the haze, breaking my thoughts. 'We don't have time to relax!'

As I twist towards her, I see what she's talking about. I push to my feet.

The smaller jötunn – the one Jonas wanted us to go for – is bearing down on us. Whoever he was fighting definitely gave it their best, and blood is pouring from the creature, but he's still on his feet and heading towards us, looking angry.

'Where's Benny?' I call out, looking around. If Benny can find a weak spot, then maybe we can bring this one down without any more of us getting hurt.

But he's nowhere in sight. My lungs seize. Where the hell is he? He was there before I fell. I saw him.

'Benny! Benny!' I shriek as I turn on the spot, only to stop when a hand grabs my elbow.

'We don't have time to freak out now.' Jonas's face is inches from mine. 'I'll blind the jötunn. You and the other two do whatever you can.'

Two, is that all that's left? Llinos, Loch, and me? Yet as my eyes find Loch, I'm not so sure we can count on him. He's standing upright but rocking back and forth on the balls of his feet. How the hell one of the other jötnar hasn't killed him already, I don't know.

'Rose, are you listening to me?'

I blink myself back into the present and nod at Jonas's question, mostly because I've lost the power to speak.

'Good. Then move!'

This time, Jonas's powers have more effect on the creature. The jötunn covers its eyes, turning in circles, and cries out, disoriented.

'Draw him to the water!' Llinos shouts. 'The waves are high. Even if he can walk through them, it'll slow him down!'

I sprint towards the jötunn, grabbing Estel's fallen sword on the way and raising it above my head as I leap forward and drive it into its thigh.

The giant wails as it swivels around in my direction, though I don't wait to see what it'll do. Instead, I race towards the water. Llinos wasn't joking when she said the waves were high. If I get caught in one of them, I'll be dragged out to sea, and even a strong swimmer would struggle in a current like that.

‘Move out of the way!’ Llinos cries. ‘I’ll see if I can push him deeper.’

The jötunn is walking straight towards the waves, hands clawing at its eyes as it’s propelled forward by the force of Llinos’s powers.

One glance tells me Llinos is nearly done, that she’s scraping the barrel of her magic’s reservoir. Her muscles are trembling and her eyes are bloodshot. Just a fraction longer, that’s all she needs to keep going for. But she hasn’t got it in her. Her knees aren’t just trembling, I realise; they’re about to buckle. And Jonas is the same, though he’s already kneeling on the ground, his body slumping forward. They’ve both run their wells dry. If they take it any further, they could end up unable to restore their powers. They’d be as good as stripped. Like me.

I can’t let that happen.

I scan around me, searching for anything or anyone to help, but everyone who’s left standing is in the same position. Fear takes hold. Surely this isn’t what Etta wants? For most of her Rettlings to end up dead or stripped in the first fucking trial?

‘Etta!’ I cry at the top of my lungs, pain searing through my chest, only for my eyes to land on the sand timer … and the last grain that falls through it.

Relief swamps me, and a blast of magic rips through the air.

The jötunn freezes with his feet at the edge of the waves. I hold my breath as I survey the scene. The other remaining giants are all in the same state, motionless and silent.

I take a shuddering breath. It’s over. The first trial is officially over, and I’m still alive.

But where the fuck is Benny?

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 29

My ears ring in the silence that now smothers us. I press my hand to one side of my head, then the other. There's no pain. Or rather, my ears are in no greater pain than the rest of my body. My knees and elbows are grazed, and the taste of blood fills my mouth, but I'm on my feet, and that's more than others.

Though those feet are unsteady. The reality of what I just faced – and survived – has left me listless and light-headed. Or maybe that's the injuries.

Jonas is still on the ground, struggling to stand, while Llinos comforts Loch only feet away from Estel's glassy-eyed body.

'Benny!' I call out, looking desperately around for any sign of our friend.

A voice booms out from the platform, halting my search.

'Rettlings, you have survived your first trial.'

I lift my head, but only by reflex. I don't want to listen to her. I want to find my friend.

But when I glance towards the platform, I see them standing beside her. Kyor, Grenda, and one of the Galreck Rettlings, Moryal. And there, at the very end … Benny. He's propping himself up on the shoulder of one of the priestesses, but he's there and very much alive.

Relief swamps me with such force that I drop to my knees.

'Thank fuck,' I mutter. My head falls forward as my chest shudders. They must have been removed from the trial the moment they dealt their fatal blow.

‘Now rest,’ Mila continues. ‘Rest and heal, for who knows when the Goddess will next call on you.’ With that, she, the other priestesses, and the sand timer all disappear.

When I finally drag myself back onto my feet, I head over to Jonas. Llinos is already there, helping him up. I move over to his other side and take his arm over my shoulder to balance his weight.

‘I’ve got you.’

‘What the hell did you think you were doing?’ he snaps. ‘Putting yourself at risk like that … I told you to run!’

My jaw drops. ‘You’re joking, right? I saved you.’

‘If I hadn’t pushed you out of the way, you’d—’

‘You’re angry because you’re in pain,’ I say, keeping my voice measured despite my annoyance at his lack of gratitude. ‘Come on. The sooner we get you in the carriage, the sooner we get you to the healers.’ I look at Llinos. ‘What’s Loch doing?’

He’s standing knee-deep in the water. It’s an act I could understand if Sanrott were his fealty God, but his sigils say otherwise.

‘I don’t know. Come on, let’s get Jonas to the carriage. Then I’ll go back for Loch.’

Conquering the sand dunes in our weakened state and with Jonas less than happy about all the help he needs isn’t exactly easy, and by the time we’ve got him in the carriage and Llinos returns to the beach, there’s no sign of Loch.

‘He must have got into another carriage,’ Llinos says after giving up her search and climbing in with Jonas and me.

The carriage is painfully empty. We should be happy that we made it through to the next stage, but it’s hard to celebrate when so many didn’t. The image of Estel’s body flying through the air fills my mind. Another image to add to the carousel of nightmares already stored in my head.

‘You were phenomenal, Rose.’ Llinos breaks the silence as the horses pull away. ‘The way you climbed that thing! Unbelievable.’

‘I’m glad I was able to use my abilities to climb and throw daggers, but I doubt I’m going to be so lucky in the trials that follow,’ I say truthfully.

She shrugs. ‘You never know, and you’ll also have the non-magical one at some point. And anyway, think about all the people with magic who didn’t survive.’

She’s right and I appreciate her optimism, but while I haven’t seen exactly who survived and who didn’t, it’s likely a few of the weaker Rettlings were lost. As such, I can almost guarantee that I’m now officially the runt of the group.

As I contemplate who else may or may not have made it, my mind flickers to Zara. What are the chances that she didn’t survive? I already know that Kyor did, but at least he’s now out of the second trial.

I fall asleep at some point and wake to the clatter of carriage doors opening. We are back in the eastern arc, where the healers are already waiting. And they’re not the only ones.

‘Thank the Gods.’ Caroline rushes to Llinos’s side and buries her head in her shoulder.

‘All Rettlings to the healers. *All* of you.’ It’s Zelle’s voice and hearing it causes a warmth I didn’t expect. His eyes catch mine and he offers a slight dip of his chin. It might be my imagination, but I’m pretty sure he looks pleased to see me among the living.

Unlike the majority of the people who stumble out of the carriages, I’m not entirely sure a trip to the healer is necessary. Then again, I might be able to walk, but I’ve also got my fair share of cuts and bruises. And maybe a couple of cracked ribs. There’s also the fact that I can’t hear anything out of my right ear. Yeah, on second thought, a trip to the healers definitely wouldn’t hurt.

‘Sorry, you two.’ I place my hands on Caroline’s and Llinos’s shoulders. ‘Gonna have to break it up. I need help with Jonas.’

‘See you later,’ Caroline whispers as she tucks a strand of bloodied hair behind Llinos’s ear.

The healing hall is to the left of the dining room, and it’s been separated into two areas: those who need the most help, and those who need a quick once-over. Llinos and I get grouped together and are quickly whisked behind separate curtain dividers while Jonas is taken away.

‘I think it’s just bruised ribs,’ I tell the healer as he scans his hands over my body. ‘Oh, and my ear. I think it burst my eardrum when it yelled.’

The healer’s cheeks pinch inwards as he mutters something to himself. Even with both working ears, I’m not sure I’d have worked out what he said, only that it isn’t positive.

No more words are exchanged between us as the tingling of his magic ripples over my skin. I close my eyes and bask in the sensation. It’s like

pressing my palm to the temple door to see Dinah or feeling the spell Jonas placed on my door. I just wish it were my own magic causing it, not someone else's.

'You're good,' the healer says as he withdraws his hands from me.

'Great. Thank you.'

He looks at my blood-soaked clothes. 'You should bathe and then fetch yourself something to eat. And then rest,' he suggests. 'Who knows when they'll call the next trial.'

As I clamber to my feet, my stomach churns. There are a lot more healers than usual. Are they here merely because they knew the injuries from the jötnar would be significant or for some other reason? Like we need to recover quickly because we're going to be expected to fight again soon. Very soon.

The healer's right. Now that they've started, they could call the next one at any moment. Maybe they'll cram the other four trials in right at the end of the four moons, or maybe they'll be kind and spread them out evenly so we have time to recover. Something tells me it won't be the latter.

'Thank you,' I say before turning and heading through the curtain, only to collide with a wall.

Or at least what I think is a wall, until I step back and find myself staring at a chest. Kyor's chest.

As I glance up towards his face, he looks down at me with a repulsed expression.

'So you made it.' I can't tell if it's disappointment or surprise in his tone.

'It would appear so,' I respond drily.

As the silence swells between us, uncomfortable and heavy, I assess his current state and conclude that he must have been healed first, because there's not a mark on him. His blue sigils remain perfectly painted on his face and a wolf stole sits around his shoulders. He's still dressed for battle, and if he went for me now, if he took his vengeance for my mother's false 'failure,' I couldn't possibly stop him. I have nothing left.

He evidently reads the thoughts on my face and clicks his tongue in exasperation. 'I'm not going to cut you down when you can barely stand. I have honour.'

Anger rises, hot and sudden, and I shake my head in pure disbelief at him. 'Honour? You absolute fuck. Even now, you think you were justified

in what you did.'

His face hardens. 'Your mother had one job to do,' he snarls. 'To help bring the baby into the world and make sure my mother lived.'

'That's two jobs, asshole. But you were right the first time. She did have *one* job to do. It was to do what the queen asked of her. My mother sadly couldn't save them both. Why don't you understand that? If she could have, she would have. It's that simple.'

'She could have tried harder!' The words burst from him, the protestation sounding like that of a small boy. 'She just … stopped.'

'She stopped when your mother told her to. When your mother – the *queen* – told her to save the baby instead.'

My teeth grind, my jaw locked so tight it aches.

'My mother had no choice. If she had let the queen live and lost the baby, she would have gone against the direct command of a monarch. She would have been dead then as well. So she did what she was told to do. She tried to save the child.' My throat stutters.

Tried. That's the word that chokes me.

That's the reason Korvane Knavin didn't just strip us of our powers but also murdered my baby brother. He claimed it was recompense for his lost son.

But no matter how strong their magic is, the fact is that healers can't save everyone. The powers of life and death remain in the Gods' hands alone.

'Kill me or don't,' I spit out, 'but either way, stop lying to yourself – if you're even capable of that.'

With that, I turn and stalk away, anger propelling strength into my weakened limbs.

When I reach the dining hall, the smells wafting up from the kitchen below suggest something special is being prepared tonight. Something to celebrate the fact that we are still alive.

Dinner will be the first time I get to see exactly how many people we lost to the jötnar, and tomorrow night we'll have the ball to celebrate.

We should be given time to grieve, to commemorate the lost ones, but that's not the way this works. You celebrate surviving and try to forget those who didn't. In that way, it's remarkably like the slums. Life and death are in a constant unrelenting cycle.

Despite the conflict, my heart lightens at the thought that Kay might be able to come with Lord Lorathin to the ball, which means I might actually get to speak to her. Another positive. Another reason not to look back and dwell on death. It's something my father taught me, however inadvertently – that dwelling on death only ruins more lives.

I head upstairs to the dorm, continuing up the rusting spiral staircase to my little abode. There's a definite quiet that wasn't here before. There's no clatter of swords in the battle yard. No laughter rattling from the dorms. At some point, there will be few enough Rettlings left for everyone to have their own rooms. I wonder if other people have already thought of that. I'm sure Shim and Elenor would be happy to get a room for themselves, not to mention Llinos and Caroline. Another unanticipated positive from death. It's twisted, that's for sure.

Despite the efforts of the healer, exhaustion hits heavy and hard, and I'm planning on taking his advice and spending the time between now and dinner sleeping. But when I reach the landing, I find my doorway blocked.

'Benny?' I say in worry. His face is ashen. 'Are you all right?'

'I did something, Rose.' His hands are both clasped around the back of his neck, seemingly working at a knot there. 'I did something I'm not sure you're going to be able to forgive me for.'

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 30

I place my hand against the door, which releases with a hum of magic.

'Neat. Jonas do it for you?' Benny asks as we step inside.

I nod. 'It's meant to stop people from attacking me while I sleep, though those stairs are so freaking creaky that they're an alarm system all by themselves.'

'That's good.' He runs his hand around the back of his neck again.

'Benny … what's up?'

He swallows. 'I feel like I took it from you, Rose. I accepted the High Priestess's offer to miss the next trial when you also helped bring that thing down.'

'Stop,' I say, cutting him off right there. 'We worked as a team. That was what we agreed to do, and we worked well. You were offered a gift, and you took it, the same way any of us would, so don't you dare spend a single second feeling guilty about it.'

He smiles at me, but it's a long way from a proper Benny grin. 'I'm still sorry.'

I give him a light hit on the arm. 'Quit it. You're being an idiot.'

At the insult, a hint of a sparkle returns to his eyes. 'Any chance I can have a hug?' he asks. 'I could really do with a hug.'

'Sure thing.' As I approach him to do just that, I hear the creaking on the stairs. 'Sounds like Llin is done with the healer. Group hug time?'

'Definitely. Can I just get one with you first?'

'Of course, my friend.'

As he engulfs me in his arms, my head rests against his chest and I'm struck by a feeling I haven't felt in such a long time. Safety.

It reminds me of the hugs that Ruben would give Kay and the others in the slums. His embraces – his warmth – were a gift he was always happy to offer, and not once did he ever ask for anything in return. That's how it feels now. Like Benny expects nothing from me but friendship and a moment of comfort. His body is wrapped in tension and it's no wonder. He's lost so many people.

And so we stay there, holding each other, not even noticing when the door opens.

'Sorry, I didn't think I'd be interrupting anything.' Jonas's voice is sharper than shards of glass.

The ward doesn't stop him, given how he's the one who set it, but I would have thought he'd have at least knocked. Still, I flash him a smile, relieved that he managed to climb the stairs by himself. But he doesn't see it. His eyes are locked on Benny with a look that would rival some of Zara's.

'You're not interrupting,' I tell him as I move out of Benny's embrace. 'Benny just came to say he's accepted the High Priestess's offer to be excused from the second trial.'

'Is that right?' Jonas's jaw twitches. I might be overthinking it, but I sense some serious hostility coming from him. Maybe he's still in pain.

'How's the leg?' I ask. 'Did they fix it up?'

Jonas's eyes linger on Benny for a fraction longer before he finally turns to me.

'Mostly. Still painful, but they said it'll be fine after a good night's sleep.' That's all the attention I get before his eyes are back on Benny again. 'Would you mind excusing us for a minute? There's something I need to talk to Rose about.'

'Sure, no worries. I get it. More alone time for you.' Benny flashes me a grin. 'Thanks again.'

'You don't have to thank me. We all did our part,' I remind him firmly. If Llin hadn't caught me, I would be with Mortidem right now.

Jonas's eyes follow Benny out of the room, and a single vein bulges across his forehead.

'Shut the door behind you,' he calls, even though he's only a couple of steps away from the door himself. Still, Benny does as he's asked.

Silence cocoons the room, perforated only by the creaking sound of Benny's footsteps retreating down to the dorm floor. Only when they've

faded into nothing does Jonas speak again. ‘Is there something going on I should know about? With you two?’

‘What?’ The laugh that escapes my lungs comes out far louder than anticipated. ‘With Benny. Are you serious? He’s just a friend.’

‘That looked like very close friends.’

‘Well, we are.’ I hear the edge in my voice, but seriously, Jonas and I shared one kiss, and now he’s acting all possessive? I don’t have the headspace to deal with this. ‘What did you want, Jonas? Or did you just come to lecture me about the people I choose to spend time with?’

His eyes widen. ‘No, of course not. I came to see you. To talk to you. And because …’ He inhales, places his hands on my waist and pulls me towards him. My body stiffens slightly before relenting and shifting closer to him. ‘I’m sorry about the way I yelled at you earlier.’ His voice is quiet, nervous.

‘It’s fine. Forget it. You were in pain.’

‘The leg was nothing compared to how it felt when I thought something was going to happen to you.’ He slips his hand into mine. ‘You know, I never told you this before, but our parents talked about us getting betrothed when we were older.’

‘Really?’ Surprise curls my lips into an unnaturally rigid smile.

‘Yeah,’ he says. ‘I often thought about what we would have become if you hadn’t left.’

A tingle of tension takes hold. ‘You make it sound like we had a choice.’

‘Sorry, I didn’t mean that. I was just trying …’ His voice fades into the ether, but his hands remain on my waist, and he pulls me even closer. ‘Rose, when the next trial comes, please try not to put yourself in danger. For me.’

‘It doesn’t work like that, Jonas.’ My tone has a hard edge to it, yes, but I don’t get why he’s finding this so difficult to understand. ‘I was just doing what had to be done.’

‘You can’t win the gifting if you’re dead, Rose.’

‘No, I can’t win if Etta doesn’t think I’m worthy. Which is what will happen if I’m not actively participating in the trials.’

‘I’m not saying don’t participate.’

‘That’s exactly what you’re saying!’ I bite back. ‘I did well today, Jonas. I survived when people with magic, people who have trained every day,

didn’t. If anything, today should have shown you just how capable I am.’ Goddess knows, it’s shown me.

‘I know you’re capable. It’s just …’ He lets out a long sigh and shakes his head. He lifts my hand up to his lips and plants a kiss on my palm. ‘Look, how about we stop this bickering and go back to what we were doing in the carriage? You do remember what we did in the carriage, right?’ The shadow of a grin flickers on his lips. ‘From what I remember, it was a lot of fun.’

Was it a lot of fun? It definitely wasn’t a bad kiss, but it was chaste, and I was also distracted by wanting to know what was waiting for us outside. Not to mention I was irritated by his lecture, which was remarkably similar to this one he’s just given me.

In the silence, Jonas’s eyes remain on me, waiting for me to respond, to let him know I want to kiss him again. But before I can figure out if that’s even true, my mouth opens into a wide yawn that’s immediately followed by another.

‘Sorry, I think today definitely took it out of me. The sleep in the carriage wasn’t exactly restful.’

Jonas laughs as he pecks the back of my hand. ‘You want me to stay? We could curl up together?’

It’s the first time he’s actually offered to stay in my bed with me, which means it’s the first time I’ve had to properly think about if it’s actually what I want. Before today, I’m sure I would have said yes, but today’s been a lot. And if we’re going to start something, I don’t want it to be on a day like this, when we’ve been at each other’s throats half the time. Yet still I hesitate before I reply.

There’s no denying that having someone lying next to me with their arms wrapped around me would be nice, but I shouldn’t just want ‘someone,’ should I?

‘Maybe another time,’ I murmur eventually. ‘You need your rest as well, and these beds aren’t exactly big enough for two.’

He presses his lips together, clearly disappointed, before nodding his head. ‘Fair enough. See you down at the dining hall for dinner? Apparently, they’ve put on one hell of a feast.’

I nod as I watch him leave, then slip into the shower to wash off the blood and grime before tumbling into sleep.

~

It's pitch-black outside my window and the smell of snow is strong in the air as I drag myself out of bed a while later, slip on clean clothes, and head downstairs.

When I get to the table, Benny and Llinos are already deep in conversation while Loch stares at nothing. I'm surprisingly relieved that there's no sign of Jonas, and the thought makes me grimace. It's not a good sign.

'Where is everyone?' I ask, gesturing to the emptiness of the hall. 'Am I early?'

'No,' Benny replies solemnly.

My jaw drops. 'You mean this is it?' I turn back around, unwilling to believe what they're telling me. This can't be all who made it, surely?

Llinos and Benny exchange a look.

'There's no one with the healers,' Llin says quietly. 'I was there just before. Maybe a couple are elsewhere, like Kyor. But the others …'

My throat thickens with a lump I can't swallow. The knights' numbers have been decimated, with only half a dozen remaining. The dire wolves of those who didn't make it will be similarly doomed now, as the only thing that awaits a broken-bonded wolf is a slow death. The thought that the deaths haven't ended with those just in the room chills me.

There's only one other person with Seiren and Kestria at the Dorain table. The Galreck numbers are equally diminished, and when my gaze falls on the Rowell Rettlings, I can't help but gasp.

'Shim's not here?' There's a crack in my voice. 'Shim didn't make it?'

Llinos shrugs. 'Better people than him have died today.'

'I know, but still—' How has one trial taken out so many people? There are three more to go before we get to the Ofur, and at this rate, we'll be lucky if even a handful make it that far.

I continue staring around the room, trying to pick out faces – or rather, missing faces – from the groups. Nessira's father – Nathan, the fire wielder – isn't here, and from the way her aunt Clade is comforting her, I'm guessing he's among the dead.

Both Baylis and Grenda are still among the surviving knights, along with another four I don't know by name yet.

‘Benny told me he took the High Priestess’s offer,’ Llinos says. ‘Thank the Gods. He also said that there were three others on the platform when the trial ended.’

‘Do you know if they all accepted the gift?’ I question, annoyed that I didn’t think to ask him earlier.

He shakes his head.

‘Kyor won’t have done.’ There’s not a shadow of a doubt in my mind. ‘It’s a matter of pride for him. He’s all about *honour*,’ I sneer. ‘He won’t think he deserves to win unless he competes in all the trials.’

The minute the words leave my lips, I watch Benny’s expression shift into panic.

‘Do you think that’s true?’ he says. ‘Do you think I can’t win if I miss a trial?’

I shake my head and rush to reassure him. ‘No. If that was the case, it would never have been offered.’

‘Unless it was a test?’ he counters, gnawing on his lip.

I exhale. This prize is seriously doing a number on him, that’s for sure. Maybe he’s right, but Etta’s never struck me as a Goddess who plays games, unlike some of the others. But who can know the mind of a God?

Llinos places a hand on Benny’s shoulder. ‘At the end of the day, it’s about finishing this together, right? As long as one of us gets through, we’re all winners.’

‘Yeah. You’re right. Of course you’re right.’ Still, an uneasy silence settles over our table, broken only by Loch’s constant muttering. His fingers are now pressed against his ears. I’d never say it aloud, but I can’t help feeling that Loch getting to the Ofur is getting less and less likely with each passing day.

‘Incoming,’ Llinos whispers. I glance down to the end of the hall and immediately see who she’s talking about.

Zara is heading straight towards us, eyes flashing with fury.

‘How the fuck did you survive that?’ she spits as she looms over me. There’s no doubt who she’s aiming her question at.

‘Glad to see you made it through the trial too, Zara,’ I say.

I’m not sure why I think injecting a bit of humour into the situation might help. This is Zara we’re talking about. I doubt she even has a sense of humour at the best of times, and even less so now that her brother’s just

died. Yeah, that probably wasn't my best move. With her jaw twitching, she moves her gaze from me to Benny and Llinos.

'How the hell did you help keep this fucking *runt* alive?' she sneers.

I'm sure she thinks that name will have got to me by now, but I find myself growing more and more impervious to it. Though I can't say the same for my friends. Llinos pushes back her chair, stands up, and faces Zara.

'That *runt*,' she snarls, 'scaled the tallest jötunn there so that she could take a dagger to his throat. She deserves to be here.'

'My brother deserves to be here,' Zara snaps. 'It's not right. Why would the Goddess save her and let him die?'

A current of unease swirls through me. I meet her eyes, hoping she'll see my sincerity. 'I'm sorry for your loss, Zara. Truly, I am.'

'Fuck you.'

Everyone in the dining hall is looking at us, but I don't care.

'I mean it. I know you two were close—'

'You're fucking dead,' she promises in a low growl. She raises her hands and I brace myself for the pain of my cracked ribs returning, but there's barely a twinge. She must have nearly drained her magic today.

On the other side of the table, Benny pushes back his shoulders and stands.

'Your brother chose the trials. He knew the risk, just like the rest of us.' He moves in between Zara and me. 'Go back to your table, Duarte. We've all got losses to mourn.'

Her top lip curls in a snarl and my throat dries as I think she's about to turn this thing into a proper fistfight, but instead, she simply looks at me with venom.

'Your days are numbered,' she fires at me before swivelling around and marching back to her table.

I don't know why Etta chose who she chose, and I don't feel even a modicum of grief over Shim's death, but I do know the pain of losing a brother. Shim and Zara were twins, and for that reason alone, I feel for her.

'Well, good to know some things never change,' Llinos offers with a weak chuckle.

Benny squeezes my shoulder and pointedly sits next to me.

'Somehow I don't think Zara and I are going to come out of this thing best buddies,' I reply weakly. 'But I'll deal with that later. Right now, I'm

starving.’

I would have thought that seeing that much death in one day would have destroyed my appetite, but apparently not. I eat more than ever before. Since moving into the barracks, my body has regained the ability to eat decent-sized meals, which means I’m actually putting on muscle. A very good sign. It’s only when we finish with the savoury and the sweets are brought out that Jonas joins us. He slides onto the bench on the other side of me, though he speaks to Benny first.

‘Sorry about being a little antsy earlier,’ he says. ‘Pain from the leg.’

‘No problem.’ Benny shrugs. ‘It was a shit day.’

‘Not all of it was shit.’ Jonas throws a glance at me, and I know he’s less than subtly mentioning our kiss. Nervousness pulses through me. I wish he’d keep whatever’s going on with us to himself, but it’s not like the rest of them don’t suspect already.

‘I just hope we get a decent amount of time to train before the next trial,’ I say, trying to steer the conversation. ‘And I hope it doesn’t involve things that want to kill us.’

‘Yeah, good luck with that.’ Llinos laughs.

‘What are everyone’s plans for later?’ Jonas continues. ‘I was going to finish up here and head to the battle yard if anyone wants to join me.’

‘Seriously?’ My eyebrows arch.

‘I need to stretch out a bit. Fancy coming?’

I don’t even hesitate with my answer. ‘Not a chance. I’m getting as much sleep as possible. Big day tomorrow.’

For the first time since I appeared downstairs, Llinos’s face lights up. ‘Oh my Gods, you’re right. The ball. Will we get to meet Kay?’

‘I’d assume so,’ Jonas answers. ‘I probably shouldn’t admit this, but my father managed to smuggle some information to me. He said he’ll be attending the ball with his wards, and I’m pretty sure that includes Acacia now.’

‘Truly?’ Tears prick my eyes at the reality of what Jonas’s news means, and before I can think, I throw my arms around him. ‘You have no idea how grateful I am. Honestly.’

As we break away from the hug, Jonas’s grin is almost as big as mine. It would be great if I had the power or influence to get letters in and out myself, but having a friend who can has to be the next best thing.

‘Just glad we could help.’

With my heart hammering, I sit back down, but I can’t get the smile off my face.

Llinos reaches out, grabbing my hand and giving it a squeeze. ‘You must be so excited.’

‘I am!’ My grin fades a little. ‘Though I’m also kind of nervous. Does that make sense?’ There’s a good chance that Kay’s still angry at me for entering, and there’s the added little issue of my not giving her a heads up about what I asked Artur to do either. Yes, there’s a fairly good chance she’s even more pissed at me than when I last saw her.

Llin snorts. ‘Not at all,’ she replies. ‘Come on, we’ll pick out your dress tonight. That way, I’ll have time to make any adjustments.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 31

‘So,’ Llin begins, ‘Benny told me Jonas went all jealous on him earlier.’

‘He did?’ The comment catches me by surprise as, for the last ten minutes, Llinos has been examining the gowns in my wardrobe, her dagger dangerously close to the fabrics. There’s no chance any of these dresses are making it through the night without some serious alterations.

‘Yup, he thinks Jonas is too possessive of you. And he thinks he’s hiding something.’

‘Really? Jonas?’ Sure, Jonas isn’t a core part of the group, what with his flitting about between us and the others from Wrohelm, but he still worked with us and only us in the trials. ‘Why does Benny think that?’

‘Not sure, but he’s good at spotting people who are hiding shit. Then again’—she shrugs—‘he’s also completely paranoid. I guess that comes from his family.’

‘His family?’ I ask. I don’t know much about Benny’s family other than, like both Llin and me, he’s the eldest child.

‘Why’s his family paranoid?’

‘Oh, it’s nothing, really.’ She has her dagger against one of the dresses again, though this time it feels like she’s purposefully avoiding looking at me. ‘They’re just really wealthy.’

Given that everyone here except the knights is a noble, wealth is something I kind of expected. Though I suppose, like anything, there are shades of it. In the slums we were the poorest there is, so even now I still have to stifle the urge to hoard extra food. Some habits are hard to let go of.

One of us.

I may be well fed and warm, but I'm still a slum rat. I wonder if that will ever change, or if the scars of the last few years will remain, come what may.

'Okay, so bear with me.' Llinos lifts up a full-length black gown from the pile. The material is a floaty chiffon with a V-neckline. 'Try this one. I've got an idea.'

Knowing she won't take no for an answer, I slip it on and stand in front of her.

'So here's what I'm thinking.' She crouches down, picking up a handful of fabric. 'We do the bottom like last time – take out a panel and have leather fighting shorts underneath. It can be your signature.'

'And on top?'

'And on top, we make this a smidgen lower.' She gestures to the neckline. 'But the sleeves will be the real statement. We'll open them up with a slit down from the shoulder, and then I'll see if I can find some type of wire to hold them open.'

'Hold them open?' I repeat dubiously.

'Yeah, kinda like bat wings.'

'Bat wings?' I've been reduced to parroting things back to her. It doesn't sound like the type of thing I'd normally wear.

'Trust me, you will look phenomenal.' Llinos reads my reticence and continues, 'Like a serious badass. Which is exactly how you want everyone to see you, right?'

I can tell from her eyes that she's desperate to do this, and considering how good a job she did before, I'd hardly feel right saying no. Besides, if cutting up all my gowns brings her joy, then I'm not going to stop her.

'Fine,' I groan, though a smile curls my lips. 'Do your thing.'



It's late by the time Llinos leaves, and despite the long day, sleep doesn't come. My body obviously feels like it's rested enough.

In addition, something's been weighing on my mind since I first got here, and it feels like it's time I do something about it. So, after getting up and dressed, I make my way to the kitchens.

Just as I hoped, Leilah is still there, wiping down the last of the kitchen sides. She doesn't bother looking up as I enter.

'It's late,' she says bluntly. 'We're not serving food now.'

'I know,' I say quickly.

As she lifts her head, her eyes sweep me up and down and then soften a little. 'Looks like you could do with more.'

'I'm not here for me,' I respond. 'And I don't need food. Not like they do.'

Her brow furrows.

'People in the slums are starving,' I explain. 'Really starving. There are children barely surviving on a meal a day. Not even that sometimes. And meanwhile, up here, we have these feasts where half the food isn't even eaten. There's so much waste. So I was wondering – hoping – if we could somehow arrange for the leftovers to be taken to the slums?'

'You want to send them half-chewed chicken legs and smears of mashed potato?' She arches an eyebrow.

'Yes. Anything and everything you have left over. Please.'

A soft sigh escapes her lips. 'I don't have the means nor the time to arrange a carriage to carry it down.'

'If you can just contact a friend of mine in the slums, he'll see it done. He'll arrange it all.' Ruben would help organise it. I *know* he would. And after all the deaths of the first trial, it would be great to have something actually worth celebrating, like starving people getting the food they deserve.

Leilah presses her lips together. 'I'll need to get someone's authority to do so. Leave it with me.'

It's not a yes, but it's not a no either. 'Thank you. I appreciate that.'

I make my way back to my room, but I still feel edgy. Rather than poring over the books from the library, the way I've done most nights, I find myself staring at the box the dagger came in, wondering if there's a clue in it. Something that will reveal more about its origin. If I can just find a symbol, then maybe I could give that to Caroline to look into. After all, it would be great if I felt comfortable enough to use it in a trial at some point, without fearing what it would do.

The box is ornately patterned with swirls and wooden inlays, but there's nothing discernible in the way of symbols or letters that I can make out. It just looks like a very pretty box.

Just as I'm about to give up, I hear the creaking of metal steps. It must be gone midnight.

My heart stutters. Has Jonas come to see if I'm up for company? He's never come up here this late before, but I can't imagine who else it would be. I stand and walk towards the door, only to stop as I hear voices. Quiet voices that don't want to be heard.

'Push it harder.'

'I'm pushing it as hard as I can.'

Zara and Mattieu, the Rowell fire wielder. I'm sure it is. There's only one reason they'd come here this late at night, and it's not because they want to snuggle.

As my throat dries I think of the ward Jonas placed on my door. I sure as hell hope he's as good at spell work as he thinks he is.

'Let me have a go,' another voice says.

How many Rowell Rettlings has she brought with her? There are five of them left. Surely, among a group of them, one of them will have enough power to undo the ward.

Nausea sweeps through me as I struggle to keep my mind straight. I'm an idiot. That's the only thought that forms, and it's far from helpful. Why didn't I take Jonas's advice? Why didn't I sleep in the dorm with the others? Why the hell did I think Zara would let me be or only attack me in the trials?

It doesn't matter that her powers have been weakened by the jötnar. If it's five against one – or even three against one – I'm as good as dead.

'Screw this,' Zara snarls after a minute. 'Just burn the place down.'

'You want me to set fire to her door?' Mattieu says, a shade incredulously. Hope flares. Maybe he won't do it.

Still, I can't rely on that. My hands are trembling as I turn in a circle, desperately searching for a way out. There're three windows, but none of them are large enough for me to fit through, and there's running water in the bathroom, but save for a solitary cup, nothing for me to carry it with. Not in the volume I'd need if fire really is in the cards.

'Yes, I want you to set fire to her fucking door,' Zara snaps. 'If I can't kill her with my bare hands, she can choke to death on smoke. Do it. Now.'

All I need is for Mattieu to have an ounce of decency in him and I'll be okay.

'I don't have much power after today,' he says weakly.

‘You’ve got enough for a fucking spark, don’t you?’ Zara snarls.

Gods, I hope he doesn’t. My breaths are ragged. So much in this room is wood. And it’s dry wood, the residual magic having ensured that not an ounce of moisture or damp gets in. The place will go up like a tinderbox. If he’s just as drained as Zara is, then maybe – maybe – there’s hope. The thought’s barely finished forming when the first tendrils of smoke billow from beneath the door. A heartbeat later, the flames take hold.

Fuck. I won’t let myself die here. I won’t. I didn’t survive fucking giants to die at the hands of a bully who doesn’t even have the patience to kill me herself.

‘You can survive this, Rose. *Think*!’

Even in the cold, fires in the slums were common. The homes were so densely packed that once one caught light, there was no chance of stopping it. But I’m not worried about keeping my home. I just want to get out of here alive.

And that I can do.

As I search around for a solution, my eyes land on the corner of the room and my heart skips a beat. I thought I had more than enough of Jonas’s stupid, overprotective nature. Now I realise it could be the thing to save me.

The sand bucket is in the same place I placed it all those days ago. It might not be enough to put the entire fire out, but it’s enough to make a dent, and that’s a lot better than nothing. I just need to make sure I can get outside.

The plan is still forming as I yank the bedsheet from the bed and throw it into the shower, blasting it with cold water. I leave it there long enough to grab my knife and sheath it in the top of my shorts, and I grab the satchel from the hiding place between the tiles. That’s all the time I’m giving myself.

Back in the bedroom, the entire door is engulfed, and flames are creeping like vines across the inside wall. Smoke is filling the space and my lungs.

It’s now or never.

I cover my entire body in the wet sheet, shield my eyes with one arm, then pick up the sand bucket and hurl it at the door.

Panic makes it a woefully shit throw.

Some of the sand goes over the flames, and it definitely subdues them a little, but nowhere near enough. I realise there's no way I'm getting out of this uninjured. It's just a case of how bad it's going to be.

'Running out of time here, Rose,' I say to myself, gritting my teeth against the pain I know is coming.

The crackle of flames is growing by the second, and they're moving too fast. I brace myself to kick at the door, only to stop.

The window is open a couple of inches. I've found myself unable to sleep in the stifling heat of the dorms, compared to the icy chill of the slums, and got into a habit of leaving it ajar. But if I open the door now, the flames will barrel inside and likely engulf me. With the air in my lungs getting thicker by the second, I rush over and pull the window closed. Then I head back to the door and once again brace myself to strike.

This time, I make contact and the door crumbles beneath my foot, sending planks of blazing wood out in front of me and producing a small gap in the centre. It's the best I'm going to get. A heartbeat later, I push myself through the flames. The heat is unbearable and the smoke scalds my lungs. It's only a matter of feet – a few steps through to the other side – and yet it's agony, the searing pain across my skin growing hotter and hotter. The roar of the blaze is so loud now that I can't hear anything else, and there's no air getting into my lungs.

It's too big, I realise. There's no way out of it. I'm going to burn to death, just like Zara hoped I would. Burn and suffocate in the smoke. A roasted runt.

'Rose! Rose!' Llinos's voice is muffled and distant. She's going to watch me die. She's going to have to watch me die. That's my last thought as I'm hit by a blast of air and tumble to the ground.



As I blink my eyes open, it's hard to ignore how well-rested I feel. Not only that, but I'm comfy, too. Like I'm lying on a soft mattress with proper pillows – the type we used to have when we lived in the High Hold and not the crazily thin specimens of the barracks. But as I stretch out, I realise it's not just the mattress and pillows that are different. It's the entire bed. Not to

mention the walls and the windows. Wide windows that flood the space with light.

The memory hits me like an axe. Zara. The fire. Llinos.

‘Thank the Gods, you’re awake.’

I push up onto my elbows. Jonas stands in the corner of the room, his face ashen.

‘Rose.’ He takes a seat on the edge of the bed. ‘Do you remember what happened? The fire, how did it start?’

‘Zara.’ My voice croaks like it’s not been used for days, though it’s probably from the effects of the smoke more than anything. ‘She got Mattieu to start it. They wanted to kill me.’

His face is thunderous.

‘I told you they’d try something like this. That you shouldn’t be sleeping on your own!’

If there’s ever been a worse time for an ‘I told you so,’ I don’t know it. If I had enough energy, I’d throw Jonas straight out of the room and tell him not to hurry back. But I don’t.

‘It’s a good job Loch heard something happening and Llinos’s powers were recovered. Otherwise it would have taken you a lot longer than a couple of days to recover. Assuming you recovered at all.’

I start to bask in gratitude for still being here, when Jonas’s words sink in.

‘A couple of days?’ I begin in a panic. ‘What do you mean, a couple of days?’ The ball. I missed the damned ball! And Kay! I slump back onto the bed, closing my eyes against the sudden hotness there. The thought of seeing Kay kept me going, and to have it ripped away like that …

‘It’s been five days, Rose. The healers did their best, but they were all pretty drained from fixing up wounds after the first trial. And it wasn’t just your bones. It was the smoke in your lungs. They worked as fast as they could, but it took time.’

I don’t doubt that the healers did everything in their power, but it doesn’t stop the tears that start to tumble. It’s stupid. I’m alive – that’s the thing I should be focusing on right now. I should be celebrating. But I can’t.

‘I missed the ball.’ My voice trembles as another tear leaks down my cheek. ‘I missed it. I missed my chance to see Kay.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 32

‘You can’t let them get away with this.’ This time, when Llinos insisted that I stay in the islanders’ room, I didn’t object. ‘You have to do something. Fight back.’

‘I will,’ I tell her. ‘Trust me, she’s going to pay for making me miss seeing my sister. Did you see her? Talk to her?’ I ask hopefully.

Llin shakes her head. ‘No, I’m sorry, Rosey. We weren’t in much of a party mood, what with you half dead and all. We showed our faces, then came back here. But I think Jonas talked to her.’

Of course he did, which is why I’ve already asked him, yet the only reply he gave was that she was ‘well.’ Not exactly the most descriptive answer.

‘So what do you have planned for Zara? Anything you want my help with?’

I shake my head. ‘No, it’ll be fine. Just going to take a little time, that’s all.’

‘Dish best served cold,’ Llinos says with understanding. ‘Say no more.’

Since I came around in the healers’ room, revenge has been the only thought strong enough to push the anguish of not seeing Kay from my mind. My first instinct was to poison Zara. Poison them all. There’s certainly enough I could use in the satchel from Dinah to do that, but I still believe that killing our opponents outside of the trials isn’t going to win Etta’s favour, given she’s the Goddess of *Life*. Thankfully, I think I’ve finally got an alternative plan I’m happy with. Which is why I’ve already made up my mind that I’m going to brew something nasty, but not deadly.

Something that takes a few days to infuse. Days I plan on spending training so that someday soon, I'll be able to kick Zara's arse.



IN A WELCOME STREAK of good fortune, the herbs and seeds from Dinah contain almost everything I need to brew my little gift for Zara. And after surreptitiously plucking a handful of bitter nightshade leaves from outside the battle yard, I have everything I need. With the ingredients gathered, I steal into an empty dorm room and set up the little stove I brought from home.

I add the nightshade leaves whole, along with a handful of the chopped stems and a variety of crushed seeds from Dinah's collection. My hands move as if by instinct, and as the contrast of aromas eddies in the air, I realise how much I've missed doing this. Not poisoning people, that is, but brewing.

This time in the High Hold is the longest I've ever gone without creating some sort of concoction, and a frisson of guilt stirs within me as I recall the promise I made to my mother that I would always take the daily tonic the way she taught – a habit I've let go of entirely since arriving here. Still, the food is so rich and varied that I'm undoubtedly getting everything my body needs. In fact, I'm sure I am. I certainly can't recall feeling stronger. It's almost odd not to have that gnawing ache in the pit of my stomach, just on the edge of starvation. My guilt intensifies at the knowledge that I have become so complacent about it, when so many are still going without. Hopefully, Leilah will get hold of Ruben, and I can start helping others a little.

Before long, Zara's potion is simmering away. It needs a few days to infuse properly, but a grim smile comes to my lips at the thought of finally getting my revenge. No one deserves a severe case of the shits more than Zara.

And who knows, once she's emptied her insides, maybe she'll be a nicer person. I laugh at the thought. There's no chance.

Ensuring the stove's heat is set as low as it can be and it's not in a position where anything could accidentally catch fire, I shut the door and

head back to the dorm room I share with the islanders for some much-needed rest. Vengeance really takes it out of you.

It's another day before I'm ready to face the battle yard, and when I do it's the coldest morning I've experienced since returning from the healers. Apparently, there were two days of snow while I was away, and vestiges of it remain on the ground.

I head outside dressed in a long-sleeved top. Though I considered taking my furs down too, I quickly decided against it, knowing as I do how training with Zelle works. Within five minutes, I'll be sweating profusely.

By the time I arrive in the yard, it's later than normal and there's no sign of Zelle. Instead, it's Holden at the helm today, standing with his arms folded across his chest as he waits for us to gather around him. My stomach drops.

'As everyone's magic is fully replenished from the trials, everyone who has magic, that is'—he looks directly at me with a sneer—'I thought it would be the perfect day for FOF of the team variety.' If I'd thought surviving the first trial would earn me his respect, I'd be sorely disappointed. Thankfully, I don't need, or even want, the respect of a man like him.

'FOF?' I ask, glancing at Jonas.

'Force on Force,' he explains. 'Group style, by the sound of things.' He turns to look at me directly. 'I know there's no point asking this, but as there's magic involved—'

'Stay out of the way?' I finish bitterly for him. 'I know your position by now, Jonas.' Still, this isn't a trial. This is a game of Holden's creation. Quite possibly purely to torture me. If I have to accept my friends' help to survive, then I'm okay with that. That's what good friends are for, right? Chats, hugs, and helping you survive megalomaniacs.

'Now, I thought it would be fun to let you pick the teams,' Holden continues, smirking viciously. 'Although it's always good to have clear team captains, don't you think? Duarte, why don't we start with you as one team captain?' His eyes go to Zara, who grins maliciously as they exchange a knowing look. Whatever is coming, they've planned this together. His gaze sweeps back across the courtyard. 'And let's have … oh, let's have Kultavaris as our other captain. Yes, that should make this interesting.'

'What the fuck?' Jonas quietly fumes beside me. 'Five days. You spent five days at the healers because of her, and now he's deliberately pitting you

against her. I'm starting to think you're right about Holden having something against you.'

Starting to? I'm not sure what more evidence he needs, but hey, it's progress.

'He's one of Korvane Knavin's men. What do you expect?' Benny mutters beside me. A flash of something flares behind Benny's eyes, only to be snuffed out in an instant, sending a strange shudder of unease down my spine.

'Right, you've got two minutes to sort out your teams. Go.'

Given who I'm up against, I expect people to flock to Zara's side, and while a few do – obviously the Rowell lot, not to mention most of the surviving Rettlings from Galreck – the others are more hesitant. Obviously, I've got Benny and co., but Holden didn't say anything about splitting the teams evenly. I'm sure he'd be more than okay with it being twenty against two, as long as I'm on the losing side.

It's with a jolt of shock that I see Grenda and Baylis come over to join us, along with Kestria and Seiren, though not Odetta – the other surviving Rettling from Dorain. I don't know why I'm still so surprised that Kestria and Seiren made it through the first trial. It's not as though I'm any stronger than they are. Odetta, on the other hand, was no surprise. She has the type of glint in her eye that reminds me more than a little of Zara, like she's in the Retterheld not only for the gifting, but also for the chance to cause pain.

The other two knights go over to Zara's group. Clearly, winning rather than morality is key to their agenda today.

'Yeva, Nessira …' Jonas calls the remaining two Wrohelm Rettlings over, and thankfully they agree. The resulting groups are far more even than I expected. Twelve against thirteen. Though in terms of fighting, I'm not sure how much that helps us, especially because they've got Zara and Mattieu, who can both inflict serious damage. I know Jonas says Yeva's incredibly powerful, but we need ash for her to wield. And if Seiren could envelop us in one of her illusions, that would definitely help, but so far, I've never seen her do it deliberately.

'How do we beat them, Benny?' I hiss to him. 'What can we do?'

'I don't know …' His voice has an unusual quake to it. 'I'm not sure. Not until I know what their tactics are.'

'They just want to kill Rose.' Loch shrugs.

I turn to look at the other islander. I swear, every day his skin becomes more and more drained, his eyes more and more vacant.

‘That’s their only plan. They just want Rose dead.’

A weight settles in my stomach and my pulse rises. He’s speaking so matter-of-factly, as if talking about what he ate for breakfast. Saying the quiet part out loud – that this isn’t a team battle; it’s an excuse for them to end me.

I’m trying to push the fear down, but it’s hard when my gut says I’m totally screwed.

‘Fantastic. So, rules.’ Holden flashes me a smirk, like he already knows he’s signed my death warrant. ‘You stay on your feet, or you’re out. That simple. You can be brought to your knees, your back … I should probably warn against purposely trying to send people to Mortidem, but accidents happen.’ His smirk grows into a grin.

Llinos gasps beside me.

My teeth are gritted as I look Holden in the eye, determined not to show even a hint of the fear that roils in me.

‘First team with everyone down loses. We will begin on my countdown.’

‘I can put a shield around us,’ Llinos hisses hastily. ‘Wind-based. Not sure how much it will protect from certain powers, but it should prevent some of the fire from reaching you.’

I’m grateful that my friends aren’t even trying to pretend the aim of this task is to win. No, our objective is completely different. It’s to keep me alive.

‘I’ll aim at Zara,’ Jonas says. ‘It should make it more difficult for her to attack you.’

‘It would be better if I bind her.’ Kestria is now standing at my side. I didn’t even see her appear. ‘I heard what they did. I get what this is. If I bind her, she won’t be able to do anything.’

‘You’re a siphon?’ I ask in surprise.

‘A bind. Similar but not quite the same. And I can only work on one person at a time.’

‘It’ll make you a target,’ I warn her. ‘The others will come for you if they know you’re the one stopping Zara from using her magic.’

‘Yeah.’ Kestria shrugs. ‘It’s the same for Jonas and anyone else who tries to help. I’m fine with this. Just do me a favour and make sure one of

you gets Odetta to her knees.’

‘Done,’ Benny promises.

I don’t know what her vendetta is against the Dorain Rettling, nor do I need to. She’s on our side.

‘I’ve got daggers,’ Grenda says, seeming unperturbed by what we face. ‘I’ll stick to tried and trusted methods.’

I shoot Benny a glance and see his jaw tick. I know he’s been desperate to know exactly what her powers are since we got here, but it doesn’t look like today’s going to be the day he finds out.

Holden is now walking away from us, clearing the battle yard so he doesn’t get caught in the crossfire. ‘Now, if you’re all ready, we will still start on my whistle and end when all of one team is on the ground. Three, two—’

‘Fuck!’ I drop straight to my knees as my most recent injury flares back to life. I should have known the bitch wouldn’t wait until it was actually time to start. The first burn begins to rise on my arm, and I wait for it to spread across my entire body. But there’s nothing. Just that single patch.

‘I’ve got her!’ Kestria yells to me.

In terms of Holden’s game, it doesn’t mean anything. I’m already on the ground. Out of it. For a naïve second, I think it’s going to be enough for them to stop attacking me. I’m wrong.

The first fireball lands only inches from where I’ve dropped.

I’m down on the ground, yes, but apparently I’m not out.

Well then. With Mattieu in my sights, I pull a dagger from its sheath and prepare to throw it at the fire wielder, only for him to blast me again as the dagger leaves my hand. It lands uselessly two feet from him.

‘Shit!’ I mutter as he prepares his next attack. ‘Llin!’ I yell out. ‘Mattieu!’

‘Sorry! Bit slow there.’

She moves to take a place in front of me, giving her a better chance of blocking me from Mattieu’s power. When two blasts come for me simultaneously, she shoots me a worried look.

‘Who the hell’s doing that?’ Llin asks.

‘Odetta!’ Kestria shouts back. ‘It’s Odetta.’

Odetta’s also a fucking flame wielder. Great. With her, Mattieu, and Zara, that’s three strong, offensive powers against us. Or rather, against me. Some of the Rettlings on the opposing team are actually trying to fight a

fair game and focusing their attention on other members of our group. But not enough.

One of the Galreck Rettlings is a wind weaver and is pushing Llin with all her force, while another one is in a fistfight with Baylis. Blood is smeared over both of them already, though who it's coming from, I can't tell.

'Got them!' Grenda shouts, throwing two daggers simultaneously into the shoulders of the Galreck Rettlings. It stops the wind weaver, but not the one fighting Baylis. The way he barely flinches, it's like he can't even feel pain. As I watch on, my chest tightens. Not just from fear, but also something more. My throat is burning and my lungs are struggling to get any air in. It's as though they're filling with smoke all over again.

'Zara!' I cough the word out. 'Zara.'

'I'm losing her! I'm losing my bind on the bitch!' Kestria's shout is far more effective at conveying what I was trying to say.

'What else have we got?' Jonas cries as he turns in circles. He's been alternating his powers between blinding Mattieu and Odetta, but it's getting less and less effective – not because he's weakening, but because they somehow don't need to see to know where to aim to hit me. 'Seiren! Can you do something? We need help!'

We're losing. I can see it. My friends are fighting with all they have, using force, fury, and fists.

And I'm hiding behind them. The one thing I told myself I'd never do in this competition.

I need to be doing *something*. I need to help. But every time I unsheathe a dagger, I have to duck again before I can get a damn throw in.

'Yeva!' I can hear the hopelessness in Jonas's voice. He's trying to lead, but he's failing. 'Can you do something here?'

'Nothing while these wind weavers keep blowing all the flames out!' she yells back.

Ash. We need ash.

'Yeva! Yeva!' It takes more than one yell for me to grab her attention as she's fighting Elenor from Rowell. 'How much ash do you need to cause some damage?'

'How much? Anything,' she replies. 'Anything's better than nothing.'

'Hold on. I've got it.'

I've been crouching this entire time, trying to give my attackers as little area as possible to aim for, but now I need to change that.

I push up onto my knees and strip my top off. The cold bites at my skin, but right now that's the least of my worries.

'Llin, when I say, I need you to let one of the blasts come past you,' I instruct her.

'What?' She swivels to look at me for just a millisecond; more than long enough for me to see the worry on her face. 'You're joking, right?'

'Don't worry. I'll be prepared. Just keep me covered for one more sec.' I lift my arms above my head and wrestle with my top. 'Okay, Llin. Let me know when it's coming.'

There's not a heartbeat before she screams, 'Incoming now!'

I plummet, landing face-first into the sand while simultaneously throwing my top into the air. Just as I hoped, it ignites and disintegrates into flames. It burns hot, and in moments, it's ash.

'That enough for you to work with?' I ask Yeva, who has just landed an impressive punch to Elenor's jaw, sending her down and out.

'It's a damned good start.'

She lifts her hand, and the cloud of ash rises into the air, swirling and thickening. Jonas wasn't joking. It's incredible what she can do. With a rush of air, she sends it across the yard, straight towards the eyes of half a dozen Rettlings. Hope flutters in my chest, but then their wind weaver spots what's about to happen. Before we even have time to blink, the ash is blown back at us.

'Fuck!' Yeva begins gathering the cinders together again, but clearly it's tougher when the ash is scattered everywhere.

I'm not the only one on my knees now. Kestria and Seiren are both down, as are Baylis and Loch. We've only brought three of theirs down – including, by some small miracle, Odetta – and Jonas has now taken over battling Zara. He's blinding her so she can't use her powers on me, but he's also having to fight against two other Rettlings at the same time. And I'm still bloody well crouching here.

I scan the yard, desperate to see a solution I haven't yet thought of, but what I actually see is a figure striding towards the field of battle. Fuck. If things weren't bad before, they sure as hell are now.

Kyor swaggers towards us. He's never shown up for training when he's supposed to – princely privileges – and now that he's finally arrived, all he

needs to do is join Zara's team and I'm as good as dead.

'What's going on?' he asks, voicing his question to no one in particular as he strolls into the centre of the fray.

'Bring the other team to their knees.' It's Loch who replies. No doubt Kyor's voice is clearer to him than to the rest of us.

'Or Mortidem,' Holden calls from a safe distance away. 'Whichever takes your fancy.'

From the sneer on his lips, Holden clearly thinks his 'joke' is amusing, yet Kyor remains impassive, scanning the yard coolly, like we aren't all battling as hard as we did against the fucking jötnar.

Kyor's assessment, when it's delivered, is cool and completely on the money. 'All of this just to kill Kultavaris?' His gaze lands on Zara. 'You give her too much power.'

It's unclear to me whether he means me or Zara.

'Well, then,' he says, as if he's made up his mind, 'just bring them to their knees, is it?' he asks casually.

A burst of pain across my shoulder makes me realise I should be paying more attention to what I'm doing rather than staring at the prince. Yet it's hard to draw my eyes away as he kicks off his shoes and digs his feet into the sand.

Over on the other team, someone screams and drops to the ground with one of Grenda's knives in their side. I barely notice. My eyes are trained on Kyor, breath quivering as I wait to see what he'll do.

Oblivious to the battle unravelling around him, he presses his palms close together, as if in prayer, before reaching one hand up into the air.

The effect is instant. Green-tinged clouds sweep in and forks of lightning streak down from the sky, cracking through the air with such force that a rumble loud enough to shake the arc wall thunders through the yard. The entire atmosphere reverberates with the charge from the lightning that sinks into the ground, radiating under all our feet.

No one can hold themselves against it. Every single person drops to the ground.

Everyone except Kyor.

Silence engulfs the yard, every pair of eyes on the prince. A single bead of sweat weaves down his forehead as he remains perfectly motionless, other than the slightest coil at the corner of his mouth.

'I win,' he says simply to Holden.

The trainer’s cheeks pull inwards and he offers Kyor something between a smile and a grimace.

‘Very impressive, Your Royal Highness, as always.’

Kyor scoffs, and it’s with a sense of satisfaction that I realise he cares as much about Holden’s compliments as I do.

‘I guess that means training’s done for the day,’ Kyor notes. Still standing, he surveys the rest of the Rettlings with narrowed eyes. ‘Looks like the healers will be busy again,’ he says. When his eyes land on me, his icy gaze locks on my eyes before travelling down towards my chest.

Only then do I remember. I burned my top so Yeva could have ash to fight with, and now I’m out here in nothing but a black bra. Sweat drips down my skin, flowing over the beginnings of the burns reignited by Zara’s powers. I should shrink away from his gaze, but I don’t. Instead, I push my shoulders back. I’ve got nothing to be ashamed of.

‘I prefer this look on you,’ he says, his eyes offering the slightest hint of a twinkle before he sobers. ‘Everyone clear out. I want the battle yard.’

The ringing command in his voice cannot be ignored, and we all scramble inside.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 33

I wake in pitch-black darkness the next morning, Loch's indistinct muttering resonating through the room. Trying my hardest not to wake anyone, I rummage around for my clothes. My choices are limited after half my wardrobe was sent up in flames by the Rowell Rettlings.

I hope Zelle will be ready to train me today. The fiasco yesterday with Holden only served to underline that, at the very least, I need to improve my proficiency with weapons.

Still bleary-eyed, I head into the battle yard, but as I approach the weapons cache, it's not Zelle who waits for me, but Kyor.

'What are you doing here?' The words are out of my mouth before I can stop them.

'I said I'd train you. Zelle's out, so I'm in. Have you eaten?'

'At this time of morning? No.'

'You need energy to spar. Eat before you come next time. Something light, but something. Now.' His eyes glitter in the darkness. 'Let's see if that footwork of yours has got any better.'

I don't even try to stop my groan. I'm truly beginning to despise footwork. Though somehow my body seems to be recalling the training from my youth, my conscious thoughts and memories of them are hazy, like a veil has been drawn over the forms.

'Your stance is too narrow.' He glares at me as I crouch into position. 'And you need to be more side-on.'

I shift myself slightly, and he sniffs.

'Better. Now come for me.' He swings a seax, the small fighting dagger whirling casually in his hand.

‘Without a weapon?’ I question.

‘Until you can show me your feet know what they’re doing, yes.’

I lunge towards him, which feels insane without a weapon. Not that I think it would help me. It feels like every other move I make, he’s correcting something, from the position of my shoulders to the angle of my back foot. I know it’s needed, but by the Gods, why does it always have to be footwork? After ten minutes he tells me to grab a seax blade of my own, though I don’t know whether my footwork actually got better or if he’s just bored and wants to change it up.

‘You know the aim is to hit me?’ He smirks as he sidesteps another of my strikes. A couple have landed close to his body, though he blocked them easily using the short length of his blade. If he had a shield, too, I wouldn’t stand a chance.

By the time Kyor calls an end to our session, I’m sweating profusely. With my muscles burning, I go to replace the sword in the cabinet, only for his hand to grab hold of my wrist.

‘It doesn’t go there.’

As I turn, I find myself only inches away from him. My chest is heaving and sweat beads on my skin as his eyes hold mine with unwavering ease. We’re too damned close. Our fingers brush as he takes the sword from me, and a spark of something sizzles between us. I catch my breath.

His eyes miss nothing. ‘You might well hate me, Thorn,’ he murmurs, closing the already minimal distance between us, ‘but you want me too.’

He’s not wrong, but I’ll deny it to my dying breath.

I swallow hard. ‘Gods, you’re an asshole. Has anyone ever told you that you’re ridiculously arrogant?’

He smiles at that, and I hate that I like the curve of his lips and the way my gaze involuntarily traces it. Gods forgive me, but it’s hard to deny they look so damned kissable.

‘Many times,’ he says easily, ‘but that doesn’t mean I’m not right.’ He leans in so that there’s barely a hair’s breadth between us. My lungs seize. If he kisses me now, I don’t know what I’ll do. Hit him, that’s for sure, but maybe not until I check whether he tastes as good as I imagine he does. My eyes fall closed as I try to push the ridiculous thought from my head, and I notice the sudden lightness in my hand. When I open my eyes again, Kyor has the sword that I held only moments ago firmly in his grasp and a smirk on his lips.

‘It goes here.’ As he slides the seax into position in the cabinet, his eyes don’t move off mine. ‘You look a little flustered, Thorn. Perhaps you could do with a shower to cool off. I could always help scrub your back, if you’d like?’

‘You know I hate you, right?’ I whisper.

‘That’s what would make it feel so good.’

His laughter follows me out of the battle yard as I all but sprint away, and I hate him a tiny bit more.



‘I KNOW WE ALL HATE HIM,’ Kestria says, ‘but we can admit that what he did yesterday was incredibly hot, right?’ A bond was forged in yesterday’s battle, and Kestria and Seiren have moved over to our table for meals. Seiren is sitting at the far end with Loch, and though it would be unfair to call it the weird end of the table, the way they both stare off into the ether, only occasionally dropping in a comment, doesn’t exactly scream normal. Still, I can’t imagine what it was like for Loch. What it must have been like to be able to hear everything on the beach – every scream, every gargling, blood-filled last breath, every pained cry from the dying as crystal clear to him as the chiming of a bell.

‘Why do you hate him?’ I ask. I’m happy to expand the club of people who detest Kyor, but I’d like to know their reasons. Other than Estel, I assumed I was the only one with a direct cause to hate him personally, as I’m pretty sure that Llinos and Benny just hate him out of loyalty, and Jonas is too much of a sycophant to actually say anything outright against the future monarch.

‘Other than his arrogance?’ Kestria questions. ‘I’ve heard stuff about some of the battles he led up by Agoyd. So many people died, and the statements given out by him and the palace about what happened just don’t match up with what people on the ground said.’

‘You mean he lied to cover his own back?’ A dry laugh crackles from my throat. ‘Sounds like Kyor.’

‘To be honest, I’m wondering why Etta bothered letting anyone else into the trials,’ she says. ‘I can’t imagine there’s any way to defeat him. That man has no weaknesses. Physically, anyway.’

I’d love to say I hadn’t noticed, but that just wouldn’t be true. He is a damn fine specimen of a human, and though I try not to think about it while I’m awake, sleep’s a different matter. It’s embarrassing the number of times he’s slipped into my dreams, though what’s more embarrassing are the things I’ve let him do to me in them. It’s just a trauma response, I’m sure. Trauma and sexual frustration.

Across the table, Llinos lets out a yawn. Immediately, Benny shoots her a look.

‘Please don’t tell us you’re tired. You wouldn’t be if you and Caz had stopped talking before three o’clock in the morning. How the hell you can still have stuff to catch up on is beyond me.’

‘Caz? I don’t think I know them,’ Kestria remarks.

‘Yeah, might be best to forget you heard the name,’ Benny replies, a hint of a threat there.

Silence swells around us, and though I don’t know why, I could swear there’s a tension undulating between Llinos and Benny that’s about more than a lack of sleep.

‘Why are you guys even still sharing?’ Kestria evidently senses it too and breaks the moment. I haven’t spent much time with the Dorainian, but the more I do, the more I like her. ‘There are plenty of dorms free now. Couldn’t you split? Boys and girls or something?’

‘There’s safety in numbers,’ Benny replies without pausing for so much as a beat. ‘I prefer that we all stay together.’

‘And what does everyone else think about that?’

‘They’re happy to go with whatever I think is best.’

Kestria tilts her head to the side, and I know she’s thinking the same as I am. It’s easy to see why the Rettlings from Rowell follow Zara. She’s the most vicious by a long way, and her powers have an unpredictability to them that makes her just as dangerous as someone like Mattieu. But Benny? Sure, he’s a brilliant fighter, and I get that the islanders are down to only three of them now, but it was the same even when Jai was around. And in a one-on-one fight between the two, I’m not sure I’d have placed my wager on Benny.

‘Well, I just hope we’ve got Zelle back in charge today.’ Benny makes a clear attempt to shift the conversation.

‘No,’ I sigh. ‘He’s not back, or at least he wasn’t this morning.’

Kestria looks at me wide-eyed. ‘You were up early.’

‘I have a lot to learn.’

Benny’s frowning. ‘That’s two days he’s been gone now. Where do you think he went?’

Despite the assertion they gave us at the ceremony of inauguration that either Holden or Zelle would be in the battle yard at all times when we’re training, it’s Commander Zelle who’s been most consistently there. Thank the Gods, considering it’s been his siphon powers that have protected me from incidents like yesterday. Not to mention Holden himself. In fact, now that I think of it, I can’t remember a single day when I’ve not seen Zelle there at some point or another. Two whole days off feels unheard of, though undoubtedly deserved.

‘Maybe he went to see his family,’ Seiren remarks. ‘I mean, he has got a family, hasn’t he?’

‘No idea.’ The rest of us look at each other with equally blank expressions.

‘The prince is the only son Zelle considers himself to have.’

Our eyes swivel to the end of the table, where Loch is pushing food around his plate as he stares at nothing.

‘What was that, buddy?’ Benny says. His tone with Loch is growing more and more childlike despite their ages. Though this time, when Loch looks back at us, it’s with perfect clarity in his eyes.

‘Zelle thinks of the prince as his son. He knows about the prince’s marks. The marks. The marks. He knows about the marks.’

And just like that, we’ve lost him again. Tension swirls around us. Easy, laughter-filled meals feel like a thing of the past.

‘Any chance some of you could grab me some food from dinner this evening?’ Llinos’s perky tone does little to hide the strain beneath. ‘Caroline isn’t working, so we thought we’d spend some time together.’

‘I’m starting to worry that you two are distracting each other,’ Benny snaps. ‘You’ve both got jobs to do, remember?’

Llinos’s eyes narrow and her tone is sharp when she speaks. ‘I don’t need reminding of what I’ve got to do. Nor does Caz. And from what Loch’s been saying in his sleep, you’ve got your own job to worry about. So maybe you should focus on that.’

I’ve not managed to pick up on anything in Loch’s ramblings, but clearly Llin’s hit a nerve as Benny’s jaw clicks and he throws Loch a quick glance. The tension has shifted to a point where I daren’t even breathe. Yet

before I can work out how to break it, Benny lets out a scoff and rolls his eyes.

‘You’re right. I do,’ he says. ‘Make sure one of us wins the Retterheld. And with the way our numbers are dwindling, I guess I need to double down. Don’t worry though. I’ll bring you and Caz some food. After I’ve been training.’

With that, he pushes back his chair and strides away. Ouch.



‘SO WHAT WAS THAT THIS MORNING?’ Kestria asks as she sweeps out at my legs, hoping to knock me down. She fails. I already predicted her move and so I hook my foot around her ankle instead, bringing her down to the ground with a thud.

I have no plan to move into one of the empty rooms, but they do provide an extra space to train in, and the moment I saw Zelle was once again missing from the battle yard, I decided not to risk facing Holden again. Kestria kindly offered to come and train with me.

She’s one of the few Rettlings I can fully hold my own against. In fact, I’d actually say I’ve got the upper hand in a lot of situations, but it’s not something I’d rub her nose in. It’s not her fault that her training is frequently derailed by sudden needs to babysit Seiren.

She continues, ‘There was some serious tension there. Are those two always like that? I thought they were friends?’

‘I think it’s come from spending too much time together.’ I try to sound as nonchalant as possible, though the truth is, I don’t believe it. Things have been bubbling between the two since Caroline came back on the scene, and I can’t help but wonder if it’s jealousy on Benny’s part. Or maybe just annoyance that Llin’s not focusing all her attention on the Retterheld.

‘They’ve been together since the boat over,’ I tell Kestria, trying to make my lie as convincing as possible, ‘and sleeping in the same dorm room. They’ve also lost a lot of people, including Suan, who Zara killed on the very first day here simply because she thought her power didn’t have a place in the Retterheld.’

Kestria nods solemnly. ‘The whisperer? I heard about that.’

‘Yeah, she and Loch were close. I think he took it the hardest.’

Kestria smiles with sad understanding. ‘I guess it gets pretty tough. Funny choices, though, the Eastern Isles Rettlings. One who can hear for miles, one who can – could – send messages on the wind. It’s like they came for a lot more than fighting, don’t you think?’ she asks pointedly.

I haven’t actually thought of it, but Kestria’s right; put Suan’s and Loch’s powers together and they’re an incredibly powerful combination for information gathering.

‘So what about you?’ I say, wanting to shift the conversation. ‘What’s the situation with you and Seiren? You two seem close.’

Kestria smiles, although there’s a sadness to her expression. ‘She’s incredible. Really. You’ve seen what her powers do. Before the battles, she was the most formidable woman you’d ever meet. She would put on these events, not just for the tower, but all around, where she’d turn the sky into massive rainbows or fill the whole of Dorain with trees and birds. Gods, the birds were crazy! The number of accidents that damn illusion caused …’ She lets out a brief chuckle that fades too soon. ‘My mother used to say a fraction less power would have been a blessing for Seiren. That way, she’d never have been forced to fight. But she was. And everyone said the same thing: when she came back, she was changed.’

‘I’m sorry. That’s awful. Can I ask what happened with Odetta?’

Kestria’s expression hardens. ‘Odetta wants power because she wants to lord that power over people. Her brother controls Korvane’s troops in Dorain. If I had to bet, I’d say she wants to take that role from him. Not to mention a chunk more power.’

‘And you?’ I ask, unable to keep the question in any longer. ‘What do you want the gifting for?’

At some point, we stopped fighting. I’m not exactly sure when, but we’re both on our feet, weapons by our side.

It’s a personal question to ask, and not one person has directly told me their answer. I don’t expect Kestria to be any different, yet as she lets out a long sigh, I feel like she actually wants to tell me.

‘I don’t know,’ she admits. ‘And that’s not me being coy or mysterious or anything. I really don’t. I thought that if I got in, then Etta would have a reason for choosing me, and then at some point the reason I needed the gifting would become known. That probably sounds crazy to you, doesn’t it? Risking my life without even having a reason.’

‘A little,’ I concede. ‘But not the bit about the answer coming to you. That feels just like Aitara deciding she needed to bring her six children forth, right? One minute she was on her own, and the next the world had seven Gods. Maybe living your way, acting on the signs you’re given, is a better way of doing things.’

Did Etta give me a sign, I wonder? Did I choose the right path? Kay has been here for weeks now, living in the High Hold with Artur and his wards, and I have no idea how she’s doing. I can only imagine how Lora and the other nobles are treating her. It makes me physically nauseous.

‘You wanna stop?’ Kestria’s voice brings me back to the moment. ‘Still got a couple of hours until dinner.’

‘No, I’m good. Let’s keep going. I need to work on those high shots.’

‘Then I’m your person for that.’

Training with Kestria isn’t a touch on training with Zelle and Kyor, but it helps my muscle mass and my stamina, and it sure as hell beats training with Holden. We keep going until darkness falls, only stopping when the smells of food and the sounds of clattering plates rise from downstairs. Kestria, worrying about how long she’s been without checking on Seiren, heads out, and we agree to meet at dinner.

I go to clean up, but rather than using the bathroom I share with the others, I grab my things from the dorm and check my infusion. I’m pleased to see it is the right hue of purple. It needs another week or so before the final addition will change it to a colourless liquid, and then it will be as potent as I want. I shower and luxuriate in the hot water. I will never get used to it and will never take it for granted the way I once did.

As I dry myself off, I study my bruised body. Kestria got a few good shots in, and to save the healers trouble, I use some of the salves I got after the FOF fight. I should really be making my own, just like I should be making and taking the tonic my mother insisted we drink daily, but at the end of each day I barely have enough energy for a conversation, let alone to start brewing. Besides, with that level of exhaustion, I’d almost certainly mess something up, and it’s not as if I need the tonic’s benefits now that I’m eating better than I’ve done in nearly a decade.

By the time I’m dry and dressed, the only person at our normal table is Jonas, and most of the food’s been cleared away.

‘Hey, I was about to come and look for you,’ he says, pushing a plate over to me. ‘Didn’t know what you’d want, so I saved you a bit of

everything.’

‘Thank you so much!’ I grab the cutlery and gratefully tuck in. ‘I didn’t realise I’d been so long. Hot water. I still can’t get over how much I’ve missed it.’

A hint of a smile ghosts across his lips and for a second I assume he’s about to say something, but he merely shakes his head and remains silent.

‘You okay?’ I ask in between bites.

‘Yeah. I was just thinking about you and Kay. You know I spoke to her at the ball.’

Her name causes me to tense. ‘Yes, you told me. You said she was well.’

He nods. ‘Actually, she was better than well. She looked … she looked like she really fitted in here. Like a real noble.’

Irritation rises and a prickle runs down my spine. ‘She *is* a real noble, Jonas. She was born here, remember?’

‘No, yes, sorry, I didn’t mean it as …’ He shakes his head and looks upwards as if asking the Gods for their help. Maybe he *should* ask Etta for the gift of thinking before he speaks. It’s certainly not the first time I’ve thought he’d benefit from it.

‘Whatever happens, I don’t want you and Kay to have to go back to the slums.’

‘You and me both.’

‘The next time I see my father, I’m going to ask him about it. See if there’s a way. I don’t know how it would work as the king has to approve all wards. And I’m not sure he really appreciated who Kay was when she arrived here, but he sure as hell knows who you are. Still, there’ll be another way. I’m sure of it. A way we can make sure you never have to go back.’

A warmth spreads out from my chest. This damn boy. One minute he has me wanting to throttle him; the next second, I could kiss him.

‘Thank you,’ I whisper, feeling a sudden rise in my pulse.

Jonas smiles. ‘You know, we’ve still not had the conversation I wanted to have with you.’

‘We haven’t?’

I can’t even remember what that conversation was supposed to be about.

‘Maybe later, if you’ve got time.’

‘You don’t want to have it here?’

He glances around the room to the other figures still sitting at the tables, though they're few and far between. 'No, it can wait.'

His lips twitch and I wonder if he's about to say more when he's interrupted by the sound of my stomach growling.

'Maybe I should let you eat,' he says, grinning. 'I was going to go do some training with Yeva anyway.'

'I'll be fine.' I nod across to the far end of the hall. 'Grenda's still here. She won't let Zara try anything.'

'Okay. See you later?'

'Possibly.' I'm not going to make promises I can't keep, and I don't think I'm in the mood for a deep heart-to-heart tonight.

I watch as Jonas walks towards the door and out into the battle yard. He really does have a good body, and the memory of him shirtless lingers in my mind for a full ten seconds, until it's interrupted by something – or rather someone – else.

Kyor has come up from the stairs by the kitchen, and all he's dressed in is a pair of fighting leathers. No shirt. No shoes. But for once it's not his shoulders, or arms, or any other part of his body that holds my attention. It's the way he's walking. Head down, warily glancing around him. He has *sneaking about* written all over his forehead, like I used to when I constantly got targeted by pickpockets in the market.

Kyor Knavin doesn't want anyone to see where he's going.

Which is why I leave my plate exactly where it is and follow him.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 34

I follow Kyor as he sneaks through the eastern arc. With every step I try to ignore the drumming in my chest telling me this is a bad idea.

There are two places he could be going. Either he's going to leave the High Hold – which is forbidden for Rettlings, but I'm sure an exception would be made for him – or he's heading to the guards' temple. But if he's going to the latter, I don't see why he'd be acting like a thief in the night.

Grateful for the clouds that cover the moon and the practice I've had at going unseen, honed through many nights spent skulking through the slums, I trail him from a distance, watching as he passes the gate that leads out of the eastern arc and keeps walking towards the temple.

Maybe he feels embarrassed about needing to pray? I chew my lip and keep following.

Other than the shadow of darkness, there's not a lot to keep me hidden, no trees or buildings to duck behind, so I wait, keeping as much distance between us as I can. At one point, he slows his pace and I hastily turn around, but when I glance back I see him striding once more towards the temple and slipping through the doors. I quicken my pace to follow.

'What are you doing, Rose?' I mutter to myself. 'Do you really need to watch Kyor pray?'

At best, it's obsessive. At worst … I don't want to think about it. What I should be doing is heading upstairs, finding Jonas's new room, and getting thoroughly distracted from any ridiculous thoughts about Kyor Knavin.

I purposely remind myself of his surname, of who his father is, of who *he* is.

I need to see what he's doing, whether that's praying or something else. And I couldn't care less if he's using the temple as some sort of hook-up site, though who would be bold enough to fuck in the temple of the Gods, I don't know.

And now I'm definitely *not* imagining him pinning me down on the altar …

Gods help me.

As the temple door slams shut, I'm faced with the issue of what to do next. I can't go in after him without being discovered, that's for sure. So it's time for a little climb.

The windows are only one storey up. I'll take a quick look to satisfy my curiosity, and then I'll be done. I'll go back to Jonas, the sensible choice to spend my evening with.

I find a foothold and shift myself up, discovering I couldn't have picked a better window. It offers a clear view into the centre of the temple with only the far end obscured. Whatever Kyor is doing in here, I should be able to see it.

I crane my neck, finally spotting a figure standing in the shadows. Only it's not Kyor. It's Zelle.

'What are you doing, Commander?' I murmur.

There's something about the way Zelle is standing and the way his gaze is constantly flickering around that makes me think he shouldn't be here. But why? I've seen him use this very temple for prayer before. What could the pair be meeting about that they'd be desperate to keep hidden?

A chill runs through me as the answer strikes.

Zelle said he didn't know what the trials would be. But what if that wasn't true? What if he's meeting Kyor here to tell him what the second trial will entail? Or when it's going to take place? What if the entire reason for this rendezvous is for the commander to give the man he thinks of as a son an advantage in the trials?

A mixture of annoyance and something else flares through me. I'd expect this from the prince, but I feel genuinely disappointed in Zelle as I've actually got no small amount of affection for the man.

'Zelle … what is this?' As he steps out of the shadows, Kyor's voice cuts through the silence with an edge I don't recognise. Concern? 'Where have you been? Why didn't you tell me you were leaving?'

'I thought you needed a little pick-me-up,' the old man replies.

‘Me? What do you mean?’

‘I mean, I saw the way you were struggling without her, and I decided to do something about it.’

‘Oh, Zelle …’ Kyor’s voice drops. ‘Tell me you didn’t. The rules …’

‘I know what you’re going to say but hear me out—’

‘There are other knights in the barracks. My knights. This isn’t fair to them.’ The tightness in Kyor’s voice is nothing like I’ve ever heard from him before. Actual anguish? Surely not.

And yet Zelle seems to have relaxed now that they’re together. He waves a hand dismissively at Kyor’s concerns. ‘This was entirely my choice, and if it comes to it, I’ll own up. But don’t worry. No one’s seen her. We got her in just fine. Now, are you going to spend your time chastising me, or is there someone else you’d rather be talking to?’

A woman. Zelle has snuck in a woman for Kyor?

The image of another woman on the altar with Kyor rips through my imagination and I find myself unaccountably furious at the thought. He flirts with me at every session – just a little, a touch here or there, but it’s not insignificant – and the whole time he’s had a woman who he cares enough about for Zelle to smuggle her in?

I’m hurt, I realise, and that is more than a little ridiculous. Kyor and I *hate* each other. We’re enemies. Foes. And the thought of him trailing his hands up another woman’s arm, the way he does mine when he corrects my hold on a sword, is absolutely *fine*.

I’m so lost in my internal diatribe that it takes me several long moments before I realise it’s not a woman at all.

Zelle has brought Kyor his dire wolf.

And she is magnificent.

She is pressing herself happily against Kyor, leaving another wolf standing alone. *Zelle’s,* I realise with shock as the other wolf goes to nuzzle the old man. To train the Rettlings, Zelle’s also been giving up time with his wolf. Knowing that, I appreciate his early training sessions with me all the more. He has been leaving his wolf stationed somewhere else so as not to rub Kyor’s and the other knights’ faces in their loss. And it *is* a loss I realise, as I watch Zelle and his wolf together, their eyes alight with joy as they fuss over each other.

I tear my eyes from Zelle to study Kyor and his wolf. Her fur is jet-black across her face and back, fading to deep grey over her hindquarters,

and then lighter still down her legs until her paws, which are almost white.

It's not that I haven't seen dire wolves before – the knights stationed at the gates here still have theirs; it's that there's something different about Kyor's wolf. And not just because she's *huge*. She's not here patrolling, ready to attack anyone who breaks the king's rule. She's here for him. For Kyor. Who no longer looks like the prince I know. It takes me a heartbeat to understand what's different.

He's smiling.

It's not a smirk or a sneer. No, this smile is broad, and it brightens his entire face. Even his icy eyes are transformed into something warm. Something full of love. He kneels beside the phenomenal beast, rubbing her fur like she's nothing more than a lapdog.

'Gods, I have missed you, El. How's it been, my beautiful Elska?'

She responds with a bound, placing her feet on his shoulders as she nuzzles him. Jaws like hers could crunch his skull in a heartbeat, and yet there's zero fear in his face. Instead, he wraps his arms around her like the two of them are about to dance.

With his hands still deep in the animal's fur, he looks at Zelle, a weak attempt at a scowl gracing his face.

'I'm still fucking furious,' he growls. 'You know I hate breaking the rules.'

Zelle grins back. 'You needed a reminder of what you're fighting for.'

Kyor scoffs as he turns back to Elska, who continues to lick his cheek. 'As if I could forget,' he says, his voice so soft and full of love that it punches into my gut. I'm intruding on an intensely personal moment I have no business watching, yet I can't quite tear my eyes away. Seeing Kyor look so full of love makes my guts writhe with a feeling I refuse to name.

As I watch, momentarily forgetting that I'm nine feet up, my foot slides against the stones and my pulse rushes. I catch myself almost instantly, but Elska's face swings towards me and my blood runs cold.

'What is it, girl?' Kyor's voice is sharp and loud enough to hear even as I scramble down the side of the temple.

Fuck, fuck, fuckity fuck.

My heart has lodged itself in my throat. If the dire wolf decides to come after me, I'm screwed, I think as I break into a sprint. She won't risk being seen though, right? Kyor will stop her from tracking me down and following my scent, right? Probably? Ugh. I stop my mind from whirring

and run. Dire wolves can mind-speak with their bonded, but can she send him images? Show him she saw *me?* If she even did see me. Maybe she didn't.

Please, Etta, keep me safe from that wolf!

I don't break my stride all the way back to the barracks, and when I arrive in the dining hall, my lungs throb from exertion and my pulse batters my rib cage. It's only when I'm halfway up the staircase that my breathing gets almost back to normal.

I don't know why, but I've already decided not to tell anyone what I saw. Not because I give a shit about Kyor potentially getting in trouble, but because of Zelle. I like him. And dammit, he's been training me every day. If I tell anyone, Zelle might get moved somewhere else. I'm not keeping Kyor's secret for *them*, but for me. That's all. Just some good old human self-interest. Nothing else to it.

I'm a few feet away from my dorm room when I hear raised voices, and the Kyor incident is washed from my mind in favour of listening to Benny's rage-filled shouts.

'You are putting us all at risk. Don't you see that?' His words are harsh and clipped.

Llinos's voice is just as sharp as she replies, 'Oh, you mean like you've put Caroline at risk for the four years she's been placed here?'

'I didn't make that decision!' he snaps. 'I don't know how many times I have to say it for you to believe me. I had nothing to do with it.' There's a moment of tense silence and then Benny's sigh is so loud that it reverberates through the door. 'Please, see my way of thinking. Our plan has gone to shit. We have to rethink our strategy.'

'No. No, I don't agree with that. I agreed to the original plan.'

'But that won't work anymore! Losing Suan screwed us. You know that. And I promise I've been trying to figure out a way we can do this without her. It's all I've been trying to do. But with Jai and Coulter gone too, it's impossible. You're just not thinking straight because of Caz.'

'So you'd rather I didn't know she was here? Tell me, Benny, if you'd been the one to find her, not Rose, would you have even told me?'

'Yes! Yes, of course I would have! Llin, I'm not a fucking monster.'

'You're sure as hell sounding like one,' Llin snarls back.

'I don't need you to agree,' Benny says coldly. 'You seem to have forgotten who you're talking to.'

My skin prickles while my chest tightens like my ribs are being bound.

‘Well, if you’re pulling rank, then why don’t I just get on my knees to you now?’ Llinos’s voice is full of sarcasm, and the tension radiating from the room is suffocating. I don’t know what to do. I don’t want to get caught here, but I don’t want to stand outside all night either.

Before I can decide whether to leave, Loch’s voice cuts through the silence. ‘Our flower is here,’ he says dreamily. ‘Rose is outside.’

My heart thuds. I either need to move now, making it look like I’ve just approached, or risk them finding me outside eavesdropping.

With a casual stride, I continue my walk and push open the door.

The three Rettlings are seated on their own beds, and Llinos and Benny smile at me in such synchronicity that it’s unnerving.

‘Hey, where have you been?’ Llinos asks. ‘Hardly seen you today. We were getting worried.’

Her voice is too high-pitched to be natural, and I wonder if she can hear it too.

‘Oh, just went for a wander,’ I say breezily. ‘How’s everything going here? Did you and Caroline have a good night?’

‘Yes, yes, all good. She just had a lot of work to catch up on, so she headed back early.’

She shoots Benny a look as if daring him to disagree with her, but his smile has dropped and he’s not saying anything at all.

It’s burning in me now, the need to know what the hell is up with my friends, the urge to dig into it. But they’re my friends, and as I owe them my life, the least I can give them in return is their privacy. I don’t want to rock the boat. I just have to pray that one of them doesn’t sink the whole damn thing.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 35

I'm more than a little relieved to see Zelle is back for our training the next morning, and he offers me a wide smile in greeting. 'I hear you had some excitement while I was away.'

'You could say that.'

'Cowards. Shameful cowards. I'm not normally one for vengeance, but in this case, I won't lose any sleep when they get what's coming to them.' I can't help but wonder if he's talking solely about the Rettlings, or whether Holden is included in the sentiment too. It's not like it could have happened without his say-so. Still, that's not something I'm going to ask. 'You okay now?' he adds.

'I'm all good,' I reassure him. 'We should get started.'

Today it's straight into sparring, with no footwork practice first, and thankfully, there's no sign of the prince. The difference his absence makes to me is more than a little noticeable. The tension in my muscles is entirely different, and I can actually focus one hundred percent on the fighting.

Only when I'm drenched in sweat and my time with Zelle is nearly up does his royal highness finally deign to join us. Though rather than a weapon in his hand, the prince carries a plate of pastries. 'Did you eat anything yet?' he asks me gruffly.

'Um, no,' I admit.

He holds the plate out, but I don't take it. Perhaps my plan for Zara is affecting my thinking, but I can't help but worry that they might be poisoned, laced with something.

His mouth tightens as he grabs one and pointedly eats a mouthful. Then he stalks over and slams the plate onto the weapons cabinet before whirling

around to face me.

‘It’s not fucking poisoned.’ His snarled words confirm he read my reluctance flawlessly. ‘It’s food, and you need to eat. If you don’t fuel your body properly then you’re wasting Zelle’s time and yours. Worse, you’re wasting my fucking time because it’s time he’s not training with *me*. So do us all a favour and eat something.’

Without another word, he turns on his heel and stalks off, not waiting to see if I consume his buttery offerings.

Silence falls between Zelle and me, and I hate the way the pastries continue to call to me. There’s no way around it. I’m fucking starving. As I move to pick one up, Zelle clears his throat.

‘It was hard to say goodbye to her,’ Zelle murmurs. It takes less than a heartbeat for me to realise what he means. My cheeks colour furiously as hollow fear sweeps through me.

Zelle knows I saw Elska.

‘I—’

He shakes his head and holds a hand up to forestall any explanation I might make. ‘The Gods led you to see what you needed to see. Cut him some slack. He’s trying to atone.’

I blink. ‘Atone for what?’

Zelle fixes his eyes on me. ‘For his lies.’

It hits me like I’ve been dragged into icy water. Zelle knows the truth. No wonder he’s been so keen to help me. He knows my mother was innocent. He knows that the only reason I’m even here is because Kyor ruined us.

‘There is no atonement for what he did,’ I spit. ‘There is no forgiveness. My brother is dead, my mother, my father. We have lived destitute, hungry, and in fear. Fuck his atonement.’

Zelle smiles a little. ‘The two of you are such a pair.’ He looks at me with an affection I can’t bear to see. ‘He was a child, Rose. A child who’d just watched his mother die before his eyes. The most precious person in his life, ripped away to join Mortidem. You’ve experienced loss yourself. You know the anger that comes with it. The desire to rage against the Gods’ will. The feeling of injustice that makes you seek someone to blame. He was a child,’ he repeats, his tone now just a little chiding. ‘Would you not forgive a child?’

‘No,’ I say shakily, more shaken than I care to admit. ‘No, because I was a child too.’

‘You were’—he nods—‘but a life lived in hate is no life at all.’ His rebuke is soft, yet it hits me like a blow to the stomach. ‘Session’s up,’ he murmurs.

A glance across the battle yard shows me that the other Rettlings have started to arrive. Rather than immediately heading over to them, Zelle squeezes my arm then moves over to the plate of pastries and plucks one up. He saunters away, no doubt ready to dispense some more unasked-for wisdom.

As the rest of the Rettlings file in, I all but run from the battle yard. The hollowness that fills me is due to far more than a lack of pastries.



‘IT TAKES ABOUT twenty-four hours to take effect,’ I tell Llinos a week later. I’m up before sunrise, not to train with Zelle and Kyor but for the sole purpose of putting my own poisoning plan into action. ‘Which means if I slip it into their breakfast this morning, the symptoms will kick in tomorrow. Less suspicious, right? I’ll pour it into their water jugs, then tomorrow morning we watch the Rowells suffer.’

‘With a dodgy tummy?’ she says dubiously, raising an eyebrow. ‘Rose, you’re so soft. Your mighty punishment for them trying to murder you is a dodgy tummy?’

‘A *really* dodgy tummy,’ I say, grinning. ‘Sweats, cramps, vomiting, shakes. It won’t kill them, but it’ll sure as hell make them feel like they’re going to die.’

I’ve not mentioned the argument I heard her and Benny having, nor have I told a soul about Kyor and Elska. I sure am racking up secrets. But the poison doesn’t need to be a secret from Llin. In fact, it feels good to be able to share something with her. And so she comes with me to add the final ingredient, changing the concoction from a deep purple to colourless.

‘All this without magic and spell work.’ Llin sounds genuinely impressed by my skills and I can’t deny the bubble of pride that fills me.

‘I need to get down there now,’ I say excitedly as I pour the now colourless liquid into two glass vials. ‘Oke has a habit of getting up

annoyingly early, and this'll get less potent if I have to wait until later in the week to use it.'

'Want me to hang around at the top of the stairs and make sure none of them are heading down?' Llinos offers. 'I can distract them if needed?'

'If you're sure?' I ask as I pocket the vials. 'I don't want you to put yourself at risk.'

She snorts. 'Wow, careful there, Rose. You're sounding like your boyfriend.'

I offer her my most withering glare. 'Not my boyfriend. Jonas is just an old friend.'

'Who clearly wants to be more.'

I shake my head as I slip on my boots. 'If we're dissecting relationships, perhaps I should ask you more about the situation between you and Benny?' I deflect, only to wince internally as the words slip out.

Llin's posture stiffens as her eyes narrow. 'What's that supposed to mean? What's he said to you?'

'Nothing,' I reply, already regretting the comment. 'I just mean, I don't even know how you two know each other.'

'Yes, you do. We're both from Brandish,' she says flatly.

'Right, but I always thought it was a big city. I certainly didn't know all the other noble kids growing up here, and it's not like Jonas knows all the nobles in Wrohelm that well either.'

Her fingers pinch the bridge of her nose and I know she's weighing up what to tell me. 'Benny and I are related,' she says eventually. 'Distantly through marriage. Not blood.'

'Ahh, so now the bickering makes sense. You're family.' I grin, trying to make light of the matter.

'We do not bicker,' she argues, only to change her mind. 'Okay, yes, we do. But don't think I didn't notice how you shifted the subject away from you and Lorathin just now. Please, whatever you're going to do, do it soon. I can't deal with another carriage ride filled with longing looks.'

'There have been no longing looks, and we don't have time for this conversation. I have to get down to the dining room. Now, are you helping me or not?'

'I've got your back.'

I smile, confident she does.

Just as planned, I leave Llinos at the top of the stairs and head down alone. When I reach the dining hall, a couple of people are already there eating breakfast, including two of the knights and the wind weaver from Galreck. Despite my heart pounding so loudly that I'm sure they can hear it, none of them pay me any attention.

I work swiftly. I've already unstoppered the vials on the way down, and as I walk past, I pour a fair dose into each of the water jugs on the Rowell table, grateful they always choose to sit at the table right at the end of the room. I'd prefer to stir it in just to make sure it's all mixed properly, but given how much I've put in there, it'll only take a couple of sips for them to feel the effects – and fingers crossed, they'll have a darn sight more than that.

Trying to control the grin that's spreading across my cheeks, I'm barely halfway to my own table when footsteps echo behind me and a glass clinks. Shit. Someone's already here, and the first thing they've done is pour themselves a drink. My heart ricochets as I realise how close I was to getting caught, but the fear dissolves almost instantly. I *didn't* get caught, and I know at least one of the Rowell lot is going to face a not insubstantial punishment for what they did to me.

As a smile rises on my lips, I can't help but glance over my shoulder, only for my jaw to drop in surprise. It's not Zara or any of her crew. It's Kyor. And he's already emptied what I assume was a whole fucking glass.

Oh *shit.*

I'm gaping, hands wringing, totally flustered.

He's topless and glistening with sweat. Without me to slow them down this morning, I imagine he and Zelle have had a heavy workout. As tempting as it is to let my eyes linger on those abs or the concentric circle tattoos, they're instead drawn to his lips, where moisture glistens, and then to the empty glass in his hand.

'Is there a reason you're staring, Thorn?' he says, arching an eyebrow at me.

'Nope,' I manage.

He smirks. He thinks it's his sexy body that has me gawping at him, and usually he'd be right, but today my stare is panic-filled. What if I did the infusion wrong? If that's the case, I may well have just poisoned the heir to the throne!

I try my best to appear calm, fighting to keep all the panic concealed inside. Oh this is *bad.*

‘You fancy a lie-in today?’ Kyor says lightly as he moves from the end table towards me. Once he’s close enough to have a perfectly civil conversation, he continues even further, encroaching on my personal space. It’s enough to draw the air from my lungs. ‘I can picture you, Thorn, tangled up in your sheets.’

‘I … I just don’t normally see you at breakfast, that’s all,’ I stutter out. *Smooth, Rose. So smooth.*

‘Perhaps I just don’t like being seen,’ he says.

He turns around and strides back to the Rowell table, where he picks up his empty glass, ready to pour himself some more water. Shit. I can’t let him drink *more.*

‘The second trial,’ I blurt out hastily.

‘What of it?’ His hand moves away from the jug and I try to hide the relief I feel.

‘Are you doing it?’ I ask. ‘Benny told me the priestess gave you a choice in whether you wanted to participate. You’re going to, aren’t you?’

His eyes glint. ‘Why? Worried about facing me out there?’

‘No. Just wondering why you need to prove yourself so much. Daddy issues, I guess, right?’

Amusement flashes in his eyes, and his lips twitch into a smirk. I realise that this time *I’ve* moved closer to *him.* And he didn’t miss it.

He’s so close I can smell the fresh sweat and vanilla musk rising from his hot skin.

‘You lack common sense, you know that? Maybe I should find a way to pound some into you.’

My throat instantly dries as I open my mouth, wishing I could think of some sort of witty retort, but literally nothing comes.

That’s part of the problem, I guess. Sharing a dorm has made my sexual frustration way worse, and I swear that’s the only reason why this encounter is making me so unfeasibly wet.

Kyor reaches out and traces a finger around the outside of my lips. ‘That’s a good look for you,’ he says huskily. ‘An open mouth.’

I snap my mouth closed sharply, and he chuckles.

Our moment comes to a close as a voice interrupts us. ‘Great workout this morning, Your Royal Highness.’

My eyes swivel away from Kyor to find Holden standing behind him. Unlike Kyor, who's glistening with sweat, Holden is dripping. His face is bright pink and from the way his chest is heaving I struggle to believe he was ever an active knight. His wolf must be embarrassed by him. 'You've got excellent technique. And power.'

'It was a good warm-up for me, too,' Kyor replies drily.

Holden's lips purse as he shifts his attention to me. 'Kultavaris,' he snarls. 'Your family always did have a cockroach-like tenacity. Well, they got what they deserved in the end, as I'm sure you shall too.'

Anger flashes through me, which surges even hotter as he shoots an oily, sycophantic grin to Kyor.

'You look hot, Commander,' I say, taking a glass and filling it to the brim with the laced water. 'You should drink. I'd hate for it to appear that you weren't able to keep up with one of the Rettlings so early in the morning. What was it the prince called it? A warm-up?'

His nostrils twitch, and his sneer exposes the slightest sliver of yellow teeth. I don't wait to see if he drinks the glass. I can't. I'm too afraid my expression will give away what I've done. So I turn and stride casually back to my normal table. When I finally muster the courage to look back, both Kyor and Holden are gone, and both glasses are empty.

Seconds later, I look up to see Llinos coming down the stairs. She gives me a questioning look, and I nod, implying I got the job done.

'It was getting weird, just standing at the top of the stairs,' she explains.

'Thanks for that. We've already got our first victim. Maybe two.' I wince a little.

Her eyes bug. 'You have?' She looks up but frowns when she sees Zara's group are only now walking down the stairs. 'Who?'

'Kyor,' I say. 'He grabbed himself a drink after training. Picked the wrong jug.'

Llinos's mouth forms an 'O' of shock. 'You just poisoned the prince and heir to the throne of Morathka?'

'I did.' I try to suppress my slightly hysterical laughter, but it's impossible, and what leaves my lips is the closest thing to a giggle I've ever made. 'And it gets even better.'

'How?' she says. Her look of disbelief borders on comical.

'The other person? It was Holden.'

Llinos bursts into laughter. When she gets a hold of herself, her face is an expression of pure elation. ‘You know, if I wasn’t spoken for, I’d kiss you right now.’

‘I think that would draw a little unwanted attention. But thanks.’ I grin back, helping myself to a large pastry from the plate in front of me. ‘Now all we have to do is wait.’



AFTER WATCHING Zara and her Rettlings fill and drink their glasses, I go straight to the battle yard. Zelle is already waiting, and judging by the rivulets of sweat rolling down his forehead, Holden isn’t the only person Kyor was sparring with this morning. For now though, he and I are the only people here.

‘Morning, Kultavaris,’ he says as he strides over to me. ‘Sleep well?’

I wonder briefly if that’s a dig at my purported lie-in, but his face is open, genuine. He really does hope I’ve slept well.

‘Not bad, thank you.’

‘Excellent …’ He picks up a sword from the rack beside him. ‘What do you say we have a bit of practice?’

‘Now that you’ve been thoroughly tired out by a proper warrior, you mean?’ I sass. I expect him to laugh, but instead, his cheeks pull in slightly.

‘He’s not had it easy.’ The solemn air has returned to his voice tenfold. ‘The prince. He doesn’t have many good people around him. Never has. And I know that doesn’t excuse what he did to your family. The lie he told.’ Zelle drops his voice low. ‘But whatever the prince said, I fear the outcome would have been the same. Kyor was a boy – a child, as I’ve said before. His word wasn’t the deciding factor in your punishment. The king was. And I think you know that.’

Some part of me did, but right now I can’t verbalise that, can’t speak it aloud and make it real. I’ve clung to my hatred of Kyor for over a decade, and without it I’m not quite sure who I am anymore.

‘He’s been helping you, too. Training you with me. He didn’t have to do that.’

‘Other than your bet, you mean?’ I fire back.

A curl of amusement twists the commander's lips. 'Is that what he told you? That we have a bet going?' He shakes his head. 'Sorry to disappoint, but as I already told you, he's helping you purely because he wants to atone.'

I stare at him, eyes wide in disbelief. *No bet?*

Zelle isn't done yet. 'Your father would be so proud of you, Rose.' His voice is almost a whisper. 'He was the most formidable fighter I'd ever encountered. Should have had my job – would have if it wasn't for politics.'

Politics. I scoff at the word. He means how my father was a bastard.

In my shell-shocked silence, Zelle continues, 'He was one of the best men I knew. Loved with his whole heart. You remind me a lot of him. A lot of your mother, too.'

I don't know when the tears started falling, but when I lift my fingers to my cheeks, I find them soaked. Hastily I scrub the tears away.

'That's enough gassing.' Zelle pushes back his shoulders with a smile, as though we've been happily chatting away about the weather this whole time. He reaches over to the weapons bench, selects a sword, and throws it to me. I catch it without a second's thought. 'Let's put those reflexes to use in a fight.'

An hour later, I've had the best spar of my life. That's not an exaggeration. It's the first time I can remember being truly pushed to fight, and I've actually risen to the challenge. My training with Kyor and Zelle has really started to sharpen me into the fighter I should always have been. Every strike Zelle aimed at me, I blocked. And I even got in a few of my own.

When we stop, we are both dripping in sweat.

'You're not the weakest here, Lady Kultavaris,' he says with an approving nod. 'Not by a wide margin. Don't let your lack of magic make you believe otherwise.'

'Thank you,' I say, my chest burning with unexpected pride.

Not the weakest. Not by a wide margin.

The way he looks at me … it's like Zelle actually believes I can survive this. Survive it and maybe even win.



‘LOCH ALSO THINKS it’s going to be soon,’ Benny says as we sit in the dorm that night. ‘He keeps saying they’re whispering. All whispering.’

‘They are.’ Loch whips his head up from where he was staring blankly at his lap. ‘They think no one can hear them. But I can. I can hear them all.’ He starts to rock.

I open my mouth, ready to ask Loch what exactly he’s heard them saying, but Benny shakes his head. I suspect he’s already tried that.

‘I just hope it’s the one without magic,’ I say instead. ‘I know I’ll stand a chance then.’ I’m determined to build on the confidence my spar with Zelle gave me, even if it’s the conversation beforehand I still can’t stop focusing on.

‘Do you think it will be a group task again?’ Llinos joins in. ‘Most of the trials only have two group tasks, or three at the very most. And normally for at least one of them we’re in pairs.’

‘But that’s only because the numbers are so much lower by the end,’ Jonas interjects. He’s sitting on the end of my bed, which is sweet but also annoying. There are plenty of spare beds in here, and with him on mine, I can’t stretch out fully unless I put my legs on him. And I know exactly what response the others will have to that. ‘I’m sure as long as all of us stay alive, then we’ll all be able to keep helping each other through. And we know for certain that one of us is through to the third trial regardless of how this next one goes.’

He lifts his glass to Benny and tilts it towards him. Since he snapped at him for being in my room, Jonas has been making a concerted effort not to be a dick, but now he’s going too far in the other direction, and if he sucks up to Benny any more he’s going to get some seriously chapped lips.

‘Well, I’m going to head to bed early,’ I say. ‘That fight with Zelle wiped me out. Besides, I want to be up early again tomorrow.’

As I catch Llinos’s eye, simultaneous smirks rise on our faces.

‘Why? What happens tomorrow?’ Jonas questions, his brow furrowing. Unlike Benny and Llin, I’m not sure exactly how Jonas will respond to finding out about my plan for the Rowells. Which is why I haven’t told him.

‘Maybe something. Maybe nothing.’ I shrug. ‘Now budge. I need sleep.’

It’s another half hour before I’m actually in bed, though rather than sleeping, my head is unsettled. Benny and Jonas have gone off to hunt down a home brew one of the Galreckians – either Moryal or Del – has

made, while Llin is silent in her bed and Loch mutters as he stares out of the window.

I've never actually made the infusion I put in the water today, and while I'm almost positive it won't do any permanent damage, I can't deny a twinge of fear.

Then there's the conversation with Zelle. If he knows the truth about my family, then how many other people do? My instinct is to say none, to assume he's the only person close enough for Kyor to share that secret with, but what do I really know of the prince? Nothing except what I've seen of him here. For all I know, he could have told everyone, maybe even bragged about it. Perhaps that was what he was laughing about with the kitchen staff when I found him there that day. My gut churns. Instinct tells me that's not right, that Kyor's not like that. He's arrogant and confident, yes, but not a braggart.

Atoning, Zelle had said. That implies remorse, doesn't it?

'Rose, are you still awake?' Llinos's voice drifts from the other side of the room.

'Yeah, just.'

I hear the creaking of her bed, and a moment passes before her weight settles on the mattress next to me.

'I've been thinking,' she continues to whisper, 'about you and Kay. When all this is over.'

'That feels like a long way away right now,' I admit.

'I know. I know it does. But I was thinking that when it's over, if you don't want to stay – and I'm not saying you won't, I'm just saying if – then you could come back with us to the Eastern Isles. There'll be a home for you in Brandish. With me. With Caroline.'

'Caroline's leaving the High Hold?' I remember the argument I overheard where Llinos said Caroline was at risk. But what kind of risky situation can a scribe be in, other than paper cuts and being bored to death by old men like Rohan? I'm missing a piece of the puzzle, and it doesn't feel good.

'Yeah. You better believe that as soon as this is over, we're going to be out of here.' She reaches out, pulling me closer to her. 'There are things you can do on the island. The ointments you make, the balms, the infusions. There are people who do that, like healers, but without magic. You could work there. I'd be able to find work for Kay, too. I know it. You'd be

comfortable. I'd make sure of it.' Her voice is passionate, and I find that I believe her utterly. My eyes are suddenly hot. For the first time, it feels like winning the Retterheld isn't the only option for me. That maybe just staying alive will be enough to give Kay and me a whole new chance at life.

I try to imagine it, Kay and I leaving behind the mainland for a fresh start. I haven't even been to the Eastern Isles; what if we don't like it? And there's also Jonas's offer to consider.

'I know we haven't known each other that long,' Llinos says fiercely, 'but the Retterheld is a crucible of fire. It burns like shit, but it also forges damn good friendships. I honestly believe that I was meant to find you, Rose. And now I can't imagine a life without you in it. But take your time. Think about it. You don't have to answer me now.'

Her last words make me realise I've been silent too long.

'Yes,' I say, but it comes out in a half-sob. 'Thank you. Thank you so much.'

For a moment we just lie there, holding each other, and then Llinos shifts. 'We should get some sleep.'

As I try to sleep, my mind fills with thoughts of the future. An actual future where it would be about living, not just surviving. When I finally drift off, I dream of sitting on a cliff edge with Kay and watching the waves crash against the cliffs. It's so vivid that I can almost taste the salty air and feel the breeze whip through my hair. As we sit there, holding hands and staring at the blue, the howl of the wind grows louder and louder until it's a clangour. A clangour that forces me to cover my ears before it finally shakes me from my sleep.

Not the wind, I realise with a sickening bolt of nausea. A bell. A Godsdamn trial bell.

'What time is it?' I yawn.

'I don't think it's even midnight,' Llinos replies. 'Benny's not in bed yet. Unless he's bunking with Jonas. Here we go again,' she says, sounding resigned.

I nod my head, unable to form a proper reply. It's the second trial. And it's starting now.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 36

I assess what to take with me as we dress hurriedly. Do I want to take my entire bag? I've got Estel's sword, as well as my daggers, but that's a lot to carry. Then again, is being without weapons a risk I want to take?

Last time, a few swords against the giants would've helped. But are we likely to be fighting again? Surely it will be something more strategic … but what? Several recent evenings have been spent discussing past Retterhelds, and despite everyone's best efforts, it seems almost impossible to deduce a pattern in the trials. We know that a magicless trial and likely a water trial will both come at some point, but in what order, no one knows. Sometimes the frozen lakes in the north of the territory have been used, but other years, multiple trials have taken place in the Sunken Temple. I'm not sure how staying silent while fighting would pan out, but maybe the priestesses don't count screaming as a word.

Hesitating, I force myself to take a calming breath and clear my thoughts. I definitely need to be armed, so I grab Estel's sword and the blade I used to slit the jötunn's throat, then hesitate again. I still know next to nothing about the blade from Dinah, although there seemed to be a theme with the Rettlings that it harmed significantly. The knighted guard who was killed in the same way as Jai had been rumoured to have assaulted one of the maids on the night of the first ball, and while no one had anything specific to say about the Galreckian who died, no one had a single pleasant word to say of him either.

But maybe the fact that Dinah gave me the blade is all I need to know. With a sudden spur of decisiveness, I take the knife out of its box and slide it next to the other in my belt, then follow Llinos out of the room,

downstairs, and into the courtyard. Once again, the carriages are waiting for us.

We move to go together, but a priestess steps between us.

‘You will travel alone to this trial,’ she says.

Llinos and I exchange a look. That’s not what either of us wanted to hear.

‘It’ll be fine,’ she says, offering me a swift hug. ‘I’ll see you at the end.’

Assuming we both survive. That’s the thing neither of us says.

I’m just about to step inside my carriage when a voice yells from across the courtyard.

‘Rose! Hold on!’ Jonas is sprinting towards me. When he stops, he grabs my hands and pulls me in towards him.

‘No risks, I know.’ I roll my eyes at him.

A smile flickers on his lips before he leans in and presses them against mine.

The kiss catches me by surprise. So much so that my body turns rigid until he steps away.

‘I’ll see you afterwards. At the ball. With Kay and Will and everyone else.’

I nod, still in shock at the moment I didn’t see coming.

‘Just friends, hey?’ Llinos smirks from the carriage beside me. ‘You’d better survive this because I’ve got some serious questions.’

She’s not the only one. As I stand there in confusion, I feel a scalding glance on me, burning my skin. I turn to locate the owner, and I meet Kyor’s glare. Jaw tight, he turns and gets into a carriage of his own.



THE MOMENT with Jonas isn’t enough to bury the anxiety I feel at being in the carriage alone. I need someone to talk to. To distract me. To tell me which direction we’re going in or repeat how important it is that we work together to get through this. Talking helps alleviate my fears. Being stuck in my head does not.

The night sky is dark overhead, meaning it’s impossible to get my bearings once we leave the last ring of Wrohelm. I try to listen for clues, but all I can hear is the howling of wolves. The sound causes a churning dread

to fill me. I don't think they'd expect us to fight wolves … would they? No, that's ridiculous. Wolves are sacred in Morathka. Though people aren't …

I'm expecting the journey to take as long as the one to the beach did, so I'm surprised when the carriage trundles to a stop while it's still dark out. Checking that my weapons are firmly in place, I step out and scan the area for the other carriages, but there are none. Instead, I'm on the edge of a forest, and waiting for me is a lone priestess. No, not just any priestess. Dinah. My heart lurches as I rush towards her.

'How?' I say, enveloping her in my arms. 'How are you here?'

'I may have pulled a few strings.' Her smile highlights the lines at the corners of her eyes. 'How are you doing, Rose? I've heard wonderful things about your first trial.'

'Well, I survived it,' I say. 'That's definitely good.'

'From what I heard, you did more than just that.' She brushes a strand of hair behind my ear, the way my mother used to do. 'Have you brought the knife with you? The dagger? The one in the box?'

'Yes.' My pulse soars as it dawns on me that the answer I've been searching for might be standing right here. 'It's the same as the one High Priestess Mila used at the vows. It's magic, right?'

'I don't have time to talk about that right now. I have to give you the rules.'

'But it did something—'

'We don't have time, Rose. If you don't start with the others, you'll be at a disadvantage. Listen.' Her expression shifts, her voice lowering. 'They have Kay.'

My stomach drops as ice floods my veins. 'What?'

She shakes her head quickly. 'She will be fine. But she is in the forest. You must retrieve her before dawn. Do that, and you will proceed to the next trial. If you don't reach her in time, you will be out of the competition.' She pauses. 'There are threats here, Rose. Very real threats. Do not let your guard down.'

I've barely registered any of the words after Kay's name. My little sister is in the forest and I have to find her. If ever there was something to spur me on in a trial, this would be it.

'There's one other thing.' Dinah's lips twitch into a smile. 'There will be no use of magic in this trial.'

My breath stills. No magic. I lock eyes with her and her smile broadens, though she tries to hide it.

‘They have no advantage over you, Rose,’ she says. ‘And you and Kay could find each other even if the world cracked apart.’

She reaches out, pressing a hand briefly to my shoulder.

‘Go now. And I will see you when I can.’



FUCK ME, it’s dark.

That’s all I can think as I enter the woods. My feet crunch on the ground beneath me, though on leaves, twigs, or crunchy insects, I’ve no freaking idea. All I’ve got to do is find Kay. That’s it. Find Kay and don’t get killed.

Two very straightforward aims, I’m sure.

I turn around and assess my surroundings. The track leading here stretches behind me, and I’m willing to bet I need to travel away from it to find Kay, heading deeper into the trees. A flood of memories sweeps through me. This could be the very same part of the forest that my father used to bring us to. The very same area where I would scour the ground for tracks and broken branches, any sign that someone may have come through that way. I recall the desperation I felt in those times. The desperation not only to get out of the forest, but also to prove to him my proficiency.

‘Cornelia?’ I hear someone shouting into the night. ‘Are you there?’

I’ve no idea who would be searching for someone of that name, but it’s not as though I know the intimate details of many of the remaining Rettlings. I’m not even sure who would be there at the end for Jonas to find. Still, rather than focusing on that, I think strategy. If there are tracks here, it’s either too dark or they’re too subtle for me to see, which means I need to think of another option.

However spread out the Rettlings are, if we can hear each other, that’s a good sign. It means the geographical boundaries of the trial are limited. As long as I move swiftly, I shouldn’t have any problems finding Kay quickly. And then there’s the bonus that I don’t have to worry about magic. If I run into Zara, she will actually have to fight me for once. And after all of my hours with Zelle, I’m betting that will end differently than our last two encounters.

Shit. Zara. *The infusion.* Well, it's not as though I deliberately sabotaged the trial for the Rowells and Kyor. But maybe Etta's even more on my side than I'd hoped.

My feet get snared on a low branch, but as I try to pull myself out, my trousers snag too. By the time I'm free, I'm completely turned around and unsure which direction I came from.

Benny's words filter unbidden into my head. *You can climb.*

Trees are my bread and butter. They're what I learned to climb on. Though I did learn in daylight, when I could see the branches and the dangers. Climbing when you can't see anything is risky. Then again, so is wandering aimlessly around a forest where dire wolves prowl. Stretching my hand out in front of me, I find a tree with low-hanging branches and begin to ascend, feeling my way.

It's a massive use of energy. The leaves and branches snag at my hair and shoulders, and catch on my boots and elbows, clawing at every part of me. I find climbing trees fairly straightforward, but trying to push through a canopy of twigs and dried leaves when you can't even see where the gaps are is a whole different feat.

At some point, the branches start to thin, but I keep moving until I'm at the top. Stars glint above me and a white moon gleams down in bright rays, washing me in some much-needed light.

It's a stunning sky. An entire universe is at the edge of my fingertips. If ever a sight made me believe in the presence of the Gods, it's this. But I am not here to worship. I need to find Kay. I draw my gaze down and across the forest.

I twist around, starting to wonder if I've made a mistake, when I spot several concentrated glimmers on the forest floor. It's the only area of the forest that appears to be illuminated. That *has* to be where Kay and the others are, and judging from the position of the stars, it looks to be to the east and no more than a mile or two away from where I am. It's definitely walkable before dawn. Assuming I don't get attacked. Or get knocked off course, which would be incredibly easy to do, considering how dark it is. I go to descend the tree when I hear sounds below me.

There's a deep retching, followed by the unmistakable, liquidy splash of vomit hitting the ground. My muscles tighten. It could be a random sickness. There's no reason to assume the person vomiting below me is one

of the people I poisoned, but if it is, I've definitely got a list of the order in which I'd want to bump into them.

I should sneak down and move away from them as quickly as possible, but as I lower myself onto a weaker branch, it snaps beneath my feet.

'Who's there?' Fuck. It's Zara's voice that calls out. 'I heard you. I heard you, and I'm armed. I'll kill you.'

I don't doubt she'll try, but the words have barely left her mouth when she starts retching again. I use the moment to make the final descent. Fast. Even when I hit the ground, she's still heaving. I know that staying silent is the sensible thing to do right now, but this woman has made my life hell, so I can't help a little dig. 'It doesn't really sound like you're in much of a state to kill anyone.' A slight chuckle leaves my lips. Bitchy? Yes. Deserved? Absolutely.

She spins towards me, her hands rising by instinct, only to find they have no effect.

My smirk widens into a grin. 'Surely your priestess told you that this is the trial without magic. Did you forget?'

'Fuck off,' she groans. 'I know you did this. I don't know how you did it, but you did. You made me feel like this.'

'Really?' Another dry chuckle resounds from my throat. 'How would I do that? I'm a powerless runt, remember? Now, if you don't mind, I've got a trial to complete.'

She lunges at me, waving her arms wildly, but I knock her aside. It's the easiest I've ever disarmed anyone, and a clear sign of just how exhausted she is. I feel the tiniest pang of guilt.

It wasn't my intention to affect her ability in the trials, and I sure as hell hope Etta knows that and doesn't hold it against me. Still, I'm not going to hang around and give her time to put a dagger through my heart.

'What did you see up there?' she asks. 'Do you know where they are?'

As if I would ever help *her* after all she's done. 'I don't know anything,' I lie, turning off in the wrong direction just to throw her off. A few metres away, I double back on myself towards the lights.

As I walk stealthily through the forest, I hear people calling for their loved ones.

Whoever was calling for Cornelia shouts several more times. Another man, with an older-sounding voice, calls out for a Mara. But I don't hear Jonas's or Llinos's voices. Nor do I hear Kyor.

I’m surprised by the depth of guilt that strikes me when I think of him, though I tell myself I shouldn’t feel bad. It was an accident that he drank the poisoned water, and he didn’t even *have* to be in this trial. He could’ve chosen to skip it altogether, the way Benny has. His pride is the only reason he’s here.

I’ve been walking for about fifteen minutes when I find another tree that looks good to climb.

When I’m sure I’m on track, I drop back down and continue on foot. My focus now is on moving forward, on getting there before dawn. With every footstep I push myself to go a little faster, growing less and less concerned about the delicacy of my feet on the forest floor or the occasional yelps that break free from my lungs when I snag my hair on overhead branches. When I next stop to test another tree, something causes me to freeze. The forest is silent. Absolutely silent. Not so much as a scuttle in the undergrowth.

My pulse hitches as I strain to hear something. Anything. Yet there is not so much as a single flutter of a wing. My skin prickles. Why the fuck did I become so complacent as to think I didn’t need to listen? My father told me often enough that your ears are always your first warning in the forest, and when it’s as dark as it is tonight, they’re pretty much the only sense I’ve got. I could kick myself for letting something so basic slide.

With my throat growing dry with every shallow breath, I turn slowly away from the tree, my heart hammering against my eardrums, and I see the reason why the forest is suddenly so silent.

A pair of amber eyes glint at me through the darkness.

A dire wolf.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 37

The dire wolf is so close I can see it is unbonded. It is a wild animal that answers to nothing but its own instincts. Fuck.

In the distance, someone screams and the wolf's ear twitches, the movement slight. Its unblinking gaze is locked entirely on me.

'I really don't want to kill you,' I say softly, like I've actually got a chance of doing that. If this beast comes for me, I'm screwed. My weapons still rest on my hip, and there's no way I can get to them and get them up in time to avoid being devoured.

The dire wolf is faster in every way, except climbing … and I'm still several feet away from the nearest tree. One leap and it'll be on me.

'I am not going to hurt you,' I say again. 'I don't want to hurt anybody. I just want to find my sister.'

I lift my foot off the ground and its eyes twitch. Still, I place my foot down again, just a fraction in front of where it was before.

'I know why you're here. I know your role. The priestesses have you weeding out the weak, right?'

I move another inch forward, showing it that I'm unafraid. It's a lie, of course, but I keep my body language relaxed, like I wholly believe in my right to be here. Because I really am starting to. *I'm not the weakest here.*

'The thing is'—my fingers slowly move to my dagger as I continue talking—'I don't think I'm the weakest here. There was a time when I was. But now? I'm not so sure. I was strong enough to get into the Retterheld. No help. No magic. Barely a mark on me at the vows, and I was strong enough to survive the first trial. I've also been strong enough to survive

attacks against me. Three now. So I'm not weak, you see. I'm not one of the ones you want to cull.'

I'm taking another step towards it when a howl pierces the sky. It's not just a wolf's call – but a wolf in agony. The animal in front of me flashes its teeth, snarling.

My heart thunders. 'That wasn't me,' I say, lifting my free hand in the air. 'That wasn't me. I'm here with you. And you know that. I'm not weak. And I don't want to hurt you or any other wolf.' The closer I get, the more mesmerisingly beautiful I see it is.

The fur on its spine is deep amber, almost the exact same tone as its eyes.

'I need to go past you,' I whisper. 'I need to go past you to get to my sister, and I'd really like it if you let me do that without either of us getting hurt.'

I'm barely an arm's length away now. It wouldn't even need to lunge to get me. Just a swipe would be enough. But still, it's not moving. It's measuring me up. I'm sure it can hear my heart pounding and the way the blood is rushing around my body.

'Please, I don't want to hurt you.'

Slowly, I lift my other hand, the one holding the dagger. I hold it out flat, like it's not a threat. Am I being ridiculously stupid? Pretty sure the answer to that is yes. Would a wild wolf even recognise a dagger as a threat? I don't know.

But as I bring it up to its line of vision, its pupils dilate. The black swallows the amber of its irises and its lip curls upwards. Not in a snarl, but in a whimper. It looks from me to the dagger again, twists, then edges away.

'You're scared of this? You don't need to be. I just need to pass, that's all. I just need to pass.'

Its whimpers grow louder and louder until the sound is almost a howl. The kind of howl that will attract other wolves.

'Don't do that.' No matter how much I don't want it to know I'm scared, I can't stop the tremble in my voice. 'Please don't. Please. Please, I need you to be quiet!'

It's not moving now. It's cowering. But scared animals don't cower for long. They attack. I don't see what choice I have. Even if it doesn't lunge for me, if it keeps making that noise, I'm going to have a lot more than one dire wolf to face. I raise the knife above my head.

‘Run!’ I scream, slamming my foot against the floor. My heart leaps up into my throat as the wolf turns and bolts.

Relief gusts from my lungs and I drop my hands onto my knees. I draw in a long breath, hoping it’ll steady the hammering behind my sternum, only for a cry to rise into the air to the left of me. The exact direction I just sent the wolf.

Fuck.

Have I just sent a scared, angry wolf in the direction of another Rettling? Sweat beads on the back of my neck. I have. I know I have. If they die, it will be my fault. *Gods, don’t let it be Llin.* The thought is enough to have me sprinting towards the sound.

My hair catches and tangles on branches but I keep running, ignoring the pain that sears my scalp. The screaming has stopped, but is it because the Rettling is safe or because they’re dead?

My legs are burning when I spot the amber eyes staring back at me. I open my mouth, ready to yell, hoping the same trick will work again, but before I get a chance there’s a flash of moonlight on metal and a silver blade rips through the wolf’s throat.

With a thud, the amber-eyed wolf falls to the ground, its eyes locking onto mine as the life leaves them.

An ache pulls through my chest, regret heavy in my gut. This is what I probably needed to survive, yet I hadn’t wanted to do it. And Gods, the look it gave me. The understanding. The knowing.

My feet are frozen to the ground, and I’m still staring at the slain beast when the thought strikes. Who the fuck killed it?

‘It’s dead,’ I whisper, fear evident in my timbre because I’m surely far too close to whoever slayed the wolf.

‘Course it’s fucking dead.’

I spin to my side, surprised to find Kyor standing there. And beside him, one blue eye and one green, both with white-ringed pupils, is Elska. Of course. If anyone is going to find a loophole to have their dire wolf in a trial with them, it would be him. I’m sure he’d just pass off her presence in the forest as coincidental. Coincidence my arse.

‘I believe you’ve met?’ Kyor says drily. ‘Albeit from a distance.’

He’s talking about the guards’ temple. How I spied on him from the outside. Yet before I can reply, I’m interrupted by his retching. He doubles over, using Elska to brace himself as he heaves.

‘You don’t look great,’ I say when he’s stopped. Guilt is roiling within me. As much as I hate to admit it, his training sessions have really helped me and repaying him with a poisoning just feels like something one of the Rowell lot would do. Not me.

‘Thanks for that observation,’ he mutters.

He looks better than Zara did, but that’s not saying much.

‘You didn’t tell the others about her,’ he groans out between retches. ‘That I saw her.’

‘Zelle’s the one who brought her in, not you.’

He looks a little bitter. ‘Your silence is for the old man then. He sure knows how to pick his projects.’

How is it possible that his eyes are still this icily blue in the dark light? Though as I continue to stare, his eyelids fall closed and he lets out a long groan. Maybe he is as bad as Zara. He’s just better at hiding it. He stares at me and the guilt I’m trying to suppress surges again.

‘Solarium root.’ I clamp my mouth shut when I’ve spoken, like that’ll be enough to stop him asking questions, even though I know it won’t be.

‘What?’ He scowls at me.

‘Solarium root. It’ll counter the effects of the infusion.’

‘The effects? An infusion? What the fuck, Thorn?’

I turn around. I’ve said enough, and he should be grateful for that.

‘Are you saying you did this to me?’ he calls after me, and if there’s a hint of hurt in his voice, I try to ignore it. Ignore him. I need to find Kay. I’ve told him the solution. If he doesn’t know the names of the plants that grow in his kingdom, then more fool him.

I start to walk away only to find myself staring into a pair of white-ringed pupils. Elska emits a low growl.

Kyor grunts, ‘You’re going to help me get that antidote, or you’re not going to get out of here alive. It’s safe to say Elska’s not best pleased with you right now. And trust me, you don’t want to see an angry dire wolf.’

He isn’t wrong there.

As if to reinforce his point, Elska bares her teeth and releases a low snarl that rumbles deep into the pit of my bowels.

I nod my head.

‘Great. Now find me that fucking solarium root.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 38

It's only once I've got the task of finding the plant myself that I realise what a ridiculously massive undertaking it is. It would be fine in the daytime when I could actually see the plants, but now, when everything is covered in dark shadows?

'What does it look like?' Kyor hisses beside me.

'The root? It's just … rooty. White, coarse—'

'Not the fucking *root,* Thorn. The *plant*. What does the *plant* look like?'

Right. The actual plant. That makes more sense.

'It's leafy—'

'Helpful.'

I shoot him a scowl, though I'm not sure if he can see it. 'It has small, dark, waxy leaves the size of a thumbnail, and the plant grows to about knee height.'

'Better. What else?'

'Umm.' I struggle to bring an image of the plant to mind. Now, in winter, it'll probably be nothing more than a small, twiggy bush, like most of the plants that fill the undergrowth. But that's not an answer Kyor's going to like, so I keep it to myself.

'In spring, it has flowers,' I tell him. 'They cover the entire bush and are light lilac with yellow centres. And they smell like citrus. Like … spicy citrus, if that's a thing.'

He nods. 'She's got it.'

'She's got it?' I look to Elska. 'You mean she understood what I was saying?'

‘No, Thorn. She’s a wolf. You think she knows what spicy citrus means? I visualised it for her. Filled my senses with it. She thinks she knows where the plant is. Follow her.’

I look to the wolf, well aware I’ve got no choice.

‘Oh, and Thorn?’ He speaks through gritted teeth, his body clenched in pain. ‘Don’t even think about running. It’ll be game over if you try to abandon me. Do you understand?’

‘Got it.’ I don’t waste any time before following Elska into the trees. Time is slipping away from me, time that could stop me from finding Kay. But I can’t think about that. I can’t. I just need to act, and fast.

Elska moves so silently through the undergrowth that all I can do is follow the flashes of white on her paws. More than once, I have to call out for her to slow down, and given that she stops and waits for me to catch up before continuing again, I have to wonder if Kyor lied when he said she didn’t understand my words.

We’ve been going for about five minutes when she sits down, her bicoloured eyes glimmering even despite the lack of light. There, at her feet, I see the shadows of small shrubs. There might not be any flowers, but there are a couple of those small waxy leaves visible.

She’s actually done it. Smart girl.

The only thing I have to dig with are my hands and my dagger. Given that I don’t want to damage the blade, I opt for the former, clawing fistfuls of dirt from the ground and tossing them behind me.

When I’ve freed enough of the plant, I wrap my hand around the stem and yank. A twisted ball of bulbous roots comes up.

I hold the plant in front of Elska’s eyes, knowing that she will be showing the vision to Kyor.

‘Take me back to him,’ I tell her. Immediately she’s on her feet, and a moment later, I’m racing to keep up with her as we retrace our steps.

When I reach Kyor, he is slumped against a tree trunk and doubled over.

‘Give it to me,’ he snarls as he stretches out his hand.

Rather than doing as he asks, I keep hold of the plant. ‘You need to peel it first. Otherwise it’ll just make you sicker. Give me a second. I’ll do it.’

‘I *can* peel a fucking root, Thorn,’ he snaps, only to grip his stomach and shudder in pain.

It’s getting worse, and if left untreated much longer, he’ll be completely incapacitated. Which is exactly what I wanted – Zara and her crew out of

commission so I could have a break from constantly watching my back. Now, I can't help but wonder how they're doing. Out here, the healers aren't an option. I just pray that Etta knows death wasn't my intention for them, no matter how much they may deserve it.

Having peeled and sliced a piece of the sticky root, I hand it to Kyor.

He grabs me with his other hand. 'You wait here until I know that this works,' he demands. 'And if anything happens to me, she will rip your throat out.'

I nod. 'It won't take long. You don't need to swallow it. Just chew it. That's all.'

Kyor's hand remains on my wrist as his mouth works at the root. There's nothing to do now but wait. Wait to see if Elska found the right plant or if both the prince and I are about to take our last breaths.

'I know you told Zelle,' I blurt into the silence. His shift is so minimal I doubt I would have felt it if he hadn't been holding me. But I do. Still, he doesn't respond. 'I know you told him you lied about my mother.'

'You really think this is the time to have this discussion?' He scoffs before descending into a coughing fit that has him slumping over his knees. When he finally speaks again, it's in a barely audible mutter. 'Fucking fool still thinks I'm redeemable.'

I'm surprised when the comment makes my heart hurt a little. *Atoning,* Zelle said.

Is Zelle the person who is waiting for Kyor at the end of this trial? The bond between the two makes it more than likely, but would they really allow one of our trainers to be involved in the Retterheld in such a manner? Then again, it's not like they're going to ask the king to wait around all night for Kyor to find him. And from the way Zelle spoke, it's not like there's anybody else Kyor is close to.

'How are you feeling?' I ask, nervous of the silence that's forming between us.

'Well enough to ram a fucking sword through your stomach for fucking poisoning me,' he snaps back. 'And believe me, if I don't finish this challenge, that's exactly what's going to happen.'

Somehow, the bravado behind the threat makes me feel better. He's clearly getting better if he can focus on his desire to kill me over his own pain.

Still, time is ticking and I need to find Kay. I pull my wrist out of his grip. A moment later, he's pushing himself onto his feet.

Before I can explain that I didn't *mean* to poison him, he murmurs, 'Less than an hour until sunrise.' I'm not sure if he's speaking to me or to Elska, but his next words are definitely aimed at the wolf. 'Come on, girl. Let's finish this.'

The giant creature lowers herself onto her haunches. Without hesitation, Kyor grabs a fistful of fur and leaps atop her. And then they're racing off into the depths of the woods.

My heart fills my mouth as I watch on, dumbfounded. It's true. She really *does* let him ride her.

Unbelievable. I wonder which of the other rumours about Kyor are also true, because I've heard a *lot.* Mostly centring around his skills with women and war.

As Kyor disappears, I consider following him. I've no doubt that Elska can sniff out whoever it is he has to find and take the most direct path there. But her footsteps are silent and the two of them are already long gone by the time I think to follow them. Instead, I head up a tree to check my surroundings.

I'm much closer to the lights now – that's the good news.

The bad news is that slivers of sunlight are breaching the horizon, the first mellow rays of morning lightening the sky as they slink over the trees.

How long does that give me till dawn? Kyor said less than an hour. I don't know if that was a guess or something Elska instinctively knew, but either way, I reckon he's right. Sixty minutes at most.

I need to move faster. I don't even try to be quiet.

'Kay!' I cry out into the night, picking up my pace. 'Kay! Kay!'

I try to listen as I run, praying I'm heading in the right direction. If I don't make it, then what will happen to Kay? Will she be safely sent back to Artur? If I'm kicked out of the Retterheld, how will I even speak to Jonas or Llinos to work out what I'm supposed to do next? They've both offered me a home afterwards, but what if they're still in the competition for another two moons? What am I meant to do in the meantime?

Panic is rising in my chest, making it difficult to breathe as I run.

'Rose! Where are you? Rose!'

It's a whisper on the wind, so quiet it's hard to believe I'm not imagining it. But then it comes again.

‘Rose! I’m here, Rose!’

Kay! My heart lurches so hard it seals my throat, and I break into a sprint.

‘Kay! Keep calling me, Kay! Keep calling me!’

‘I’m here, Rose! I’m here!’

With every step, her voice gets louder, but I’m still not there. *Gods, don’t take her from me now.* My chest is heaving as tendrils of light creep through the canopy above me, colouring the grey leaves with golden light.

‘Kay, I’m nearly there. I’m coming!’

‘Hurry, Rose! Hurry up! Don’t you dare screw this up now, or I swear to the Gods I will never forgive you! You hear me, Rose? Hurry the fuck up!’

Her voice is so loud I can hear the enunciation in every word, but I struggle to reply. My lungs burn. My body is wrecked.

‘Rose!’

‘I’m coming, Kay. I’m—’

The word is swallowed from my throat as I break into a clearing and see her standing there, bound to a tree with whips made of white light.

I don’t know if it’s the magic that’s holding her there or the way the sunlight is diffusing through the twigs and branches above, but her hair is luminous and her eyes are so vibrant that she looks like a Goddess. She is a creature of the forest, too perfect to possibly be human.

‘Rose, you need to touch me!’ she yells. ‘That’s the way to break the magic. You need to touch me. Quickly!’

It’s more of a grab than a touch, my arms squeezing so tightly around her tall frame that I’m surprised I don’t hear her bones crack. I’ve got her. I’ve got her.

‘You’re alive.’ Her voice breaks as she pushes herself back and wipes the tears from my cheeks. ‘I was so worried. I’ve been so worried. They said you were hurt by other Rettlings.’

‘It’s okay. It’s okay. We’re both all right. We’ll be all right.’ I don’t know if I’m holding her up, or if she’s holding me. All I know is that I don’t want to let go. And yet she steps back, her forehead creasing with concern.

‘They say you scaled a jötunn? That you defeated it without magic? And that another Rettling tried to kill you?’

‘I wouldn’t say I defeated it alone. It was a team effort. And as for Zara trying to kill me …’ I shrug. ‘I guess it didn’t help that I set her alight with a fire bead on our first night in the High Hold.’

She gapes at me. ‘Bloody hell, Rose! Tell me you’re joking?’

‘About her trying to kill me, or me setting her alight?’

‘Both!’

There’s something about the way she’s fretting that’s remarkably comforting. This is my sister, my Kay, gaping at me with bafflement, like she can’t quite understand how I’ve done what I’ve done. It’s a look she’s given me many a time, as though I’ve somehow pulled a miracle out of the bag, a meal from nothing.

‘It’s fine,’ I assure her. ‘Zara tried to kill me first so I was just teaching her that I’m not an easy target.’

‘Rose!’ I can’t tell if she’s scandalised or impressed. But I don’t care. She’s here. With me. That’s all that matters.

We’re both smiling through the salty tang of tears, and as Kay’s grip once again tightens on me, I finally look around. There are six trees like the one Kay was bound to. Five are now empty, while an old man is still bound to the other. His posture is hunched and his grey hair is limp around his shoulders where it blends with an identically coloured beard.

‘What do we do now?’ I ask Kay. ‘Will the priestess come to take you back?’

‘The others released their loved ones and then, after a moment or so, they disappeared.’

She lifts her hand in a wave to signify something disappearing, only to freeze partway through the gesture. Her face pales.

‘Kay?’

‘My ring. Mother’s ring!’ Before I can even respond she throws herself to the ground and starts looking through the dirt.

‘I had it. I know I did! Rose, I can’t have lost it. I can’t!’

Without hesitation, I join her on the cold earth, raking my hands over the leaf litter. ‘Don’t worry,’ I say. ‘We’ll find it.’ We have to. It’s Kay’s last memento of Mother.

‘What did you mean when you said the others “disappeared”?’ I ask.

‘Oh Gods,’ Kay moans. ‘Please, I—’

No sooner has she started to speak than the world begins to spin. The colours of the trees and the brightening sky blur as the forest floor drops away beneath our feet, taking with it any hope of finding Mother’s ring.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 39

When the ground appears again, it's a rocky road. No more crunching leaves, no tall trees with a twig-filled canopy. An unnatural weakness has afflicted my knees, sending me off balance.

Fear and adrenaline pour through me. 'Kay? Kay, where are you?' I spin around as flakes of snow drift down and settle on my skin. 'Kay!' The scream scrapes at my throat.

'They've taken them already,' a female voice says bitterly. 'They gave us just long enough for the briefest conversation.'

I blink at the figure beside me. It's Grenda. Grenda, with her fierce tattoos and rippling back muscles. Though now she barely resembles the knight I've grown used to. Her eyes are red-rimmed, and her shoulders are hunched.

'At least I saw him.' I hear the pain in her voice and my own anxiety momentarily fades.

'One of your sons?' I ask.

She nods and sniffs before taking a long, shuddering breath and stiffening her back. The transformation is instant. The mourning mother is gone, and the warrior has returned.

'My youngest,' she says. A small smile flickers on her lips now. 'He was well. It's been three years since I last saw him. They'll send him straight back to the front line now, I know that, but at least I got to hold him. I got to hold him for as long as possible. And he's well. Strong.' Pride courses through her words.

I curse myself. I spent too long with Kay talking about the trials and looking for the ring instead of telling her about Llinos and her offer for us to go live on Brandish with her after the trials. Thankfully, I know I'll get to continue the conversation with Kay at the ball.

I'd like to think that Korvane's commanders would give Grenda's son leave long enough to attend the dance too, but if it's up to Holden, there's no chance.

'Is this all of us?' I say as I look around. There are only two others on the road, and my gut clenches. 'Where are the others? Jonas? Llinos?'

The panic of nearly not having made it through the trial ebbs, giving rise to a cold dread that I'll have to endure the rest of it on my own.

'I saw one body in the woods while I was walking.' Grenda's voice is solemn. 'A young woman from Rowell. Elenor, I think her name is.'

In terms of the people from Rowell I hope won't make it, Elenor wouldn't be top of my list, but I also won't pretend to be saddened by this news.

'There must be others,' I say, thinking of the way Kyor sped through the woods on Elska's back. There's no way he didn't get back in time. Which means there's at least a chance that Llinos and Jonas are alive too, just in another portation group.

'What now?' I ask. 'Where are we meant to go?'

'I think I heard carriages. Horses' hooves that way.' Grenda nods her head. 'We should go see.'

There is no talking as we make our way down the path, until, sure enough, there is a carriage waiting there. Two other Rettlings are sitting inside. Oke from Rowell, and Moryal the wind weaver from Galreck.

My eyes instinctively settle on Oke. Does she know about Elenor? Should I tell her? I immediately dismiss the idea. The last thing I want is for her to think I had something to do with it. Though that thought is immediately compounded by another. *Maybe I did.* Oke's skin is sallow, as if she's spent the last five hours vomiting up her guts. Perhaps Elenor was too sick to survive, too weak to even try to fight off one of the dire wolves.

I do my best to shake the thought away because I didn't set out to kill anyone, but it gnaws at me all the same.

No one speaks on the journey back, and Oke is too wrecked to even try to bother glaring at me, which is a nice change. I assume the others, like

me, are thinking of the loved ones they got to hold for all too short a time and wondering whether their friends made it through the trial.

As the carriage stops and I step outside, a familiar figure is waiting for me. I run towards him, wrap my arms around him, and squeeze tightly.

‘Gods, I was worried about you,’ Jonas says, his voice muffled against my hair.

‘Llinos?’ I ask desperately. ‘Have you seen her? Is she back already?’

His eyes say it all, and the strength that had returned to my knees on the journey back is stolen once more. He hasn’t seen her.

Panic surges. ‘Have you checked inside? Maybe she went into the dining hall for something to eat. Or to see Caroline? Yes, maybe she’s in the library. We need to check.’ I’m babbling, and as I go to move, he grabs me by the wrist.

‘Zelle told me I was in the first carriage back. I’ve been out here the whole time.’

It’s well past dawn now, and given how close I cut it to finding Kay, I can’t believe there’s anyone still to come. So what does that mean? Is Llinos out of the Retterheld or is she—no, she can’t be. She can’t. I won’t even think it.

As I continue to turn, searching for any sign of Llin, my eyes fall on Zara. She looks horrific. Blood drips down her arms, cheeks, and side, and there’s a greenish stain on her leathers. She barely makes it two steps out of her carriage before she stumbles.

Oke, who looks only marginally better, takes her by the arms and mumbles something about the healers’ quarter.

How could *they* have made it and not Llinos?

‘Thorn, you and I need to talk.’ The voice is a growl in my ear that causes my blood to run cold. Slowly, I turn to find his gaze as cold as solid ice as he glares at me.

‘This isn’t a great time, Kyor,’ Jonas replies. ‘People didn’t make it.’

‘Oh, I’m well aware. But I wasn’t asking.’ The prince doesn’t break eye contact with me as Jonas looks between the pair of us.

‘I’ll be fine,’ I tell Jonas, attempting to hide my uncertainty.

‘I’ll be just over there,’ he replies.

Kyor scoffs. ‘Like you could do anything,’ he mutters.

‘Such humility. It’s a great look for a future king.’ The words leave my mouth before I can stop them, and when Kyor arches an eyebrow, I’m not

sure if I've amused him or pissed him off further.

'Humility doesn't bring men to their knees. Or women, for that matter.' From the glint in his eyes, he definitely finds himself amusing, though in a blink the glint is replaced with the stony look I've become accustomed to.

He pulls me aside and lowers his voice. 'You fucking poisoned me, Thorn,' he hisses. 'You tried to kill the heir to the throne? I could have your head for that.'

A tremble of nerves grips me, but I quash it the best I can.

'I didn't try to kill you.' I look around to see if anyone heard me and then lower my voice to match his volume. He's keen to keep our conversation private, and for obvious reasons, so am I. 'You weren't my target. I wanted to get to the Rowell crew after the FOF situation. You just drank from the wrong jug when I wasn't looking. I stopped you from taking another glass.'

His eyes glitter. 'The *one* time I go to the dining room,' he mutters, but his shoulders loosen a little.

'And it's not like I knew the trial was going to be today. None of us did.' I look him in the eyes and will him to believe me.

His lips part as if he's about to speak, but whatever he was going to say is interrupted by a shout behind us.

'Rose!'

'Llinos? Llinos!'

Just like Zara, Llinos is covered in blood. But her smile and eyes are bright, and that's all I need to see. A relieved laugh bursts from me as I race across to where she stands outside the final carriage.

'Llin! I didn't think you'd made it,' I say, moving to hug her, only for her to step back out of my reach.

'I nearly didn't.' She glances down at her arm and I see a chunk has been taken out of the top of it. Only a dire wolf could do that, which means the fact that she's still standing is a freaking miracle.

'It's not as bad as it looks,' she says. 'Actually, I'm not sure about that. One of the priestesses gave me something when I got to the carriage, so maybe it is. I feel pretty chilled out about it.'

'That'll be the paparvy,' I say. 'We need to get you to the healers.'

'I've got her,' Jonas says, sidling up beside us and placing his hand at the base of her spine to stop her from tumbling forward.

‘I think Caz’ll like it.’ Llinos’s voice is unusually loud. ‘I think she’ll find a scar hot, right? Maybe I should show her now.’ As she tries to twist away from us, Jonas and I hold her in place.

‘Nope, absolutely not. You can see Caz later. Healers first.’

A wide grin crosses Llin’s face as she sways from side to side, and I’m not sure if she’s about to hug me or pass out. She does neither.

‘Guess what, Rosey?’ she slurs. ‘Tonight you get to wear your new dress, and Jonas is going to want to fuck you so badly when he sees you in it.’ Her grin remains in place as she twists to the other side, to where Jonas is propping her up, his cheeks now a deep shade of red. ‘Oh, hey Jonas.’ Llinos’s voice rises excitedly. ‘I’ve altered Rose’s dress, and she’s gonna look so hot that you’re—’

‘Oh, I heard,’ he mutters, clearing his throat and avoiding my gaze. ‘Everyone heard. Please, let’s get you to the healers. Fast.’

As we carry her away between us, I try to ignore the way Kyor’s gaze burns a hole into my shoulder blades.



THEY’VE KEPT Llin in the healers all day, and Caroline is climbing the walls. When she last saw Llin it was at the very final moment of the trial, just before they were portated out of the clearing, and I’m willing to bet that the sight of Llin with her fresh bite is one that will stay with her for a long time.

‘Can you go down and check on her again?’ she asks me for the seventieth time as she paces our dorm. ‘They might have more news now.’

‘I was down there half an hour ago,’ I remind her again. ‘And she was fine.’

‘You said she was sleeping.’

‘She was. And that’s exactly what the healers said she should be doing.’ I place two hands on her shoulders, hoping to keep her still and not just because her pacing is making me dizzy. The last thing I want is for people from the floor below to come up to complain and find her here. I’m sure Caroline’s constant presence in the barracks is an open secret among many of the Rettlings, but that doesn’t mean she shouldn’t be careful.

‘Right. You’re right. Sleeping is probably best.’

As she continues to nod, Caroline moves to sit on one of the beds, only to jump to her feet again when the door swings open. Though rather than speaking or even starting to pace again, she remains frozen to the spot, her lips tightly pressed together as Benny steps into the room.

‘Any news?’ I ask him.

He shakes his head. ‘They only plan on bringing the Wrohelm bodies back. Those from other cities will be sent directly home. Those that they can find, anyway.’

My chest throbs. Llinos was in the last of the carriages to return to the High Hold, and I was so concerned about her that I didn’t even think about Loch. We don’t know if he simply didn’t make it to the clearing in time or if he was killed. All we know is that he didn’t make it back.

‘I’m sorry,’ I offer, knowing it will never be enough. ‘Is there anything we can do?’

I hope that he’ll give Caroline a job to keep her distracted, but he shakes his head. ‘No, it’s fine. I’m just going to go for a walk.’

‘Want some company?’ I don’t expect the answer to be yes, but I want to offer all the same.

‘No, it’s good. I’m just going to jump into the shower first.’

When he comes back out, he’s dressed not in his fighting leathers or his ball attire, but in an ordinary shirt and trousers. It’s strange to see him dressed so casually, and I can’t imagine where he’s planning to go. Perhaps the temple?

I’ve already been to give Etta my thanks, and I fully intend on doing it several times over between now and the next trial. Whenever that will be.

An hour later, Caroline’s nagging becomes too much to bear and I head back to the healers, where, to my surprise, Llinos is awake.

‘She needs to stay off the wine at tomorrow’s ball,’ the healer tells me. ‘We’ve used magic on the wound, but she’s had a fair amount of paparvy seed to help with the pain.’

‘Got it,’ I tell him, though I’m not even sure she’ll want to go to the ball. She might prefer to stay in with Caroline. I, however, cannot wait. Tomorrow night, I get to have a proper conversation with Kay, and this time, I won’t waste it.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 40

Caroline and Llin's reunion is understandably tear-filled, and as such it's several hours before Caroline eventually heads back to work. With her gone, Llin and I finalise my dress for tomorrow's ball. Llin has been working on it for days, but I haven't seen it. When she pulls out the finished article, I can't help but gape.

It is phenomenal. Part dress, part work of art.

As planned, Llinos removed the centre section from the layers and layers of flowing black tulle of the skirt so that my leather fighting shorts, thigh sheath, and an edge of dagger are visible beneath. My 'signature style,' she calls it. And the top is even more unique. The satin plunging V-neck is pure elegance, while the black sleeves are wired open, looking almost like wings fluttering behind me. There's no chance of me not standing out, that's for sure.

At breakfast the next morning, Leilah finds me and tells me she's spoken with Ruben and plans to share the scraps of food with the slums. I can't thank her enough and the timing couldn't be better as we'll be able to make use of the undoubtedly vast amount of waste from the ball tonight. With surviving the second trial, helping the slums, and getting to see Kay twice, this week's going to be tough to top.

That evening, Llinos continues to fuss over me, even once I've got the dress on.

'See,' she says in satisfaction. 'It's like a bat.'

As I stare at my reflection, that's not what I see. I see something with far more gravitas. And the way the tulle is layered reminds me of … feathers, I realise.

‘It looks more like a bird than a bat,’ Caroline comments from the bunk she’s lying on.

‘It does,’ I agree. ‘A raven.’

A collective shudder rolls through the room, and my eyes lift towards the window as though expecting to see a raven waiting there. It’s with an odd sense of disappointment that I find the sill empty. I should be relieved, shouldn’t I? Ravens are an omen of bad luck after all.

The battle yard was close to empty this morning, and Kyor missed my training session with Zelle, making knots form in my stomach. There’s a good chance that he still blames me for the poisoning, and I probably should have explained the situation a little better, but what else was there to add? He wasn’t my target, and I stopped him from dying in the woods. It’s pretty straightforward.

As always, I returned to the dining hall for breakfast after my session with Zelle, and the vast room offered my table a stark opportunity to see just how many were lost in the second trial. Less than we expected, we agreed. Along with Elenor and Loch, Stefan the knight, Del from Galreck, and one of the Rowell Rettlings were the only ones who didn’t make it. With Jonas and Kyor included, the Wrohelm Rettlings are down to half their original number.

It’s with a definite pang of relief that I see both Seiren and Kestria survived, while on the table next to them Clade, Nessira and Yeva are huddled together.

‘Maybe they thought we deserved something more gentle after the jötnar,’ Jonas suggested.

‘Maybe,’ Llin replied, though the tightening of her face suggested that she didn’t consider the piece missing out of her arm ‘gentle.’

Benny wasn’t there at breakfast or lunch, and neither is he here as we prepare to head over to the ball.

‘Still nothing about Loch’s body?’ I ask Llinos quietly as she slips on her own dress. This one is a vivid blue ballgown dotted with white flowers, which I once again assume is of her sister Carys’s choosing.

‘Not that Benny’s told me.’ She grimaces and mutters, ‘But then, I get the feeling there’s a lot he’s not telling me at the moment.’

‘Everything okay with you two?’ I ask tentatively. It’s the first time she’s brought up the tension between her and Benny, and I don’t want to let it go.

Her nostrils flatten as she draws a long breath in, only to release it with a sigh. She offers a watery smile.

‘Too much time together,’ she says simply. ‘Nothing more.’

Across the room, Caroline’s expression begs to differ.

There’s no denying it stings, knowing Llinos is lying to me, but we all came into this with our secrets, and no matter how our friendship has grown, I understand that there are some secrets we each have to keep.

After closing the zipper at the back of Llin’s dress, Caz moves over to the bed and grabs her bag. ‘I should get going,’ she says. ‘As Rohan’s family is at the ball, we can work at his house tonight. Have fun, and I’ll be here when you get back.’

‘I hate that you can’t come,’ Llin replies.

‘I know, but when you win this thing, you can demand it.’

Llin’s face spreads into a grin. ‘That sounds like a plan.’

Snow drifts down as Llin and I walk to the centre of the High Hold, and by the time we’re back indoors, goosebumps have risen on my arms and my fingers are completely numb.

A familiar face is waiting for us. He’s dressed in full formal attire, and once again has his blond hair tied back and long beard tamed and braided.

‘Wow.’ Jonas steps forward and takes my arm. ‘You look … wow …’

A slight tinge colours my cheeks as I remember Llinos’s drug-induced comment about how he’d feel about my dress, but judging from the way he’s looking at me, she wasn’t wrong.

‘Llin’s the seamstress so deserves the credit,’ I deflect uncomfortably. ‘She’s phenomenal.’

‘Right …’ Jonas replies, as if he can’t manage more than one syllable.

Silence threatens to sweep in around us, but before it can, I’m slammed into from the side.

‘What took you so long?’

The instant I get my breath back, it’s stolen again. Kay. Looking more beautiful and full of life than I ever thought possible. My lungs tremble with joy and tears fall as I pull her as close to me as possible, and when I finally move back, it’s only so I can see her more clearly.

We’re still by the door, the cold wind whipping in from outside, and yet I barely feel it. Instead, I’m completely consumed with taking in every part of her the way I should have done in the forest. Her hair in my hands, her face cupped in my palms …

It’s only been six weeks or so, but she’s changed. Filled out. She looks healthy. The healthiest I’ve ever seen her.

‘Thank the Gods,’ I breathe, going in for another hug.

‘It’s okay. You can let go of me now.’ She grins. ‘Just till we get somewhere warmer. I’m freezing! Artur keeps his home so warm that the slightest chill gets to me now. It’s mad how quickly you can get used to luxury.’ Her eyes are a little haunted by her own comment. She may be getting used to luxury, but she hasn’t forgotten the slums. I doubt either of us ever will.

‘Artur’s taking good care of you?’ I ask, still not ready to let go of her yet.

‘He is. Don’t look so worried. It’s been incredible, really. But I want to know about you. Tell me about the jötnar.’

‘It was a team effort, really.’ The comment reminds me to turn to my side. ‘Llinos, this is my sister, Kay. Kay, Llinos. Jonas, you’ve met, right?’

‘We have.’ She smiles at Jonas. ‘I’m so grateful for all the kindness your family has shown me.’

‘It’s been our honour. I’m afraid I can’t stay and chat though. I need to go and talk to my father.’ He shifts his gaze to me. ‘But perhaps we can share a dance later, Rose?’

‘Of course.’ I smile.

He leans in, and for a second, I panic. He’s not going to kiss me here in front of Kay, is he? I turn my head to the side, planning to peck him on the cheek, only for him to do the same, and our lips land against one another in a clumsy kiss.

‘See you later,’ he says with a surprised grin.

Meanwhile, I fight a grimace.

‘Oh, good Gods!’ Kay hisses, pulling me towards her the second he’s out of earshot. ‘Are you and Jonas a thing? Will was telling me how Jonas told him that—’

‘No, we are not a thing.’

‘They totally are,’ Llinos replies, leaning towards us with an impish grin.

Kay’s smile is so broad I can practically feel the joy radiating from her. ‘I need you to fill me in on everything. Although can we please get away from the door? As I said, it’s freezing. And I want to dance.’

I follow her into the ballroom, barely even looking at the show-stopping chandelier, the black and red roses that decorate the place, or the platters of food and drink. All my attention is on Kay and the way she moves so effortlessly through the room, as if she was born to be here. The irony is not lost on me.

'William has had to undertake some errands for Artur today, but you've already met him, right?' Kay asks. 'In some ways, I'm actually glad he's not here. He's been trying to teach me to dance, but honestly, he's terrible. You'd think he was the one who had never attended these things before, rather than me.' She stops to look at me. 'Don't tell him I said that though, will you?'

'No, of course not.' I can't stop the grin that's raising my cheeks. This loquacious version of my sister, so confident, so at home … it's a wonder to see. It's what I've dreamed of.

A waiter walks past and Llinos offers the drinks a longing look.

'Next time,' I tell her firmly. 'You can drink next time.'

'Just a little one?' she asks wistfully, reaching out.

I swat her away. 'No!'

She rubs her hand. 'Your sister is a real ball-buster,' she complains to Kay.

'Yeah.' Kay grins. 'But you should take it as a compliment. She only does that because she loves you.'

'I think she's okay too,' Llin admits, shooting me a smirk, but it quickly drops as her gaze flicks to someone behind me. She offers a courteous nod to whoever approaches us, and from the wariness in her eyes, I assume it's either someone she doesn't know or someone she wishes she didn't. As she melts into the crowd, a glance over my shoulder reveals a man of similar age to me striding towards us.

'I was wondering where you'd got to,' he says, stretching out his hand to Kay. When she offers hers, he takes it and lifts it to his lips. 'I thought I'd stepped on your feet one too many times and you'd gone in search of a different dance partner.' He laughs.

'Not at all.' She beams. 'I was just finding my sister. Rose, this is Hew.'

Hew is ridiculously pretty, with floppy ginger hair, a plump mouth, brown eyes, and pale skin. I can see why Kay would feel flattered by his attention, but that's only because she's disturbingly unaware of how beautiful *she* is.

‘The infamous Rose Kultavaris.’ Hew stretches out his hand, and I offer my own for Kay’s sake. ‘Pleased to make your acquaintance at last. I have heard much about you.’

‘From Kay or other sources?’ There’s a bristliness to my voice and yet he smiles.

‘Both.’

‘Is that so?’ My skin prickles at his suaveness. It reminds me of all the men and women who turned their backs on my parents. Maybe his family was among them? Still, I offer him a tight, polite smile. ‘Do I want to ask who else has been talking about me?’

‘Probably not. Although, by the looks of it, the main culprit is on his way over now.’

He nods his head, gesturing behind us to the figure walking our way. And it really is one hell of a figure.

Kyor’s interpretation of formal wear is nothing more than a white shirt and tightly fitted trousers, but he still outshines the guests around him. I don’t know how he does it, but every time I see him his eyes appear bluer and his shoulders broader. Of course, his overall appeal is also enhanced by the fact that he’s cleaned up since all the heaving and retching in the forest.

‘You’re friends with Kyor?’ I ask.

‘Hew was in the forest for the prince to save,’ Kay answers me. ‘Though he was kept in another part from me.’

So it’s not just Zelle that Kyor is close to. Interesting.

‘The prince and I have been friends since childhood,’ Hew says with unconcealed self-importance. ‘There’s not a thing I wouldn’t do for him.’

‘Interesting company you’ve picked here, Howells.’ Kyor ignores me completely as he speaks to Hew.

‘Yes, well, I was just going to ask Kay for another dance. Perhaps make up for my previous lack of skill.’

His eyes glitter at Kay and I don’t like it.

‘You really weren’t that bad,’ she replies with a tinkling laugh before taking his arm.

Before she can take a single step away, I reach out and grab her. ‘I thought we were going to talk. Catch up?’

Conflict flashes on her face. ‘Of course, yes.’ She bites her lip.

‘Let her have some fun,’ Kyor chides from behind me. ‘This is meant to be a ball, remember? And you have all night to talk. I’m sure Hew won’t

keep her for long.’

He’s right. I don’t want to stop her from enjoying herself. Not when she looks so happy.

‘Find me after the dance,’ I instruct tightly.

‘Of course,’ she replies, her smile tightening. ‘Though maybe after the second one.’

I’m unable to draw my narrowed eyes away from Kay and Hew as they walk towards the dance floor.

‘She’s eighteen, right?’ Kyor says. ‘She doesn’t need your permission to do anything.’

‘She’s eighteen and she knows nothing about the way the court works.’

‘And you recall such matters, do you?’ he asks softly. ‘Well then, Kultavaris, you’ll recall how essential it is to curry royal favour. Dance with me.’

It’s not a request, and I hate that, but he’s right, damn him. I can’t afford to spit at him in front of the whole court, not if I want Kay to stand a chance of belonging here if I win the gifting.

The music strikes up, and Kyor holds out a hand. I take it, trying to ignore the burst of static as his fingers curl around mine. Wordlessly, I allow him to guide me to the dance floor where he places his other hand on the small of my back, sending shockwaves through my body.

My breath catches as momentary panic rises through me, and it’s only partially because the prince has his hands on me. I’m not actually sure that I remember how to dance. I don’t even recognise what music this is, other than it’s not a waltz. As I grapple for memories of my previous life, Kyor draws me to him, the strength of his movements guiding me, leading me.

His body presses against mine, and unwanted heat floods through me.

‘Don’t worry. I’ll go slowly,’ he whispers against my ear. The heat of his presence becomes stifling, and I realise this is nothing more than another excuse to torture me. His thigh brushes mine again and again, and each turn and step drags me across the hard lines of him. I wish Llin had never cut that damned front panel out.

As I struggle to keep my breath even, his eyes catch mine and I see the glint within those pale irises. He knows exactly what he’s doing to me, and I hate him all the more for it.

Other than his initial remark, we’re silent as we dance, though words aren’t needed given that the taunting caress of his flesh against mine says it

all. The thin fabric of my dress is barely a barrier for my hardening nipples, which ache with every brush of my chest against his. My legs want to twine around him, not step neatly in time with him. In fact, every part of me screams to close the last inches between us, to feel his mouth on mine, to tear away civility and give in to the mess of need clawing at my insides. Need I never thought possible; it is primal and desperate and affecting every fibre in my body.

And the worst of it? He knows. I can feel it in the way his hand presses just a fraction firmer on my back, in the way his breath ghosts my ear, making me shudder. The tension between us is so thick I could choke on it, and the urge to run my hands across his skin is almost overwhelming.

As Kyor twirls me across the dance floor, I feel the weight of a hundred sets of eyes. Watching. Judging. Whispers ripple through the crowd, speculation sparking in every stolen glance.

Among them, I catch sight of Zelle. He's dressed in his uniform – a clear indication that he'll be working and not enjoying the frivolities tonight. Still, he's smiling as though the sight of Kyor and me moving in step – so different from our usual sparring – pleases him. When his gaze finally locks with mine, that smile deepens. A moment later, he's melted back into the crowd. No doubt back to work.

Finally, the music comes to an end, and the moment Kyor's fingers release mine, I flee into the crowd without a backward glance. I agreed to a dance, not to a conversation. Thankfully, I see salvation in the form of the formally dressed Benny and head straight towards him.

'Where have you been all day?' I ask, trying to focus on anything other than Kyor Knavin.

'Just praying,' he replies. 'Are we going to talk about that?' He gestures to the dance floor.

'No more than we're going to talk about your "praying,"' I fire back sharply.

He winces a little, and I know I've found my mark. Whatever Benny was doing, it wasn't consulting the higher powers. 'Fair.'

The music begins anew and apprehension curls in my gut as I watch Kay and Hew dance together again. I press my lips together. She doesn't know that two dances in a row signal serious intent, that Hew is telling all others that Kay is his to court, and that by accepting the second dance, she is telling the rest of the nobles the same.

Kay’s practically floating in her green dress, eyes sparkling with joy. I have to admit that she and Hew make a striking pair; there’s no doubt about that. And from the way he glides, pulling her into every turn, the only way he’s been stepping on her feet is if it’s been deliberate.

I scan the crowd, trying to spot Artur, only to realise I have an issue. I no longer know what Artur Lorathin looks like. My memories of him are hazy at best, and the truth is, I struggle to see a face I recognise outside of the Rettlings. What I need is to find Jonas so that he can reintroduce us. Changing plans, I begin looking for my fellow Rettling, but before I can even work out where to start, a voice cuts through the ballroom.

‘Murderer! Korvane, you will pay for what you’ve done!’

A second later, the room is engulfed in total darkness.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 41

The screaming starts immediately and intensifies as magic is thrown out into the cloud of blackness that consumes us. Coloured blasts illuminate the ballroom with split seconds of blinding intensity, only to fade instantly, leaving coloured blurs in front of my eyes and an ashy tang at the back of my throat as I'm jostled from side to side. After that, screams and darkness are all that fill the room.

Having my sight ripped away from me is terrifying, but thanks to Jonas and Seiren, I've experienced similar before. So I pull myself together, ignore the fear, and focus on finding Kay.

'Kay!' I scream, trying to make my voice heard above all the crying wails, but it's impossible.

Panic rises through me. I can't lose her here. She can't have survived years in the slums only to die in the Godsdamn High Hold because of my decision to enter the Retterheld.

'Kay!' I shout again. I'm struck from the side again, but this time whoever it is holds me firmly and twists my shoulders.

'Get to the edge of the room, Rose.' Benny's voice peals through the darkness. 'Stay there. Out of the way.'

'I need to find Kay!' I argue.

'I'll try,' he promises. 'I can't see everything, but I'll try.'

With my heart beating fast enough to choke me, I stretch out my hands, feeling in front of me, and when I find the grooves of the wood panels, I do as Benny says, bracing myself against the wall. I remove my dagger from its sheath before calling my sister's name again.

'Kay! Kay, I'm here! I'm here!'

My throat cracks, and as I go to scream her name again, a voice bellows, ‘Silence! All of you! You will listen!’

For a heartbeat, I assume the voice is being amplified by magic, but as my skull begins to pound, the truth hits me. *It’s inside my head.* The voice is *inside* my head.

‘You need to hear the truth! You need to hear what your *great* king is doing to the people of his kingdom.’ The voice is thick with sarcasm and disdain.

The screams have turned to whimpers, and I’m not sure if I’m among the people making the sound. This magic’s so loud that I can barely form a thought, though there is only one that matters. I need to get to Kay.

‘Tonight is the night you will hear the truth …’ the voice continues. ‘Tonight you—’

An agonised scream detonates inside my skull, spearing straight into my mind. And then … *snap.*

In the space of a single heartbeat, both the darkness and the voice inside my head vanish.

One minute, my senses have been dominated by powers beyond my control; the next, the room returns before my eyes and my head is my own.

My hand flies to my mouth at the sight of the ballroom. Several bodies lie prone on the floor, smashed glasses and blood smeared on the wood around them.

‘Kay!’ No sooner has her name left my lips than I spot a glimpse of her green dress on the edge of the dance floor. Hew has put himself between her and whatever this threat is, and relief slams into me with such intensity that my knees buckle.

Hew may have come across as an arrogant arsehole, but at least he’s protecting my sister.

Now that I know she’s safe – for now – I tear my eyes from Kay and assess the situation. It takes less than a heartbeat to understand why the magic stopped so suddenly.

‘You took your time, Commander,’ Korvane says as he takes a sip from his drink.

‘Apologies, Your Majesty,’ Zelle replies. ‘I was walking the walls.’ I note that the commander doesn’t look at the king as he speaks. Instead, his attention is on a woman in the crowd with ash-blonde hair and deep mauve lips.

‘Do you want to do this the easy way or the hard way?’ Zelle says, his eyes still locked on hers.

‘I think it might be harder than you think.’ She smiles and the instant Zelle takes a step towards her, two dozen other men and women step out from the crowd, all of them armed, including one with a sword of ice formed in his grip.

‘Issen!’ someone screams.

Chaos breaks loose yet again, and beside me, another ice wielder appears. These aren’t like the Issen I was told about as a youth, with white eyes and white skin. Instead, their skin tones and eye colours are as varied as those of the men and women of Morathka. That thought has barely entered my head when a single ice bolt is hurled towards the king, only for it to be extinguished in a blast of air before it reaches Korvane.

My heart thuds. It shouldn’t be possible for them to use magic this close to Zelle.

‘They have their own siphon!’ The cry goes out just as I arrive at the same conclusion. It’s impossible to tell if their siphon is strong enough to nullify Zelle’s powers completely, but given that I’ve seen the commander mute the powers of forty Rettlings without breaking a sweat, the flicker of something close to consternation that crosses the old man’s face is alarming.

Another shard of ice comes out of nowhere, and heads turn in the direction it came from. The panic that started to fade at Zelle’s appearance has returned, and people are rushing to exit the ballroom when someone hurls what appears to be molten metal at one of the attackers. A woman with bright blonde hair drops to the ground, dead, the ice of her own formation melting around her.

She can’t be Issen, can she? Issen, here? So far from the Coltan Mountains? Yet the Issen are the only ones gifted with ice, and so I have no other explanation. What the hell is going on?

There must be at least a dozen ice weavers and fire wielders working together in here, all wanting the king dead. The ice weavers are undoubtedly Issen, but the fire wielders? *Rebels.*

I’ve heard whispers, of course, in the slums. Angry people insisting that if we rose up together, we would be able to fight back. But I dismissed such voices as naïve fools. No one in the slums has the energy, let alone the

resources, to dethrone a king. Yet here they are, inside the palace, fighting with their lives.

Grenda is one of the first Rettlings to jump into action, and she disarms the first attacker with a flick of the wrist. I still have no idea what her power is, but from the way the rebel facing her writhes in pain, I reckon it's something to do with manipulating bodies.

All the while, the king stands unmoved, a bored expression on his face as he sips his drink, as if he can't even see what's happening in front of him.

There's so much magic in the air that it's impossible to tell where it's coming from or how to avoid it.

Half the Rettlings have joined in, including all five remaining knights, but I can't tell what we're up against and how many rebels there are. Twenty? Forty? A hundred? How far does this go?

I squeeze the hilt of my dagger, but for the first time in an age, I wish for a sword.

Scouring the room, I find Kay is still with Hew, who is holding her tight. Every muscle in my body wants to run to her, to protect her, but I know that doing so will only draw unwanted attention to me and potentially get us both caught in the crossfire. As much as I hate it, the only thing I can do is trust her with Kyor's oldest friend.

Odetta and Mattieu are both casting flame after flame, and while hers seem indiscriminate, Mattieu specifically aims at a female rebel close to him. With the strength of his power, I expect the woman to be cinders in no time, but instead she grasps the fiery bundle of magic roaring towards her with her own power and twists it back in the other direction. Before it meets its targets, it evaporates, and it only takes me a heartbeat to see why. Zelle. He's trying to protect the Rettlings as well as the king, and somehow he's managing it, even with someone siphoning his magic. His hands are moving constantly, his right hand using his sword to block any strikes that come towards him, his left pulling daggers from his belt, which he throws at every target he spots. Though how he can tell the rebels from the people simply running for the door, I have no idea.

Realising their tactics aren't working, the rebels are suddenly on Zelle, at a ratio of four to one, and judging by the way two of them are using magic, he still hasn't brought the siphon down yet.

At least one of those he's fighting is an Issen, though I would never have known it to look at her. Her frozen blade disappears and reappears in

the blink of an eye, constantly grazing the commander, yet never getting close enough to strike home. She has magic enough to form the weapon, but not enough skill to use it properly.

Dozens of people stand around, watching on, all fearful of getting too close. Thankfully, Grenda isn't one of them.

'On your left, Commander,' she calls out.

'Find that fucking siphon!' he barks back.

It's the first time I've ever heard him swear, and judging by the fear that flashes across the faces of the guards and other nobles, it's not a good sign.

Zelle and Grenda form a rhythm, her swordwork as impressive as his, yet it's not enough. And I'm not the only one who sees it. As Zelle continues to battle the icy blade of the Issen, Kyor grabs a sword from some noble's waistband – probably meant for display – and moves towards the two of them. But Zelle shakes his head.

'Don't you fucking dare,' he snaps. 'Respectfully,' he adds.

'Don't be a fool,' Kyor snarls. Fighting close to Zelle means Kyor's magic is also removed, but his skill with a blade is not. More rebels swarm in, and Kyor faces them, sword swinging deftly.

Steel flashes in the dim candlelight, each strike swift and economical as Kyor moves like water over stone – fluid, unstoppable – cutting down the first rebel before the man can even raise his weapon. My eyes follow him as he falls to the ground and his body lands with a thud. I know I shouldn't be staring, that I need to be doing something, but the tattoo on the rebel's wrist has me frozen.

Delicate black ink weaves up his arm, outlining a thin tendril of smoke. It's identical to Peter's and the one I saw on the carriage driver.

Before I can contemplate what this means, a second rebel lunges at the prince, only to be met with a twist of Kyor's wrist and the snap of steel biting flesh. Every motion is precise and deliberate, and several rebels falter, their fury curdling into fear as they realise too late that even without magic, Kyor is still death incarnate.

No matter how many are cut down, more rebels rush in. *How many of them are there?*

I can no longer stand on the sidelines and watch. Clenching my dagger, I'm about to wade into the fray when my eyes fall on one of the rebel bodies, and I freeze yet again. The shock of red hair. The paintbrush freckles. My body stiffens. It can't possibly be…? But it is. Peter's lifeless

eyes stare at me accusingly, his flaming red hair coated in blood, just like the tattoo on his wrist. I cast my gaze around the room and find another body. This time the smoke tattoo weaves up the side of her neck. It was never just a random tattoo that Peter liked to display. It was a sign. A sign of what he was. A rebel.

Panic surges through me. I never saw the same mark on Ruben's body, but he and Peter were inseparable. Does that mean he's here too? I whirl around wildly, trying to find my former lover among the press of the crowd.

I don't see him, but that doesn't mean he isn't here. Godsdamn it.

Zelle's pushing the rebels back inch by inch, reclaiming the ballroom, and all the while, King Korvane sips his drink like this is all some elaborate entertainment he ordered that's disappointing him.

I falter because suddenly I'm not sure whose side I'm on. Killing King Korvane has been a recurring dream of mine for as long as I can recall. But taking on Zelle? And Kyor? Fuck. I don't even know where my head's at, let alone what I'm meant to do.

While I watch, Zelle slices straight through an Issen, then pulls the sword out and goes for the next one, but his blade meets nothing but air.

No friction. No slowing. Nobody.

'It's an illusion!' somebody shouts.

There wasn't an Issen ice warrior at all. It was all a distraction, and seconds later, we see what it was really for.

A rebel shimmers into existence, materialising only inches behind Zelle, and his blade arcs in a cruel, merciless sweep, steel whispering as it slices across the commander's throat.

For an instant, everything slows. Zelle's eyes widen, shock flashing there as disbelief collides with pain. His lips part as though he might speak, but only a wet gurgle escapes. Blood blossoms in a vivid spray as his trembling hand lifts, pressing uselessly against the wound as though sheer will might hold him together.

Horror grips me because I'm a healer's daughter. I know the difference between wounds that beg to be mended and wounds that mock the very idea of hope. This is one of the latter.

The commander's blood pours too fast, too freely, and there is nothing left for me to do but watch him die.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 42

‘Zelle, no!’

Kyor’s voice echoes through the hall as he races forward to where his tutor, his confidant, his friend, is lying on the ground, blood pouring from him.

If the rebels thought the prince was deadly before, it is nothing compared to what he becomes now. He cuts through the remaining rebels like they are paper, and the few survivors decide to flee.

‘Where’s a healer?’ Kyor shouts as he slides onto the marble floor, lifting the old man’s head onto his lap as he tries to stem the blood with his fingers. ‘Where’s a fucking healer!’

It’s too late, I want to say, but I don’t. The words are cruel and unnecessary. Kyor’s a soldier; he’s seen death – *dealt* death – so many times, and he knows there’s no light left in Zelle’s eyes. He just can’t accept it.

A man walks forward from the crowd, but rather than going to Zelle, he stops and looks at the king, who offers a shake of his head.

‘He needs a healer!’ Kyor cries again.

‘You’re making a fuss, son,’ Korvane drawls. ‘There’s nothing that can be done. Now, get off the floor. You’re not a peasant.’ His face is taut, the disdain he feels for his only son stark. And I’m sure I’m not the only one who hears the threat in his words.

Kyor looks up at his father in disbelief.

‘He saved your fucking life! Do something!’

The king’s lip rises in what is close to a sneer. ‘What he did was his job. Very well, as it happens. But there is nothing that can be done now, and

there is no benefit to you making a scene.' He lifts his gaze to the room, curling his lips into a smile. 'Someone clean up this mess. We still have a ball to enjoy.'

Most people shuffle, trying to look anywhere but at the ghastly scene before them, but some do as commanded and go to remove the dead bodies of the rebels.

I can't draw my eyes away from Kyor. The white of his eyes. The slump of his shoulders. His pain is so palpable I can feel it burning into my own chest.

'Music,' the king says gruffly, clapping his hands. 'Let's have the music playing again. We should be dancing. But first, someone deal with this.' He gestures to Zelle's corpse.

The blood has stopped pulsing now. Zelle's gone. I know it. Everyone knows it. Everyone but Kyor, who refuses to accept it. Servants appear from the hallways, ready to remove the bodies of the dead, and yet none even dare to approach Kyor.

'Rose! Thank the Gods!' My sister's voice pulls my gaze away from the prince, and a gasp leaves my lips as I see the blood on her forehead.

'You're bleeding! What happened? We need to get you to a healer!'

'It's fine. It's not mine.'

'It was just a nick.' Hew is beside her and he shifts his posture to show me the cut at the top of his shoulder.

'Thank the Gods. And thank you for keeping her safe.'

He dips his chin as I pull Kay into me. Her warmth is a poultice to the fear that filled me. When we break away, she looks back up to Hew, only to find his attention has shifted to Kyor.

The prince is still on his knees. Lost.

'He needs you.' I speak so quietly I barely hear myself. I try again. 'Hew, the prince. He needs you. He needs a friend.'

Hew's face is grey. 'That's not how he works,' he says finally. 'Best to leave him be. Do as the king said. Dance. Enjoy the ball.'

Coward, I think harshly. Fucking coward.

Zelle was right then, yet again. Kyor doesn't have many people around him he can trust, not when his supposed best friend won't even risk Korvane Knavin's wrath for him.

Kyor stares glassy-eyed and in shock. It's like all the power has been stripped from him. Suddenly, he lurches to his feet, turns on his heel

without a word, and marches out of the ballroom.

I watch him go, and something snaps in me. ‘Kay, stay with Hew. Don’t leave his side, all right?’

‘Why?’ Her brow crinkles. ‘Where are you going?’

‘I’ll be back in a minute,’ I say, sheathing my dagger then walking out of the ballroom and into the piercing night.

The snow has almost stopped, and Kyor’s footprints are pristine shadows in the white blanket covering the ground, leading straight across the courtyard and out of the western arc. More footprints appear, criss-crossing the prince’s, but I don’t break my stride, following the set going straight to the eastern arc, to the battle yard. I’d bet my place in the Retterheld that’s his destination, because of course he’d pick the furthest point in the High Hold to escape to on a night when it’s sub-zero.

Screw etiquette. Next time, I’m wearing my furs to the ball.

I don’t know why I’m following him or what I hope to gain by running into the night after a prince of the realm. As a good Rettling, I should still be at the ball, drinking wine with Kay, pushing what just happened from my mind the way the king expects us to.

Pretending we didn’t just lose someone we love and respect.

But that’s precisely why I left, and why my feet won’t stop walking. Because I learned long ago that pretending doesn’t work. And right now, Kyor needs *someone* to grieve with him.

Just as I expected, I find him in the battle yard, pounding his fists against the wall. His hands are bare, blood dripping down his knuckles.

‘Kyor,’ I murmur his name.

He whirls and looks at me, shaking his head before snorting in disgust.

‘Just what I need tonight. A damn thorn in my side.’ His words are bitter, but I’ve seen lashing out in grief – hell, I’ve done it myself a time or two – so I let the harsh words slide off me.

‘Kyor.’ I walk towards him. ‘I’m so sorry.’

He grunts. No words, just the sound of his broken heart choking his chest as he takes his knife and digs it into the wall, carving another long line into the brickwork. That’s when I notice the part of the wall that he’s standing at. It’s the place I noticed all those weeks ago, when Benny and I were watching the other Rettlings. The area with all the lines etched into the stone. And Kyor has just added another line to the tally.

A sinking feeling takes hold in my gut. ‘They’re yours, aren’t they? The marks? They’re people you’ve seen die.’

I try to squash the horror that rises within me at the sheer number of them.

He doesn’t look at me. Doesn’t stop digging tiny fragments out of the rock face.

‘They didn’t try,’ he says harshly as his knife continues to work at the stone. ‘No one fucking tried to save him.’

‘They couldn’t do anything,’ I tell him gently. ‘The way the kin—the way your father spoke was cruel. No, beyond cruel. Zelle deserved more than that. But no one could have saved him. When blood leaves the body that fast … it’s already too late.’

His dagger is still clenched in his hand as he swivels around and points it at me.

‘What are you doing here, Thorn?’ His eyes lock onto mine and that piercing blue holds me so fast that it makes everything else in the world fade away.

My heart pounds as I take a step closer.

‘I don’t know,’ I say truthfully. ‘I didn’t want you to be alone. You don’t deserve to have to face this alone.’

A pause holds the silence between us before he scoffs.

‘Why?’ he asks, but the question is torn from him, and I’m not sure if he’s asking why Zelle died, or why I’m here.

‘You’ve seen all these people die?’ I say, touching the rockface.

He glances at the wall and dismisses it with a shrug. ‘You fight in wars, you see people die.’ He says it as if it’s nothing, but it’s not nothing. He wouldn’t be out here if it were, nor would the marks be carved into the stone.

Silence sweeps between us once more as I look at the wall, suddenly aware of two things. One is that the weather has changed again to icy sleet, and the other is that the etching he’s just made for Zelle is covered in blood. Blood that will dry brown and stain the stone. I now understand the colour staining some of the other tallies.

‘These ones,’ I say, pointing to the row before Zelle’s mark, ‘these were for the soldiers who died on the front, aren’t they?’

This time, he snaps around to face me.

‘What do you want, Thorn? Did you think finding me here, vulnerable and broken, would finally give you the courage to kill me? Well, go on. Go on, I give you permission. I absolve you of any blame Etta might place on you. I’m the one who ruined your life so you’re justified in ending mine, and we both know it.’

He rips open his shirt, revealing his bare chest and the rings of tattoos I’ve seen time and time again in my head. The sleet melts against the warmth of his skin, causing the water to trickle down his body, glinting off all of the sharp angles. He takes another step towards me.

‘I’m sure you’ve got that pretty dagger of yours on you. Do it. I won’t fight back. End this. Etta won’t blame you.’

I sigh and scrub at my eyes. Now, in this moment, I can be honest with myself. Stabbing Kyor Knavin is the furthest thing from my mind.

‘No,’ I say.

Rather than looking pleased, he reaches out and unsheathes my dagger.

‘Do it!’ he yells, pressing it into my hand, trying to prise my fingers open and make me take it. ‘You want me dead. Fucking *own* it, Thorn.’

‘I’m not going to kill you, Kyor.’ I don’t even reach for the blade, keeping my fist closed tight.

‘Why not? It’s what you want. It’s what we both want! We want each other dead.’

‘No.’ I shake my head. ‘We don’t. Not anymore.’

‘You’re fucking lying,’ he snaps at me. He’s inches from my face, his eyes glaring in a way that should have me cowering. But it doesn’t.

I hold his gaze. ‘Zelle thought you were redeemable.’ I take a deep breath. ‘And so do I. You were a child, Kyor. You were a child, and you lashed out because you were in pain. So much pain. I know that type of pain, Kyor. Just as I know the pain you’re in now. Because you loved Zelle. And he loved you, too.’

I reach out my hand and place it against his chest. Sleet streams down my face, into my eyes, and through my hair, but I don’t move to brush it away. Instead, I stay as I am, rooted, clinging to this single point of contact. Because in this moment, all I want is to be tethered to him. To make him feel my presence. To remind him, remind both of us, that no one deserves to feel so utterly alone in the world.

His eyes narrow as they glance down at my hand, as if he doesn’t understand what it’s doing there. As if he doesn’t understand the simplicity

of touch.

‘Why are you here, Thorn?’ he asks, his voice plaintive and lost.

Rain is pouring over us now.

‘I’m here because you need someone.’

‘Yesterday you poisoned me, and today you’re … what? Trying to save me?’

‘You don’t need saving. This wasn’t your fault. And I didn’t poison you, not on purpose, and you know it.’

As his eyes linger on mine, they shift, filling with something I can’t read. It’s hot, strong, and hypnotic. And it’s muddling my mind.

With a yank of my hand, I pull myself away from him.

‘We need to get back to the b-ball,’ I stammer, suddenly needing to leave. Because if I stay, things will get … complicated. ‘I need to see my sister.’

He shakes his head, but his eyes soften. ‘I’m not going back in there. You should, though. Speak to your sister. You don’t know when you’ll get the chance again.’ He winces and bites down on his lip. ‘Fuck. I wasn’t saying that because I think you’re going to die. I just meant … hell, I don’t even know what I meant.’ He licks his lips and shakes his head ruefully.

‘You know, you look damned good dripping wet, with that obscene dress plastered to you. I’ve wanted to rip it off you all night.’ He takes in a shuddering breath, visibly trying to get a hold of himself. ‘You need to go, Thorn, before I won’t let you.’

I swallow audibly and, wishing I could control the drumming in my chest, turn my back on him and walk away.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 43

Llinos is waiting at the doorway and she rushes towards me when she sees me.

'Rose, thank the Gods. Where have you been? Kay said you ran out after Kyor?'

'Not exactly …' I'm not sure why I'm lying to her, but I can't bring myself to share what's happened even with her.

'And why the hell are you so wet?' she adds, plucking at my sodden gown.

This question, at least, I can answer. 'It was raining.'

'Not here, it wasn't.'

A glance back outside is all it takes for me to see she's right. My footprints from earlier still mark the snow.

The rain … it must have been Kyor. It's not just lightning, but the entire spectrum of the storm he controls. I wonder if he even knew he was doing it.

'You need to get dry.' Llinos chews on her bottom lip. 'It'll be cold, but it'll be fast, and then you can head to one of the fires to warm up.'

I'm about to ask what the hell she's talking about when the blast hits me. Pure cold air whips through my hair and dress, covering every inch of my skin in goosebumps and instantly making me start to shiver.

'Better,' she says appraisingly as she steps back. 'But as I said, you need to get warm.' She grimaces. 'And give your hair a brush. Come on, let's find Kay and get you by a fire.'

A quick squeeze of my hair tells me that party trick of hers works well. Wind weaver, seamstress extraordinaire, and walking hair dryer. Some

friends come with real benefits.

As I make my way back into the ballroom, it's almost impossible to believe that this is the same place where, less than an hour ago, the king was attacked and one of the most beloved commanders of his guards was killed. The wine is flowing even more freely than before and the music is beating out a quick, jovial pulse to which men and women are throwing themselves across the dance floor. The sight of it curdles my stomach.

'Rose, where did you go?' Jonas is on me before I've even had a chance to look for Kay. 'And what happened to your hair?'

'It's a new style,' Llin answers for me.

'Have you seen Kay?'

He frowns for a moment, obviously dissatisfied with both our responses, though he replies all the same. 'I saw her heading into one of the antechambers.'

'The antechambers?'

'Down the corridor.'

'Which one?' I begin, only to shake my head. 'It's fine. I'll find her.'

I stride towards a corridor with an arched ceiling and gilded frescoes and swing open the first door I come to. The first room is occupied by a group of middle-aged women who all fall silent the moment they see me, but as Kay isn't among them, I couldn't care less. The second door is more of the same, but when I open the third, there is a couple whispering together on one of the sofas.

Anger and heat roll through me, though before I get a word out, Hew spots me and jumps to his feet.

'We thought it was best to move away from the ballroom. You know, with the rebels and everything.'

'The rebels who've already been killed?' Hew might have gone up in my estimation with the way he protected Kay during the riot, but he's plunged right back down again. Bringing an unmarried woman alone into a room like this isn't exactly protecting her reputation. And judging by the way he's shuffling awkwardly, he knows it.

'You two must have a great deal to catch up on.' His voice is bright, unnaturally so considering the evening we've just had. 'I shall leave you ladies in peace. Rose.' He takes my hand and kisses it gently, though my arm remains rigid the entire time. He then turns back to Kay, who already has her hand out, ready and waiting.

‘Kay, I will call for you tomorrow?’

‘It will be the highlight of my day,’ Kay replies, holding his gaze for a fraction too long for me to feel comfortable. A moment later, he turns away and leaves.

‘No,’ I say, trying to keep my voice measured. ‘Whatever is going on there, or whatever you think you might want to happen, it ends now.’

‘What?’ Kay tries to feign innocence and fails. I know my sister way too well for that. ‘He was just being friendly.’

‘No,’ I snap out. ‘He’s not.’ I’m fully aware of exactly how hardheaded I sound, and I really don’t give a shit. Protecting Kay has been the central purpose of my life for years, and I’m not failing her now. ‘Kay, he is not the type of person you want to be friends with. You don’t even know him.’

‘No, *you* don’t know him,’ she stresses, sitting ramrod straight. ‘You’ve said all but three words to him. I, on the other hand, have spent several hours with him today and on many other occasions. Artur and Hew’s father are good friends, and I can tell you, he’s a good man, a really good man.’

Fuck. Of course Kay would think that. She thinks that about everyone. She could meet Mortidem, with his black cane and red eyes, and she’d probably just compliment him on how well the colours go together. And I can tell from the way she bites down ever so slightly on the corner of her mouth that there’s no chance she’s going to listen to me on this one.

‘Can you just keep your guard up around him?’ I beg, hoping for a middle ground. Though rather than agreeing, she chuckles. ‘Why are you laughing? I’m not joking,’ I huff.

‘No, I know you’re not. But you sounded like Hew just now. He was telling me to keep my guard up and not to trust the people at court. You should have heard the long warning he gave me before you got here tonight. He was worried people would try to pry information about you from me to exploit your weaknesses in the next trial.’

‘He said that to you?’

That’s definitely not the conversation I thought the pair of them were having, but then maybe I should give Kay more credit. No matter how much I think of her as a little kid, she’s not. In fact, she’s old enough to have entered the Retterheld herself. The thought makes me feel physically sick.

‘Yes,’ she says. ‘Like I mentioned already, I have spent a fair bit of time with him, and I like to think I’m a pretty good judge of character.’

She wants me to agree with her on the matter, but I can't. She's just too trusting to be rational when it comes to people.

'So tell me everything,' Kay says, lounging back on the sofa and patting the seat next to her. 'Your friends seem lovely. And Jonas—'

'Is also just a friend,' I assure her hastily. 'You're right. The others are great. They're from the Eastern Isles.'

As soon as I start, the words don't stop. We talk for hours, with me covering everything from the moment when Jonas met me in the High Hold, to my time in the forest – though I omit a fair few details about Kyor, the dire wolf, and the dagger.

Kay has plenty to tell me, too. About how Artur arranged to move her to the High Hold and had a seamstress fix her new dresses, as well as her room with two fireplaces and the pastries she's eaten every night.

More than once, I consider telling her about the offer Llin made for us to go with her to the Isles, but I don't. Kay seems so settled, and I don't want to say anything to make her think I have less than one hundred percent confidence in me winning the gifting. She doesn't need to worry about contingency plans. That's my job.

I am about to ask her about other people she's met, but before I can, the door to the antechamber swings open. Standing there is a portly man with beads of sweat dripping down his forehead, which he dabs away with a handkerchief. There are just enough similarities to the man I remember from my past to tell me this is Artur Lorathin.

'There you are,' he says jovially.

I jump to my feet, trying not to gawk. He's changed so much. His hair has gone, his figure has rounded, and there's a pittedness to his skin that looks to have been caused by overindulging in drink. He's a long way from the warrior my parents considered their friend – on the outside, anyway.

'Lord Lorathin.' Remembering my manners, I hurry across to the door and bend my knees in a poorly practised curtsy. 'I cannot thank you enough for what you have done for my sister. Your generosity in bringing her here, so that I can see her at these events, is more than I could have dreamed.'

His smile reveals two rows of perfectly white teeth. 'Rose, please, call me Artur. And it is my honour. Kay has been quite the perfect houseguest. And from what I hear, you're a rather formidable Rettling.'

'I am grateful that Etta and the Gods have favoured me thus far.'

‘And long may it continue.’ He flashes me another smile before turning his attention to my sister.

‘Acacia, dearest, it is time we head back to the apartment. The king has retired and it is only good form that we do the same.’

‘Oh. Of course.’ She tries to smile, but I know that, just like me, there’s reluctance in every pore of her body to be separated again. She turns to look at me and her eyes fill with tears.

I try to hold my own back, to be strong for her.

‘I love you,’ I whisper, holding her so close I’m sure that neither of us can breathe. But I don’t care. Breathing doesn’t matter if Kay’s not in my life. ‘This isn’t goodbye, remember? Only three more trials.’ Though I can admit to myself that that’s three too many.

When I break away, tears stream down her cheeks.

‘Please stay alive, Rose. I won’t be okay if I lose you, too. Please stay safe.’

‘I promise that it’s at the top of my to-do list,’ I quip, squeezing her once more.

She turns and takes the arm Artur has extended for her.

‘Goodnight, Rose.’ His voice is courteous, but the pause that follows feels sharp somehow. ‘I’m sure we will see you again. If Etta wills it so.’



MY BODY CLOCK wakes me early the next morning, and I stumble half-asleep down to the yard. It’s only when I’m nearly to the weapons cabinet that I realise Zelle will not be waiting for me. The knowledge is like a sledgehammer to the heart, and the pain only increases at the sight of Kyor sleeping by the cabinet, an empty bottle in his hand and a few other empties alongside him.

I hesitate for just a beat before waking him.

‘You can’t sleep here,’ I say, noting the red rim of his eyes. ‘You’ll freeze.’

I help him to his feet, but it’s not easy and he sways dangerously as I try to find my balance to hold him upright. Finally, I’ve got him in a position I can handle, with an arm wrapped around his waist, and using more force than seems kind, I tug him forward. Apparently, it’s my turn to lead.

It’s slow going out of the yard, and he toys with my hair as we stagger together. I let him, mostly because wrestling free would mean dropping him flat on the floor.

After what feels like one of the most intense workouts I’ve had so far, I get him into the warmth of the barracks. The question is where to go next. There are plenty of seats in the dining hall, but the last thing he needs is for the other Rettlings to see him in this state. Most will understand, but undoubtedly some will see his compassion as weakness. I could take him to the dorms, but manoeuvring him up the stairs feels even more daunting than getting him inside. The kitchen downstairs, however? Food and water would be his friend, and I could stand in front of him as we head down to ensure he doesn’t fall.

‘Such a pretty Rose,’ he murmurs, his fingers winding a little too tightly in my icy-blonde hair, making my scalp prickle. ‘So beautiful,’ he whispers.

If he keeps saying things like that, I might have to forgive him for all the tangles he’s making.

It’s early, even for the kitchen staff, but one person is already working downstairs, though she stops the moment she sees us.

‘Oh, Ky,’ Leilah gasps. ‘It’s all right, my boy. It’s all right.’

Without so much as a glance at me, she pulls him into her arms. His weight sags into her and his shoulders shudder as he allows his tears to tumble free.

For all his power, all his posturing, the sound that escapes him is nothing more than a broken sob.

He isn’t untouchable, isn’t carved from stone. He’s just a man, fragile and aching, stumbling through grief like the rest of us.

Feeling like I’m intruding, I silently slip away, scrubbing away tears that I didn’t even realise were falling.



FROM THE HANGING heads at breakfast, I think it’s fair to assume that Kyor isn’t the only one nursing a serious hangover, though whether the other Rettlings were drinking to celebrate their survival or to forget the traumas they’ve had to endure so far is anyone’s guess.

Later that day, the battle yard is close to empty as Llinos and I spar together. As great a job as the healers have done on her injury, she struggles to even block using that arm, and for the first time ever I have to hold back to give her a chance. Some of it might come from me getting stronger, of course, but it's definitely not that alone.

'Three more trials,' Llinos says, swinging her sword at me.

'Technically two and then the Ofur,' I reply.

'I'm trying to think of it as just another trial. I mean, I can't imagine it's going to be worse than the others.'

'Can't imagine or don't want to?' I sass.

'Oh, definitely don't want to.' She grins at me.

She swings at me again and this time gets a decent strike across my ribs. I've been distracted more than I'd like during our fight as my eyes keep falling on the tallies etched into the wall. I'm too far away to take them in clearly, but it doesn't change the fact that I can't forget they're there. That I can't seem to tear my mind away from the prince, no matter how hard I try.

'How long before the next trial, do you think?' I restart the conversation in the hope that it'll stop me thinking about Kyor. 'Surely they'll want to give us all time to heal fully before they hit us with the next one.'

'Who knows? I'm hoping for as long as possible though, because the healers said they've done as much as they can for my arm and now it just needs time. And if I have to fight like this …' She presses her lips together, unable to finish. Not that she needs to.

'There might not even be any fighting in the next one.' I'm clutching at straws, trying to find something to comfort her. 'We're also meant to use our heads for the trials, right? Maybe it'll be something logical. You're great at strategic thinking.'

'Maybe,' she replies, though she doesn't look convinced. If anything, her nervousness seems to grow. 'There's something else I wanted to talk to you about. I feel really, really shit about it, and it might not even happen, but I think we need to be prepared for it. But I don't want you to be pissed, because it's not an insult, it's just …'

I stop swinging and look at her.

'You want to spit it out?'

She takes a deep breath in. 'There's almost always a trial near the end when they make us act in pairs. And we decided before we came in that I would be with Loch and Benny would work with Jai, but now … well …'

Once again, there's no need for her to finish the sentence. She'll work with Benny. Of course she will.

'It's fine. Really,' I tell her. And it *is*, but I'd be lying if I didn't admit to myself that there's the tiniest sting of disappointment.

'I just feel crap,' she says. 'And I want to be clear that it's not because you don't have powers or anything. It's really not that.'

'I get it. I promise.' I do, but it doesn't stop the heavy weight that drops in my stomach. Or the reminder that even though I've got this far, I'm still *less* than the rest of them.

'If it comes to pairs, I'm sure I can go with Jonas. He'll love the chance to tell me to stay back.'

She lets out a nervous laugh. 'Yeah, true.'

'Really, Llin. It's fine.'

'Thank you.' This time her smile is more genuine as she whips up a spiral of sand with her hand. 'It's weird being able to use magic in here. Feels wrong.'

Shit. I hadn't even thought about that. Without Zelle to siphon the Rettlings, the battle yard is going to become even more dangerous. And that's saying something.

'Fuck. I guess that means Holden'll be in charge of all the sessions now.'

This knowledge causes a far deeper churning in my gut than the idea of Llin pairing up with Benny. Holden has already used 'training' as an excuse to try to kill me once. With Zelle gone, he'll have unlimited opportunities.

I guess I'll be training in the empty dorms again.

Llinos stops playing with the magic in the air and starts moving her feet again, only to stop mid-step at the sound of approaching voices.

'Yeah, maybe it's time we cut this short for the day.' She gestures to the gateway where Zara, Oke, and Mattieu are striding towards us.

If I had to bet on which three of Zara's little group would survive, it probably would be them. But it's funny how the last couple of weeks have changed things. Changed me. I feel stronger. Tougher. Comfortable? Maybe. Definitely not a runt. I've made it this far, and there's no reason to believe I can't make it to the end.

But they look tougher too, though in a more weathered way.

Physically, their skin looks tired and worn, with bags under their eyes and countless scars, with Zara's burn mark from our first meeting still

prominent. They look like the Retterheld is breaking them, not making them.

They've lived a life of privilege where death was just some honourable passage to eternal darkness. But watching friends and family die, stripped of life because they volunteered for a gifting driven by ambition rather than need, is something else entirely. That kind of loss changes you, especially if this is the first time they've ever truly seen what the world can take.

Once again, my eyes flick to the tally on the wall.

'Excellent. Fighting fodder.' Zara grins.

I open my mouth to respond, only for my jaw to lock in pain. I only got cuts and scrapes in the last trial, but them opening all at once like that was a shock I didn't expect. If she goes back to the fight with the jötunn, then that's going to be tougher to deal with.

Fuck! A fresh spike of pain slices through my ribs. We're on to older wounds too, then.

'Stop it!' Llinos has both her sword and a hand raised at Zara and the others. 'This is not what Zelle would have wanted.'

A scoff. 'You really think I give a fuck what Zelle would have wanted? That old man was nothing. Siphons are a drain. That type of magic is a farce. Where's the real strength in it?'

'Did you just fucking question the strength of a man who died saving the life of the king?' Kyor's voice cuts through the air, low and dangerous.

He stands leaning against the wall with his sleeves rolled up and his feet bare, yet another glass bottle swinging loosely in his hand. Dammit, he must have got away from Leilah. I suppose even she can't stop a prince if he's determined to get really fucking drunk.

His attention lingers on me for a moment before he looks back at Zara.

His voice is resonant, each word clipped and sharp. 'You think Zelle was weak?' He straightens to his full height, one step carrying him into her space.

Zara stands tall too, looking him in the eye, but I can see the sudden nervousness in her gaze.

'I said his powers lacked strength, Your Royal Highness, and I stand by that.'

'Right, right. Weak,' Kyor says. 'But see, the thing is, when you've got really powerful magic on your side, it's not necessarily a good thing.' Shadows fall over us and a dark cloud sweeps in, all of it tinged with that

peridot tint I now know is all his. Thunder rumbles once and then again. ‘Because it’s ever so easy to lose control.’

There’s a crack like a whip as a lightning bolt strikes the wall. Sparks fly upward, the scent of singed stone filling the air.

Oke and Mattieu move closer to Zara, as if the three of them huddling together will offer any protection at all.

‘Fuck you,’ Zara snarls, teeth gritted. ‘I don’t care that you’re the prince. Right now, you’re just another Rettling in my way.’

‘Is that right?’ he says mildly.

Lightning strikes again. This time, the bolt lands just a couple of feet in front of them.

The flash is blinding and my vision is temporarily stolen. It’s like I’ve been hit by Jonas’s power.

The moment it clears, I’m staring at Kyor again. His jaw is locked tight, so I’d bet Zara has opened up every old wound she could find on him, and yet he’s still walking towards her.

‘Zelle had more powers than your small mind will ever conceive of,’ he grinds out.

Mattieu sends a fireball in his direction only for Kyor to snuff it out with a gust of wind before it even reaches his feet.

‘Let me make one thing clear,’ he says as rain begins to pour over the three of them. ‘You mention Zelle again, you even *think* about mentioning him … and my lightning bolts won’t miss.’

He sends another down and it strikes just an inch from where Oke grips her sword. Any closer and the metal would have conducted the electricity. She would be dead. How the fuck does he have that much control when he’s drunk? I can’t even imagine what he’d be like sober.

‘You’re all done here,’ he says, looking from them back to me. ‘The ground’s mine today. Tell the other Rettlings – they set foot here, and I’ll kill them.’

The three Rowell Rettlings exchange a look, though only when Zara nods do the other two bolt for the gate. To give Zara her due, she walks slowly. But maybe that’s stupidity rather than bravery.

Llinos grabs my hand. ‘Rose, we should go.’ I hear her, but I don’t respond.

Instead, I pull my hand from her grip and walk towards the prince. ‘Kyor?’

I'm sure he must be able to hear me, but when I place my hand on his shoulder, he startles as if I've drawn a sword on him.

'You shouldn't be here,' I tell him. 'It won't help.'

'I told everyone. I told you. The battle yard's mine today. Unless you want to start something with me, Thorn—'

I ignore him easily. Only a couple of hours ago his hands were tangled in my hair and he was calling me beautiful.

'The drinking won't help,' I say, nodding to the bottle. 'From someone whose father tried that method and lost to it, believe me, it's not a road you want to go down. Go back to Leilah, eat some Godsdamn food, and drink some water. Zelle wouldn't want you to do this.'

With that, I spin on my heel and leave him to his grief.



WITH THE BATTLE yard evidently out of commission for the day, it's probably my laziest afternoon since arriving back in the High Hold.

For several hours, I flick through books on daggers, trying to find anything useful. I'm about to give up when my eyes fall on a small image at the bottom of a page. My heart stutters.

The three blades of Vindrun.

I pick the book up and move over to the light, trying not to get my hopes up – after all, the image is small – but the more I study it, the more certain I become. These blades aren't similar to mine. They're identical.

With my pulse quickening, I turn the page, ready to read more, only to find a different image – a large crystal with endless text about Sanrott beneath. I flick back again, hoping to find two pages stuck together, but there's nothing. Where the hell is it! My hands tremble as I open the book wide and run my finger along the inside of the page, only for my stomach to sink.

A thin, jagged strip of paper tells me what I already feared. The page has been ripped out. But who would have taken it?

Mila. The answer comes to me immediately. The High Priestess has the same dagger so she would seem the obvious choice, but I'm not sure how I'd go about asking her about the missing page. And why rip it out, unless she wanted to keep something hidden?

Still, I now know that my dagger is one of the three blades of Vindrun. It's a start. A good one. Now that I have a name, Caroline should have a much better chance of finding out more.

I dress in my old slum clothes. There's no point wasting my fighting leathers and furs when Caroline doesn't give a damn about things like that, and the only other items I have are ballgowns, which I'm not going to wear to the library. Besides, slum clothing might be unfashionable and unflattering, but it's comfortable. And right now, that's what matters.

Llinos marches into the room as I'm gathering my things.

'I thought people worked long hours on the island.' She flops onto the bed. 'But I haven't even seen Caz today. These damn nobles expect her to be at their beck and call the moment they have something they think worthy of being recorded by an official scribe. And, spoiler, most of it's not.' She lets out a sigh before rolling onto her stomach and looking at me. 'What have you been doing while I've been gone?'

A hint of frustration sparks within me. So much for hoping to get Caroline on the case tonight. Then again, I've waited long enough already. Another day likely won't hurt.

'I think I've got a name for the dagger, but I still don't know anything about it.' I hesitate. 'Is it wrong that I wish I could test it out on someone, just to see what it does? I feel like there must be a reason Dinah gave it to me.'

'I volunteer Zara,' Llin replies without missing a beat. 'Actually, I volunteer the three remaining Rettlings from Rowell.'

'I don't think you can volunteer someone without their permission.'

'Well, that's shit.'

I laugh only to be interrupted by a knock at the door.

'You expecting company?' she asks me, tension rising.

'Yeah, because *I'm* the one who has frequent visitors,' I hiss back, although there is actually a possibility that Kestria fancied a sparring session. I briefly spoke to her about it at dinner, but I meant later in the week rather than tonight.

A grin spreads across Llin's face. 'I guess Caz finished early.'

She scrambles up from the bed and runs to the door, only to freeze when it's half open.

'Oh. I think you must be lost.' She isn't rude so much as confused, but the way she speaks makes my skin bristle and I rise to my feet, unsure who

would warrant such a welcome.

I recognise our guest instantly when he speaks. ‘I need Thorn,’ he says gruffly. ‘And I need her now.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 44

‘Get out.’ Kyor’s voice is nothing more than a low growl as he glares at Llinos. ‘Now.’

Considering his display earlier with Zara, I wouldn’t judge Llin in the slightest if she sprinted off without a second glance in my direction, but whether it’s loyalty, bravery, or just sheer stubbornness, she remains there, blocking his way.

‘I’m not letting you in here unless Rose is okay with it.’

She looks directly at me, though I don’t answer straight away. He’s angry, he may well be drunk, and he’s definitely hurting. Yet even if he had a weapon in his hand – which he doesn’t – he wouldn’t hurt me. I’d bet my life on it.

‘Let him in, Llin. It’s fine. He’ll be fine.’

Rather than moving, she continues to search my face, her own crinkled in concern. ‘I’ll go find Benny. We’ll be just outside if you need us.’

I nod. She may not be pairing up with me, but she’s still got my back.

Kyor barely moves to the side, meaning Llinos has to squeeze past him. Once she’s in the corridor, she shoots me one more worried glance over his shoulder, and despite the apprehension I’m feeling, I send her a reassuring smile. Being alone with Kyor, in a bedroom, feels like a dangerous prospect.

As Llin’s footsteps retreat, I finally move towards Kyor. ‘How drunk are you?’

He stumbles inwards and his full weight falls on me, and though I can barely hold him up, I somehow stop us both from falling flat on our faces

while simultaneously kicking the door closed. The last thing I need is for any of the other Rettlings to see him like this.

With a shift of my posture, I find a better hold and lead him over to a bed. As I lower him down I realise the drink isn't the only reason he can't stand properly. His black top is soaked around his middle. And it's not from rain or sweat. It's blood.

'What the hell happened?' I say, lifting it up and seeing the gash underneath. It's not that deep, but it's long, and blood continues to ooze from the wound. I've seen this man fight, and considering he can take down a freaking jötunn on his own, he must have been sparring with a dozen of his father's guards at the same time.

'Just a misstep.' He lifts one shoulder and winces at the movement.

'And you came here?' I arch an eyebrow.

'I didn't have anywhere else to go,' he says, and my heart aches anew for him.

His eyes lock on mine and there's a twist behind my sternum that I hastily try to quash.

'How about one of the healers?' I ask drily as I turn around and move towards the sink, as if not looking at him will control the racing of my pulse. 'You know, that's actually their job. The clue is in the name.'

After wetting a cloth with cold water, I head back to him and hold up the corner of his shirt in order to press the compress against his wound. He winces, his body flinching in agony, but he makes no more sound than a slight hiss.

'Healers answer to my father,' he groans, visibly swallowing the pain. However much he's drunk, he hasn't lost the ability to feel. 'They report back everything that happens to me, and I really don't need our great king knowing every little scratch I get.'

I press a little harder as I wipe the edges of the cut, and I can hear his teeth grind together as he hisses again.

'I had someone who would help when I got myself into situations like this, but now he's …' He trails off.

My eyes glance up and meet his, and I instantly know he's talking about Zelle. Zelle was the person who would patch him up and keep his secrets from his father, because Zelle was one of the few people in the High Hold – if not the entire world, I suspect – that Kyor actually trusted.

'Are there any more wounds?' I ask. 'Or is this it?'

‘There’s one higher up that stings like a fucker.’

As he lifts the front of his top further, I struggle to stifle a gasp. It’s barely a quarter the length of the other one, but it’s at least twice as deep. And it’s still bleeding. A lot.

I try not to show my concern as I think about the herbs I have in my bag. Some would help hasten clotting, but they won’t be enough here. As I move the cloth away I know there’s only one solution to this.

‘It needs stitches.’

‘I know,’ Kyor replies. ‘That’s why I came to you. You stitched up your own hand, right? After the temple? When you were injured. I figured you were the type of person who would do it yourself rather than getting a slum rat to do it for you.’

‘Slum rats,’ I murmur, shaking my head a little. ‘That’s a great way to refer to your subjects, Your Royal Highness. You really are a man of the people, aren’t you?’

He blanches. ‘I didn’t mean—’

‘Yes, I know exactly what you meant,’ I snap.

As tension fills the room, Kyor pulls his top down and locks his jaw. ‘This was a mistake, Thorn. Coming here, coming to you, was a mistake. I should go. Find a seamstress or something. They can sew. Among other things.’

He tries to smirk as he goes to stand, but he isn’t strong enough. Instead, his entire body sways and wobbles, his legs unable to support his weight.

‘Sit the hell down. I’ll stitch you up.’

He glowers and for a split second I think he’s going to stubbornly refuse, but then he drops back onto the bed with a groan.

‘Fine,’ he mutters.

Only when I’m sure he’s not going to move again do I pull out the small leather pouch containing my needles, though it’s the paparvy seeds in one of the side pockets that grab my attention first. No matter how much he tries to hide it, he has to be in agony. After gathering the items I need, I move over to my little gas stove.

‘I’ll give you something to take away the pain,’ I say, placing a crucible on the flame.

‘No.’ His voice is sharp and cutting. ‘I don’t want that.’

‘I won’t give you much,’ I explain patiently. ‘Just enough to take the edge off.’

‘I said no. I don’t care about the pain. Just stop the bleeding. Do it tight so it doesn’t open up when I fight.’

Now it’s my turn to hiss. Does he think I’ll think less of him if he takes the seed? No, it’s stubbornness, pure and simple.

‘It’s going to hurt more when I sew it up.’

‘I’ll cope.’

Never have I met someone more frustrating, more arrogant, or more absurdly attractive. Sure, I stitched up my own hand, but that cut wasn’t anywhere near as deep as this is. I shake my head and try to focus, threading the needle then holding the sharp metal over the flame to sterilise it.

‘Do you want something to bite down on?’ I ask.

‘You offering anything fun?’ he replies, mouth tilting suddenly in a flirty half-grin.

Great. Drunk, injured Kyor is a horrific flirt. Good to know. Unfortunately, that’s not going to improve with my next request.

‘No,’ I answer shortly. ‘Now, this will be easier if you take your top off,’ I say.

‘I thought you’d never ask. But I could probably do with a hand,’ he admits.

It’s hard not to be taken aback. Never have I heard this man ask for help, even indirectly, which means he’s in a serious amount of pain. There’s no chance I’m going to refuse, but the prospect of even partially undressing Kyor Knavin has my mouth dry and heat pooling low in my stomach.

Keep it professional, Rose.

I reach out to grasp the bottom of his shirt and the silkiness of the fabric takes me off guard. So smooth and soft, it’s such a contrast to my own rough-hewn clothes. Mindful of his wound, we work together to get the shirt off him. His jaw remains locked throughout, with only the slightest hiss escaping from between his teeth.

I’ve seen him shirtless before, but it’s different now that he’s close enough for me to smell the musky aroma of iron and vanilla that rises from his skin. It makes it hard for me to think.

My eyes are drawn to the numerous lines on his body. He wasn’t lying about not using healers. There are dozens of scars – thin, silver lines that could easily be erased with magic. Yet he wears them like a badge of

honour. No, I realise, not honour, but reminders. Like the tallies etched into the walls. He wants to remember how he got them. Why he got them.

I unconsciously trace my fingers over one, catching myself as his flesh trembles under my fingers.

A side effect of the drink, I tell myself, because it's not cold in the dorm room. Then again, I've got goosebumps rising on the back of my neck and all across my arms.

'Are you actually going to do the stitches, Thorn? Or do you want to just keep staring?'

I flush as my eyes snap up to meet his gaze, his icy irises glinting.

'I don't mind,' he continues. 'Just I'd hate to bleed out. So maybe you could do the ogling after the stitches?'

Gods, I hate how right he is. I was definitely ogling.

'Just working out how deep I need to go,' I say, gesturing to the needle.

'Funny, I was thinking something remarkably similar.'

A deep red blush colours my cheeks, and the heat pooling in my gut intensifies. Fuck! What the hell is wrong with me? I'm not a prude, yet every flirtatious word from him sets my entire body on fire.

It's just because I need to get laid, that's all. Nothing to do with the man doing the flirting. Nope.

I steel myself and begin. His body clenches as the needle pierces his skin, and he exhales slowly as I pull the thread through, pierce the top of the wound, and then pull the stitch tight.

'First one down,' I tell him. 'You'll need another six or seven, I think. Still all right without that paparvy?'

His jaw is locked. 'I'm fine. Just focus on what you're doing.'

'Don't worry. I'm focused.'

I do the second stitch and then the third, all without looking up. It's crazy how much control he has. His refusal to cry out in pain. That damn stubbornness of his. All he offers is the occasional long exhale. After the last stitch, I tie the string into a knot before grabbing a dagger and cutting the thread, then step back. They look good, if I do say so myself. I'm about to say as much to Kyor, but when I look up, he's staring at me with a completely unreadable expression.

'What?' I ask, shrinking under his scrutiny. That's when I remember I'm wearing my old slum clothes. Garments I'd be judged by the instant I left this room. Garments that highlight all too clearly just how far I've fallen,

and how far apart in status we are. ‘Are you seriously staring at my clothes?’ I spit defensively, folding my arms over my chest.

Kyor’s eyes lock on mine as he snorts. ‘Your clothes?’ he says, arching an eyebrow. ‘When have I ever given a fuck about what people wear? Trust me, the only time I’ve ever thought about your clothes is when I’ve been imagining ripping them off you.’

My heart squeezes tight in my chest. He’s only saying that because he’s drunk, though the stitches seem to have sobered him up remarkably.

‘You’re all patched up now,’ I say, throwing him his blood-soaked shirt. ‘You’re good to go.’

He stands up, leaving his shirt on the bed. ‘And what if I don’t want to?’

I feel my breath leave my lungs in a long exhale as my pulse rockets. But it’s not out of fear. No, it’s far more dangerous than that.

I lick my lips. ‘You’re drunk.’

‘And?’ He takes a step forward. ‘I was sober enough to find my way here. Sober enough to know where I needed to be.’ He lowers his voice further still. ‘Sober enough to know where I wanted to be.’

‘I’m not going to be your distraction, Kyor,’ I assert firmly.

This time, he doesn’t stumble. Doesn’t sway. Two strides and he’s right in front of me.

‘Why did you follow me last night?’ he whispers, brushing his hand along my jaw and grazing my bottom lip.

‘I already answered that.’ I try to control the tremble in my voice. ‘Why are you still here? You got what you came for.’

He laughs, deep and resonant, the sound shaking through my bones.

‘Trust me, Thorn, those stitches are the last thing on my mind.’

He takes another step forward, pressing me against the wall with his hips. ‘Tell me you don’t want this,’ he murmurs. ‘Tell me you haven’t also thought about this, and I’ll go.’

Gods, yes, I’ve thought about this. Only my imagination was lacking. Here, now, his voice alone is enough to make me slick with heat. His hand brushes over my ear, then clasps behind my neck.

All I have to do is lean forward, and my mouth will be on his. Devouring him. Feeding the hunger that’s been growing inside me since the first time I saw his icy-blue eyes.

My chest is heaving, and we’re so close my nipples are pebbling, brushing against him.

‘Tell me,’ he demands.

But I can’t. I can’t say I don’t want him as much as he wants me.

After a beat, his smile curls, low and oh so dangerous. ‘You want me too,’ he purrs in satisfaction. ‘Fucking own it, Thorn.’ He slides a well-muscled thigh between my legs, and I let out a low moan as he hitches my body against him in the most delicious way …

There’s a fierce bang on the door, and a second later the door swings open. Kyor is already moving away from me, ready to defend us both, but he lowers his hands a fraction when he sees Benny standing there.

‘You okay, Rose?’ Benny asks pointedly.

I nod, but I know that my colour is still unnaturally high.

Words. I need to manage words.

‘Fine,’ I squeak.

Kyor grabs his shirt from the bed and looks back at me. ‘Think about it,’ he orders me, like I actually have the option not to.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 45

Practice in the battle yard recommences two days later, when they find another siphon to help suppress people's powers. The replacement, Roderick, isn't anywhere near as strong as Zelle, meaning he can't just stay in place but must constantly move around the yard, offering the other Rettlings inevitable opportunities to flex their magic whenever he is far enough away.

I make sure to stick close to Llinos and Benny, just in case Zara tries to pull one of her stunts. Jonas is also determined to make sure I'm protected, but his protective presence is stifling. Thankfully, one of the court guards came and called him away, and with reluctance, he went.

I finally feel like I can breathe.

I haven't met Kyor for morning training since our moment in my room, nor do I know if he's been there to meet me. Being alone with the prince right now feels like a bad idea. I need to focus on the Retterheld.

The sun beats down on us, just strong enough to ward off the morning chill. Benny is busy watching Grenda and Oke engage in a fight that has most people's attention. Despite all his powers of observation, he's still not got anything on Grenda. Whatever her powers are, she doesn't need to use them. Either that, or she's managed to shield them from his sight.

While he's focused on figuring it out, Llinos and I are practising our sword skills. Or at least, that's what we're meant to be doing. She seems far keener on gossiping.

'He hasn't taken his eyes off you the entire morning. Are you sure you didn't do more than stitch him up?'

‘You were out of the room for ten minutes,’ I reply, swinging my sword at her. If she’s not going to pay attention, I’ll at least use it to my advantage. ‘What exactly do you expect us to have done in that time?’

She arches an eyebrow. ‘I can think of a few things.’

‘Well, they didn’t happen.’ I glower. ‘None of them.’ Except in the vivid dreams that came instead of me.

I swing my sword again, trying to push down the memories of the way Kyor pinned me against the wall with his hips. The way he asked if I’d thought about him taking me. The way I can still feel his muscled form pressed against me, like it’s permanently imprinted on my skin.

‘Well, I think he definitely *wanted* something to happen.’ Llinos refuses to let it be, continuing to press as she sweeps my sword away from her with a gust of wind. Apparently, Roderick’s far enough away from us that she can use her magic, and she’s definitely using it to her advantage. ‘From the way he’s looking at you now, I’d say he still wants something to happen.’

‘He always looks at me like that,’ I snap back, refusing to glance in Kyor’s direction. ‘Remember the whole thing about blaming me for his mother’s death? The look you’re talking about is hatred.’

She snorts. ‘Nope, that’s not it. But even if it were, have you never heard of hate sex?’

‘Oh, for fuck’s sake.’ I groan. ‘And will you stop looking at him? He’ll notice.’

‘Too late,’ she mutters. ‘He’s walking over.’

Heat rolls into me at the thought, and when I speak, my voice is a little too high. ‘Gods, Llinos. Seriously?’

My back is currently to Kyor, and I try to keep it that way, continuing to strike at Llinos’s sword. But I don’t need to turn around to know when he’s there. My body can sense him. It’s a prickle on my skin and the clenching of my pulse. It’s like the very air wants me aware of his presence. Slowly, I turn around.

‘I’ll take over here,’ he growls at Llin.

‘She’s all yours,’ Llinos says with a smile. Traitor.

‘You want to fight?’ I ask.

‘You didn’t come this morning,’ he says, voice low. ‘Don’t trust yourself to be alone with me, Thorn?’

I swallow and lift my chin. ‘Of course I do.’

‘Good, then I’ll see you tomorrow. I’m not done making a warrior of you yet. Now, let’s make up for your absence this morning. No holds barred,’ he murmurs silkily. ‘Unless you’re going to turn me down. Again.’

From the sudden coughing fit to my left, it’s fair to assume Llinos has heard every word.

‘I *knew* something happened,’ she mutters, confirming my suspicion, but I don’t even glance in her direction. My gaze is locked on Kyor. On those blue eyes that have filled my thoughts way more than I want to admit.

No holds barred? Though he’s been training me in movements and stamina, in a true fight with him, he’d kick my arse effortlessly. ‘We both know you’re going to have me on my back in seconds,’ I respond, only for his lips to twist into a wicked grin.

‘Wasn’t that easy last time, was it?’ he replies. ‘Maybe this time I’ll get lucky.’

His every word is deliberate, taunting me, teasing me. I try to act unaffected, but my damn body is betraying the effect he has on me. The hitch in my breath. The tightening around my thighs. I just pray to Etta that his powers don’t allow him to see it.

‘I’ll make it real simple,’ he says. ‘All you have to do is draw blood. And I don’t care what part of your body you use to do it.’

He presses a finger to his bottom lip, instinctively drawing my eyes to it.

Fuck, this is torture. Not just because I’m about to get my arse handed to me, but also because there’s no denying how much part of me wants him to drive into me in a very different manner.

Still, I chuck the sword I was using to the side and unsheathe the daggers in my belt. If he wants to get close to me, then we’ll get close.

‘Your favourites. Good.’ He flashes me that smirk again before taking a few steps back and kicking off his shoes so he’s standing barefoot in the sand.

‘Why do you do that?’ I ask, curiosity getting the better of me. ‘Why fight barefoot? You’re more likely to injure yourself.’

‘No, I’m not.’ He presses his lips together. ‘Conductivity.’ His voice is nearly a whisper. ‘The earth’s charge is much easier to control when I know the terrain. And having control of static lets me do things like this.’ A prickle starts at the top of my neck, small at first, but then it grows, heating up as it slides downwards, tracing across my collarbone before splitting.

Dipping. Trailing lines across my breasts before cascading further still. I can't help but gasp, though the smugly satisfied smirk it elicits from him makes me wish I could have at least pretended to be unaffected.

He bends closer, his breath a hot whisper on the curve of my neck, making me shudder all over again. 'Just so you know, Thorn, if you liked that, there's much more to come.'

I swallow hard. We need to start this fight so that it's over and done with as quickly as possible.

I step away from him, and the minute I move, the static on my skin stops. His eyes take on a whole new glimmer. Speed is possibly the only thing I have on him, but only for very short distances as I'm certain his stamina is better than mine. I wish that thought didn't evoke an array of distracting dirty images in my mind.

With my dagger in hand, I lunge forward so clumsily he barely has to sidestep.

'Fuck,' I mutter. One nick, that's all I need to make, and his entire bare chest is open to me. But it almost feels sacrilegious to inflict any wound on a body like his, especially when it's clearly been exposed to enough pain already. No matter how good a shape he's in, wounds take time to heal.

I keep my distance, sweeping my feet in a constant arc that stops us from getting too close and moving in one direction and then the next. As he takes a step towards me, I move back by an equal distance. It's like there's an invisible barrier that won't let him get any closer to me. Or perhaps that's just my common sense finally intervening.

'Are we going to dance like this all day?' he purrs, his voice sending a quake down into the depths of my bones. 'You'll never get rid of me this way.'

'I'm just biding my time,' I growl back, my voice almost as low as his in an attempt to disguise the twist in the pit of my stomach.

With a surge of determination, I feint left then pivot, raising my elbow towards his jaw, but he catches me by the shoulder and spins me round, pressing my back against his chest. A gasp rattles from my lungs that's not entirely due to the impact. I'm not sure if it's my pulse or his that I can feel pounding through me. Either way, I struggle to draw breath. My body is desperate to see what it would find if I pressed myself into his hips, but I swallow back the urge, cursing my own insanity.

‘I think you got it wrong the other night, Thorn,’ he whispers against the shell of my ear, the warmth of his breath spreading like molten metal down my spine. ‘I didn’t want you to be a distraction. You are the distraction.’

Whatever game he’s playing with me, I’m starting to think it’s just as dangerous as the Retterheld itself. But, just like the gifting, I don’t intend to lose.

I tilt my head up towards him and part my lips slightly as if I’m going to speak … only to swing my elbow up, ready to drive it into his jaw. But he sees it coming.

He twists me around so that I’m facing him and pins my arms across my body as he holds me effortlessly in place. My eyes snap to his because I don’t trust myself to look straight ahead. And certainly not to look down.

‘You are the reason I can’t think. Can’t sleep. Can’t stop imagining the way it would feel if it was my fingers and not my power doing this.’

He lets the static run free again, though this time, it’s on the inside of my thigh. My body melts, craving the sensation, and his hips shift towards me. The movement is so minuscule that I doubt anyone else would even notice. But I do. I feel the pressure. He’s hard. Fighting me, holding me, has him hard. And it’s enough to make me slick.

I bite down on the inside of my cheek until I feel the metallic taste of blood on my tongue. It’s the only thing I can do to stop myself from moaning. Shit, from begging.

I need to get a grip. I wrench my arms free and slam my hands against his chest, pushing myself away.

‘See what I mean?’ he groans. ‘You are the distraction.’

‘I’m okay with that,’ I say, sliding my feet across the sand as I move further away from him, keeping my eyes on his.

I go low, aiming for a shot that will really hurt, especially in his current situation, but he anticipates the move and grabs me under the shoulders, flipping me over his back and slamming me into the sand.

Pain sears up through me at the impact. My bones throb from the force, yet a moment later, the pain has gone, swallowed entirely by the fact that Kyor is straddling me, his full weight pushing down into me and those icy eyes locked on mine.

Dryness fills my throat as I struggle to move. To want to move.

I try to push up, but all that does is drive his weight further into me. It’s no accident that he’s pinning me down by my hips.

‘Ready to give in?’ he murmurs, and I know we’re not just talking about the fight.

‘Not going to happen,’ I say through gritted teeth. I need to focus. I need to win the gifting. If I’m his distraction, then he is no less mine, but where he can afford it, I can’t. Not when I’ve made it this far.

‘No? Then how about this?’ he growls. ‘Tell me you wanted me to stay. Tell me it crossed your mind, even if it was just for a split second. Tell me you wanted to lock that door and let me do all those filthy things I’ve imagined doing to you. Say that and I’ll let you go. I think that’s fair.’

Fair? Nothing about this is fair. I’m pinned to the ground by the son of the man who destroyed my family, and all I can think about is not moaning. Not showing him how much my body wants him.

‘The thought didn’t cross my mind,’ I lie boldly.

‘Really? So if I turn up tonight – sober – and pin you to the wall, telling you I want to make your body writhe with pleasure, it won’t cross your mind to let me stay? If I tell you I want to run my tongue across you until you lose every shred of restraint, you’ll say you don’t want that either? If I whisper every filthy thought I’ve had of you into your ear until you beg me to make them real, you’ll push me away? Tell me, Thorn … tell me you don’t want to feel me stretching you from the inside.’

I’m soaked, dripping in a way I never knew I could. But when that Godsdamn smug smirk rises on his face, reality hits me. This power he’s got over me – not the sparks he cascades over my skin, but his words that send me into a near frenzy? I can play that game too.

He’s not joking when he says I’m the distraction, and I need to use that. Not be afraid of it.

‘That’s what you’re thinking about now, right? Isn’t it?’ I murmur, deepening my breath so that it’s close to heaving. ‘Right now, you’re imagining what you’d like to do to me. Or maybe you’re thinking about the way I watched as you pulled your shirt up over your head. How you pinned me against the wall. Or how you moaned.’

‘From what I remember, you were the one moaning,’ he says huskily.

‘Really? Maybe I’ll have to rectify that next time.’

‘Next time?’ I hear the hitch in his voice, and I know I’ve got him. Without so much as a pause for breath, I move.

Boom.

I slam my elbow straight into his side, landing the blow an inch above his stitches.

He gasps, shifting away from me, his eyes flashing as I kick him off me and stand to stare down at his now supine body.

‘That was a low blow,’ he growls, though his eyes flash with something close to respect. He sits upright and presses his fingers to the wound, checking to see if he’s bleeding.

‘I trust my stitching,’ I say when his fingers come back clean. ‘Now, I believe we’re done here.’

In one sweeping moment, he’s on his feet. ‘I think you’ll find the condition was to draw blood,’ he growls, his eyes glinting. ‘Like you said, your stitches are good.’

‘And I think you should check your neck.’

He moves his fingers up to the place where the very tip of my knife nicked the thinnest line on his skin at the same moment my elbow struck him. A small droplet colours his fingertips, and when he looks back at me, it’s a genuine smile gracing his lips, not a smirk.

‘Well, then. We’re done for now.’ Still looking absurdly proud, he turns, picks up his shoes, and walks away without another word.

I’m still standing there with my pulse hammering when Llinos races back towards me.

‘Okay, that’s enough training. We’re all trained out.’ She grabs my arm as she hauls me in the direction of the dorms. ‘You and I are going to have a serious conversation. Now.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 46

‘I don’t know what’s wrong with me,’ I tell Llinos as we walk into the dining room later that evening. ‘It’s some screwed-up physical attraction thing. You know, it’s just a case of “can’t have, therefore want.” It’s a weird physical crush, that’s all.’

Llinos grins back at me. ‘Rosey, honey, you’ve said that phrase about a hundred times today. Who are you trying to kid? I mean, I don’t mean to be funny or anything, but why the hell not go there? That fight was beautiful. Imagine what it’s gonna be like when you’re fucking.’

She says the word ‘imagine’ like I haven’t done that way too often for my own good. I groan. ‘I can’t get distracted. Two trials left and then the Ofur. Besides, he’s the heir to the throne, and I’m a slum rat.’

‘You’re not!’ she says sharply.

One of us.

‘I am,’ I say firmly, ‘and I’m not ashamed of it. The people there are good people who’ve fallen on hard times.’ I think of the gifts they laid at my door. It’s a reminder that I need to ask Leilah about the food I hoped to get out to the slums. ‘Kind, generous people. But all of that doesn’t change who *he* is.’

‘And where you live doesn’t change who *you* are. You are, and always will be, Lady Kultavaris.’

‘Leave it, Llin, please,’ I beg. ‘Now, can we go and get some food? I’m starving.’

Jonas is already at our table, but there’s no food in front of him. Instead, he’s staring at a piece of paper. A pang of annoyance hits. Artur is still sneaking in correspondence to Jonas but hasn’t thought that perhaps it

would be nice if he could do the same for Kay and me. Then again, Artur's already doing more than he needs to, to help us, so I can hardly begrudge him the oversight.

'Everything all right?' I ask.

He crumples the paper and shoves it into his pocket. 'Yeah, just correspondence from my father.'

It's only been four days since the ball, but Gods, I miss Kay already. Though I'm not exactly sure how she'd take my situation with Kyor, particularly given the warning I gave her about Hew. Talk about hypocrisy.

'Did he say anything about Kay? How she's getting on?'

Jonas frowns. 'No, why?'

'No reason. I just thought he might say something.'

'No, no.' He shakes his head, but the thin vein in his forehead is pulsing slightly, a surefire sign he's concerned about something.

Before I can question him further, Benny sweeps in and sits next to me.

'Hear I missed an interesting fight earlier.' He grins at me before flashing Llinos a loaded look.

Jonas looks up. 'What happened?'

'Oh, it was just Zara and Oke,' I say quickly, shooting the others a look. Somehow, I don't think Jonas needs to hear this.

'Yeah? Who came out on top?'

Llinos snickers. 'I'm not sure, actually,' Llinos says. 'We all got a bit … distracted. Distracted. That's the right word, wouldn't you say, Rosey?'

I hate her. She's my best friend and I hate her.

'From what I hear, they just wore each other out,' Benny joins in. 'Or they're definitely going to in the future.'

Llinos and Benny both stifle laughs. I want to glare at them, but honestly, I'm just pleased to see them getting on, even if I need to be the butt of the joke for that to happen.

'Are you sure everything's okay?' I ask Jonas again, because he's looking nervous and weird.

He blinks a couple of times. 'Yes, yes, it's all fine. Just maybe you and I could …' Whatever it is he wants us to do, I don't find out, as his voice trails off, and his eyes fix on something past my shoulder. 'What is he doing here?' Jonas frowns. 'And why is he walking this way?'

Benny turns to look, but I don't need to. There's a trickle of static along my collarbone that tells me exactly who is approaching.

‘Mind if I join you?’ Kyor asks, the query barely a question.

Gods, why is his voice so attractive? Maybe if I could just imagine it in a different way – high-pitched or too nasal or something – it wouldn’t make my muscles clench at the sound of it. The thought of him whispering in my ear again—no, I will not think like that. Even if it was all I was thinking about when I fell asleep last night, not to mention several times since our battle earlier.

‘Not sure we can say no to the prince, can we?’ Jonas mutters from his seat.

‘Rose can,’ Llinos quips.

Benny snickers, and I elbow him in the side.

‘What are you doing here, Kyor?’ I say.

‘You always seem to have so much fun. Thought I could join you. Not distracting you, am I?’

I swallow. ‘Of course not,’ I say defiantly.

Not needing any more of an invitation, he slides in next to me, only for the conversation to stall entirely. Though if Kyor notices, he doesn’t show it. Instead, he picks up his fork and begins to eat, shifting slightly so that his thigh presses close to mine.

The effect is instant. The heat. The dampness. Trying to keep my expression as neutral as possible, I move away by a fraction, only for him to immediately spread his legs so that he is still touching me. My breathing tightens. I don’t want to scooch along the whole bench, so I grit my teeth and try not to think about just how good that pressure feels against me. And how much better it would feel in other places.

‘Well,’ Benny says flatly a couple of minutes later, after Kyor’s still not said another word. ‘That was a great dinner, but I think I’m done.’ As he stands to leave, Llinos quickly copies him.

‘You know what? Me too. Jonas, you coming?’

‘Me?’ Jonas looks at her, a confused frown on his face.

‘Yes. I wanted to talk to you about that thing.’

‘That thing.’

‘Yes, that *thing.*’ Without waiting for him to respond, she grabs Jonas by the arm and hauls him away. Once again, Kyor and I are alone, and even though there’s more than enough room on the bench, neither of us moves.

Only when Kyor’s plate is empty does he turn and look at me.

‘Tomorrow morning. I expect to see you there.’

‘To train?’ I ask, wishing my voice wasn’t so breathy.

‘To train,’ he confirms.

‘I can’t,’ I blurt.

‘And why is that, Thorn?’ he purrs.

Irritation sparks at his obvious delight. ‘What do you want, Kyor? Do you want to hear that you’re a distraction to me? You are, okay? Do you want to hear that there’s something physical between us? Because we both know there is. And I just, I can’t do that. With you.’

His humour fades from his face until he looks all too serious.

‘Very well,’ he says finally. ‘Nothing else will happen between us, Kultavaris, not until you ask for it.’

I hate that I instantly miss him calling me Thorn.

‘In the meantime,’ he continues, ‘I expect to see you every day for our early morning training sessions. No funny business, not a single touch I wouldn’t give anyone else. Deal?’

I swallow. He’s the best fighter there is in the competition, and training with him is an opportunity only an idiot would pass up. I nod. ‘Deal.’



TRUE TO HIS WORD, Kyor is there for every morning session for the following week and a half. He trains me like any other soldier, driving me through relentless, close-quarters fighting, honing my blocks and strikes until they’re sharp and economical. And through it all, he remains completely and infuriatingly business-like.

As such, I’m in a decidedly foul mood as I make my way to breakfast and find Llin there picking at her food.

‘It’s been too long since the last trial,’ she grumbles as I sit down. ‘Does it feel like it’s been too long? When the hell is it going to be?’

‘It changes every Retterheld,’ Jonas starts, and the rest of us exchange a look, knowing a history lesson is coming. ‘One year, they were only three days apart, and the entire thing was over and done with within fifteen days. They’ve never been more than a moon apart though, meaning we could have another thirteen days to wait.’

‘I’ll go mad,’ Llinos huffs. ‘I hate the waiting.’

If I was her, I'd be counting any extra days spent training as a blessing. The wound to her arm was significant, and though it's healed well, she's still far from her usual strength.

'There's definitely going to be water at some point,' Jonas continues his pontification. 'I'm sure of it. You need to be ready for that one, Rose. As I recall, you never used to like the water?'

'That was a long time ago,' I reply. 'Don't worry. I'll be fine.' As casual as I sound, it's a lie. Jonas is right. I hated open water and I still do. And though I've been hoping since I arrived to at least have an opportunity to train down in the sea, that hasn't happened.

'I think we should all stay on alert,' Llinos adds. 'You never know when it might happen.'

'When exactly aren't we on alert around here?' I reply. 'I know I am. All the fucking time.'

My eyes shift around the depressing dining room. So few trials down and already more than half of us are gone. I know from Benny and Jonas's history lessons that it's not been the deadliest Retterheld, but it's up there.

With so few competitors, it's easy to see that Kyor isn't here. I can stop him from touching me, but it seems I can't stop thinking about him. Wondering where he is and who he's with. Were the stunts he pulled on me something he's tried on every Rettling? Not to mention every eligible woman at court? You don't come in with confidence like that unless you're sure of your ability. And if the sparks that flew between us through the fight are anything to go by, just his fingers on me are going to be enough to send me over the edge.

I am *not* thinking about his fingers on me.

'Do you think Zelle's death slowed things down?' Llin asks, still mulling over why we haven't yet had our third trial. 'Not Zelle himself, I mean, but the rebels' attack. Maybe they're upping the security.'

'Ah yes, because it's so essential to make sure we're secure when we're heading towards probable death,' Benny replies grimly as he joins us at the table.

I'm only half listening because Kyor has appeared at the top of the kitchen stairs. And annoyingly, he sees me looking. He looks … eager, excited.

Knife, he mouths at me. I'm still frowning when I notice two interlopers walking into the room: a man and a woman, both with grey hair twisted and

piled high on top of their heads.

‘Guys,’ I say, interrupting the bickering that’s still going on between Benny and Llinos. ‘Guys, have you ever seen those two people before?’

Both of the islanders glance down to the end of the dining hall, although the man has now moved and is heading towards us.

‘No.’ Llinos shakes her head.

‘Never,’ Benny adds.

‘Does anyone else feel that?’ Jonas asks, frowning.

The moment he speaks, I feel it too. Something is swirling right in the pit of my stomach.

‘Is this—’ Before I get the words out, the clanging starts – the chime announcing the start of the trial.

I reach for my knife – Godsdamn it, that’s what Kyor meant – but just as my fingers begin to curl around the hilt, the dining hall disappears, my knife with it.

The third trial’s begun, and I’m defenceless.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 47

My knees hit the hard ice as I land, but the sound is muted and the impact is softened by thick padding. It's not just my location that has changed; it's also my clothes.

White furs cover my arms, my legs are encased in dark brown leather trousers, and furred boots are on my feet. My stomach roils. These are the clothes of the Issen. Why the hell am I in the clothes of the Issen?

'Rettlings, welcome to the third trial.'

High Priestess Mila stands on a podium ten feet in front of us. She's wearing a fur-lined version of a priestess's robe, so thick it holds itself inches from her body.

'You may be asking yourself where you are,' she says. 'Well, let me ease your curiosity. You are on the edges of Follen Lake.'

Follen Lake? Is she for real? That's at least a five-day journey on horseback, if not longer. The amount of magic they must have used to get us here by portation is staggering.

Even dressed as I am, being wrenched from the warmth of the dining room to the aching cold here is shocking. My hands are covered with thick white gloves, but it doesn't stop the tingle of ice from reaching my fingers. I close them around my mouth and try to breathe heat into them, but the temperature is so cold that the plume of breath nearly freezes in front of me.

This is as far north as I have ever been and it is the site of the battle where the Morathkians pushed the Issen back so they could save the land that wasn't already frozen by their dark ice magic. The story of Follen Lake is one every child across the kingdom knows, but it's not a tale of total victory.

The Morathkians believed they were on solid ground, only for the Issen to melt the very ground beneath their feet. Thousands of men plummeted into the water below, clawing helplessly at the sheet of ice that trapped them in what became their icy graves. Were it not for the grace of Etta and the strength of our magic, all would have perished. But by the Gods' mercy, enough soldiers were saved to drive the Issen back to their lands behind the Coltan Mountains.

'Your trial is simple,' Mila continues, her smile sharp. 'You merely have to cross this section of the lake.'

She gestures with her arm to the section in question, but there's nothing to be seen but dense fog, ice, and snow. It's going to be slippery.

The ice is probably thinner in places, and I suspect that the real challenge will be stopping ourselves from plunging into the freezing water.

I knew water would come into play at some point, but freezing water where I could get trapped under the ice?

I shudder involuntarily.

'There is no time limit,' she continues. 'When the last living Rettling crosses to the other side, the trial will be over.'

Okay, so she definitely thinks some of us are going to die. Great.

'Use whatever powers you have at your disposal. Nothing is prohibited. I may or may not see you on the other side. Etta's blessings on you all.'

Like that, she's gone.

None of us move. Or at least, no one that I can see.

We were spread out when they brought us here, all spaced about twenty-five feet apart. To my right, I can see Oke, and beyond her is Mattieu. Of course, those two get to be together. Mattieu is wearing the same furs and leathers as I am, whereas Oke is dressed in the furs of the standard Morathkian army uniform.

I press my hand against my thighs, hoping that by some miracle my dagger is concealed somewhere in my uniform, but all I find is a single nondescript blade. Still, I take it out and arm myself.

The cold air hitches in my breath when I see Kyor to my left. But there's still no sign of Llinos, Benny, or Jonas. In a trial where I need powers, I'm away from the only people I'm certain will offer me help. Still, I edge towards the prince. I don't know what is happening between us, but I know he's powerful, and right now his magic might be the only thing to save me.

‘Any idea what we should do?’ I ask Kyor when I reach him. His army uniform is the same as the one Oke wears, but it fits him so perfectly I wouldn’t be surprised if he insisted he had fully tailored attire. ‘Since you’re the military leader and everything.’

‘No one ever comes to Follen Lake.’ He looks pale, his thumbs pressing into his palms in agitation. It makes my own stomach lurch. If even *Kyor* is nervous, then I’m truly fucked.

‘What are you like at holding mental wards?’ he asks.

I look at him flatly. ‘No magic, remember?’

He nods. ‘Right. Maybe that will help you. Just get your body across the finish line. You can worry about your mind afterwards.’

‘I didn’t figure you as someone for riddles,’ I reply as a gust of wind pushes the fog across the lake and causes fear to creep up my spine.

‘I’m not. Trust me.’

He’s opening his mouth to say more when a scream tears through the air.

‘What was that?’ I scour the area around me, but the fog is too dense and I can’t see much past where Oke stands.

‘Someone stepped on the ice. My guess is they woke the spirits. If you want to finish this thing, there’s only one way: make it to the other side.’ Kyor meets my eyes and his blue gaze pierces me. ‘Just keep walking, Thorn. I’ll stay as close as I can.’

With that, he takes his first step onto the ice.

Fifty feet away, Oke does the same.

I wasn’t going to be the first, not after hearing that scream, but I don’t want to be the last either, so I draw in a deep breath and take my first step. Any ideas I had of sprinting ahead vanish. The ice is slick and wet, meaning running will likely leave me face-planting and easy prey. And that’s being optimistic. If I hit a patch of thin ice, it’ll be game over.

I adopt a method of lifting my foot as little as possible and sliding forward, and I feel like I’m actually making some progress when it starts.

At first, I assume it’s the wind. A low rumbling, quiet and distant. But it grows closer, sharper, turning into a growl. Even though I can’t see where it’s coming from, my fists clench, ready to strike out the only way I can.

I’m still edging forward, scouring the desolate landscape, now dotted with distant figures, when the first shriek of pain hits me.

It’s not just a random cry. It’s the cry of someone being killed. Murdered. The sound carries over the ice, allowing me to hear the blood filling their lungs as the blade is withdrawn from their sternum. I feel the pain in my own body as if it’s real, yet when I look down, there’s nothing. Nothing but the white furs and brown leather I’m dressed in.

‘Your punishment is long overdue,’ a voice snarls at me. ‘I will take great pride in your death.’ I spin around, searching for the source of the threat, but there’s no one there. The voice is inside my head, I realise, like the voice during the attack at the ball.

It’s not real, I tell myself.

I drop my hands onto my knees, trying to focus on what *is* real. What I can see. What I can touch. As my head remains quiet, I try to steady my breathing. What was it Kyor said? Worry about my mind later? Well, at least I know what he was talking about now.

Both he and Oke are ahead of me, and though Oke has her hands pressed to her forehead as she inches forward, Kyor walks with his hands behind his back. It’s a far cry from the way he normally approaches challenges, but it’s obviously working.

‘Your blood will feed the land of the old one,’ a voice wails as another scream cuts through the icy air. This time the voice is loud enough to make me clasp the sides of my head in agony.

I clench my teeth. ‘You’re just in my head.’ I’m not sure if I’m whispering or whimpering. ‘You’re just in my head.’

‘Am I?’

In front of me, cloudy figures emerge, taking on corporeal form. Hundreds upon hundreds. We are walking through their battleground, the land and ice on which they lost their lives, and we are paying the price for it.

To the left of me, I see one of the white fur-covered figures heading straight for Kyor, his sword raised, ready to strike.

‘Kyor! Watch out!’ I stand transfixed as he turns to look at me. ‘No!’

The Issen’s sword swoops down towards the prince and the air rushes from my lungs as the scream leaves me. But Kyor doesn’t fall to the ground, and there’s not a drop of blood as the Issen blade carries on through him.

Blue eyes hold mine. ‘They’re not real, Thorn. Just remember that.’

‘They look fucking real. And they sound it, too.’

He nods. For once, there's no hint of a smirk on his lips.

'I know. Keep moving. Get to the finish line,' he repeats before twisting around and continuing.

'They're not real,' I mutter. 'And what's not real can't hurt you.' Physically, I correct myself. Mentally, I'm not so sure. Kyor's comment still lingers, but I'll do as he advises and worry about my mind later.

More and more warriors appear, shifting into existence through the snow and ice. Not just Issen, but Morathkians, too, still clad in their uniforms. The same uniforms Kyor and Oke are wearing.

So that's why they chose to dress us like this. So we can't tell the apparitions of the Morathkians and Issen apart from our fellow Rettlings. It's sick.

'You are a traitor,' a voice rolls through my head. 'Your blood is tainted.'

Two of the warriors begin fighting in front of me and their voices are at full volume in my head, their rage, their agony, their thirst for vengeance consuming me.

It's hard to believe it's not real when I can hear them, can feel the metal clashing through my bones, sense the warmth of their breath against my skin.

I can't even be halfway across the lake yet. How the hell am I going to make it all the way?

Willing to try anything, I close my eyes, praying that I don't step onto any thin ice. But while walking that way removes the images from in front of me, it increases the noise.

The cries. The pain. It all echoes off the distant mountains and reverberates through the very marrow of my bones. They're dying. They're dying all around me. And I have nothing to help them. No magic. No weapons strong enough. No way out.

I just need some respite. Some quiet. Anything to give me a moment's peace.

If I could just stop the sound, would that be enough?

Yes.

Maybe.

Maybe it would work.

But how?

For the first time since I stepped onto the ice, I remember the knife in my hand. It's not as pretty as the dagger from Dinah, but it should work perfectly. I tip my head to the side and lift the blade.

'Thorn! Fucking hell! No!'

The pain across my face is completely different from the internal pain I was feeling. The echo of the slap continues to sting my skin as I blink my eyes, suddenly aware that my hand is now empty, though I can barely remember what it was holding before.

All I can focus on is Kyor standing in front of me, fear filling his face.

He slapped me, brought me out of …

I realise then what I was about to do with the blade they gave me. I was going to slice my own throat.

'I was going to … I just wanted it to stop …' I whisper. My throat dries as the reality of what I was about to do sinks in.

Kyor stopped me. He saved my life.

'I know. You're okay now.' He bends down and picks up the dagger. 'Maybe I should hold on to this, though? I've got a little more experience than you.'

'More experience with spirits trying to make you kill yourself?' I ask.

'No, being surrounded by death.'

My heart clenches for him.

Our gazes are still locked when a scream jolts my attention away. This one wasn't in my head.

'Mattieu, stop. Stop!' Oke shouts. Her friend is trying to battle spirits clad in the Morathkian uniform, but his usual precision is missing as he hurls blast after blast of fire into the air, with no chance of meeting a target. His magic is worse than useless – it's dangerous. We are on an ice-covered lake and every blast of fire he sends out weakens the thin layer between us and the icy depths.

'Mattieu, stop!' Oke calls again, but he's not listening.

I can't move, too transfixed by terror. Not for me, but for them.

Abandoning her screaming pleas, Oke moves towards him. But she's dressed in the uniform of the very spectres Mattieu is trying to defeat, and it's very possible he won't realise that she's real. She'll get herself killed.

But that's on her, isn't it? It's not like she hasn't tried to kill me countless times. My mind is a cacophony of conflicting emotions. Can I let her die? Can I let anyone die when I have a chance to save them?

‘I need to get her out of there,’ I say to Kyor.

‘You can’t. She’ll kill you. This is their fate, not yours.’

‘They can’t die like this. This isn’t fair. This isn’t a fight. It’s torture.’

‘Thorn, don’t do this.’

He grabs my arm, but somehow I slip from his grasp.

I don’t have a choice. Etta’s the Goddess of Life, and right now, I won’t let any life be taken like this. Better to be defeated by a giant or a dire wolf than by a friend whose mind is gone. Besides, Kyor didn’t need to save me, and yet he did. He did the right thing, and so will I.

‘Oke, no! No!’ I cry.

The voices are creeping back into my head, but I fight against them. I can only fight one battle at a time, and right now, they’re not mine. Saving Oke is. ‘Oke! You can’t save him. You can’t save him. You’ll get yourself killed. Please!’

She offers me only the briefest glance before turning back to Mattieu, just in time to watch him plunge a knife into his own stomach.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 48

For a split second, I pray that this is going to be like when the Issen's sword went through Kyor. That it isn't a real knife in Mattieu's hand, but an illusion. But as the blood sprays and he falls to his knees while the spectres continue their fight around him, I know I'm not going to be that lucky twice.

'No! Mattieu, no!' Oke rushes towards him and her knees land so hard on the ice that cracks form in the glass-like floor. 'It's okay. I've got you. I've got you.'

As she presses her hands to his stomach, a soft red glow fizzes from her fingers and the smell of burning meat fills the air.

Oke is a healer? The thought comes with a torrent of relief, though it doesn't last. That smell … No healing I've ever known has made an aroma like that. She's not healing him, I realise; she's just trying to stop the bleeding by cauterising the wound.

But Mattieu plunged his dagger all the way to the hilt. Can cauterisation fix something like that? It only takes me a minute to know the answer. From the blood pooling at Mattieu's mouth and running onto Oke's furs, I'd say not. Though as I watch on, I realise Mattieu is the least of her worries. There's something about the way she's shaking her head and moving her lips. It's as though she's talking to a dozen people at once. Or fighting off voices in her mind. The spectres are closing in around her, and if she's not careful, she's going to be next. I have to get to her.

Rain has started falling. Freezing rain so cold it seeps all the way to my bones. I need to keep moving. Water-soaked furs are even heavier, meaning it's going to be harder to walk across the ice. Not to mention more perilous.

‘Oke, you need to leave him. We need to go.’ I wade through the mirages of battling Issen and Morathkians and grab her by the arm. ‘You have to go now. You have to save yourself, or you’re both going to die.’

Her eyes widen as she looks at me, the rain streaming down her face; the whites bulge from their sockets, and her pupils swallow her irises with their all-consuming darkness.

Is this what I looked like when Kyor knocked the blade from my hand? What Mattieu looked like before he ran the knife through his own stomach? I have a horrible feeling it is. I need to snap her out of this before she kills herself.

‘You … you wanted this. You wanted him dead. They’re right. You are our enemy. You need to die.’

Fuck.

Not only does she want me dead, but apparently the spirits do too. Great.

‘Oke, snap out of it! Please, I’m trying to help you!’ I yell. ‘I’m trying to save you!’

She grips a dagger, the point aimed at me. So words aren’t going to be enough to stop this from happening. Good to know.

The rainwater on the ice has made it even more slippery, yet somehow I swing my leg up and kick the weapon out of her hand before she gets a chance to strike. My aim is spot on, and it clatters to the ground, but as my foot lands, I feel the crack of the ice beneath me.

Not having a weapon doesn’t deter her. In one lunge, Oke has wrapped her strong hands around my throat. My breath falters and my body instinctively thrashes about, weakening the already fragile ice beneath us. If I don’t think of something soon, I’m going to die out here. Either by Oke’s hand or in the icy water, and neither is an option I want to take.

‘You defile the land, defile the one true God. The Mother God.’

Fuck. The voices are back in my head. But I can’t let them win. I won’t die. Not here. Not when I’m trying to help someone survive in a trial for the fucking Goddess of Life. That’s not how these things are meant to work. *Please*, I beg whatever God is listening. *Please, I just need something. Anything.*

I kick out at Oke, and she slams me down on the ground. This time, the crack in the ice is audible. Loud enough to resonate through my skull. Loud

enough to block out the voices trying to lay their claims there. *Please, Gods, help me!*

The apparitions are drawing closer, circling Oke and me as if they want to be there at the moment of our deaths. And it's coming soon. I can feel it. The air. It's so cold. So thin.

Oke's hands are still at my throat, squeezing, while I lie flat on my back, praying the spread of my weight will keep the ice from giving way beneath us. Still, I have no choice but to thrash out again and land a kick to her stomach that causes her to loosen her grip. As I scramble up to my knees, fighting dizziness and gasping for breath, Oke towers over me. And she's not alone. One of the apparitions dressed in Issen garb stands resolutely beside her, looking at me.

'Please, Etta!' I choke out, my voice raw from the crush of Oke's hands. 'Help me!'

'You are asking the wrong God,' the apparition says. 'You should ask the Mother.'

His voice is crystal clear, as if he's speaking normally and not inside my head.

'Etta is my Goddess,' I reply, only to realise the insanity of this moment. I'm being distracted by a talking spirit. Thankfully, Oke seems to be experiencing something similar, but I know it's only going to be minutes at most before she finishes what she started.

'Just ask. Ask and we will help you, Daughter.'

I'm going insane. Of course I am. I don't have an ancient warrior spirit telling me to ask for help.

But what do I have to lose?

'Help me,' I whisper, my voice barely a breath. 'Please, help me.'

The words leave my lips at the same moment Oke swings back to face me. My stomach plummets when I see she's found her dagger and has one very clear target for it. She raises her weapon and I lift my hands in defence, as if the flesh of my palms will be enough to block the blade from piercing my sternum. I clench my body as I prepare for the pain of impact, though I keep my eyes open. I don't know why it matters, but I refuse to meet Mortidem with my eyes closed.

Every fibre in my body is taut as the tip of the dagger touches my skin, but all I feel is cold. Not pain. Just cold. Ice crystals form along the blade's

length, bright white, refracting light for just a heartbeat before the metal shatters completely.

Oke's jaw hangs loose as she stares at the useless wooden hilt in her hand.

'You … what the hell are you?'

She throws the hilt to the side before lunging. This time, a single shot of ice radiates from my palm in a long stream that strikes Oke through the heart. She stumbles back and drops to the ground, her full weight thudding down and shattering the ice beneath her.

It feels as though the entire earth shifts as water surges up and over the frozen surface, swallowing Oke into the darkness beyond as the cracks extend towards me.

'No!' I scramble backward, but they're moving so fast. Any second now, I'll be in the water.

Unless …

I stop and look up. That same figure is still there, something close to a smile now shadowing his face. Keeping my eyes on his, I place my hand on the soaking, cracking ice and speak.

'Help me,' I whisper again.

'I think you can help yourself,' he replies.

This time, I feel it. A rush of energy fills my body and sets every cell within me alight. I've felt magic before – of course I have, hundreds of times – but never have I felt anything like this. So energising. So pure. It floods into me, causing my back to arch as my eyes fall closed and I gasp. Only when the sensation has faded do I look down again, already knowing what I'm going to see. There's not a single crack in the ice. Excitement and relief flicker through me. Magic. I don't know where it's come from, or why, but somehow … I have magic in me again.

I move to stand, only to stop.

Kyor stands looking at me in total disbelief. 'I came back to help you,' he says. 'What the fuck did you do?'

Fear floods through me as any hint of relief I felt evaporates, gone like the cracks in the ice. His lips parted, Kyor stares at me unblinking. I don't know how much he saw of what I did, but I know he saw something. The fucking *Prince of Morathka* just witnessed me harness the one type of magic utterly forbidden in our lands. And using it carries a death penalty.

Is this it? Is this where he kills me? Will he use lightning or good old-fashioned blades? Blade, I'd guess, as lightning would crack the ice. As he glances down to his side and pulls out his dagger, I'm certain I'm right. But as I steel myself against his impending attack, he turns the blade around and hands it to me.

'Take this and hold on to it. And whatever the fuck it is you just did … no one can know. They'll kill you if they do.'

'Kyor. I … I …' I don't know what else to say. I know I was there, but it wasn't my magic. It couldn't have been. Whatever that spectral Issen did, that's on him, not me. If it even happened the way I think it did. After all, the whole point of the trial is to make us see things that aren't truly there.

'You did what you had to do.' His voice is commanding, controlling. The voice he uses in battle with his men, perhaps. 'You did whatever you needed to do to survive.'

'I didn't … It wasn't me.'

He presses his lips together.

My chest twists and I can see he doesn't believe me, but how can I know what he even saw? All I know is that whatever happened, however Oke died, I don't have the magic to do that. So why does it feel like her blood is on my hands?

Kyor's voice cuts through the cacophony of my thoughts. 'Let's get to the end of this thing. Together.'

We walk in silence, the rain dripping from our furs. The voices don't have the same impact they did before. Maybe it's the image of Oke's dying face that fills my mind and blocks them out. Or perhaps the Issen spectres have decided I'm no longer worth their effort. Either way, I'll take it.

More than once, I turn to Kyor to see if he's watching me with distrust, but he never is. We trudge on for what feels like hours in the biting cold, the wind almost cutting my skin.

But then, in the distance, I see the blue of the priestesses' robes and the silhouettes of the Rettlings who've already made it. A minute later and the silhouettes become people. Llinos and Benny.

My heart leaps at the sight of them, but as I quicken my pace to get to them, Kyor grabs me by the top of my arm and holds me firm.

'You can't tell them,' he whispers urgently. 'I don't care how much you think you trust them or whatever you believe happened. I watched you make a sword out of ice and there is only one group of people who can do

that. You can’t tell them, Rose. Not unless you want to risk being put to death.’

The way he’s looking at me is pure desperation, and the use of my name makes his advice hit harder. For the longest time, I would have sworn that *he* was the one not to trust. Yet he’s trained me for weeks on end without once trying to truly harm me, and he’s just saved my life. The time has come to make a choice. Either I trust him or I don’t.

And I find that I do.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 49

The last part of the journey off the lake takes us up a shingle bank. My feet slip on the black silt until I finally reach the ridge and drop down onto the hard stones. A sob stutters from my lips as someone hands me some water. I drink greedily, not even having the strength to thank – or even notice – whoever gave it to me.

It's only when Llinos takes a seat beside me that I speak. 'What are we meant to do now?' I ask.

'Wait, I think.'

So that's what we do. We wait on the hard shingle, staring out at the forest of fog in front of us. Watching as the rain stops. Waiting for the moment the priestess tells us that it's over, that there are no more living people left on the ice battlefield. But for now, I have hope and I'm refusing to let go of it. I can't. Jonas is still out there.

'How long has it been since the last person returned?'

I've asked the same question several times already and Benny and Llinos have alternated replying. But this time, I'm met with silence. I would almost prefer the voice back in my head to this. Almost. Still, I need an answer. 'How long?' I press.

'I don't know … maybe twenty minutes?' Llinos's voice is low. Solemn. 'Seiren was the last. Rose, I know you don't want to hear this, but maybe you need to prepare yourself.'

'He's still out there,' I reply stubbornly. There is some spell keeping the cold at bay, but still I can't seem to get warm.

Jonas. Jonas is the only member of our group who hasn't returned. Jonas, who has tried everything he can to keep me safe. Who begged me,

again and again, to not put myself at risk. And he didn't once cross my mind when I was on the ice. The thought that he might not make it is unfathomable.

'People are still alive.' I don't let a hint of doubt enter my voice. 'If they weren't, the priestesses would've taken us back to Wrohelm already. Jonas is still alive. I know he is.'

A prickle of static acts as a reminder that Kyor is standing only a few feet behind me, though whether it was his intention or not for me to feel it, I don't know. I'm pretty sure he hasn't stopped staring at me this entire time, as if he's terrified that I'm suddenly going to send out a bolt of ice and expose myself. I'm not saying I won't. But it won't be deliberate if I do.

'We're done here. Why are we waiting? There's no one alive out there now. They'll have frozen to death. This is a waste of our time.' Zara's voice cuts through the fog and I hate her for it. Her friends haven't returned, and unlike me, Zara doesn't know for certain that they're dead. The fact that she would just give up and move on with life … if I didn't hate her before, I do now.

'How many people haven't returned?' Llinos asks.

'Nine, including Jonas,' Benny replies.

'And we only know for certain that at least one of them is still alive.'

'Theoretically, it could be all nine,' Benny says, trying to be optimistic, but we all know that isn't true. I do, anyway. Because I saw two of them die. That means the most it could be is seven. But then I think of that first scream before I even stepped on the ice. Did that Rettling survive? It doesn't feel likely. That would make it six. Six possible lives out there. And Jonas isn't the only one I care about. While Seiren made it, there has been no sign of Kestria.

As the silence resumes, I consider telling them that Oke and Mattieu are dead, but I don't. Maybe because I'm worried that if I say that, then someone else will feel it's okay to say they saw Jonas or Kestria die too. And that's not something I can cope with hearing. I can't.

'How many are left? How many are alive on the ice?' I turn to find that Kyor has finally stopped keeping vigil over me and is standing in front of Mila. Even with the priestess standing on a platform, Kyor is tall enough to look her in the eye, although she barely acknowledges his presence.

'I know you know,' Kyor continues bluntly. 'At least have the decency to tell us that.'

Her lips curl. ‘The Great Goddess will let us know her chosen soon, I’m sure.’

Her chosen. The comment makes me nauseous. If that really is the case and only those Etta chooses to survive are making it past these trials, then what does that say about me?

I close my eyes because I’m not here in this moment because Etta chose me. I’m here because Kyor stopped me from doing something very stupid with my dagger. And because some spectre called me ‘daughter’ and told me to ask him for help, and then, according to the prince, I made a fucking ice sword appear from thin air and saved myself from Oke.

It feels like madness to even think it.

‘There! In the distance. Can you see?’ Hope swells through me, only to fall again as I realise it was Seiren’s voice rising over the howling wind. Half of what she says is fanciful, and I’ve never once held it against her – whatever’s happened to her, it’s not her fault – but this … this isn’t something I can cope with being another hallucination.

But then Grenda speaks too. ‘She’s right. Someone else is coming. Someone big.’

Llin’s hand clasps mine as we stare out into the mist at the blur growing ever closer to us.

‘They’re carrying someone,’ Benny says. ‘It’s not one person. It’s two. One’s being carried. But I’m not sure who.’

My heart thrums against my ribs with a pace fast enough to nearly choke me. ‘Is it him? Is it Jonas?’ My voice warbles as Benny’s eyes meet mine.

‘I can’t tell, Rose. I’m sorry. I can’t.’

My throat is tight as I skim the faces on the bank. There are only a few Rettlings who could carry Jonas any distance, and most of them are here around me. One isn’t though. Baylis. The guard. The first one who was called up to the vow. He’s not here. *He* could carry Jonas.

But as the blurred figures finally come into focus, my breath rushes out in a gasp of relief. Jonas isn’t the one being carried. He’s the one doing the carrying. He’s okay. But Kestria … Kestria lies in his arms. Unmoving.

‘I need a healer!’ His shout is muffled by distance and fog. ‘Someone get her a healer. Now!’

With my hands clenched into fists, I watch on, hope rising with every step he takes towards us. It’s not long now. Minutes at most. In minutes,

he'll be here, safe on the shingles with the rest of us. But just as the thought takes hold, his knees buckle. He catches himself, but his body hunches over.

'Someone help her!' he calls again. 'Please!'

'Fuck this,' Benny mutters. A heartbeat later, he is rushing down the stony bank back onto the ice.

'It's okay. I'm coming. I've got her.'

My chest is pounding as I watch on. Benny takes the Dorain Rettling out of Jonas's arms, at which point Jonas drops entirely, his knees and hands flat against the ice.

'We need a healer!' Benny calls again with Kestria in his arms. He strides back towards us, somehow keeping himself upright as his feet slide on the ice. What will happen if he doesn't make it now? He already completed the trial, but if the ice cracks and he and Kestria go under, then what? He's out of it? That can't be right.

My worry flicks from Benny to Jonas as I notice that the latter still hasn't moved. While Benny and Kestria are nearly at the shingle beach, Jonas is still out there. Still on all fours. He's head down, staring at the ice.

'What's he doing?' I whisper. 'Why isn't he moving?' My hands clench and unclench as I watch on, waiting for him to get back on his feet. With every second, my heart rate quickens, but nothing is happening. 'Jonas! Get up! You're nearly here! You're nearly here!'

I shift further down the shingles towards the ice, my feet sliding on the stones as I go. But it's no good. Either he can't hear me or he's not listening. Either way, he's not moving. And staying still on the ice like that only ends one way. With a burst of clarity, I know I can't wait any longer. Picking up my feet, I rush down the last stretch of the bank … only to be pulled back before I hit the ice.

'What are you doing? You barely made it out of there yourself.' Kyor's blue eyes lock on mine with urgency. 'Think rationally, Thorn. Think about what could happen.'

Rationally? My rational brain is telling me that my friend is fifty feet away, close enough for me to watch him die, and I'm not going to do it. I'm not. Surely Kyor's seen enough death to know why I can't do that.

But I quickly realise that's not what Kyor's saying. He's afraid. Afraid of what would happen if anyone else saw it happen again. If that ice magic he's so certain I used to kill Oke reappeared. We both know the answer. If it does, I'm as good as dead.

But Jonas wouldn’t leave me out there. He wouldn’t stand idly by and watch me die. So I can’t leave him.

‘I have to,’ I say, shaking off Kyor’s grip.

‘Fuck!’ he mutters.

‘Right beside you,’ Llinos tells me as we step onto the ice together.

We are barely two feet away from the bank when Benny passes us with Kestria, headed in the opposite direction. I don’t know why I turn to look at her, why I don’t just keep going straight for Jonas, but something causes me to slow. To look at the body in his arms.

My heart drops and a chilling dread fills my stomach as my hand flies to my mouth.

I know why Jonas isn’t moving. Why he’s staying there on the ice, even though it’s certain death. And why he felt he had to get Kestria to the end.

Kestria’s eyes are white, and from what I saw, the ghosts on the ice didn’t have the powers to do something like that. No, the only person I know with that power is Jonas.

Jonas blinded her.

‘Llin take her.’ Benny hands Kestria over to Llinos before turning back and heading with me to get Jonas.

‘Just make sure we keep a safe distance apart,’ Benny tells me as we approach. ‘The ice is patchy and thin here. If we put too much weight on one place, we’ll go under.’

‘I’ll follow your lead,’ I tell him, shifting further away.

My feet stumble as we reach Jonas, and it has nothing to do with the ice. His lips are tinged blue, and his fingers are taking on the same hue as he mutters to himself.

‘I didn’t mean to. I didn’t mean to …’ he stammers as Benny hooks one arm under his left side and I take his right. ‘I didn’t know. I didn’t know …’

‘It’s fine. It’s fine. She’ll be okay.’ Tears fill my eyes, the cold stinging as they blur my vision. Fissures form in my chest for Jonas and Kestria alike.

‘I don’t know why it wouldn’t stop. It always stops, but it didn’t. I didn’t know. I don’t know …’

‘It’s okay, Jonas. It’s okay. Come on, we’re nearly there. Let’s finish this thing,’ I soothe.

Together Benny and I drag him up the bank. His knees scrape the hard black stones, but he doesn’t so much as flinch.

No sooner have we reached the ridge than Mila raises her hand.

‘All the chosen have returned,’ she announces, a self-satisfied smile curving her lips and making me hate her just a little more.

My stomach drops. It’s over. Oke is dead, and I’m responsible. A corkscrewing feeling constricts my breathing, tightening around my chest. I don’t know what that Issen spirit did or how it’s even possible, but for that split moment I had magic flowing through me again. Utterly illegal magic.

I turn my head, hoping to catch Kyor’s eye, but before I can the snow disappears from beneath our feet.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 50

As soon as we return to the High Hold we take Jonas and Kestria to the healers. They aren't the only two who need help, but the others can all walk there themselves.

'The healers don't think they can get her sight back,' Benny murmurs to Llin and me as we eat dinner that night. Not that any of us have much of an appetite. Thankfully, my dagger was where I left it when I disappeared, and it is now safely tucked in its sheath and secured to my person once more.

'You went down there?' Llin asks Benny in surprise.

'I just … I needed to do something.'

I get it. Helplessness is a feeling I'm more used to than most. Nights spent in the slums when I couldn't remember the last time I ate. When our bodies were so cold I was scared Kay or I might go to sleep and never wake up. I felt hopeless then, too.

The hall is all but empty, and the quiet is unnerving. We're officially down to sixteen. Sixteen Rettlings will compete in the penultimate trial. Eighty percent of us are dead or at least assumed dead. Looking at the numbers like that, every minute longer I'm here feels like a miracle.

'But it was magic that caused Kestria's condition,' I respond. 'Surely magic can erase it.'

'They've tried everything they can and none of it's worked. They're out of options, which means she's out of the Retterheld.'

Silence descends again and I push a piece of meat around my plate. A month and a half ago I would have wept to see food like this. Now I can barely swallow.

‘Have you seen Jonas yet?’ Benny breaks the silence with a question I feel ashamed to answer.

‘No, not yet. I was going to go down to the healers after this.’

We’ve been back for hours, and I know I should have been down there already. If it were the other way around, I’m sure Jonas would have camped at the end of my bed until I was ready to talk. The very least I can do is not abandon him now, when he needs me. But it’s hard to face his pain over blinding a woman when I killed one.

‘You won’t find him with the healers,’ Benny confirms. ‘They let him out. A couple of hours ago, I think.’

‘What?’ The word comes out far louder than I expected. ‘Why?’

‘Because he’s okay, I guess.’

‘Okay?’ My jaw drops. ‘He tried to stay out on the ice. He was on all fours, metres from the finish, ready to give up and die. We had to drag him in, even when he was physically fine. That’s not okay.’

Benny looks down. ‘I meant physically okay,’ he mumbles as I stand. Any cowardice I felt at avoiding my own frailties is gone as I march upstairs to find Jonas.

The really stupid thing is, I don’t actually know where Jonas’s room is. Whenever he wanted to talk, he either waited outside my door or we slipped off during training. Still, there aren’t that many of us left, and many rooms are empty, so it doesn’t take too long to find him.

I knock on the door, open it when I don’t hear an answer and then knock again when I step inside, in the hope it’ll alert him to my presence. Yet he doesn’t even turn, his gaze fixed out of the window.

‘Jonas?’

He jerks like he’s just had a dagger drawn at his throat.

‘Rose, what are you doing here?’

‘I came to see if you were okay. Why else?’

He bites his lip, and for the first time since I arrived at the High Hold, I’m struck by a startling realisation that, with each trial, it gets less and less likely that both of us are going to make it to the end.

‘She won’t ever get her sight back,’ he says quietly. ‘There’s nothing they can do.’

‘There’s nothing they can do at the minute,’ I reply firmly, taking a seat next to him. ‘Maybe they’ll find something later. And there are other healers in Morathka, in Rowell, Dorain, and Galreck. We don’t know what

they’re capable of.’ My hand hovers above his knee, unsure whether I should actually touch him. But I realise he needs it. He needs physical reassurance. When my hand rests on his thigh, he finally turns to look at me.

‘Jonas, I know that whatever happened, it was an accident. I know you didn’t mean to hurt her.’

‘I should’ve seen.’ He falters, his gaze shifting down again. ‘I should’ve been able to tell it was her, not one of them. I should’ve known from the screaming.’

‘You weren’t the only one who couldn’t tell. Mattieu was going to kill Oke.’ I take a deep breath. ‘It was … insane. I nearly …’ I trail off, not wanting to confess what I nearly did to myself, what I would have done but for Kyor stopping me. Still, Jonas needs the truth, at least some of it, and I hope it will shock him out of this funk to know he isn’t the only one carrying guilt. ‘I killed Oke, and I’m not even sure how. And believe me, that doesn’t make it any better.’

He looks at me again, this time with real shock in his eyes.

‘*You* killed Oke?’

I could have done without the incredulity.

‘Rose,’ he breathes as he reaches for my hand, but I gently shake it away.

‘I didn’t want to do it,’ I say firmly, for myself as much as for him. ‘I was trying to save her. The spirits got to Mattieu, and she was spiralling too.’

Memories surge: the scream, the ice, and the power that shouldn’t have been possible for me to channel. However much we’re sharing in this moment, I have no intention of telling him about that.

‘I don’t blame myself for doing what had to be done. And you shouldn’t blame yourself either.’

He breathes out again in a long sigh. ‘It’s easy for you to say. You killed Oke, yes, but she tried to kill you … how many times? What did Kestria ever do to deserve what I did to her?’

‘Nothing,’ I admit softly. ‘But what did Coulter do to deserve what happened to him at the temple? What did Estel do to deserve her death? These trials … it would be great if the good people finished on top, and though I wish things were that simple, they’re just not.’

‘She’s a good person. She’s … she’s …’ He shakes his head, letting the words fade.

My heart aches for him because he’s right. Kestria *is* a good person, and this whole thing just sucks. There was a time when I thought the Retterheld would be a glorious event full of redemption and hope and camaraderie, but it isn’t. It’s dark and insidious and it’s killing us all, one by one.

I take a shuddering breath. ‘Jonas. I don’t know why some of us have survived and some haven’t. I really don’t. But you’re not a bad person. What happened today doesn’t change that.’

He huffs as he presses his lips tightly together. ‘There are things about me, Rose. Things you’d hate me for if you knew.’

‘I doubt it.’ I place my hand over his. ‘Jonas, I know *you*. And if you really have done something that terrible, then whatever it is, I’m sure it’s because you didn’t have a choice.’

His chin dips in the tiniest of nods, and for the first time, it feels like I’m reaching him.

‘I’m starting to believe you, Rose.’ He meets my gaze, but it’s only when he lifts a hand towards the side of my face that I realise what he’s going to do.

He’s going to kiss me again.

‘Jonas …’

‘You don’t want this?’ he asks softly.

I don’t. But I see the hope in his eyes. The last thing he needs is rejection today. If I tell him no, I could send him back into the pit of despair he’s been wallowing in.

So I manage a smile. ‘Not here. Not now.’

He nods. ‘Right person. Wrong time?’ he says hopefully.

‘Something like that.’ My chest tightens. I hate that I might be leading him on, even a little, but the truth is, I don’t want his lips on mine. I want Kyor’s.

I stand and gently remove my hand from his. ‘Get some sleep, Jonas. We’ve still got two trials. We’re going to get through them. Together.’

With that, I kiss the top of his head and leave the room.

There’s someone else I need to see tonight.



MORE THAN ONCE I'VE wondered where Kyor's room is. I know he's way too much of a stickler for rules not to be sleeping in the barracks, so though he's not in the dorm rooms, I'm certain he's nearby. Given his absence upstairs and his affinity for the basement kitchen, as evidenced by our multiple run-ins there, I've concluded that he must be somewhere downstairs.

Betting on my hunch, I head down to the kitchens and find several of the cooks working over the stoves.

'I'm looking for Prince Kyor,' I say.

They exchange a look that tells me I was right. He *is* down here somewhere.

'I just want to talk to him. I'm a … friend.'

The word chokes my throat. Of all the things we are, we're not that. I have zero platonic feelings for the prince.

'It's fine, ladies. She can come through.' His voice carries from the far end of the kitchen where he stands by a door. He pushes it wide open before stepping to the side. My own royal invitation.

Butterflies swarm through me, most likely trying to make me see sense, but I ignore them as I offer the cooks a brief smile of thanks and slip through the door. As it shuts behind me, I tell myself the roaring in my blood is from apprehension and nothing else.

There are no windows, given that it's in the basement, but the lamps offer more than enough light to see by. It's a simple room. No decorations, nothing to soften the stone-grey walls, but the bed is a damn sight larger than the ones we've been subjected to upstairs. Yet despite the scarcity, the space somehow still looks well lived-in, with books stacked high, clothes draped over chairs, and a wardrobe with its doors open. This doesn't look like a room that's been occupied just for the weeks of the trials.

'This has always been my hideaway,' he explains casually. 'Close to food, away from my father. Win-win.'

My eyes fall on the desk in the corner of the room, its surface covered with scattered paper and charcoal. Silently, I move over to it, and a breath of surprise snags in my throat at what I find.

'Elska.' There is no mistaking the image. Even in black and white, the two tones of her eyes and ringed irises have been captured perfectly. I move to see the paper underneath, but he catches me by the wrist and tidies the sketches away.

‘Did you do these?’

He offers a casual lift of one shoulder. ‘It passes the time.’

I turn to look at him. ‘What are you going to do?’ I ask. ‘About everything. About me.’

He takes a step forward. ‘I don’t know what you’re talking about,’ he says, his voice low. ‘We were on the battlefield. It was … difficult. Ice, fire, ghosts, flying daggers. I saw nothing.’

He takes another step towards me. He’s so close now, his chest only inches from mine. My heart hammers behind my ribs.

‘So is that why you came here?’ he asks. ‘To see what I saw?’

‘It’s one of the reasons.’

‘And the other?’

There is no smirk on his lips. None of the usual playful teasing. My breathing is growing shallower. I try to find the force to resist the inevitable, but do I want to? No, I don’t. That’s the truth. I don’t want to fight it anymore. This is what I’ve wanted since that night in the temple all those weeks ago.

‘I seem to have forgotten the other reason I came here.’ My voice is barely a whisper.

‘I don’t think that’s true,’ he replies. ‘I think you know exactly what you want. I told you. If you want it, you only have to ask.’

I remember. Of course I remember. But it’s a line that, once crossed, there’ll be no coming back from.

I wet my lips. ‘I want it,’ I breathe.

He smiles. ‘Good girl. You’re going to be mine,’ he promises. ‘Say it.’

‘Yours,’ I stutter out.

‘That’s right.’ He moves closer until there’s barely anything between us and I’m backed up against the wall. He slides his fingers into my hair and fists it in his hand, causing a moan to slip from my lips. His eyes darken, and his restraint snaps.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 51

He presses his lips to mine and his taste floods me as his mouth claims mine with an urgency that borders on desperation. No smart remarks. No more teasing. Just the raw need that fills us both. As heat floods through me, he tilts his head and bites down on my lower lip. A low, guttural groan escapes my throat, and before I can catch my breath, he seizes me, his hips locking me in place as his thumb grazes along my jaw.

'Gods, Thorn,' he groans. 'You have no idea what you do to me.'

My hand reaches around the back of his neck, grasping a handful of his hair as I pull myself deeper into the kiss. As slick as I feel myself becoming, this isn't enough. I need more. I need all of him.

As if reading my mind, his hand scoops around me and he hoists me upward, my legs going around his hips. The moan that fills the air comes from him this time, but it might as well be mine. I no longer have control over my body. No longer care what happens beyond this moment.

The trials. The gifting. Whatever the hell I did to Oke. None of it matters. All I can think about is this. The feel of his body pressed against mine and how much more I need.

His hands slip up my top with deliberate slowness, so that I'm nearly crying out by the time his rough fingertips finally skim over my nipples. I swear they've never been so sensitive. He strokes them lightly, and then he gives them a gentle squeeze, which becomes a more forceful pinch. Conscious of the staff just on the other side of the door, I use all my willpower not to let out a loud moan. Instead, I bite down on my bottom lip, clenching my eyes closed as I fight to maintain a tiny scrap of self-control.

‘Don’t,’ he orders. His hand moves from my breast to my jaw, his thumb brushing against the corner of my mouth. ‘Don’t hold back. Don’t be quiet. How else am I going to learn what you like? To know whether you like a soft touch’—his fingers skim my nipple again—‘or a more forceful one?’ He pinches my nipple then and my hips arch into him. ‘Ah. Thorn, you like a little pain.’ It’s his turn to groan. ‘You were made for me.’

Gods, his voice. I didn’t know it was possible for a voice to make me so wet, and yet here I am, drenched.

My thighs squeeze, not to hold on, but because the distance is too great. I need him closer. I need the friction of him inside me. Fingers, tongue, cock … I don’t care. I just need something more. The hunger is all-consuming as his fingers continue their exploration while his mouth closes in around my neck, kissing, licking, nibbling, eliciting another whimper of delight.

‘That’s better.’ His voice is a breathless groan that causes my body to slicken further, if that’s even possible. ‘That sound. You have no idea how fucking hard it makes me.’

‘I have a fair idea,’ I manage to respond. I can feel him pressing into me through the thickness of our trousers, but it’s not enough. I need to actually feel him. I’m throbbing, pulsing with feral desire. Letting instinct take over, I roll my hips down, increasing the pressure on us both. Another moan ripples from his throat and my body responds by bucking deep into him. There’s too much fabric. I need to be free of it. I need him, all of him.

I release my arms from his neck, tightening my legs around him to hold myself in place as I pull my top over my head.

A feeling of satisfaction rises in me as a muffled gasp catches in his throat before he lowers his mouth to the top of my breast. I tilt my head away, allowing him to trace his tongue down, weaving a line towards my nipples. As my back arches, I push further into him. I’m so close to begging for release that my entire body is trembling, but at the same time, I don’t want this to end.

It’s taking every bit of control I have not to rip his trousers off and wrap my hand around his cock, yet somehow my fingers stay in his hair as I lean into him. His hands are everywhere, one still on the back of my neck, holding me in place, while the other explores before coming back to my breasts, rolling my nipples between his fingers.

‘More,’ I gasp, unable to hold back any longer. ‘I need more.’

He doesn’t question. Instead, he holds me tight as he turns me around, throws me down on the bed, and removes his top.

Fuck me, he is perfect. Every single inch of his torso is carved and glistening beneath those bands of circle tattoos, and I want to touch it all. Every part that is visible to me, and every part he’s still keeping hidden. I lift my hand and run my fingers along the pinkest scar on his body. The one that I sewed up. He pulled the stitches out himself, rather than asking me. Why does that not surprise me?

‘It’s my favourite one,’ he purrs as he notices where I’m staring. ‘Because it reminds me of the first time you put your hands on me. The first time I heard you moan, Thorn. The first time I *made* you moan.’

Gods know, he’s going to hear me moan more.

I sit up, my breathing shallow and ragged as I drag my hand over his chest, tracing that thin line of hair that leads downwards to my reward. His head tilts back as he groans out my name, melting me into a puddle beneath him. I’m going to come the second he slides into me. I already know it. I just hope to hell I have the same effect on him. Because that’s what I want most. Even more than feeling the release in my body. I need to feel his release inside me.

‘Thorn,’ he groans my name again, but I don’t respond. Instead, I work the top button on his trousers. His eyes gaze down at me as he bites his lip. Gods, those eyes, he could devour me with those alone.

Impatience gets the better of me, and with only two of his buttons undone, I reach up and wrap my hands around his neck, pulling him back down onto me. His tongue rakes the inside of my mouth as I finally feel the length of him pressing against me again.

How can I need something this much? How can my body know complete and utter desperation for something it’s never felt before?

‘I need you.’ The words leave my mouth unbidden. ‘I need all of you. Inside me. Now.’

His hands graze over my breasts and my stomach as if he, too, needs to feel every last bit of me, yet when his fingers reach my waistband, they stop. I wait for him to work the buttons. To finally expose me so he can take me however he wants, but his hands continue to hover right where they are.

‘Don’t stop.’ The words are perforated by my breath. ‘Don’t stop. I need this. I need … I need …’ I don’t even know how to finish that sentence.

He stands up and edges away from the bed. I assume it's to give me room to undo my own trousers, but when I look up at him, his face is tight with a sudden frown.

'Why?' he whispers.

'What?' I'm still fighting with my buttons, my fingers fumbling and slowed by confusion.

'Why?' he says again. 'Why do you need this? Is it because you think this is the only way I'll keep your secret?'

'What?' I sit upright, aware of the throbbing that continues between my legs. The rhythm of my pulse that's desperate to be matched by his own.

'No, no …' I want to pull him back down on top of me and continue what we started, but he remains out of reach.

'You didn't want this,' he growls, not even looking me in the eye. 'The other night when I came to you. You didn't want this. But today … suddenly now you do? Nothing's changed except I hold your secret.'

'What? No. I … I … You were drunk then.'

His eyes lock back onto mine. 'So that's the only reason? You just happened to choose today out of all days to come and seduce me by pure coincidence?'

I open my mouth, but no words come out. What do I say? That I wanted him all along, but I was fighting it for my own sanity? That wanting him felt like a betrayal of my entire family, my entire past, but today I couldn't fight it any longer? Or is he right? Is some part of me doing this so that he will keep my secret?

No. No, of course I'm not. This *is* what I want. The damn trials have taken life after life, and who knows if they'll take mine before the end. Right now this is all I want, and this might be the only chance I have to get it. But as I clear my mind, and my throat, I already know I took too long to respond.

'You need to go,' he says, picking up my shirt and throwing it at me. 'I need you to go now.'

'Kyor.' I stand and reach for him, but he recoils from me.

'You don't have to fuck me to keep me silent. I'm not going to tell anyone.'

'I didn't think you would!' I shake my head. How did things go to shit so fast? 'I never thought you'd tell anyone,' I repeat.

His head whips up. ‘So you trust me? Utterly?’ His voice is a low purr that trembles down my spine as he takes a step towards me. ‘Tell me you trust me and we can carry on where we just stopped. Believe me, there is nothing I want more than that, Thorn. Just tell me that you trust me. Truly trust me.’

My pulse is drumming and my breathing is ragged, but it’s not just the hunger to feel him inside me that’s causing it. It’s the pain. The confusion. I believe what I said – that I don’t think he’ll tell anyone what he saw – but now the past is merging with the present. After what he and his family did to mine all those years ago … trust? It’s a hard-won thing.

‘I … I …’ I stutter.

I know what I want to tell him. I want to tell him the words that will have his lips back on mine and his body inside me. Yet they refuse to form. Because what good can come of this closeness between us? How can we possibly have a future together? How can I explain this to Kay when Kyor and his father are responsible for our family’s ruin? Our brother’s death? Every logical partial thought I have is telling me to walk away. And yet I cannot leave.

He grimaces. ‘If it’s that difficult for you to say, then I think we already know the answer.’ Without another word, he picks up his shirt, slips it over his head, and turns for the door.

‘You know your way back,’ he growls just before the door clicks closed behind him.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 52

I only realise I'm heading up to the smoke-stained shell of my previous room when the charred stairs creak beneath my feet. I assume Caroline will be with Llin, and I don't need them to question where I've been for the last half an hour. Or what happened when I went to speak to Jonas. In truth, there's a lot of the day I want to push from my mind and pretend never happened, but the best I can hope for now is a decent night's sleep.

As I open the door and the smell of ash fills my nostrils, I freeze. There, on the windowsill, are three ravens. Three.

The sight should see me running for literally anywhere else, but I don't have the energy. Instead, I curl up on my bed and close my eyes.



WHEN I GO DOWN to breakfast the next morning, Llinos and Benny are waiting for me, and they're not alone. Jonas is at the table and eating. It's a definite improvement over yesterday. He flashes me a smile, though I struggle to meet his gaze as I think about the way his hand reached for my cheek. The way he wanted to kiss me. And the way I immediately ran to Kyor, only to be rejected in the most humiliating way possible. Suffice to say, I didn't get up for our early training session this morning.

'Is it just me, or does everyone else not feel like having a celebratory ball tonight?' Llinos picks at the pastry in front of her as her gaze flitters down to the end of the dining table where Seiren is sitting alone. I'm sure they asked her to join us, but like most of the remaining Rettlings, she

doesn’t look like she’s in the mood for company. ‘The fewer and fewer there are of us, the harder it is not to think about how it could be your last.’ Llinos looks glum. This whole thing is really taking its toll on her. On all of us.

‘Hey!’ I nudge her. ‘It’s absolutely not going to be your last one.’

She sighs. ‘I know I’m hardcore, but I’m just saying. It feels wrong, you know? To be swanning around in luxury when so many people haven’t made it.’

I don’t reply. There’re always people dying, I think, as my mind flickers from the slums to Kyor’s etches on the battle yard wall.

‘Balls are a distraction,’ Jonas says tightly. ‘We need to think about the next trial.’

There’s an efficiency in his voice. An urgency. Like it’s not the ball he doesn’t want to think about, but Kestria. Not that I can blame him. We all have different ways of coping with things. Normally I’d use brewing to distract myself from everything that’s going on. Maybe I should try that again. Still, if Jonas wants to take the lead on whatever’s coming next, I’m hardly going to hold that against him.

‘It has to be pairs, and it has to be water,’ Benny replies.

‘We’ve already done water, remember?’ I point out.

He snorts. ‘That was ice. It doesn’t count. There’s always one in the actual water, whether it is swimming or rowing somewhere dangerous with boats. And the Ofur is always a solo task, but I can’t imagine that it will be water-based.’

If it is, I’m screwed, I think to myself. It’s not just about how weak a swimmer I am. If any of that spectre’s magic is still flowing through me, a massive body of water would be the worst place for it to show up. I’m pretty sure that freezing so much as a puddle would be enough to get Kay and me killed.

‘I agree.’ Jonas nods. ‘Water and pairs. Which means you’re going to need help, Rose. We need to sort this now. Benny and Llinos will be together. And you and I will pair up. And this time, you stay out of the way until I’m sure you’re safe.’

Irritation at his condescension slams through me, but I try not to let it show. I get that he needs to take charge, and Llinos and I had the conversation about pairings a couple of weeks before anyway. I saw how utterly broken he was last night and understand that this facade of his is

exactly that. But highlighting *my* weakness, as if I'm incapable of adding anything to the trial at all, isn't going to change what happened out there on the ice. There's also the fact that he would have died in the trial had it not been for the rest of us.

'I'm fine with those pairings,' I say steadily, 'but I suggest we wait and see what the trial is before we rule me out.' My response is measured and reasonable, and I assume there's no way he can argue with it. Turns out I'm wrong.

'No, it'll be easier if I don't have to worry about you.'

'I don't need you to worry about me. The fact that I'm still here should tell you that.' I hear my voice rise in volume as I struggle not to grind my teeth. But when he lets out a sigh, I feel my last tether start to fray.

'Please, Rose, at some point, your luck is going to change. Water or not, you have to see how unlikely it is that you'll make it through the last two trials without our help. You need to be prepared.'

Static brushes my shoulders a second before a new voice growls, 'It's not luck she's still here, and saying that it is, is a fucking big insult to someone chosen by Etta.'

My chest skitters as memories of last night come searing back to me. His lips on mine, his tongue on my body, and the way he left because I couldn't say I trusted him.

'You're not needed in this conversation.' My voice is clipped and icy.

'I disagree.'

'Kyor …' There's a tremble to my tone. He's the one who told me to keep the incident with the ice magic secret, so why do I feel like he's about to expose me? Maybe I was right not to say those words.

'This is a private conversation,' I say evenly.

I've never seen Jonas show anything but deference to the prince, but the press of his lips now is just more evidence as to how close he is to breaking point. And to snap here, with Kyor, is something he doesn't want to do.

'Then perhaps you should have been a little quieter.' Kyor's eyes flick to me, and all I can think about is his request for me not to be quiet and how desperate I was to ask the same of him. To hear him lose himself within me. My gaze is drawn to his fingertips, to the static spark that flickers visibly between them.

I swallow, apprehension rising. He's not going to attack Jonas, is he? He can't. There's no way. He values Etta's grace way too much. But Jonas? I

don’t think he gives a shit at this point.

‘Rose saved you all against the jötunn,’ Kyor growls. ‘Everyone saw it. You would be dead if she hadn’t done what she did. And when it came to the forest, she held off a fully grown dire wolf on her own. She didn’t just blind them, which is what you did, right? Just blinded the threat and walked straight past? Really freaking brave strolling past something that can’t see you.’ That vein on Jonas’s forehead is pulsing again, anger seething from his very being. ‘And from what I’ve heard, you even messed up with that power, too.’

‘Kyor, enough!’ I snap.

His lips purse like he knows he said too much, but I can tell he’s not going to stop. He’s got more to say.

‘You know she actually tried to save Oke?’ he tells Jonas. ‘She tried to save someone who had tried to kill her. And she nearly died doing it. But she didn’t. She’s still here. And now you’re going to sit there and tell her she needs to stay back because she’s weak? You have no idea how strong this woman is. No fucking idea. Oh, and just so you know, if there’s any pairing in the trials, she’s with me. You can take that as an order from your prince.’

With that, he turns around and marches away.

My gaze follows Kyor until he disappears, and when I look back, everyone is gawking at me. Jonas knows what happened with Oke because I already told him. But the others stare at me in disbelief.

Finally, Llinos clears her throat. ‘Talk about sexual tension. If you don’t fuck that prince soon, then I might genuinely consider it,’ she says. ‘And Caroline is going to be less than happy about that.’

Next to her, Benny snorts, but Jonas abruptly pushes back his chair and stands.

‘Turns out it wasn’t just a case of wrong time, was it, Rose?’ he mutters, shaking his head. ‘Of all the fucking men.’ He turns on his heels and marches off.

‘Well fuck.’ I drop my head into my hands.

‘I don’t know why they say women are the emotional ones.’ Llinos shakes her head in mock-disbelief at Jonas’s back before she smirks.

‘Hey, don’t put me in with those guys,’ Benny protests. ‘I don’t have an emotional bone in my body.’

‘Yeah, right.’ My head is throbbing from whatever the hell just happened, but I’m grateful for the pair of them trying to make light of it.

‘And talking of emotional men who get unreasonably erratic around you,’ Benny continues. ‘I guess it’s time we head to the battle yard and face Holden.’

I grimace. If I’m not training with Kyor, then he’s probably right. I need to spend the day training. Besides, Holden must recognise that I’m not a runt by now, right?



‘Is it me, or is Holden staring at us way more than normal?’ Benny asks. Llin and I are meant to be fighting him together, but she’s distracted – most likely wishing she could be spending time with Caroline before the next trial. But with the scribe working, it’s either sulk in the dorm or practise with us. Although what she’s really doing is a piss-poor attempt at both.

‘Not us,’ I respond to Benny’s comment. ‘Me. I swear, after every trial, he’s more and more angry that I’m still alive. I’m pretty sure if I make it to the Ofur he’s going to kill me himself.’

Llinos laughs as she slices her sword towards Benny only to have him block it with ease. ‘I’d like to see him try now that you have your own prince protector.’

I let out a low groan. ‘He is not my protector.’

‘No? Then where did you sleep last night?’

‘Truthfully?’ I say. ‘In my old room.’

Her eyes widen. ‘As in the one that was burned down? With no door?’

I grimace. ‘Yeah. I figured Zara wasn’t going to come for me there, not that I really expected her to come for me at all. Seeing her sitting at breakfast this morning was such a sorry sight, I almost felt bad for her.’

Zara chose her normal table and sat there alone. She was there when I arrived and was still there when I left, staring blankly into nothing. Quite a change from the woman who purportedly was just fine leaving her fellow Rettlings to freeze to death on the ice.

‘From all the talk over here, I assume you’re hoping that whatever trials you face next will simply be lulled to sleep with your drivel.’ The nasal timbre of Holden’s voice cuts through the air as he strides towards us.

‘I’m pretty sure that’s the only technique he’s ever used to win a fight,’ Llinos mutters, just loud enough for us to hear.

Benny laughs, but my attention is still fixed on Holden. The very sight of him is enough to make my skin bristle.

‘Miss Kultavaris, it appears that you and I have never had the pleasure of sparring together. Given how much you and Zelle used to enjoy your little tussles, I thought we could rectify that now.’

I can feel Benny’s and Llin’s eyes boring into me, but as much as my heart slams in my chest, I know I need to do this. I believe I’m good enough to survive the final two trials and that I don’t need Jonas or Kyor to protect me, and now is my chance to prove it. Maybe then they’ll believe me.

Holden continues, ‘I’m interested to see exactly how you’ve survived trials that have killed the likes of Baylis Airlan. His wolf travels back to Afaven Forest for his final rest while you stand here, yet again.’

Were he and Baylis close? I never noticed, but then, they were both knights of a similar age. Maybe they trained together. Fought together. I’m hardly surprised he assumed Baylis deserved a place above me. Deep down I probably thought the same at the beginning. But these trials have never been solely about who the strongest fighter is. These are Etta’s trials. The Goddess of Life. So what does it mean for me now that I’ve taken one? The vision of Oke’s dying eyes threatens to resurface, but with a sharp inhale, I push the image down and focus on the moment. With the way Holden feels about me, this spar could easily be as deadly as the next trial.

It’s only as Holden draws his sword that I realise it’s the first time I’ve actually seen him fight. Standing on the sidelines and barking orders? Absolutely. But fighting? No.

I step back as he performs an elaborate and utterly unnecessary flourish with his blade, while behind me, Benny clears his throat.

‘Left shoulder,’ he mutters between coughs.

A flicker of a smile touches my lips. I doubt Holden heard, but either way, I don’t care. At least now I’ve got a target. Yet as I fix my gaze entirely on his blade, an icy chill cascades down my spine. The last time a blade struck me, the metal froze under my touch and shattered. But surely that won’t happen here? I’ve fought in the yard hundreds of times and as far as I’m aware there are no Issen spectres doling out their magic inside these walls.

I swallow down the fear pounding through me. No, not fear. Nerves. That's what Zelle told me. There's only a dagger in my hand, and that's not going to cut it, so I crouch to grab a sword.

It's at that very moment that Holden chooses to lunge.

'Watch out!' Llinos yells as his sword whips towards me.

By some miracle, I block it, my own sword bracing just inches above my head as the metal clangs.

As my sword swings one way and then the next, blocking his strikes and attempting my own, a fluidity takes hold. There's no time to think about the manner in which my feet are moving, nor any need. Turns out the hours of training have paid off. My movements are instinctive and my feet dance across the sand, adrenaline pounding through me, quickening each step.

A grimace contorts Holden's lips as he swings high, aiming for my neck, but his action is careless and easy to avoid. I duck down and swing hard at the side of his knees.

'Fuck!' he cries out. The sudden pain is enough for him to loosen the grip on his sword and it's the only advantage I need. As I stand back up, I swing my sword higher, putting my body's momentum behind it and striking the underside of Holden's blade, knocking it from his hand.

'Bitch,' he snarls as the sword clatters to the ground, but he makes no attempt to reach for it. Instead, he brings his hands together, lengthening his fingers and twisting his wrists. I brace myself, ready to duck his fire, but nothing comes. From the pinch of his brow, he's as confused as I am.

'I'd say she won that one, wouldn't you?' It's Kyor. He's watching us from a short distance away, and next to him stands Roderick, Zelle's replacement siphon.

My chest stutters. Is that pride in Kyor's expression or something else?

'I'm sure there are other Rettlings who would benefit from your aid now, Commander,' Roderick says, though Holden doesn't so much as glance in his direction. His eyes are trained solely on me.

'You got lucky, Kultavaris,' he hisses. 'And luck always runs out sooner or later.'

His words are so similar to the ones Jonas offered me this morning that they should probably sting. But they don't. That wasn't luck just now. That was me. And from the smile on Llinos's and Benny's faces, they both saw it.

Yet my gaze moves immediately from them to Kyor, as though seeking his approval.

Neither of us speak as his eyes trail down to my lips. How the hell my body can have such a feral response to just his gaze is beyond me, and yet it does. My heart is racing and it has nothing to do with the fight I just had.

‘I don’t know what you’re doing here,’ I say, trying to keep my tone casual. ‘But unless you’ve come to spar, we’re busy.’

‘Maybe that’s exactly what I’ve come for.’

His eyes lock on mine, and my mind is flooded with images of last night. It’s like I can taste him on my tongue, can feel his hands gently pulling my hair …

Fuck. I’m pretty sure I’m going to start panting.

Tingles start on my skin, static running up and down my body. I want to moan, but I bite my lip.

Damn him! He *is* toying with me.

‘Well,’ I say, snapping myself out of it before I lose any more control. ‘Then I’ll leave you to it. Enjoy your workout. Llin and I need to get ready for the ball.’

‘Actually, I’m not going.’ Llinos makes no attempt to hide her eavesdropping.

Kyor’s attention finally shifts from me to her, and a single crease forms between his brows.

‘You’re not? Why?’

She moves closer. ‘Because the rules about who is and isn’t allowed to attend are archaic and serve only to bolster the—bolster certain egos.’

Kyor’s frown and confusion only increase.

‘She means her girlfriend can’t come because she’s a scribe and not a member of the court,’ I snap, wanting this ridiculous conversation to be over with as quickly as possible. ‘Now, if you don’t mind, we need to go.’

With the sword still in my hand, I swing around, loop my spare arm into Llinos’s, and drag her away.

‘What are you doing talking to him?’ I hiss. ‘We don’t initiate conversation with Kyor.’

She lifts her eyebrows accusingly. ‘Well, how about I’ll keep my mouth shut … if you tell me the truth about what happened between you and him? And Jonas, too?’

I let out a long sigh. She’s not going to let this go, and maybe it’ll help to get some advice. After all, it’s not like it can make things worse.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 53

‘I don’t know what it is between Kyor and me. Just physical attraction, I guess.’

‘But you and Jonas kissed,’ Llinos says, her brow creased in concentration as she slices through another ballgown.

‘Things have changed since then. Last night he wanted something more to happen, but I turned him down.’

‘And you said no because of this attraction to Kyor?’ Her eyes glint as she speaks. ‘Two hot guys wanting you. I can’t imagine how difficult it must be. I mean, have you thought about having both? At the same time?’

I offer her my best glower. ‘No, I haven’t.’

I haven’t seen Jonas since he stormed off at breakfast, and I’m sure it’s deliberate. We almost always cross each other’s paths in the dining hall or the battle yard, but today there’s been no sign of him. If it wasn’t for the fact that I’m desperate to see Kay, I’d skip the ball and hang out with Llinos rather than potentially having to face Jonas.

The dress Llin chooses for tonight is different from the others. The high neck cuts a horizontal line across my collarbones, while the back plunges all the way down to the base of my spine. While the top is black, the colour blends down into a deep blood-red on the skirt. The final detail is the slit. It’s a change from the normal fighting-shorts style – clearly Llin wanted to try something different – but it’s hardly modest, so high up my leg it’s almost at hip height.

‘Well.’ Llinos steps back. ‘If your aim is to have them physically drawing swords over you, this will definitely do that. And by swords, I mean—’

‘Just don’t.’ I shoot her a glare.

She snickers. ‘I’m just saying it’s hot as hell.’ She studies me. ‘I think we should leave your hair loose tonight. Straight. Give me a minute and I’ll see if I can get rid of some of that frizz.’

For the next ten minutes, she works on pulling the knots and snarls out of my hair. By the time she’s done, it’s time to leave, and yet she still hasn’t even had a shower.

‘It’s not like anyone actually checks if we go,’ she says. ‘And I just don’t feel in the mood.’

‘But what about the wine?’ I try weakly. ‘You were so upset last time when you couldn’t drink.’

She offers a slight smile. ‘Maybe you can sneak a bottle out for me?’

I’m about to suggest that if she comes, we can sneak several out and carry on the party here later, but before I can, there’s a knock on the door.

‘Are you ladies decent?’ Benny calls only to immediately push the door open. ‘Disappointing,’ he sighs as he strides in and strips his top off, only to stop in the middle of the room and look at Llin. ‘Why aren’t you ready?’

With a simultaneous groan and roll of her eyes, she drops down onto her bed.

‘I told you, I’m not going.’

‘Right, but that was when Caroline couldn’t come.’

Her head tilts to the side. ‘What do you mean, when?’

A grin quirks at the corner of Benny’s lips as he nods towards the door. Standing there, in a deep green ballgown, is Caroline.

With the gasp still leaving her lungs, Llin rushes to the door and wraps her arms around her girlfriend.

‘How?’

Caroline looks fit to burst; she’s smiling so broadly. ‘Well, it turns out having a girlfriend who’s friends with the prince has its bonuses. I can’t believe you didn’t tell me you two were close.’

Llin’s jaw drops. ‘Oh *we’re* not,’ she says, looking at me. ‘Rose, that’s not just physical. Doing stuff for your friends … that sounds like it could be bordering on actual feelings.’

Despite struggling to accept it, my stomach flutters in agreement.

‘You need to get dressed,’ I say to Llin instead.

‘Or is Caz coming as my date?’ Benny teases, flashing the scribe a grin.

‘I’VE JUST HAD the best thought,’ Llin exclaims as we cross the courtyard half an hour later. ‘Wasn’t it Kyor’s best friend who Acacia was with last time? What was his name? Hew? You guys could double-date. That would be so cute.’

‘Stop. It. Now.’

There’s no denying I’m going to have to speak to Kyor tonight, if only to say thank you for allowing Caz to attend, but the thought alone is enough to fill my stomach with butterflies.

As we step into the ballroom, we find that tonight’s theme is the colour white. White flowers, white suits on the waiters, white ice sculptures. Even the floor is white. I glance down at the hem of my dress, only for the air to stiffen in my lungs. The blood-red against the white floor conjures the image of Oke’s blood pooling on the ice. Blood I spilt.

‘Rose, you look lovely as always.’ I’m jerked out of the memory by Jonas’s voice. He is dressed the same way as he was at the other balls. Smart, attractive with his ceremonial sword, and still not the one I want.

‘May I walk you in?’

I hesitate. Giving him false hope isn’t going to help him, but I also don’t want to appear rude.

‘I was going to find Kay,’ I tell him, only for my line of sight to fall directly on her. A warmth spreads through my heart as I remember what Dinah said about us being able to find each other, even if the world cracked apart. She’s standing with a young man I recognise vaguely, though it’s definitely not Hew.

‘Isn’t that your father’s ward?’

‘William. Yes.’ Jonas sweeps his arm around my waist, causing my muscles to stiffen in response. ‘Come on, let’s get you a drink.’

‘I need to see her first,’ I say, slipping out of his grip, only for him to grab me by my hand.

‘We can get a drink. She’s not going anywhere.’

‘No, I want to see Kay first.’ I’m practically spitting the words, and I can feel Llin and the others staring at me, but I don’t care. I have no idea why Jonas thinks he has the right to stop me from speaking to my own sister, but it’s not going to happen. ‘You want a drink, then get one. I don’t

need an escort.’ With that, I turn on the ball of my foot and march across the dance floor towards her.

I’m still several feet away when Kay notices me. The way her eyes light up is almost enough to make up for the distance between us these past several weeks.

‘Rose!’ She squeals my name as she races those last few feet towards me and wraps her arms around me with such force I feel my ribs popping. Not that I can blame her. Never has a single hug felt as good as this. Tears fill my eyes as I hold her against me.

‘I can’t believe it,’ she whispers, her head still pressed against my shoulder. ‘I can’t believe you’ve survived all this without magic.’ She pulls away from me slightly, tears now streaming down her cheeks. ‘Rose, you’re actually going to win this thing! I believe it. You promised to bring us back here, and you did it. And now you’re going to win the Retterheld.’

‘It’s going well,’ I admit, brushing away her relieved tears with my thumb. I can’t believe how much healthier she looks. The colour in her cheeks. The brightness in her eyes. This is what I did this for. But as great as it is to have her faith in me, now I also have the fear of letting her down. ‘But there’s still the fourth trial and the Ofur to get through,’ I remind her.

‘Well, you’re certainly making the bookies look foolish,’ a voice interjects from behind me. I twist around only to realise I barged past William to get to Kay, and without so much as a greeting.

‘Sorry, William.’ I offer him my hand, which he kisses briefly and politely. ‘I hope you’re well. You were saying something about bookies?’

‘Very well. I was just saying that you might find one or two people whose purses are substantially lighter, what with you still being here.’

‘Then more fool them.’ Kay grins at me.

A light pause falls between us, though William fills it with ease and awareness.

‘You two have plenty to catch up on, so I shall leave you and hear how my own brother has been faring.’ He nods towards Jonas, who is staring at us from across the room. ‘Have a wonderful night, ladies.’

‘Thank you, William.’

‘It was lovely to see you again, Rose. Kay, I’ll see you at home later.’ He smiles at my sister.

‘See you later, Will.’

A notable tension ripples through me at the ease with which Kay seems to have accepted the court as her home. I need to tell her about Llin's offer. The goal was always to return to the High Hold, but now we have an option that is even better. Because if my closest friends are in the Eastern Isles, it would be foolish for us not to go there. But before I get a chance to speak, Kay takes my hands and pulls me towards one of the seats at the edge of the room. It's not next to the fire, so I guess she's also growing accustomed to the warmth here.

'So tell me everything. We don't have long till Hew arrives, and I promised him he could have all my dances tonight.'

The tension squeezes harder around my throat and chest. 'Kay, what are you doing?'

'What? Honestly, Rose, if you spent any time with him at all, you'd love him. He's fun. He's caring. He's attentive. He's—'

'A lord,' I say. 'A member of the Royal Court, from which we were banished after our powers were stripped.'

'To which we'll be returned, when you win the gifting, right? There's no point lying. I worked it out. That's the only reason you'd put yourself through this, right? For us. So that we can get out of the slums. So that we can live safely.' I try to interrupt but she won't let me get a word in edgeways. 'None of that matters to Hew. He doesn't care about that. He likes me as a person. Do you know what an incredible feeling that is?'

I thought I did. I thought Kyor saw me.

Anxiety holds me fast, but looking at the joy on her face, the last thing I want to do is burst my little sister's bubble. I can't remember the last time I saw her this happy – if I ever have.

'Just don't do anything stupid,' I say to her, pressing my lips tightly together.

'Like what?' she asks innocently.

My cheeks heat. 'Like … you know what. If he's as loyal and caring and unbothered about things as you say, then he'll have no issue waiting until there's a ring on your finger, will he?'

She scoffs. 'My Gods, you really are the sensible older sister, aren't you?'

'Kay …' Something about the way she avoids my gaze causes my pulse to hitch up another notch. 'Tell me you haven't. You haven't? Honestly.'

Again, she offers me another look of exasperation.

I've felt like a parent plenty of times in the last few years, but I've never felt like the parent of an eighteen-year-old quite as much as I do now.

'Just a little bit of fooling around, that's all. Nothing that would get me into trouble. And you can't tell me you're not doing the same. I've seen the way Jonas looks at you. He's smitten. So smitten, William reckons he might actually propose.'

'What?' I feel my jaw drop to the floor. That has to be a joke, right? Marriage? Me, married to Jonas? What could possibly be the advantage to Jonas and his family in his marrying me? Perhaps they anticipate that if I win this thing, it will strengthen their name, but then why would Jonas be in it if he didn't think he could win? I think of the way Estel sneered when she mentioned my father marrying for love. Artur would not wish for that same ridicule for Jonas. Besides, a marriage for love needs to be two-sided.

With a shake of my head I push the thoughts aside. I did not put myself in this competition to find a husband. Given the survival rate, it would've been a pretty shit mathematical probability to take a chance on.

'Oh, look who it is!' She's on her feet without a moment's hesitation, a wide grin on her face. I turn to see Hew striding towards us with Kyor at his side. As etiquette dictates, Kay stretches her hand out to the prince first.

'Acacia.' Kyor smiles softly. 'You look lovely.'

'Thank you,' she says, dipping ever so slightly into a formal curtsy.

'Rose.' His eyes lock on mine. No hint of a smile. Nothing but neutral formality. And yet it's still enough to make my pulse rocket. Still, I miss hearing 'Thorn' fall from his lips, and I hate the stiffness with which he holds himself apart from me.

'Rose!' Kay hisses, clearly expecting me to follow her lead and curtsy.

Though I thought often about bending my knees for Kyor, it wasn't for a damned curtsy.

'Miss Kultavaris.' Hew looks solely at Kay as he speaks. 'I believe you promised me all your dances tonight.' His voice is syrupy sweet.

'That seems somewhat selfish,' Kyor says. 'She probably wants to spend time with her sister. Besides, weren't you saying there was that woman from Dorain you were planning on having some fun with tonight?'

Hew crinkles his nose and scoffs. 'No, I was not. And your sense of humour is vile. Thankfully, Miss Kultavaris knows better of me than that.'

'Come on,' Kay says, holding out her hand. 'We can fit in one dance, and then I'll be in need of a glass of wine and a talk with my sister.'

Hew whisks her away without another word, leaving me alone with Kyor.

Silence rushes into the space between us. Heavy. Expectant.

‘Thank you,’ I say quietly to get it over with. ‘For allowing Caroline to attend tonight.’

He shrugs. ‘It was hardly a big deal. I just wrote her an invitation.’

‘Well, it meant a lot to Llin. And to me.’ Another pause takes hold and once again, I know there’s more I have to say. Finally, I coax the words out. ‘Thank you for not saying anything to them. To my friends. About … you know …’

‘I was never going to,’ he says just as quietly. ‘I promise you. No matter what changes between us, you have my word on that.’ He pauses and glances out across the ballroom. ‘Would you like to dance with me again, Miss Kultavaris?’

My body is desperate to respond yes, but it’s his use of my surname that slaps some sense into me.

‘Kyor, you’re the prince, the king’s heir. And I am from the family that was stripped of magic because they were blamed for your mother’s death.’

‘So that’s a no? You don’t want to dance?’ For the first time tonight, that twinkle has returned to his icy eyes.

‘What I want is irrelevant.’

‘Not to me it’s not.’

The urge to be close to him is unbearable. I tried to dismiss what is between us as nothing more than an attraction, but though I’ve been attracted to men before, it’s never felt like this. Like every cell in my body is screaming out to be touched by him. And from the hunger in his eyes, I’m not the only one who’s feeling it. Maybe if we got to finish what we started, it might offer a respite from this insanity. Maybe just one night would be enough to get it out of our systems.

The thought has barely formed when the moment is severed by Holden appearing beside us. ‘I hope you’re not neglecting your other guests in favour of the Rettlings, Prince Kyor. Or rather, one particular Rettling.’

I stiffen at his presence, feeling my hands clenching at my side.

‘Your father was asking me where you were,’ Holden continues. ‘As you well know, there’s a certain etiquette when it comes to these situations.’

‘You’ve come here and interrupted your prince in a private conversation to lecture *me* on etiquette?’ Kyor’s gaze is so withering I’m surprised there

aren’t sparks flying from it.

To give Holden his due, he only shrinks back a fraction.

‘Kyor,’ I say, placing a hand on his chest. I’m not sure why, other than it feels like the right thing to do. I feel the disapproval flare from Holden but ignore it. ‘Go, do your part. Perhaps the commander was hoping I might give him some fighting tips after the results of this morning’s spar.’

‘I will find you again soon,’ Kyor promises. ‘We need to talk.’ The slightest ghost of a smile rises on his lips before he turns and walks away, leaving me alone with Holden.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 54

It doesn't matter that Kyor's still in the same ballroom as me; I feel his absence like a cold draught. How is it possible that I have such a need for this man?

I'm also painfully aware of Holden lingering beside me like an insidious black rot.

'Well, Miss Kultavaris,' he drawls, 'you've managed to prove a few of us wrong in doubting your abilities.'

'Really?' I arch a brow. 'There were doubters? I must've missed the part where their opinions mattered.'

Holden is the epitome of everything I hate about courtly life, with his feints and stabs dressed up as conversation.

His lips curl, not into a smile, but a sneer sharpened by old jealousy.

'The trials only get harder, you know. Just because you've made it this far, it doesn't mean you'll make it to the end. And even if you do, Etta only chooses one for the gifting.'

'Oh, thank you for the lecture,' I purr. 'I never would've guessed the trials were *meant* to be difficult. Next you'll be telling me fire is hot.'

Am I being reckless? Possibly. But I don't care. Not even Holden would be stupid enough to try something at a ball. His gaze shifts across the room as he stands uncomfortably close, and I know exactly who he's looking at before he even starts to speak.

'You should know that the prince will tire of you soon enough. It is what he does. You are a new challenge. A big one, admittedly, with all that unfortunate shared history.' He twists back to me, his sneer back in place. 'It must run in your family – coveting things you shouldn't. Though I can

assure you that while your father may have undeservedly gained his title, you will not get the prince. No, in the end he will marry for strategy. For power. For allegiances. He will never marry, or even love, someone as powerless as you. You are a notch in his bedpost, nothing more. Enjoy it while you can, because when he discards you – as he inevitably will – you will resume your place in the slums with nothing more than your memories to keep you warm.'

I don't want his words to cut. I don't want to feel the sting of them beneath my ribs. But I do. Because they are true. It's not love, whatever this is between Kyor and me. I'm not stupid enough to contemplate that word. But it *is* something. Something undefinable and raw and everything I need right now.

'So lovely to hear you think I'll survive the Ofur.' I smile before letting the expression drop, one of utter boredom sweeping over my face. 'What is it you want, Holden? Or are you just here to tell me things I already know?'

His smile flashes broad and almost casual. 'Oh, no. I've said all I wanted to say. Except, perhaps, congratulations on your continued survival, against all odds.' He nods to a waiter carrying a tray of wine glasses and the servant immediately scuttles over. Holden takes two glasses and hands one to me. 'To the fourth trial.' He clinks his glass against mine. 'May you forever hold Etta's favour, or may you meet Mortidem in eternal darkness, reuniting with all those who await you there.'

'How touching,' I say, swirling the wine. 'A toast that manages to be both a blessing and a death threat. You must be the life and soul of every party.'

Llinos and Caroline approach, hand in hand.

'Rose, there you are,' Llinos greets me loudly. 'We were looking for you.' A flood of relief rushes through me, as – utterly ignoring Holden – the two women sweep me away in a babble of words. 'Where's Kay? I was going to introduce Caroline to her. And Kyor, too. We need to thank him.'

I refuse to look back but can feel Holden's gaze boring into my back.

Once we're far enough away, Llin lowers her voice and leans in close. 'What was that about?'

'The usual,' I reply, then murmur, 'He's realised that there's something between Kyor and me, and he's not too happy about it.'

As if his name alone is a magnet, my eyes are drawn to the prince. Goddess help me.

‘Well, we don’t have to think about Holden now.’ Llin shifts my attention back to her. ‘Kyor, on the other hand … have you already spoken to him tonight? You have to tell me everything. Although, wait, I need a drink first. Like you said, I have to make up for last time.’

‘You don’t have to make up that much,’ Caroline warns. ‘I don’t want to carry you to bed.’ She looks around the ball, a small smile pulling at her lips. ‘Then again, there are a couple of men and women whose help with the task I’d be perfectly willing to accept.’

‘Hey!’ Llin pouts playfully. ‘You’re meant to have eyes only for me, right?’

Caroline’s grin wavers. ‘My lips and my body are definitely all yours … but my eyes are allowed a little wander now and then, aren’t they?’

‘This is why I need a drink.’ Llinos laughs, planting a kiss on Caroline’s lips.

I look around, but the waiter who served Holden and me only moments ago has disappeared.

‘Here, take mine,’ I say, handing Llinos my glass. ‘I’m not that thirsty.’

‘Are you sure?’

‘I’ll find another in a minute,’ I say, my chest tightening. It’s so damned hot in here, so hard to breathe. ‘I need some air.’

‘Really?’

I ignore Llin’s question. ‘I’ll just be a minute.’

I don’t know where I’m going, only that I need to get away from all the noise and the false smiles of nobles that would happily shove a dagger into my back rather than have a slum rat win this thing.

I push my way out of the cloying ballroom, and the moment I’m on my own, I can feel him watching me.

There are several hallways that lead off the ballroom. When I glance down the first one, it’s occupied, so I move to the next. There are doors on either side, though what type of rooms they lead to is anyone’s guess. I move to press my ear against one to hear if it’s empty, but before my hand has even touched the door handle, another hand has pushed it open and shoved me through it.

‘You shouldn’t wander off at these events,’ he growls. ‘There are people who would happily do unspeakable things to you.’

My pulse rockets and yearning spreads through my body at the sound of Kyor’s voice, though my attention remains on the room as I realise we’re in

what seems to be a library of some sort. There are books, armchairs, and not another soul in sight.

‘There could have been someone in here,’ I say as I turn around to face him.

‘Then I would have ordered them to leave.’ He says the words so matter-of-factly, as if his pulse isn’t racing too. But I can see it in his eyes, the way his pupils have grown so wide that only a sliver of that icy blue remains.

He places his hands on my hips, their simple presence enough to make my body shudder. He doesn’t move them. Nor does he send those delicious sparks cascading across my skin, providing the rush I so desperately desire.

And he won’t. I know he won’t. Not until I’ve said those words.

My throat is dry, desperate for the taste of him again. Desperate for his mouth against mine. I know what I have to do, to say, but my breath is coming so fast I struggle to think straight. He’s looking at me as though he would devour me, ruin me, if I gave him even half a chance. And he will. Because I’m done fighting it.

‘I trust you,’ I whisper, wishing I could control the breathiness in my voice. And it’s true. How can I not? He saved my *life*, and he’s kept my secret. A secret that would see me dead without question. This man before me isn’t the same boy whose lies destroyed my family. He’s a man who has had to live with the guilt of those actions. Who bears the weight of every death he sees. A man who wishes to atone.

I do trust him and it shocks the very foundation of my worldview. I lick my lips and look at him, begging him to believe me. ‘I do trust you, Kyor.’

‘About damn time,’ he rasps. Then his mouth is on mine and his hand is moving from the safety of my hips up towards my chest. ‘I was going insane watching you in that dress, Thorn. Not being able to get my hands on you.’ He growls the words into my neck, the heat of his breath causing my own temperature to skyrocket. As his teeth graze along the tender skin of my shoulder blade, he simultaneously slides one of his hands in through the side of my dress to graze against the hard peaks of my nipples, while the other slips into the slit, eliciting a deep moan from somewhere at the very depth of my being.

‘That’s it, Thorn. That’s what I need to hear.’

For a moment he stays as he is, one hand toying with my nipples, the other moving towards my inner thighs, but then, without warning, he

replaces his hand on my breast with his static hum. As I gasp at the sensation, his free hand claws into my hair and he pulls my mouth back against his. The taste of wine is faint in comparison to the tang of vanilla on his lips, and I want it all. And from the way his tongue plunders my mouth, the feeling is mutual.

My back arches off the wall, pressing me against him. He's rock hard. I can feel it. And the thinness of my dress makes it feel so close that it's agonising.

'Gods, you will never stop distracting me,' he groans. 'Never stop distracting me.' Is he begging or ordering? I don't know, but at this point I'll accept either.

The need to feel him in me is even more intense than it was in his room, and I move to unbutton his trousers. As much as I want to make this last, I also have no desire to get caught screwing the prince. Anyone could walk in on us, and the danger of it all adds an extra frisson to my already wild excitement.

I shouldn't be doing this, not with him. Especially not when we're so close to the end of the Retterheld. This is the point I should be breaking *away* from people, not making closer ties. But I can't stop myself.

'Wait here,' he orders and for a split second I fear he's going to walk away and leave me in this state, but instead he stops at a large ottoman. He grabs the underside with one hand, hoicks it up, and drags it over to me. I'm sure it would have been easier just to ask me to move, but I'm grateful he didn't. I'm not sure my legs even work right now. Assuming he wants me to lie down, I turn my back towards it, but he stops me, placing a hand on my shoulder.

'Not yet,' he growls as he wraps his hands around my thighs. The slit of my dress falls open, revealing the height of my boots and the soaked cotton of my underwear.

'Fuck.' He groans. 'You're so wet for me, Thorn. You know this is the point of no return, right? You need to tell me now if you want me to stop.'

'Don't you dare,' I hiss back.

A dark chuckle resonates in his throat as he lifts my left leg so that my foot is planted on the ottoman two feet off the ground, and then he slides his fingers under the fabric of my underwear. He begins to circle my clit with a touch so light I can't help it when another moan escapes my lips. I grind my hips down onto his fingers, silently urging him to apply firmer pressure.

‘That’s it, Thorn. Keep showing me what you like.’

I bite down on my bottom lip, wishing I could show some sort of restraint, but I can’t. My hips continue to rock back and forth in a wild, needy rhythm I’m desperate for him to replicate as he increases the pressure. My head falls back, and when my eyes slide closed, he slides a finger into me, pulling a thick moan from my throat.

‘So wet, so tight. So fucking tight, Thorn.’

The way he purrs at me is enough to have my walls clenching, and the curling motion of his fingers inside me is more than enough to make the heat rise in my stomach.

‘Oh Gods,’ I pant. ‘I’m going to come.’

He smirks that delicious smirk I’ve come to adore. ‘That’s it. Good girl, Thorn. Come for me.’

And I do. Hard and fast, the contractions sending me higher and higher. But rather than bring release, they bring an even greater desperation.

I need to feel him inside of me. All of him.

I look at him with heavily lidded eyes. ‘Take me. Fuck me quickly. Someone might come in.’

He ignores my request, adding a second finger to the plundering of my silken depths. ‘Not yet. I’ve waited so long, I won’t be hurried.’

How have I never felt anything close to this? How did I ever think I enjoyed sex when *this* damn near ecstasy exists?

My desire is interlaced with desperation for him. And though it’s hard to focus on anything but the way his fingers are brushing my inside wall with scary expertise, I fumble with his buttons, loosening his trousers enough that I can get my hand inside. He groans, control fraying as I encircle his cock with my hand. The sound is enough to have me gasping.

I can already feel the dampness that’s built up at his head and my tongue yearns to reach down and taste it, but instead, I run my fingers over him before clenching his girth in my hand. I stifle a moan. My fingers don’t come close to making it all the way around. Still, I pull my palm down in a long stroke, trying to take in as much of it as I can.

His groan is feral and he tightens my grip on his cock with his own hand. ‘This is yours, Thorn. All of it. Fucking own it.’

His words make me dizzy, the frenzy of need reaching an entirely new height.

He stifles his next moan by biting down on my shoulder so hard I'm sure he's going to leave a mark.

'Don't be quiet,' I whisper sultrily in his ear. 'How else am I going to learn what you like?'

His eyes meet mine as a smirk spreads across his face. 'Oh, that's how you want to play it, is it?'

With a thrust of his arm, his fingers push even deeper into me, and he moves his other hand from where it was holding the back of my neck and places his palm flat against my abdomen. The static is instant both inside and outside my body, sparking on every millimetre of my clit, while inside my walls start to clench, tightening in on his fingers.

The entire room is lost to me. Everything is lost to me. All I can feel are the places where our skin touches. My hand on his cock. His fingers in me. Our mouths and tongues in uncontrollable chaos.

'I'm close,' I whisper, desperate for him to fill me before I come. 'I want you inside of me. I'm so close, Kyor.' His name comes out as a breathy moan.

'Not yet. Come for me again. Let go for me. I've got you.'

A scream threatens to leave my lungs, but though we each enjoy hearing the other moan, I'm aware enough to know that we can't risk getting caught.

Any second now I'm going to break. I'm going to let loose and unravel, shattering into a million pieces, and I doubt I'll ever be put back the same. I try to focus on him, desperately trying to keep a consistent rhythm up and down his length, in the hope of hearing that guttural groan rise from his throat again. But I can barely focus.

My head rolls back and the waves rush through my body, one, then another, and another. I bite down on the inside of my cheek. Next time I'll scream for him. Next time. Because this can't be it. It can't be. My legs quake and all their strength evaporates as he holds up my entire body. Finally, when the last tremor subsides, I look at him.

He's looking at me in wonder. Tenderly. 'I don't know how I thought I could ever fight this.' His eyes are locked on me as he brushes a strand of my hair from where it's fallen over my forehead. 'That was incredible.'

'Was?' I raise my eyebrow. 'Oh, we're not done. Not by half. It's your turn now.'

I go to kneel, but he holds me up and shakes his head.

‘Not like that. Not on your knees for me. Not ever.’

Instead, he sits back with his legs over the edge of the ottoman. It’s the first time I’ve seen the full length of his cock exposed like this, and the urge to drop down on my knees and take it in my mouth is overwhelming. But if that’s not the way he wants it, then I’m going to have to get creative. Fighting the desire to just slide his length all the way into me, I place my hand on his chest and push him down so that he’s lying on his back. Yet as my fingers reach for his cock, I stop.

‘Did you hear that?’ I ask, frowning.

A line of confusion forms on his forehead. He sits up. ‘Is someone coming? Because I already told you—’

‘No, it sounded like a—’

This time it’s clear. A scream rips through the doors. And not the kind I just spent the last thirty minutes suppressing.

The memories of another bloody ball arise in both of our heads, and soundlessly we hastily stand and start tucking ourselves away.

Another scream tears through the quiet, and I freeze as I recognise the voice.

‘Llinos! The Gods help us! Llinos!’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 55

I'm still pulling up the sides of my dress as I race out of the room and back into the ballroom, where the music has stopped and people are edging close to the walls, as if it's another rebel attack. Only there's no flame-throwing and no screaming other than from a small cluster of people gathered on the edge of the dance floor. My people. Benny, Jonas, and Caroline.

'Help me!' Caz's voice resonates around the cavernous space. 'Please! Someone help me!'

'What's happening?' I cast my question into the air, not caring who answers as long as someone does.

Benny is on the ground with Llin. Her skin is a sallow yellow tone, with bile-green foam bubbling at her lips as she struggles to speak through her coughs.

'What's happening?' I ask again.

'I don't know. I don't know!' Benny clutches his head. 'They were dancing. They were just dancing! Then Caz was yelling and … I don't know. What's happening to her?'

'She just started coughing. She couldn't stop. We need a healer. We need a healer. Where is a fucking healer?' As Caroline screams her demand, a woman in a sapphire gown pushes past me to place her hands above Llin's chest. A healer.

'Give her some space,' Jonas says, but none of us move. I can't take my eyes off Llin as she struggles to speak. The part of her lips that's visible beneath the foam seems to have taken on a bluish hue, as if there's no air reaching her lungs. Fear writhes through me.

I kneel next to her. ‘It’s okay, Llinos. It’s okay.’ My voice quivers and tears begin to fall down my cheeks. ‘Just breathe, okay? You don’t need to speak. Just breathe, honey.’

‘Can’t,’ Llin says, a cough wracking her. ‘Can’t breathe.’

The healer’s hands are glowing with a deep amber light, but the frown lines on her forehead only deepen. It’s not working.

‘What did she drink?’ the healer asks.

As Caroline struggles to draw breath, let alone reply, a hollowness spreads through me. There’s only one reason why the healer would ask that question.

‘She’s been poisoned?’ I ask tightly, but the question is rhetorical. I already know the answer. ‘She’s been poisoned.’

Llinos meets my eyes, and I see the resignation there, the acceptance. And it slays me.

‘Help her!’ I bark at the healer.

The foam at Llin’s mouth is no longer green. It has taken on a pinkish hue. Blood is filling her lungs, but the healer has moved her hands away from her chest. As she starts to stand, I grab hold of her.

‘Please. There must be something you can do.’

She shakes her head, eyes sympathetic. ‘It’s in her system. If it was just in her stomach, maybe … but no, I’m sorry. It’s too late. It’s just too late.’

My whole body trembles as I stumble back.

‘No. No, she can’t. It can’t be. You have to do something. You have to.’

The healer presses her lips together but moves her hands back to Llinos’s chest. They pulse with magic for just a moment before she takes them away, visibly tired. ‘I’ve eased her pain and her breathing as best I can. It’ll give you a few moments to say goodbye.’

‘Rose …’ Llinos’s voice is barely a breath, yet it burns through my entire body, causing more tears to stream down my cheeks. ‘It’s okay. It’s … okay.’

‘No. No.’ I drop down next to Llin and wipe my hand across her brow. It’s nearly impossible to see through the blur of tears filling my eyes.

‘You or Benny better win.’ She tries to smile, only for a drop of blood to slip from the corner of her lips. With the slightest movement of her eyes, she looks from me to Caroline, and her smile is true. ‘We found each other again. I knew we would.’

‘Stop speaking like that.’ Caroline’s voice is firm, even as it trembles. ‘You’re okay, okay?’

‘You’re a terrible liar.’ Llin’s smile widens. ‘I love that about you. I love everything about you. I always will.’

‘Stop it. I’m not losing you now.’ Caroline gulps in air between her sobs. ‘Not when we just found each other again. I refuse to lose you, Llin. You hear me? I refuse to. So you’d better sort this out, because I don’t care how tough you think you are, I’m gonna kick your arse if you don’t stop this and get up now. You hear me? You need to get up.’ She tugs at Llinos’s still form, and her voice breaks as she sobs while shudders wrack her body.

‘Llinos! You need to be okay. Get up! Llin!’ Caroline screams, but even as she buries her head in Llin’s chest, my friend’s expression remains fixed. Her smile unchanged. Unmoving. Not even a tremor. Not even a breath.

Kyor’s voice is low. ‘We need to move her somewhere private. You don’t want to do this here. Trust me.’

He’s standing right behind me. I didn’t even realise he’d followed me.

‘Do something.’ Tears stream down my cheeks as I turn to him. ‘Do something. You have magic. You have healers. Do something!’

‘You know I can’t.’ His voice is hollow with pain. ‘We both know that all too well. She’s gone, Rose. I’m so sorry.’

He folds me into his arms in a much too public show of support, and I don’t have the strength to refuse him.

I don’t understand. When I left them, they were laughing. Ready to dance.

The healer’s earlier question resurfaces in my mind. *What did she drink?*

The wine. I feel sick. I push myself away from Kyor and turn to Caroline. ‘What did Llin drink? Caroline! You need to answer me! Did Llin drink the wine in the glass I gave her?’

Tears stream down her cheeks, and her skin is so pale it’s translucent. When she lifts her head, her eyes are glazed, nothing but hollow pain behind them. ‘She was just drinking wine,’ she says. ‘Just … wine.’

‘The glass I gave her? She drank that too?’

‘I … I … I think so.’

The deathly cold that filled my veins is replaced with an insatiable heat, and a roar in my ears sounds so loud it drowns out all else.

‘He gave me the wine,’ I seethe. ‘That bastard gave me the wine.’ I turn back to Kyor. ‘Holden. He got me the drink, but I gave my glass to Llin. Oh Gods. I gave Llin my glass, and she drank it instead of me.’ I can barely breathe.

Benny is sobbing on the ground as he tries to comfort Caroline. Jonas stands above them, looking lost. And hundreds of guests stare at us.

But there’s only one I’m looking for.

‘Where the fuck is Holden?’ I snarl.

‘Rose?’ It’s Jonas who speaks. ‘What is it? What’s wrong?’

‘Holden. Where the fuck is that prick?’ My gaze rakes across the room. There’s no sign of him.

‘He was here a moment ago,’ Jonas says. ‘He asked me if I’d seen you.’

I bet he did, the son of a bitch. I run for the door.

‘Rose!’ Jonas calls after me. ‘Rose, think about what you’re going to do here!’

‘Fuck that,’ Kyor replies for me. ‘She doesn’t need to think. She needs to *do.*’

I feel them both, shadows racing behind me as I tear out onto the grounds and spot Holden in the distance, moving quickly, ready to slip through the gate into one of the other arcs. If he gets through there, I’ll lose him, because the rules of the Retterheld forbid me to leave our arc unless it’s to attend a trial. Maybe that’s what he wants, though – for me to be disqualified. Blood rushes in my veins and I push myself to breaking point to reach him before he escapes, but he’s too far ahead.

But then, when he’s only a foot away from the gate, a bolt of lightning blasts the wood and the entire thing goes up in flames. Holden leaps back, and when he turns to see us bearing down on him, he freezes.

I turn to Kyor.

‘He’s all yours,’ he tells me with a nod.

I draw to a stop facing Holden, my breathing heavy. I expected him to run away from us or prepare to fight, but instead he just stands there, his jaw locked and his muscles twitching unnaturally, as if some static force is holding him firmly in place. Kyor has him. Fuck, what terrifying powers that man has. Good thing I’m no longer afraid of him. No longer afraid of anything. He and Zelle have trained me for this moment, and I won’t let either of them down.

My heart pounds against my ribs as I take a step towards the aged commander. My footsteps are steady and my resolve unwavering. I have no weapons on me, but Holden's ceremonial sword is still there, sheathed at his side. When I reach him, I place my hand on the hilt and withdraw the sword. His lip spasms as if desperate to curl up in a snarl.

'You murdered her.' My voice is low, a thunderous rumble that barely even sounds like me. 'You murdered Llinos.'

'That's on you, not me,' he spits, forcing the words out through his gritted teeth. 'You're a Gods-forsaken cockroach, slum rat. If you had only known your place—'

'Her place?' Kyor's voice is a growl beside me as sparks of pure energy surge between his fingers. I have never seen him like this before. So powerful. So dangerous. 'Her place, Holden, is wherever the fuck she decides it is.'

I appreciate the support, but this moment is mine, not Kyor's. 'You said he was all mine, remember?'

His eyes meet mine, and he nods, his hands dropping as I raise the pilfered sword.

'Rose, stop!' Jonas's voice cuts through the silence. 'Don't do this! You are not a killer. You don't want to do this.'

I want to laugh. Even now Jonas underestimates me. Or maybe that's not it. Maybe he just doesn't know who I am. I can't help but scoff as I look him in the eye.

'I'm the one who stabbed the jötunn, Jonas. I killed Oke. I'm not the little girl you remember, and it's time you realised that.' I turn to Kyor. 'Release him.'

He doesn't argue, doesn't try to change my mind; he just does as I bid. In a flash, Holden is free, and the old man wastes no time as he lunges towards me. He knows, just like I do, that only one of us will come out of this alive. And he may have superior strength and experience, but I have a wealth of fucking *rage*.

He barrels into me like a bull, all fury and bulk. The force of the impact causes the hilt of the sword to slide from my grip. I allow it to drop and the momentum to carry us both to the ground. His fists are like iron, one smashing into my jaw, the other into my ribs, but the pain helps me focus. And I know I'll give it back twice as hard and more.

With the power of my whole body I swing my fist into him and my knuckles crack against his cheekbone. The taste of blood fills my mouth, but whether it's his or mine, I don't care. We'll both be bloody messes at the end of it, but I'll be the one who walks away.

Recovered from the strike, Holden tries to pin me, but I'm lighter and faster. Just like Zelle taught me, I twist and kick, driving my knee into his gut until he grunts like the beast he is.

'You're slow, old man,' I snarl, ramming my forehead into his nose. The crunch is exquisite.

'You fucking bitch!' he roars, grabbing a fistful of my hair and slamming me towards the dirt. Stars explode in my vision, but I push on, raking my nails across his face, then driving my elbow into his throat. As he coughs and wheezes, I scramble on top of him, hammering endless blows into his skull. Each strike drives him further into the ground. He is nothing to me, nothing but a bully someone should have put down years ago.

'I may be a cockroach,' I hiss through gritted teeth as I punch again and again. 'But you're no more than a tick, a foul creature that spreads disease and ruin wherever it goes. No more.'

His grip weakens and I see the flicker of doubt in his eyes before I wrench free, staggering to my feet. The gate looms just behind him, its stone frame littered with broken rocks. My hand closes around one – heavy, jagged, perfect. I have him pinned to the ground. All it will take is a couple of strikes and he'll be done.

As my weight holds him down, his eyes meet mine. There is no belittlement in them now. No snide condescension or malice. There's nothing but fear. Fear that this is his end.

Is it? I look at my hand as though surprised to find the rock in my grasp. Can I do it? Can I take a life for a life? I want to. Gods know, for Llin I want to. And yet … I lower my hand. I am better than this. Better than him.

'You need to leave here,' I say, the rock still in my palm as I stand and allow him to wriggle free. 'If I see you again, I will kill you.'

'Yes … yes …' he mutters, shuffling backward on the ground. 'Of course.'

Adrenaline continues to surge through my veins. My hands are trembling. Hands that nearly killed a man in vengeance. Unable to lay my eyes on the snivelling Holden for a second longer, I turn back to look at my friends, only for Jonas to cry out, 'Rose! Watch out!'

I spin back to find Holden on his knees, the sword in his hand with the hilt pressed against his stomach, ready to thrust it up and out into me. There is no time to think.

I let the jagged rock fly free from my hand, hurling it straight towards his head.

The crack of the rock against his skull resonates through the air and his eyes momentarily widen before a thick trickle of blood weaves its way down his face. A moment later, he falls to the ground. Dead. I killed him.

I wanted to show mercy, to be better than him, but he took that path from me. He gave me no choice.

'Rose? Oh Gods. Rose, what have you done?'

The voice, full of horror and disbelief, is like a vice around my chest. I turn to face her. To face the pain of her condemnation. And yet … it is just a flicker. There is already too much hurt within me for it to even properly register.

'What have you done?' my sister whispers again as she stares at me. Her eyes are the same green as my own, and yet they look as though they are staring at a stranger.

I twist back to look at Holden. See the blood pooling on the ground beneath him.

'Delivered justice,' I reply, my throat tight.

'Kultavaris did so at my command,' Kyor announces loudly. 'Holden was a traitor who wilfully killed one of Etta's blessed Rettlings. He is with Mortidem now. May his judgement be swift.'

As Kay drops her hands to her knees and folds in half, Jonas hurries to her side. 'Don't look, Acacia. You don't need to see this.' He puts his arm around her and wordlessly leads her away, and she lets him without even looking back.

My sister is horrified at me, *by* me. Did she think I was surviving the Retterheld by pressing flowers and practising needlepoint?

I straighten my shoulders. Everything I do, I do for my sister. But this? This I did for Llinos.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 56

I don't think about the blood on my gown or the grazes on my skin as Kyor and I return to the ballroom to retrieve Llin's body. I'm sickened, but unsurprised, to find the party is back in full swing. Korvane and his sycophants continue to drink and laugh while music floats through the air, as if one of the kindest people I've ever met hasn't just returned her powers to Mortidem.

Three balls. Two deaths. Two people lost that I respected and cared for greatly. These soirees are proving as deadly as the trials themselves.

My gaze sweeps the room, and I find that Benny has carried Llinos over to a corner and placed her down on a couch with her head resting on Caroline's lap. Neither of them look up at us as we approach.

'Benny, I'm so sorry. I'm so sorry.'

'Is he dead?' Benny asks, still focused on Llin.

'Very,' I reply.

He closes his eyes and lets out a shuddering breath. 'Then that'll have to do.' A moment later, he finally shifts his gaze from Llinos and looks at Kyor instead. 'On the island, we burn our people at sea,' he says. 'Is that something you can make happen here? I know she was a Rettling but—'

'This wasn't a Retterheld death,' Kyor interrupts. 'She was a noble of the Eastern Isles and deserves a proper burial. I will see to it now.'

As Kyor leaves, I try to think of something to say to Caroline. She mutters quietly as her tears fall in an endless torrent.

'I should have found you sooner, my love,' she whispers as she strokes Llin's tresses. 'I should have found you the moment this all began, but I was a coward.'

‘You found each other,’ I say, not even sure if she can hear me. ‘You found each other and found your second chance. That’s what matters.’

Caroline doesn’t even glance at me as she continues to comb her fingers through Llinos’s hair.

This wasn’t the way this night was supposed to end. Llinos wanted to stay in the dorm. She didn’t want to even come. If she hadn’t … if Kyor hadn’t fixed it so Caroline could come … Llin would still be alive. If I hadn’t passed the glass to her, Llin would still be alive, and I would likely be dead.

Jonas and Kay are standing off to one side of the room with Hew and William. For a second, I consider going to her. Explaining myself. Telling her that this is what court life really is. Backstabbing and heartbreak and petty personal vendettas stretching through generations.

The only reason Holden wanted me dead was because of the absurd jealousy he had towards my father. This night should be a lesson for us both.

But I can’t tell her that. I can’t even face her. She deserves to cling to her naïveté for as long as she can.

So instead, I turn back to Benny. I can’t imagine the pain that fills him. Of the six Rettlings who arrived from the Eastern Isles, he is the only one who remains.

‘What can I do? What do you need?’ I ask him.

He shakes his head. ‘I’m not sure I even know anymore. She was so mad at me. I thought I’d have time, you know, to put it right.’

‘You did, Benny.’ I place my hand on his shoulder. ‘You know you did. I saw you two. Whatever happened between you, she was moving past it. I’m sure of it.’

He scoffs. ‘I guess we’ll never know.’

My heart throbs. How many times can it get broken and keep beating? How much suffering can one person endure before a heart simply decides it can no longer keep going? I don’t have the answer, but right now I feel closer to that moment of defeat than ever before.

Kay approaches in a similar manner to the way I approached the dire wolf in Afaven Forest. ‘Rose, I’m going to head back home now,’ she says, still visibly trembling. ‘William and Hew are going to walk me.’

I nod dully, a tiny sting piercing my heart that she isn’t willing to stay for me. ‘Goodnight.’

‘Goodnight, Rose.’ She pauses before pressing her lips together and glancing at Jonas. ‘Think over what I said about Jonas. You could make a far worse match than a Lorathin.’

It’s hard not to laugh. I’m mourning the death of one of my closest friends, and Kay is thinking about matchmaking me.

Kay turns away, not even bothering to wish me luck with the next trial or tell me to stay alive. Maybe it’s too hard for her to think of it like that, to face how deadly this all is. Or maybe, like Holden, she also thinks I’m a cockroach who is destined to fall right back into the gutter I came from.

The ball carries on around us, with music and dancing and people skirting around our little group, but we remain in silence until Kyor returns.

‘I have permission from the High Priestess for us to leave the Rettling grounds, and I have two carriages ready. One to take us to the water,’ he says, ‘and the other full of wood to build a raft. That’s right, isn’t it?’

Benny nods.

‘Then we should leave now.’

No one speaks on the carriage ride to the sea. Llin is cradled by Caroline on one seat, with Benny next to her, while Jonas, Kyor, and I cram together on the other.

I am in shock, I realise. My limbs feel weak, detached almost, and I can’t stop trembling. Can’t stop seeing the moment of Llin’s death, her smile fixed forever. You’d think, as a healer’s daughter and then an orphan – and a slum rat – I’d be used to death, but it’s different when it’s a friend. Someone you love. Maybe not loving is the answer.

No one speaks, but at some point the air turns cool and salty as the sound of the gentle lapping of waves drifts into the carriage. I only wish the waves could wash away the memories I can’t stop from flooding through my mind.

As the carriage draws to a halt, the men and I climb out. Caroline stays with Llin, still stroking her hair, and she begins to hum softly, like she would to comfort a small child. My eyes sting and my chest is tight, but I help Kyor and Jonas carry wood from the second carriage to where Benny is lashing each board together expertly. This clearly isn’t the first funereal raft he’s built.

It gives me purpose and a much-needed distraction to do something, to help in some small way, and I move methodically, lifting one plank, then

another. I don’t stop – I can’t stop – because if I do, the absence of motion will allow the thoughts to creep in, and the pain will follow.

On the occasions I do look up, I find Kyor or Jonas staring at me, concern etched across their features. But they keep their distance.

‘It’s ready,’ Benny says gently to Caroline, when the raft is finally built. ‘Let me carry her for you,’ he offers.

Caroline nods dully and he sweeps Llin’s frame up into his arms like she weighs nothing.

Wordlessly, Benny carries Llin down to the water and lays her down on the wooden raft before stepping back and allowing Caroline a few last private moments with the love of her life.

‘It’s time,’ he says a minute later, pressing his hand against the small of her back. ‘It’s time.’

Still trying to stifle her shuddering breaths, Caroline moves to one side of the raft while Benny takes his place on the other. Together, they push the raft out, wading into the soft waves of the sea, which break and foam around their calves, the green ballgown swirling around Caroline. Before they get too deep, Kyor hands them each a burning torch and then returns to my side.

I don’t want to watch. I don’t want to see Llin’s body, which only hours ago was so full of hope and laughter and life, be turned into nothing more than ash and memories. But I won’t draw my eyes away. Watching on and honouring her passage is the least Llinos deserves.

The water is halfway up their thighs when, as one, Benny and Caroline lower their torches. The flames catch slowly at first, licking around Llin’s body until they rise up, higher and higher. Before they have consumed her entirely, Benny and Caroline offer the raft one final push, and the current of the sea takes her, slowly drawing Llinos away from the shore.

Kyor’s hand slips into mine, his fingers intertwining with my own, as we stand there watching the flames float into the distance, carrying with them the most loyal friend I have ever known.

‘I didn’t know how to pronounce her name the first time we met,’ I whisper. ‘I didn’t know how to pronounce it, and now I’m never going to say it to her again.’

As we watch Benny and Caroline return to the shore, dripping with water and tears, I know that Kyor won’t bother to offer me some trite words of comfort. Like me, he has already suffered too much in his life, and he

knows there is nothing he can say. But the truth is that he doesn't need to say anything. Right now, his presence is enough.



BY THE TIME we arrive back at the High Hold, it can only be a few hours until breakfast. I don't know where Caroline goes or where she lives when she isn't with us or scribing in the library, but I don't offer to go with her, knowing she needs to be alone. So I simply hug her tightly before she disappears. Looking weary beyond tiredness, heartsore, and exhausted, Benny trudges upstairs to our dorm. And Jonas doesn't even look back as he climbs the steps to his room.

I don't hesitate when Kyor tugs my hand. I follow him down the stairs towards the kitchens and into his bedroom. He steps inside and closes the door behind me.

As he slips off his jacket, I reach up onto my tiptoes and press my mouth to his. Yet my tongue has barely savoured a hint of his vanilla taste when he breaks away. Pulls away from me.

I frown. 'I trust you,' I say impatiently. 'I trust you with my life. That's what you needed to hear, right? Well, there you go. Now you know. I trust you and I want you.' I move to kiss him again, but rather than reciprocating my action, he cups my cheeks and draws my face away from him.

'I believe you,' he replies softly, 'but you're forgetting the only rule of this relationship.'

Another day, another moment, and my mind would have spun at the word. Now, my mind is strangely numb. I shake my head. 'What rule?' I say. 'There are no rules.'

'Not as a distraction. That's the one you gave me, remember? Not as a distraction.'

I open my mouth, desperate to object, to say that's not the reason I want him, that it's more than desire. It's a need, a yearning, an absolute desperation.

The pain of his rejection burns through me. A pain that quickly shifts into anger.

'You're choosing *now* to be a gentleman? Seriously? When I actually need you to fuck me, that's when you find some morals?'

A muscle twitches along his jaw. ‘I was a kid, Thorn—’

‘I’m not talking about my family. I’m talking about Estel’s sister.’ Even as the words leave my lips, I’m not sure why I’m bringing this up. What am I hoping to achieve? I know that causing other people hurt does nothing to minimise my own. And yet I can’t stop myself.

‘Estel’s sister, Thea?’

‘Yeah, the one you got pregnant, although you denied it was yours. The one who was stripped like my family was stripped. Sound familiar?’

‘Rose—’

‘What? You want me to trust you, but you don’t want me to know anything about you. Is that it?’

That muscle ticks again. ‘I don’t know what you’ve heard …’

I scoff. My voice is so bitter I barely recognise it. ‘I told you exactly what I heard. You knew what would happen to her, and you still denied the kid was yours.’

‘Because I wasn’t the father!’ It’s the first time he’s raised his voice, and it’s exactly what I need. I don’t care how much I want whatever this is between us; all I know right now is that he’s the only person in this arc with the power to truly hurt me, and I need him to do that. I need him to do that because I deserve it. I’m the reason Llinos is dead. I deserve to suffer. And I know Kyor’s never one to back away from a fight. Yet rather than continuing to battle with me, he lets out a sigh.

‘I knew Thea. Just like I knew Estel. Through balls, through parties, through growing up in the High Hold. But I didn’t get her pregnant. I don’t think I even fucked her.’

‘You don’t *think*? Wow, Kyor, there’s so many you can’t even recall the names of all the women you’ve bedded? What a gentleman.’

‘That’s not what I meant.’ He rubs his temples as he walks the short distance over to his desk and pulls out the chair, though he doesn’t sit down.

My irritation rises. I need him to either fuck me or tell me to fuck off, and I’ll push him as hard as I have to, to make sure one of those things happens.

‘When I was made commander and first went out to fight, I would get pretty messed up. Drinks, other stuff … whatever the hell I could find. I just wanted to forget what I saw … the blood, the death. So yeah, I screwed around then. And I don’t remember a lot of it. Am I proud of it? No, but it was years before Thea was stripped of her powers.’ He moves away from

the chair and steps towards me, taking my hands. ‘Look, I get you’re in pain right now. And I know what it’s like to be in pain and want to lash out, so we can go outside and we can beat the shit out of each other if that’s what you want. Or I can find us something that will get us blind drunk so you can try to forget the fucking nightmare that you’ve just been through, though I’m going to tell you from experience that it’ll just come back and bite you even fucking harder.’ He sighs. ‘I will do whatever you ask of me, except sleep with you. Not now. Not like this. I don’t want you to regret our first time together.’

‘You don’t know what I’ll feel.’

‘No, but I can take a guess.’ He moves his hands to my waist. I want it to be the same as before – full static sparks that make us rip each other’s clothes off without a second thought – and there’s definitely something there, but it’s different. Deeper. I need him. I need him so fully it hurts.

‘If you wanna keep saying things to try to hurt me, Thorn, then you do that. I can take it. I can take anything apart from being responsible for causing you any more pain. I’ve caused too much already.’

He lifts his finger and grazes my cheek as he pushes a strand of hair behind my ear. My body yearns for his touch in any way it can get it.

‘You haven’t,’ I whisper, only for a single tear to slip down my cheek.

‘I’m not going anywhere, Thorn. I promise you. We have time.’

A lump lodges hard in my throat, bringing on more tears. I don’t want to let them fall.

‘Will you hold me?’ The words crack from my throat, coming from a place so deep inside of me I didn’t even know it was there.

‘Always,’ he replies.

There is no shame, no embarrassment, and no doubt or second-guessing as I remove my gown and let it fall to the floor.

The slightest gasp catches in his throat as his eyes run over my body, but then he moves over to the chest of drawers, pulls out a shirt, and throws it to me.

I catch it in my hands but don’t immediately put it on. Instead, I take a step towards him.

‘What if tonight is all we get?’ I wonder aloud, my voice a cracking whisper. ‘What if tomorrow is the trial, and—’

He silences me with a kiss, stealing the words from my lips and the air from my lungs. When we break away, his hand brushes through my hair

then strokes the small patch of soft skin behind my ear.

‘I will die before I let anything happen to you,’ he says. ‘You have my word.’

I believe him because I can feel it in my bones that he means it. But that still doesn’t answer my question.

‘What if tonight is all we get?’ I ask again.

‘Then I shall spend it holding you,’ he replies. ‘And that will be enough.’

I close my eyes, hearing Llinos’s voice in my ear telling me that this thing between Kyor and me is more than just physical attraction. And damn it, she’s right. She was fucking right.

He lifts my hand to his lips and gently kisses each of my fingertips.

‘Come on, Thorn,’ he says. ‘Lie down. You need sleep.’

I do as he bids and slip under the covers, and a small sigh escapes my lips as he climbs in beside me and wraps his arms around my waist. With his warmth and scent around me, I curl into him. And sleep finally takes me.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 57

I wake frequently in the night, startled by the sounds of my dreams. A scream of pain. A gargle from foam-filled lungs. A crackle of fire as the pyre drifts out towards the horizon. But every time my eyes snap open, Kyor is there, his hand stroking my hair as he holds me close.

‘You’re safe. You’re safe, I promise you.’

The only kisses he offers me are chaste and small, pressed to my temples or my forehead, and once or twice against my lips, firm enough to steady my pulse until the next nightmare starts.

When I’m woken the final time, it is not my dreams but laughter that startles me awake. Confused, I sit up.

‘It’s the cooks,’ Kyor explains from where he’s sitting at his desk, charcoal in his hands. ‘They’re making breakfast. I should have thought. Should have asked them to keep it down a bit. Sorry.’

‘It’s fine. I don’t mind.’ The constant hum of noise reminds me of the slums somehow. Of Ruben and Peter and having Kay constantly there beside me. Not just for a couple of hours at a ball every now and then. Nights that seem destined to end in tragedy.

Still, I’m surprised by how loud the kitchen is, with the clattering of pans and the laughter of the women as they go about their early morning jobs. It’s so joltingly ordinary.

‘Do they always wake you like this?’

‘Every day,’ he says. ‘I like waking up to laughter. It’s normally the only time of day I get to hear it. Besides, it guarantees I’m up before everyone else. Before the Retterheld, it ensured I got some time in the battle yard by myself. These days it ensures I’m up to train with you.’

‘Thank you.’

He moves in the space of a moment, coming to sit beside me and interlocking his fingers with mine.

‘How are you feeling?’ His eyes are full of concern, softness, safety.

‘Broken,’ I reply truthfully, then hesitate before continuing. ‘You know, it’s strange. I thought … I thought death couldn’t get to me like that again. First it was Florian, then my mother, then my father. The number of people I saw in the slums … I thought I was hardened to it. But yesterday it felt like I’d learned nothing. It’s so raw. And it’s stupid, because we’re in the Retterheld. The fact that she and Benny and I made it this far is a miracle. I should have been better prepared for it.’

‘No,’ he says. ‘Hardening yourself to death doesn’t help. It just stops you from grieving people you loved. That’s not fair on either of you.’

‘And have you grieved properly?’ I ask him pointedly, keen to shift the focus and learn more about the man who held me through all my nightmares. ‘Have you grieved Zelle? Your mother? Your baby brother?’

His eyes shift from mine as he lifts his hand to his mouth and bites the corner of his thumbnail. ‘I’m sure if my mother was here, she’d say no. But I think I’ve tried my best.’

I swallow. ‘I’m sorry. I’m sorry you lost her.’

In all the conversations we’ve had before, I don’t think I’ve ever spoken the words or thought about what Kyor losing his mother meant to him without simultaneously being drawn back to what I also lost that night.

As if he knows what I’m thinking, he offers me a fleeting smile. ‘It’s life. We lose people. I guess the aim is to try not to lose yourself afterwards. I failed at that once.’ Silence swells between us and I want to break it. Want to break the hurt of the memories filling us both. But before I can, he’s on his feet. ‘I’ll fetch us something to eat.’

‘You don’t have to do that. I can go to the dining hall.’

‘But it’s not exactly a long journey for me, is it?’ He flashes me a smile before opening the door. The scent of freshly baked bread and sweet pastries floods the room.

‘You’re up late today, Your Royal Highness,’ one of the cooks calls.

‘Did we hear voices in there? A visitor, perhaps?’ Hearing Leilah’s voice is a reminder that I need to talk to her about the food for the slums, though now, with me eavesdropping on her and Kyor’s conversation, it doesn’t feel like the right moment.

‘Just after some food please, Leilah,’ he says.

‘Right. Would that be food for one or two?’

‘You ask a lot of questions, don’t you?’

I’m surprised by the playfulness in his tone. I’d hate to be interrogated by anyone about who I was sharing my bed with, and yet the prince is taking a ribbing from one of his staff in good humour.

‘Well, you know me, I like to keep an eye on you,’ the woman continues. ‘Make sure they’re good enough.’

‘Trust me, she is,’ he replies. ‘I think the issue is whether I’m good enough for her.’

Warmth spreads through me, and not just at his words. When I was dreaming of making it to the Retterheld I had such a clear vision of the prince. How he’d be cold, calculating, and plotting the downfall of everyone he disliked. I never imagined Kyor as someone who would spend his time chatting with the kitchen staff. But then, I never imagined he would be the man holding me all night, comforting me through nightmares, and bringing me breakfast. I know so little about him; the rest is just an image painted in my head. A version of him formed from years of festering pain. The other part is the man he projects. The ruthlessness, the constant solitude and the lack of need for anyone or anything. Neither of them seem to fit the glimpses I’ve seen of who he actually is.

When Kyor returns, the plate he carries is piled high with enough food for at least half a dozen people. But the first thing I reach for is a glass of water.

‘How long do you think we have until the next trial?’ I ask as I sip. ‘It has to be at least a few days, right?’

‘Guess so. Are you up for training now?’

I don’t reply straightaway. It’s tempting to stay here, to lock the door, to hide away from the world. But then I think of Benny. Of him waking up alone. Of him walking down to the dining hall and seeing our table empty. There’s no way I can do that to him.

‘Thank you for this’—I gesture to the food—’but I should go upstairs to the dining hall for breakfast. I need to make sure Benny’s okay.’

‘Do you want me to join you?’

I hesitate for a moment, then shake my head. ‘I think maybe it would be best if it was just him and me for now. Is that okay?’

‘Of course it is.’ He leans forward, pressing a soft kiss to the top of my forehead. ‘I’ll see you in the battle yard? Or just come back here if you want. Door’s always open to you.’

I kiss him back, this time on the lips, before picking my dress up off the floor and leaving. I keep my eyes on the ground as I pass the cooks in a proper walk of shame, wearing only Kyor’s shirt. Here’s hoping I encounter no one on the way to the dorm.



THANKFULLY, rising so early gives me time to get upstairs, shower, and get dressed before anyone else is stirring. I’m glad that Benny woke up with me there, and together we head down to breakfast. I’m not sure my heart could have taken it if I’d seen Benny sitting there alone – or taken a seat by myself, knowing Llin wouldn’t be joining us.

One by one, the rest of the Rettlings filter in. There are so few of us now. The days of clattering plates and barely being able to hear yourself think over all the clamour are long gone.

‘Can I sit with you?’ Jonas asks when he appears.

I nod. ‘Of course.’

‘I’m sorry for—’

‘Thank you for your help with Kay.’

We speak at the same time, and I cut myself short. Jonas shakes his head.

‘Sorry,’ he says.

‘I was just saying … thank you for your help with Kay last night.’

He nods and then hesitates, and from the way the knots are forming in my stomach I have a horrible feeling I know what he’s going to say. ‘You and Kyor … you can’t trust him. You know that, right?’

‘Jonas, please.’

‘I saw it last night. I think he might even believe it’s real between you two, but it can’t be. He’s the heir apparent, and you’re …’ He trails off.

‘Wow!’ A laugh of disbelief rolls from my lungs. Just when I thought we were actually making some progress, he throws out a line like that. ‘Whatever Kyor and I are, it’s none of your business.’ I wish I didn’t sound so sharp. This isn’t how I wanted to spend this morning. The first morning

without Llinos. But then, how did I think it would go? All of us are hurting. And Jonas still has everything with Kestria to work through. There's no chance he's done that yet.

Benny speaks up. 'Well, assuming the next trial is a pairing, I'm guessing Rose'll want to do it with the lightning-wielding, storm-controlling warrior prince rather than either of us. So I guess it's you and me.' Benny's weak attempt at humour may break the silence, but Jonas's gaze is still locked on me.

'Looks like it,' Jonas replies coolly.

'Not gonna lie, I'd rather have had Llinos. Don't know what we're going to be up against, but unless it's a multi-eyed creature, I'm not quite as thrilled about your powers as I was about her ability to control the wind.'

'Sorry.' Jonas pushes back his chair. 'I can't do this. I can't pretend this is normal. He ruined your life. He fucking hates you. You have to know this is all a game, right? That he's just playing with you until he gets bored and moves on, leaving you even more screwed up than you were before? How are you that fucking stupid?'

'Call her stupid again and it will be the last word to ever leave your mouth.'

Kyor stands proudly behind me, and every pair of eyes in the room is on him. He's still topless, and from the charcoal on his fingertips, it looks like he hasn't even washed yet. Though poor hygiene is hardly what Jonas should be worried about. I've never seen a man with more hatred in his eyes.

'Kyor …' Jonas chokes out as he tries to push back his shoulders, but it doesn't matter. It's not about who has more height or muscle mass; it's about the pure power resonating from the two men, and Kyor wins hands down in that category.

'I'm pretty sure that what you just said is enough for me to have you put to death for treason, but I'm in a generous mood, so instead I'm simply going to tell you two things, and you'd better listen good. Number one: you don't know how I feel – you don't have a fucking clue – so don't you dare presume you do. And number two'—he turns and looks at me—'I never hated her. I hated what she reminded me of.' His gaze softens as it bores into me with such tenderness that heat pricks the back of my eyes. I nod, the tiniest of gestures, but he sees. In a flash, his hard gaze returns and he looks

back at Jonas. ‘You speak to her like that again and I will *kill* you.’ With that, he turns and strides out of the room.

Silence is still echoing in the dining hall when Benny speaks a few moments later.

‘And this is why I’ve kept sex out of the Retterheld,’ he mutters.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 58

‘We’ve put this off for long enough.’ Kyor’s expression is unusually stern as he looks at me. ‘Please just try, just this once. For me.’

‘You want me to try to do something that could get me killed?’ I reply, folding my arms across my chest.

‘I’ve already told you, no one is going to come down here. Now, see if you can freeze the water.’

It doesn’t matter how many times I try to tell Kyor that whatever it looked like to him, the magic that killed Oke was the spectre’s and not mine; he refuses to believe me. Maybe because I don’t have any evidence. Not that I haven’t tried to get some. I’ve been down to the library every afternoon for the past ten days, trying to find Caroline to check on how she’s doing and to ask for her help with researching the matter. I figure that maybe having a task to focus on might help her with her grief, but there’s been no sign of her. I’d like to think that she’s not been avoiding me on purpose, but I can’t blame her if she is.

Still, Kyor’s been insistent that we should see if the powers are still within me. Just to check. And finally, I’ve given in.

‘Just try to freeze that water,’ Kyor pushes, gesturing to the bowl in front of me.

‘I don’t know why you think I can do this,’ I repeat. ‘I can’t.’

‘Just try. Please.’

I let out a slight huff before directing my attention to the bowl.

With my focus on the water, I tense the muscles in my hand so hard that my fingers start to throb.

‘Why are you helping me do this?’ I snap in frustration when nothing happens. I spin around to glower at Kyor. ‘You know only one of us will be gifted.’

He nods, pairing the gesture with a brief shrug. ‘You’re right. But maybe some things have become more important to me than the gifting. Like keeping you alive. And you having control over whatever magic you were able to conjure in the trial is part of that.’

Silence falls between us, stretching into a tension-filled silence with one unspoken question. One I want to ask, only I’m not sure I want the answer. Namely, why would the future king – a man who can have anything he wants in an instant – need the greatest gift offered by the Gods?

He parts his lips and for a split second I think he’s about to tell me. But then he glances back at the bowl and the water within it.

‘Practise,’ he says. ‘Freeze it.’

We stay there for almost an hour, after which the water definitely *feels* colder, but that’s probably just because it’s a chilly night. Or maybe because my fingers have lost the ability to feel. Either way, I’m spent.

‘I need to stop. This isn’t working. I told you, it’s not my magic.’

He presses his lips together as though he still isn’t convinced, but thankfully he doesn’t press the matter any further.

‘Can we just head to bed?’ I say, looking up at him.

‘If that’s what you need.’

‘It is.’

I don’t make any pretence of heading upstairs. Instead, I cross the kitchen and walk into the dimly lit space that is solely his. His drawings are still on the desk. Most of them are of his wolf, though some are of people. I know there’s one of Zelle as I caught sight of it the other day, but I haven’t looked through the others. Even when he sketches late at night, while I doze in bed, I haven’t asked him what he’s working on. If he wants to show me, he will.

The room is lit only by the glow of a single lamp. As he strips off his shirt, the light catches the ridges of his back, his muscles glistening as he moves and flexes. I reach out and trace a line between his shoulders and feel him shiver beneath my touch.

‘Rose …’ My name comes out as a breath, a barely there gasp. As he stands, as stoic as a statue, I move my hand further down his back to the hollow at the base of his spine. Then lower still.

But before my hands reach his waistband, he spins around and grabs me by the wrists.

‘You know the rule.’

‘Not as a distraction,’ I say, my hands now on the bare skin of his torso. ‘But what was it you said to me? *You are the distraction.* Isn’t that right?’ I smile, though the gesture is snatched away as a memory of Holden’s words crosses my mind. How this is a game and Kyor’s going to grow bored with me.

I’ve never been naïve enough to think that whatever this is will last forever, but to be over so soon, before it even really started, hurts more than I would have expected. I cross to the other side of the room before twisting back to face him.

‘You know, if you changed your mind about wanting this, I understand,’ I say, trying to keep my voice steady. ‘But at least have the decency to admit it.’

‘What?’ His eyes widen as he looks at me with pure disbelief. ‘Why would you say that?’

‘Why?’ I can’t help the bitterness of the laugh that escapes my throat. ‘Because every time I try to initiate something, you brush me off. You barely kiss me, unless it’s just a peck. When I strip to climb into your bed, you turn away from me. And you’re gone most of the time when I wake up. If all you want is friendship—’

‘That is not all I want!’ He strides towards me and for a split second I’m sure he’s going to grab me and kiss me, but instead his hands stretch out in front of him as though he’s trying to keep a physical barrier between us.

‘Rose, I don’t kiss you because if I start, I don’t know if I’ll be able to stop. I can’t watch you get undressed, because the sight of your skin has me wanting to plunge my tongue deep enough that you’re all I’ll taste for days to come, and I’m certain you’ll see it all over my face. And I’m gone in the morning because the sight of you, lying in my bed, barely dressed, gets me so hard that if you were to ask me for anything, I would be powerless to say no. You are still a thorn in my side, and I want you from the moment I wake, through every breath I take, until the moment I go to sleep. Every dream I have, every wandering thought, you are there. Don’t you ever again doubt that I want you. I’m just trying to respect you. To protect you and not take advantage of you. That’s it.’

He looks at me, unblinking and without a shadow of doubt in his voice. And there's none in me, either, as I take a step closer so that his hands brush against my skin.

'I don't need you to protect me, not here in this room. In here, either you treat me as your equal, or you accept that there's no hope for us and this is already over.'

'That's not something I'm willing to accept,' he says, his voice a growl.

'Good,' I rasp, already feeling the slickness between my legs. 'Then show me how much you want me. Now.'

His mouth is on mine in an instant, and not with timidity or doubt, but with the same urgency and pressure as that first kiss. Back then he accused me of not trusting him, of kissing him to keep him silent. But there's no doubt in my mind anymore. I trust this man with my life, my soul. I might as well. After all, I fear he already has it.

My hands work over his chest and he buries his head in my neck, licking and biting at the skin, causing my hips to buck as my body melts against his.

'Kyor,' I groan.

'I wouldn't,' he whispers. 'You keep saying my name like that and this will be over way too fast.'

'Kyor,' I say again and a shudder rolls down his spine as he presses his weight into me, finally allowing me to feel his full length. Any illusion of control I had is gone as I grab a fistful of his hair and pull him closer into me.

'Good Gods, you are beautiful,' he says as he fumbles with the bottom of my shirt. I lift my hands above my head so he can strip me, so that he can see all of me. He sighs out a moan as he holds his hand millimetres from my bare nipples and allows the static from his hand to spark against my skin.

'Fuck!' I gasp as I grip hold of him with such force my nails bite into his skin.

'Too much?' he asks, looking at me with concern.

'Gods no,' I reply, shaking my head. 'We've got a long way to go before you hit too much.'

A grin slides across his face, but rather than returning his hands to my chest, he works on the buttons of my trousers. The moment they're undone, he pulls them down.

I reach for him. It's my turn. I need to hold him, feel him, but before I can even manage to undo the top button, he has me by the wrists and pulls my hands away.

'We have time for that,' he says. 'First, I'm going to need you to lie back on that bed and let me kiss you like I've been dreaming of.'

Even if I wanted to say no, I don't have the strength. Instead, I drop back, my legs falling open, every inch of my body exposed to him. A guttural noise rises from Kyor's throat.

'You have no idea how hard you make me,' he growls.

'I would if you would let me feel you inside me,' I say hopefully.

His laugh is wild and carefree as he grins at me. 'You really do lack patience, don't you?'

'Only with you.'

'Well, it's coming, and so will you. Don't worry.' He leans over my body and runs his hands over my stomach as he plants his lips against the top of my thigh. I half whimper, half groan as my hips buck into him.

'I am going to make it my mission to touch every part of your body,' he says, drawing his tongue higher, 'with every part of mine.'

With every moment, he adds to the pressure that only makes me yearn for more.

'I need you inside me,' I plead. I've never felt like this before. So desperate. So utterly without control or restraint.

'Soon.' He reaches the apex of my thighs and my legs instinctively open wider as I reach up, desperate to pull him in closer. But before I can, his fingers are hovering above my clit, sparking against the skin.

'Fuck … I can't … You can't …'

'Too much, my love?'

'Don't stop. Don't …' I can't finish a response. My back is arched again, the pleasure exquisite. I need to feel something inside me – *him* inside me – but I know from that glint in his eyes that he's enjoying watching me way too much.

'You know, I think you're using your powers so you don't have to touch me yourself,' I gasp out.

It's a lie, an outright one, and he knows it, but I'm willing to try anything to get what I want.

'Oh, I'm perfectly willing to touch you,' he purrs. Relief floods through me. Finally I'm going to get to feel him inside me, but instead, his head

disappears between my legs.

I cry out as his tongue sweeps my most sensitive of areas. My entire body melts into his as his tongue starts a constant motion that has my legs trembling. I didn't think anything could be more intense than his static shock, but with what his mouth is capable of, I am going to crumble imminently.

'I'm going to come,' I gasp, struggling to get out the words between breaths. 'I'm going to come if you keep doing that.'

'That's the point,' he growls back. It's a fight between my body and mind, and my body is losing. It doesn't matter that I want to hold on. That I want to wait until I feel him in the depths of me. I can't stop. The motion of my bucking hips matches the rhythm with which his tongue works me, and my hands grip the sheet as I try to maintain a modicum of control, but before I can even try to steady my breath, he slides two fingers inside me.

'Fuck, you're soaking,' he groans as he moves his mouth momentarily away from me. I don't know why he's surprised, and I want to say as much, but before I can, he switches up the pressure inside with a curl of his fingers. My entire body clenches, tightening around the feel of him.

'I want to have you inside me.' It's my turn to growl, and yet all it elicits from him is a wicked grin as he looks up at me and then a lick of his lips. He momentarily closes his eyes as he savours my taste.

'I know what you want, and we'll get there,' he promises. 'I'm just going to need you to do this for me first, okay? I'm going to need you to let go. You do that, and I'm all yours. Just let go for me. I want to watch you come apart, Rose.'

Fuck. That's not an offer I can refuse, and even his voice is bringing me closer. My body is right on the edge, and I'm so damn close. He offers one more long rake up between my thighs with his free hand, as the other pumps in and out of me before his mouth finds my clit again. That's all it takes. The kisses. The touch. I can no longer hold it back. Muscles spasm and quake as the orgasm shakes through every part of me, and my pulse is so fast I can barely believe I'm still breathing. And yet he doesn't stop, his fingers still toying with me, pushing me higher still.

Only when every part of my body is spent and my breathing is ragged and shallow does he drop down onto the bed beside me, kissing me gently on the lips. I try to respond, but my body is weakened by whatever the hell he just did to me.

‘I don’t think I’ve ever seen a sight that good,’ he says, using his thumb to brush down my lip. ‘You have no idea how fucking sexy that was.’

‘You don’t play fair,’ I say, sitting up slowly and manoeuvring myself so that I can straddle him. ‘Now I’m going to have to get my own back.’

The feel of just how hard he is between my legs is enough to have me needing him again, and I rock my hips with just enough force to feel the pressure of him pulse beneath me. As that first moan leaves his lips, I slide my hand down and finally grasp hold of him.

‘Gods.’ His eyes roll backward as a low groan reverberates in his throat. ‘You know, I thought I knew what this was meant to be like. Turns out, I’ve been getting it wrong for years.’

With every long stroke up and down his shaft, I tighten my squeeze ever so slightly. His hips buck in response. I thought after the orgasm he just gave me that I would need at least a little respite, but apparently the sight and feel of him is all it takes to get me ready to go again.

‘Gods, I want to be inside you,’ he growls with his eyes closed. ‘I want to feel that tight wetness around me.’

‘Is that so?’ I say, unable to stop the smirk from rising on my lips. ‘Because I’m pretty sure that when I wanted the same, you told me I needed to have patience, remember? I think it’s time you take a little bit of your own advice, Your Royal Highness,’ I tease.

His eyes snap open as his body turns rigid beneath me.

‘Don’t,’ he says, shadows filling his gaze. ‘Don’t call me that.’

I shift back, loosening my grip on him. Surely he has to be joking, but there’s not a hint of humour in his voice.

‘Kyor?’

‘I’m not him to you. I’m not your prince. Your kingdom’s heir. Your whatever else other people call me. I’m yours. That’s it. You understand? I’m yours, even if you’re not mine. Even if this isn’t the same for you as it is for me. If you don’t …’

He stops, and my chest burns with the word he hasn’t said. Is that what this is? Not infatuation, not lust, but something else? Something far more dangerous? I don’t reply. Instead, I press my lips against his and respond the only way I can.

‘I’m yours,’ I whisper before the kiss deepens.

Whatever this was before has transformed. The urge to feel him in me is still there, the desperation just as acute. I need him to be so far within me

that it will be impossible to imagine us being separate again.

I want to say it. I want to offer him that assurance. That word. Yet as the tip of his head finally pushes me apart, all I can do is gasp.

‘I’ll go slow,’ he promises.

‘Kyor!’ I moan. It’s all so much, too much.

‘I’ve got you. I’ve always got you …’

It’s just the head, and yet it’s stretching me as it inches slowly in, my senses on overload.

‘Gods, Rose. I … I …’ The word is on the tip of his tongue, I know it is, but before he speaks it, I thrust my hips downwards and plunge him in a little deeper. ‘Fuck!’

Our gasps are simultaneous as his body spasms inside me, but it’s not enough. He’s not all the way in. I’m not sure I can take him all, but I sure as hell am going to try. I want every single inch of him. I brace myself, ready to thrust again, only for a shrill sound to cut through the air.

Our eyes meet.

‘The fourth trial?’ I groan, sinking my head onto his chest.

‘Of course it fucking is,’ he growls. ‘Get dressed. We don’t know how long we have, and if they use portation …’

Yeah, being chucked in a tundra of ice in the nude would not go well for either of us.

‘Later,’ I tell him, allowing my tongue one more sweep against his, and he nods as we carefully detangle. ‘We will finish this later.’

‘That better be a promise,’ he says, grabbing my hand. ‘Rose.’ His eyes lock on mine, and I know exactly what he’s going to say, but I can’t hear it now. Not like this. Not when one of us could die.

‘Later,’ I say forcefully.

His lips press tightly together before he nods once. ‘Later.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 59

‘I don’t have my furs,’ I say to Kyor in a panic as I race to pull on my clothes. I can’t believe I didn’t think to bring them down here with me.

I’ve spent every night here after all. But I guess I thought we had more time until the next trial.

‘In the wardrobe,’ Kyor tells me. ‘Benny gave them to me a couple of days ago. I forgot to tell you. Guess he figured it might be another middle-of-the-night thing.’

‘Thank you, Benny,’ I mutter as I grab the clothes. There was a reason the others always looked at him as a leader. He thinks of it all. As I sheath my dagger, feeling the steady cool of the metal in my hand, Kyor is already painting his sigils.

‘You want me to do yours?’ he asks. ‘Etta and Aitara, right? With the Wrohelm rings?’

I nod. ‘Thank you.’

Given his artistic skill, it’s unsurprising that his hand is far steadier than mine and the circles of Wrohelm are actually circular, unlike when I’ve drawn them.

‘I should’ve got you to do them before now. You’ve done a better job than I can.’

‘How about I do it for every battle going forward, then?’ he says, and it makes my heart ache because my father used to paint my mother’s.

‘That sounds like a deal.’ I turn my head up and kiss him gently on the lips.

With our faces painted, we gather with the others in the courtyard, where the carriages are already waiting.

Benny beckons us over.

‘What have you learned?’ I ask.

He gestures to the carriages. ‘Their tyres. They’re the same ones we picked up when we arrived at port. Exactly the same. They need them to go over a very specific terrain so my best guess is we’re heading to the Lueayan Channel.’

Fear flutters through me. I know people have swum the expanse of water that lies between the mainland and the Eastern Isles before, but surely they can’t expect us to do that? If they do, there’s no way I’ll make it.

I gulp. ‘Maybe we have to row across,’ I say hopefully.

‘There’s no point guessing,’ Kyor replies. ‘It’s a waste of energy.’

‘He’s right,’ Jonas agrees.

The comment causes Benny and me to exchange a look. Jonas has barely spoken to me or Kyor since the incident in the dining room, and he’s normally the one offering the most speculation in these situations. Maybe he just doesn’t want to go into the fourth trial with bad blood between us. After all, we’ve lost people in nearly every trial so far. There’s no reason this one should be any different.

‘Your best bet is to use the journey to get some sleep,’ he continues. ‘Make sure you’re rested. You’ll need as much energy as possible.’

As he finishes, I glance across the group. There are sixteen of us left, and judging by the way they’re already forming pairs, they’ve all had the same thoughts and conversations as we have.

Some of the pairings are obvious. Nessira’s with her aunt, Clade, while two of the remaining three guards are together, and two of the Galreckian Rettlings, Moryal and Del, have formed a pair. The third Galreckian is with Seiren, and Odetta seems to be with Yeva. I feel a pang of sympathy for Yeva, given how vile Odetta can be, but the pairing makes sense. Yeva needs ash, and Odetta burns things. That leaves Grenda with Zara. They’re by far the oddest of the pairs and, as much as I hate to admit it, having Grenda on her side gives Zara an even better chance of surviving.

‘Do you think we have to travel alone?’ Jonas asks, looking at the carriages. ‘There are enough for each of us.’

‘I’m going with Rose,’ Kyor replies instantly.

I raise an eyebrow at him. ‘If that’s what I want, right?’

‘I’ll make it worth your while.’ He grins and I can’t help grinning back, even as Jonas mutters something behind us.

Given his comment, when Kyor and I climb into the carriage, I expect us to carry on where we left off. Instead, he takes off his fur and bundles it into a makeshift pillow against the wall.

‘We need some sleep,’ he tells me.

‘You’re not serious?’

‘Absolutely. You may have forgotten, but we didn’t exactly get much rest before we were interrupted.’

I frown. ‘Actually, I can’t remember. Were we doing something fun? Perhaps you should remind me.’

His smile is enough to make my insides melt as he leans forward, brushing a kiss against my lips. If I couldn’t see his hands down by his side, I’d swear he was using his static on me. Because the fizz that rolls through my body is unbearable.

‘We can pick it up later,’ he murmurs. ‘Once we live through this trial. Promise.’

I don’t expect to sleep. Not with the bumpiness of the journey, the impending sense of doom, and the fact that just looking at Kyor reminds me of the feel of him between my thighs. Yet at some point my eyes close, and it’s only when I feel Kyor’s hand gently squeezing my shoulder that I realise I drifted off.

‘Thorn, we’re here.’

I open my eyes and breathe in a yawn. The air is salty, crisp. We’re definitely by the sea, but not the same stretch we used to say goodbye to Llinos. Instead, as Benny predicted, we’re facing the Eastern Isles.

Rather than opening the door and stepping outside, Kyor blocks the way. His brow furrows. ‘Thorn, I don’t mean to sound like Jonas here, but I can get us through this. You know that, right?’

‘You do sound like Jonas,’ I respond through a second yawn.

‘I’m not telling you to sit back or stay out of the way. I’m just asking you not to take any unnecessary risks.’

‘Definitely sounds like Jonas,’ I grouse again, though I can’t help the smile on my lips that only widens as he kisses me. When we break away, he draws in a long, steadying breath.

‘Okay,’ I tell him. ‘Let’s do this.’

We climb out, only to find that the carriages have stopped mere feet from a cliff edge. Had it not been for the last dregs of moonlight shimmering on the water, I might have missed it altogether, and falling off a

cliff because I wasn't paying attention would be a shit way to end the Retterheld.

There, in front of us, stands Mila. I can't help but wonder how many people she expects to die in this trial. After all, she's the only one who knows how deadly each round will be.

As the others gather around us, my hand slips into Kyor's.

When Zara casts her eyes back to me and scoffs, I'm tempted to pull my hand away, but I don't. Screw her. Screw anyone who judges me for being stripped. Or for who I'm fucking. They'll judge me even if I win this damn thing, and I'll let them. It says way more about who they are than who I am. And so I squeeze Kyor's hand a little harder and don't let go.

'Rettlings, welcome to the fourth trial.' Mila's voice is as commanding as always, though my eyes wander to her waist, where a dagger rests at her hip. I press a hand to its twin, hidden beneath the folds of my jacket.

'Your fourth trial is simple,' she continues. 'Tomorrow night, the ball will not be held in Wrohelm, but on the Eastern Isles.' I glance at Benny and see the flicker of excitement on his face. 'All you have to do is reach it. At the bottom of the cliff face, you will find four boats. Each boat will hold two people. When the last boat has landed on the shore, the trial is ended. Simple.'

Excitement flutters in me. A cliff climb and a row? I can do those. Yet almost immediately a knot tightens in my stomach. Those numbers don't add up. There are sixteen of us, and only four boats.

Half of us won't even be able to attempt the crossing? Fuck. It's a race against time.

Everyone is looking at one another, working it out. The knot in my stomach turns into pure dread.

We're going to have to kill one another. That's what's going to happen. I can already see it in Zara's and Odetta's eyes. They are going to kill whoever they have to if it means they get a boat.

Kyor leans in towards me. 'We're fine,' he says confidently. 'No one is getting near us. There's no one faster down this cliffside than you and me, and we both know it.'

He's right, but my fate isn't my only concern. I glance at Jonas. I have no fucking idea what he's going to do.

'You can't waste time thinking about them,' Kyor says. 'Everyone knows what they signed up for. You worry about yourself, that's it. Okay?'

I nod. ‘And you.’

‘I look forward to seeing you on the Eastern Isles,’ Mila concludes her little speech, and a moment later, a flash explodes in the sky.

The fourth trial has officially begun.

I don’t need Kyor to tell me what to do. I race to the edge of the cliff and start to scramble down.

‘I know I said I trust your judgement,’ Kyor calls, ‘but you see it’s pretty steep here, right?’

‘I know you’ve climbed worse,’ I call back. ‘And it’s going to stop the others from doing the same.’

‘Not disagreeing. Just a little bit in awe,’ he says, flashing me a grin. ‘My girl fucking owns it.’

‘Damn right I do.’ I’ve come so far, and in this trial especially, I’m not the weakest. I’m one of the strongest.

It’s amazing how at ease I feel in this part of the trial. Not just at ease, but genuinely excited. I almost forgot my love of climbing. The rush and the thrill of finding the best path and pushing my body to follow it through.

In just a matter of minutes, I’m going to be by the water. But that’s where my advantage ends. There might be boats, but something tells me this isn’t going to be as straightforward as gently rowing across to the Eastern Isles into a warm welcome. There’s something in the water. I’d stake my life on it. And unfortunately, I’m going to have to do exactly that.

‘How are you doing?’ Kyor calls again. He’s almost level with me now, giving me a chance to see the way his arm muscles flex and tighten as he stretches for each of the handholds. I can’t help but remember that first night I saw him and the way his eyes fixed in my mind even then.

‘You all right?’ he asks, concern etched in his features.

‘Sorry.’ I shake the moment away. ‘Got a little distracted.’

He offers me a knowing smirk. ‘Really?’

‘It’s not my fault you look so good in life and death situations,’ I tell him, only for him to chuckle.

‘Come on. Some of the others are closing in. We need to get to the boats first.’

He hits the ground while I’m still ten feet up.

‘Would you be insulted if I offered to catch you?’ he calls up.

‘You really think that me landing on you – me straddling you – is the best use of our time right now?’

‘I wouldn’t argue with it.’

‘For fuck’s sake,’ Benny yells down from above. ‘You do realise things echo off a cliff and get louder, right? I think I preferred it when you two were pretending to hate each other.’

‘I definitely preferred it,’ Jonas mutters.

I land a moment later, my feet firm on the ground. Benny is not far behind, but Jonas still has a long way to go.

‘Make sure you hold that boat for him, Benny!’ I call.

‘Don’t worry. I know the rules,’ he replies. ‘You just get you and your prince across.’

I don’t need to be told twice. I race across the stone beach to where the boats have been dragged up past the shoreline. They’re sturdier than I expected, with wooden hulls and wooden oars with metal ends. Great for a gentle row on a lake, but crossing a freaking channel? We’ll have to wait and see.

‘Where do you want me?’ I ask Kyor. ‘Front or back?’

‘Now, Thorn, really?’ he groans.

‘I meant in the boat,’ I huff.

‘Right. Right, go in the front. I’ll steer.’

I head to the bow and start to drag it forward as Kyor pushes from the back. We need to get it into water, but where we go from there, I’ve no idea. No bright lights guide us as only the faintest glimmers of the Eastern Isles are visible over the waves.

‘Any chance they just have really small lamps on the islands?’ I ask.

Kyor flashes me a grin. ‘Sadly, I think they’re just far away, my love.’

If it wasn’t for the fact that the others are racing down the cliff face behind us and would happily skewer us with their swords, I would let my heart stutter over what he just called me again. But then, it could easily have been a slip of the tongue. Or a casual term of familiarity, nothing more.

I force the words out of my head as my feet hit the water, and a rush of fear judders through me, so visceral it steals my sight.

I don’t want to be here. I shouldn’t be here.

The thoughts come with a hollowness. Like they are somehow detached from my own mind. But how could that possibly be? How can I have thoughts that aren’t my own?

‘Thorn?’ Kyor’s voice snaps me out of the moment. Only then do I realise the water is knee-deep. ‘You need to get in.’

‘Right. Sure.’

As I climb into the boat, Kyor pushes us out, wading through the waves until the water is at his thighs. Then, with one final launch, he jumps in and begins paddling.

For a few minutes, we’re completely silent. The only sounds are the lapping waves and the gentle splash of our oars breaking the surface.

‘Is it just me,’ I say, ‘or does this all feel a little too easy?’

‘Just stay alert,’ Kyor murmurs.

I do as he says, but it doesn’t stop me from talking. ‘Where are the others? How are they doing?’

‘Hold on. They’re … shit.’ His response is enough to make my chest squeeze. ‘Looks like Benny and Jonas are going to have to fight the others for a boat.’

‘Fight who?’

‘Yeva and Odetta.’ My throat constricts even further. Jonas and Yeva are both from Wrohelm, so what does that mean? Would he switch sides and help her instead? No, I can’t imagine he would, and Yeva and Odetta’s combined firepower is substantially greater than what Benny and Jonas are working with.

‘Fuck,’ I say. ‘Any chance you can intervene? Offer them a helping hand?’

Kyor exhales sharply. ‘Rose, my love, are you suggesting that I interfere in other Rettlings’ fights just to aid your friends?’

Yup. There was no mistaking it then. Twice in two minutes. Still, this time I don’t dwell on it.

‘That’s exactly what I’m saying. Can you do it or not?’

‘You know that if I do that, there’s a chance that Etta won’t see them as worthy of the gifting. They should really do it on their own.’

‘Are they going to do it on their own?’ I snap. ‘Or are they going to get killed?’

His silence is all the answer I need.

‘Just do it, Kyor. I’m not losing them too.’

He turns back. Silver crackles of lightning appear between his fingers and a cloud darkens over the shore. A split second later, the light shoots from his hands, bounces off the cloud, and crashes downwards, striking the

ground between Benny and Odetta. It's a testament to Benny's powers that he was able to leap away before it struck, but Odetta wasn't so lucky. She sprawls backward, giving Benny and Jonas a chance to grab the boat. By the time Odetta has gathered herself enough to start hurling flames at them, the boys are already on the water.

Relief rolls through me. I get what Kyor meant about Etta seeing them as worthy, but we've all needed help at some point or another in the Retterheld. I know I certainly wouldn't be here without their support.

But I'm not going to dwell. The boys are alive, and they've got a boat. That's what matters. I refocus on the view in front of me. As far as I can see, there is nothing. Nothing but the sea. Still. Quiet. Maybe it *is* as simple as crossing the channel.

But then, as the water brushes against the hull and spills over my legs, a feeling ripples through my stomach, a twisting that grips the very core of my soul. It is pure, tortured agony. My breath hitches for a moment, but then the pain is gone and it's like I'm not even in my body. I'm above it. Seeing the water. Seeing our boat. Seeing Jonas and Benny rowing towards us as we sit there drifting. What in the Gods' names is going on? Is this part of the trial? Have the priestesses somehow used their magic to pull me from my body? I didn't even know that was possible. How the fuck do I get back?

'Rose!' The boat surges and Kyor slams into me, and just like that, I'm back in my body. Whatever that aberration was, it's passed. So does that mean it was part of the trial or not? Only as Kyor reaches out over the side of the boat do I realise I've dropped one of my oars in the water.

'What? What happened?' My voice cracks.

'I was about to ask you the same, Thorn. Are you okay? You just stopped rowing and let go of the oar,' he says, handing it back to me.

'Did I?' I can't remember that. I can remember being above it all. And before that all I can remember is pain and the fierce anguish that filled me when the water struck my legs.

My chest pounds as I twist around to look at Kyor, already aware of how insane I'm about to sound. But if that wasn't the priestesses' doing, then there's only one explanation. Somehow, there's still magic running through me.

'I felt something,' I tell him. 'I felt something in the water.'

'What do you mean?'

‘I’m not sure.’

I put the oar back in the rowlock and lean over the side.

‘Rose, what are you doing!’

‘Just let me do this.’

He quiets as I lower my hand into the water.

A moment later, the pain tears through me and I scream out in agony.

‘Rose!’

I rip my hand out of the sea and the feeling is instantly gone. That presence. That pain. Vanished.

There is something in there. Something in pain. Something strong.

Kyor stares at me, then glances at the water.

‘Don’t touch it. Don’t,’ I plead with him. ‘It’s … it’s horrible.’

He ignores me, just the way I knew he was going to. ‘I just want to see, that’s all.’

Fixing his own oar, he dips his hand into the sea. His brows knit together as he pushes his arm in deeper.

‘I can’t feel anything,’ he says.

‘Really?’ I breathe. ‘It was in so much pain. Like it was trapped. Like it shouldn’t be here.’

He watches me carefully, but I suspect he’s thinking exactly the same as I am. It’s just a case of who has the guts to voice it first. In the end, it’s me.

‘Do you think this has something to do with the ice? With what happened before?’

‘I don’t know,’ he says. ‘But I’m starting to hope it might.’

The comment catches me by surprise. ‘You are? Why?’

He tightens his grip on the oar and nods towards something over my shoulder.

‘Because if it is, then maybe you’ll be able to work out how the hell we get past that.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 60

My gaze snaps to the front of the boat, and the air rushes from my lungs. Six gargantuan tentacles protrude from the water, twisting and rising as the mammoth body writhes upwards. How big is that thing? A hundred feet? Two hundred? I have a horrible feeling I'm still underestimating its size. As a twenty-foot wave barrels in our direction the creature's head breaks the surface and a single yellow eye locks on mine. A tremble holds my voice hostage before I finally choke the words out.

'Is that … is that a kraken?' I gape. 'Since when are there krakens in these waters?'

'You're the one who said it felt like it was in the wrong place,' Kyor reminds me.

Shit. He's right. We have to get past a fucking furious kraken – a creature that's been dragged out of its homeland and dropped here in the channel. Why in all the Gods' names would Etta set a trial like this?

'I can use lightning. If I can get enough power, I can drive it back underwater,' Kyor says, thinking aloud.

'For how long?' I say cynically. 'It's hurt. That's why it's acting like this. I felt its pain. Striking it with lightning will only exacerbate the situation.'

'So what would you suggest?'

It's a genuine question.

I frown as I muse aloud, 'Okay, if it doesn't want to be here, why isn't it leaving?'

'Something must be holding it in place,' he theorises.

'Right. Presumably magic of some kind.'

‘Yes.’ The hitch of excitement in his voice is undeniable, and I feel exactly the same. Not just because we’re closing in on a plan, but because of how easily we are falling into step with each other. It shouldn’t feel this effortless, but it does.

‘Okay.’ I rub my lip as I think. ‘If we can break down whatever magic is holding it in place, then it’ll move on, right? It’ll go and we’ll be able to cross.’

I look around me. How the hell could anything have enough power to hold something that size in place?

‘You need to paddle away,’ I tell him. ‘Stay parallel to the shore and don’t get any closer while we think this through.’

Kyor doesn’t question me, immediately pulling his oar through the water and switching up our direction to make sure we don’t get any closer to the kraken. Meanwhile, I study the shore. Benny and Jonas are in their boat heading towards us, while Zara and Grenda have another. There are a few bodies scattered on the shingle, but I don’t look closely enough to see which of the remaining Rettlings are dead. That won’t help anyone now.

‘How have they trapped you?’ I mutter as my gaze falls on Mila, still standing at the top of the cliff, watching us. She’s barely as high as a matchstick from this distance, but I can tell it’s her. Just like I can tell there are other priestesses spread along the cliff. As I continue to stare at them, my eyes catch on the thin wisps of magic radiating from their hands.

‘It’s them. The priestesses,’ I say. ‘We need to stop the priestesses from using magic on the kraken.’

‘You want us to attack priestesses of Etta during Etta’s trials?’ Kyor’s doubt is clear, but I shake my head.

‘No, I’m not saying we attack them, but we do need to interrupt their concentration and break the channels between them. They’re using their collective powers to hold the kraken in place, so we have to stop the magic in order to set it free. Can you do something? It doesn’t have to be lightning. Snow, wind, rain … whatever you’ve got will work. Just do something.’

He exhales sharply as he looks up at the sky. ‘Okay. Just so you know, Etta, you’re the one who set this trial, so this is on you.’

He releases his oar and dark storm clouds instantly swell above us.

With Kyor’s hands occupied, I’m the one tasked with keeping the boat in place. It’s not an easy task. Too far away from shore and we risk facing

the kraken's raging tentacles; too close and one of the Rettlings without a boat could come after ours.

The thunder rumbles.

Benny rows up beside us, then grabs hold of the side of our boat. 'Do you want to tell us exactly what's going on? We'll stay more stable if we brace like this,' he explains. 'So, Rosey, what's the plan?'

The nickname makes me think of Llinos, and I miss her so fucking much. She could have probably just blown the priestesses over for us. That would have sorted this issue fast. I push the bite of grief aside as best I can. Kyor can command the wind. He can do it.

'The kraken is being held in place by magic,' I explain. 'It's hurt, and it's angry, and it's scared. And any attempt to row across it is going to end with us getting knocked out of our boats. For sure.'

'So your idea is…?'

'Kyor is going to distract the priestesses channelling the magic, the ones holding it in place. If he can do that and sever their connections, then the kraken should be able to swim out of the channel pretty fast. We'll have an easy crossing from there.'

'Attacking Etta's priestesses at Etta's trial?' The scepticism in Jonas's voice is scarily reminiscent of Kyor's.

I choose to ignore it.

'I have already mentioned that,' Kyor interjects. 'If you've got a better idea, then by all means, let's hear it.'

'Didn't say I had a good idea.' A rare smirk tips Jonas's lips. 'But I'm glad you're the one attacking Etta's representatives rather than me.'

'It's the trials,' Benny cuts across. 'We're still together until the Ofur, so we do whatever we need to, to get there, okay? What do you need from us, Kyor?'

Kyor's eyes widen in surprise. Up until now he's faced every trial by himself … unless you count Elska and me getting the Solarium root for him, which I'm pretty sure you can't.

'Jonas, keep the boats steady,' he responds. 'Benny, keep an eye on the kraken. See if you can figure out any patterns in its movements. Maybe the edge of its boundary, too. If this doesn't work, we'll need another plan to get past it. Oh, and Lorathin?'

'Yes.'

‘Don’t get any smart ideas about blinding it. The last thing we need is an even more pissed-off kraken.’

Working together isn’t going to be a hundred percent smooth, but we’re definitely stronger as a team.

‘Okay,’ I say, looking each of them in the eye. ‘Let’s do this. Ready?’

‘Yep.’

Dark clouds continue to swell above us as Kyor calls them in. I’ve seen him draw on his powers before, not just in the small ways that excite my body but also with the larger lightning strikes during Holden’s game in the battle yard, but I’ve never watched him the way I’m watching him now. Now I can see it’s … phenomenal.

The entire sky is blanketed in thick, black clouds of his own creation while the air buzzes with static energy. I can feel it radiating from him. Pure power. And I should be terrified, but I’m not. I’m in awe.

‘Over to you, my love. How hard do you want me to go?’ The innuendo is less than subtle and there’s a twist in his lips as he speaks. It’s a ridiculous time for flirting, but he looks so damn good with all that power at his fingertips that I can’t bring myself to chasten him.

‘You know what you’re doing. How hard do you want to go?’

‘Oh, you have no idea.’

‘For fuck’s sake, you two!’ Benny snaps. ‘Read the room!’

A smirk flickers on Kyor’s lips, but Benny’s right. We need to focus. Even though we’re out of the kraken’s reach, the more time it’s trapped, the more pissed it’s getting. And if this doesn’t work, then we’re going to have to find another way past it.

‘You don’t want to risk hurting them,’ I say, my tone back to business. ‘Just stop them from channelling. Wind?’

He shakes his head. ‘It’s difficult to control at this distance. I might end up blowing them off the cliff face.’

‘What about hail?’

He offers the slightest dip of his chin. ‘Hail could work.’

A low, thunderous roar cracks from the clouds as they split open and pelt the cliffs with shards of hail. The air between us and the priestesses turns opaque as the icy pellets slam down from the sky directly over them, highlighted only by the thin forks of lightning that streak the air. It’s the expanse of what he’s capable of that has my jaw hanging loose. The distance between us and the furthest priestess must be approaching a mile,

and yet he's hitting them all simultaneously with the hail, with enough control for not a single fragment to hit us or the water. That amount of power and skill … it's unfathomable.

'Is it working?' Jonas asks.

I don't reply. I can't tell just by looking, so I lean over the edge of the boat and reach for the water.

'Rose!' Jonas leaps up from his seat and the movement sends his boat lurching in the waves and knocking into ours.

Hurriedly, I grab the sides to steady myself.

'She's fine,' Kyor snaps. 'Or she would be if you just did what was asked of you. It's all right, Thorn. Do it. Just don't let yourself fall in.'

I press my hand into the waves, and panic and pain surge within me.

Is it less than before, or was I just braced for it? I can't tell. I pull back breathlessly, absently drying my arm on my trousers.

'Maybe lessening a bit,' I announce. 'But it's not enough. It's still in pain. The ward's still in place.'

Kyor's brow knits. 'Meaning I need to kick it up a notch?'

'I think so.'

'Here we go, then.'

He lifts his hands, only to stop and look at me and then the others.

'Just in case any of you need a basic science lesson, water conducts electricity. I'll try to make my shots as precise as I can, but it'd be great if you kept your hands inside the boat.'

'Noted.' I grin, wondering if he was tempted to forego the warning on the off-chance Jonas might get zapped.

When Jonas merely nods, Benny adds hastily, 'We accept that now is not the time for us to disagree with your methods. You do your thing.'

'All right. Then here we go.' Kyor draws in a deep breath that shudders in his chest, and I realise only now exactly how much this is taking out of him. His breath is wheezing. He's struggling. And I don't think I've ever seen Kyor struggle with anything before.

I open my mouth, ready to tell him to stop lest he accidentally strip himself of magic, when the lightning strikes. Hard.

A dozen bolts explode from the sky, splitting apart as they strike the shore, landing perfectly between the priestesses. A sharp, metallic tang fills my nostrils as Kyor slumps forward.

'Kyor!'

I twist around, catching him before he can collapse fully, and cradle his head in my hands.

‘I’m fine,’ he gasps. ‘I’m fine. Just need a minute. Did it work?’

I glance at Benny. It’s a sign of how well he and I work together that he knows exactly what I need. He shifts himself with the rhythm of the boat so as not to worsen the rocking, then holds Kyor upright for me so I can press my hand into the water.

It hits me straight away. The confusion. So much confusion. But the pain is gone.

The ward is down.

‘It can go,’ I murmur, expelling my words in a long breath. ‘The ward’s down. It can leave. We should be able to cross.’

A collective sigh of relief rattles from Benny and Kyor as I pull my hand out of the water and reach for my oar, ready to finish this trial, but Jonas’s voice breaks the quiet.

‘If you’re so sure it can leave, then why is it still here?’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 61

I don't want Jonas to be right. I want the kraken to be leaving, but its tentacles *are* still above the water, flailing wildly.

'So you can communicate with that thing?' Jonas asks. 'How the hell?'

'There must be residual magic from the priestesses flowing through the water,' Kyor lies, his breath still shallow, wheezing. 'The sea must be filled with it from whatever they had to do to get this thing in here. I can feel it too.'

Jonas doesn't look convinced, but Benny nods easily as his eyes lock on mine. 'Sure, makes sense,' he says lightly. 'I guess it's your girly emotions that make you more attuned to it, right? I must just be too macho to feel it.'

I can't help but smile, both at the slight zing at Kyor and the memory of Llin's comments about women not being the emotional ones. The expression is fleeting though because Jonas is right – it's not moving on.

'Do we need to somehow let it know it's free to go?' I wonder aloud.

'How?' Kyor asks.

'Well, if I—if *we* can feel what it's thinking, maybe it also works the other way around? Maybe I can send thoughts to it. Tell it that it's free to go.'

'You think that'll work?' Jonas asks dubiously.

'I think it's worth a try,' Benny responds before I can.

I'm still not sure whether he's bought our lie about residual magic in the water, but I'm glad to have him here. With three against one, whatever Jonas says will be brushed aside.

‘Hold the boat steady,’ I tell the others before plunging my hands into the water. Though there’s an immediate icy chill, it doesn’t take long before I cease to notice the temperature. Instead, the kraken’s emotions flood me, consuming every other sensation I have. It only takes me a heartbeat to know they’re the same as last time. Confusion and loss, but no discomfort. The pain has definitely disappeared.

If I wasn’t sure before, I am now. The ward is gone and it’s free to go. It just doesn’t know it.

You can swim away, I think, pushing the words through my mind with as much force as I can. *You can swim away. Swim away!*

A flicker comes from the creature – the slightest modulation in its emotions. Excitement sparks within me. It’s working. It’s going to work. *Swim away!* I try again. *You’re free. Go!* I practically scream in my mind. *Please, hear me. You can leave.*

The same flicker comes again, as though it’s struggling to make sense of what I’m telling it. I’m only adding to its confusion. A single tentacle rises up out of the water – it’s only the tip, but it’s covered in suckers the size of carriage wheels – and with a gurgling roar from the kraken’s unseen mouth, the tentacle slaps down into the foaming waves. Something about the way the motion slows just before impact tells me it’s as much in frustration as anger. I need it to hear me. Properly.

As I pull my hands out of the water, I turn to the others.

‘Paddle towards it,’ I demand.

‘What?’ All three men respond simultaneously.

‘Paddle towards it. Now! I need to be closer.’

Out of the corner of my eye, I see the other two boats. They’ve both taken a wider route, possibly hoping we’ll be enough of a distraction so they can slip across unnoticed. Though if that’s the case, they’ve vastly underestimated the size of this beast.

‘It can hear me, but it doesn’t understand. I’m sure if I can just get closer, it’ll work. Do you need a minute first?’

My question is aimed solely at Kyor, though he shakes his head. ‘No, I’m good. But if you don’t mind, I might do this the easy way.’

‘The easy way?’

A moment later, I’m slung onto my back as we’re struck from behind by a gust of wind that careens our two small boats straight into the kraken’s path. I wait for the second gust to come from the front and slow us down,

but it comes later and harder than any of us expect. The boats rock violently as waves crash over the sides.

‘Wanna wind the weather down a bit, buddy?’ Benny asks Kyor.

‘Sorry.’ The prince grimaces. ‘That storm took it out of me. Not so easy to judge strength when you’ve just blown a dozen priestesses off a cliff.’

Even in the tumultuous chaos, I can feel Benny snicker.

I smack him.

‘Not the right moment?’ he asks innocently.

‘What was it you said?’ I shoot back. ‘Read the room?’

In case we need a reminder of just how much we need to get out of here, a tentacle smashes down less than two feet in front of us, sending a wave that rockets us up in a cloud of white foam. We clutch the sides of the boats, holding fast as we crash back down again.

‘Will everyone just focus?’ Jonas snaps. As we all look to the kraken, the frown tightens on his forehead. ‘Is it moving towards the shore?’ he asks. ‘Because if it keeps doing that, it’s going to beach itself and probably kill us in the process.’

‘You’re always such a ray of sunshine,’ Benny mutters, but Jonas isn’t wrong.

‘We need to get this thing to swim down the channel,’ I say. ‘Now.’

As much as I’m hoping the new proximity between us and the creature will make it easier for me to communicate with it, the tumultuous water is making sticking my hands in a darn sight harder.

I twist around to look at Kyor. ‘I need you to hold me steady. Make sure I don’t fall in.’

‘Don’t worry. I’ve got you.’

His shifting in the boat barely adds to the rocking as he places his hands on my hips, my whole body at his mercy as I lean overboard and plunge my hands into the water.

The kraken’s emotions smack me hard. Yup, I was right about the frustration. It’s suffocating in it.

Not this way! Swim down the channel. You’re free! Swim away down *the channel.*

I scream at it with all my mental power, but even with the shorter distance, I’m only getting the same level of recognition as before. It’s not that it can’t hear or understand. It’s that it’s too consumed by its own torment to focus on me.

Moving the boats here has made no difference other than putting us in dangerously close proximity to its tentacles. Fuck.

‘Still nothing?’ Kyor asks as he pulls me out.

‘No,’ I say. ‘But I’ve got another idea. I don’t think you’re going to like it though.’

‘Does it get us past this kraken?’ Jonas asks.

‘It should do.’

‘Then we like it,’ he says.

I’m pretty sure he’s only saying that because he doesn’t know what my idea is. Still, I don’t need his permission. Bracing myself against the waves and what’s about to come, I twist back and look at Kyor. The moment I press my lips together, his face hardens.

‘No. Rose, just no.’

‘I need to be there with it. In the water. This’ll work.’

‘And if it doesn’t?’

‘Then I drown.’ I shrug as nonchalantly as I can, like I haven’t feared this very moment since coating my fingers in ash and submitting my name for the Retterheld months ago. ‘But that’s not going to happen. This will work, Kyor.’

‘Fuck no,’ Jonas snaps, having finally twigged onto my plan. ‘You’re not going into the water, Rose. You’re not a good enough swimmer.’

Kyor rounds on him. ‘Stop telling her what she can’t do. I can’t deal with you dragging her down right now.’

‘If she gets in the water, it’ll be the kraken that drags her down,’ Jonas fires back.

Another tentacle comes down, creating a wave strong enough to lift the bow of the other boat out of the water entirely. When it smashes back down, Benny is left without an oar. Fuck.

‘Stop bickering! If we carry on like this, all four of us are going to die out here!’ I shout above the constant crashing. ‘At least this way, there’s a good chance the three of you will get out.’

‘No,’ Jonas repeats. ‘We’ll do something. I’ll … I’ll …’

‘If you say “blind it,” I swear I will push you out of this boat myself.’ My response surprises me, but it’s justified. Jonas’s power has made the situation worse before and we can’t risk that now.

Ignoring Benny and Jonas, I turn to Kyor. ‘You asked me to trust you. Now I’m asking you to do the same.’

I see the conflict on his face. The hesitation. Finally, his chin dips in a nod. ‘What do you need from me?’ he asks simply.

‘The moment you see a chance, get past it. If you can get me out fast, go for it. But if I go under, you need to leave me—’

‘Rose that’s not—’

‘I’m not risking anyone else.’ I leave him with that statement and try to look at Benny while simultaneously throwing off my furs and shoes. But with all the rocking, it’s not exactly easy. So I choose to shout instead. ‘Benny! Remember what Llin said. One of us has to make it.’

I strip down so that I’m barely clothed. Of all the bad ideas I’ve had in the Retterheld, this one feels like the worst. But it’s the only one we’ve got.

Goosebumps rise on my arms. This is it. This is the only way. I know that. And it’s a stupid plan. All I’ve got is a gut instinct telling me that this is what I have to do. For all I know, it could be some kind of delirium caused by something in the water, but if that’s the case, at least I’ll meet Mortidem knowing that I saved my friends.

Knowing that I saved Kyor.

I look at the dark water rolling beneath me. The raging blue and black depths. Once I jump, there will be no turning back. Shit, I really, really don’t want to jump.

I cast my final words to the second boat. ‘If this works, it should calm the kraken. Maybe enough to get me out. But if it doesn’t, then none of you can come after me. Not you two, and definitely *not* him. You lose Kyor and you’re dead too.’

I see them both nod, at which point I turn to Kyor. Even exhausted, he is the most perfect specimen of a human. Those icy-blue eyes. Those perfect lips. Gods, if I’m only going to get one last kiss with him, I wish to hell it was on stable land. But that’s not going to happen, so I’ll make do with what I have.

That’s what I think, at least, until I lean in to kiss him, only for him to brace me by the shoulders.

‘No.’ His eyes lock on mine. ‘You can’t have it both ways. Either you know you can do this, in which case, there’s no need to kiss me like it’s goodbye. Or you don’t think you can, in which case we stay in this boat and find another way. I’m *not* losing you.’

The way he speaks makes it feel like it’s just the two of us, alone together in his room, not struggling to stay afloat in a tiny wooden boat as

waves crash over us.

‘Rose, in case I haven’t made it clear before now, I would rather drown here holding you in my arms than let you sacrifice yourself for me. Understand? So what’s it going to be? Can you do this, or do we need to find another way?’

That’s it. I love this man. If I didn’t know it before, I sure as hell do now. I swallow, fighting the desperate urge to kiss him. Instead, I muster a nod.

‘I can do this.’

‘Good. Then do it.’

I don’t wait. I cross my arms over my chest and jump over the edge of the boat, plunging into the icy water.

The cold seizes my lungs, and before I can even form a thought or remind myself to kick my legs, everything is drowned out by the kraken. The creature’s suffering is monstrous, but cold is not one of the things that’s causing it turmoil. And so it becomes the same for me. It is like I belong here. In this water. Consumed by the animal’s raw, unfiltered pain. It’s in a place it never expected to be. A world it doesn’t belong to. And I know exactly how it feels.

As I kick myself back up to the surface, I open myself to it all and, in return, offer it everything I can.

I know. I know you don’t belong here. But you can swim away now, I think, sending the words with as much force as I can. *Swim away. There’s nothing stopping you anymore. I promise.* I picture it in my head, the image of the tentacles moving pointedly *down*stream, down the channel.

The recognition I felt before comes again. But this time, it’s stronger. It’s hearing me. It understands. A wave is heading towards me. Trying to give myself as much of a chance as possible, I draw in a long breath only a moment before my head disappears back under the water.

You can go, I say again. *Please. You can go.* Its response comes again. Stronger still. It’s listening. *Swim down the channel. Stay deep. Go. Go!*

I kick upwards, ready to grab a breath.

Only I mistime the wave.

Cold slams into my chest, and instead of the sweet burn of air, I taste salt and iron. Water rips its way into my mouth, and though I try not to swallow, it’s too late. My lungs protest – no, they seize – and I *need* to take

another breath. But the next gasp is filled with water too, and a hot, wet pressure swells and claws at my ribs.

Sound narrows to a bloody, muffled drumbeat as my ears pop, and the light thins into a silver tunnel I can't reach. Panic arrives fast, bright and precise, cutting through thought. Breathe. Breathe. Breathe.

Coughing and choking do nothing but pull more water in. I kick until my thighs burn, feet slashing, propelling me towards a surface that refuses to show itself. Where the fuck is the surface? The Godsdamn air?

Adrenaline sharpens everything as my hands claw the water like fingers scrabbling desperately at a ledge. Thoughts fragment into images: the tiny boat; Kyor's smile; Benny's teasing laugh; the small, stupid things that matter; and Kay.

Always Kay.

Time stretches into a long, thin rope of moments where all I can feel is the heavy thud of my slowing heartbeat. I'm not going to make it. The world is losing its grip on me.

For a sliver of a second, the part of me that's stubborn and ridiculous refuses to accept this ending. It fights. It kicks. Yet air remains elusive. I don't even know if I'm kicking in the right direction.

This is it. This is the end.

If I'm dying, just let it have purpose. I reach out desperately to the kraken again.

Go home! You can go. Please, just go.

I'm trying to make sure it hears me, but I can feel my thoughts growing weaker, my mind blurring. This is when I meet Mortidem then.

I didn't even get a chance to be one with Kyor. A ridiculous regret, but still, it's there.

I'm dying alone aside from a sea monster and endless water. At least there's no pain anymore. That's something, right? At least there's no pain.

I offer one final kick, knowing it won't help. The edges of my vision are darkening, and I realise, with complete calmness, that whether I give up or not, Mortidem is coming for me.

In the deathly darkness of the water, as my eyelids flutter closed, a single flash of colour marks my passing. Blue. A blue so piercing it's like it can see all the way into my very soul. Like it *is* my soul.

Then, a moment later, the world goes black.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 62

Everything feels wrong. Too soft. Too warm. If this is what death is like, it's certainly not what I expected.

My body feels relaxed and weirdly floaty, yet the water is gone. And I can breathe. That's nice. I take a few breaths, enjoying the way my chest lifts and falls. But still, it's like my body isn't quite right. And my hands? There's something wrong with my hands. My knuckles feel as though they've been clamped. Not broken but squeezed so tightly that they might splinter. As I try to move them, the feeling intensifies.

'Rose? Rose!'

I blink my eyes open. Kyor is there, staring at me, his blue eyes bloodshot. 'Thank the Gods,' he breathes as he drops his head down to my chest.

'Kyor?' My voice croaks.

His head jerks back up. 'I'm here. I'm here, my love. What do you need?'

'I think you're crushing my hand.'

A light laugh escapes him as he instantly releases me and uses his now-free hand to wipe his cheek. Then he lowers his forehead so it rests against mine.

'We had to give you some paparvy seed,' he murmurs. 'You were in so much pain from the cold.'

The cold? Was it cold in the water? Yes, it was, but just for a while. I remember that now.

'Paparvy? Oh, that's why I feel floaty.'

He smiles. 'You'll feel fine in half an hour or so. It'll wear off soon.'

What’s the last thing I remember? I remember mentioning Llin. Telling Benny one of us had to make it. My chest tightens and panic cuts through the seed-induced fog.

‘The others. Did they make it? Benny and Jonas?’

Kyor nods. ‘Everyone who got into a boat made it across. Thanks to you. You made it, Rose. You’re in the Ofur. One of the final eight.’

The final eight. Those words fall on me with a weight I would never have expected. I should be happy that so many of my friends made it this far, but it doesn’t change the fact that there are those who didn’t. Turns out this wasn’t like the Retterheld where everyone made it to the Ofur. Like so many others, ours was messy and bloody and full of loss.

Still, he looks so damn proud of me that my heart melts a little. Wait, is it really melting? I rub my chest and he stills my hand, looking concerned.

‘Are you okay, Rose?’

‘I think my heart is melting,’ I explain.

His answering smile is like a sunrise, and I’m quite happy to bask in it.

He offers me water and watches me like a hawk as I sip it, visibly relaxing as the fog starts to leave me.

Suddenly, a frivolous thought strikes me. ‘The ball. Did I miss it?’

A smirk rises on his lips, one that’s tinted with just the slightest hint of bashfulness. ‘Actually, you’ve got about two hours until it starts. I may have insisted, in a not at all diva-ish and entirely princely manner, that no ball would be happening until I was present. And I would not be leaving your side until you were awake. They weren’t up for postponing it indefinitely, but in true Thorn style, it looks like you woke just in time.’

I roll my eyes, but it’s hard to deny the warmth that floods through me as I realise he’s dressed in his formal garments, jacket and all. Definitely ready for a ball.

‘No, it doesn’t sound like you were diva-ish at all,’ I say. ‘Next you’ll tell me you only requested a parade and a small throne.’

‘Only a little one.’ He winks. ‘The Eastern Isles already hate me and my father.’ The remark takes me by surprise – I didn’t realise the dislike of Korvane had spread this far – but before I can comment Kyor continues. ‘And I didn’t think you’d want to miss the ball. Llinos’s family will be in attendance.’

The warmth I felt only a moment ago is replaced by a hard lump in my throat.

‘They will?’

Kyor nods, his smirk gone. ‘Benny has spoken to them,’ he explains. ‘Told them about you and your friendship with Llinos.’

The lump catches in my throat, making it nearly impossible to breathe.

‘Do they know?’ I choke out. ‘Do they know how it happened? Why it happened?’

‘They know she was poisoned and that it wasn’t a Retterheld death, and they know that she received the proper rites on the funeral pyre.’

‘So they know.’ I swallow back the tears that are threatening to spill. ‘Do they blame me?’

His brow creases deeply. ‘Of course they don’t blame you. It wasn’t your fault. It was Holden’s. No one blames you, Rose.’

He leans over and kisses my lips. It’s like the drink I’ve been waiting for. The thirst that only he can quench. Yet all too soon, it ends.

‘I should go and let you get ready. Besides, I probably need to show my face and do a bit of grovelling to bolster relationships after my dramatics.’ He pauses, hesitating. ‘Your remaining buddy from the Isles owes you an explanation as well.’

‘Benny? What did he do?’

‘I’ll let him explain that. Just take it easy, okay? I’ll see you at the ball tonight. There’s a guard stationed at your door. You need anything, you send for me.’

He leans in and kisses me again before breaking away and looking me straight in the eyes. The way his gaze locks on me, I have a sudden jarring recollection of blue eyes in black water.

I sit up abruptly. ‘You! You’re the reason I’m here. Dammit, Kyor, you were supposed to leave if the coast was clear!’

His gaze is licked with fire. ‘Nothing on this earth was tearing me from you. And don’t tell me you wouldn’t have done the same for me.’

His words stop me. Because I would. Of course I would. Silence fills the room as we stare at each other, a wealth of words passing unsaid between us. I know it’s only a question of time before they burst out, no matter how unwise they might be.

‘Thank you for saving me. Again.’

‘You saved us first.’ He brushes a strand of hair away from my face and tucks it tenderly behind my ear. ‘I’ve got to go, but just in case you want a

bath, it’s through there.’ He gestures to the other side of the room. ‘And it’s big enough for two. In case you fancy that later?’

‘Later?’ My eyes widen as I sit up, suddenly wide awake. ‘Any reason we need to wait?’

His laugh resonates through me. ‘I’m more than game, but given that the last thing you bathed in was seawater and that was three days ago, I thought maybe you’d want to freshen up first?’

Horror rushes through me. It’s not that Kyor’s never seen me in a sweaty state before given we’ve trained together plenty of times over the last couple of weeks, but this is different. I must reek. As I lift my hand to my hair, the feel of grease slides off my fingertips. Fingertips that are black under the nails. I’m absolutely filthy. And he’s been sitting with me like this for days.

‘You go do your princely things …’ I tell him, pushing his chest and offering only a closed-mouth peck on his lips. I can only imagine how bad my breath is.

‘You still look beautiful,’ he says as he backs away. ‘Truthfully, I don’t think you’ve ever looked more beautiful.’

‘You’re delusional,’ I say with affection. ‘Now go. It’s going to take the full two hours to get myself presentable.’

With a chuckle, he leaves.

With Kyor gone, I sit up and look around me. The Eastern Isles. It’s still a surprise to learn that he and his father have particular issues with this area of the kingdom. Benny and the others never mentioned anything. Sure, they dropped a few anti-Kyor comments in the beginning, but I assumed that was just in solidarity for all I’ve been through.

It is hard to believe I’m really here though. On Llinos’s home soil. The place I was meant to come and live with her. Colourful tapestries hang on the walls, and my view out over the water is one of perfect crystal blue.

‘I wish you were here with me, Llin,’ I whisper as I sling my legs over the edge of the bed, only to catch my reflection in a mirror. Despite being bedridden for a couple of days, I still look strong. It’s actually hard to believe it’s my body I’m looking at. My ribs are no longer visible, but there’s no fat on me. Just thick, corded muscle. I look like I always wanted to when I was younger.

Like a warrior.

Just as Kyor said, the bath is plenty big enough for two, and the water is steaming. When it's half full, I slide my body under the surface, closing my eyes as I breathe in the scent of the bath oils. Maybe I should feel nervous about being in water so soon after nearly drowning, but I don't. I feel at peace. Then again, maybe that's just the paparvy, though I don't feel floaty and weird any longer.

Only when my eyes start to cycle back into sleep do I pull myself out of the bath and wrap myself in the thickest, fluffiest robe I've ever seen, which I found hanging on the back of the door. I may have been living in the High Hold for the past two months, but I sure as hell haven't been living a court life – this brief moment is enough to remind me of that. Now there's a real chance I will.

The final eight. The odds have never been better, but I'm well aware that this is no time to relax. There are still seven other competitors, each as desperate for the gifting as I am, and three of them I consider good friends, if not more. No, it's not going to be easy.

As I tie the belt of the robe around my waist, there's a knock on the door. The deep voice of what I assume is a guard follows. 'Miss Kultavaris, you have a visitor.'

'Send them in,' I call back, checking that the robe's knot is secure and I'm presentable. I assume it will be Benny or Jonas, but it's not. It's Zara. I feel my mouth gawping, not just because she's here, but also because of how normal she looks. No weapons. No snarl. And her hair has grown so much since we began this thing that it now covers a large amount of the scar my fire bead caused all those months ago. It takes me a minute to get over my shock.

'Are you lost?'

It's not the warmest welcome, but it could still stand to be a darn sight colder than it is. I remember what Kyor said about the guard being there for anything I need and wonder if perhaps I should call him to take her away, but I half suspect that Zara wants me to show that I'm still afraid of her. I'm not.

A slight smile quirks at the corners of her lips. A smile because she wants to attack me? It would be a great time to do it. By opening up the wounds the water caused in my lungs, she could drown me right here on dry land.

As the thought arises, I’m shocked to feel a tingle of magic spread through my palms. Is this what my power does? Raises its head when I feel threatened? From what’s happened so far that makes sense, although it still doesn’t answer the question of where the hell it came from. All magic flows to Mortidem upon death, so how in the Gods’ names did that spectre on the ice pass some to me?

‘I’m not lost.’ Zara takes a seat on the edge of the bed. ‘I just saw Kyor. Judging by the inane smile on his face, I assumed you were awake so thought I’d come and apologise.’

I raise my eyebrows so high I’m sure they hit my hairline. ‘You’re going to have to be a bit more specific than that.’

She exhales sharply. ‘I’m sorry I attacked you when you first arrived. And again after Shim died. I was wrong to lash out.’

The way her jaw clenches, it’s as though it’s physically painful for her to get the words out. Not that I’m complaining at all.

‘And in the battle yard?’ I question. ‘You remember? You were all literally trying to kill me.’

‘That was Hold—’ she snarls, only to cut herself off. ‘That too.’

I try to read her face, see if there’s any sign of trickery, but whatever my new powers are, they don’t stretch to lie-detecting.

Silence fills the room.

She really does look genuine, and having one more ally in this thing would definitely be more useful than keeping her as an enemy, but I’m not going to respond with something as trite as ‘apology accepted.’ A two-minute conversation doesn’t negate everything she’s tried to do to me up until now.

‘I appreciate you taking the time to say that,’ I reply in what I believe is a fair answer.

She nods, only to remain where she is, looking at me as though she expects me to say more. When she realises that isn’t going to happen, she stands up and walks to the door, only to hesitate. ‘Maybe as a gesture of goodwill I could paint your sigils for tonight.’

I frown. ‘Tonight?’

My stomach lurches. They can’t be doing the Ofur tonight, can they? Or maybe they can. It’s been three days and the others are probably all well-rested. But how would they already know it’s happening? There have been no chimes, have there?

‘It’s tradition on the Isles,’ Zara interrupts my mental spiral. ‘People wear their sigils for balls and formal occasions. I’m sure they’ve got some paint in one of these drawers.’ She moves over to the dresser and sure enough, she pulls out a palette. ‘See? I mean, you can check with Kyor when he gets back, but that’s how it’s always been every time I’ve attended a ball here. I don’t see why it’d be any different now.’

Can I really do that? Let her paint my sigils? Pretend I actually like her? There are only three people I’ve ever let paint them before: my parents and Kyor. She’s not a name I want to add to the list.

‘Thank you for telling me and for the offer, but I like to do it myself. As a sign of respect, you know?’

She nods. ‘I understand. I should let you get ready.’ For a second time, she turns to leave, but once again she hesitates, this time to reach to her belt and withdraw a dagger. She’s not seriously going to try that now, is she? Would she kill me for not letting her paint my sigils?

The tingle in my palm grows stronger and a pulse begins in my chest, the energy rolling through my veins. The tingling turns into a deep throb as she turns the blade around, hilt towards me. Offering it to me. What the fuck?

‘It’s tradition,’ she says. ‘Where my family comes from, we offer blades to those we respect. I thought perhaps you could wear it tonight. Since I can’t paint your sigils.’

I remain fixed to the spot, not reaching for the gift. There has to be some kind of ulterior motive, a trap waiting for me, but I can’t see what it is.

‘I don’t mean to sound like a bitch,’ Zara breaks the silence, ‘but if you don’t take it, it’s fucking rude. Like, big-time smite rude. But I get it if that’s your plan. It’s not like I wouldn’t deserve it.’

Could it be poisoned? I doubt it, given how she picked it up herself. The poison would be on her too, and she’s been holding it for far longer than I intend to.

The tingling is still in my palm as I take the hilt of the dagger. I’m not sure if I’m controlling it or if it’s controlling me, but either way, I know that power is at my fingertips if I need it, and it’s the first time I’ve felt a tiny modicum of control in fourteen years.

‘Thank you. I guess I’ll see you at the ball then.’

‘Right. It’s the big room on the ground floor. You can’t miss it. I’d better go get dressed and do my own sigils. I’ll leave you to it.’

It’s difficult to decide what the most unbelievable part of the last few days has been. The fact that I’m in a relationship with the man who ruined my family, that I can, on some level, communicate with giant, ancient krakens, or that Zara was nice to me. Actually, screw that. The last one is definitely the weirdest.

With Zara finally gone, I head over to the wardrobe. Given that there was paint for the sigils inside, I expect there to be clothes as well, and I’m not disappointed. The array of fabrics and styles are even greater than those Dinah gave me, and unlike my selection back on the mainland, everything here is the height of fashion. As I run my fingers across the material, I can’t help but think of Llinos. She would have loved this. There’s one dress in particular, in a deep green, that I can imagine would have complemented her skin tone perfectly. A knot fixes itself in my stomach.

Can I really go and face her family? Look them in the eye knowing I’m the one who should be dead, not her?

I don’t have a choice. Not really.

With a deep breath in, I reach my hand up and pull out a dress at random. Turns out there are some things even scarier than krakens, and the sooner I get this done, the better.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 63

I've never paired sigils and daggers with a dress before, but there's a first time for everything. My first random dress choice didn't work at all as there was nowhere to sheath the blade, and given it's the first show of goodwill Zara has ever given me, I don't want to throw it back in her face. Which is why, when I peer into the wardrobe a second time, it's with a little more discernment. Thankfully, I find the perfect garment.

The black leather, halter-neck jumpsuit, with a keyhole cutout below my sternum, is the perfect mix between warrior and womanly, and my own knife belt fits perfectly across the hips. After sheathing various daggers – including Zara's and my own from Dinah – I paint on my sigils, aware of just how clumsy they look compared to the ones painted by Kyor's steady hand. I brush my hair and do a simple plait around my crown, like Llinos sometimes wore, and then I head out, feeling like the shadow of my best friend is walking with me.

The stone here is paler in colour than the grey bricks of Wrohelm, and even though I can hear the music drifting from downstairs, I take my time absorbing it all, from the paintings to the views to the colour of the carpets, imagining Llinos beside me, telling me little facts about each. Facts she'd almost certainly have learned from Caroline.

Five minutes have passed before I even reach the staircase to the ballroom. Am I delaying speaking to her family? Absolutely. I know what Kyor said about them not blaming me for her death, but how could they not? That wine was meant for me. And I was the one who handed her the glass.

I blame myself, and they should too.

One by one, I take the steps, not sure if I'd rather face them sober or drunk. In the end, though, I know it makes no difference. It will be painful however it happens. As I reach the doors to the ballroom, I feel the music reverberating through the ground.

Aware of the tremble in my hand, which is thankfully absent of the tingle of magic, I step in through the doorway.

The music screeches to an abrupt halt, gasps rattle through the air, and hands fly to mouths at the sight of me.

My throat constricts, and I feel sick as I take in the assembled courtiers, all in their finest gowns, with nothing more than sparkling eyeliner and garish lipstick on their mouths. There is not a painted sigil in sight.

'By the Gods, Rose,' Zara speaks into the stunned silence. 'I can't believe you'd disrespect the Eastern Isles so much as to turn up to a ball ready to offer violence. That's unbelievable. But then, what can we expect, letting a *slum rat* take part in the Retterheld?'

Anger pulses through me and it takes serious restraint on my part not to draw the blade she gave me and throw it into her treacherous, conniving little heart. I curse myself for being an idiot, for believing – even for a second – that she could ever show me a drop of respect.

'I think it's bad-ass,' a young girl announces loudly, breaking the hush of the hall.

I turn to look at her, and my breath catches in my throat. I know without being told who she is. Carys, Llin's little sister.

'Absolutely bad-ass,' Benny agrees loudly as he moves to join me.

A murmur turns into unfettered conversation as people begin talking among themselves. Still, I'm sure my face has never been redder.

'Okay. This was not what I expected you to be wearing,' Benny says as he sidles up beside me.

'Zara.' The one-word growl is all I need to explain my situation. 'Is this … should I go back and change? Wash off the sigils?'

'And give her the satisfaction?' He snorts. 'No, don't worry. I've got this.' He clears his throat and all eyes turn from me to him, every whisper and chatter disappearing. Huh. 'Ladies and gentlemen, may I present my dearest friend and a most formidable warrior – who, as her face betrays, takes her work rather seriously – Rose Kultavaris. She is, regrettably for our enemies, the reason your earl still breathes this evening.'

Another gasp rolls from the guests. This one has the slightest hint of awe mingled in.

‘Earl?’ I mutter in shock. Sure, I knew Benny was nobility. *Rich* nobility. But there’s something about the way he said his title that held gravitas.

‘My mother is the Duchess of the Eastern Isles,’ he tells me. ‘Her ruling over the kingdom is—’

‘Second only to King Korvane,’ I finish for him, as the pieces finally slot into place.

‘Speaking of which … looks like you definitely caught someone’s eye with that outfit of yours.’

My eyes are drawn across the room to where Kyor’s standing staring at me, lips apart, as if he’s in shock. As if I’m the most mesmerising thing he’s ever seen. Which is ridiculous, because compared to him, I’m nothing.

Only as I smile does his expression flicker, and a grin takes hold of that perfect mouth of his as he strides across to me.

‘Your Royal Highness,’ Benny says formally with a dip of his chin.

‘Lord Benaris,’ Kyor responds just as politely before turning to me. ‘I’m guessing from the glowers that this look of yours is courtesy of our friend from Rowell.’

I huff. ‘I don’t know why I believed a single thing she said to me.’

‘Because you’re trusting and want to think the best of people. And that’s not a bad thing.’

‘Right now, I feel like it is.’

‘You have to give it to her that it’s a bit more inventive than her normal stab-you-or-set-you-on-fire approach,’ Benny counters.

‘Yeah, maybe,’ I say. ‘She gave me one of her daggers and everything. I’ll use it when I stab her through her heart.’

He snorts.

‘Well, it’s good to see you up. Any chance you’ve got it in you to meet a couple of people before you get out of here?’

I know exactly who he’s talking about, and the answer is a resounding no. Kyor puts his arm around my waist in a show of support.

‘If you want, I’ll be with you the entire time,’ he says, shooting Benny a look that says there’s no point trying to disagree with him.

I nod, knowing there’s no real way out of this. ‘Okay, I’m ready.’

Both men brace me as we walk further into the room, Kyor holding me steady and helping me ignore all the eyes following my every step.

‘If I tell you they’re staring because you’re beautiful, would you believe me?’ Kyor whispers.

‘No. But I appreciate the effort.’

‘Well, I’m staring because you’re beautiful. How about that?’

Some people are talking now, returning to their conversations, but I can’t help casting another look at Zara. Her smug smile has been replaced by a scowl. She’s clearly less than impressed that I’ve overcome this problem so quickly. Still, I shift my daggers further around my waistband so they’re not quite so visible.

‘Rose,’ Benny says, coming to a stop. ‘This is my grandmother, the Dowager Duchess.’

The woman in front of me is dressed in a dark silver gown that’s almost the exact shade as her hair, the sapphire- and emerald-encased tiara on her head looking almost like a crown. Something tells me this is the type of woman you curtsy to, and so I do, though with just a small bend of my knee.

‘I’m truly very pleased to meet you,’ I say in all honesty.

Her smile tightens slightly as her gaze shifts to Kyor at my side before coming back to me. ‘I hear I should be grateful to you for keeping my grandson alive.’

‘I believe we have both kept each other alive,’ I reply truthfully. ‘I am sure I would not be here without your grandson, and the other islanders, who I also counted among my friends.’

She nods at that, looking pleased. ‘Then you are blessed by the Gods to have found one another. I am extremely proud of all our men and women who answered Etta’s call. Ultimately,’ she says, looking pointedly at Kyor, ‘it is only the Gods that we should answer to.’

Benny grimaces and drops his voice once more to offer an explanation of his grandmother’s acerbic comment. ‘My grandmother’s great-grandfather was the ruler who sought a unification with Morathka,’ Benny tells me. ‘Before then, we were an independent kingdom.’

‘I wasn’t aware that the Eastern Isles were ever independent,’ I say in surprise.

The Dowager sniffs. ‘King Korvane treats truth like an optional accessory – splendid when it suits him, conveniently absent when it

doesn’t.’

Tension ripples through the air, yet no matter how uncomfortable I’m starting to feel, Kyor remains completely relaxed.

‘I would happily take back with me any documents or books you feel our records may be missing.’ He smiles. ‘It has been lovely to chat with you again, Dowager. I hope to see you on the mainland soon.’

She sniffs again. ‘A pretty face and tight arse aren’t enough to win me over, young Kyor. You can tell your father that too.’

‘I’m sure my father would be honoured to hear you think he still has a tight arse,’ Kyor replies without missing a beat. ‘Now, if you don’t mind, I believe there are some other people Rose has been hoping to speak to. It’s been a pleasure, Dowager.’

Despite herself, I see a flash of amusement cross her face, followed by consternation. I get that all too well. I hated Kyor once upon a time too, but his charm – and other parts of him – won me over.

I offer a fumbled farewell and another curtsy before leaving the Dowager.

‘You know, for someone who insists they’re nothing like their father, you can sure be a prick like him,’ Benny mumbles to Kyor when he catches up with us a moment later.

‘Really? I thought I was just accepting compliments.’ Kyor smirks back.

Benny leads us to a small room off the ballroom, where a woman and a young girl who need no introduction are waiting. It’s the girl who was brave enough to call me bad-ass in front of the whole court. Llin’s baby sister.

‘This is Rose,’ Benny introduces me softly. ‘Llinos loved her.’

Just having those words spoken aloud makes my throat fill with rocks.

‘Carys.’ My voice trembles as heat burns behind my eyes. A miniature version of Llinos, she looks so much like her sister it’s enough to break my heart all over again. I slip out of Kyor’s grasp and bend down to the child’s height. ‘I’ve heard so much about you. Llinos adored you.’

The young girl nods, suddenly silent, no doubt battling her own tears.

‘You picked such beautiful dresses for Llin to wear.’ I’m not sure why I say such an inane thing, and all it does is rouse images in my mind. Images of Llin dead in a ballgown. Dead because of me. I close my eyes, waiting for whatever punishment, physical or verbal, she’s about to unleash on me.

Instead, I find myself engulfed in an embrace.

‘She wore them?’ Carys asks in a small voice.

‘She did.’ Tears leak down my cheeks as I open my eyes. ‘She wore them all for you.’

‘She was so beautiful.’

The girl’s eyes glaze, and all I can do is nod as I stifle the sobs that want to break free.

‘She was,’ I choke out, ‘the most beautiful person I have ever known, inside and out.’ My hand rises and brushes against Carys’s cheeks. ‘And you look just like her.’

The young girl’s lips tremble, and I’m struck by the overwhelming urge to hold her and never let go. But before I can, a throat clears above me.

There, standing over us, is a woman I have never met, yet I know with my whole heart who she is. ‘Go now, Carys,’ she says. ‘Let the adults talk a moment.’

‘But Mother—’

‘Go!’

A slight huff leaves her pouted lips, but nonetheless Carys goes.

As silence threatens to take hold, I bite my lip, not sure where to start. In the end, I go with the words that have been bursting within me from the moment I knew this moment was coming. ‘I’m so sorry.’ I gulp in breaths as I stand face to face with Llinos’s mother, Morwenna. ‘I am so, so sorry.’

A ghost of a smile graces the older woman’s face as she takes my hand. ‘For what, Rose? You trained with her, fought with her, and you loved her. And she you. And most of all, you returned Caroline to her. To us. Her last days were happy and full of love. She chose to enter the Retterheld, and she knew the cost of doing so. You have nothing to apologise for.’

‘Llinos… she shouldn’t have … she wasn’t meant …’

She opens her arms and pulls me into her chest. ‘She loved you dearly. I know that much. She wrote, smuggled a letter all this way, asking if we’d be able to help you secure a home afterwards, for you and your sister.’

‘She did?’ I break away from the embrace to see only a warm smile gracing Morwenna’s face.

‘She did. The offer is not rescinded because Llinos is no longer with us. She loved you as a sister, and as such I will love you as my own. As she would have wished.’

Tears pour down my cheeks unchecked as her generosity breaks my heart anew.

The way she rocks me as she holds me, brushing her hand against the back of my head … it has been years since I've been held in such a manner. Held as a mother holds her own.

'It was my drink,' I say brokenly when I can finally manage words between the sobs.

'I know. And you killed him for it,' Morwenna says fiercely. 'Thank you,' she whispers, pressing a kiss to my temple. 'Thank you for loving my daughter – for avenging my daughter – when we were not there to do that for her.'

Any words I hope for choke in my lungs as I push myself away, striking the tears from my cheeks in a smudge of blue. Rather than letting me go entirely, Morwenna steps back, allowing Kyor to take her place. To take my weight.

'We'll see each other again,' Morwenna says firmly. 'And if you don't find yourself a place in Korvane's court'—her eyes flick to Kyor—'then I will help you find one here.'

'I'm sorry, My Lord,' Kyor says to Benny without a hint of mockery, 'but I believe I should take Rose back to our room. It's been a lot, and she was not long ago at death's door.'

Benny nods. 'Look after her,' he tells Kyor solemnly. 'She may have Wrohelm rings, but she's one of us, too.'

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 64

By the time we're back in the room, I've finally gathered myself enough to stop crying.

'I should go back,' I tell Kyor as we reach the top of the stairs. 'Apologise.'

'You have nothing to apologise for. What you should do is get some more rest. I should have insisted you stay in bed, but I knew you'd want the opportunity to see Llinos's family.'

It's hard to deny I need sleep. My muscles feel unnaturally heavy, and my eyelids are the same. Yet as Kyor closes the door behind us, my eyes drift down his body and yearning fills me.

'What?' He turns back and looks at me with a half-smile quirking his lips. 'What are you looking at?'

'Nothing,' I lie. Then I grin. 'Well, okay, I was just thinking that the Dowager was right. You really do have a tight arse.'

An easy laugh rolls from his chest. 'Really? You nearly died, and that's what you're thinking about?'

'That's always what I'm thinking about whenever I'm alone with you.'

He smiles, lifting my hands and kissing them.

'You're voracious. Though I have to admit, it's the same for me, my love. But you could barely walk back across the ballroom, so such matters will have to wait.'

'You could always be gentle with me,' I suggest.

'Is that what you want?'

I bite my lip. 'No. Absolutely not.'

He grins. It’s a grin that reminds me of the time I saw him in the temple with Elska and Zelle. The first time I saw him without a mask. The Kyor I get now is the real him. Not the one he shows in public, or in fights, or every other moment of the day. And it causes my heart to throb.

‘We’ll wait,’ he tells me.

I want to disagree. To tell him I don’t need to wait. That waiting is pointless when we don’t know how long we’ve got left together. But as I go to say as much, a yawn escapes.

‘Do you have to go back?’ I ask instead, as I try to undo the buttons on the back of my neck. The angle’s more than a little awkward. ‘Do you have obligations?’

Kyor shifts, pulling me closer.

‘Right now,’ he murmurs, ‘the only obligations that matter are here in this room.’ He presses a kiss to my forehead as he undoes the buttons. ‘Now sleep. Who knows, tomorrow we might get to test out that bathtub.’

Now that’s an offer I can’t refuse.



I WAKE up to the awareness that my body feels far more like my own. There is a slight ache to my limbs, but nothing like it was. Even more helpfully, my mind is far clearer than it has been, meaning the paparvy must be fully out of my system. I stretch a little, flexing my arms and fingers, only to find the smooth contours of Kyor’s body behind me.

As gently as I can, I turn around to face him. Even with his eyes closed, he’s the most perfect specimen of a man I have ever seen.

‘Thorn,’ he says, eyes still closed. ‘Why are you staring at me?’

‘Just feeling lucky, I guess. You know, that we’re still here. Alive.’

As his eyes open, he traces a lazy line down my arm with his finger.

‘I don’t think I’ve ever felt as lucky as I do now,’ he whispers. His eyes are wide now, and his fingers move in circles across my bare back. ‘I’m so sorry for everything that led us here, but it’s hard regretting the only thing that’s ever given me happiness. Brought me you.’

‘I understand.’ And I do. I know exactly what he means. All that loss. All that pain. I hated the way Dinah would say that Etta had her reasons, but

lying here like this, I can’t discount the possibility that she might actually be right.

For a moment we simply breathe one another in, and then he lifts his hand to smooth my hair behind my ears.

His gaze holds me as I lean forward, pressing my lips against his. With a gentle laziness, his tongue caresses the contours of my mouth. As we exchange slow kisses, I feel him harden, pressed against my stomach. My body pulses in response, though the kisses don’t change at first. They remain just as slow and tender, even as I feel my restraint straining within me with each breath, an underlying urgency to the situation rising.

I did as he asked on the boat and didn’t kiss him farewell, and now I want my reward. I want him all.

My hand grabs a fistful of hair at the back of his neck and I pull him towards me.

‘Thorn …’ The low moan rises from his throat and shatters the remnants of my resolve.

I roll my hips towards his, only for a tremble to quake through me as I brush against his hard cock. Yet rather than responding the way I need him to, his body tenses as he backs away, an expression of concern on his face.

‘We shouldn’t.’

‘Yes,’ I say with more certainty than I have felt about anything I can ever remember, ‘we should.’

He still doesn’t move. ‘Three days. You were unconscious for three days,’ he says instead.

‘And now I am back, given a chance to live.’ As I wonder at his reticence, my thoughts flash to Estel’s sister’s pregnancy. ‘I have a tonic,’ I tell him. ‘Something I took in the slums, if that’s what you’re worried about?’

A low, raw growl reverberates from his throat.

‘No,’ he says shortly. ‘That wasn’t my concern—’

‘Then show me. Make me forget that anything outside of this room even exists. Make me forget it all. You can do that, right?’

The switch is immediate. His lips find mine and his hands tangle in my hair, pulling me on top of him with urgency.

I move my hand down, stroking the head of his cock teasingly. I pull away from his lips and look into his eyes, a smile tugging at my lips. ‘Unless, of course, you don’t want to fuck me, Kyor? Which would be very

disappointing, because I have a very particular itch to scratch, and if you're not willing to, then perhaps I—'

With one smooth motion he flips me onto my back, pinning me down with some delicious forearms. 'Don't you dare finish that sentence,' he growls, eyes flashing.

My smirk widens. He's played right into my hands.

'Then I'm yours, Kyor.' I lean up and kiss him lightly. 'Fucking own it.'

When his mouth lands on mine, I pour all the yearning and fervour that burns within me into the kiss. The feeling is something feral and fierce that I want to revel in. His hands move across my body, glancing over my breasts, kneading, stroking, and caressing before pointedly continuing down to the apex of my legs. His fingers graze lightly over my swollen clit – teasing it – before he strokes those clever fingers of his against my opening.

'Fucking hell, Thorn,' he groans low. 'You're soaked.'

'Can you blame me?' I gasp as my own hand slips down his stomach. He's the reason I'm so wet. Just the knowledge of how hard he is is enough to have me drenched. I moan with anticipation as I finally take hold of him, curling my fingers around his girth. I need him in me, but I also need so much more than that.

There's no way I can reach fully around the thickness of his cock with one hand, but the other is too busy gripping the hair at the base of his neck. Still, the groan that rattles from his lips is confirmation that what I'm doing is good enough for now.

'Oh Gods,' he gasps. 'Gods, yes.' The sound of his voice causes my inner walls to clench and tighten.

I'm well aware that twice now he's left me shattered and breathless, but this time it needs to be both of us. I need him to let go too.

His eyes lock on mine as he pushes a finger into me and then, with a moan, a second, causing me to gasp.

'Have I told you that you are the most beautiful thing I have ever encountered?' he whispers.

'Today? No.'

He laughs as he kisses down the side of my neck and it's there again – that smile he keeps hidden from the world. The one that causes my heart to stutter. That smile is the undoing of me, just as much as his fingers and mouth and every other part of his rock-hard body.

His kisses continue, tracing the line along my collarbone before lowering further still. He slips my nipple into his mouth and my body responds, lapping up every sensation, but it's not enough. It won't be enough until I shatter him the way he's done to me, until we break together and reform into something else. Something stronger.

In one sweeping movement, I rock my hips and roll him back on the bed so that I'm straddling him. He raises an eyebrow in question.

'It's my turn to take control,' I say with a grin.

His eyes glint as he relaxes back into the pile of pillows. 'You don't have to try to take it all,' he murmurs.

Just the thought of finally exploring his body in full is enough to have me on the edge, but I resist the urge to go straight for the prize. Instead, I start with my hands, sweeping up and over that magnificent torso of his, and then I let my mouth follow their path.

As I place my lips against his chest, a shudder rolls through his body and his eyes close. A satisfied smile takes hold of my face. I didn't realise how much I wanted to do this until now.

I take my time, kissing a line down his body until I reach his cock, where I run my tongue over the head and savour the low groans that reverberate from him as I taste the precum already beading there.

His hips buck. 'Thorn … Gods, Thorn!' His moans turn into a gasp as I take him in my mouth, stretching my jaw to allow for all his thickness. 'Fuck!'

He's probably right that I can't take him all, but I'm sure as hell going to try. As my mouth lowers down his length, his hips rock back and forth, pushing him deeper and deeper into my throat. The movements are slow and controlled, but with the guttural sound he allows free, I feel myself getting wetter and wetter. The memory of the way he stretched me – filled me – is at the forefront of my mind, but no matter how much I want him in me, I need to first feel him unravel the way he's unravelled me before. The pace of his thrusting quickens and I speed up my movements to match, taking more and more of him each time, eager to help him explode. But just as I feel the shudders rising through him, he grabs my hair with both hands and gently pulls me up and off him.

'As good as that is – and it is – I need to be in you. Now,' he demands.

I don't argue. I can't. I'm fresh out of reasons why he shouldn't pound me in two.

My entire body is burning with need as he flips me onto my back and pushes my knees apart. He could bind me to the bed and keep me strapped there for all eternity and I don't think I'd object. For a split second, his eyes lock on mine, and I want nothing more than to lose myself within them, but then the tip of his cock presses against my opening.

'Ky …' My neck arches back as the ecstasy of that initial stretch leaves me grappling for air.

'How the fuck do you make me want you so much?' he groans as his tongue rakes my mouth.

'It's mutual,' I moan.

'Fuck!'

I swallow back a whimper as he pushes me further open, slowly inching deeper and deeper. I love how well he fits in me. Know how phenomenal that tightness is for both of us. The sensations he's producing are so overwhelming that I can barely breathe, and when he adds in a caress with his static magic, it's enough to make me want to scream his name. I try as hard as I can to swallow it down.

'Don't you dare,' he growls. 'Let me hear every fucking sound, Rose.' I'm not sure I even have a choice as the air rushes from my lungs. I groan loudly and he grinds further into me. 'Gods, Thorn, you feel so fucking perfect. This, you. Everything. I'm claiming it now.'

I can't stop the gasps and moans that rise from my throat, born from every animal instinct within me as he slides in and out of me with perfect, measured control. My walls tighten with every thrust, and my hips move instinctively in time with him. The friction rubs against every nerve inside my body, squeezing me tighter and tighter around his cock. He's already found that spot. The one that's going to make me soak him in the most phenomenal release possible.

'That's it,' he whispers against my ear. 'Let me see you come, Thorn. Let me watch you come with me inside you. Let me feel you clamp around me.'

The hunger in his eyes has reached a new level of burning, but that damn iron will of his is still stopping him from letting himself go. And it's not as though I'm going to be able to hold on forever. Every movement he makes within me is bringing me closer and closer to the edge.

'I want to feel you lose yourself with me,' I beg, 'like you've never lost yourself with anyone before, Kyor. I need that. Lose yourself in me like you

did the first time we kissed. Do everything to me now that you imagined doing then. Take me like this is all we get.'

'I'm not sure that's wise.' He growls out the words. 'I don't know if I'll be able to stop.'

'That's the point. Give me your all, Kyor. Give me everything you've got,' I demand, my head spinning, my careful filter removed from my mouth in the wash of urgency. 'I'm so close,' I gasp out. 'Come with me.'

'Gods, I don't know how you do this to me,' he says as he pushes himself deeper into me. Deeper than I even knew was possible.

'I need you,' I whisper back through panting breaths. 'I need to feel you all the way in me. I need to feel your cum filling me. I want it all.'

'Thorn …' He groans my name like a prayer and a benediction.

I bite down on his bottom lip. 'Come with me, my love.'

It's the first time I have returned the term of endearment, but I feel the effect of the word on him instantly. Desperation cascades through his every cell as his eyes meet mine. The next thrust that comes is the deepest so far and I throw my head back and scream at the power of it. He plunges into me again, and my body takes it all.

'Kyor!'

'Rose,' he answers as he pushes himself harder and faster into me.

My breath comes in shallow, urgent pulls as heat pools low and tight in my core. As the world narrows to the press of him plundering into my welcoming body, my muscles clamp down with an impossible pressure. 'Kyor, I'm coming. I'm going to come. Please … please come with me.'

It all happens simultaneously. His grip tightens as he throws his head back. His body trembles and quakes beneath my fingers. He pulls me so close there is no space, no air between our bodies, nothing that can separate us. The charge that rushes from him fills every part of my body and for a split second, there is no him and no me. There's just us. Just us and the pure energy of this moment.

'Thorn!' he cries out as a crack of thunder rattles the windows.

My own rush arrives, overwhelming and bright, tipping me then sending me tumbling over the precipice. My body shakes and shudders again and again before the sensation slowly starts to ebb.

I don't know if the aftershocks are mine or his. If the buzzing that causes my hair to stand on end and my lungs to struggle to catch breath is magic or physical.

The only thing I know is that we can never go back from this moment. Something between us has irrevocably changed.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 65

I lie with my head on the dip of his shoulder; the shape is so perfect it feels like it's been made just for me to lie there. The static charge of the room has finally died down, though I can't imagine what my hair looks like. I'm betting frizzy.

A sense of sadness ripples through me as I think about how much Llin would have loved that little titbit of information, though she would have been bound to use it to mock me mercilessly.

Now that I'm sated, tiredness has struck again, aching all the way down to my bones. As I let out a yawn, Kyor shifts a little on the bed, moving himself and me a little more upright.

'We need to talk about Jonas and Benny,' he says.

I raise an eyebrow. 'You want to talk about them now? After that? Interesting. I'm not saying I'm opposed, but …'

He growls and then shoots me a glare so venomous I'm almost reminded of those early days. But now I recognise this icy expression for what it is. Jealousy.

'Not funny,' he huffs.

'A tiny bit funny?' I try.

'No.'

I drop back onto his chest and let out a giggle. Toying with him is fun. How is it that when I'm with him, nothing else seems to matter?

'Fine,' I say in all seriousness as I realise his body is growing tense. 'What is it you want to talk about?'

'They didn't buy it. The residual magic thing. Neither of them. Lorathin questioned me on it and I tried to cover, but he's not as dumb as he looks.

Even with that pretty-boy beard of his.’

I didn’t know that a pretty-boy beard was a thing, and I add it to what’s probably going to be an endless list of things I wish I could share with Llin. Still, I bite down on my lip. There’s no denying he’s likely right.

‘I’ll talk to them.’

He doesn’t look convinced. ‘And tell them what? Are you going to mention precisely how you killed Oke?’

‘No,’ I reply instantly. I trust my friends, but I’m not a fool. The Wrohelm court taught me how fragile some friendships can be, and I don’t plan to repeat the mistakes of my youth.

‘Then what are you going to say?’

‘I don’t know right now, but I’ll think about it.’

Silence falls between us, but I can feel his thoughts whirring away. It’s as though that static bolt that ran from him to me has increased my sensitivity even to the parts of him he keeps hidden.

‘There are other ways,’ he says slowly. ‘People with powers in the High Hold. Powers to alter memories. Spells, too. I’m sure I could find one. Find a way to make it work. Assuming you don’t want a more … permanent solution.’

I swivel around to look at him, hoping to find humour in his eyes. But no, he’s absolutely serious.

‘No.’ I say the word as firmly as possible. ‘One hundred percent no. I’m not wiping my friends’ memories. And we’re definitely not killing them.’

‘Even if it keeps you alive?’

‘Even then.’ My gaze softens as I shift myself around so that I’m straddling him. I plant a kiss on his lips. ‘Besides, you don’t believe in killing Rettlings outside of the trials, remember?’

‘That was when the trials were the most important thing to me,’ he responds.

My heart swells with such an unexpected warmth that it causes a prick of heat behind my eyes. Is it sweet or psychotic, a man wanting to kill my best friends to protect me? I guess it’s both.

‘I trust them, so please, my love, trust me too.’

I linger on those words again. It’s only the second time I’ve said them, and they came with even more ease than before. Unfortunately, they don’t appear to have alleviated his fears the way I hoped.

‘I get that you needed to trust them before now,’ Kyor continues. ‘But the next trial is the Ofur. Allegiances don’t last past this point. It will be every man for himself. And let’s not forget your buddy Benny already made some serious lies by omission. I’m assuming from your reaction earlier that you didn’t know who he was?’

I didn’t, but I don’t respond. Did Benny lie? Perhaps. But it’s not as though I ever pressed too hard. I knew there was a hierarchy with Llin and the others, and I knew he was at the top of it. I’m sure it wouldn’t have been that hard to work out if I’d really wanted to do so.

‘Benny did what he thought was best, and it doesn’t change how much he helped me. Without the islanders’ training and protection at the start, I doubt I’d have even made it past the first trial. And as for Jonas, his father was and is a true friend of my family. He’s the only one who helped Kay and me when we were stripped.’

A pout tightens Kyor’s lips, and I wish I could read the meaning behind it. At first, I assume it’s because I’ve reminded him of what his lie did to us all those years ago. But then his frown lines deepen.

‘I don’t get it. I know you’re happy that Acacia’s in the High Hold with him, but I’ve known Lord Lorathin my entire life and I’ve never known him to do anything that doesn’t benefit himself.’

‘Could that just be the fact that you instinctively see the worst in everyone?’ I tease. A smile twitches at the corner of my lips, but he refuses to reciprocate it. ‘Kyor, you’ve got to listen to sense when it comes to Benny and Jonas. At least let me speak to them before you start making any rash plans. Please?’

He lets out a sigh. ‘Fine, no killing them … yet. But you need to get control of this power. Know what you can and can’t do, when you should and shouldn’t use it. When we get back to Wrohelm, that’s the only training you and I are doing.’

My smile twitches again. ‘You know, it sounds as if you like telling me what to do.’ I plant a kiss on his neck, lowering my chest so that it’s flush against him. ‘I’m sure we can think of a far more fun way of putting that commanding attitude of yours to use.’

He huffs out a laugh. ‘I thought you needed more rest.’

‘Well, maybe this time you could do a bit more of the work?’

Mock horror registers on his face and in one sweeping motion, he stands up, with me still wrapped around his waist. With a wicked grin and a glint

in his eyes, he throws me onto the bed and follows me down.

‘Oh, I am more than happy to do all the work …’ He growls, sending a static ripple straight between my thighs, but before my body can respond, my attention is stolen by the scars on his arm.

It’s not the first time I’ve noticed this particular set of scars, which are far paler and clearly edged than many he has, but this time I am drawn to them. There’s something about the thickness of the lines and the way their curves perfectly match the contours of his skin that makes them look almost organic in creation.

‘How did you get these ones?’ I ask, running a finger along the skin.

‘Really, Thorn, that’s what you want to talk about now?’

‘If you don’t want to tell me, you don’t have to. I’ve just never seen scars quite like them before.’

He draws in a long breath as he shifts slightly and lies down next to me.

A slow silence builds around us, but I don’t press it. No scars come without pain and sometimes the memories are almost too raw to confront. I feel he’ll tell me about their origin when he’s ready.

‘My father.’ His eyes are fixed on the ceiling as he speaks, his fingers combing lazily through my hair. ‘He considered it a strengthening exercise. He would ignite a fire on his palm and hold it against my skin. The more I screamed, the longer I had to endure it.’

‘Kyor!’ My hand flies to my mouth. ‘That’s torture. No parent should do that to their child. Hell, no human should do that to anyone. Ever.’

He shrugs as though I can’t see the pain radiating from the memory. ‘It was only for a few years. Once my powers came in, I told him it was only fair that I see how a king fared in a similar test. Suddenly he didn’t seem so keen to use that particular training method.’

Tears sting my eyes. All that wealth. All that luxury. All that darkness hidden beneath the gilding. For all the pain our father’s neglect caused Kay and me, not once did I fear he would physically hurt us. With my heart heavy, I press my hand against Kyor’s cheek and tilt his head to look at me.

‘I am so sorry you went through that,’ I whisper.

‘Others have gone through far worse.’

‘That doesn’t make it right.’

For a long while we lie there in silence, my head rising and falling to the rhythm of his breath, until finally his lips find mine again. The kisses are softer than before, with tenderness in every touch, and yet once again I

find my body pressing closer and closer. Needing that intimacy. And from the way his hands start grazing my body, I'm not the only one.

'Again already, my love?' he whispers.

A stream of static brushes my chest and my eyes roll to the back of my head as I anticipate what's about to happen, but before I can draw his head down to me, a horn blares out somewhere in the distance. His head twists to the window and he peers out.

He grimaces. 'That's the ship back to the mainland. Which means we need to get moving.'

'Can't we just see if there's another one coming in a couple of days?' I groan, only for Kyor to let out a laugh that hits me right in the chest.

'Don't worry. We'll pick this up later.'

With his hand on my forearms, he hoists me up to sitting as I let out an exaggerated sigh. 'I just wish we could take this bed with us.'

'Don't worry. We won't be sleeping in the barracks forever.'

I get that the comment is meant to make me feel happy, but instead, it causes a bolt of nervousness to churn in my belly. What is going to happen to us when this ends? Jonas assured me that Kay and I wouldn't have to go back to the slums, and Morwenna has offered us a home here – and with Benny as the future duke of this place a future in the Eastern Isles is a promising one – but that option would take me away from all we've known, not to mention away from Kyor. And given that Jonas's proposal was made when he still thought there was a chance for him and me, the offer could well be retracted now. I shake the thoughts away. That's not a question I have the capacity to wonder about right now. In fact, I don't have the capacity for much.

'I'll head straight to the library when we get back. See if I can find some books on whatever this is that's happening to me,' I tell Kyor as we head outside and towards the dock. 'I've no idea where I'll start though. Not with how big the place is.'

A new nervousness fills me. It would certainly help if Caroline was in the library to help with my research, but I still don't know if she's ready to face me.

The thought of Wrohelm also causes another pang of disappointment. With the post-trial ball having been held here in Brandish, there was no chance to see Kay, meaning the next time she and I will be together is when this thing is over. Hopefully that will give her time to realise there was

nothing I could do when it came to Holden, that I honestly tried to let him go. His death was in his own hands.

‘You okay?’ Kyor asks, my silence clearly more conspicuous than I realised.

‘I was just thinking about Kay. I wish they’d let us see other people now and then. Do they really think that me seeing my baby sister will somehow jeopardise the trials?’

Kyor shrugs. ‘It sucks, but it’s another way to test your dedication to the gifting, I guess. But Acacia will know you’re okay. Every person in the High Hold who’s placed a bet against you has lost it, so your continued success will be all anyone is talking about.’

I can’t help but laugh. ‘You mean, they all thought I’d be dead by now?’ I ask, feigning shock.

He kisses the top of my head. ‘Yes and more fool them.’ He steps back so he can take my hands and look me in the eye. ‘I know it’s hard, but we’re in this together, right? At least we have each other. And lots of privacy in the barracks now, too.’

I grin. ‘That is a good thing,’ I say, pushing myself up onto my tiptoes to kiss him.

The ship is probably a hundred times bigger than the rowboat we came across on, and thankfully, there is no sign of a kraken in the water as we cast off.

Benny and Jonas are on the deck, staring out at the view.

Leaving Kyor a little way back, I go and offer Benny a deep hug. ‘How are you doing?’ I ask him.

‘Good. It was good to see everyone. Reminds me what I’m fighting for, you know?’

I nod, though the truth is I still don’t know what it is he – or any of the others – are here for. And now, more than ever, that lack of knowledge is unnerving. Just like Kay said at the beginning of this, everyone thinks they’re worthy of Etta’s gift, and as Kyor pointed out, it’s each person for themselves now that we’re at the Ofur, meaning maybe I should be a little more sparing with my trust. Though the way Benny beams at me makes it nearly impossible.

‘Well, I think it’s safe to say that every person on the island is happy that you’re okay now,’ Benny says. ‘Those storms were definitely starting to piss people off.’

‘There were storms while I was out?’

I’m frowning, still not sure what the weather has to do with me until Benny’s gaze shifts across to Kyor, and it clicks.

‘You mean …’

‘Let’s just say they had an unusually greenish hue …’ Jonas replies.

A spasm of warmth flickers inside me. He told me he was terrified, but it’s different to know there was physical evidence of it.

‘I’m also very glad to see you’re all right, Rose,’ Jonas says. There’s a strange formality to his tone and when I go to hug him, his body is unusually rigid. ‘Just one more trial to get through.’

‘Right?’

I know from the look Benny gives me that he can feel the tension too, but I’m not exactly sure what I can do about it. A boat is hardly the most practical place for a private conversation, assuming that’s even what Jonas wants, as the other four remaining Rettlings are here too. Along with Zara and Grenda, the other two who made it to the Ofur are Moryal and Del, the two behemoth men from Galreck.

My mind shifts to the last trial and specifically to Seiren. I pray she didn’t die trying to seize a boat.

With Jonas being so standoffish, I quickly head back to Kyor, though we don’t speak much. Instead, we simply stand there, his arms wrapped around me as I gaze out at the water. When the mainland comes into view, my stomach twists. The weight of it all presses down, and I know that no matter what happens at the end of this, life will never be the same as before, but wasn’t that what I wanted? Deep down, I know whatever future awaits us has to be better than life in the slums, but the unknown is nerve-wracking all the same.

‘Can you see that?’ Benny comes over to us when we’re still a fair way from the shore. ‘It looks like they’re waiting for us.’

‘A welcoming committee, you mean?’ My heart lifts at the thought that I might get to see Kay after all. But the hope fades as Benny shakes his head.

‘No, I don’t think so. I think it’s just priestesses.’

A knot binds my ribs as Kyor and I exchange a look.

I sigh. ‘They can’t be doing this again so soon. There’s no way.’

‘We’re not ready for the Ofur.’ Kyor frowns. ‘You’re barely recovered.’

‘No, it’s not possible,’ Jonas joins in. ‘Every Retterheld recorded has been across four moons. We’ve only just finished the third cycle. It should be at least another week, if not two.’

‘Well, someone ought to tell them that then.’ Benny gestures to the shore where I can now make out the blue robes of the priestesses, even if I can’t see their faces. And I know exactly which priestess he’s talking about when he adds, ‘Is it just me, or does she also freak the fuck out of you all?’

None of us reply. We don’t need to.

High Priestess Mila waits on the dock and my eyes go to her belt, to the dagger that is still at her side.

‘Is it me, or does something about this feel dodgy?’ Benny asks. ‘Dodgier than usual,’ he amends.

‘It’s not just you,’ I reply.

‘Just stay close.’ Kyor takes my hand, his comment solely for me. ‘And not because I think you need me, but—’

‘I know,’ I say. The fact is, I also want to hold his hand. There’s a quiver in the air, creating a sense of unease.

Not a single person speaks as we disembark, and Mila waits until we’re all standing on the dock before she speaks.

‘Rettlings, I am grateful to see your safe return. Etta has blessed you indeed. But I am afraid I have bad news. During the previous trial, there was a gross violation of the Retterheld rules.’

A cold like iron threads through my blood. She knows, I think in a panic. She knows that I used the ice powers that somehow hide in the shadows of my veins. Issen powers.

She knows I’m the reason the kraken escaped. I am going to die for this, and from the way Kyor’s hand is now clenching mine, he’s thinking the same.

‘As is customary when such things happen, I have sought Etta’s guidance, for I myself believed that the only suitable punishment was death.’

My knees feel weak. Have I survived a drowning by kraken only to be put to the sword now? The confirmation of my worst fear is enough to steal any strength I had. I can’t breathe. This isn’t happening. Killed, not in the trials, but for this? Something I have no control over?

‘I’m not going to let anything happen to you,’ Kyor growls beside me. ‘If they—’

‘But,’ Mila continues loudly, glaring at Kyor, ‘in this particular circumstance, Etta has chosen to make an exception.’

She steps forward. ‘Prince Kyor Knavin, you are hereby disqualified from the trials for attacking, injuring, and showing wilful disrespect towards the priestesses of Etta.’

It feels like the air has been ripped from my lungs. They’re going to take Kyor? For his lightning strike? I should be relieved it’s not my neck on the line, that my secret is safe, but this can’t be happening. I need him.

‘No.’ I lurch forward, my arms in front of him. ‘It wasn’t his fault. He only did that because—’

‘It’s fine, Thorn.’ His voice cuts across mine. ‘I used my powers to break the ward on the kraken. I will accept my punishment.’ He leans in as if to kiss my cheek, but instead he whispers, ‘It’ll be okay. I promise you. I’ll be waiting for you. Just get control of those damn powers and win the Ofur. The gifting is yours. Fucking own it, Thorn.’

Before I can reply, he disappears.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 66

I stare at the spot where Kyor stood only seconds ago. *Fucking portation.*

Jonas appears at my side, seemingly attempting to fill the void left by Kyor, but he can't. No one can. 'It's okay,' he says. 'He should have known what he was doing.'

I glare. 'He did! He didn't hit them. Not a single one of them,' I hiss.

Jonas opens his mouth as if he's going to say more, but I can feel the daggers I shoot from my eyes, and thankfully, he stays quiet. My heart hurts – physically hurts, as if it's been knifed by an icy blade of my own creation. The words I said to him in bed this morning replay in my mind. *'Take me like this is all we get.'* That's what I told him. Why in the Gods' names did I say something that stupid? Something I didn't for one second believe could be true. I should have known the Gods listen to it all.

On the other side of the dock, Grenda offers me a look of consolation, but it's Zara who speaks.

'Well, I for one am feeling very optimistic about the Ofur.' A smirk curls her mouth. 'Particularly after that unexpected outcome.'

'Fuck off, Zara,' I say, but Benny and Jonas grab me before I can launch myself at her.

'Oh, look at that. More big men coming to your aid, ensuring you don't ever have to fight for yourself, *runt*.'

I know she's just trying to rile me, and I hate that it's working.

'Fuck you! You have no idea what I'm capable of,' I snarl, lifting my hands, no longer surprised by the buzzing energy that courses through them. The power trembles through my veins, begging to be released.

‘The fact is you’re down to just two guard dogs now,’ she sneers. ‘This is going to be fun.’

‘I am going to kill you,’ I say through gritted teeth. ‘I am going to kill you just the way I killed Oke. Not that you cared. You didn’t even bother waiting to find out if your friends were still alive before demanding to be allowed to return to the barracks.’

The words leave my mouth before I can stop them, and her eyes widen in shock. Though in a flash, it transforms into fury.

‘You bitch,’ she says, ready to lunge at me, exactly the way I want her to. The fear of exposing myself is suddenly forgotten. All that matters is tearing Zara apart, however I can.

‘That’s enough!’

Grenda’s voice cuts through the tension as Zara continues to snarl at me, but that’s all she’s doing. It takes a heartbeat to realise that’s all I’m doing, too. And not because I’m waiting for her to strike first. I physically can’t move.

My arms are frozen in clenched fists and for an instant I think it’s my powers; that they’re manifesting again out here in front of all these people. The fear I suppressed before is suddenly laid bare as my heart lunges up into my throat, but then I realise Zara is in exactly the same state. She wants to come for me. She just can’t.

Well, now I know what Grenda’s power is. No wonder she’s such a force to be reckoned with. It’s not like anyone can fight back if they’re frozen in place. It’s magnificent in its deadliness. Even more so when I consider its strength was likely significant enough to hold a jötunn in place.

‘Let’s make no mistake,’ she says, her voice a low grumble. ‘I could drive a sword through both of you before you could even blink. But I’m not going to.’

She looks at Zara first. ‘You want this. You have fought your way to get here, and while I may not agree with the methods you’ve used at times, I understand that fierce drive.’ She turns her attention to me. ‘I will not lie, I did not expect you to make it this far, but having seen you against the jötunn – not to mention the manner in which you put yourself at risk in the water – I do not doubt that you are deserving. And it has nothing to do with who you choose to share your bed with.’ The belated addition somewhat sours the compliment. ‘I am a woman of honour. Beyond this event, I have

never taken a life outside of battle. But make no mistake, I will happily change that if needed. Now, are you two going to play nice?'

I try to respond, but it's impossible. I guess even my vocal cords are being held by her power, and judging from the silent rage emanating from Zara, she's in the same situation.

'Very good,' Grenda continues. 'Zara, I'm going to let you go first. And if you don't walk straight to your carriage, I will take that as a personal insult.' She pauses. 'I do not respond well to being insulted.'

Zara is released, still practically foaming at the mouth, and I see her contemplate her options, weighing whether or not to strike. A large part of me hopes she will, because Grenda will easily take her down. But she knows it too, so instead she offers one last snarl before walking towards the carriage.

A moment later, I too am free, though unlike Zara, I do not move immediately for the carriages.

'She will not forget this,' I warn the old knight. 'You've made yourself a target.'

Grenda smiles softly, and I'm reminded of Dinah. The same gentle calmness of the knight also radiates from the priestess.

A surge of guilt floods through me at the way I whined about not being able to see Kay at the ball. The only moments Grenda has had with her family were before she was snatched away from her son in the forest. And yet I have never heard her offer so much as a single grumble or word of complaint.

'We all have a target on our backs when it comes to that one.' She shrugs. 'It will be Etta's judgement that decides the rest. I will see you back at the barracks.'

With that, she heads towards her own transport home. I turn to Benny and Jonas. 'Now that the drama's over, want to share a carriage?' I ask.

'Sure,' Benny replies. 'Though this is you we're talking about, Kultavaris. There'll always be drama involved.'

I'm surprised that I have it in me to laugh, but a slight chuckle leaves me before my eyes fall on Jonas. There's not a hint of humour in his expression at all.

'Actually, I thought I might take one by myself. You know, stretch out, get some sleep. Some of us spent most of the last three days awake. Worrying.'

‘Oh, okay.’ I’m not sure why my chest feels quite so tight. Maybe it’s because this is the start of it. The start of the end. Of each of us looking out for ourselves. Maybe it’s something else. Either way, I step back and turn to Benny.

‘Guess it’s just you and me then.’



I SLEEP during the carriage ride, but it’s fitful. My body feels too warm, though I don’t know if it’s the lingering effects of the water or the absence of Kyor. Maybe it’s the guilt. I killed Oke, I handed Llinos a glass of poison, and now my suggestion got Kyor kicked out of the Retterheld. Yes, I’ve got more than my fair share of guilt.

My restless state is enough for Benny to notice.

‘You want to bunk in with me tonight?’ he asks as we trundle over rocky terrain. ‘In a purely platonic way, obviously. The last thing this group can deal with is a love triangle becoming a love quadrilateral, and to be fair, you probably wouldn’t be my first choice out of the trio of possibilities.’

I wouldn’t have thought it possible, but he actually manages to raise a smile on my lips. I thump him lightly on the arm. ‘Yeah, I’ll pass on the love quad, thanks.’

He chuckles, but it fades quickly. ‘It would probably be best for you to bunk back with me though. With Zara on a rampage against you, you shouldn’t be on your own at night.’

‘It’s fine, honestly. I’ll be safe.’

I think about Kyor’s room. About him and me alone in there. Will they have made him clear out his belongings, I wonder. What about his drawings, his charcoal? It’s been four days since he slept there. Will the scent remain, even if the bedclothes are gone? Gods, I hope so. A flicker of hope ignites within me. He’s used the room long before the Retterheld, so maybe, like Caroline, he could sneak in through the library and temple to find me. But then, the Prince of Morathka is a much more identifiable figure than one stray scribe.

‘Okay, well, stay close, okay?’ Benny breaks my stream of thoughts. ‘You might not have your prince, but I reckon I make a pretty good knight.’

‘You do,’ I agree. ‘And I suspect a pretty good future duke, too. I guess that explains why the others all followed your lead the whole time.’

I lean my head on his shoulder, expecting him to offer some joking remark about his lineage, but instead, he sits upright. ‘Jeez, Rose, you’re freezing.’ He slips off his coat. ‘Put this on.’

I try to shrug it away. ‘Honestly, I don’t need it.’

‘You do. For me? If you get hypothermia, that’ll be the end of the relationship between Wrohelm and the Eastern Isles for good. Which isn’t necessarily a bad thing, except I’m pretty sure Kyor would come for my head. So please, Rose, take the fur.’

I do as he asks and shift up my own stole so that it sits under my head as a pillow.



AT FIRST, I think it’s Kyor gently rocking me awake, ready to bring my body to climax the same way he did last time I woke up. But as the shroud of sleep lifts and I blink open my eyes, I see Benny standing there instead. The memory of what happened hits like a stone dropping in my stomach.

No Kyor. No Llinos. No Kay.

I thought I was motivated before I came into this. It’s nothing compared to now. I am determined to win this. Determined and exhausted. And hungry.

As we climb out of the carriage, we head to the dining hall to see Jonas already leaving, his hands full of baked goods.

‘Are you not going to sit down?’ I ask him, gesturing to our table. It’s stupid that it’s still the only table I want to sit at given that it’s right at the end of the hall and there are so many others completely empty, but I’m not ready to let go of the memories that live with it.

‘No,’ Jonas says stiffly, shaking his head. ‘My legs are soft from sitting so long on the boat, and then in the carriage. I’m going to stretch my legs in the battle yard.’

‘Give me five minutes and I’ll join you,’ Benny replies.

‘No offence, but I could do with a bit of time by myself,’ Jonas says with a flatness that leaves no room for argument. ‘Just … you know, the whole paired thing is over now. We need to focus on solo skills.’

‘Well, that’s me told,’ Benny mutters, rolling his eyes as Jonas begins to walk away.

‘I’ll spar with you later,’ I offer. ‘I’m going to sleep for a bit, and then I need to head to the library.’

‘Really? Why?’ Jonas stops in his tracks six feet away from us and turns back, his eyes fixing on mine. For a reason I can’t fathom, I feel the cold fill my palms. I assumed the iciness I felt from him earlier was a residual reaction to Kyor and me being together, but now I’m not so sure. ‘What do you need the library for?’

My throat feels as though it’s wedged shut. Still, I try not to show it, speaking as casually as I can. ‘To speak to Caroline,’ I lie. ‘I saw Llinos’s family, remember?’

His eyes linger on mine, his lips twisting as though he’s trying to pull more information out of me by his gaze alone. And then, without warning, he sniffs. ‘Right. Of course. Well, I’ll leave you two to your food,’ he says, then turns around and leaves.

This time, Benny waits until Jonas is fully out of earshot before he speaks. ‘I never realised that being involved in a trial for ultimate power would involve such complex love lives. They kind of left that bit out of the history books, don’t you think?’

This time, when I hit him, I make sure it hurts.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 67

Thank the Gods, the room still smells of Kyor. I lie on the bed and bury my head in the pillow, drinking in the faint whisper of him in the fabric before sitting up and moving to the desk where his drawings remain scattered. I've never looked through them before. I've wanted to, but he's never offered to show me. Now, though, he's not here for me to ask him permission, and I'll do anything that gives me a chance to feel closer to him.

The top drawing is of Zelle, fighting through a storm. Water drips from the old man's beard, but even in the monochromatic shades of charcoal, I can tell the storm is of Kyor's making; there's just something about the way the clouds streak across the sky. The commander holds his sword arm raised as if he's about to strike, and a playful grin twists his lips, the type he almost solely reserved for fighting with Kyor. Is it a real memory or just a representation of how they felt when they used to train together? It's impossible to know, but it doesn't change the feeling that emanates from the page. One of respect. Of loss. Of a mentor – a father – sadly missed.

Beneath the drawing of Zelle, there are two of Elska: one of her prowling through the forest, the other of her face alone. Once again, he's captured the two colours of her eyes in nothing but tones of black and grey, but it's her body that I can't draw my eyes away from. The way he's shaded her so that her white paws fade into the white of the paper is utterly masterful. A prince, a fighter, a protector, an artist. I have to wonder if there's anything this man can't do. I lift the papers and begin to flick through them, stopping on a drawing of me. Me asleep in his bed, hair splayed across my face, arm folded up over my head. I should look a mess,

yet somehow, the way he's captured me, I look, well … beautiful. As I stare at my own image, my heart burns beneath my ribs. I suspect he drew it while he was avoiding lying too close to me, trying to be a gentleman. I was so angry at him at the time. Angry at him for not wanting me the way I wanted him. But this … this shows just how wrong I was. Even I can see that. See the yearning in his lines. I want to crush the paper to my chest, but instead I lay it back down reverently.

I flick through several more images – some of buildings, some of weapons and animals – until I reach another person. Or rather, two people. It's one of the smallest pictures, and yet the level of detail in it easily surpasses the rest. It looks as though Kyor came back to work on this one time and time again.

The woman is sitting in a comfortable-looking chair, with a book on her lap and a child at her feet. The child has a pencil in his hands and is scribbling on a piece of paper. There's no sign of a crown or even a ballgown on the adult, no hint of palace luxuries in the background, and yet I know exactly who I'm staring at: Kyor and his mother, the son and the mourned queen.

It's a perfect portrait. The ease with which she sits. The light smile that traces the curve of her jaw. And while there's no visible interaction between the two of them, you can feel the connection they share just being in each other's presence.

I didn't know it was possible for a picture to show so much love, and yet here it is …

With a burst of guilt at invading Kyor's privacy, I grab the papers, wishing to straighten up the pile. In my hurry, one of them drops to the ground.

As I pick it up, a cold chill runs down my spine.

It's me. Me standing in the temple, dressed in my rags from the slums. If the picture with his mother is the epitome of peace and love, then this captures pain and rage. My face is harsh, and pure hatred jets out of my eyes. It stabs me to my core, knowing that this was how I looked to him in our first meeting after so long. He knew my identity even then, and though that hatred wasn't there then, when I didn't know his name or who he really was, it came, and he was right to anticipate it.

Tears leak down my cheeks and guilt hollows out my stomach. I press the heels of my hands to my eyes to stem the tears, and I wish to all the

Gods that I'd told him that I love him. That I'd said the words aloud. If I die in the Ofur, and he doesn't even know…

I sniff back the tears. Any thought of sleep I had is gone.

He's still here, I remind myself. Still alive and safer than he was in the Retterheld. I should be grateful that he is no longer part of this, but it's not that straightforward, and not just because I wish he was still with me.

He might be safe, but I'm not. I know these powers are growing stronger; I can feel them changing and shifting, and I have no idea how to control them. It was one thing back when my green magic came through. That was expected and I had my mother to guide me. But this … this is magic I know nothing about, appearing at a time when I should have nothing. I suddenly feel piercingly alone.

I need something to do, and the library seems like the perfect distraction.



WHEN I REACH THE TEMPLE, I stand in the middle of the aisle, shifting my gaze between the altars of the seven Gods. It seems like the right time to pray … but to which one? I'm hoping that perhaps one will speak to me, though any sign would be useful, but in the end, there's nothing. And so I thank them all, finishing with Etta and Aitara before descending the steps to the library.

I wonder whether Caroline will even be there. Even without seeing her I know she won't be okay. Hell, I'm certainly not. But hey, misery likes company, right?

I'm still on the second step when a voice echoes through from the depths of the library.

'No, I told you already, Sanrott himself was encapsulated in stone! Not just his power, but the very God! Why would you just write, "Sanrott's power"?'

'Sorry, I'll make that amendment now.'

Caroline's response to Rohan is tired. Weary. As if her spark has gone. Though I can't exactly blame her. The fact that she's still able to cope with Rohan's ranting at all … well, it's more than I could take. Knowing she's

there, I move even more slowly, still not sure if I'm going to approach her. Yet, as if she's able to sense my presence, she turns to look at me.

'I'm sorry, Rohan'—she stands and pushes her chair back—'I'm going to have to finish now.'

'Now? But we've already been interrupted once today!'

'This bit about Sanrott sounds like a part of the tale we need a whole session for, not just the end of one,' Caroline replies diplomatically.

I can tell from the scowl on Rohan's face that he's not having it.

'I would think you'd have better grace than to refer to my family's legacy as a tale, and I've got half a mind to—'

'Time's up, Rohan,' she snaps sharply. 'If you want to find another scribe that'll work with you, then good luck. We're done for today.'

My jaw drops. This is definitely a side of Caroline I've not seen before. I wait for Rohan to put up more of an objection, but instead he merely mutters to himself as he grabs his cane and ambles off.

'I'll see you tomorrow, Rohan,' Caroline calls after him as he disappears between the shelves, no doubt regretting her sharp tone.

Only when all we can hear are his footsteps and the clicking of his cane does she turn to me.

'Congratulations,' she says dully. That's it. A single word.

My skin prickles. 'Congratulations?'

'On surviving the fourth trial. I heard it was touch and go.'

'Right. Yeah.'

Her shoulders are stiff. Her face is expressionless. 'I heard it was an interesting turnout for the prince, too. The rumour mill is having a field day with it. Not to mention the bookies. He was everyone's favourite.'

'Right.'

'I take it you and he are … something.'

Something. I can't immediately think of a better word to sum up what Kyor and I are, but then again, the last thing I expected when coming here was to talk about him.

'Yes … listen, I saw Llin's mother, Morwenna, on the island. Met Carys, too.'

For the first time, Caroline's facade flickers and pain flashes in her eyes. 'I assume you're here because you want something. After all, that's the only time you turn up, isn't it? So what do you want, Rose?'

It’s a direct hit and the words cut like a knife in the windpipe because of how true they are.

‘You’re right, I shouldn’t’ve come. I’m sorry. I’ll find it myself.’

I twist away from her to stare at the maze of books. I have no idea where to start.

‘I don’t want to blame you, you know,’ Caroline whispers as I start to walk away. ‘I know you didn’t do it deliberately. That you didn’t know the drink was poisoned. But I can’t help it. I can’t help wishing it was you instead.’

I freeze, vision blurring, and look back at her. ‘You’re not the only one who wishes that, Caroline. I promise you.’

Her breath hitches and she shakes her head. ‘I’m sorry. That was cruel of me.’

‘It was justified,’ I murmur.

‘No, it wasn’t. You loved her too.’

‘Not in the same way.’

‘No, but you still loved her.’ She glances up at the ceiling as she wipes away the tears, then looks at me as she inhales again. ‘So what do you need?’

I’m still torn. She wasn’t wrong when she said I only come here when I need something, and I’d hate for her to think that’s all I want this friendship for – for how she can help me. She and Benny are the last fragments of my best friend that I have. But without her help, I’m at a complete loss.

‘Okay, so the latest trial was getting around a kraken.’ I watch her closely. She doesn’t look surprised by this.

‘I heard. That’s crazy.’

‘Right. Well, I was just wondering if you have any books about them. About krakens. Or perhaps the people who could communicate with them. Whether that’s a traditional magic thing, or I don’t know … maybe something other people in other kingdoms can do?’ I try to sound as casual as possible.

Benny would be able to read the lie straight away, and even Llinos wouldn’t have been quick to believe me, but Caroline is wearing an expression I can’t read.

‘Well, turns out there is a book about it,’ she says. ‘But I only know that because someone else found it. Someone else who was looking for exactly the same thing you are.’

‘Somebody else?’

Chills run down my neck only to spread into a warmth of relief. Kyor, I think. Kyor must have got to it first. He said he’d help me in whatever way he could, and he is.

I clear my throat, trying to keep my pulse steady. ‘Who wanted it?’

She nods towards the back of the room, implying I need to turn around. My heart stutters at the thought of seeing Kyor again so soon, and somewhere we can actually have something close to privacy without breaking any rules. Only as my eyes fall on the figure does the fluttering turn into a heavy weight that sinks to the pit of my stomach.

‘Me.’ Jonas steps out of the shadow, his focus narrowed on me. ‘I’m the one who wanted it.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 68

I feel sick. Physically nauseous. Jonas is my friend. Wasn't I trying to convince Kyor only this morning that we could trust him? Then again, that was before Jonas's comment about working on our solo skills. He's out for himself now, and I guess that includes doing whatever it takes to get rid of the competition.

'Jonas.' I try to keep my voice steady. 'Whatever it is you think you know, it's not what you think.'

'Is that right? Well, I'll tell you now, I've got a fair few suspicions,' he says. 'Suspicions I'm pretty sure I can find the answers to in here. Unless you want to save me the trouble?'

He steps forward. There's a thick tome in his arms and a single vein is raised and pulsing across his forehead. Out of the corner of my eye, I see Caroline slink away. I assume it's because she thinks we want privacy. Part of me wants to call out to her to stay. But maybe the fewer witnesses, the better.

'Is this the power you used to kill Oke, too?' he asks. 'You didn't take your dagger with you to the lake. You left it in the dining hall. Did you use magic to kill her?' He lowers his voice. 'Issen magic?'

I don't answer – I can't – and he takes my silence as agreement.

With a sharp inhale, he takes a step towards me. 'Rose, whatever is going on with you, if anybody finds this out, you are dead. You know that.'

My eyes jerk up to meet his. 'Of course I do! But I don't know what *this* is. I need time to work it out.'

'You don't get time here. Remember? There are no second chances. You, of all people, should know that. Think of your mother. Your father.'

There’s a clattering from somewhere deeper in the library, and I drop my voice to a whispering hiss. ‘What would you have me do, then? Would you have me turn myself in for powers I don’t even understand?’

‘No, of course not.’ That vein is still protruding from his forehead, though it’s not pulsing quite so much anymore.

‘Then what, Jonas?’

He looks at me for a moment, his cheeks drawing inwards. He sets the book down. ‘Marry me,’ he says. ‘I’ll protect you and make sure people don’t find out. Marry me, Rose.’

I gape at him. He has to be joking. And yet his expression is deadly serious.

‘What the hell are you on about?’ A disbelieving laugh cracks from my lungs. ‘You can’t be serious.’

‘It makes sense,’ he says, taking my hands. ‘It’s the only thing you can do. If we’re married, you’ll be back to being a member of the court. Acacia, too. Once that happens, we can move somewhere. Away from Wrohelm. Maybe Benny could get us a place on one of the smaller Eastern Isles. Somewhere quiet.’

My laughter may have stopped, but the disbelief remains. He wants me to run away and hide for the rest of my life. ‘Jonas, I’m not going to marry you. I … I can’t. I love Kyor.’

It’s the first time I’ve said the words aloud, to anyone, and it feels wrong. They should be reserved for Kyor alone.

Jonas is unfazed by my confession. ‘Whatever you believe you feel, it’s almost certainly due to the stress of the situation, Rose. Some weird coping mechanism to make all the suffering here seem normal. Believe me when I say that’s not what love should be.’

I grit my teeth, fighting the urge to spit at him.

‘Kyor is the prince,’ Jonas continues. ‘And you are … whatever you are, Rose. Please think about this sensibly. I’m not denying your feelings for him. I’m not. I’m sure there’s something there for you, and maybe it’s even reciprocated. But at some point, he’s going to have to be king. King of the whole of Morathka. Sworn to protect his subjects from the Issen. What’s going to happen if he finds out? When he realises the truth, he will have to put you to death, Rose. You know that.’

I try to hold my gaze steady – try not to give anything away – but as my lips press together, a look of disbelief dawns on Jonas’s face.

‘He knows. Gods, he already knows.’ He shakes his head as he tugs his beard. When he looks back at me, his resolve has returned. ‘That doesn’t change anything. It doesn’t. You marry me, and I’ll do whatever it takes to keep you safe. You know I will. We can go wherever you want. Take Acacia and William—’

I frown. Something about the way he says William’s name is off. ‘Why would we take your father’s ward?’

He combs his fingers back through his beard again. ‘He’s a brother to me,’ he says. ‘I won’t leave him behind. I’m just thinking through all of the logistics. Thinking through how it would work. What other choice do you have?’

‘I have the choice of winning the Retterheld.’ The words leave my mouth with utter conviction – the same conviction I felt all those months ago when I first entered Etta’s temple to give my offering. There’s no denying that my conviction has wavered at times since, that I even doubted my chances, but I don’t anymore. Etta let me in for a reason. And that’s to win this thing.

I stand there, back straight, with my eyes narrowed on Jonas, only for him to tut like I’m a small, incapable child rather than someone who has survived four fucking deadly trials. Someone who dragged him off the ice to safety in the third trial and convinced Kyor to save his life in the fourth. My hackles rise.

‘Even now. Even after all the times *I’ve* had to save *you*, you still don’t think I can do it. You still think I’m just some weak, powerless little girl.’

The slightest flush of embarrassment colours his cheeks, but it does nothing to douse the fury I’m feeling.

‘It’s the best of the best left, Rose. It’s not about you. You saw what Grenda’s capable of, and Zara wants you dead. She’ll put a sword through your stomach the instant the Ofur begins.’

‘I can do it. I know I can.’

‘And then what?’ His tone is so sharp it’s like being struck with tiny shards of glass. ‘You think you can just win, get your powers back, and then pretend like none of this ever happened?’

‘Yes. That’s exactly what I plan on doing.’

With a noise that could be a scoff or a laugh, he lifts his hands to his head. ‘That is insane, Rose. Do you even know how to control these new powers of yours? Or what you’re capable of? Because I know you, and I’m

willing to bet that however you killed Oke, it wasn't what you wanted to do, what you intended to do. It was the magic that did it. Not you.'

Pain claws through me as I bite the inside of my cheek. I don't know what I hate more about this conversation: the fact that he thinks he has the right to speak to me like this, or that almost everything he's saying is spot on.

'Please, Jonas. Let it go. We're not having this conversation here. It's stupid and dangerous.' I pause. 'Please don't mention this magic to anyone.'

'I won't. You know I won't, Rose.'

I turn to go, but he catches me by the hand. Any anger that was in his eyes has now transformed into outright desperation.

'Think about it. Please, Rose. It would keep you safe. And it's not like you didn't feel something for me before. You know, before he came along. We can rekindle it, the flame between us.'

There it is. The hurt. The jealousy. The fact that he thinks it should be him I'm with. As he continues to stare into my eyes, with all his vulnerability right there for me to see, the smallest fraction of my anger ebbs away.

'Jonas, I love you as a friend. I always have. But as for it turning into something more … I guess we'll never know now.' I look down, mainly because I can't bear to look at his face any longer, and my gaze lands on the book he's holding. 'I promise I'll tell you whatever I find,' I say, taking it from him. He lets me. 'I'll see you at training later.' I walk back towards the staircase, and when I reach the bottom step, he calls my name again, the crack of urgency in his voice stopping me in my tracks.

'I would be able to protect you as a husband, Rose. I can't promise the same if I'm just your friend.'

I shake my head as I release a bitter laugh. 'If you're trying to blackmail me into marrying you, I think that's a pretty sure sign you were never my friend in the first place.'

I don't look back again.



I FIND Benny in the battle yard, staring intently at Grenda.

'This is training?' I ask him.

He starts to nod his head, only for the motion to turn into a shake, accompanied by a groan.

‘She has to have a tell. Something she does that will give us a chance to block her. If we can’t, then the rest of us don’t stand a chance. She could just freeze us all and leave us there until she’s finished the Ofur and won the Retterheld. The problem is that she isn’t using her bloody magic, so I can’t see if there’s a tell or not.’

Right now, Grenda is fighting Moryal and Del simultaneously, and they’re giving her a serious workout. I’ve seen her feet slip on the sand more than once, and she’s come precariously close to not blocking a couple of strikes. Strikes I’m not convinced they would’ve pulled, not if it gave them the chance to take her out of the running.

‘As far as I can tell, the only thing any of us have got on her is stamina,’ Benny tells me. ‘She’s the oldest left, so if it’s a five-day Ofur, we might stand a chance.’

‘A five-day trial? I think I’ll throw in the towel now,’ I groan.

He laughs, but it fades as he looks at me properly. A crinkle forms between his brows.

‘You okay?’ he asks. ‘You look like shit.’

‘Just what every woman wants to hear,’ I huff. I clear my throat. ‘Actually, any chance you and I can have a chat later? Maybe up in my old room.’

His eyebrows bob. ‘It must be serious if you want us to risk the death-trap stairs.’

‘If you can’t manage the stairs, you’re going to be screwed when it comes to the Ofur.’

‘Good point. After dinner?’

‘Perfect.’

~

SEVERAL HOURS LATER, I’m sitting on the ash-covered sheets of my old bed, having told Benny everything. Unlike with Jonas, where I was vague about what happened on the ice with Oke, I didn’t hide anything – from the way the ice radiated from my hand and killed her, to the way I froze the water to stop myself from plunging to an icy death. I even tell him about the way

Kyor was trying to help me train it, and the times I've felt the tingle of power buzz beneath the surface of my palm. With that covered, I move on to Jonas and his offer, or rather threat, of marriage.

'Fucking arsehole,' Benny mutters. The two words are all I need to assure me I made the right choice in telling him. 'That's a hell of a lot to deal with, Rosey. How are you feeling now?'

'Scared,' I admit.

'Of the powers, or the fact that Lorathin is so desperate to get into your pants he'd blackmail you?'

I grimace.

Thankfully, Benny fills the silence. 'What do you need from me? How can I help?'

Benny's simple offer of solidarity is everything, and I close my eyes as an all-too-familiar heat burns behind them. I never used to be a crier, and now it feels like it's all I do.

'I don't know.' I reach out and squeeze his hand gratefully. 'I got this book from the library and was going to see if it could help, but I don't even know what's in it yet.'

'Shall I have a look? I'm pretty good at skim-reading.'

He takes the book and flicks it open, but rather than looking at the page, he continues to stare at me.

'My grandmother, the Dowager, used to say,' he begins. 'Well, I can't remember exactly how she put it … but basically, when she was training me and my brother, and we got frustrated that our powers weren't working the way we wanted them to, she would say that everyone's powers can turn up when they're scared or angry. But if they show themselves when you're feeling safe, that's how you know you'll be able to control them. She used to tell us to chase that safe feeling – the feeling of home.'

'I like the sentiment,' I tell him. 'But there's one big problem. Exactly how many times have you felt safe since you got accepted to the Retterheld?'

'Good point,' he concedes with a half grin. 'Let's look through the book.'

Benny's fingers start flicking through the pages like he's riffling through a deck of cards, and I can't help but laugh.

'You know, the point is to read the pages, not just flick past them.'

‘I am,’ he says, rolling his eyes. ‘My magical sight is handy for more than just spotting tells.’

I draw in a long breath as jealous understanding dawns. ‘You could read an entire library in a week.’

‘Three,’ he tells me. ‘That’s how long it took me to get through the ones in Brandish, anyway.’

‘Wow.’

He grins. ‘It has its uses. But on the battlefield, people don’t really care about reading speed, so my talents are disparaged.’

‘That’s a mistake,’ I murmur.

He grins. ‘I know, but let’s not tell my enemies, hmm? It’s useful to be woefully underestimated.’

I mime buttoning up my lips.

I thought I knew all about Benny’s powers, but there’s so much more to magic than what you see on the outside.

The smile on his lips fades as he scratches the side of his cheek, and I can tell there’s something he wants to talk to me about, but I’ve no idea why he’d be having difficulty saying it.

‘Do you really trust him?’ he asks finally.

‘Kyor? Yes,’ I say without hesitation. ‘He’s known about me since it happened, and he’s not said a word to anyone. I know he made some mistakes when he was younger, but he wants to put them right.’

Benny’s only reaction is a single nod. ‘Okay, next question: do you think he’ll be a good king?’

I shrug. ‘Honestly, I don’t know. But I know he’ll try to be. Is that the same thing?’

‘Maybe,’ he says wistfully, offering me another smile.

‘Sorry, but there’s nothing in here that sounds like what you’ve been able to do. No creating ice or talking to krakens. Seems like you’re even more special than we thought, Rosey.’

My disappointment is palpable. Still, I go to thank Benny for his help, only for my words to get lost in a yawn.

‘Maybe it’s time we head to bed?’ he suggests.

‘It’s probably a good idea,’ I agree, rising to my feet. ‘See you at breakfast in the morning.’

‘See you at breakfast.’

~

GIVEN that I'm now a familiar face to the kitchen staff, there's no real need for me to go upstairs for breakfast, other than the fact that I don't want to leave Benny on his own. However, five minutes after tucking into my pastries, I thoroughly regret my decision.

'Any chance one of these seats is free?' Jonas asks.

Given that the only reason they are is because our friends are dead, I don't bother smiling at his attempt at a joke.

'I think you'll find there are plenty of other seats,' Benny says. 'Might even find one or two where you're welcome.'

'Benny, it's fine,' I say. 'If this is where he wants to sit, then I'm not going to stop him. I'd hate him to feel pressured to do something he really doesn't want to do.'

My less-than-subtle dig hits exactly as I hoped it would, and Jonas inhales stiffly.

'How much did you tell him?' Jonas asks, nodding at Benny.

'Everything,' Benny replies for me. 'She told me every part. And guess what, I didn't try to blackmail her because of it, because that's not what friends do.'

'I wasn't blackmailing her,' Jonas hisses back as he sits down. 'I w*as* trying to *help* her. Long term. My proposal would keep her safe.'

'Well, your proposal sucked. And it sounds to me like you were trying to get one over on the prince by, well, literally getting one *over* on Rose.'

'This stops now, guys,' I say, looking at them both. 'We can't do this. The only reason we've got this far is because we've worked together. All of us. I don't care that only one of us can win. We're not going to end this thing by tearing each other apart. Not after everything we've been through.' I turn to Jonas and lock my eyes with his. 'It may have escaped your memory, but the only reason you're still here is because Benny and I went back onto the ice to get you to the end of the third trial.'

'Not to mention Rose saved our arses against that kraken. Otherwise, neither of us would be here,' Benny interjects.

I shoot him a quick smile. While I'm grateful for his support, there's still more I've got to say to Jonas.

'Jonas, I know, or at least I *hope*, that what you said to me yesterday was purely out of concern.'

‘It was—’

‘I’m not done. As I said, I’m sure it came from a place of concern, and I *am* grateful that you worry about me. Truly. But like I’ve been saying since the beginning of the Retterheld, either I deserve to be here, deserve to earn the gifting, or I don’t. It was *my* decision to enter. *My* decisions that got me this far. If you don’t want to work together anymore, I understand, I really do, but if you do want our help, you don’t get to dictate to me anymore. That’s not how friendship works. And if you can’t honour that, then I guess I got it right yesterday, and there was never friendship here at all.’

He exhales. ‘I know we’ve worked together this far, but now it’s the Ofur, the final task, where only one person can be gifted. That’s the whole point of the competition. I’m not going to turn on you, Rose, I promise that, but I think we should make an agreement now that this is where we stop actively helping each other. It’s the right thing to do.’

Benny looks at me. ‘Yep, do *not* accept the proposal.’ He turns his attention back to Jonas. ‘Of the people who die in the Ofur, eighty percent of them are killed by *other Rettlings*, not by the trial itself. You *know* that, right?’

Jonas grits his teeth. ‘Yes, I know that.’

‘So why the hell would you *not* want to work together?’

‘Because I want the gifting!’ Jonas nearly shouts. ‘If we work together, then how do we decide who gets it? We can’t, and that’s the truth.’ His chair scrapes against the floor as he stands up. ‘I can’t keep going around in circles with this. You two do whatever you want to do. But I’m out.’

His footsteps echo across the dining hall as he marches outside and towards the battle yard.

‘You know, there was actually a time when I thought that guy *was* hot,’ Benny mutters. ‘I really do have shit taste in men.’

‘You really do. I’m going back down to the kitchens,’ I say, standing. ‘Catch you later.’

With Jonas heading out to train, I decide to go back to Kyor’s room. It’s not that I don’t feel safe – with so few of us left, Roderick has no issue siphoning everyone’s powers at once, meaning Zara can’t strike me with her magic. No, the reason I don’t want to train is something else entirely. I don’t admit as much to Benny, but the magic I used in the fourth trial took more out of me than I expected, and I’m still worn around the edges. I could do with at least another hour of sleep.

Given how few of us there are to feed, I expect the kitchen to be empty. But instead, Leilah is still there.

‘Rose,’ she says. ‘Everything all right?’

She offers me a sad smile. It’s pretty much the only expression she’s offered me since telling me that the plans to get food out to the slums didn’t work. Of course I had to pick the ball when the rebels attacked to arrange my gift. She’s tried again since then, but apparently it’s been impossible to get permission for carriages to move between here and the slums. Clearly Korvane thinks the rebels all came from there.

‘Yes. Yes,’ I tell her. ‘Everything’s fine.’

‘Good. I kept a couple of extra pastries for you.’ She gestures to a plate by her side. It’s piled high, the same way she always did for Kyor.

‘Thank you, that’s very kind. But you should take them. I had plenty.’

‘Oh, I think you’ll want at least one of these. Why don’t you take a look?’

Intrigued, I look more closely at the plate of pastries and see the envelope folded beneath the delicacies.

Leilah smiles at me. ‘I should get going. Won’t be long until the lunch shift starts.’

‘Thank you,’ I murmur. Picking up the plate, I head into Kyor’s room. Once I’m alone, I set the plate down and snatch up the envelope.

My name, written in Kyor’s strong hand, is enough to make my heart clench. His penmanship leaves a little to be desired – given his artistic talent, I expected whorls and flourishes – but even so, the way the letters loop reminds me of the way his hands curved around me when he slept. Yes, I’ve got it bad.

THORN,

You’ve always had more strength in you than you realise. Don’t doubt it now. Do whatever it takes – fight, claw, endure – but above all, stay safe.

You’ve got this. I’ll be waiting when you win.

Yours always,

K

YOURS ALWAYS. My eyes hold fast on the words.

Right now I don’t know if I have days, weeks, or months left in the Retterheld, or if my death will come in the Ofur or from having this forbidden magic running through my veins.

But none of it matters. Because Kyor is offering me always.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 69

We're all carrying our weapons at all times now, strapped to our bodies so we're ready for the Ofur even if it's called during meals or while we sleep. I even held my dagger between my teeth while I had my last bath, which had to be at least four days ago now.

As I hauled myself out of the tub and wrapped a towel around me, it struck me that, should the priestesses choose that precise moment to summon us to the next location, the dagger would be of little use if I was buck naked. So that was it. I stopped bathing. It's only been once that we were taken without warning, but it's not a chance I wish to risk.

The lack of cleanliness is hardly pleasant, especially not with all the training I'm doing, but judging from the grime that covers the other six remaining Rettlings, I'm not the only one taking this approach. I'm actually grateful that Kyor is no longer here with me. I'm not sure how long the attraction would last if we both smelt like rotten vegetables.

Still, at least my daggers are small. Benny's sleeping each night with a sword strapped to his back, though I can't imagine how the hell he's doing it or how he hasn't pierced his skin in the process. But it's what works for him.

As for Jonas … I don't know what he's doing. I can't avoid seeing him entirely, but he's no longer sitting with Benny and me at meals. Instead, he's chosen to sit on his own. At least it's not just us he doesn't want to team up with.

Despite all our fears over potentially being jerked awake in the middle of the night, unprepared and yet expected to fight, the chimes for the Ofur instead arrive close to midday, when all seven of us are out in the battle yard. Roderick's the only other person there, and judging by the shock on his face, he didn't know this was going to happen. The instant the first chime rings out, a long trail of priestesses appears through the gate. One after another they walk in ceremonial pomp, with Mila at the front.

'How many of them are there?' Benny's muttering mirrors my own thoughts.

These can't just be the priestesses from Wrohelm, even with all the rings included. There must be closer to two hundred of them. I scan through the faces as they enter, trying to see if Dinah is among them, but if she is, I can't spot her.

Mila waits until they have formed a closed loop around us before she speaks.

'Rettlings,' she says. 'Welcome. You've successfully made it thus far in the Retterheld, and the next time we meet, one of you will have met with the Great Etta herself and received her gifting. The rest of you, may you take the Goddess's blessing from here and beyond into the rest of your lives. If you survive the Ofur, that is.' She smiles as though she isn't talking casually of our deaths.

I glance at Benny, fighting the urge to reach out and take his hand, but see his arm already stretching out to me. But before our hands can touch, my stomach hollows and my vision blurs as dizziness takes hold. It feels like the floor's fallen out from beneath me the same way it did when we were portated before. The air shudders as I try to catch my breath, and a moment later, we're standing in a thick mist.

It's impossible to tell where we've been taken, and it's fucking freezing. When we were on the lake I could see a little way on either side of me, but here the fog is so dense it's opaque, and I can barely see my hand in front of my face, let alone anyone else.

'Where are we?'

It's Zara who speaks first, though it's impossible to work out where she's standing. With the way her voice echoes, it sounds as though it's bouncing off the side of a mountain.

'Benny!' I call out, and then, because old habits die hard, 'Jonas?'

'Here.'

‘I’m all good.’

I take a tentative step forward only to remember the way that the carriages previously dropped us precariously close to a cliff edge. If my first suspicion about being on a mountainside is correct, then even a tiny misstep could be deadly. I edge back to where I was and consider what to do next.

Mist is water, suspended. Can I freeze it? If I can, that’ll hopefully clear the air a little. I raise my hand, unsure what I’m about to do, when a voice cuts through the quiet.

‘Moryal? A little help here would be great.’

It’s Del who speaks, and a moment later, he gets his wish. The blast of air from the Galreck wind weaver has me struggling to stay upright, but it does the job. The mist clears ahead, and we can finally see where we’ve been brought.

My jaw hangs loose.

I’m not sure whether I’m proud that I was right or not, because I’m too busy being terrified. We are standing on a plateau about halfway up a mountain. I’ve no idea where exactly, though from its size, I guess it would have to be part of the Coltan Mountains, right at the very north of Morathkian territory. From the blue light emanating from the peak, my assumption is that we have to get to the top to win the Retterheld.

As I move my gaze from the peak, I see I’m not the only one gawking. Del’s jaw is clicking from side to side as he visibly thinks through what we’ve got to do next, while Benny is a little further away, taking it all in. It’s only as I turn to see Zara that a gasp leaves my lungs. Unlike everybody else, she’s not looking at where she has to go. Instead, her sword is out and she’s heading straight towards Grenda, who stands oblivious, with her back to her.

‘Grenda!’ I scream out as I lunge towards Zara, but I already know I’m not going to be fast enough. Before I can get another sound out, the tip of Zara’s sword protrudes from Grenda’s stomach.

In one swift sweep, Zara pulls it back out and Grenda’s body crumples to the ground. Blood pours onto the pristine white snow as the air rushes from my lungs. Moryal covers his mouth in shock as Benny and Jonas both look on in horror. We’ve all seen death before in this competition. But like this? It was an assassination, pure and simple.

‘I needed to get there before that bitch had a chance to freeze us all and win this thing,’ Zara snarls. ‘There’s a new top dog, people, and soon’—she smirks—‘I’ll be the only dog.’

‘You are a fucking bitch!’ I agree.

‘Rose!’ Jonas screams at me, but Zara isn’t coming for me yet. Instead, she’s sunk her powers into Moryal, and his leg collapses beneath him. He must have broken his leg at some point in one of the trials, and now he’s suffering all that pain again.

‘Del!’ he yells out. ‘Help me!’

The other Galreckian turns his head and purses his lips, but he doesn’t move.

‘Del! We’re a team. You promised! I literally just helped you!’

‘Side with me and I’ll let you survive this,’ Zara barks at Del. He doesn’t need to think for long. Rather than helping his friend, he turns on his heel and starts to walk away.

‘What the fuck!’ Moryal sweeps out with his power. Even in his pained state, he pummels the air with a wind that knocks us off our feet, though from the way Del flies six feet across the plateau, he definitely got the worst of it.

‘We need to get out of here,’ Benny says, grabbing my hand. In the fracas, I didn’t even realise he’d closed the distance between us. ‘There’s a cave over there. That’s where we need to go.’

I assumed we needed to climb the outside of the mountain, but I trust Benny’s magical sight way more than my random guesses. He was right about the jötnar, and he’ll be right about this. Together, we pound the ground towards the cave.

Jonas is hot on our heels, though when I cast a glance backward, my attention shifts to Del. He’s back on his feet, fighting off Moryal who is having to split his powers between fending off Zara and trying to knock his former friend off the edge of the plateau.

‘Shit!’ Zara shrieks. The only way she’s going to stop Moryal is by getting up close with a blade the way she did with Grenda. But with the strength of that wind, she doesn’t stand a chance. ‘Fuck it. You’re not going to beat me now,’ she says, leaving the two Galreckians to fight among themselves and chasing after us instead.

‘Tell me you and Jonas didn’t get any crazy injuries in the last trial that I don’t know about,’ I gasp between panting breaths as I follow Benny into

the cave.

‘I didn’t. But I don’t know about—’

‘Fuck!’ Jonas yells behind us.

I stop in my tracks and turn to find him clutching his ribs. As he casts his gaze into the cave, his eyes catch mine.

‘I’m fine. You worry about yourself. Go.’

I know I should do what he tells me to, and after the way he’s spoken to me over the last few days – or rather not spoken to me – I’d be well within my rights to leave him to Zara. But I can’t do that. With my heart racing so fast I can barely draw breath, I look at Benny.

‘It’ll be three against one,’ I say to him.

Benny’s jaw juts outwards. ‘Really?’

‘I have to,’ I tell him. A moment later, I change direction and head out of the cave, back towards Jonas and Zara.

‘Why haven’t you blinded her!’ My voice catches with incredulity as Zara continues to stride towards us, clear-eyed with perfect vision.

‘I-I can’t …’ Jonas stutters. ‘I mean, I haven’t … I haven’t since, since …’

Since Kestria. That’s what he can’t say. He hasn’t used his powers since he blinded her in the third trial. No wonder he’s been so focused on training in the yard these last few weeks. He’s afraid to use his magic.

‘Jonas, if you can’t do this, we’re fucked. Zara will rip our old injuries open, and she’ll easily kill Benny and me while we’re in agony.’

‘Run,’ Jonas tells me miserably. ‘At least if you run, you’ll stand a chance. Rose, I’m sorry. I’m so sorry—’

He gasps then lets out an agonised moan. Another broken rib, perhaps? I’m not going to waste time asking. Not when Zara is less than ten feet away. Yet before I can even draw my dagger, a welcome voice speaks behind me.

‘Did someone say three against one?’ Benny! If it wasn’t such an inappropriate time for it, I swear I’d hug him.

‘Llin would never have forgiven me if I’d left you,’ he says by way of explanation, and my desire to hug him only grows. But Zara’s got her sword out and is rolling her shoulders, limbering up.

‘If you want to use some of that magic of yours, now would be a great time,’ Benny suggests.

‘Right,’ I say, though I’m not exactly sure what I’m planning on doing. Make another ice blade? Stab it through her heart, the same way I did with Oke? I raise my hand, ready to use whatever it is the Gods have given me, only to be barrelled through from the side. Del. I was so focused on Zara that I didn’t even realise he was still in play. His strike knocks me off balance and sends me careening through the air. I land six feet from where I started, and I must have struck my head because my vision swims for a moment.

‘This is not how the trial is meant to work!’ My teeth grind together as I push myself up onto my feet. At this rate, we’re not even going to get into the mountain, let alone up it. I now don’t care how much of my powers I have to expose to Zara. She’s not going to live to tell anyone.

Come on, I urge myself. This is when it’s kicked in before, when I’m in danger. So where the fuck is it? A new sense of panic surges through me, but with it comes something else: the buzz of magic fizzing in my palms. It’s here. It’s going to save me. I push myself up, ready to attack, just as a strangled scream tears through the quiet.

‘Fuck!’

My heart ricochets off my ribs at the sight of Benny on the ground, Zara’s sword sticking out of his thigh, and Jonas on his knees, doing everything he can to stop Del from serving him with a deathly blow. I don’t know which of them I’m meant to go to – which of them I can help, if either.

But as Zara withdraws her blade, ready to strike again, I already know the answer. I will not lose another friend. Not a single one. Not today. The word rips from my lungs as power surges through me.

‘No!’

My scream echoes off the mountainside as a wall of ice appears in the middle of the plateau, every molecule of water held within the air now frozen solid. I’ve *created* a freaking ice wall that’s ten feet high and at least twice as long. A moment of disbelieving elation fills me before Benny’s moan reminds me of the situation.

Likely more the product of the Gods’ blessings than actual skill, the ice wall has separated us from our enemies. Zara and Del are on one side, and Benny, Jonas, and I are on the other. But the ice is thin. A couple of good strikes with a sword or Del’s shoulder and it’ll all come crashing down.

‘We need to go.’ Jonas scrambles to his feet. ‘Rose, we have to go now. Before she comes for us.’

‘I’m not leaving Benny.’

The sword struck his outer thigh, which is better than the inside, but the wound is still bleeding. Benny fumbles with his belt, trying to remove it to make a tourniquet, and I hurriedly help.

‘Rose, I’m not hanging around,’ Jonas snaps.

‘Then go!’ I yell back.

Hesitation flickers on his face before his features settle into hardness. ‘I’m sorry,’ he says. A moment later, he’s running into the cave.

‘You need to go too,’ Benny grunts as I manoeuvre his leg to get the belt around it. ‘You need to go now. I’m not going to die. I’ll bow out. Quit.’

I yank the tourniquet tight, wincing as he grits his teeth in pain. ‘Can you even do that?’ We have no idea what happened to the Rettlings who didn’t make it onto a boat. Or the ones in the second trial who didn’t get to their loved ones in time.

‘I don’t know,’ Benny replies truthfully. ‘But what I do know is that if Zara gets through that wall, the only reason she’ll let me live is if she doesn’t have time to waste on a fight. If you’re beating her, she’ll leave me. Please, if you want to save me, you need to do this. You need to go.’

My heart throbs at the thought of leaving him, but he’s right. I know he is. If Zara knows that Jonas and I are ahead of her, then catching up with us is going to be her only priority.

‘Go win this thing.’ He flashes a smile through the pain. ‘For Llin.’

‘For Llin,’ I repeat. ‘And for you.’

A moment later, I’m blinking back tears as I race into the cave, fighting the hollowness that tears me from the inside. For the first time since I arrived for the Retterheld all those months ago, I’m truly on my own. Benny, Llin, Kyor … there’s no one by my side.

Either I win this thing today or I die trying.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 70

I don't look behind me as I plunge into the mouth of the cave. My eyes sting, though whether it's from the cold, the pain, the overuse of my magic, or leaving Benny, I can't be sure. I just pray to the Gods he's right and that he won't die out here.

Not after getting this far.

A wind sweeps in from outside, bolstering me forward towards a lantern-lit open space. Steps. That's what I'm expecting to see. Thousands and thousands of steps that we have to climb to get to the top of this and meet Etta. Maybe there'll be ledges and precipices, a ridge to be manoeuvred, or a chasm to jump across. Anything to make the ascent as deadly as possible. As my feet draw to an abrupt stop and air wheezes through me, I know for certain that one part of my prediction was correct.

'You have to be kidding.'

Three carved stone staircases lead up and away from the floor of the cavern, disappearing into the darkness above me. My first task, it seems, is to choose which one to take. Not only is it a climb, but by the looks of things, it's also a freaking maze inside the mountain.

I stand in front of the central staircase. I'm assuming that the way to the top can be found through all of them, and maybe starting in the middle is the sensible option, but as I go to move, Kyor's voice echoes in my mind.

Aim to the left.

That was what he told me to do, that first night I spoke to him out in the battle yard, when I assumed he wanted to kill me and part of him probably did. He told me to aim for the left of the heart, the side that pumps blood around the body.

For fuck's sake, Rose, I chastise myself. This is not the time for emotion to get in the way, and if I make the wrong decision and have to come straight back down, I might find myself running directly into Zara.

Screw it, I say to myself, taking a single step towards the central staircase before changing my mind and taking the left-hand option instead.

'Here's hoping you're right, my love,' I whisper aloud.

As soon as I reach the first fork, there are once again three flat paths sprawling before me. Well, I was definitely right to assume this is a maze. Again, I go left, then left the next time, too. But then I reach my first dead end. As I prepare to turn back, I notice a faint shaft of light radiating down on me.

Surely I've got to go up, too? I've got to get to the top of a mountain, and other than the staircase at the beginning of the maze, everything has been flat.

With a deep breath in, I reach up, grabbing the slight edge protruding from the wall at the bottom of the shaft of light, and work my way up using my elbows and knees for leverage. Six feet later, I'm standing on the second floor of Gods know how many.

The vertical choices are even more frustrating than the left-right-centre decisions, mainly because there are a lot more of them. It feels like every few steps I take, I have to decide whether I should go up or keep going on the flat.

One shaft emits a particularly strong glow of light from its opening, so I start my ascent, confident that such intensity must be because it's coming from the next floor. But after ten feet of scrambling up, I discover the glow comes from a lamp fixed to the side of the stone wall.

With a groan of frustration, I shimmy myself back down and try again. I have to climb three different shafts before I finally find the right one to lead me to the next level, whereas the third takes only two, but on the fourth floor, I must try close to a dozen before one finally grants me access upwards.

How many floors are in a mountain? That's a piece-of-string question if ever I've heard one. And from the varying heights I've had to climb between each one, I have no idea of the exact distance between them. Twenty feet, fifty feet, a hundred?

My arms are already feeling heavy, but it's not as though I've got another choice besides moving forward, other than to stay here until

someone else wins this thing and the priestesses portate me out.

The thought of Zara winning is more than enough to propel me forward. There has never been anyone less deserving of a gift from the Goddess of Life than that cold-hearted psychopath.

At some point during my climbs, my stomach began to growl. Quietly at first, then louder, and more and more frequently. I must have been in here for hours, but gauging time without a hint of sunlight is impossible. The light within the maze has clearly been designed to test us, alternating between near darkness and lamps with such intensity I'm forced to squint and cover my eyes.

I don't know what number shaft I'm going up or what floor I'm hoping it will take me to when I hear a scream rattling through the darkness. My muscles clench as my body turns rigid. Was it Zara? It sounded more female than male, but who knows? There's nothing to say it was even human. I remain there for a minute, catching my breath as my arms and legs burn from the brace position I'm holding myself in. But no other sound comes.

I have been climbing up this one passage for over twenty minutes and I'm starting to think I made the wrong choice because there's nothing but pure darkness above me. But as I raise my hand to adjust my hold, my fingers find the lip of an opening.

As I haul myself up, the darkness remains. My stomach somersaults. So now, not only do I have to find the right route in the dark, but I've also got to make sure I don't slip down the shaft I just climbed. Fucking perfect.

I wonder if my magic can somehow make light, and I raise my hand, willing the buzzing to my fingertips and visualising a light forming in front of me.

But there's nothing. Not a hint.

'It was worth a try,' I mutter to myself, disheartened.

Other than that single scream, the only other sounds I hear are quiet scratches and scrapings, like rats in the gutters of the slums, and I assume it's one of the remaining Rettlings moving up and down the shafts, like me. I'd far prefer to bump into a horde of rats than Zara, or even Jonas at this point.

The growls of my stomach have become sharp pangs, while my throat is so dry from thirst that even swallowing causes pain to throb up and around my skull. I can't believe there's any skin left on my palms or shins from all

the shimmying, and I'm trying not to think about the stabbing pain knifing in my knees that gets worse and worse with every jump. I've had to launch myself up to reach almost every shaft, and the pain of landing smack down again each time I've taken a wrong route is starting to take its toll. But the physicality of this challenge is only part of it. It's the mental torment, too.

Etta is testing us. Our resolve. In the darkness, we have a total inability to know if we're getting any closer to our goal or where our fellow competitors are. With each wrong turn, the urge to break down, to scream or at least rest, gets stronger and stronger, yet each time I fight it.

Neither Jonas's nor Zara's powers will be of any good to them here, and I'm willing to bet that I'm better at climbing, meaning at least any mistakes I make in the tunnels should be quicker to recover from than theirs.

Luck. Luck is the only thing that would mean one of them would get there before me. Luck and the Gods' favour, that is.

As I weave my way back and forth around twists and turns, I contemplate which magics would actually help in this situation. I can't imagine that my original green-weaving would have been beneficial at all. Unless there are seeds hidden in the rocks that could grow into trellises for me to climb. That would have been something. Maybe Llin could've used her wind weaving to work out which of the shafts opened up into another level, but I'm not even sure if that's something she could've done. I doubt Benny's powers would've been of any use either, unless he can somehow *see* the correct path, even in all of this darkness.

I guess being a light weaver could have saved a lot of time, but other than that I can't think of whose magic I'd want in this situation. Not Grenda's, not Jai's. Even Kyor's powers would be of little help.

Could Del be breaking down the walls wherever he is in the maze? The obscene strength his magic gives him certainly makes him strong enough. It wouldn't be the brightest thing to do – lest he bring the whole cave system down on his head – but desperation can make people do strange things. Isn't that why I'm here?

My body is busy as I climb, and my mind whirs just as frantically as I think about the remaining Rettlings and how they may be doing. Height is the only advantage I can see Jonas and Del having over me, yet some of the shafts are so narrow that the men's broadness could be an issue.

It's on another wrong turn that I notice the pathways have also narrowed. I don't know if it's been gradual or just a change on this floor,

but they’re definitely narrower than when I started, which means I’ve got to be getting higher. The knowledge spurs me forward and up into the next shaft, which leads into a dimly lit chamber. It’s the most open space I’ve encountered since the plateau.

Adrenaline floods through my veins. I’m nearing the end. I know I am. And the fact that the trial hasn’t ended means that no one else has won yet either. This is mine. I know it’s going to be mine.

My body’s trembling, and for once, it’s not with fear. The only issue is that I’ve got no idea where I’m supposed to go next. There are a couple of narrow passageways leading off the chamber, and given it’s a maze, taking one of them is probably a good idea. But instead, I turn around, taking in the space around me. Why would they have left an area like this, so different to everything else, if there wasn’t a purpose for it?

I scan the gloom-filled area, only to notice a thin strip of illuminated motes dancing lazily in the air. I cast my gaze upwards and the fluttering excitement of before reignites. It’s another shaft, and there’s light coming through it. But given that light has tricked me before, I know it doesn’t necessarily mean anything, and it could easily be another red herring. Carrying on with the maze is likely the most sensible thing to do … only there’s something about the colour. The bluish hue is the same tone as the light I saw at the top of the mountain.

My footsteps echo around me as I head towards the nearest wall, continuing to stare at the gap above me. Unlike the other shafts I’ve climbed, jumping up won’t get me within reach of the opening of this one. I’ve got to climb up to it first.

It doesn’t matter how fast I want to go. I take it steady, making sure I’m secure before reaching for each new handhold or foothold. When I reach the shaft and look up, my breath leaves me in a quiver. It’s going to be the longest climb by far, and my limbs already ache with every breath I take. I can feel them trembling, but I know that one misstep, one missed hold, and there will be no coming back from the fall.

My muscles are clenched the entire time I climb, anticipating the moment when it all comes to an end. When I’m whisked back to the barracks, the High Hold, or wherever they take those who haven’t won the Retterheld. Maybe the slums for me.

With each inch I traverse upwards, my excitement grows, but so does my fear. A second’s difference, that’s all it takes between winning and

losing. And though I get a little comfort from not being able to see any of the other Rettlings above me, I know that there is more than one way up the mountain. Maybe one of the flat routes led to a nice, easy set of stairs. Maybe I'm straining every limb while Zara is strolling.

I grit my teeth and push the thought down. I won't let her defeat me now, not even in the confines of my own mind.

The higher I climb, the brighter the blue light becomes. It's not just a shimmering haze anymore; now it's illuminating the rocks, fiercely bright but not blinding. And the light isn't the only change. The air is thinner here. Crisper, cooler, and laced with something that takes me a moment to place. Magic.

Magic is thick in the air.

I'm nearly there. I know I am.

I reach upwards, only to stretch a little too far. My hand slips, my shoulders go with it, and with a cry of fear and force, I slam my foot into the rock. My toes crunch with the impact and tears burn through my eyes. I don't know which bone is broken, though I know at least one is, but I'm balanced and stable for now.

As my panting breaths slowly calm, I force myself to continue up, biting down against the pain in my foot. My wrists are exhausted – the strain on them has been constant – and if this isn't the last shaft, I'm going to have to give myself a rest before I tackle the next one. The thought of another one makes me want to cry, but I steel myself and continue on.

When I'm a foot from the top of the shaft, my heart leaps. I've made it. I know I have. I'm at the top.

I scramble up the last few inches – no finesse, no skills, no energy – and I'm entirely spent as I pull myself over the edge. I want nothing more than to collapse onto my knees, but I don't. Instead, I look up … and my heart falters at the sight of a familiar face staring down at me.

'Dinah?' Tears prick my eyes.

In her blue robe with the blue stone gleaming at the centre of her forehead, she is every bit the priestess I know and love. Yet as I clamour up onto my feet, desperate to hold her – or for her to hold me – I stop. There's something about her eyes that is different. The paleness of them. The depths of her pupils.

Awe rips through me. It's not Dinah at all.

‘Great Goddess.’ I drop to my knees, bowing my head low. Why did I not see it sooner? To stare at a God? Surely that is a crime. But she must know I meant no disrespect by it.

I lift my head, just an inch, ready to give my apologies, but before I can voice my pleas, another voice speaks. One that is familiar and coated with its usual disdain.

‘Well, slum rat, you took your sweet time, didn’t you? Never mind, there’s still time enough for me to end you.’

My body freezes, fear and disbelief pinning me to the spot. It can’t be. It just can’t.

Zara.

Zara got here first. After all I’ve endured, all I’ve lost, Zara has fucking won the gifting.

And now, she’s going to kill me.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 71

No. No, I can't accept it. I *won't* accept it.

All the people we've lost, all those actually deserving of this gift, and *she's* here? The person who has disregarded the very thing the Goddess of Life stands for at every turn? It's absurd.

It's as though my heart has been wrenched from my chest, the pain of losing to Zara clamping around my lungs. I would accept losing to anyone else. Literally anyone else.

'You got here first …' The words stumble on my tongue.

'How very observant of you.' Zara is grinning from ear to ear. It's not her normal smirk; it's an actual grin, though it's still laced with her usual malevolence. 'What is it they call second place? Oh yes, first *loser*. How apt. You know, I always thought my brother would be at my side to see me win this, but at least I get the joy of you watching me receive my gift before I kill you.'

She's not joking. Of course she's not.

I try to block her out. Maybe the fact that she's here, that she's won, will be enough to end the trial. Perhaps I'll be sent back to wherever the magic chooses. I still expect her to come after me, of course, but at least that way I'll have a head start.

With her upper lip still curled in a snarl, she goes to say something more, but it is the Goddess who speaks instead.

'Welcome, child.'

The hairs rise on the back of my neck, and I know without a shred of doubt that she's talking solely to me. My knees buckle as though they've surrendered every ounce of their strength to her.

How I could ever have mistaken this figure for Dinah is a mystery. The air around the Goddess's body shimmers ever so subtly, and the depths of her pupils surpass any mortal man's or beast's. If I needed any more proof, it comes from her voice. It's an octave lower than the woman I know and lilting with an accent lost to time.

As I look at the deity encased in my friend's form, the Goddess tilts her head slightly to one side. The gesture reminds me of an owl, so much so that I half expect to see wings unfurl from her sides.

'Are you both ready?' she asks, straightening her neck.

'Ready?' Zara asks the same question that's on my tongue. 'What do you mean? I got here first. I've won.'

A flicker of a smile teases the Goddess's lips. 'The trial has not yet been completed.'

My heart leaps in my chest with such force that my entire body jolts. It's not over. Hope roars in my ears.

'No!' Zara slams her sword down against the stone like a petulant child mid-tantrum. Her face is red with fury. 'I was here first. I reached you first. That is the condition. I win the gifting.'

A flicker of anger flashes in the Goddess's eyes and Zara's redness pales.

A moment of silence swims around the cavern and then, without a clear reason why, both the deity's expression and the Rettling's objection are gone. It's almost as though an exchange has happened between the pair that I wasn't privy to.

'You were the first to arrive.' The voice that is not Dinah's echoes around us. 'I will agree to that. But that is all. Do you know why it's called a *gifting*? Why it is not a prize?'

'Because it is a gift from you alone, Great Goddess.' Zara's response makes me want to laugh. So *now* she remembers the need for deference? I wonder what she'll choose if she wins. A power to rival the Gods, perhaps? It wouldn't be beyond her arrogance.

'Gifts are given,' the Goddess continues, as though Zara never spoke. 'This one, to a person of *my* choosing. And I have not yet decided to whom I will gift it.'

That jolt hits my chest again, combined with a sharp spike in my pulse. That's twice she's said it now. Twice she's said it's not over.

'There's still a chance,' I breathe to myself. *There's still a chance.*

‘Yes,’ the Goddess says, turning to me, ‘there is.’

She can read my thoughts. While not entirely unexpected – it explains why Zara suddenly went quiet earlier – it’s still fucking scary.

I try as hard as I can to empty my mind, but it’s not exactly easy. Thankfully, the moment she starts talking again, I have more important things to focus on.

‘First, I must start by asking one thing of you.’ That deep tone rumbles through me. ‘Your answer will determine whether or not you may continue to fight for the gifting.’

A final challenge. A fight? Was that word a deliberate choice? Gods, I hope not. If Zara brings back all the pain I was in after the kraken – pain that could only be muted by paparvy seeds – I might as well offer myself up to her now.

‘Of course,’ Zara replies instantly. Her grin is back in play. ‘Whatever you want. Whatever it is, I *will* beat her.’

She shoots me a glare before turning back to the Goddess who steps forward. My skin prickles and it feels as though her entire attention is solely on me. And yet from the way Zara has stiffened, I expect she feels the same.

‘I must ask you to relinquish any powers you have to me.’

‘What?’ Zara’s eyes widen in an unspoken objection.

‘Are you refusing?’

I glance down at my feet. How the Goddess hasn’t killed Zara yet is beyond me. She has the patience of a saint. But I guess she knows more than I do. Especially if she can read our thoughts. Maybe the Rowell Rettling just keeps all the nice things in her head and speaks the rest. I doubt it, but who knows.

‘No, no,’ Zara replies hurriedly. ‘But what will happen when I win the gifting? Will it be returned to me, along with my gift?’

Again that wistful smile floats across the Goddess’s expression.

‘*If* you win’—her stress on the first word causes a flutter of gratitude within me—‘all of your powers will be returned to you, along with the gift you have requested.’

‘And if we lose?’ I ask.

‘Then you leave here powerless. Assuming the other allows you to live.’

That’s a no-brainer. Of course Zara’s not going to let me leave. Still, it doesn’t change my answer.

‘You can take my powers,’ I say. ‘They’re yours.’

Zara huffs behind me. ‘She’s got fuck-all to give.’ She eyes me. ‘Though how a slum rat managed to afford a fire bead and an ice bead is beyond me.’ A frown creases her forehead.

The Goddess ignores her. ‘Rose Kultavaris will cede her magic to me. Do you acquiesce to my request to do the same?’

Zara gapes. Though whether it’s at the possibility that I have magic or the Goddess’s use of big words that confuses her, it’s impossible to tell.

Still, she exhales and looks at the Goddess. ‘Yes. Take mine too.’

The instant the Goddess inhales, I brace myself for the pain. But it does nothing, and a scream runs through every line of my body as the magic I recently gained is ripped away, a burning agony filling me as my very essence is pulled apart.

Next to me, Zara screams out loud. Having never been stripped before, she couldn’t have known how much it would hurt.

When it’s over, Zara’s red hair has been stripped to white-blonde. She matches me now. A fellow outcast.

I once dreamed of all my enemies being stripped like me, yet now that the moment has come, I’m surprised to find no satisfaction, only weariness. Magic or not, nothing will change between us. There will be no kinship, no bonding over a shared pain. At this point, I’m pretty sure Zara has no empathy left, if she ever had any to begin with.

I watch her raise her hand, clearly trying to draw the pulse of magic to her palms. When her hand drops and a tear leaks down her cheek, I almost feel sorry for her. Almost. Then I picture Grenda, and any burgeoning sympathy dies.

‘Very good.’ The Goddess’s chest rises and falls. ‘Now we must wait.’ With that, she closes her eyes.

Standing in such a manner, she looks even more like Dinah than she did with her eyes open, and I can’t help but wonder whether my friend is still there, present within herself and watching this whole debacle.

A chill sweeps through me as I wonder whether the honour of allowing the Goddess to possess you is something that can only occur once. Will Dinah’s life leave when the Goddess does? I pray she wouldn’t be so cruel to one of her own priestesses.

As the minutes tick by, I find myself desperate to know who or what we’re waiting for, and from the way Zara is fiddling with her furs, she is too. But the Goddess says nothing.

In the silence, I take the time to observe my competitor a little closer, like Benny would. Zara is standing with her back propped against the wall. Like me, her arms are covered in scrapes and scratches, but there's also a long tear on the left leg of her trousers, which are soaked through with blood. Maybe she caught her leg on one of the jagged rock edges in the light shafts. Perhaps she's the one I heard scream.

A dull throb forms in the pit of my stomach. It doesn't matter how much of an arse Jonas was at the end, he still looked out for me at the start. Still felt enough for me to offer me marriage; a lifetime bound to me, with my forbidden powers and love for another man. The thought of Jonas lying dead or dying somewhere in the maze is enough to raise tears in my throat. They won't leave the others here, will they? I voice the question loudly in my mind, hoping the Goddess might hear and answer me. The priestesses will take the bodies of those who died, surely?

When no reply comes, my mind returns to my friends. To Benny. I pray to every God and Goddess that he hasn't frozen to death out there, waiting for us to finish. Yet it's hard not to think of his skin turning blue. His fingers black as frostbite claims them.

My mind is still rife with such images when a faint sound draws my attention. A scratching somewhere beneath me. That rat-like scraping. Only, it's not rats at all. I know it's not, just like I knew it wasn't them before. It's another Rettling in the tunnel, and given how things have unfolded since the Ofur began, there are only two options for who it might be: Del or Jonas. And no matter how ridiculous it is of me, I know which one I'm praying to see.

As the scratching gets louder, the tension claws at my insides. I hold my breath, offering silent prayers to the Goddess who stands in front of me. If she hears my desperate pleas, she doesn't show it. Her eyes remain closed, her face expressionless.

Only when a crown of sandy hair crests the opening do I let out a gasp.

'Jonas!'

While Zara scoffs as if disgusted by this new addition, I run over to the shaft he came through and offer him my hand. His weight is almost enough to pull me down, but somehow, I don't fall. Instead, I haul him up, grunting with effort until his feet finally find the flat ground. I wouldn't have thought it possible, but he looks even worse than I feel. Blood has dripped down his

cheeks and dyed his beard a reddish-brown, and one of his eyes is swollen shut. But he's alive. He's still alive.

'Rose.' His voice echoes all the relief I feel, yet as he goes to hug me, I gesture behind him.

His eyes flick first to Zara. He blanches. 'She's been stripped?'

But before I can answer, his eyes fall on Dinah and reverence washes over him.

'Is that …' Before I've even responded, he falls to his knees and offers the same words I did. 'Great Goddess.'

Dinah's eyes ping open, a smile lighting them. 'Welcome, child.'

It's exactly the same greeting she gave me. Does that mean Jonas has made it too? That she's going to take his powers and tell us all to fight?

Do I want that or not? Anything to prevent Zara from being gifted is a good thing in my mind, but what chance do I stand of winning against Jonas as well? And will I be able to fight with my friend, even if he's out of favour at this very second? As I contemplate the answers to my questions, the Goddess steps down from the rock on which she stands, then raises her hands, offering her palms up to the sky.

'Zara, Rose. Now the time has come for the last part of your trial.' Jonas *is* out of the running, then. That answers that question, but it also begs another: why did we need to wait for him to be here before Etta told us what the final part of the trial is?

It's with a sickening drop in my stomach that realisation comes.

A heartbeat later, the Goddess confirms it. 'Whichever one of you kills Jonas Lorathin will be victorious. You may begin.'

With that, she steps back.

Zara doesn't even bother waiting to see if I react. Instead, she lunges straight for Jonas. Her sword whistles as it cuts through the air, but the moment he blocks the strike he looks at me.

'Rose!' Jonas yells out. 'You can't let Zara kill me! You can't let her win! It has to be you. It has to be! Kill me quick!'

His words make me feel sick. He may have pissed me off on so many occasions, yet now – when it truly matters – he would throw away his life for me. For my success.

Jonas has his dagger, but the knuckles of his right hand are red raw, and I can tell from the way the vein bulges on his forehead that just gripping it properly is agonising.

Zara swings wildly at my would-be betrothed a second time. How she got that sword up some of the shafts, I've no idea, but it's clear she's struggling to hold it and balance her weight on that injured left leg.

Jonas sees it too and strikes out behind her knee. A good shot would have brought her down, but he's also tired and injured, and it makes his aim sloppy. She recovers and moves into her next strike before he's even rebalanced.

My own knuckles are white as I grip the hilt of my dagger, but I don't move to unsheathe it.

I don't know what to do.

Do I risk it all and help him, or do I kill my friend? As I will my feet to move, I'm suddenly aware of the cloaked figure closing in on me.

'You are not moving.' The Goddess's voice resonates all the way to my bones. 'Do you wish to give your gifting away?'

'You wish me to kill, here, in front of you, the Goddess of Life?' I shake my head bitterly, making my choice. 'He's my friend. I won't kill him, not even for you. Not even for the gifting. It's not right.'

'Would you have the same conviction if it was my brother Mortidem you were standing before?' she asks.

'If the God of Death wants death, then I doubt my personal desires would weigh very heavily.'

A sound almost like a chuckle rings out from her throat as I turn away. I'm sure there are a thousand different scriptures explaining the reasons I should never turn my back on a God, but unless I do something, I'm going to lose another of my friends. Jonas is struggling and still refusing to use his powers, and Zara is giving it all she's got.

'You need to use your magic!' I scream at Jonas. 'Use your magic. Blind her.'

His eyes dart to me and I see the panic within them, the fear of what he might do. It's clouding his judgement. Stopping him from understanding what will happen if he *doesn't*.

'She's going to kill you. For fuck's sake, Jonas. Don't be so fucking stupid!'

'You should know,' the Goddess murmurs in my thoughts, 'that Jonas has lied to you. Manipulated you. Some would say he deserves death, and that justice dictates you should be the one to give it to him.'

'This is the test,' I say as realisation dawns.

‘Are you certain, Rose Kultavaris?’

I swallow hard because if I’m wrong, I’ll lose it all. Yet the Goddess of Life cannot want this of me, surely?

I look again at Jonas. See the way his eyes keep darting to me. See Zara’s mouth foaming as she fights for his death. One of them will die here today, and objectively, there’s only one person I want that to be. Not the one who carried a blinded Rettling off a frozen lake so she would at least have a chance to live. No, it has to be the one who murdered runts for sport.

The air trembles in my lungs. I need to save Jonas because it’s the right fucking thing to do, and sometimes we have to do what’s right, even when it puts everything on the line. No, *especially* when it puts everything on the line.

I breathe in and step forward, my dagger raised.

A roar tears from Zara’s throat the instant she sees me, the sound more beast than woman. She lifts her sword in a clean arc and the steel sings as it cuts through the air. She is nothing but a fur, leather, and braided hair blur as she runs at Jonas.

Her blade is long enough that a single sweep would send him sprawling – or me should she decide to change targets. I have no shield and no reach, and the only weapons in my possession are daggers, so small they might as well be fingernails in comparison to her sword.

But if I can close the distance between us …

I don’t waste any more time. Instead, I run at her.

Zara’s strike splits the air where Jonas stood less than a heartbeat before, and he twists as best he can, pivoting to escape her blade.

I vault low, and the world narrows to the sound of my heart and the thudding of my boots on the hard earth. It’s loud enough for her to hear me coming for her.

Instantly, she decides I’m the bigger threat – or maybe it’s just the fact that killing me will be enough for her to win by default – and she turns to face me head-on.

‘Fuck you, Kultavaris.’

Unlike all the times I’ve seen her fight before, her sword now swings without finesse or control, rage getting the better of her. Yet she catches my shoulder with the flat of her blade all the same. Pain shoots up from the impact point, and my arm goes numb from the shock, but I roll with it,

dropping my weight and tangling my legs with hers in a move Kyor taught me. *Go in brutal and precise.*

Zara's taller, stronger, and her sword finds me twice more – once against my ribs, once along my thigh. Both wounds burn, but I can still move, still breathe. I use one of my throwing daggers. Given the nature of the previous trials, it feels like it's been too long since I had a chance to truly test my ability with the weapon, but the moment it leaves my hand, I know the throw is good. With brutal precision it strikes her in her sword hand. As a shocked gasp flies from her lungs, the weapon drops from her fingers and I kick it away.

'I can kill you with my bare hands!' she snarls, but I barely listen. She has tried to kill me time and time again, and yet here I am, a finalist in the Ofur.

And. She. Doesn't. Deserve. To. Win.

I slam into her, deliberately kicking that wounded leg. As she cries out in pain, satisfaction sparks within me. She's hurt and she's angry and I just got in another good hit. But I'm not getting complacent. Using my hands, I grab her shoulders, grappling and pushing her down as blood pours from the wound in her leg. I'm close enough to smell it.

Her knees bend, and I'm certain that any second they're going to buckle, but instead, she strikes out, kicking my feet from under me. The impact robs me of my breath, and that single moment is all she needs. She wraps her arm around my throat, pulling me down into her. As her knees drop, she squeezes tight, restricting the air that my lungs so desperately crave. Within seconds my head is swimming. She is choking me. Killing me. But it's not fast enough for her.

While her left arm continues to crush my airway, her other hand rakes my body for my dagger. But I know she won't find it. Because I already have it in my hand.

Perhaps it's the lack of air or maybe it's the Goddess's doing, but either way I feel my heartbeat slow, the surge of adrenaline replaced with the steadiness of certainty.

Now is the time I finally find out what Dinah's dagger will do. Reading through dusty tomes has left me none the wiser, but books don't always hold the answer. Sometimes you have to raise your head above the parapet and *do.*

Pulling in the deepest breath I can muster, I clutch Zara's forearm. It's hardly a lethal place to strike, but maybe I don't need a mortal blow, not if what happened at the inauguration vows was anything to go by. Picturing Jai and the way the blood gushed from that single wound in his hand, I slice the dagger right across that choking forearm.

Zara grunts in pain as the metal tears through the top layers of skin, but remarkably, her hold on me doesn't loosen. Fearing I misjudged the blade, I struggle to angle my neck down to look at the arm slowly killing me.

Tears prick my eyes as relief washes through me. It's not just a trickle of blood seeping from the small wound, but a torrent. It's pouring, gushing red and hot out of her arm and onto my fighting leathers.

'What?' Zara says, her voice now woozy. 'What have you done, you fucking *runt*?'

Her grip on me loosens only slightly, but it's enough for me to kick back and push her away from me. I scramble forward on my knees as I breathe deeply, gratefully choking in lungfuls of air. The dagger is warm in my hand, blood sticky between my fingers.

Once my head has stopped spinning, I slowly twist around and face her.

I should feel triumphant. I should feel relief. Instead, a hollowness opens under my ribs as I see the exact moment Zara's chest stills and her face slackens into something softer, a gentle expression that she never wore in life.

'Is she…?' Jonas whispers.

I swallow. 'Yeah.'

'You still have to kill me, Rose.' Jonas's voice trembles. 'That's what the Goddess said. The person who kills me will get the gifting.'

A smile curls my lips. 'I don't think I do. Do I, Goddess?'

My heart flutters as I hold my breath, and for the first time since I laid eyes on her, the Goddess's mouth turns upwards and a glinting smile enhances those abyssal eyes.

'No, you do not. It is yours,' she says in a voice that doesn't belong with Dinah's body. 'Rose Kultavaris, the gifting is yours.'

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 72

I should be feeling elated, but a strange numbness fills me instead. I fear it's not over, that there's still a sting in the tail to come.

Zara thought she had won, too. She reached the Goddess first, the way we thought we had to do to win this. Now she's lying dead on the ground, her blood seeping into the worn stones beneath her.

'Why me?' I ask the only question I can. 'Why, when Zara reached you first?'

Dinah's lips don't move as the voice echoes in my head. 'I am the Goddess of Life, and she had no respect for that.'

'But she won,' I argue aloud.

'No, she completed the trials and arrived here first.' The Goddess's voice is melodic and patient. 'Some Rettlings use the trials to grow, and I hoped she would be one to do so. Pain, loss, community – they can bring out the best in so many. But in others, they only deepen the darkness. She turned away from love and friendship at every stage, every opportunity. She is one who has spent a life of being, not living. I will not gift the unworthy.'

I tried more than once to be civil to Zara. If she had reciprocated, would it be her standing here instead of me? Quite possibly. The thought chills me. My compassion could truly have led to my downfall, just like Kyor warned me.

'Has this happened before?' I ask curiously. 'Have there been others who reached you first but did not win?'

Her smile rises on one side, with a definite coyness to it. 'The correct person has always won,' is all she says.

The smile remains fixed, and I know she's given me all the answers I'm going to get. It shouldn't surprise me. The Retterheld is ultimately about worthiness. And the fact that the Goddess finds *me* worthy …

As I stand there, struggling to believe what is happening, I sense movement behind me. Jonas is on his knees, looking at me. Tears fill his eyes, but are they because he's pleased for me or just relieved that I didn't have to kill him? Or maybe they're not for me at all. Maybe they're because he didn't win?

The presence of one friend reminds me of another, and I twist back to the Goddess.

'Benny. Did he make it? Did he get out?'

'Is the gift you want from me the answer to that question?' The deity arches a single eyebrow in an expression that is as alien to Dinah as the voice is. 'It seems a waste, but if that is your desire …'

'No, no! I just …'

As the smile tugs at her lips, I realise she's toying with me. Great, the Gods have a sense of humour. I'll try to remember that when I think of all the crap they've put me through.

Her expression flickers and the knowledge that she can hear my thoughts hits again. Oh shit.

'Goddess, I wasn't thinking straight. I … I …' I bow low, glancing at her out of the corner of my eye, but she shakes her head.

'No need to apologise. It is a bad habit of mine. You humans so rarely share the truth, so I find it far easier to understand your workings in this manner. But rest assured, from now on, your thoughts will be yours and yours alone.'

A tremble of relief rises within me, though it's hard to believe it fully. After all, it's not as though I can feel when she enters my head.

'Rose Kultavaris,' she begins, tone brimming with pride. 'You came to me knowing what gift you would ask for. Wishing for everything that was taken from you and your family to be returned. Is that still your desire?'

I nod. 'I know you cannot return lives, and that my parents' powers have been passed to Mortidem, but for myself and my sister, I wish for our magic, our titles, our home. I wish for our lives to be as they should have been. For Kay's life to be as it should have been. That will be enough.'

That eyebrow arches again, though not quite as high.

‘You have no thirst for revenge? You do not ask for the death of the man who did this to you? I’m sure many in your position would wish to see him dethroned. Cast from his High Hold and tossed into the life you and your sister were forced to suffer. I could do that, of course, but not both.’

I hate myself for contemplating the idea – even for a moment – but it is not as though I haven’t dreamed of that exact form of revenge many, many times. Of Korvane Knavin seeing firsthand how his people live outside the exalted rings of Wrohelm. But would the person who takes his place be any better? It is not as if I could rule, and Kyor is not ready. I know that. But one day, if the line stays as it is, then Kyor will be king. Kyor, who etches a mark for every death he sees so that their lives are not forgotten. Who was only cast from this place because he trusted me out on the water. He would listen. He would see. With him as the king’s heir, their family bloodline has hope. The people have hope.

‘I believe the return of those things that were lost will be enough for me, thank you.’

‘Perhaps you’re right,’ she says. ‘First, I will return the magic, and then your home and wealth.’ She winks. ‘And maybe I’ll give you a little more, too … to make up for the time you lost.’

I assume she’s talking only of extra wealth, but then she takes my hands and searing power rushes up through my palms, flooding my veins. It’s so hot it should burn me from the inside, consuming my very being, but instead, it fills me and makes me whole. More than whole. My head flies back, and somewhere in the distance I hear Jonas scream out my name, but I can’t so much as move my eyes towards him. My lungs are gasping as I breathe in every ounce of magic offered. All that was stripped from me, all that I recently received, and so much more besides.

When the Goddess finally releases me and steps back, my hands have the faintest glow to them.

‘Your magic has been returned. The High Priestess will see to your home and wealth. And as for the most important part of what was taken from you, it will come with time.’

And with that enigmatic promise, the world disappears from beneath my feet.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 73

I squeeze my eyes tightly closed against the light that comes as a blinding contrast to the depths of the caves I was in just moments before. When I blink them open again, confusion takes hold. The room I've been taken to isn't my room in the Retterheld barracks; instead, it's a work of art. A sumptuous bed, larger than any I have seen, sits in the centre of the space, and ornate tapestries and gilded mirrors hang on the walls, the latter of which reflect the light flowing from the large, lead-lined windows. I step towards one and gape at the sight that awaits me. From here I can see out across the entirety of Wrohelm, the city and its rings fading into the distance. It's a view the likes of which I hadn't even realised was possible. Whatever this room is, it must be in the very highest part of the High Hold, or at least close to it.

The height is somewhat dizzying, and I step back, trying to draw in a breath. I struggle to get my thoughts in order. Did that really happen? Did I really just win the gifting? Everything I ever wanted is mine. It feels … unbelievable. A dream. A hope. A wish. Now my reality. I almost cannot accept it, yet I know it is real. I can still feel the weight of my dagger in my palm as I killed Zara and the sting of the grazes on my shins and elbows from the countless shafts I climbed through. I can still see Jonas's eyes as he thought his last moment had come. Yes, it is real.

With my heart pounding, I try to take a deep, calming breath, when something new causes my pulse to quicken further. My magic. I can feel it within me. Weaving through my veins. Filling my cells. Gods, I forgot how it feels, that warm, comforting buzz between my ribs.

Several small ornamental plant pots sit around the room. While looking at one, I twist my wrist, feeling the tendrils of my magic flow from my fingertips. As I watch, the plant flourishes, its leaves twisting upwards as new buds sprout, then open into wide, colourful petals. Flowers.

My magic. Just like my mother's.

It has truly been returned.

A gasp escapes my lungs and tears trickle down my cheeks. I did it. I actually did it.

'Rose?' a familiar voice calls from behind the door. 'Rose, are you here?'

'Kyor?' I twist towards the sole entrance to the room.

'Rose?' I hear him call my name again a second before the door swings open. His look is one of awe and wonder and pure adoration.

'I knew you would succeed. You did it, Thorn. You did it!' His grin is triumphant and proud and infectious, and I find myself laughing, giddy with pure joy as I fall into his arms. His scent and his arms wrap around me in delicious perfection. Everything about this moment is more than I could have dreamed. He is here. I am here.

'You are the most magnificent person I have ever met,' he declares before planting his lips against mine. His magic does not spark between us now. We don't need it. Kyor as he is, is enough for me. And from the way he holds me, as if I am something to be cherished, savoured, it's clear that the feeling is mutual.

When we finally break away from the kiss, I look up into those clear blue eyes, unsure how I ever thought they were icy. That's not the type of blue they are at all. They're the blue of a cerulean sky, of clear, warm water. The type that invites you in and holds you in complete comfort.

'Where are we?' I ask. 'And how the hell did you know I'd be here?'

'It's the Spire,' he tells me. 'Tallest point of the High Hold. I always wondered what this part of the palace was for. It's always been off limits, even to me. But then I saw the priestesses outside—'

'The priestesses?'

'They told me that this is where they take the gifted before the final ball.'

'They told you I won?'

He shakes his head. 'They didn't need to. It was always going to be you. I knew, Thorn. I knew it would be you.'

He looks down at me as his hands cup my cheeks. Both our eyes are glistening with tears.

‘I have it all back, Kyor. Everything. My magic, my wealth, my title.’

As I say the words aloud, a realisation takes hold. In the back of my mind, there was always an expiry date to this relationship. The last thing the Prince of Morathka could do was marry a stripped former lady of his court. But that’s not who I am anymore. I am worthy of him now. We can truly be together. In this moment, with this gift, we have something I didn’t know I desperately needed: a future together. I was hardly likely to be Korvane’s ideal daughter-in-law before, but now I’m the gifted, and if Kyor tells him the truth about my mother, then what possible objections could he have?

As Kyor gently combs his fingers through my hair, I look with surprise at the bright white strands. ‘I thought it would go back to brown,’ I admit. ‘You know, now that my magic has returned.’

‘I like it this way,’ he says, leaning forward and kissing me gently on the forehead. ‘I like everything about you, Thorn. You know I love—’

A loud knock on the door cuts off the words I long to hear. At least the feel of his kiss lingers against my temple.

‘We’ll hold that thought.’ He grins ruefully.

‘It’ll keep,’ I agree softly with a smile of my own. My heart is so full, it feels like it might burst with happiness. All my troubles and all my trials are behind me now. My shoulders ease for what feels like the first time in moons.

‘Lady Rose.’ The deep female voice resonates from behind the door. ‘It’s time to get you ready for the ball.’

‘Something tells me I’m going to have a hard time keeping you to myself tonight.’ Kyor mock huffs, gently kissing the top of my ear.

‘Don’t worry. We’ve got all the time in the world,’ I tell him.

He shifts back, his face alight with joy as he runs a finger along my jawline. ‘We do,’ he agrees. ‘We really do.’

There’s another impatient knock, immediately followed by the same deep, gruff voice. ‘Lady Rose, we really do need to get you ready.’

‘Yes, yes, that’s fine,’ I call back. ‘Come in.’ I kiss Kyor’s lips lightly. ‘I’ll see you at the ball.’

‘I’ll be saving every dance for you, Lady Rose the Gifted,’ Kyor promises, pride in every word.

He kisses me once more before moving to the doorway and opening it. A stream of maids, dressed identically in pale yellow frocks and white hats, scurry in. Kyor frowns slightly, his gaze hovering over them.

A laugh escapes my lips. After everything I've just survived, he's worried about leaving me alone with half a dozen maids?

'I'll be fine,' I tell him. 'You go and get ready. I'll see you at the ball.'

He nods quickly, winks at me with a cheeky smile, and disappears outside.

Unlike me, who has absolutely no idea what I'm doing, the maids quickly get to work. One heads straight into the bathroom, another for the wardrobe, while one starts stripping my bloodstained clothes from me.

'Congratulations, my lady,' she says as she works, her eyes trained downwards so that all I can see is the blanket of fabric covering her hair. 'They're pleased on the streets. One of us. That is the chant, is it not?'

My heart surges as I think of all the people my victory has brought hope to. The gifting may have been about getting Kay's and my powers and station back, but maybe I've achieved far more than that.

'We will let you bathe,' she says. 'The dresses are on your bed for you to choose from. When you have selected your gown, I will come and help you dress and do your hair.'

'Thank you,' I tell her with a grateful smile.

The bath is everything I need it to be – warm, cleansing, and scented enough to remove the smell of blood from my skin. I wish I had asked Kyor to stay with me a little longer so he could join me, but there will be time for that later. Now that I'm not a slum rat anymore.

My eyes drift closed to thoughts of Kay. Will she know yet that I've won? Perhaps, if her stripped magic has returned to her as instantly as mine did. Yet her magic had not even settled before it was removed from her, so will she recognise the feeling of it?

Will the ball be the first time she learns of the identity of the gifted? I have no doubt she's been worried sick all this time, but a smile of anticipation curls my lips as I imagine her ecstatic joy when I finally see her. Surely the tension brought on by Holden's death will fall away? I imagine seeing Benny and Jonas, too. While there will be envy there – how can there not? – I know they will be happy for me.

The conflict between elation and worry continues to undulate within me as I drift into sleep in the embrace of the warm, comforting water. When a

knock on the door startles me awake, I discover the bath is now stone cold, and I realise just how long I've slept. It's hardly ideal.

'My lady, I'm sorry, we can't wait any longer. Guests will be arriving for the ball soon. You need to get dressed.'

I step out of the bath, towel around me, and head back into the main chamber, where three dresses have been placed on the bed. They're far from the unique chicness of Llinos's designs, but beautiful nonetheless, and I waste little time in picking the deep emerald ballgown with a plunging neckline.

'That colour suits you perfectly,' the young woman says. She's the only maid present now, but there's something vaguely familiar about her, though it could just be that she was one of the fussing maids from earlier.

'Thank you. My mother always looked beautiful in green.'

'Come, slip it on, then I'll tighten it and fix your hair for you.'

I do as she suggests, stepping into the ballgown. The fabric is insanely soft, and as she pulls the ties tight around the waist, I can't help but gaze at my reflection. No, it's not like Llin's creations at all, but there is something almost regal about it. Fit for a princess, I let myself think, before hastily pushing the thought aside.

My heart aches for Llin. I wish she was here, holding a dagger and taking it to my dress with a wicked gleam in her eye. Almost immediately my thoughts wander to how Caroline is coping and if she still blames me for her loss. I do.

When the dress is on, I struggle not to gawp at the finished look. I truly do look like a princess. I try not to imagine myself on Kyor's arm, yet no matter what I do, the image refuses to go away. Korvane hates my family, yes, but only because he believes in my mother's supposed misdeeds. Now that my powers and status have been restored, there's nothing to stop Kyor from sharing the truth with his father. Once he does that, the final barrier to our future will fall away.

Though even the limits of my imagination can't envision cosy dinners with Korvane. The man who ruined us all. Whose actions led to my parents' deaths … but maybe I just need time, too. Maybe there is more to him than the cruel man I've seen. I hope so, for Kyor's sake.

'Come, sit down.' The maid leads me over to the dressing table where she starts to brush my hair the moment I've taken a seat. 'You love the prince very much, don't you, my lady?'

I blink. That's not the small talk I was expecting. My eyes tilt upwards, catching hers in the reflection. Was I thinking my thoughts out loud? Or were they simply written all over my face?

She smiles gently. 'I was here earlier,' she explains. 'When the prince was with you. And he looked at you with such adoration. I imagine it must feel incredible to have someone look at you like that.' She sounds wistful and is giving me such a knowing smile that I feel vaguely uncomfortable. Korvane no doubt has spies everywhere, and the familiarity with which she's speaking to me is not normal for any maid. Is she trying to entrap me into saying something damaging?

'The prince is a good man,' I murmur, evading the question, and she combs a thin wax into my hair to assist with the styling.

'I have an idea for a style,' she says, twisting a strand of damp hair around her finger. 'A style I know the prince will love.'

She takes several pieces from the front, curling them into deep spirals. It's not a look I'd normally go for with my frizzy hair, but I have to admit, it suits me more than I expected. We sit in silence as she works, twisting and twirling my hair expertly.

'You are lucky to have someone like him you can trust so well,' she says again after a long moment.

This time my jaw tightens. I'm not saying that me defeating fifty other trained warriors to win the Retterheld should be what this woman wishes to discuss, but she is clearly more interested in Kyor than my achievements, and that's ringing all my alarm bells.

'As I said, he is a good man,' I repeat, hoping my curt tone will be enough to dissuade her from her prying.

'Yes. And so misunderstood, too,' she continues nonetheless. 'But I suspect you understand him. Don't you, my lady?'

I open my mouth, not sure how to respond, when something flutters down from the woman's hand. A piece of paper lands by my foot.

'Oh, sorry, my lady,' she says, though her tone is guileless and says she is anything but. The paper is far easier for me to pick up as I'm sitting, so I reach for it. As I take hold of it, the corner starts to unfold and the edges of a charcoal image become visible.

My pulse quickens. What is this? Has she got hold of one of the images Kyor drew of me? Is this a blackmail attempt?

The maid stands still behind me.

‘See for yourself, my lady,’ she commands, tone unlike any maid I’ve ever met.

Unable to do otherwise, I obey.

My hands tremble as I unfold the paper, and my eyes lock on the image in front of me. Just as I expected, it’s one of Kyor’s pictures. The perfectly drawn proportions, the detail in the eyes … I know his style perfectly, just as I know the bed the female figure lies upon. It is the one in the kitchen of the barracks. The place he told me he had used as a sanctuary long before the Retterheld even began. I thought I was the first he’d welcomed into his inner sanctum, but evidently not. For while I know both the style and the location of the image, what I do not know is the woman who is the subject of his art. It’s certainly not me, and that’s a punch to the gut in and of itself.

As I study the unknown woman, her familiarity niggles at me.

She lies there, arms outstretched, smiling gracefully as the blanket discreetly covers the top of her chest. Her hair falls in lazy curls, almost identical to the ones the maid has teased mine into. The look of pure bliss on her face, and those eyes … I lift my gaze back to the mirror, to the reflection of the maid. A gasp sounds in my throat.

She has dropped her hat, letting the full length of her hair fall down past her shoulders. It is not dark like that of the woman in the picture. Nor like her sister’s was when she was still alive. It is the same tone as mine. White-blonde and stripped of colour, just like she was stripped of her magic.

‘Thea.’ I choke on the name of Estel’s sister as tears burn my eyes. Thea, who was stripped of magic and cast out, all for the perfidy of having the gall to fall pregnant with Kyor’s child.

As I gape at the subject of Kyor’s picture, now here in my very presence, her lips twist into a sneer. ‘He told me he loved me, too. Whatever he has told you, whatever he has made you believe, he will never choose you. He is just a spoiled rich boy, forever tethered to his narcissistic brute of a father. And you will never come before his king and crown. It’s better you learn that lesson now than when it’s too late.’

My chest is so tight I can barely draw breath. This can’t be real. Can it?

I stare at the picture, yet it blurs as tears begin to fall. He drew her like he drew me. Has lain with her in the bed I considered my sanctuary.

As I struggle to ease the trembling in my lungs, Thea pulls the paper from my loose hand. ‘I know I may seem cruel now,’ she says, ‘but I’m

doing you a favour, Rose Kultavaris. You have your powers back. Don’t lose them again for him.’

My throat is closed with rising tears, and before I can say a word, she turns and walks out, leaving me with hair styled perfectly like hers.

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 74

An untethered feeling hangs heavy in the air around me. What the fuck just happened? As a surge of panic tries to rise up in me, I force it down. Now is my moment, my day, and I will not let anyone ruin it for me. What I need to do is think logically. What was Thea trying to achieve?

As much as I want to believe she was lying to me, hoping to turn me against Kyor, what would be the point? With the whiteness of her hair and the familiarity in her features, there is no denying she is Estel's sister. And according to her, Kyor loved her, or at least made her believe that he did, and then he left her to be stripped. So what of their child? Benny had said that it had perished, but Kyor had said he was unsure if the pair had even slept together. But the evidence of their intimacy was there in the black-and-white drawing.

Is there a blue-eyed heir to the throne toddling around somewhere in one of the lower rings?

All my insecurities return, punching into me as though they never left. I cover my mouth, trying to stop myself from heaving. Was this all just a game to him? Breaking hearts, ruining lives, just because he could? No. I shake my head.

No, I know Kyor. He's not like that.

Yet, I still feel sick. My head is in my hands when there's a sharp knock at the door.

'My lady, it is time we accompanied you to the ball.'

It's the gruff maid's voice again. Not Thea's, of that much I'm certain.

I stand, wiping my eyes and looking at my hair in the mirror. Fucking Thea did my hair to match hers. To match the way she said Kyor liked it.

I can't wear it like this. I reach up to braid it, but I'm interrupted before I can even begin. 'My lady?' The voice comes again, this time with an edge of impatience.

'I'll just be a minute,' I call back, letting my hands drop from my hair.

I draw in a long breath. I wash my face, grab a hairbrush and rake it through my hair, the perfect curls gone, forced into loose waves instead. I bend my lips into something reminiscent of a smile. That will have to do.

This is about the gifted. Me, Godsdamn it all. This is my ball and I will not let my fears and insecurities ruin the victory of the moment. With a sharp inhale I push Thea's poisonous words down into the deepest recesses of my soul. They can haunt me there another day, but not now.

Besides, everything I did was for Kay, for her future. Whatever is between Kyor and me, it has no bearing on this moment. Kay and I are free. And that is everything.

I wonder just who I'm trying to convince.

With another breath in, I tilt my chin up and open the door to the gruff-sounding maid. I have no idea how long I have kept her waiting, but rather than showing any annoyance, she offers a warm smile.

'You look beautiful, Lady Rose,' she says. 'Really beautiful. I'll escort you to the ballroom.'

'Thank you. It's fine though. I don't need a chaperone.'

'I'll just lead you to it,' she assures me. 'Don't worry. No one expects a maid to be on your arm today.' Another smile.

I've never been in the Spire, so I accept her assistance, though in the end it's a fairly straightforward walk down the steep steps, which bring me out at the bottom of the palace. Huddled by the doorway is a cluster of priestesses. I scan their faces, but none are Dinah.

'Excuse me,' I ask one. 'Can you tell me if Dinah is okay? I saw her … I saw her at the end.'

The priestesses exchange a series of tight-lipped looks, and fear rolls through me. Before I can speak again, one bestoned priestess takes pity on me.

'To be an avatar of the Gods takes much energy. Dinah will be resting for a day or two yet but is unharmed from the experience.'

‘Thank you,’ I say gratefully. There. Yet another thing to be grateful for. Dinah is well. Kay is safe. I have my magic. I am determined to count my blessings, even if I’m now unsure whether Kyor is among them.

While the escort from this point is unnecessary the maid leads me towards the ballroom, the two of us now flanked by the procession of priestesses. We approach a series of knights and their dire wolves lining the path, and unease prickles down my neck. Is it an honour guard or increased security following the previous rebel incidents?

As I walk, the knights genuflect to me as though I’m someone important. My mouth dries while my heart is suddenly racing again.

My moment of recognition – reclamation – is finally here.

‘The gifted. Lady Rose Kultavaris,’ one of the priestesses confirms imperiously to the knight on the door. As he goes to open the door and announce me, the maid takes my hand and curtsies deeply. ‘One of us,’ she whispers to me, with such pride and awe that heat prickles my eyes. She gives my hand one final squeeze and releases it before rising to her feet and striding away.

One of us. It is the reminder I need. I push aside Thea’s bullshit. This is my moment and I am going to fucking own it.

I can already hear the music, the chatter, and the laughter. Do they know it’s me who’s about to be announced? Have the others returned? Where is Benny? Jonas?

‘The gifted,’ the knight announces. The ballroom falls utterly silent. ‘Lady Rose Kultavaris.’

A moment of absolute quiet holds in the air, and the only sound I can hear is the drumming of my heart as it batters my ribcage. The maid who chaperoned me down may have been pleased to see me win, but what about the court? Is this the moment they decide they know better than the Goddess and deem me wholly unworthy? What will that look like? With an image of raucous booing and jeering filling my head, the ballroom bursts into applause. Faces beam at me, and women dab their eyes with false pride, as though they never once spat on me and called me the Queenkiller’s daughter.

‘You should greet the king,’ a priestess whispers in my ear. ‘It is tradition.’

My already parched throat dries further still.

King Korvane is sitting on his throne with a smile so fixed and false it should be hilarious. Next to him is Kyor. His eyes display that same awe he showed me in the chamber earlier, the cerulean blue depths so full of love I can't possibly believe it's false.

The two royals are not alone. Murmuring to Korvane is High Priestess Mila. I find I have no wish to speak to any of them right now, so I select a glass of wine from a nearby waiter and stand holding it. I doubt I will ever sip a glass of wine given to me by a stranger ever again.

Even now, I can see Llinos's face as she struggled to breathe.

Godsdamn it all.

Unsure how to proceed and aware of all the eyes scrutinising my every move, I feel my anxiety beginning to rise. I don't want to face Korvane. Or Kyor. Yet I don't know where to go. The crowd parts, creating a clear walkway straight between me and the dais where the king awaits, and yet still I do not move. To give my thanks to him after the pain he caused my family – the pain he caused Kyor – is something I'm not sure I'm capable of.

Whispers crescendo and smiles grow tighter as eyes flicker between me and the royals, wondering who will react first. Then, without warning, there is a bustling motion to the side and Benny barrels into the centre of the room, a glass in hand. The relief at the sight of my friend is intensified further as he lifts his drink into the air. 'To the gifted! To Lady Rose!'

The court hesitates, their collective gaze still darting towards the king, until another lone voice echoes Benny's toast.

'To the gifted! Lady Rose.'

It's enough to open the floodgates.

'To the gifted! The gifted!'

The chorus goes up around me, hundreds and hundreds of voices, yet once again my mind can only hear one. It's like my senses can only tune in to him.

As I stare at Kyor, the image of Thea's picture rises in my mind and, with it, bile that stings the back of my throat. He told her he loved her too. And then he let her be stripped. Have I been duped the same way she was? Fooled into believing his emotions are real? It didn't feel like it, but I suppose no one suspects the conman until it is too late. And it is too late. If he's been playing with me … my heart won't survive it. Because I wasn't playing. I was all in. Now, I'm not so sure. He kept my secret though, didn't

he? He didn’t tell anyone about the forbidden frozen magic that burst from within me.

It is torture. More torturous than any of the trials I suffered through.

‘You did it. You fucking did it!’ Benny’s voice brings me back into the moment. When I turn around, he’s there, beaming at me. ‘I don’t need to tell you this, but you know that Llin would be so freaking proud of you right now.’

‘I wish she was here to see this,’ I admit, feeling the tears build up again. Gods, am I just made of tears these days?

‘Me too, me too.’ He takes my hand and squeezes tightly. ‘Our Rose, Gods above, the gifted. I’m damned proud of you. What did you ask for?’ he queries.

‘For everything to be restored to me and mine. Our magic, our wealth, our titles.’ I smile. ‘I have my magic back.’

‘I’m happy for you, Rose. You deserve it all and more.’ Benny looks at me with such pride that my heart warms all over again. ‘Have you seen Kay yet?’

‘Not yet,’ I tell him.

‘Rose!’ Jonas is the next to accost me. ‘Rose, you’re here. Thank goodness. I wanted to speak to you. There’s something I need, we need, to discuss. Now.’

A grind of irritation echoes through my clenched jaw. I don’t expect my friends to venerate me because I won, but would a single word of congratulations hurt? What can be so urgent that it can’t wait another day?

A sudden thought surges through me. Could he wish to propose again, even though he knows of my feelings for Kyor? That single thought leads to another more insidious one. Did he know about Thea? Did he know Kyor professed to love her too? He certainly tried to warn me away from the prince often enough.

With a forced smile, I place my hands on Jonas’s shoulders. ‘Not now. Just have a drink, please. Celebrate with me before anything else.’

‘Of course.’ His smile looks almost as forced as mine. ‘Congratulations, Lady Rose,’ he says as he sweeps into a courtly bow as deep as the knights offered.

‘My Lady Rose, the gifted.’

His voice sounds from behind me. Warm, almost triumphant. The same voice that only hours ago made me want to shut the world out so that only

two of us remained. My heart ricochets off my ribs as I turn to face him.

Kyor. He looks every inch as perfect as he did when he left me earlier. But is he?

I hate Thea in this moment, for what she has ruined for me.

I try to smile, but I know it doesn't reach my eyes.

'Thorn, are you okay?'

No. The answer rattles around my head, but I can't speak openly with him here. This is not the right time or place.

'I need to see Kay,' I say instead. 'Have you seen Kay?'

It is as though the Goddess gifted me the power to summon my sister, for I have barely finished my question when I hear her voice.

'Rose? Rose!'

Her white-blonde hair flashes through the crowd and in this moment, nothing else matters. Not Kyor, not even the magic that fills me. Kay is safe. Kay has a place here in the High Hold. That is what I did all of this for. It's been Kay and me always, and it can go back to that if it has to.

The instant she reaches me, I throw my arms around her tightly, trying to absorb her happiness to share in it.

'You did it! This is incredible. Our lives, Rose!' She's beaming like I should be. 'This is amazing! Unbelievable. Oh, I have so much to tell you, so much to tell you.'

I can feel Kyor's gaze hovering on me.

Every dance, that's what he promised me. Now I'm not sure how long I can even stand to be in the same ballroom as him. I need to talk to him about Thea, but I can't face it here, surrounded by hundreds of fluttering court butterflies, each as deadly as a viper.

'Tell me, tell me your news,' I say instead to her.

She frowns slightly. 'Do you not need to be, I don't know, mingling, dancing? People look as if they want to speak to you.'

As I glance around, I can see that she is right, and almost every pair of eyes is trained on me. But this is the celebration of my triumph, my gifting, and I have earned the right to spend it as I wish.

'I wish to hear your news,' I respond, continuing to drag her away, and this time she doesn't protest. Behind us, I can hear Benny loudly talking about how beautiful our reunion is, trying to make it acceptable that I'm slipping out of the ball held in my very honour. He is truly a God among men.

We slip into one of the first antechambers, and it's with a new bout of nausea that I realise it's the one Kyor and I were in the night Llinos was murdered. I want to move, find another place, but then Kay will only ask what's wrong, and that's not a conversation I'm ready to have.

'So tell me your news,' I say impatiently, needing a distraction from the thoughts raging in my head. 'What is it?'

'Rose,' she starts, her voice tempered in the way I know well. It means she's about to tell me something she thinks I won't like. 'I couldn't be happier,' she continues firmly. 'The court, it's where I'm meant to be.'

'I know. That's why I entered the Retterheld. I always knew you would be happy here.' I frown. 'Is it your magic? Has it not come back?'

She shakes her head. 'No, not that I've noticed yet, but I've not tried to do anything. And it's not like magic can matter that much. You won the Retterheld without it.'

I press my lips together. Did I? I wouldn't have survived without the powers I got on that frozen lake. But Kay doesn't need to know about that right now.

'Rose.' Kay places her hands on my shoulders. 'I don't need to worry about whether I have magic or not anymore … not now I'm getting married.'

The shock is enough to force the air from my lungs, but I try to disguise it as best I can. 'Hew? Do you want to marry Hew?'

My throat thickens. Hew and Kyor are close. This marriage would bind us, however loosely, for the rest of our lives ahead.

Kay's usually soft face is inscrutable. 'No,' she says finally. 'No, not … Hew.'

My mind goes blank. 'Then who? Kay, I understand that you were worried about having to leave the court after the competition ended, but that's not going to happen. You're a lady again now. A proper member of the court. You don't need to be hasty. You don't need to get married to stay here.'

She chews on her bottom lip. 'I know I'm a member of the court, but there's something else you must know.' She repeats the chewing motion as she draws in a breath. 'I … I'm pregnant.'

My jaw drops. I stagger back a little, falling into the chair behind me. 'You're what?' I whisper, making no attempt to hide my shock.

She brushes my concern away with a wave of her hand. ‘You do not need to worry, I promise.’

‘You are pregnant, out of wedlock, without a …’ I stop as another thought careens in. ‘Whose baby is it?’

She grimaces. ‘It is Hew’s. I thought he loved me.’ She scoffs, a bitter look crossing her face before she pastes on a smile, as if what is coming next is positive. ‘When I told him of our baby, he admitted to already being betrothed to a duchess in Dorain.’

‘What?’ I can barely speak, barely think. Hew got my sister pregnant, with no intention of doing the honourable thing? ‘The men of the Wrohelm court are snakes,’ I snarl. ‘Every single one of them.’ I press my thumbs against my temples as I rub my forehead. Kay is pregnant out of wedlock. She will be kicked out of the court again. As the thought enters my head, my brain catches up to the rest of her words. Dropping my hands I look her in the eye. ‘But if the baby is Hew’s, and he’s marrying someone else, then who are *you* marrying?’

Wordlessly, she entwines her fingers with mine. From the nervous soft smile that graces her lips, I already know I am going to hate what follows. ‘Honestly, I promise you, it is fine. I have sorted it.’

Sorted it? Relief storms in. She’s taken a potion, ended the burgeoning life before it can end hers. ‘Have you taken a tonic?’ I ask her, but when she looks blank, I continue, ‘If not, I can make one. I have not made one for a while, but I’m sure I—’

‘No!’ She snatches her hand from mine. I see the horror in her eyes, the same as the night I killed Holden. Horror and judgement for my actions. ‘Death did not used to be your first instinct, Rose, and it certainly isn’t mine.’

‘I killed for you!’ I snap back.

‘I didn’t ask you to!’ Her own voice rises. ‘I would never have asked you to.’ Her breath seethes through gritted teeth as she clenches and unclenches her hands. ‘Rose …’ She says my name with forced composure. ‘This life growing inside me is my child. I’m not going to just dispose of it because the timing is inconvenient. I’m not so heartless as you.’

‘Pardon?’ I could not have been more shocked if she had punched me. Heartless? Is that how she sees me? After all I have done for her, hearing that word tripping from Kay’s tongue is crippling. ‘You have no idea what my heart has gone through,’ I snarl. Any ounce of patience I have is gone.

‘I’m done with this, Acacia,’ I snap. ‘If you are not taking the tonic nor are you marrying the father, then who exactly are you planning to marry to remedy this Godsawful mess?’

She presses her lips together. For the first time, I feel the slightest hint of nervousness radiating from her. ‘I am going to marry Artur.’

‘Artur?’ I frown, confused. There is only one person I know by that name, and I am certain she cannot mean him. Not ageing, portly Artur Lorathin. ‘Who?’ I ask again. Maybe there is another Artur at court I have not yet met.

Then she speaks, and in a single moment confirms all of my worst fears. She tips her chin up. ‘I am marrying Lord Artur Lorathin. Jonas’s father.’

OceanofPDF.com

CHAPTER 75

If I were not already sitting, my knees would have collapsed. How? How, after everything I did to give us a better life, have we ended up here?

When I finally find my voice, it is laden with desperation and disbelief.

'Kay, you cannot be serious. He is … he's old enough to be our father. Closer to grandfather's age, even.'

She shrugs like his age is of no concern. 'But he is wealthy. A life with him would be secure. The baby and I would both be secure.'

I shake my head vehemently. 'No, Kay. I forbid it. There has to be another way.'

She folds her arms and glares, looking impossibly young. Nothing more than a teenager having a strop. My heart breaks anew. 'I thought you would be proud of me for dealing with my own problems. But no, precious little Kay can't possibly make decisions about her own life!'

I baulk. 'That is not what I meant.' I try to take her hand but she jerks away from me. 'You're so young, Kay. You don't need to tie yourself to an old man. We can find another way.'

'I don't need you to find another way!' she shouts.

I bristle, sitting back. 'Please, Kay, you're not thinking straight.'

'Yes, yes, I am thinking straight. You just never listen. You always have to barrel in and save me, controlling everything. You think I'm incapable of doing anything for myself.'

'That's not what I think!' I snap.

'Yes, yes, it is. You lie to me. You hide things from me.'

'Kay, I swear I only do the things I do to protect you.'

‘I’m an adult.’

‘Only just,’ I mutter.

Her eyes glower. ‘I’m never going to grow up if you don’t give me a chance to, am I?’

I am struggling to believe the words spilling from her mouth. I kept her alive. Safe. And she’s punishing me for it. I can’t even find my voice as she barrels on.

‘How come all the other girls in the slums work in the dirtiest of jobs, and I’m just playing kindergarten teacher, Rose? I’ll tell you how come. It’s because you were paying people off, right? Paying tithes to Rula. Making sure I never ended up working in one of those places. Oh yes,’ she says at my sharp glance, ‘do you think I don’t know how things work? I still lived in the slums, Rose, no matter how much you tried to coddle me!’

My anger rises, hot and swift. ‘I was not coddling you, you idiot. I was protecting you! Stopping you from ending up selling yourself to the highest bidder. Though that is what you have ended up doing all the same.’ I instantly regret the words, and when the slap stings my cheek – delivered with a strength I can’t help but admire – I know it is wholly deserved.

‘I’m sorry,’ I breathe. ‘I didn’t mean it.’ I place my palm against the red heat of my skin as I close my eyes. ‘It’s … it’s just such a shock, Kay. I wanted so much more for you.’ I open my eyes and meet her gaze, pleading with her to understand. ‘I wanted everything for you. Choice. A love match, even.’

Her rigid shoulders soften just a fraction. ‘This is what I want. A life of security is what I want, and Artur can offer me that.’

I swallow down the lump that threatens to fill my throat. ‘And what about when he wants more, Kay? What about when he wants to use you that way too?’

She can’t quite squash the grimace that dances up to her lips. ‘It is expected, I suppose,’ she responds, as if the idea doesn’t make her very skin crawl. ‘I’ll cross that bridge when I come to it.’

‘No! Godsdamn it, Acacia. Over my dead body.’

‘Well, it very nearly was, wasn’t it?’ she spits. ‘And still, you never once stopped to ask me what I want. You’ve spent so long protecting me, shielding me, but you’ve never even seen who I am.’

‘That’s not true, Kay,’ I say, stung. ‘I see you. I know you. More than any other.’

‘I don’t know if you do,’ she says slowly. ‘And I don’t know if I know you, either. I don’t know that person who beat a man close to death then killed him with a fucking rock.’

‘He deserved it,’ I snarl. ‘He killed my friend. Tried to kill me!’

‘But what gave you the right to dole out his punishment?’

‘I was defending myself!’

She lets out a long sigh. ‘Rose, maybe Artur isn’t who I dreamed of marrying, but I deserve to have some choice in the matter. And it *is* my choice. This is what I’m doing. Choosing to marry him rather than to be stripped and cast out again.’

I drop my head into my hands. She’s right; it is her choice. But she’s making a bad one. I promised Mother I would look after her, and standing by and letting her ruin her life is not that.

Before silence has a chance to fall, the door creaks open. I ready myself to make whoever it is leave again, only to find myself face to face with Lord Lorathin himself. Portly, balding, and with a gleam in his eyes that I want to punch out of them.

‘Ah, Acacia, my dearest,’ he says, sliding up to Kay and slipping his hand around her waist in a proprietary manner that makes me want to vomit. ‘Have you told your sister the good news?’

Her stubborn mouth flashes me a smile even as I can see the anxiety shining within her eyes. She will do this. She will marry this old man just to prove a point, just to prove she doesn’t need me to solve her problems.

Maybe she’s right, and I don’t know her at all, because I never believed my sister would be so damned stupid.

I stand. ‘Just in case you wanted it, please know that you do not have my blessing, and I will do everything in my power to make sure this obscene wedding doesn’t happen.’

With my final words said, I whirl around and storm out of the antechamber, only to collide with the frame of a young man. Another ward of Lorathin’s who I’ve just thundered into with such force that he’s crashed into the wall and fallen on his ass.

‘William,’ I say contritely. ‘I’m sorry.’ I offer a hand to him and pull him back to standing.

‘It’s fine. Father told me to wait outside the room. Gosh, you are strong.’ He gives me an admiring look. ‘No wonder you won the Retterheld. What you have done, it’s incredible. You must be so very, very proud.’

‘Yes, I am, thank you.’ I extricate myself from his gentle grip. ‘I hate to be rude,’ I say, brushing past him, ‘but I must go.’

‘Of course.’ He beams with fresh-faced innocence, the type I used to believe I saw in Kay. ‘I’m sure you have so many people to speak to. Everyone is talking about you.’

I bet they are.

I give him a loose wave as I head into the ballroom, my intentions set. I will find Hew and force him to marry Kay. Even that popinjay is better than Artur, with that sick gleam in his eye. I scan the room, which is a swirl of silks and wine, all jewel tones and false laughter. And though Hew is my target, my gaze falls on another instead.

‘Rose!’ Kyor’s face lights up as he says my name, raising his hand ever so slightly to catch my attention, as if my eyes were not drawn to him like a magnet. The sight of him causes a pain to claw through my body, but Thea and her bullshit pale in comparison to the storm Kay has unleashed inside me.

Kyor’s warm hand rests on my waist and he smiles at me for just a heartbeat before it disappears. ‘What is it? What’s wrong, Thorn?’

‘Hew. Fucking Hew. I need to speak to him. Now.’

The barest of sighs escapes his lips. ‘What has he done this time?’

‘Kyor,’ I snap. ‘Hew! Find him.’

‘Okay. I’ll grab him and we’ll meet you in the courtyard.’

As I stalk outside I realise that my green, plunging ballgown is hardly suitable for a meeting outdoors, yet whether it’s fury or the magic in my veins, the cold barely touches me. Hew will not get away with this. And I don’t care how mad at me Kay is. If she can face marrying a man like Artur, then she can marry a man she liked enough to fuck and ruin her life.

While Kyor strides into the courtyard, Hew skulks behind. The prince’s jaw is tight, anger thrumming from him. I think it’s safe to assume Hew told him about Kay’s pregnancy then.

Still, Kyor waits until they reach me and we have relative privacy before he whirls on Hew.

‘What the hell do you think you’re playing at?’ he demands.

Hew carries a glass of red wine, his lips already stained with it. I wonder how many drinks he’s had while he waited for my dramatic entrance.

‘Why are you so mad?’ Hew asks, looking genuinely perplexed.

‘What the fuck do you mean? Kay is Rose’s sister.’ Kyor gestures to me.

‘And?’ Hew frowns before his expression lightens and he laughs. ‘Oh, you’re joking? This is rich. You’re fucking the other sister?’ His laugh is enough to make me feel sick. ‘This is classic. I’m going to be honest, though. I think I got the hotter one.’

Kyor’s fists are clenched, and the static in the air is suddenly buzzing. If Hew doesn’t sober up fast, there’s a strong chance the prince will use his lightning on his childhood friend. Part of me wants to egg him on, but that won’t help Kay. I need Hew alive and unfried to marry her. To do the right thing.

I touch Kyor’s arm, silently asking for his patience.

‘You’ll marry Acacia,’ Kyor grinds out. ‘And acknowledge the baby.’

Hew laughs. ‘The fuck I will. My engagement is a political move, Ky. Your father’s the one who arranged it. He told me who I’ll marry, and I said, “Yes, Your Majesty,” because I like living. You can’t undo it any more than I can.’

‘What?’ Kyor looks genuinely surprised by this news. ‘How did I not know this?’

‘I don’t know. Maybe because you’ve been off waging wars on the Torailian and riding that wolf of yours like a pony.’

Yup, he’s definitely plastered. The Morathkians haven’t been at war with the Torailians for decades, and to refer to Elska as a pony? It’s hard to believe he’s still standing. The static in the air hitches a notch higher.

‘Korvane gifted me a year of freedom before the shackles of marriage,’ Hew continues, ‘and I’ve been enjoying my year thoroughly.’ He downs a hefty mouthful of wine before slapping Kyor on the arm. ‘Look, you can’t really be mad about the Kultavaris thing. I was just taking a leaf out of your playbook.’ With a slight laugh, he goes to take another gulp of wine, only to find the glass empty. His face crinkles in confusion. ‘Well, this needs rectifying immediately,’ he says, turning on his heel and walking back into the palace like he hasn’t just dashed every single hope I had.

Hew won’t marry Acacia. He won’t acknowledge the baby. I feel sick.

And what did he mean by Kyor’s playbook? A terrified part of me already knows he’s talking about Thea. About how getting her pregnant was enough to see her stripped of her powers and thrown out of the High Hold, his problem erased. But is Hew talking about me, too? Is making women fall for him only to ruin them Kyor’s idea of fun? It’s with panic that I recall

his response to finding out I was on the dealun seed tonic. Was I wrong to assume the reaction was jealousy? Was it actually because I disrupted his plans to ruin me? Is Kyor no better than Hew?

He has to be. I need him to be. There has to be another explanation for all this.

‘Kyor,’ I whisper.

‘We’ll fix this,’ he promises rashly. ‘Somehow.’

With no more words to say he leans in, ready to press his lips to mine, and for a split second I consider backing away. But I don’t. I need this kiss. Because I need to believe in him. Believe in us. That what we have is real.

As I let my body lose itself in the moment, the kiss grows deep and desperate. His hands tangle in my gown as he pulls me closer, only for a throat to clear behind us.

‘Well,’ Korvane Knavin drawls, ‘this is not where I expected to find the two most important people at the ball.’

I watch Kyor’s cheeks pale as he turns to face his father, his arm still around my waist.

‘I’m glad to find you two here,’ Korvane says, a dark smirk curling his lips. ‘Alone. You see, I’ve heard some quite concerning rumours about the pair of you, and it appears they were correct.’ The smile drops lightning fast, and in its place is pure threat. ‘It ends now.’

Panic surges through me, but I snuff it out. I know why Korvane wants this to end. But that’s only because he doesn’t know the truth.

‘I know why you think we can’t be together,’ I tell him. ‘Because I’m the Queenkiller’s daughter, right? But I’m not, am I?’ I look at Kyor and will him to tell the truth. ‘Kyor,’ I entreat, ‘tell him. Tell your father what happened that night, how my mother could do nothing more. Tell him how she did nothing wrong.’

My breath trembles in my lungs as Kyor wets his lips. But no words come out. No confession is spilt.

‘Kyor?’ His name is barely audible on my lips, and a deep laugh escapes the king as he watches on, a casual ball of fire dancing between his hands.

‘Miss Kultavaris,’ he begins.

‘Lady Kultavaris!’ I snap, because no matter what, at least I have that.

He inclines his head. ‘Lady Kultavaris,’ he corrects without missing a beat. ‘You have received a great gift indeed. As the Goddess has seen fit to raise you back from your position in the slums, it is clear that she deems

your punishment complete, and so it is.' His eyes narrow. 'But I did not err with my judgement, and my son didn't lie that night,' he growls. 'My son would not lie, not to me. Not to the king. Because to deceive the king is to defy the crown, and to defy the crown is to betray the realm. And if the Crown Prince lied to me, well, then that would be treason, and I wouldn't have a son at all. And whatever power and wealth he was set to inherit would be gone, just like that.' The ball of fire in his hands leaps up, the flames suddenly big enough that we can both feel their deadly heat.

Just as suddenly as it flared, the fire is gone, winked out of existence in a moment. Korvane continues, 'As for his role in the north of the land, he would be stripped of that. And the men and women who serve him there …' He holds my gaze for a moment longer before looking at Kyor. 'Well, I am sure they would fare perfectly well under other leadership, don't you think my son? Yes, the punishment for lying to the king, even for a child, would be great. So, boy, is there anything you want to tell me?'

Kyor's eyes lower slightly, and his hand drops from my waist.

The king nods with satisfaction. 'As I thought. Come, Kyor. You have duties to attend to.'

Kyor steps away from me, and he rips my heart out as he leaves without a backward glance, the skin on my waist still warm from his touch. Korvane's satisfied smile burns into my memory as everything I've built crumbles around me.

My knees threaten to buckle, and yet I stay standing. The same way I have always stayed standing, whether that be through death, the deprivation of the slums, or the trials the Retterheld has thrown at me. Not once did I break. Not once did I fall and fail to rise again. And today, *my* day, will not be the first time I do so.

The monsters of Wrohelm may be the same as they always were, but I have a whole new set of teeth.



IF YOU ENJOYED ***Web of Vows and Vengeance***, thank you for stepping into this world. Rose's story is only just beginning, but don't worry, book two, ***Vows of Blood and Deception,*** is on its way.

Pre-order your copy now.



IF YOU'D LIKE something to tide you over while you wait for ***Vows of Blood and Deception*** (coming summer 2026), you can read the free prequel novella, ***Veil of Web and Ruin***.

It follows Rose at her most desperate, as she's tasked with stealing poison from Etta's Garden – a choice that sets far more in motion than she could ever anticipate. Get a ***Veil of Web and Ruin*** for free by signing up to Aria's VIP email list (you can unsubscribe at any time).

https://www.aria-ashbrook.com



AND IF THIS story stayed with you, Aria would be hugely grateful if you could consider leaving a review on your favourite bookish platform. Fantasy romance is a fiercely competitive genre, and for a debut novel, every review genuinely makes a real difference. Your support helps this world – and these characters – continue.



OceanofPDF.com

About the Author

Aria Ashbrook



Aria Ashbrook writes emotionally charged romantasy filled with dangerous trials, forbidden magic, and slow-burn love that could burn kingdoms to ash.

Aria Ashbrook is the shared pen name of award-winning authors Heather G. Harris and Hannah Lynn. Together, they craft sweeping romantasy worlds where danger courts desire, destiny tangles with vengeance, and love burns brighter than the stars.

Between them, they've written dozens of novels, won multiple awards, and built fiercely loyal readerships across fantasy and romantic fiction. *Web of Vows and Vengeance* is the first in their thrilling new romantasy series.

- Join their VIP newsletter at: https://www.aria-ashbrook.com/
- TikTok: @Aria_Ashbrook_Author
- Instagram: @AriaAshbrookAuthor
- Facebook Page: @AriaAshbrookAuthor
- Facebook Group: Aria Ashbrook Fan Group

OceanofPDF.com